THE BIBLE

in Plain Language

OLD TESTAMENT

THE BIBLE

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

VOLUME 3

Proverbs to Malachi

With an explanation for every section

EDITED BY ANDREAS RUPP

The Bible in Plain Language
Volume 3: Proverbs to Malachi

Edited by Andreas Rupp.

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Volume 1: Genesis to 1 Samuel
Volume 2: 2 Samuel to Psalms
Volume 3: Proverbs to Malachi
Volume 4: Matthew to Revelation

How to read this book

The Bible is the most important book in the world.

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No verse is left out. No name and no number.

Short sentences

Every line is one short thought.

So you can read in peace.

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[1] The small numbers are the verse numbers.
With them you can find every passage.
Just like in every other Bible.

The boxes

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
> After every section there is a box like this.
> It explains what you have read.
> And what it can mean for us today.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Some passages in the Bible are hard.
They have also been misused, for example against Jews, against women, or to justify violence.
At such passages you will find a note like this.

The Psalms

Some Bibles number the Psalms differently.

Then the other number is given in brackets.

Help

The Bible also tells of suffering and violence.

If something weighs on you: At the end of every volume you will find phone numbers where you can get help.

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PROVERBS

Chapter 1

The beginning of wisdom

Before we begin: What is the book of Proverbs?

The book of Proverbs is a book full of wisdom for life.

It has short, wise sayings for everyday life: about work and laziness, friendship and quarrels, money and poverty, words and silence, family and neighbors.

Many proverbs are linked to King Solomon. He was famous for his wisdom (1 Kings 4:29–34). But other wise people also added proverbs, for example Agur and King Lemuel (Chapters 30 and 31).

The book has several parts:

– Chapters 1–9: longer speeches. A father (and a mother) teach their son. Wisdom appears like a woman who calls out in the street.

– Chapters 10–29: many single, short proverbs. Often they are two lines that show a contrast, like this: "The wise … but the fool …"

– Chapters 30–31: words of Agur and Lemuel, and at the end the praise of a capable woman.

The motto of the whole book is in Chapter 1, verse 7: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge."

Important: Proverbs are not promises that always come true for everyone. They describe how life usually works. The book of Job and the book of Ecclesiastes show that there are exceptions too.

The book often speaks to "my son," because back then it was written for young men. But its wisdom is for all people, for women and men, young and old.

What this book is for VERSES 1–7

1 The proverbs of Solomon, the son of David, king of
Israel:
2 to know wisdom and instruction,
to understand words of understanding,
3 to receive instruction in wise dealing,
in righteousness, justice, and fairness,
4 to give good sense to the simple,
knowledge and good judgment to the young man,
5 so that the wise man may hear and grow in learning,
and the man of understanding may gain good advice,
6 to understand proverbs and parables,
the words of the wise and their riddles.
7 The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge.
But the foolish despise wisdom and instruction.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–6 name the purpose of the book: It wants to make people wise for life. Not only the "simple," that is, people without experience, but also those who are already wise. You never stop learning.

Verse 3: "Righteousness" comes up very often in this book. Righteous means: living right before God.

Verse 7 is the most important sentence of the book. "The fear of the LORD" does not mean being afraid. It means: taking God seriously, respecting him, trusting him. Whoever lives like this has the foundation for all wisdom.

In the book of Proverbs, the "fool" is not simply someone who knows little. It is someone who does not want to learn and does not take God seriously.

Don't let yourself be led astray VERSES 8–19

8 My son, listen to your father's instruction,
and don't leave your mother's teaching!
9 For they will be a beautiful wreath for your head
and chains around your neck.
10 My son, if sinners try to lure you, don't agree!
11 If they say, "Come with us!
Let's lie in wait for blood!
Let's secretly lie in wait for the innocent without any
reason!
12 Let's swallow them up alive like Sheol (the world of the
dead),
whole, like those who go down into the pit!
13 We'll find all kinds of valuable wealth.
We'll fill our houses with plunder.
14 You shall cast your lot with us.
We'll all have one purse."
15 My son, don't walk on the path with them!
Keep your foot away from their path!
16 For their feet run to evil.
They hurry to shed blood.
17 For the net is spread in vain
in the sight of any bird.
18 But these men lie in wait for their own blood.
They secretly lie in wait for their own lives.
19 Such are the ways of everyone who is greedy for gain.
Greed takes away the life of its owners.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Father and mother both teach. The mother is named on purpose.

Verse 9: Good teaching is like jewelry. It makes a person beautiful.

Verses 10–14: A gang tries to win over a young man: "Come with us! … We'll all have one purse." That sounds like belonging and quick money. This kind of temptation still exists today: gangs, crime, fraud.

Verses 17–18: A bird that sees the net does not fly into it. But these men do not see their own trap. Whoever harms others harms themselves in the end.

Verse 19: Greed destroys the life of the one who is greedy.

Wisdom calls out in the street VERSES 20–33

20 Wisdom calls aloud in the street.
She raises her voice in the public squares.
21 She calls out at the noisiest places.
At the entrance of the city gates, she speaks her words:

22 "How long, you simple ones, will you love being simple?
How long will mockers enjoy mocking,
and how long will fools hate knowledge?
23 Turn back when I correct you!
Look, I will pour out my spirit on you.
I will make my words known to you.
24 Because I have called, and you have refused,
because I have stretched out my hand, and no one has paid attention,
25 but you have ignored all my advice
and wanted none of my correction,
26 I also will laugh at your disaster.
I will mock when trouble comes over you,
27 when trouble comes over you like a storm,
when your disaster comes like a whirlwind,
when distress and fear come on you.
28 Then they will call to me, but I will not answer.
They will search for me eagerly, but they will not find me,
29 because they hated knowledge
and did not choose the fear of the LORD.
30 They wanted none of my advice.
They despised all my correction.
31 So they will eat the fruit of their own way
and be filled with their own plans.
32 For the turning away of the simple will kill them.
The careless ease of fools will destroy them.
33 But whoever listens to me will live safely.
He will be at peace, without fear of harm."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here wisdom is described like a woman who calls out loudly in the middle of the city: in the market square, at the city gate, where everyone passes by. Wisdom is not hidden. Everyone can hear it.

Verse 23: She invites: Turn back! I want to give you my spirit.

Verses 24–32: Hard words for those who do not want to listen. Whoever ignores every warning must live with the consequences. "They will eat the fruit of their own way": You reap what you sow.

Verse 26: "I also will laugh": This is picture language that is made sharp on purpose. It does not mean that God is happy about suffering. It shows: Whoever rejects wisdom cannot suddenly rely on it in a disaster.

Verse 33: The goal is good: Whoever listens to wisdom lives safely and without fear.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 2

Search for wisdom like a treasure

If you search for wisdom VERSES 1–11

1 My son, if you receive my words
and store up my commandments within you,
2 so that you turn your ear to wisdom
and set your heart on understanding,
3 yes, if you call out for good sense
and raise your voice for understanding,
4 if you look for her like silver
and search for her as for hidden treasures,
5 then you will understand the fear of the LORD
and find the knowledge of God.
6 For the LORD gives wisdom.
Out of his mouth come knowledge and understanding.
7 He stores up sound wisdom for the upright.
He is a shield for those who live with integrity,
8 so that he may guard the paths of justice
and protect the way of his holy ones.
9 Then you will understand righteousness and justice,
fairness and every good path.
10 For wisdom will come into your heart.
Knowledge will be pleasant to your soul.
11 Good judgment will watch over you.
Understanding will protect you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wisdom does not fall from the sky. You have to search for it, like a treasure hunter who digs for silver. You have to listen, call out, search.

But at the same time, wisdom is a gift: "The LORD gives wisdom" (verse 6). Both belong together: our searching and God's giving.

Verse 11: Whoever is wise has a guard inside. He notices in time when something becomes dangerous.

Wisdom protects you VERSES 12–22

12 She will save you from the way of evil,
from the men who speak twisted things,
13 who leave the paths of uprightness
to walk in the ways of darkness,
14 who are happy to do evil
and enjoy the twisted ways of evil,
15 who are crooked in their ways
and wrong in their paths.
16 She will save you from the strange woman,
from the foreign woman who flatters with her words,
17 who leaves the friend of her youth
and forgets the covenant of her God.
18 For her house leads down to death,
her paths to the spirits of the dead.
19 No one who goes to her comes back again.
They do not reach the paths of life.
20 So walk in the way of good men,
and keep to the paths of the righteous!
21 For the upright will live in the land.
The blameless will stay in it.
22 But the wicked will be cut off from the land.
The unfaithful will be torn out of it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wisdom protects from two dangers: from evil men (verses 12–15) and from the "strange woman" (verses 16–19).

The "strange woman" is a woman who leaves her husband ("the friend of her youth") and seduces another man. This is about adultery. "Strange" here means: she does not belong to you, she is married to someone else. It is not a statement against foreign women or against women in general.

Because the book was written for young men, it speaks of the seductive woman. But the warning is just as true the other way around: for women facing seductive men. Unfaithfulness destroys relationships and lives.

Verse 17: Marriage is a covenant before God. Whoever breaks it breaks more than a promise to a person.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 3

Trust in the LORD with all your heart

Kindness and truth VERSES 1–4

1 My son, don't forget what I teach you.
Keep my commandments in your heart.
2 They will give you a long life,
many years of life, and peace.
3 Don't let kindness and truth leave you.
Tie them around your neck.
Write them on your heart, as if it were a tablet.
4 Then God and people will like you.
They will think well of you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Kindness and truth should be as close to you as a chain around your neck. And they should be deep inside you, as if written on your heart.

Verse 4: Whoever is kind and faithful is valued by God and people. Something similar is said later about Jesus as a child (Luke 2:52).

Don't rely on your own understanding VERSES 5–12

5 Trust in the LORD with all your heart.
Don't depend on your own understanding.
6 Think of him in everything you do.
Then he will make your paths straight.
7 Don't think that you are wise.
Fear the LORD, and turn away from evil.
8 That will be healing for your body
and strength for your bones.
9 Honor the LORD with what you own.
Give him the first fruits of all your harvest.
10 Then your barns will be full,
and your wine vats will overflow with new wine.
11 My son, don't reject the LORD's discipline.
Don't be annoyed when he corrects you.
12 The LORD corrects the one he loves,
just as a father corrects the son he takes delight in.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6 are among the best-known verses of the Bible. Our understanding is good, but it has limits. Whoever trusts God and includes him in all decisions finds the right way.

Verse 7: Whoever thinks he already knows everything cannot learn anything anymore.

Verses 9–10: The "first fruits" are the first and best part of the harvest. People gave it to God as thanks. The principle is still true today: God first, not last. But it is not a trick to get rich.

Verses 11–12: When God corrects us, it is a sign of his love, as with good parents. The letter to the Hebrews quotes these verses (Hebrews 12:5–6). "Correct" here means bringing up a child, not violence.

Wisdom is worth more than gold VERSES 13–20

13 Happy is the person who finds wisdom,
the person who gains understanding.
14 Wisdom brings more profit than silver.
What she gives you is better than fine gold.
15 She is worth more than rubies.
Nothing you could wish for is as valuable as she is.
16 In her right hand she holds a long life.
In her left hand she holds riches and honor.
17 Her ways are pleasant ways.
All her paths lead to peace.
18 She is a tree of life for those who take hold of her.
Happy is everyone who holds on to her.
19 The LORD made the earth with wisdom.
He set the heavens in place with understanding.
20 With his knowledge he broke open the deep waters.
With his knowledge the skies let the dew fall.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wisdom is worth more than gold, silver and precious stones. For with wisdom you can live well. Money cannot promise that.

Verse 18: "A tree of life" reminds us of the Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:9). Whoever holds on to wisdom finds real life. In Judaism, people sing this verse when the Torah scroll is put back into its cabinet.

Verses 19–20: God made the whole world with wisdom. Whoever lives wisely lives in harmony with creation.

Then you can sleep in peace VERSES 21–26

21 My son, keep these things always in sight.
Hold on to good wisdom and careful thinking.
22 They will give life to your soul.
They will be like jewelry around your neck.
23 Then you will walk safely on your way.
You will not trip.
24 When you lie down, you will not be afraid.
You will lie down, and you will sleep well.
25 Don't be afraid of sudden terror.
Don't be afraid when ruin comes on the wicked.

26 The LORD will be your confidence.
He will keep your foot from being caught in a trap.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever lives wisely has a good conscience and can sleep in peace.

Verse 26: The real reason for this peace is not our cleverness, but God: He is our confidence.

Do good when you can VERSES 27–35

27 Do good to those who need it.
Don't hold it back when you are able to do it.
28 You have something with you that your neighbor needs.
Then don't say to him, "Go away and come back later.
I will give it to you tomorrow."
29 Don't plan evil against your neighbor.
He lives next to you and trusts you.
30 Don't argue with anyone without a reason
if he has not harmed you.
31 Don't envy a violent man.
Don't choose any of his ways.
32 The LORD hates people who are crooked.
But he is a close friend to honest people.
33 The LORD's curse is on the house of the wicked.
But he blesses the home of those who do right.
34 He mocks those who mock others.
But he is gracious to humble people.
35 Wise people will receive honor.
But fools will only be raised up to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 27–28: Very practical: If you can help someone and he needs it, do it now. Don't put it off until tomorrow. This is especially true for wages, debts or help for the poor.

Verses 29–30: Being a good neighbor: Don't take advantage of other people's trust, and don't start pointless quarrels.

Verse 31: Violent people sometimes seem successful. But don't envy them.

Verse 34: This verse is quoted in the New Testament: "God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble" (James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5).

Verse 35: "Fools will only be raised up to shame": Whoever lives foolishly only seems to rise. In reality, his way leads to shame.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 4

Guard your heart

What my father taught me VERSES 1–9

1 Listen, sons, to a father's instruction!
Pay attention, so that you know understanding!
2 For I give you good teaching.
Don't leave my law!
3 For I was a son to my father too,
tender and the only child in the eyes of my mother.
4 He taught me and said to me:
"Let your heart hold on to my words.
Keep my commandments, and you will live.
5 Get wisdom! Get understanding!
Don't forget, and don't turn away from the words of my mouth!
6 Don't leave her, and she will keep you safe.
Love her, and she will protect you.
7 Wisdom is the most important thing. Get wisdom!
Yes, even if it costs everything you own, get understanding!
8 Value her highly, and she will lift you up.
She will bring you to honor when you embrace her.
9 She will give your head a beautiful wreath.
She will hand you a splendid crown."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a father speaks who learned from his own father. Wisdom is passed on from generation to generation: from grandfather to father to son.

Verse 3: A loving look back: The father remembers how he himself was a small, tender child, loved by his mother.

Verse 7: Wisdom is the most important thing. It is worth giving everything for it. Jesus tells a similar parable about a man who sells everything to buy a precious pearl (Matthew 13:45–46).

Two ways: light and darkness VERSES 10–19

10 Listen, my son, and receive my words!
Then the years of your life will be many.
11 I have taught you in the way of wisdom.
I have led you on straight paths.
12 When you walk, your steps will not be held back.
When you run, you will not stumble.
13 Hold on tight to instruction! Don't let her go!
Keep her, for she is your life.
14 Don't step onto the path of the wicked!
Don't walk in the way of evil men!
15 Avoid it, and don't walk on it!
Turn away from it, and go on!
16 For they don't sleep unless they have done evil.
Their sleep is taken away unless they have made someone fall.
17 For they eat the bread of wickedness
and drink the wine of violence.
18 But the path of the righteous is like the light of dawn
that shines brighter and brighter until the full day.
19 The way of the wicked is like darkness.
They don't know what they stumble over.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: Wise advice: Don't even start on the wrong path. Stay well away from it.

Verses 16–17: Evil people are addicted to evil. They cannot sleep until they have harmed someone.

Verses 18–19: A beautiful picture: The way of the righteous is like the sunrise. It keeps getting brighter. The way of the wicked is dark. They stumble and don't even know why.

Guard your heart VERSES 20–27

20 My son, pay attention to my words!
Turn your ear to what I say!
21 Don't let them out of your sight!
Keep them in the center of your heart!
22 For they are life to those who find them,
and health to their whole body.
23 Guard your heart with all care,
for out of it is the spring of life.
24 Keep a twisted mouth away from you!
Keep lying lips far away from you!
25 Let your eyes look straight ahead!
Fix your gaze directly in front of you!
26 Make the path of your feet level!
Let all your ways be firm.
27 Don't turn to the right or to the left!
Keep your foot away from evil!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23 is one of the most important sentences of the book. In the Bible, the heart is not only feelings. It is the center of a person: thinking, wanting, feeling. Everything we do comes out of the heart. So: Take good care of your heart! What do you let in? What do you think? What do you want?

Verses 24–27: The whole person is needed: the mouth (what I say), the eyes (where I look), the feet (where I go).

Verse 25: Look ahead to your goal, and don't let yourself be distracted.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 5

Stay faithful to your wife

Sweet as honey, bitter as wormwood VERSES 1–14

1 My son, pay attention to my wisdom!
Turn your ear to my understanding,
2 so that you keep good judgment
and your lips protect knowledge.
3 For the lips of an adulteress drip honey.
Her mouth is smoother than oil.
4 But in the end she is as bitter as wormwood
and as sharp as a two-edged sword.
5 Her feet go down to death.
Her steps lead straight to Sheol (the world of the dead).
6 She does not think about the way of life.
Her ways are crooked, and she does not know it.
7 So now, my sons, listen to me!
Don't turn away from the words of my mouth!
8 Keep your way far from her!
Don't come near the door of her house,
9 so that you don't give your honor to others
and your years to the cruel one,
10 so that strangers don't feast on your wealth
and your hard work does not make another man's house rich.
11 You will groan at the end,
when your flesh and your body are worn out,
12 and you will say, "How I hated instruction,
and my heart despised correction!
13 I did not obey the voice of my teachers.
I did not turn my ear to those who taught me!
14 I have almost come to complete ruin,
in the middle of the gathered assembly."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The father warns his son against adultery. At the beginning, the temptation seems sweet as honey. But in the end it is as bitter as wormwood, a very bitter plant.

Verses 9–10: Whoever cheats loses a lot: honor, years of life, money. Back then, adultery could cost heavy punishments and payments of compensation.

Verses 12–14: In the end, the man is sorry: If only I had listened to my teachers!

As in Chapter 2: The book speaks to young men. The warning against unfaithfulness is for everyone, for men and for women.

Drink from your own well VERSES 15–23

15 Drink water out of your own cistern,
running water out of your own well!
16 Should your springs overflow into the streets,
streams of water into the public squares?
17 Let them belong to you alone,
not to strangers with you.
18 Let your spring be blessed!
Be happy with the wife of your youth,
19 a loving doe, a graceful deer!
Let her breasts satisfy you at all times.
Let yourself always be captivated by her love.
20 For why, my son, should you be captivated by an adulteress?
Why should you embrace the breast of another woman?
21 For a person's ways are before the LORD's eyes.
He examines all his paths.
22 The evil deeds of the wicked catch him.
The ropes of his sin hold him tight.
23 He will die because he has no instruction.
In the greatness of his foolishness, he will go astray.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the Bible speaks openly and positively about love and sexuality in marriage.

Verses 15–17: Your "own well" is a picture for your own wife. In a dry land, having your own well was a great treasure. You do not share it with strangers.

Verses 18–19: Be happy with your wife! Let yourself be captivated by her love again and again, even after many

years. The Bible sees physical love in marriage as something beautiful and good (compare the Song of Songs).

Verse 21: God sees everything, even what happens in secret.
Verse 22: Sin is like a rope that you get caught in yourself.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 6

Go to the ant!

Guaranteeing a debt: Free yourself quickly VERSES 1–5

1 My son, if you have guaranteed a loan for your neighbor,
if you have shaken hands on a promise for a stranger,
2 then you are trapped by the words of your mouth.
You are caught by the words of your mouth.
3 Do this now, my son, and save yourself,
since you have come into the hand of your neighbor:
Go, humble yourself!
Press your request with your neighbor!
4 Give no sleep to your eyes
and no slumber to your eyelids!
5 Free yourself like a gazelle from the hand of the hunter,
like a bird from the trap of the bird catcher!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To "guarantee a loan" means: I promise to pay someone else's debts if he cannot. Back then, people sealed this with a handshake.

The advice: If you have given such a guarantee without thinking, try to get out of it quickly. Otherwise you can lose everything.

This advice is still relevant today. Many people get into great debt by guaranteeing loans for friends or relatives. That does not mean that we should not help. But we should not promise anything that we cannot carry.

If you have debts and need help: In many countries, nonprofit debt counseling services help for free.

Learn from the ant VERSES 6–11

6 Go to the ant, you lazy person!
Look at her ways, and become wise!
7 She has no leader,
no overseer and no ruler.
8 Still, she gets her bread ready in the summer
and gathers her food at harvest time.
9 How long will you sleep, you lazy person?
When will you get up from your sleep?
10 A little sleep, a little slumber,
a little folding of the hands to sleep,
11 and your poverty will come like a robber
and your need like an armed man.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The little ant is an example: No one has to drive her on. Still, she works hard and gets ready for the winter.

Verses 10–11: Laziness comes in small steps: "A little sleep, a little slumber …" Today people say: Just five more minutes. And suddenly need is there, like a robber who comes by surprise.

Important: This is about laziness, not about people who are sick, worn out or unemployed. Poverty often has very different causes. The Bible calls many times for helping the poor.

The troublemaker VERSES 12–15

12 A worthless person, a man of wrongdoing,
is the one who goes around with a twisted mouth,
13 who winks with his eyes,
who gives signals with his feet,
who points with his fingers,
14 whose heart is twisted,
who plans evil all the time,
who always sows quarrels.
15 So his disaster will come suddenly.
He will be broken suddenly, and there is no healing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture of a sneaky person: He speaks falsely and gives secret signals with his eyes, feet and fingers. In this way he makes plans with others against someone.

He keeps stirring up quarrels. But in the end, his behavior falls back on himself.

Seven things that God hates VERSES 16–19

16 There are six things that the LORD hates,
yes, seven that are disgusting to him:
17 proud eyes, a lying tongue,
hands that shed innocent blood,
18 a heart that makes wicked plans,
feet that run quickly to do harm,
19 a false witness who tells lies,
and the one who sows quarrels among brothers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Six, yes seven": a typical way of counting that puts special weight on the last one. The seventh is the worst: sowing quarrels between people who belong together.

The list goes through the whole body: eyes, tongue, hands, heart, feet. Evil can be done with everything we have.

God does not hate the people, but these deeds, because they hurt others and destroy community.

The commandment is a lamp VERSES 20–35

20 My son, keep your father's commandment,
and don't leave your mother's teaching!
21 Tie them on your heart always!
Tie them around your neck!
22 When you walk, it will lead you.
When you sleep, it will watch over you.
When you wake up, it will talk with you.
23 For the commandment is a lamp, and the law is light.
The correction that comes with instruction is the way of life,

24 to keep you from the immoral woman,
from the flattering tongue of the unfaithful wife.
25 Don't desire her beauty in your heart,
and don't let her catch you with her eyelids!
26 For a prostitute brings you down to a piece of bread.
The adulteress hunts for your precious life.
27 Can a man scoop fire into his lap
and his clothes not be burned?
28 Or can someone walk on hot coals
and his feet not be burned?
29 So it is with the one who goes in to his neighbor's wife.
Whoever touches her will not go unpunished.
30 People don't despise a thief
if he steals to fill himself when he is hungry.
31 But if he is caught, he must pay back seven times as much.
He must give all the wealth of his house.
32 Whoever commits adultery with a woman has no sense.
Whoever does it destroys his own life.
33 He will get wounds and dishonor.
His shame will not be wiped away.
34 For jealousy wakes up the husband's anger.
He will not hold back on the day of revenge.
35 He will not accept any ransom.
He will not be satisfied, even if you give many gifts.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: The good teachings of parents go with you through your whole life: during the day, at night and in the morning.

Verse 23: "The commandment is a lamp": like Psalm 119:105.

Verses 27–28: Whoever cheats is playing with fire. You cannot walk on hot coals without getting burned.

Verses 30–35: A comparison: A thief who steals because he is hungry can still be understood. He can make up for the damage. But adultery cannot be made good with money. The hurt husband cannot be bought.

Verse 34: This describes how a betrayed man may react. It is not permission for revenge or violence. It only shows how deep the wound of unfaithfulness goes.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 7

The young man and the seductive woman

Call wisdom your sister VERSES 1–5

1 My son, hold on to my words.
Keep my commandments safe inside you.
2 Keep my commandments, and you will live.
Guard my teaching as carefully as the pupil of your eye.
3 Tie them on your fingers.
Write them on your heart, as if it were a tablet.
4 Say to wisdom, "You are my sister."
Call understanding your close relative.
5 Then they will protect you from the woman who is not your wife,
from the foreign woman with her flattering words.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "As carefully as the pupil of your eye": The pupil is the dark center of the eye. You protect it very carefully.

Verse 3: "Tie them on your fingers": In Judaism, people tie small boxes with Bible words to their arm and head when they pray (tefillin). This recalls verses like these (compare Deuteronomy 6:8).

Verse 4: Wisdom should be as close to you as a sister.

A story at the window VERSES 6–23

6 Once I was at the window of my house.
I looked out through the lattice.
7 I saw some young people who had no experience.
Among them I noticed a young man who had no sense.
8 He walked along the street near her corner.
He went on the road to her house.
9 It was at twilight, in the evening.
It was in the middle of the night, in the dark.
10 Look, a woman came to meet him.
She was dressed like a prostitute, and she had a sly plan.
11 She is loud and rebellious.
She never stays at home.
12 Sometimes she is in the streets, sometimes in the squares.
She lies in wait at every corner.
13 She grabbed him and kissed him.
Without any shame she said to him:
14 "I have peace offerings at home.
Today I have paid what I promised to God.
15 That is why I came out to meet you.
I was eager to find you, and now I have found you.
16 I have spread colorful covers on my couch,
striped sheets made of yarn from Egypt.
17 I have sprinkled my bed
with myrrh, aloes, and cinnamon.
18 Come, let's make love until the morning.
Let's enjoy each other's love.
19 My husband is not at home.
He has gone on a long trip.
20 He took a bag of money with him.
He will not come home until the full moon."
21 She talked him into it with her persuasive words.
She seduced him with her flattering lips.
22 He followed her right away,
like an ox that goes to be slaughtered,
like a fool who steps into a noose.
23 In the end an arrow pierces his liver.
He is like a bird that rushes into a trap.
It does not know that it will cost its life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The father tells a story that he watched from the window. In the evening, a young man without experience goes on purpose to the area where the woman lives. He is looking for temptation.

Verse 14: With a peace offering, people got meat back, which had to be eaten at home. So the woman is saying: I have a good meal at home. She even uses religion for her seduction.

Verse 17: Myrrh, aloes and cinnamon are sweet-smelling spices.

Verses 19–20: Her husband is away, no one will notice. Temptation often sounds like this: No one will find out.

Verses 22–23: The young man does not notice that he is walking into a trap, like an animal going to the butcher.

The story warns against unfaithfulness and against thinking "just this once."

Her house is the way to death VERSES 24–27

24 So now, my sons, listen to me.
Pay attention to what I say.
25 Don't let your heart turn toward her ways.
Don't wander onto her paths.
26 She has brought down many victims.
She has killed a huge number of people.
27 Her house is the road to Sheol (the world of the dead).
Her house leads down to the rooms of death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unfaithfulness has already destroyed many lives: marriages, families, children, trust.

The father's advice: Don't even let your heart go in this direction. The decision is made in the heart, long before anything happens (compare Proverbs 4:23).

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 8

Wisdom speaks

Wisdom calls all people VERSES 1–11

1 Doesn't wisdom call out?
Doesn't understanding raise her voice?
2 On top of the high places by the way,
where the paths meet, there she stands.
3 Beside the gates, at the entrance of the city,
at the entrance doors, she calls aloud:
4 "I call to you men!
My voice goes out to all people.
5 You simple ones, understand good sense!
You fools, get an understanding heart!
6 Listen, for I will speak excellent things.
What my lips say is right.
7 For my mouth speaks truth.
Wickedness is disgusting to my lips.
8 All the words of my mouth are righteous.
There is nothing crooked or twisted in them.
9 They are all clear to the one who understands,
right to those who find knowledge.
10 Receive my instruction rather than silver,
knowledge rather than the best gold!
11 For wisdom is better than rubies.
Nothing you can wish for compares to it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As in Chapter 1, wisdom calls out in public, where everyone passes by: at crossroads and at the city gates. Her invitation is for all people.

Her words are true, righteous and clear. They are worth more than gold and precious stones.

Kings reign by me VERSES 12–21

12 "I, wisdom, live with good sense.
Find knowledge and good judgment!
13 The fear of the LORD means: hating evil.
I hate pride, arrogance, the evil way, and the twisted mouth.
14 Advice and sound knowledge are mine.
I have understanding and power.
15 By me kings reign,
and rulers decide what is just.
16 By me princes and nobles rule,
all the righteous rulers of the earth.
17 I love those who love me.
Those who search for me eagerly will find me.
18 With me are riches and honor,
lasting wealth and success.
19 My fruit is better than gold, yes, than fine gold,
what I bring in is better than the best silver.
20 I walk in the way of righteousness,
in the middle of the paths of justice,
21 so that I may give wealth to those who love me.
I fill their treasuries.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Fear of God shows itself in a very practical way: You hate evil, especially pride and lies.

Verses 15–16: Good politics needs wisdom. Rulers should govern justly. That is still true today for everyone who carries responsibility.

Verse 17: A beautiful promise: Whoever searches for wisdom will find it.

I was there when God made the world VERSES 22–31

22 "The LORD had me at the beginning of his work,
before his deeds of long ago.
23 I was set up from everlasting,
from the beginning, before the earth existed.
24 When there were no depths, I was born,
when there were no springs full of water.
25 Before the mountains were set in their place,
before the hills, I was born,
26 when he had not yet made the earth,
or the fields,
or the first dust of the world.

27 When he set up the heavens, I was there.
When he drew a circle on the surface of the deep,
28 when he made the clouds above firm,
when the springs of the deep became strong,
29 when he gave the sea its boundary,
so that the waters would not go beyond his command,
when he marked out the foundations of the earth,
30 then I was the master builder at his side.
Day by day I was his delight,
always rejoicing before him.
31 I rejoiced in his whole world.
My delight was with the human race.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most beautiful texts in the book. Wisdom tells: Before there were mountains, seas and earth, I was already with God. I was there when he created everything.

Verse 30: Wisdom was like a master builder at God's side. Or, as the Hebrew word can also be translated: like a child who plays before God and is full of joy. Creation is full of joy.

Verse 31: Wisdom especially likes to be with people.

Jews often see wisdom as the Torah, God's teaching, which was with God even before the world. Christians see in this text a pointer to Christ. The Gospel of John says: "In the beginning was the Word. The Word was with God. … Everything was made through him" (John 1:1–3). Paul calls Christ "the wisdom of God" (1 Corinthians 1:24).

Whoever finds me finds life VERSES 32–36

32 "So now, my sons, listen to me,
for happy are those who keep my ways.
33 Listen to instruction, and be wise!
Don't refuse it!
34 Happy is the person who listens to me,
watching at my gates every day,
waiting at the posts of my door.
35 For whoever finds me finds life
and will receive favor from the LORD.
36 But whoever sins against me harms his own soul.
All those who hate me love death."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 34: A picture like someone in love who waits every day in front of the door of the person they love. That is how longingly we should search for wisdom.

Verses 35–36: It is about life or death. Whoever finds wisdom finds life. Whoever rejects it harms himself.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 9

Two invitations

Lady Wisdom invites VERSES 1–6

1 Wisdom has built her house.
She has cut out its seven pillars.
2 She has cooked her meat.
She has mixed her wine.
She has also set her table.
3 She has sent out her servant girls.
She calls out from the highest places in the city:
4 "Whoever has no experience, come in here!"
To people who have no sense, she says,
5 "Come, eat some of my bread.
Drink some of the wine I have mixed.
6 Stop being foolish, and live.
Walk on the road of understanding."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wisdom is like a generous hostess. She has built a beautiful house and prepared a feast. She invites everyone, especially those who do not know much yet.

"Seven pillars": The number seven stands for completeness. Her house is perfect.

Jesus tells a similar parable about the great feast to which everyone is invited (Luke 14:15–24).

Who lets himself be taught? VERSES 7–12

7 If you correct a mocker, he will insult you.
If you correct a wicked man, he will hurt you.
8 Don't correct a mocker, or he will hate you.
Correct a wise person, and he will love you.
9 Teach a wise person, and he will become even wiser.
Teach a person who does right, and he will learn even more.
10 The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.
To know the Holy One is understanding.
11 Through me you will live many days.
Years will be added to your life.
12 If you are wise, your wisdom helps you.
If you mock, you alone will suffer for it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9: A test: How does someone react to criticism? The mocker becomes angry. The wise person is thankful and learns from it. Wise people are glad to be corrected.

Verse 10: Here the motto from Proverbs 1:7 is repeated. So the first big part of the book ends the way it began.

Verse 12: Everyone is responsible for himself. Wisdom helps you yourself. Mocking harms you yourself.

Lady Folly invites too VERSES 13–18

13 The foolish woman is loud.
She has no self-control, and she knows nothing.
14 She sits at the door of her house,
on a seat in the highest places of the city.
15 She calls out to the people who walk by,
who are going straight along their way:
16 "Whoever has no experience, come in here!"
To people who have no sense, she says,
17 "Stolen water is sweet.
Food eaten in secret tastes good."
18 But they don't know that the spirits of the dead are there.

Her guests are deep down in Sheol (the world of the dead).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the opposite picture: Lady Folly. She invites too, with exactly the same words as wisdom (verse 4 and verse 16). Both call those without experience.

But Folly has prepared nothing. She offers only "stolen water" and "food eaten in secret": what is forbidden, which seems especially attractive.

Verse 18: Her guests do not notice that in reality they are sitting in the world of the dead.

Every person faces this choice: Which invitation do I follow? Wisdom, which leads to life, or Folly, which sounds tempting but leads to death?

This ends the first part of the book (Chapters 1–9). From Chapter 10 on come the single short proverbs of Solomon.

PROVERBS

Chapter 10

The proverbs of Solomon begin

Hard work and righteousness VERSES 1–7

1 The proverbs of Solomon.
A wise son makes his father glad,
but a foolish son brings grief to his mother.
2 Treasures gained by wickedness are no use,
but righteousness saves from death.
3 The LORD will not let the soul of the righteous go hungry,
but he pushes away the craving of the wicked.
4 Whoever works with a lazy hand becomes poor,
but the hand of the hard worker brings wealth.
5 Whoever gathers in summer is a wise son,
but whoever sleeps during the harvest is a son who brings shame.
6 Blessings are on the head of the righteous,
but violence covers the mouth of the wicked.
7 The memory of the righteous is a blessing,
but the name of the wicked will rot.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the second big part of the book begins: the short proverbs of Solomon (Proverbs 10:1 to 22:16).

Almost every proverb has two lines. Often the second line shows the opposite of the first, like this: "The wise … but the fool …" In this way, you learn by comparing.

The proverbs mostly stand alone. You can read each one by itself and think about it. The headings in this edition only give a rough summary.

Verse 1: What children do affects their parents too. Here father and mother are named.

Verses 4–5: Hard work usually pays off. But as the introduction already said: Proverbs describe what is normal, not every single case. Not every poor person is lazy.

Verse 7: Good people are remembered well: "The memory of the righteous is a blessing." To this day, Jews say about someone who has died: May his memory be a blessing.

The power of words VERSES 8–21

8 Whoever is wise in heart accepts commandments,
but a chattering fool will fall.
9 Whoever lives blamelessly walks safely,
but whoever goes crooked ways will be found out.
10 Whoever winks with the eye causes sorrow,
but a chattering fool will fall.
11 The mouth of the righteous is a spring of life,
but violence covers the mouth of the wicked.
12 Hatred stirs up quarrels,
but love covers all wrongs.
13 Wisdom is found on the lips of the one who has understanding,
but a rod is for the back of the one who has no sense.
14 Wise people store up knowledge,
but the mouth of the fool is close to ruin.
15 The rich man's wealth is his strong city.
The ruin of the poor is their poverty.
16 The work of the righteous leads to life.
The gain of the wicked leads to sin.
17 Whoever pays attention to correction is on the way of life,
but whoever rejects correction leads others astray.
18 Whoever hides hatred has lying lips.
Whoever spreads slander is a fool.
19 Where there are many words, there is no lack of disobedience,
but whoever holds back his lips acts wisely.
20 The tongue of the righteous is like the best silver.
The heart of the wicked is worth little.
21 The lips of the righteous feed many,
but fools die for lack of understanding.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many proverbs are about our words. Words can give life (verse 11) or cause harm.

Verse 12: A famous sentence: "Love covers all wrongs." Whoever loves does not expose the mistakes of others, but forgives. The New Testament quotes this sentence (1 Peter 4:8; compare James 5:20).

Verse 13: Back then, the "rod" was a normal way to bring up children. Today we know: Violence against children does harm, and in many countries, including Germany, it is against the law. The message of the proverb stays: Whoever does not want to listen must bear the consequences.

Verse 15: A sober look: Money protects. Poverty makes people vulnerable. This is an observation, not an excuse. In other places, the book calls for helping the poor.

Verse 19: Whoever talks a lot also says a lot that is wrong. Sometimes silence is wiser.

The blessing of the LORD VERSES 22–32

22 The LORD's blessing brings wealth,
and he adds no trouble to it.
23 For a fool it is fun to do wickedness,
but for a man of understanding wisdom is a joy.

24 What the wicked fear will catch up with them,
but the wish of the righteous will be granted.
25 When the whirlwind passes, the wicked is gone,
but the righteous stand firm forever.
26 Like vinegar to the teeth and like smoke to the eyes,
so is the lazy person to those who send him.
27 The fear of the LORD makes life longer,
but the years of the wicked will be shortened.
28 What the righteous look forward to is joy,
but the hope of the wicked will come to nothing.
29 The way of the LORD is a fortress for the upright,
but ruin for those who do wrong.
30 The righteous will never be shaken,
but the wicked will not live in the land.
31 The mouth of the righteous brings forth wisdom,
but the twisted tongue will be cut off.
32 The lips of the righteous know what is pleasing,
but the mouth of the wicked is twisted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: What God gives does not bring sorrow with it. Wealth gained through wrongdoing, on the other hand, brings worries.

Verse 25: When a storm comes, it becomes clear who stands on firm ground. Jesus tells a similar parable about the house on the rock (Matthew 7:24–27).

Verse 26: A funny comparison: A lazy messenger is as unpleasant as vinegar on your teeth or smoke in your eyes.

Verse 27: This is a general experience, not a guarantee. Good people sometimes die young too. The book of Job and Ecclesiastes speak openly about this.

PROVERBS

Chapter 11

Honest scales and generous hearts

Honesty and humility VERSES 1–8

1 A false scale is disgusting to the LORD,
but accurate weights please him.
2 When pride comes, then comes shame,
but with humility comes wisdom.
3 The honesty of the upright guides them,
but the crooked ways of the unfaithful destroy them.
4 Riches are no use on the day of anger,
but righteousness saves from death.
5 The righteousness of the blameless makes his way straight,
but the wicked falls by his own wickedness.
6 The righteousness of the upright saves them,
but the unfaithful are trapped by their evil desires.
7 When a wicked man dies, his hope is lost,
and the expectation of power comes to nothing.
8 A righteous person is saved out of trouble,
and the wicked takes his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: In trade, people used scales with stone weights. Some traders cheated with false weights. God hates cheating in business. That is just as true today: false bills, hidden costs, lies in advertising.

Verse 2: "When pride comes, then comes shame." From verses like this came a well-known saying: Pride comes before a fall.

Verse 4: In the end, what counts is not how much money someone has, but how he has lived.

The city and the neighbor VERSES 9–15

9 With his mouth the godless man destroys his neighbor,
but the righteous are saved through knowledge.
10 When things go well for the righteous, the city is glad.
When the wicked die, there is shouting for joy.
11 By the blessing of the upright, the city is lifted up,
but by the mouth of the wicked it is torn down.
12 Whoever looks down on his neighbor has no wisdom,
but a man of understanding keeps quiet.
13 Whoever spreads gossip gives away secrets,
but whoever has a faithful spirit keeps a secret.
14 Where there is no wise guidance, a nation falls,
but where there are many advisers, there is victory.
15 Whoever guarantees a loan for a stranger will suffer for it,
but whoever refuses to guarantee loans is safe.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Good and honest people are a blessing for the whole city, for society. Evil words can destroy a city.

Verse 13: Whoever passes on secrets destroys trust. A faithful friend can keep quiet.

Verse 14: Good decisions need many wise advisers. No one should decide alone, least of all someone who has power.

Verse 15: Again the warning against guaranteeing loans (compare Proverbs 6:1–5).

Generosity pays off VERSES 16–26

16 A gracious woman gains honor,
but violent men gain riches.
17 The merciful person does good to himself,
but the cruel person harms his own flesh.
18 The wicked earn wages that deceive,
but whoever sows righteousness reaps a sure reward.
19 Whoever is truly righteous gets life.
Whoever chases after evil gets death.
20 Those who have a twisted heart are disgusting to the LORD,
but those whose ways are blameless please him.
21 Most certainly, the evil person will not go unpunished,
but the descendants of the righteous will be saved.
22 Like a gold ring in a pig's snout,
so is a beautiful woman who has no sense.
23 The wish of the righteous is only good.
What the wicked can expect is anger.

24 One person gives freely and gets more and more.
Another holds back more than is right, and still
becomes poor.
25 The generous soul will be richly filled.
Whoever gives others water will get water himself.
26 People curse someone who holds back grain,
but blessing comes on the head of the one who sells it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: You gain honor by being kind. Violent people may get money, but no real honor.

Verse 17: Whoever is merciful does himself good. Whoever is cruel harms himself too in the end.

Verse 22: A strong picture: Beauty without sense is like gold jewelry on a pig that digs around in the dirt. Of course this is just as true for men.

Verses 24–25: A surprising principle: Whoever gives generously does not become poorer, but richer, in joy, in friends and often in blessing too. Whoever is stingy gains nothing by it.

Verse 26: Whoever stores up grain during a famine to drive up the price is acting wrongly. This is still true today for speculating with food.

The tree of life VERSES 27–31

27 Whoever eagerly looks for good looks for favor,
but whoever searches for evil, it will come to him.
28 Whoever trusts in his riches will fall,
but the righteous will flourish like green leaves.
29 Whoever brings trouble on his own house will inherit
the wind.
The fool will be servant to the one who is wise in heart.
30 The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life.
Whoever is wise wins people.
31 Look, the righteous are paid back on the earth.
How much more the wicked and the sinner!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: Money is no safe support. Righteous people are like a tree with fresh leaves (compare Psalm 1:3).

Verse 29: Whoever brings quarrels into his own family is left with empty hands in the end. He "will inherit the wind."

Verse 30: "Whoever is wise wins people": A wise person draws others to him and can help them.

Verse 31: Everyone feels the results of his actions already here on earth. Peter quotes this verse in its Greek form (1 Peter 4:18).

PROVERBS

Chapter 12

Whoever loves correction

Learning and family VERSES 1–8

1 Whoever loves correction loves knowledge,
but whoever hates being corrected is stupid.
2 A good person gets favor from the LORD,
but he condemns a person with wicked plans.
3 A person is not made secure by wickedness,
but the root of the righteous will not be moved.
4 A capable woman is the crown of her husband,
but a wife who brings shame is like rot in his bones.
5 The thoughts of the righteous are just,
but the advice of the wicked is deceitful.
6 The words of the wicked lie in wait for blood,
but the speech of the upright rescues them.
7 The wicked are overthrown and are no more,
but the house of the righteous will stand.
8 A person is praised for his wisdom,
but whoever has a twisted mind will be despised.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: An honest sentence: Whoever does not want to be criticized stays stupid. Whoever wants to learn from mistakes becomes wise.

Verse 3: A tree with deep roots does not fall in a storm. It is the same with righteous people.

Verse 4: A good wife is like a crown, a great treasure. A partner who brings shame makes life hard. This is true for both sides of a marriage.

Hard work and kindness to animals VERSES 9–14

9 Better is someone who is little known and has a servant
than someone who thinks he is important and has no
bread.
10 A righteous person cares about the life of his animal,
but even the kindness of the wicked is cruel.
11 Whoever works his land will have plenty of bread,
but whoever chases fantasies has no sense.
12 The wicked person wants the plunder of evil men,
but the root of the righteous flourishes.
13 An evil person is trapped by the sin of his lips,
but the righteous gets out of trouble.
14 A person is filled with good things by the fruit of his
mouth.
What a person's hands do will be paid back to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Better to be modest and have enough than to show off and go hungry.

Verse 10: A beautiful verse about protecting animals: A righteous person takes care of his animals. Whoever torments animals shows what is in his heart. The laws of Moses already protected animals (for example Deuteronomy 25:4).

Verse 11: Whoever works hard has food to eat. Whoever only chases dreams and quick riches ends up with nothing.

Words that heal VERSES 15–23

15 The way of a fool is right in his own eyes,
but whoever is wise listens to advice.

16 A fool shows his anger the same day,
but whoever overlooks an insult is wise.
17 Whoever is truthful gives honest testimony,
but a false witness lies.
18 Some people speak without thinking, and it is like the stabbing of a sword,
but the tongue of the wise heals.
19 Truthful lips will last forever,
but a lying tongue lasts only for a moment.
20 Deceit is in the heart of those who plan evil,
but those who encourage peace have joy.
21 No harm will happen to the righteous,
but the wicked will be filled with evil.
22 Lying lips are disgusting to the LORD,
but those who do the truth please him.
23 A wise person keeps his knowledge to himself,
but the heart of fools announces foolishness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A fool always thinks he is right. A wise person asks others too.

Verse 16: Whoever strikes back at once when he is insulted makes everything worse. Whoever stays calm is wise.

Verse 18: Words can hurt like a sword. But words can also heal. Everyone has the choice.

Verse 19: Lies do not get far. The truth lasts.

Verse 20: Whoever makes peace has joy (compare Matthew 5:9: "Blessed are those who make peace").

Verse 21: This is no guarantee that good people never suffer. It means: In the end, evil will not defeat the righteous.

A kind word VERSES 24–28

24 The hands of hard workers will rule,
but laziness ends in forced labor.
25 Worry in a person's heart weighs it down,
but a kind word makes it glad.
26 A righteous person is careful in friendship,
but the way of the wicked leads them astray.
27 The lazy person does not roast his game,
but the possessions of hard-working people are valuable.
28 In the way of righteousness is life.
On its path there is no death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: A beautiful, simple sentence: Worries weigh us down. But a kind word can make a person glad again. Everyone can say a word like that today.

Verse 26: Choose your friends carefully. Bad friends can lead you astray.

Verse 27: A funny picture: The lazy person has hunted an animal, but he is too lazy to roast it. He never finishes anything.

Verse 28: The way of righteousness leads to life. Some Jewish and Christian interpreters already see here a hope beyond death.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 13

Hope and fulfillment

Guard your mouth VERSES 1–6

1 A wise son listens to his father's instruction,
but a mocker does not listen to correction.
2 By the fruit of his lips a person enjoys good things,
but the unfaithful crave violence.
3 Whoever guards his mouth guards his life.
Whoever opens his lips wide comes to ruin.
4 The soul of the lazy person wants things and gets nothing,
but the wish of hard workers will be fully satisfied.
5 A righteous person hates lies,
but a wicked person brings shame and disgrace.
6 Righteousness guards the way of honesty,
but wickedness overthrows the sinner.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Whoever is careful about what he says protects himself. Whoever blurts everything out gets into trouble. This is also true for what we write on the internet.

Verse 4: The lazy person wishes for a lot, but he does nothing for it. Wishing alone is not enough.

Wealth and poverty VERSES 7–11

7 Some people pretend to be rich and yet have nothing.
Some people pretend to be poor and yet have great wealth.
8 The ransom for a man's life is his riches,
but the poor person hears no threats.
9 The light of the righteous shines brightly,
but the lamp of the wicked goes out.
10 Pride only produces quarrels,
but wisdom is with those who take advice.
11 Wealth gained dishonestly dwindles away,
but whoever gathers it by his own hand makes it grow.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Appearances can fool you. Some show off even though they have nothing. Others are modest even though they have a lot.

Verse 8: A surprising thought: Rich people can be blackmailed or kidnapped and then have to pay a ransom. No one threatens the poor person for that reason. Wealth brings worries too.

Verse 11: Quick, dishonest money disappears quickly. What is earned honestly and slowly grows.

Hope that is put off VERSES 12–19

12 Hope that is put off makes the heart sick,
but when a longing is fulfilled, it is a tree of life.
13 Whoever despises instruction will pay for it,
but whoever respects a command will be rewarded.
14 The teaching of the wise is a spring of life,
to turn away from the traps of death.

15 Good understanding wins favor,
but the way of the unfaithful is hard.
16 Every wise person acts with knowledge,
but a fool shows off his foolishness.
17 A wicked messenger falls into trouble,
but a trustworthy messenger brings healing.
18 Poverty and shame come to the one who refuses instruction,
but whoever pays attention to correction will be honored.
19 A longing that is fulfilled is sweet to the soul,
but fools hate to turn away from evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 is a very human sentence. Whoever waits and hopes for something for a long time becomes tired and sad: for healing, for a partner, for a child, for work, for peace. The Bible understands this pain. And when the longing is finally fulfilled, it is like new life.

If disappointed hopes leave you not knowing how to go on: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 17: A good messenger brings healing, because he passes on messages faithfully and makes peace.

Good friends and a good inheritance VERSES 20–25

20 Whoever walks with wise people becomes wise,
but whoever makes friends with fools will be harmed.
21 Misfortune chases sinners,
but good things reward the righteous.
22 A good person leaves an inheritance to his grandchildren,
but the wealth of the sinner is stored up for the righteous.
23 Plenty of food grows in the fields of the poor,
but injustice sweeps it away.
24 Whoever spares the rod hates his son,
but whoever loves him is careful to discipline him.
25 The righteous person eats until his soul is satisfied,
but the belly of the wicked goes hungry.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: Tell me who your friends are, and I will tell you who you are. Friends shape us.

Verse 22: A good inheritance is not only money, but also a good example, values and faith.

Verse 23: An important sentence about justice: Poverty often does not come from laziness, but from injustice. The poor work and harvest, but others take it away from them. That still happens today.

Verse 24: For a long time, this verse was used to justify hitting children. Back then, that was normal. The message of the verse is: Love shows itself when parents bring up their children and set limits for them, instead of letting everything go. Today we know: Hitting harms children, and in many countries, including Germany, it is against the law. Good parenting works without violence.

If you experience violence in your own family: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

PROVERBS

Chapter 14

Righteousness lifts up a nation

The wise woman builds her house VERSES 1–9

1 Every wise woman builds her house,
but the foolish one tears it down with her own hands.
2 Whoever lives in his uprightness fears the LORD,
but whoever goes crooked ways despises him.
3 The fool's talk brings a rod to his back,
but the lips of the wise protect them.
4 Where there are no oxen, the feeding trough is clean,
but a rich harvest comes through the strength of the ox.
5 A truthful witness does not lie,
but a false witness pours out lies.
6 A mocker looks for wisdom and does not find it,
but knowledge comes easily to a person with understanding.
7 Stay away from a foolish person,
for you will not find knowledge on his lips.
8 The wisdom of the wise is to think about his way,
but the foolishness of fools is deceit.
9 Fools mock at making atonement for sins,
but among the upright there is goodwill.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A wise woman builds up her house: her family, her home, her community. Foolishness, on the other hand, destroys what you have. That is true for every person.

Verse 4: A picture from farming: Without oxen, the barn stays clean, but you also have no harvest. Whoever wants to achieve something must also accept work and mess.

Verse 6: Whoever mocks cannot learn. Whoever is open learns easily.

The heart knows its own sorrow VERSES 10–17

10 The heart knows its own bitterness and joy.
A stranger cannot share them with it.
11 The house of the wicked will be overthrown,
but the tent of the upright will flourish.
12 There is a way that seems right to a person,
but in the end it leads to death.
13 Even in laughter the heart may be sad,
and joy may end in sorrow.
14 The unfaithful will be paid back for his ways,
and in the same way a good person will be rewarded for his ways.
15 A simple person believes everything,
but the wise person thinks carefully about his steps.

16 A wise person fears evil and stays away from it,
but the fool is hotheaded and careless.
17 Whoever gets angry quickly does foolish things,
and a sly person is hated.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Every person has feelings that others cannot fully understand. Only God knows our heart completely.

Verse 12: A serious sentence: Not everything that feels right is right. That is why we need God's teaching and good advice.

Verse 13: Some people laugh on the outside, but inside they are sad. You cannot see it by looking at them. It is worth looking closely and asking.

Verse 15: Whoever believes everything he hears or reads is easily fooled. Today this is especially true for fake news on the internet. Check before you believe and pass it on!

Poor and rich VERSES 18–24

18 The simple inherit foolishness,
but the wise are crowned with knowledge.
19 The evil bow down before the good,
and the wicked at the gates of the righteous.
20 The poor person is avoided even by his own neighbor,
but the rich person has many friends.
21 Whoever looks down on his neighbor sins,
but happy is the one who has pity on the poor.
22 Don't those who plan evil go astray?
But love and faithfulness belong to those who plan good.
23 In all hard work there is profit,
but mere talk leads only to poverty.
24 The crown of the wise is their riches,
but the foolishness of fools crowns them with foolishness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–21: A sad observation: Rich people have many "friends," poor people are avoided. But God sees it differently: Whoever looks down on the poor sins. Whoever helps them is happy.

Verse 23: Working gets you somewhere. Only talking and making plans gets you nothing.

The fear of the LORD is a spring of life VERSES 25–35

25 A truthful witness saves lives,
but a false witness is deceitful.
26 In the fear of the LORD is a secure fortress,
and he will be a refuge for his children.
27 The fear of the LORD is a spring of life,
turning people away from the traps of death.
28 In a great number of people is the king's glory,
but when the people are missing, it is the ruin of the prince.
29 Whoever is slow to anger has great understanding,
but whoever has a quick temper shows foolishness.
30 A heart at peace is life for the body,
but envy makes the bones rot.
31 Whoever oppresses the poor shows contempt for his Maker,
but whoever is kind to the needy honors him.
32 The wicked is brought down in his disaster,
but in death the righteous has a refuge.
33 Wisdom rests in the heart of the one who has understanding,
and it is made known even in the inner being of fools.
34 Righteousness lifts up a nation,
but sin is a disgrace to any people.
35 The king shows favor to a servant who acts wisely,
but his anger falls on the one who brings shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29: Patience is a sign of wisdom. A quick temper makes you foolish.

Verse 30: A modern thought: Inner peace is good for your health. Envy makes you sick.

Verse 31 is one of the most important sentences of the book: Every poor person is created by God. Whoever treats a poor person badly insults God himself. Whoever helps him honors God. Jesus says something similar: "Whatever you did for one of the least of these my brothers and sisters, you did for me" (Matthew 25:40).

Verse 32: The righteous has a refuge even in death. Here we can hear a hope beyond death.

Verse 34: "Righteousness lifts up a nation": A country is not great because of power or wealth, but because of justice.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 15

A gentle answer

Gentle and harsh words VERSES 1–7

1 A gentle answer turns away anger,
but a harsh word stirs up anger.
2 The tongue of the wise makes knowledge attractive,
but the mouth of fools pours out foolishness.
3 The LORD's eyes are everywhere.
They keep watch over the evil and the good.
4 A gentle tongue is a tree of life,
but deceit in it crushes the spirit.
5 A fool despises his father's correction,
but whoever pays attention to correction shows good sense.
6 In the house of the righteous is much treasure,
but the income of the wicked brings trouble.
7 The lips of the wise spread knowledge,
but not so the heart of fools.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 is one of the best-known proverbs: Whoever answers calmly and kindly can end a quarrel. Whoever answers harshly pours oil on the fire. This works in the family, at work and on the internet.

Verse 3: God sees everything. For the evil this is a warning, for the good it is a comfort.

Verse 4: Kind words are like a tree that gives life. Lies and meanness can break a person inside.

What pleases God VERSES 8–15

8 The sacrifice of the wicked is disgusting to the LORD,
but the prayer of the upright pleases him.
9 The way of the wicked is disgusting to the LORD,
but he loves the one who chases after righteousness.
10 Hard discipline is for the one who leaves the way.
Whoever hates correction will die.
11 Sheol (the world of the dead) and Abaddon lie open
before the LORD.
How much more the hearts of the human race!
12 A mocker does not love to be corrected.
He will not go to the wise.
13 A glad heart makes a cheerful face,
but an aching heart breaks the spirit.
14 The heart of the one who has understanding looks for
knowledge,
but the mouth of fools feeds on foolishness.
15 All the days of the suffering are miserable,
but whoever has a cheerful heart has a feast all the
time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: God cannot be bribed with sacrifices when someone's life is evil. But the honest prayer of an upright person makes him glad, even without a sacrifice.

Verse 11: "Abaddon" is a Hebrew word for the deep pit, another word for Sheol, the world of the dead. God sees even into the deepest depths. All the more he sees into our hearts.

Verses 13 and 15: Our mood inside shows on our face and shapes our whole life. A glad heart makes every day a feast. If someone is sad for a very long time and cannot become happy again, it can be depression. That is an illness and not a weakness. Doctors and therapists can help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Better a little with love VERSES 16–23

16 Better a little with the fear of the LORD
than great treasure with trouble.
17 Better a meal of vegetables where there is love
than a fattened calf with hatred.
18 An angry person stirs up quarrels,
but whoever is slow to anger calms the quarrel.
19 The way of the lazy person is like a thorn hedge,
but the path of the upright is a highway.
20 A wise son makes his father glad,
but a foolish person despises his mother.
21 Foolishness is a joy to the one who has no wisdom,
but a man of understanding keeps his way straight.
22 Where there is no advice, plans fail,
but where there are many advisers, they succeed.
23 A person is glad about the answer of his mouth.
How good is a word at the right time!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: What really makes people happy? Not expensive food or a lot of money. A simple meal with people who love each other is better than a feast full of quarrels.

Verse 19: For the lazy person everything is hard, as if there were thorns in the way. Whoever lives uprightly makes good progress.

Verse 22: Big decisions should not be made alone. Get good advice!

Verse 23: The right word at the right moment is a great gift.

God hears prayer VERSES 24–33

24 The path of life leads upward for the wise,
so that he does not go down to Sheol.
25 The LORD tears down the house of the proud,
but he keeps the widow's borders safe.
26 The LORD hates the thoughts of the wicked,
but the thoughts of the pure please him.
27 Whoever is greedy for gain brings trouble on his own
house,
but whoever hates bribes will live.
28 The heart of the righteous thinks about how to answer,
but the mouth of the wicked pours out evil.
29 The LORD is far from the wicked,
but he hears the prayer of the righteous.
30 The light of the eyes makes the heart glad.
Good news gives health to the bones.
31 The ear that listens to correction lives
and will be at home among the wise.
32 Whoever refuses instruction despises his own life,
but whoever listens to correction gains
understanding.
33 The fear of the LORD teaches wisdom.
Before honor comes humility.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Back then, widows often had no protection. Powerful people tried to take land from them by moving the boundary stones. God himself protects the widow's border. He is on the side of the weak.

Verse 27: Bribery destroys. Whoever rejects it lives well.

Verse 28: Good advice: Think first, then speak.

Verse 30: A shining face and good news do body and soul good.

Verse 33: "Before honor comes humility": Whoever does not take himself too seriously will be honored in the end.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 16

People make plans, God directs

Commit your deeds to the LORD VERSES 1–9

1 The plans of the heart belong to people,
but the answer of the tongue comes from the LORD.

2 All of a person's ways are pure in his own eyes,
but the LORD weighs the motives.
3 Commit your deeds to the LORD,
and your plans will succeed.
4 The LORD has made everything for its own purpose,
yes, even the wicked for the day of disaster.
5 Everyone who is proud in heart is disgusting to the LORD.
They will certainly not go unpunished.
6 By kindness and truth guilt is atoned for.
By the fear of the LORD people turn away from evil.
7 When a person's ways please the LORD,
he makes even his enemies be at peace with him.
8 Better a little with righteousness
than a big income with injustice.
9 A person's heart plans his way,
but the LORD directs his steps.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1 and 9 are the basis of a well-known saying: People make plans, but God directs. We may make plans. But in the end, God has the last word.

Verse 2: We often think of ourselves as good. God looks deeper, at our real motives.

Verse 3: "Commit your deeds to the LORD" means: Put everything you do into God's hands.

Verse 4: This verse is difficult. It does not mean that God made people evil. It says: Nothing is outside of God's plan. In the end, evil too will not escape his judgment.

Verse 6: Guilt is not taken away by sacrifices alone, but by kindness and truth, by God's grace and by a changed life.

The just king VERSES 10–15

10 Decisions inspired by God are on the lips of the king.
His mouth must not be unfaithful when he judges.
11 Honest scales and balances belong to the LORD.
All the weights in the bag are his work.
12 It is disgusting for kings to do wrong,
for the throne is made firm by righteousness.
13 Righteous lips please kings.
They value the one who speaks the truth.
14 The king's anger is a messenger of death,
but a wise man will calm it.
15 In the light of the king's face is life.
His favor is like a cloud with spring rain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These proverbs are about the king, about those who have power. A good ruler should judge justly and value honest people.

Verse 11: Honest measures and weights are God's business too. Justice in trade matters to him.

Verse 12: Power only lasts if it is just. To this day, that is a standard for every government.

Verse 15: In the land of Israel, the spring rain was important for the harvest. A just ruler is just as vital.

Pride comes before a fall VERSES 16–24

16 How much better it is to get wisdom than gold!
Yes, getting understanding is better than silver.
17 The highway of the upright is to turn away from evil.
Whoever watches his way keeps his life safe.
18 Pride goes before destruction,
and a proud spirit before a fall.
19 It is better to be humble with the poor
than to share plunder with the proud.
20 Whoever pays attention to the word finds good things.
Happy is the one who trusts in the LORD.
21 Whoever is wise in heart will be called sensible.
Kind lips help teaching.
22 Understanding is a spring of life to the one who has it,
but the punishment of fools is their foolishness.
23 The heart of the wise teaches his mouth
and adds learning to his lips.
24 Kind words are a honeycomb,
sweet to the soul and health to the bones.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: "Pride goes before destruction, and a proud spirit before a fall." This is where the well-known saying comes from: Pride comes before a fall.

Verse 19: Better to be humble among the poor than rich among the show-offs.

Verse 21: People like to listen to someone who teaches kindly.

Verse 24: Kind words are sweet as honey. They do the soul good, and even the body.

Being patient is better than being a hero VERSES 25–33

25 There is a way that seems right to a person,
but in the end it leads to death.
26 The hunger of the worker works for him,
for his mouth drives him on.
27 A worthless person digs up trouble.
His speech is like a burning fire.
28 A twisted person stirs up quarrels.
A gossip separates close friends.
29 A violent person lures his neighbor
and leads him on a way that is not good.
30 Whoever winks his eyes to plan twisted things,
whoever presses his lips together, is set on evil.
31 Gray hair is a glorious crown.
It is gained by a life of righteousness.
32 Whoever is slow to anger is better than a mighty hero,
and whoever controls himself is better than someone
who captures a city.
33 The lot is thrown into the lap,
but every decision comes from the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25 repeats Proverbs 14:12. Some proverbs appear twice, because they are especially important.

Verse 26: Hunger drives a person to work.

Verse 28: Whoever spreads rumors and gossip can even split up best friends.

Verse 31: Old people deserve respect. Their gray hair is like a crown.

Verse 32: Real strength is self-control. Whoever has his anger under control is stronger than a war hero.

Verse 33: Back then, some decisions were made by casting lots, a kind of throwing dice. The proverb says: Even what looks like chance is in God's hand.

PROVERBS

Chapter 17

A friend loves at all times

Better dry bread in peace VERSES 1–6

1 Better a dry piece of bread with quietness
than a house full of feasting with quarrels.
2 A servant who acts wisely will rule over a son who
brings shame,
and will get a share of the inheritance among the
brothers.
3 The melting pot is for silver and the furnace for gold,
but the LORD tests the hearts.
4 An evildoer listens to wicked lips.
A liar lends his ear to a harmful tongue.
5 Whoever mocks the poor insults his Maker.
Whoever is glad about a disaster will not go
unpunished.
6 Grandchildren are the crown of the old,
and the pride of children is their parents.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Peace is more important than luxury (compare Proverbs 15:17).

Verse 2: Wisdom counts for more than family background. A wise servant can get further than a son who is good for nothing.

Verse 3: Metal is tested in the fire to see if it is real. In the same way, God tests what is in our hearts.

Verse 5: Whoever laughs at the poor, or is glad when things go badly for others, insults God, who created every person.

Verse 6: Grandparents are happy about their grandchildren, and children are proud of their parents. A beautiful picture of several generations.

Love covers wrongs VERSES 7–14

7 Fine speech does not fit a fool,
much less do lying lips fit a prince.
8 A bribe is a precious stone in the eyes of the one who
gives it.
Wherever he turns, he succeeds.
9 Whoever covers a wrong encourages love,
but whoever keeps bringing a matter up separates best
friends.
10 A correction goes deeper into a person with
understanding
than 100 blows into a fool.
11 An evil person looks only for rebellion.
So a cruel messenger will be sent against him.
12 Better to meet a mother bear robbed of her cubs
than a fool in his foolishness.
13 Whoever pays back evil for good,
evil will not leave his house.
14 The beginning of a quarrel is like a dam breaking.
So stop the argument before the quarrel breaks out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A sober observation: Whoever bribes thinks that he can get anything with money. The proverb does not praise this. In other places, bribery is clearly condemned (verse 23).

Verse 9: Whoever forgives a friend for a mistake and does not keep bringing it up keeps the friendship.

Verse 10: A wise person learns from a single word. A fool does not even learn from hard consequences.

Verse 12: A funny, strong comparison: An angry mother bear is less dangerous than a fool who is doing something stupid.

Verse 14: A quarrel is like a small hole in a dam. At the beginning, you can still plug it. Later everything breaks through. So: Stop arguing early!

A friend loves at all times VERSES 15–22

15 Whoever lets the guilty go free and whoever condemns
the righteous,
both of them are disgusting to the LORD.
16 Why does a fool have money in his hand to buy wisdom,
when he has no sense?
17 A friend loves at all times,
and a brother is born for times of trouble.
18 A person without sense shakes hands on a deal
and guarantees a loan in front of his neighbor.
19 Whoever loves disobedience loves quarrels.
Whoever builds his gate high is asking for destruction.
20 Whoever has a twisted heart does not find good things,
and whoever has a lying tongue falls into trouble.
21 Whoever has a fool for a son has grief.
The father of a fool has no joy.
22 A cheerful heart is good medicine,
but a crushed spirit dries up the bones.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A sentence for every court: Condemning the innocent and letting the guilty go free are equally bad before God.

Verse 16: You cannot buy wisdom if you do not want to learn.

Verse 17 is a wonderful sentence about friendship: A real friend is always there, not only in good times. And brothers and sisters are there for each other especially in times of need.

Verse 19: Whoever "builds his gate high" shows off and puts himself above others. That leads to a fall.

Verse 22: "A cheerful heart is good medicine": Medicine knows today that joy and laughter are good for your health.

Keeping silent is wise VERSES 23–28

23 A wicked person secretly accepts a bribe
to twist the ways of justice.
24 The person with understanding keeps wisdom before
his eyes,
but the eyes of a fool wander to the ends of the earth.
25 A foolish son brings grief to his father
and bitterness to the mother who gave birth to him.
26 It is also not good to punish the righteous,
or to whip officials for being honest.

27 Whoever holds back his words has knowledge.
Whoever has a calm spirit is a man of understanding.
28 Even a fool is thought wise when he keeps silent.
When he shuts his lips, people think he has understanding.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: Bribery twists justice. That is corruption.

Verse 24: The wise person looks at what is in front of him. The fool dreams of faraway things and does not see what is close by.

Verse 26: Whoever is honest must not be punished for it. This is also true for people who uncover wrongdoing.

Verse 28: A funny ending: Whoever keeps silent seems wise, even if he may not be. Sometimes it is better to say nothing.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 18

The name of the LORD is a strong tower

First listen, then speak VERSES 1–9

1 Whoever cuts himself off from others is looking only for himself
and fights against all good judgment.
2 A fool has no joy in understanding,
but only in telling his own opinion.
3 When wickedness comes, contempt comes too,
and with shame comes disgrace.
4 The words of a person's mouth are like deep waters.
The spring of wisdom is like a flowing stream.
5 It is not good to favor the wicked
and to take away justice from the innocent.
6 A fool's lips get into quarrels,
and his mouth asks for a beating.
7 A fool's mouth is his ruin,
and his lips are a trap for his life.
8 The words of a gossip are like tasty treats.
They go down into a person's innermost being.
9 Whoever is careless in his work
is a brother of the one who destroys.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Whoever withdraws from everyone in order to think only of himself loses sight of what is right. We need other people.

But whoever withdraws because of sadness or fear is not selfish, but needs help and care.

Verse 2: A fool does not want to understand, but only to say his opinion. We know this from many discussions on the internet too.

Verse 8: Gossip tastes like a treat. People like to hear it, and it sticks. But it poisons the heart.

Verse 9: Whoever works sloppily causes just as much damage in the end as someone who destroys on purpose.

The strong tower VERSES 10–15

10 The name of the LORD is a strong tower.
The righteous person runs to him and is safe.
11 The rich man's wealth is his strong city,
like a wall no one can climb, in his own imagination.
12 Before destruction a person's heart is proud,
but before honor comes humility.
13 Whoever answers before he has listened,
that is foolishness and shame for him.
14 A person's spirit will hold him up in sickness,
but a crushed spirit, who can bear it?
15 The heart of the person with understanding gets knowledge.
The ear of the wise looks for knowledge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: A comparison: The righteous person finds protection with God, as in a strong tower. The rich man believes that his money is a safe wall. But that is only his imagination.

Verse 13: Whoever interrupts someone and answers before he has really listened makes himself look foolish. First listen, then speak!

Verse 14: A strong will to live helps you bear sickness. But when the soul is crushed, that is harder than any sickness. Distress of the soul is serious and needs help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Hearing both sides VERSES 16–21

16 A person's gift makes room for him
and brings him before important people.
17 Whoever presents his case first seems right,
until another comes and questions him.
18 The lot settles disputes
and keeps strong opponents apart.
19 A brother who has been hurt is harder to win than a fortified city.
Disputes are like the bars of a fortress.
20 A person's stomach is filled with the fruit of his mouth.
He is satisfied with the harvest of his lips.
21 Death and life are in the power of the tongue.
Those who love it will eat its fruit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: A gift can open doors. This is an observation, not advice to bribe.

Verse 17: A very wise sentence: Whoever hears only one side believes it at once. But you must always hear both sides before you judge. This is true in court, in a quarrel between friends and with the news.

Verse 19: A hurt brother is harder to win back than a fortress. Quarrels in the family go deep. So: Don't hurt others carelessly!

Verse 21: Words have power over life and death. With words you can build up or destroy, encourage or crush. This is especially true for bullying.

A friend who sticks closer than a brother VERSES 22–24

22 Whoever finds a wife finds a good thing
and receives favor from the LORD.
23 The poor beg for mercy,
but the rich answer harshly.
24 A man with many companions may be ruined,
but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: A good marriage is a gift from God.

Verse 23: A sad observation: The poor have to beg, and the rich often answer harshly. It should not be like this.

Verse 24: Having many people you know does not mean having real friends. One single faithful friend is worth more. Christians see in Jesus this friend "who sticks closer than a brother." Jesus calls his disciples his friends (compare John 15:13–15).

PROVERBS

Chapter 19

Whoever has pity on the poor lends to the LORD

Poor but honest VERSES 1–7

1 Better is a poor person who lives with integrity
than someone with twisted lips who is a fool.
2 It is not good to have eagerness without knowledge,
or to hurry with your feet and miss the way.
3 A person's foolishness ruins his way,
and his heart rages against the LORD.
4 Wealth brings many friends,
but the poor person is separated from his friend.
5 A false witness will not go unpunished.
Whoever pours out lies will not go free.
6 Many try to win the favor of a ruler,
and everyone is a friend to the one who gives gifts.
7 All the relatives of the poor person avoid him.
How much more do his friends stay away from him!
He runs after them with requests, but they are gone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Honesty is worth more than money.

Verse 2: Eagerness alone is not enough. Whoever rushes off without thinking gets lost.

Verse 3: A person makes mistakes through his own foolishness, and then he blames God. We know this.

Verses 4–7: A bitter truth: Whoever is rich has many "friends." Whoever becomes poor is left by everyone, even by his own family. The Bible describes this honestly, so that we do better and do not leave the poor alone.

Patience and forgiveness VERSES 8–14

8 Whoever gets wisdom loves his own life.
Whoever keeps understanding will find good things.
9 A false witness will not go unpunished.
Whoever tells lies will perish.
10 A life of luxury does not fit a fool,
much less does it fit a servant to rule over princes.
11 A person's good sense makes him slow to anger.
It is his glory to overlook a wrong.
12 The king's anger is like the roaring of a lion,
but his favor is like dew on the grass.
13 A foolish son is a disaster for his father.
A wife's quarrels are like constant dripping.
14 House and riches are an inheritance from ancestors,
but a wise wife is from the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Whoever is wise does not get upset right away. It is an honor to forgive someone something instead of holding it against him.

Verse 13: Constant quarreling in a marriage is like a dripping faucet that drives you crazy. Of course this is also true for quarrelsome men.

Verse 14: You can inherit a house. But you cannot buy a good, wise marriage partner. That is a gift from God.

Lending to God VERSES 15–21

15 Laziness makes you fall into a deep sleep.
The lazy soul will go hungry.
16 Whoever keeps the commandment keeps his life safe,
but whoever despises his ways will die.
17 Whoever has pity on the poor lends to the LORD.
He will pay him back.
18 Discipline your son while there is still hope.
Don't share the guilt for his death.
19 A hot-tempered man must pay the penalty.
For if you rescue him, you will have to do it again.
20 Listen to advice and accept instruction,
so that you will be wise in the end.
21 There are many plans in a person's heart,
but the LORD's plan will stand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17 is a wonderful thought: Whoever helps a poor person is really giving to God. And God stays in no one's debt. Jesus says something similar (Matthew 25:40).

Verse 18: Parents should bring up their children in time, while they can still be shaped. Whoever sets no limits at all lets the child run into disaster. Bringing up children does not mean violence.

Verse 19: Whoever has a hot temper gets into trouble again and again. If you always get him out of it, he learns nothing.

Verse 21: Again the thought: People make plans, but God directs (compare Proverbs 16:9).

What makes a person lovable VERSES 22–29

22 What makes a person desirable is his kindness.
A poor person is better than a liar.
23 The fear of the LORD leads to life, and then to
contentment.
Such a person rests and is not touched by trouble.

24 The lazy person puts his hand in the dish
and does not even bring it back to his mouth.
25 Whip a mocker, and the simple will learn good sense.
Correct a person with understanding, and he will gain knowledge.
26 Whoever robs his father and drives away his mother
is a son who brings shame and disgrace.
27 If you stop listening to instruction, my son,
you will wander away from the words of knowledge.
28 A corrupt witness mocks justice,
and the mouth of the wicked gulps down wrongdoing.
29 Punishments are ready for mockers,
and beatings for the backs of fools.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: What really makes a person lovable? Not money or looks, but kindness.

Verse 24: A funny picture: The lazy person is even too lazy to lift his hand from the plate to his mouth.

Verses 25 and 29: Back then, punishment by beating was normal. The proverb wants to say: Whoever does not want to listen must feel the consequences, and others learn from it. Today, in most countries, there is no more punishment by beating, and that is a good thing. The heart of it stays: A wise person learns from a single word.

Verse 26: Treating your parents badly in their old age is a great shame. The commandment "Honor your father and your mother" (Exodus 20:12) is also for grown-up children.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 20

Who can say: My heart is pure?

Wine and quarrels VERSES 1–7

1 Wine is a mocker, and beer is a brawler.
Whoever is led astray by them is not wise.
2 The terror of a king is like the roaring of a lion.
Whoever makes him angry puts his own life at risk.
3 It is an honor for a person to stay away from quarrels,
but every fool starts a quarrel.
4 The lazy person does not plow because of the winter.
So he begs at harvest time and has nothing.
5 The plan in a person's heart is like deep water,
but a man of understanding will draw it out.
6 Many people claim to be full of unfailing love,
but who can find a faithful person?
7 A righteous person lives with integrity.
Happy are his children after him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Alcohol turns people into mockers and fighters. Whoever lets alcohol control him is not wise. Whoever has a problem with alcohol can find help, for example at addiction counseling services or with Alcoholics Anonymous. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357.

Verse 3: It is not a weakness to avoid a quarrel. It is an honor.

Verse 4: In Israel, people plowed in fall and winter. Whoever is too lazy then has no harvest in the summer.

Verse 5: What a person really thinks is often hidden deep inside. A wise person can help bring it to light by asking good questions.

Verse 6: Many talk about love and faithfulness. But truly faithful people are rare.

No one is without sin VERSES 8–15

8 A king who sits on the judgment seat
scatters away all evil with his eyes.
9 Who can say, "I have made my heart pure.
I am clean and without sin"?
10 Two different weights and two different measures,
both of them are disgusting to the LORD.
11 Even a child shows by his actions
whether what he does is pure and whether it is right.
12 The hearing ear and the seeing eye,
the LORD has made both of them.
13 Don't love sleep, or you will become poor.
Open your eyes, and you will have plenty of bread.
14 "It's no good, it's no good!" says the buyer.
But when he has gone on his way, he boasts.
15 There is gold and plenty of rubies,
but lips full of knowledge are a rare jewel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: An honest question: No one can say about himself that he is without sin (compare 1 John 1:8). Everyone needs God's forgiveness.

Verse 10: Two different measures: buying with one weight and selling with another. God hates cheating. In German, the expression for a double standard, measuring with two different measures, comes from here.

Verse 11: Even with children, you can see from their behavior what they are like.

Verse 14: A funny proverb about bargaining at the market: The buyer says, "It's no good, it's no good!" In this way he wants to push the price down. Later he proudly tells what a good deal he made.

Verse 15: There is a lot of gold. But wise words are rare and precious.

Wait for the LORD VERSES 16–23

16 Take the coat of the one who guarantees a loan for a stranger.
Hold him as security for an unfaithful woman.
17 Food gained by cheating tastes sweet to a person,
but afterward his mouth is full of gravel.
18 Plans are made firm by advice.
Make war with wise guidance!
19 Whoever goes around as a gossip gives away secrets.
So don't get involved with someone who opens his lips wide.
20 Whoever curses his father or his mother,
his lamp will go out in the deepest darkness.

21 An inheritance gained quickly at the beginning
will not be blessed in the end.
22 Don't say, "I will pay back evil!"
Wait for the LORD, and he will save you.
23 The LORD hates two different weights,
and dishonest scales do not please him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Whoever carelessly guarantees a loan for strangers has only himself to blame when his things are taken as security. Hard advice to be careful (compare Proverbs 6:1–5).

Verse 17: What you get by cheating tastes sweet at first. But later it is like gravel in your mouth.

Verse 18: Even in war, you need good advice. Whoever makes big decisions should think them through well.

Verse 21: Whoever grabs an inheritance early (compare Luke 15:12) will not become happy with it.

Verse 22: An important sentence: Don't take revenge yourself! Leave it to God. Paul says the same thing (Romans 12:17–19).

The lamp of the LORD VERSES 24–30

24 A man's steps come from the LORD.
How then can a person understand his way?
25 It is a trap for a person to dedicate something to God too quickly
and only think about his vows afterward.
26 A wise king sifts out the wicked
and drives the threshing wheel over them.
27 The human spirit is the LORD's lamp,
searching all his innermost parts.
28 Love and faithfulness keep the king safe.
His throne is held up by love.
29 The glory of young men is their strength.
The beauty of old people is their gray hair.
30 Wounding blows clean away evil,
and beatings clean the innermost parts.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: We often do not understand the way our life takes. But God leads our steps.

Verse 25: Be careful with quick promises to God. First think, then promise (compare Ecclesiastes 5:4–5).

Verse 26: In threshing, people drove a wheel over the grain to separate the grains from the chaff. A just king separates the wicked from the good.

Verse 27: A beautiful thought: Our conscience is like a lamp from God that shines into our inner being.

Verse 28: A good ruler does not rule with violence, but with love and faithfulness.

Verse 29: Young and old each have their own beauty: the young their strength, the old their experience.

Verse 30: Back then, people believed that physical punishment could make a person better. Today we know: Violence does not make people better, it hurts them. At its heart, the meaning is: Painful experiences can make a person think.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 21

The king's heart in God's hand

Doing right is better than sacrifice VERSES 1–8

1 The king's heart is in the LORD's hand like streams of water.
He turns it wherever he wants.
2 Every way of a person is right in his own eyes,
but the LORD weighs the hearts.
3 To do righteousness and justice
pleases the LORD more than sacrifice.
4 Proud eyes and an arrogant heart,
the lamp of the wicked, are sin.
5 The plans of hard workers surely lead to profit,
but everyone who is hasty surely rushes into poverty.
6 Getting treasures with a lying tongue
is a breath that quickly passes, for those who look for death.
7 The violence of the wicked will sweep them away,
because they refuse to do what is right.
8 The way of the guilty is crooked,
but the behavior of the innocent is upright.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A farmer guides water through small channels onto his field, wherever he wants. In the same way, God guides even the heart of the powerful. Kings and presidents too are not outside of God's power.

Verse 3: God would rather have us act justly than carry out religious rituals. The prophets say this too (Hosea 6:6; Micah 6:8). Jesus quotes this thought (Matthew 9:13).

Verse 5: Whoever plans well and works hard gets further than someone who wants to do everything in a rush.

Better to live on the roof VERSES 9–19

9 It is better to live in a corner of the roof
than to share a house with a quarrelsome woman.
10 The soul of the wicked wants evil.
His neighbor finds no mercy in his eyes.
11 When the mocker is punished, the simple become wise.
When the wise is taught, he receives knowledge.
12 The Righteous One looks at the house of the wicked
and brings the wicked to ruin.
13 Whoever shuts his ears to the cry of the poor
will cry out himself and not be heard.
14 A secret gift calms anger,
and a bribe hidden in the coat calms strong rage.
15 For the righteous, it is a joy to do justice,
but for those who do wrong, it brings ruin.
16 A person who wanders away from the way of understanding
will rest in the assembly of the dead.

17 Whoever loves pleasure will be poor.
Whoever loves wine and oil will not become rich.
18 The wicked is a ransom for the righteous,
the unfaithful for the upright.
19 It is better to live in a desert land
than with a quarrelsome and irritable woman.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9 and 19: Said with humor: Better to live alone in a small corner on the flat roof, or even in the desert, than in a house full of quarrels. The proverbs are written for men. The same is true for women with a quarrelsome husband.

If you experience violence in your own relationship, you can get help day and night. US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 12: "The Righteous One" can mean God himself here, the one who is righteous above all. The WEB, our English source text, writes it with capital letters and understands it this way.

Verse 13: Whoever ignores the need of the poor will one day stand without help himself.

Verse 14: An observation of how bribery works. It is not advice.

Verse 18: A difficult verse: The disaster that would really hit the righteous hits the wicked in the end.

Victory comes from the LORD VERSES 20–31

20 Precious treasure and oil are in the home of the wise,
but a foolish person swallows it up.
21 Whoever chases after righteousness and kindness
finds life, righteousness, and honor.
22 A wise person climbs into the city of the strong
and tears down the fortress it trusts in.
23 Whoever guards his mouth and his tongue
keeps his life safe from troubles.
24 The proud and arrogant person, "Mocker" is his name,
acts with overflowing pride.
25 The craving of the lazy person kills him,
for his hands refuse to work.
26 Some people greedily want more all day long,
but the righteous give and do not hold back.
27 The sacrifice of the wicked is disgusting.
How much more when he brings it with evil
intentions!
28 A false witness will perish.
A person who listens will speak forever.
29 A wicked person makes his face hard,
but the upright makes his ways firm.
30 There is no wisdom, no understanding and no advice
against the LORD.
31 The horse is made ready for the day of battle,
but victory comes from the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: The wise person saves and plans ahead. The fool uses everything up at once.

Verse 22: Wisdom is stronger than walls and weapons.

Verse 26: The greedy person always wants more. The righteous person likes to give.

Verse 28: Whoever listens well, his word lasts.

Verses 30–31: People can prepare well and should do so. But the result is in God's hand. No human plan can stand against God.

PROVERBS

Chapter 22

A good name is better than riches

God made the rich and the poor VERSES 1–9

1 A good name is more desirable than great riches,
and favor is better than silver and gold.
2 The rich and the poor have this in common:
The LORD made them all.
3 A wise person sees danger and hides,
but the simple go on and suffer for it.
4 The reward of humility and of the fear of the LORD
is wealth, honor, and life.
5 Thorns and traps are on the path of the wicked.
Whoever guards his life stays far away from them.
6 Train up a child in the way he should go,
and when he is old he will not turn away from it.
7 The rich rule over the poor.
The borrower is servant to the lender.
8 Whoever sows wickedness reaps trouble,
and the rod of his anger will be broken.
9 Whoever has a generous eye will be blessed,
for he shares his food with the poor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A good reputation and the trust of others are worth more than money.

Verse 2: An important sentence: Before God, rich and poor are equal. He created both. No one is worth more than the other.

Verse 3: A wise person sees dangers early and gets out of the way.

Verse 6 is a well-known saying about bringing up children: What children learn early shapes them for their whole life. That is why good parenting is so important. But it is no guarantee: Children who were brought up well can also go their own way. Parents are not to blame for everything.

Verse 7: Debts make you dependent. Whoever borrows money is no longer free. Good advice: Be careful with loans.

Verse 9: "A generous eye": Whoever sees the need of others and shares will be blessed.

The lazy person and the lion VERSES 10–16

10 Drive out the mocker, and the quarrel will go out.
Yes, arguments and insults will stop.
11 Whoever loves a pure heart and speaks kindly
is the king's friend.

12 The LORD's eyes watch over knowledge,
but he ruins the words of the unfaithful.
13 The lazy person says, "There is a lion outside!
I will be killed in the streets!"
14 The mouth of an adulteress is a deep pit.
Whoever is under the LORD's anger will fall into it.
15 Foolishness is tied up in the heart of a child.
The rod of discipline drives it far from him.
16 Whoever oppresses the poor to make himself richer,
and whoever gives to the rich, both end up in poverty.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: A funny proverb: The lazy person makes up the craziest excuses so that he does not have to go to work: "There is a lion outside!"

Verse 15: Children have to learn many things first. Back then, people believed that this included hitting. Today we know: Hitting harms children, and in many countries, including Germany, it is against the law. Children need love, clear rules and patience. If you need help with parenting: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verse 16: Whoever takes advantage of the poor, or flatters the rich in order to become rich himself, loses in the end.

The words of the wise begin VERSES 17–21

17 Turn your ear and listen to the words of the wise!
Set your heart on my teaching!
18 For it is a pleasant thing if you keep them within you,
if all of them are ready on your lips.
19 I teach you today, yes, you,
so that your trust may rest in the LORD.
20 Haven't I written to you 30 excellent sayings,
full of advice and knowledge,
21 to teach you truth, reliable words,
so that you can give good answers to those who sent you?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a new part of the book begins: "The words of the wise" (22:17 to 24:22).

Verse 20: "30 excellent sayings": This collection has 30 sections. It is very similar to an old Egyptian book of wisdom, the "Instruction of Amenemope," which also has 30 chapters. So Israel also took over wisdom from neighboring peoples and connected it with faith in the LORD.

Verse 19: The goal of all wisdom: that you trust in God.

Don't take advantage of the poor VERSES 22–29

22 Don't take advantage of the poor because he is poor,
and don't crush the needy in court!
23 For the LORD will plead their case
and take the life of those who rob them.
24 Don't make friends with a hot-tempered person!
Don't spend time with someone who carries anger inside him,
25 so that you don't learn his ways
and set a trap for your own life.
26 Don't be one of those who shake hands on a deal,
one of those who guarantee debts!
27 If you have nothing to pay with,
why should your bed be taken away from under you?
28 Don't move the ancient boundary stone
that your ancestors set up!
29 Do you see a person who is skilled in his work?
He will serve kings.
He will not serve unknown people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–23: Whoever takes advantage of the poor because they cannot defend themselves will have to deal with God. God himself is the lawyer of the poor.

Verses 24–25: Anger is catching. Whoever spends a lot of time with hot-tempered people easily becomes like them.

Verse 27: Whoever guarantees a debt and cannot pay loses even his bed.

Verse 28: Boundary stones marked which land belonged to whom. Whoever secretly moved them stole land. This usually hurt the weak.

Verse 29: Whoever does his work well is valued and goes far.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 23

Give me your heart

At the table of a powerful man VERSES 1–8

1 When you sit down to eat with a ruler,
think carefully about what is in front of you.
2 If you are a greedy eater,
put a knife to your throat.
3 Don't long for his fine food.
That food can fool you.
4 Don't wear yourself out trying to get rich.
Be wise and hold back.
5 Why do you look at something that will soon be gone?
Riches surely grow wings like an eagle
and fly away into the sky.
6 Don't eat the food of a stingy man.
Don't long for his fine food.
7 In his heart he is always counting the cost.
"Eat and drink!" he says to you.
But he does not really mean it.
8 You will throw up the bites you have eaten.
And your kind words will be wasted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: When a powerful person invites you, be careful. Maybe he wants to bribe you with good food or get information out of you. "Putting a knife to your throat" is a strong picture for: Control yourself!

Verses 4–5: Wise advice: Riches do not last. They can fly away like an eagle. That is why we should not spend our whole life chasing them.

Verses 6–8: A stingy person invites you and says in a friendly way, "Eat and drink!" But in his thoughts he counts every bite. With someone like that, no food tastes good.

The strong Defender of orphans VERSES 9–14

9 Don't talk to a fool.
He will look down on your wise words.
10 Don't move an old boundary stone.
Don't take over the fields of orphans.
11 Their Defender is strong.
He will take their side against you in court.
12 Open your heart to teaching.
Open your ears to words of knowledge.
13 Don't hold back correction from a child.
If you punish him with a rod, he will not die.
14 Punish him with a rod,
and you will save his life from Sheol (the world of the dead).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Orphans had no one to defend them. But God himself is their strong Defender. Whoever takes something away from them will have to deal with him.

Verses 13–14: These verses reflect the way children were brought up back then, when hitting was normal. Their message is: Parents should not leave children to themselves, but bring them up with love and clear limits, so that they do not get onto a path that leads to ruin.

Today we know that hitting harms children in body and soul. In Germany, children have had a right to be brought up without violence since the year 2000. This verse is no permission to hit children.

Help for children, young people and parents: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

My son, if your heart is wise VERSES 15–25

15 My son, if your heart is wise,
then my heart will be glad too.
16 Deep inside I will be full of joy
when you say what is right.
17 Don't let your heart envy sinners.
Instead, fear the LORD all day long.
18 Then you will surely have a future.
Your hope will not be destroyed.
19 Listen, my son, and be wise.
Keep your heart on the right path.
20 Don't spend time with people who drink too much wine,
or with people who stuff themselves with meat.
21 Drunkards and people who eat too much will become poor.
Too much sleep will dress them in rags.
22 Listen to your father, who gave you life.
Don't look down on your mother when she is old.
23 Buy the truth, and don't sell it.
Get wisdom, discipline, and understanding.
24 The father of a righteous child is full of joy.
A man who has a wise child is happy because of him.
25 Let your father and your mother be glad.
Let your mother, who gave birth to you, be full of joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: Sometimes people who do evil seem to be doing well. Don't envy them! Whoever trusts God has a future and a hope.

Verses 20–21: Too much alcohol and too much food make people poor and sluggish.

Verse 22: A beautiful verse: Don't despise your mother when she is old. Old parents deserve respect and care.

Verse 23: "Buy the truth, and don't sell it": Truth is so valuable that you should give everything for it. And you should not give it up for anything in the world.

Give me your heart VERSES 26–28

26 My son, give me your heart.
Let your eyes follow my ways.
27 A prostitute is like a deep pit.
A woman who is unfaithful to her husband is like a narrow well.
28 She lies in wait like a robber.
She makes more and more men unfaithful.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 26: "Give me your heart": The father does not only want obedience, but trust and love. Many people also hear the voice of God in this sentence.

Verses 27–28: Again the warning against unfaithfulness. Whoever falls into this "pit" has a hard time getting out again.

Who has pain? VERSES 29–35

29 Who has pain? Who has sorrow?
Who has fights? Who has complaints?
Who has bruises for no reason?
Who has red eyes?
30 People who sit for a long time over their wine,
people who go to try out mixed wine.
31 Don't look at the wine when it is red,
when it sparkles in the cup,
when it goes down smoothly.
32 In the end it bites like a snake.
It poisons like a viper.
33 Your eyes will see strange things.
Your mind will think up confused things.
34 You will be like someone who lies down in the middle of the sea,
like someone who lies on top of a ship's mast.
35 "They hit me, but I was not hurt!
They beat me, but I don't feel it!
When will I wake up?
I can do it again. I will look for more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an amazingly exact description of alcohol addiction, almost 3,000 years old.

Verses 29–30: Whoever drinks too much has quarrels, injuries that he cannot explain, and red eyes.

Verses 31–32: At the beginning, wine seems beautiful and pleasant. But in the end it bites like a snake.

Verses 33–34: Drunk people see things that are not there. They feel dizzy, as on a rocking ship.

Verse 35: The saddest thing: The drunk person does not even notice that he was hurt. And as soon as he wakes up, he wants to drink again. That is addiction.

If you or someone in your family is struggling with alcohol: Addiction is an illness, and there is help. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. Alcoholics Anonymous and local addiction counseling services also help.

PROVERBS

Chapter 24

Rescue those who are being led away to death

A house is built by wisdom VERSES 1–10

1 Don't envy evil people,
and don't wish to be with them,
2 for their hearts plan violence,
and their lips talk about harm.
3 Through wisdom a house is built.
By understanding it is made firm.
4 By knowledge the rooms are filled
with all kinds of rare and beautiful treasures.
5 A wise man has great power.
A man with knowledge increases his strength,
6 for with wise guidance you fight your war,
and victory comes through many advisers.
7 Wisdom is too high for a fool.
He does not open his mouth in the gate.
8 Whoever plans to do evil
will be called a schemer.
9 The plans of foolishness are sin.
People hate the mocker.
10 If you give up in the time of trouble,
your strength is small.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–4: A house, a family, a life is not built only with stones, but with wisdom. And the most beautiful treasures in it are not furniture, but knowledge and love.

Verse 7: Court cases were held and decisions were made in the city gate. There the fool has nothing wise to say.

Verse 10: Real strength only shows in hard times.

Don't look away VERSES 11–12

11 Rescue those who are being led away to death!
Yes, hold back those who are staggering to the slaughter!
12 If you say, "Look, we didn't know this,"
doesn't the one who weighs the hearts notice it?
Doesn't the one who protects your life know it?
Won't he pay back everyone according to what he has done?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most urgent calls in the Bible: When people are in danger of death, step in! Don't look away!

Verse 12: The excuse "We didn't know this" does not count before God. He knows what we knew.

After the Holocaust, many people in Germany said, "We didn't know anything." This verse is a lasting warning not to overlook injustice. It is still true today, everywhere people are persecuted, abused or killed.

Don't be glad when your enemy falls VERSES 13–22

13 My son, eat honey, for it is good,
honey from the honeycomb, which is sweet to your taste.
14 In the same way you will know that wisdom is for your soul.
If you have found it, there will be a reward:
Your hope will not be cut off.
15 Don't lie in wait, you wicked man, against the home of the righteous!
Don't destroy his resting place!
16 For a righteous person falls seven times and gets up again,
but the wicked are brought down by disaster.
17 Don't be glad when your enemy falls!
Don't let your heart rejoice when he is brought down,
18 or the LORD will see it, and it will displease him,
and he will turn his anger away from him.
19 Don't get upset because of evildoers,
and don't envy the wicked,
20 for the evil person will have no reward.
The lamp of the wicked will go out.
21 My son, fear the LORD and the king!
Don't join those who rebel,
22 for their disaster will come suddenly.
Who knows what ruin may come from them both?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: Wisdom is sweet like honey. It does the soul good.

Verse 16: An encouraging sentence: Good people fall too, even often, "seven times." But they get up again. Falling down is no shame. Staying down is.

Verses 17–18: Don't be glad about your enemy's misfortune! God is not pleased when we enjoy someone else's harm. This fits with Jesus' command to love our enemies.

Verses 19–20: Don't get upset about evil people who are successful. Their success does not last (compare Psalm 37).

More words of the wise VERSES 23–29

23 These also are sayings of the wise:
Taking sides in court is not good.
24 Whoever says to the wicked, "You are righteous,"
peoples will curse him, and nations will hate him.
25 But it will go well with those who prove the guilty wrong,
and a rich blessing will come on them.
26 An honest answer
is like a kiss on the lips.

27 Prepare your work outside,
and get your fields ready.
After that, build your house.
28 Don't be a witness against your neighbor without a reason!
Don't deceive with your lips!
29 Don't say, "I will do to him as he has done to me.
I will pay the man back for what he has done."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–25: A judge must be fair and must not favor anyone. Whoever lets the guilty go free loses everyone's trust.

Verse 26: A beautiful picture: An honest answer is a sign of friendship, like a kiss.

Verse 27: First lay the foundation, then build. First take care of your income, then build a house or start a family.

Verse 29: "I will do to him as he has done to me": That is not a good rule. Revenge is not our business (compare Proverbs 20:22).

The vineyard of the lazy person VERSES 30–34

30 I went past the field of the lazy person,
past the vineyard of the man without sense.
31 Look, it was all grown over with thorns.
Its ground was covered with nettles,
and its stone wall was broken down.
32 Then I saw it and thought about it carefully.
I saw it and learned a lesson:
33 A little sleep, a little slumber,
a little folding of the hands to sleep,
34 and your poverty will come like a robber
and your need like an armed man.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wise man tells what he has seen: A vineyard that no one takes care of grows wild. Weeds grow, and the wall falls down.

He learns from it: Decay does not come suddenly, but slowly, through many small things left undone. That is also true for friendships, marriages and faith.

Verses 33–34 repeat Proverbs 6:10–11.

This ends the part called "The words of the wise."

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 25

Apples of gold in settings of silver

The men of Hezekiah VERSES 1–7

1 These also are proverbs of Solomon,
which the men of Hezekiah, king of Judah, copied out.
2 It is the glory of God to hide a thing,
but the glory of kings is to search out a matter.
3 As the heavens are high and the earth is deep,
so the hearts of kings cannot be searched out.
4 Take away the waste from the silver,
and material comes out for the silversmith.
5 Take away the wicked from the king's presence,
and his throne will be made firm by righteousness.
6 Don't make yourself important before the king,
and don't claim a place among great people,
7 for it is better that someone says to you, "Come up here!"
than that you are put lower in front of the prince
whom your eyes have seen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Here a new part begins (Chapters 25–29). King Hezekiah lived about 250 years after Solomon. His writers collected old proverbs of Solomon and copied them out. That is how they were kept for us.

Verse 2: God has hidden many things in the world. People may and should search them out. Many scientists have understood this verse as encouragement.

Verses 6–7: Don't sit down in the place of honor on your own. It is better to be asked to come forward than to be sent away. Jesus tells almost exactly this parable (Luke 14:7–11).

A word at the right time VERSES 8–15

8 Don't be quick to bring charges to court.
What will you do in the end when your neighbor puts you to shame?
9 Settle your quarrel with your neighbor himself,
but don't give away someone else's secret,
10 or the one who hears it may put you to shame,
and your bad reputation will never go away.
11 A word spoken at the right time
is like apples of gold in settings of silver.
12 Like an earring of gold and jewelry of fine gold,
so is a wise person who corrects to an ear that listens.
13 Like the coolness of snow at harvest time,
so is a faithful messenger to those who send him,
for he refreshes the soul of his masters.
14 Like clouds and wind without rain,
so is someone who boasts of gifts he does not give.
15 By patience a ruler can be persuaded.
A gentle tongue breaks bones.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–10: A quarrel should be settled directly with the other person, not right away in court and not behind his back. Jesus gives similar advice (Matthew 18:15).

Verse 11: A wonderful picture: The right word at the right time is as precious and beautiful as a work of art made of gold and silver.

Verse 13: In the hot harvest time, something cool feels good. That is how refreshing a reliable person is.

Verse 14: Whoever promises a lot and keeps nothing is like clouds that bring no rain. Disappointing.

Verse 15: "A gentle tongue breaks bones": Patience and kind words often achieve more than violence.

Don't overdo it VERSES 16–20

16 Have you found honey? Eat only as much as is enough for you,
so that you don't eat too much and throw it up.
17 Set your foot in your neighbor's house only rarely,
so that he does not get tired of you and hate you.
18 A person who gives false testimony against his neighbor
is like a club, a sword, or a sharp arrow.
19 Trusting an unfaithful person in a time of trouble
is like a bad tooth or a lame foot.
20 Like someone who takes away a coat on a cold day,
or like vinegar on baking soda,
so is someone who sings songs to a sad heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: Good things too should be enjoyed in moderation: honey and visits to the neighbors. Too much of a good thing spoils everything.

Verse 19: Whoever relies on an unreliable person in a time of need is like someone with a toothache who tries to bite.

Verse 20: A sensitive proverb: Cheerful songs do not help someone who is sad. When vinegar gets on baking soda, it foams up. That is how a sad person reacts to forced cheerfulness. It is better to weep with those who weep (Romans 12:15).

When your enemy is hungry VERSES 21–28

21 If your enemy is hungry, give him food to eat.
If he is thirsty, give him water to drink,
22 for in this way you will heap burning coals on his head,
and the LORD will reward you.
23 The north wind brings rain,
and in the same way a slandering tongue brings an angry face.
24 It is better to live in a corner of the roof
than to share a house with a quarrelsome woman.
25 Like cold water to a thirsty soul,
so is good news from a faraway country.
26 Like a muddy spring and a dirty well,
so is a righteous person who gives in before the wicked.
27 It is not good to eat much honey,
and it is not honorable to look for your own honor.
28 Like a city that is broken down and has no walls,
so is a person who does not control his spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–22 are among the greatest sentences of the Old Testament: Be good to your enemy! Give him food and drink. The "burning coals" probably mean: He will be ashamed and maybe turn around. Kindness can turn an enemy into a friend. Paul quotes these verses (Romans 12:20–21): "Don't be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good."

Verse 24 repeats Proverbs 21:9.

Verse 25: Good news from far away, for example from someone you love, is as refreshing as cold water.

Verse 26: When good people give in to evil, it is like a dirty well: You can no longer rely on them.

Verse 28: Whoever cannot control himself is as unprotected as a city without walls.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 26

About fools, lazy people and liars

How to deal with fools VERSES 1–12

1 Like snow in summer and like rain at harvest time,
so honor does not fit a fool.
2 Like a fluttering sparrow, like a darting swallow,
so a curse that is not deserved does not land.
3 A whip for the horse, a bridle for the donkey,
and a rod for the back of fools!
4 Don't answer a fool according to his foolishness,
or you will become like him.
5 Answer a fool according to his foolishness,
or he will think he is wise.
6 Whoever sends a message by the hand of a fool
is cutting off his own feet and drinking violence.
7 Like the legs of the lame that hang down limp,
so is a proverb in the mouth of fools.
8 Like someone who ties a stone into a sling,
so is the one who gives honor to a fool.
9 Like a thorn bush that gets into the hand of a drunk person,
so is a proverb in the mouth of fools.
10 Like an archer who wounds everyone,
so is the one who hires a fool or hires those who just happen to pass by.
11 Like a dog that goes back to its vomit,
so is a fool who repeats his foolishness.
12 Do you see a person who is wise in his own eyes?
There is more hope for a fool than for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: A comforting sentence: When someone curses you without a reason, it has no power over you. The curse flies past like a bird.

Verse 3: A comparison from that time. It means: Whoever does not listen to words must feel the consequences. It is not a call to violence.

Verses 4–5 seem to contradict each other. That is on purpose! Sometimes it is better not to respond to foolish talk at all, so that you don't become foolish yourself. Sometimes you have to disagree, so that the other person does not think he is right. Wisdom means: seeing what is right in which situation.

Verses 7 and 9: A fool may be able to repeat wise sayings, but he does not understand them and uses them wrongly.

Verse 11: A strong picture: The fool makes the same mistakes again and again. Peter quotes this verse (2 Peter 2:22).

Verse 12: Whoever thinks he is wise and does not want to learn anymore is even worse off than a fool.

The lazy person and his excuses VERSES 13–16

13 The lazy person says, "There is a lion in the road!
A fierce lion is roaming the streets!"
14 As the door turns on its hinges,
so the lazy person turns on his bed.
15 The lazy person puts his hand in the dish.
He is too lazy to bring it back to his mouth.
16 The lazy person is wiser in his own eyes
than seven people who answer with good sense.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Four funny proverbs about the lazy person:

He makes up excuses (verse 13). He turns back and forth in bed like a door on its hinges, but he does not get anywhere (verse 14). He is even too lazy to eat (verse 15). And still he thinks he is smarter than everyone else (verse 16).

Quarrels, gossip and lies VERSES 17–28

17 Like someone who grabs a dog by the ears
is someone who passes by and meddles in a quarrel that is not his own.
18 Like a madman who shoots torches, arrows, and death,
19 so is the man who deceives his neighbor
and says, "Wasn't I only joking?"
20 When there is no wood, the fire goes out.
Without gossip, a quarrel dies down.
21 As coals are to hot embers and wood to fire,
so is a quarrelsome person for starting quarrels.
22 The words of a gossip are like tasty treats.
They go down into the innermost being.
23 Like silver waste coated on a clay pot,
so are burning lips with an evil heart.
24 A spiteful person hides what he is with his lips,
but in his heart he carries evil.
25 When his speech is charming, don't believe him,
for there are seven disgusting things in his heart.
26 His spite may be hidden by deception,
but his wickedness will be uncovered before the assembly.
27 Whoever digs a pit will fall into it.
Whoever rolls a stone, it will roll back on him.
28 A lying tongue hates those it hurts,
and a flattering mouth causes ruin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Whoever grabs a strange dog by the ears gets bitten. Whoever meddles in someone else's quarrel gets into trouble himself.

Verses 18–19: Whoever hurts others and then says, "Wasn't I only joking?" is as dangerous as someone who shoots arrows wildly in all directions. This is also true for bullying that is disguised as a joke.

Verses 20–21: Gossip is like wood for a fire. Without gossip, the quarrel goes out.

Verse 23: A cheap clay pot coated with a silver shine looks valuable, but it is not. That is what beautiful words from an evil heart are like.

Verse 27: "Whoever digs a pit will fall into it." This is where a well-known saying comes from: Whoever digs a pit for others will fall into it himself.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 27

Iron sharpens iron

Don't boast about tomorrow VERSES 1–6

1 Don't boast about tomorrow,
for you don't know what a day may bring.
2 Let someone else praise you, and not your own mouth,
a stranger, and not your own lips.
3 A stone is heavy, and sand is a burden,
but the trouble a fool causes is heavier than both.
4 Anger is cruel, and rage is overwhelming,
but who can stand before jealousy?
5 Better open correction
than hidden love.
6 The wounds a friend gives are faithful,
but the kisses of an enemy are many.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: No one knows what tomorrow will bring. That is why we should not boast about what we will do tomorrow. James says the same thing (James 4:13–15).

Verse 2: Praising yourself makes a bad impression. It is better when others praise you.

Verse 4: Jealousy is even more destructive than anger.

Verses 5–6: A real friend also tells you unpleasant truths, even when it hurts. A false friend only flatters you. Judas betrayed Jesus with a kiss (Matthew 26:48–49).

A neighbor nearby VERSES 7–14

7 A full soul refuses even honey,
but to a hungry soul every bitter thing is sweet.
8 Like a bird that flutters away from its nest,
so is a person who wanders away from his home.
9 Perfume and incense make the heart glad,
and so does the honest advice of a friend.
10 Don't leave your friend and your father's friend!
Don't go to your brother's house on the day of your disaster.
A neighbor who is near is better than a brother who is far away.
11 Be wise, my son, and make my heart glad,
then I can answer the one who mocks me.
12 A wise person sees danger and takes shelter,
but the simple go on and suffer for it.
13 Take his coat when he guarantees a loan for a stranger!
Hold it as security for an unfaithful woman!
14 Whoever blesses his neighbor with a loud voice early in the morning,
it will be counted as a curse to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Whoever is full does not even value the best things. Whoever is hungry is glad about everything. Thankfulness often depends on whether you know what it means to lack something.

Verse 8: Whoever has to leave his home is like a bird without a nest. Many refugees know this feeling.

Verse 10: Old friendships are precious. And in times of need, a neighbor often helps faster than relatives who live far away.

Verses 12–13 repeat Proverbs 22:3 and 20:16.

Verse 14: A funny proverb: Whoever shouts a blessing loudly early in the morning, while the neighbor still wants to sleep, does not make himself popular. The right moment matters.

Iron sharpens iron VERSES 15–22

15 A constant dripping on a rainy day
and a quarrelsome wife are alike:
16 holding her back is like holding back the wind
or like grabbing oil with your right hand.
17 Iron sharpens iron,
so a person sharpens his friend's face.
18 Whoever takes care of the fig tree will eat its fruit.
Whoever looks after his master will be honored.
19 As water reflects a face,
so a person's heart reflects the person.
20 Sheol (the world of the dead) and Abaddon are never satisfied,
and a person's eyes are never satisfied.
21 The melting pot is for silver and the furnace for gold,
but a person is tested by the praise he receives.
22 Even if you crush a fool in a mortar with a pestle together with the grain,
his foolishness will not leave him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–16: Like a leaking roof on a rainy day. This is true for quarrelsome partners, whether men or women.

Verse 17 is a famous proverb: As two pieces of iron sharpen each other, so good friends make each other better, through conversations, discussions and also disagreement.

Verse 19: When you look into water, you see your face. When you look into your heart, you see who you really are.

Verse 20: People always want more. Their eyes are never satisfied. That is a fitting description of greed and consumerism.

Verse 21: How someone deals with praise shows his character. Does he become proud, or does he stay humble?

Verse 22: Some people never change, no matter what happens.

Take good care of your flock VERSES 23–27

23 Know well the condition of your sheep,
and pay attention to your herds,
24 for riches do not last forever,
and the crown does not last for all generations.
25 The hay is brought in, and the new grass appears,
and the plants of the hills are gathered in.
26 The lambs are for your clothing,
and the goats are the price of a field.
27 There will be plenty of goats' milk as food for you,
as food for your family,
and to feed your servant girls.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A little song about good farming: Take good care of what has been entrusted to you. Then you will be provided for.

Verse 24: Money and power do not last. But whoever works carefully and takes care of living things has a new harvest every year.

Today we can apply this to everything that has been entrusted to us: work, family, employees, creation.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 28

Whoever confesses his sins finds mercy

Bold as a lion VERSES 1–7

1 The wicked run away when no one is chasing them,
but the righteous are as bold as a lion.
2 When a land rebels, it has many rulers,
but order is kept by a man of understanding and knowledge.
3 A needy person who oppresses the poor
is like a pounding rain that leaves no crops.
4 Those who leave the law praise the wicked,
but those who keep the law fight against them.
5 Evil people don't understand justice,
but those who seek the LORD understand it fully.
6 Better is a poor person who lives with integrity
than someone who goes crooked ways and is rich.
7 Whoever keeps the law is a wise son,
but whoever spends time with gluttons brings shame on his father.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Whoever has a guilty conscience is always afraid, even without a reason. Whoever has a good conscience can be bold.

Verse 2: When a land turns away from God, there is chaos and constantly new people in power.

Verse 3: It is especially bad when someone who was poor himself takes advantage of other poor people.

Verse 5: Whoever seeks God gets a sense for justice.

Excessive interest and honest confession VERSES 8–14

8 Whoever increases his wealth by excessive interest
gathers it for the one who has pity on the poor.
9 Whoever turns his ear away from hearing the law,
even his prayer is disgusting.
10 Whoever leads the upright astray onto an evil way
will fall into his own trap,
but the blameless will inherit good things.

11 The rich person is wise in his own eyes,
but the poor person who has understanding sees through him.
12 When the righteous win, there is great glory,
but when the wicked rise to power, people hide.
13 Whoever hides his sins will not succeed,
but whoever confesses them and gives them up finds mercy.
14 Happy is the person who always has reverence,
but whoever hardens his heart falls into trouble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Whoever gets rich with excessive interest does not keep the money in the end. God makes sure that it comes to those who help the poor. The law of Moses forbade taking interest from poor Israelites (Exodus 22:25).

Verse 9: Whoever does not want to listen to God, his prayers are empty.

Verse 12: When good people govern, the land is glad. When evil people come to power, people hide in fear. This has happened again and again in dictatorships.

Verse 13 is one of the most comforting verses of the book: Whoever hides his guilt does not become happy. But whoever honestly admits it and stops doing it finds God's mercy. Compare Psalm 32:5 and 1 John 1:9.

The cruel ruler VERSES 15–22

15 Like a roaring lion or a charging bear,
so is a wicked ruler over helpless people.
16 A cruel ruler has no sense.
Whoever hates dishonest gain will live long.
17 A person who is tormented by the guilt of bloodshed
will be a fugitive until death. No one will support him.
18 Whoever lives blamelessly is kept safe,
but whoever goes crooked ways will fall suddenly.
19 Whoever works his land will have plenty of food,
but whoever chases fantasies will have plenty of poverty.
20 A faithful person is rich with blessings,
but whoever is eager to get rich will not go unpunished.
21 Taking sides is not good,
and yet a person will do wrong for a piece of bread.
22 A stingy person hurries after riches
and does not know that poverty is waiting for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–16: A cruel ruler is like a wild animal for his people. Cruel, unjust rule is not strength, but foolishness.

Verse 17: Whoever has killed a person finds no peace. His conscience torments him.

Verse 20: "Getting rich quick" is dangerous. This is also true for gambling and dishonest investments. If you are addicted to gambling, you can find help. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 21: Some people let themselves be bribed even for a small thing.

Whoever gives to the poor VERSES 23–28

23 Whoever corrects a person will later find more favor
than the one who flatters with his tongue.
24 Whoever robs his father or his mother and says, "It's not wrong,"
is a partner of a destroyer.
25 Whoever is greedy stirs up quarrels,
but whoever trusts in the LORD will do well.
26 Whoever trusts in himself is a fool,
but whoever lives in wisdom is kept safe.
27 Whoever gives to the poor will lack nothing,
but whoever closes his eyes will get many curses.
28 When the wicked rise to power, people hide,
but when they perish, the righteous do well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: In the end, honest criticism is valued more than flattery.

Verse 24: Grown-up children too must not take advantage of their parents, for example by taking their money or grabbing their inheritance early. That is wrong, even if you try to make it sound good.

Verse 26: Whoever trusts only in himself is relying on shaky ground.

Verse 27: Whoever gives to the poor does not become poorer. Whoever looks away becomes guilty.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 29

The fear of people is a trap

Righteous rulers VERSES 1–7

1 Whoever is often corrected and still makes his neck stiff
will be broken suddenly, and there is no healing.
2 When the righteous do well, the people are glad,
but when the wicked rule, the people groan.
3 Whoever loves wisdom makes his father glad,
but whoever spends time with prostitutes wastes his wealth.
4 The king makes the land stable by justice,
but whoever takes bribes tears it down.
5 A person who flatters his neighbor
spreads a net for his feet.
6 An evil person is trapped by his sin,
but the righteous can sing and be glad.
7 The righteous care about justice for the poor.
The wicked do not care about knowledge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Whoever is warned again and again and still stays stubborn will one day fall hard.

Verse 2: Good governments make a people glad. Bad governments make them groan.

Verse 4: Corruption destroys a country. Justice gives it stability.

Verse 7: One mark of righteous people: They work to make sure that the poor get justice.

The wise person controls himself VERSES 8–14

8 Mockers stir up a city,
but wise people turn away anger.
9 If a wise person goes to court with a fool,
the fool rages or mocks, and there is no peace.
10 The bloodthirsty hate a person of integrity,
and they try to kill the upright.
11 A fool lets out all of his anger,
but a wise person keeps himself under control.
12 If a ruler listens to lies,
all his officials become wicked.
13 The poor person and the oppressor have this in common:
The LORD gives sight to the eyes of both.
14 The king who judges the poor fairly,
his throne will stand forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Whoever spreads hate stirs up a whole city. Wise people calm things down and bring people together.

Verse 11: Simply letting out your anger is not wise. Whoever controls himself is wise.

Verse 12: When a boss or ruler likes to hear lies, everyone around him becomes a liar.

Verse 13: The oppressor and the oppressed have the same eyesight from God. Both are God's creatures. This gives the poor person his dignity and reminds the powerful of their responsibility.

Bringing up children and revelation VERSES 15–21

15 The rod of correction gives wisdom,
but a child left to himself brings shame to his mother.
16 When the wicked increase, sin increases,
but the righteous will see their downfall.
17 Correct your son, and he will give you peace.
Yes, he will bring joy to your soul.
18 Where there is no revelation, the people throw off all limits,
but happy is the one who keeps the law.
19 A servant cannot be corrected by words.
Even if he understands, he will not respond.
20 Do you see a person who is hasty with his words?
There is more hope for a fool than for him.
21 Whoever spoils his servant from his youth
will have him become like a son in the end.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15 and 17: Children need to be brought up and need limits. A child who is completely left to himself is lost. The "rod" was normal back then. Today we know: Good parenting works without hitting. What matters is loving consistency.

Verse 18: A well-known verse: When a people no longer hears God's word, it loses its measure and its direction. Where God's teaching counts, there is something to hold on to.

Verses 19 and 21 describe the relationship with servants as it was normal back then. Slavery and oppression are wrong. In many places, the Bible tells how God sets people free from slavery.

Verse 20: Whoever speaks before he thinks is even worse off than a fool.

Whoever trusts in the LORD is safe VERSES 22–27

22 An angry person stirs up quarrels,
and a furious person commits many sins.
23 A person's pride brings him low,
but whoever is humble gains honor.
24 Whoever is the partner of a thief is an enemy of his own life.
He takes an oath, but does not dare to testify.
25 The fear of people is a trap,
but whoever trusts in the LORD is kept safe.
26 Many seek the favor of the ruler,
but a person's justice comes from the LORD.
27 A dishonest person hates the righteous,
and those who are upright in their ways hate the wicked.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: Whoever takes part in a theft and then keeps silent in court, even though he would have to testify under oath, harms himself.

Verse 25 is a freeing sentence: Whoever is always afraid of what others think is caught as in a trap. Whoever trusts in God becomes free.

Verse 26: Many try to look good in the eyes of the powerful. But in the end, justice comes from God.

This ends the proverbs that the men of Hezekiah collected. Next come the words of Agur (Chapter 30) and Lemuel (Chapter 31).

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 30

The words of Agur

Who knows God's name? VERSES 1–6

1 The words of Agur, the son of Jakeh, the revelation:
The man speaks to Ithiel, to Ithiel and Ucal:
2 "Surely I am the most ignorant person,
and I don't have human understanding.
3 I have not learned wisdom,
and I don't have the knowledge of the Holy One.
4 Who has gone up into heaven and come down again?
Who has gathered the wind in his fists?
Who has tied up the waters in his coat?
Who has set up all the ends of the earth?

What is his name, and what is his son's name, if you know?

5 Every word of God is flawless.
He is a shield for those who take refuge in him.
6 Don't add to his words,
or he will correct you, and you will be found a liar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Agur is a wise man we know nothing else about. Maybe he did not come from Israel. Ithiel and Ucal are probably his students. Some also read the names as words: "I have worked hard, O God, and I am worn out."

Verses 2–3: Agur begins very humbly: I know nothing! Real wisdom begins with seeing how little you know.

Verse 4: Big questions as in the book of Job: Who made the world? No human being, only God. The question about "his son's name" is a riddle. Jews often think of Israel here, which is called "God's son" (Exodus 4:22). Christians hear in it a pointer to Jesus (compare John 3:13).

Verses 5–6: God's word is reliable. You should not add anything to it. That is also a rule for this edition: leave nothing out, make nothing up.

Neither poverty nor riches VERSES 7–9

7 "Two things I have asked of you.
Don't refuse them to me before I die:
8 Keep falsehood and lies far away from me.
Give me neither poverty nor riches.
Feed me with the food that I need,
9 so that I don't become full, deny you, and say, 'Who is the LORD?'
or so that I don't become poor, steal,
and so dishonor the name of my God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the only prayer in the whole book of Proverbs, and it is very wise.

Agur asks for two things: honesty and enough to live on, no more and no less.

Whoever is too rich easily forgets God, because he thinks he does not need him. Whoever is too poor may be tempted to steal.

Jesus teaches us to pray in a similar way: "Give us today our daily bread" (Matthew 6:11).

There is a generation that ... VERSES 10–17

10 "Don't slander a servant to his master,
or he will curse you, and you will be guilty.
11 There is a generation that curses their father
and does not bless their mother.
12 There is a generation that is pure in their own eyes
and yet is not washed from their filth.
13 There is a generation, oh, how proud are their eyes!
Their eyelids are lifted high.
14 There is a generation whose teeth are like swords
and whose jaws are like knives,
to eat up the poor from the earth
and the needy from among people.
15 The leech has two daughters: 'Give, give!'
There are three things that are never satisfied,
four that never say, 'Enough!':
16 Sheol (the world of the dead), the barren womb,
the earth that never gets enough water,
and the fire that never says, 'Enough!'
17 The eye that mocks at its father
and scorns obeying its mother,
the ravens of the valley will peck it out,
and the young eagles will eat it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–14 describe four kinds of bad people: They despise their parents, think they are perfect, are proud, and exploit the poor. People like this exist in every age.

Verses 15–16: A number proverb: "three, yes four." Some things are never satisfied: death, the earth in the dry season, fire. The unfulfilled wish for a child is named here too. That is no reproach against women who cannot have children. It shows how deep this longing is.

Verse 17: A very strong picture for the end of a person who despises his parents: He dies and is not even buried. It is a warning, not a command.

Wonders I don't understand VERSES 18–23

18 "There are three things that are too amazing for me,
four that I don't understand:
19 the way of an eagle in the air,
the way of a snake on a rock,
the way of a ship in the middle of the sea,
and the way of a man with a young woman.
20 This is the way of an adulterous woman:
She eats and wipes her mouth
and says, 'I have done nothing wrong.'
21 Under three things the earth trembles,
and under four it cannot bear up:
22 under a servant when he becomes king,
under a fool when he has plenty of food,
23 under an unloved woman when she gets married,
and under a servant girl who takes the place of her mistress.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–19: Agur is amazed: An eagle flies, a snake glides over the rock, a ship sails over the sea, and they leave no track behind. And how love grows between a man and a woman is just as great a mystery.

Verse 20: In contrast: the adulterous woman who acts as if nothing had happened.

Verses 21–23: With humor, Agur describes situations in which order is turned upside down: When someone suddenly gets power who cannot handle it, there is trouble.

Small but wise VERSES 24–28

24 "There are four things that are small on the earth,
but they are very wise:
25 The ants are not a strong people,
and yet they get their food ready in the summer.
26 The hyraxes are only a weak people,
and yet they make their homes in the rocks.
27 The locusts have no king,
and yet they march in rows.
28 You can catch a lizard with your hands,
and yet it is in kings' palaces.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful passage about small animals we can learn from:

The ant plans ahead. The hyrax, a small animal a little like a groundhog, looks for shelter in the rocks. The locusts stay together, even without a leader. The lizard gets in everywhere, even into palaces.

You don't have to be big and strong to be wise.

Proud in their walk VERSES 29–33

29 "There are three things that march proudly,
four that walk proudly:
30 the lion, which is the mightiest among animals
and does not turn back for anyone,
31 the greyhound, the male goat,
and the king against whom no one can rise up.
32 If you have acted foolishly by lifting yourself up,
or if you have planned evil,
put your hand over your mouth!
33 For as the churning of milk produces butter,
and the squeezing of the nose produces blood,
so the stirring up of anger produces quarrels."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 29–31: A picture of dignity and self-confidence. The Hebrew word that is translated here as "greyhound" is uncertain. Some translate "rooster" or "horse."

Verse 32: "Put your hand over your mouth": When you notice that you have done something foolish, be quiet and don't make it worse.

Verse 33: A play on words: Whoever churns milk gets butter. Whoever squeezes the nose gets blood. Whoever stirs up anger gets quarrels. In Hebrew, the words for "nose" and "anger" sound the same.

PROVERBS

CHAPTER 31

The capable woman

A mother's advice to her son VERSES 1–9

1 The words of King Lemuel, the revelation that his
mother taught him:
2 "Oh, my son! Oh, son of my womb!
Oh, son of my vows!
3 Don't give your strength to women,
or your ways to what destroys kings.
4 It is not for kings, Lemuel,
it is not for kings to drink wine,
or for princes to say, 'Where is strong drink?'
5 or they will drink and forget the law
and twist the justice that is owed to all who suffer.
6 Give strong drink to the one who is about to die,
and wine to those who are bitter in soul.
7 Let him drink and forget his poverty,
and remember his misery no more.
8 Open your mouth for the mute,
for the rights of all who are left alone.
9 Open your mouth, judge righteously,
and get justice for the poor and needy."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We know nothing else about King Lemuel. What is special here: A mother teaches her son, a king. Her words were taken into the Bible.

Verse 3: A king should not waste his strength on many women, as many kings with big harems did.

Verses 4–5: Whoever carries responsibility must stay sober. Drunk rulers make unjust judgments.

Verses 6–7: These verses describe wine as comfort for the dying and the desperate, as people knew it back then. It is no advice to numb sorrow with alcohol. Today there is better help: pain medicine, pastoral care and counseling. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 8–9 are a great task: Speak up for those who have no voice! Stand up for the poor, the weak and the forgotten. This task is for everyone who has influence.

A capable woman – who can find her? VERSES 10–31

10 Who can find a capable woman?
Her value is far above rubies.
11 The heart of her husband trusts in her.
He will not lack anything of value.
12 She does him good and not harm
all the days of her life.
13 She looks for wool and flax
and works eagerly with her hands.
14 She is like the merchant ships.
She brings her food from far away.
15 She gets up while it is still night,
gives food to her household
and portions to her servant girls.
16 She looks at a field and buys it.
With what her hands have earned, she plants a vineyard.
17 She wraps strength around her waist
and makes her arms strong.
18 She sees that her trading brings a profit.
Her lamp does not go out at night.
19 She puts her hands to the distaff,
and her hands hold the spindle.
20 She opens her arms to the poor.
Yes, she reaches out her hands to the needy.
21 She is not afraid of the snow for her household,
for her whole household is dressed in scarlet.
22 She makes covers of tapestry for herself.
Her clothing is fine linen and purple.
23 Her husband is respected in the gates
when he sits among the elders of the land.
24 She makes linen clothes and sells them,
and she delivers sashes to the merchant.

25 Strength and dignity are her clothing.
She laughs at the time to come.
26 She opens her mouth with wisdom.
Kind teaching is on her tongue.
27 She watches carefully over the ways of her household
and does not eat the bread of laziness.
28 Her children stand up and call her blessed.
Her husband praises her too:
29 "Many women do noble things,
but you are better than all of them."
30 Charm is deceiving, and beauty does not last,
but a woman who fears the LORD will be praised.
31 Give her some of what her hands have earned!
Let her works praise her in the gates!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Proverbs ends with a song about a capable woman. It is an alphabet poem: In Hebrew, each of the 22 verses begins with the next letter of the alphabet, from A to Z, so to speak.

This woman is amazingly independent and strong: She works with her hands, does business, buys land, plants a vineyard, takes care of her family and her workers, helps the poor, teaches with wisdom and is not afraid of the future.

She is no picture of a woman who only serves. She is a wise businesswoman, a teacher and a mother who is honored.

Verse 25: "She laughs at the time to come": She is not afraid of the future, because she has planned ahead well and trusts God.

Verse 30: The most important thing is not beauty, but the fear of God. So the book comes full circle to its beginning: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge" (1:7).

In Judaism, men sing this song ("Eshet Chayil," that is, "A capable woman") for their wives on Friday evening at the beginning of the Sabbath.

Some interpreters also see in this woman a picture of wisdom itself, who appeared as a woman at the beginning of the book (Chapters 1, 8 and 9).

The song is not a standard that every woman has to measure herself by. It is praise for everything women do, and a call to honor it openly (verse 31).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Proverbs?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A book for life: Proverbs is full of practical wisdom for everyday life: work, money, friendship, marriage, bringing up children, words, neighbors, politics.

The motto: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge" (1:7). Wisdom begins with taking God seriously. This thought stands at the beginning and at the end of the book (31:30).

Two ways: Again and again, the wise person and the fool stand against each other, the righteous and the wicked, the hard worker and the lazy person. Lady Wisdom and Lady Folly both invite (Chapter 9). Every person has to choose.

The power of words: No topic comes up as often as our words. "Death and life are in the power of the tongue" (18:21). "A gentle answer turns away anger" (15:1).

The poor: Again and again, the book takes the side of the poor, widows and orphans. "Whoever oppresses the poor shows contempt for his Maker" (14:31). "Open your mouth for the mute" (31:8).

No guarantee: Proverbs describe how life usually goes. They are not promises for every single case. Not every poor person is lazy, not every godly person becomes rich. The books of Job and Ecclesiastes complete this picture.

Difficult verses: Some proverbs reflect the world of back then, for example the rod in bringing up children or the position of servants. We have translated them completely and explained them: Violence against children is rightly forbidden in many places today, and slavery is wrong.

Wisdom for all: The book often speaks to "my son." But it ends with the praise of a wise, strong woman. Wisdom is there for everyone.

Christ, the wisdom: Christians see in wisdom, who was there at creation (Chapter 8), a pointer to Christ (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30). Jews see in it the Torah, God's teaching.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Ecclesiastes (in Hebrew, Qoheleth). It asks the big questions: What is left of life? "All is vanity." It is an honest, thoughtful book that completes Proverbs.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 21 OF 66

ECCLESIASTES

12 CHAPTERS

ECCLESIASTES

Chapter 1

All is vanity

Before we begin: What is the book of Ecclesiastes?

In Hebrew, the book of Ecclesiastes is called "Qoheleth." That means something like: "someone who speaks to an assembly." That is why he is called "the Preacher" in English.

The Preacher calls himself "the son of David, king in Jerusalem." That is why the book was linked with Solomon for a long time. Many scholars today think that it was written later, and that Solomon only serves as an example of a rich, wise king.

The book is unusually honest. The Preacher looks at life "under the sun" and asks: What is left in the end? What does a person gain from all his hard work?

His famous word is "hevel." It really means "breath," "mist" or "a puff of wind": something that is there and disappears again at once. The WEB, our English source text, translates it as "vanity." This edition keeps the word "vanity." What is meant: Everything is fleeting, passing, impossible to hold on to.

The book is not only sad. Again and again the Preacher says: Enjoy your food, your work, the people you love. That is a gift from God.

At the end it says: "Fear God and keep his commandments" (Ecclesiastes 12:13).

The book of Ecclesiastes completes the book of Proverbs. Proverbs says how life usually goes. The Preacher says: But not always. And in the end, everyone dies.

Many people find their own questions in this book. It shows: Doubts and questions too have a place in the Bible.

All is vanity VERSES 1–11

1 The words of the Preacher, the son of David, king in
Jerusalem:
2 "Vanity of vanities," says the Preacher,
"Vanity of vanities, all is vanity."
3 What does a person gain from all his hard work
that he works at under the sun?
4 One generation goes, and another generation comes,
but the earth remains forever.
5 The sun rises, and the sun goes down,
and hurries back to its place where it rises.
6 The wind goes toward the south and turns around to
the north.
It keeps turning around as it blows,
and the wind returns again to its paths.
7 All the rivers run into the sea,
and yet the sea is not full.
To the place where the rivers flow,
there they keep flowing.
8 All things are full of weariness, more than anyone can
say.
The eye is not satisfied with seeing,
and the ear is not filled with hearing.
9 What has been is what will be,
and what has been done is what will be done.
There is nothing new under the sun.
10 Is there anything of which someone could say,
"Look, this is new"?
It was already here long ago, in the ages before us.
11 No one remembers those who came before,
and those who are still to come
will not be remembered either
by those who come after them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Vanity of vanities" means: Everything is completely fleeting. The Hebrew has "hevel," a breath. Like your breath on a cold day: You see it for a moment, then it is gone.

Verse 3: "Under the sun" is one of the Preacher's favorite expressions. He means: here on earth, in human life, as we see it.

Verses 4–7: Nature always goes in circles: sun, wind, rivers. Everything moves, but nothing arrives at a goal. People come and go, the earth stays.

Verse 9: "There is nothing new under the sun" has become a famous saying. Technology changes, but people stay the same: They love, quarrel, hope and die.

Verse 11: After a few generations, no one knows anymore who we were. A sobering thought.

Much wisdom, much grief VERSES 12–18

12 I, the Preacher, was king over Israel in Jerusalem.
13 I set my heart on seeking and searching out with
wisdom
everything that is done under the sky.
It is a heavy burden that God has given to people
to trouble themselves with.
14 I have seen all the works that are done under the sun,
and all is vanity and a chasing after wind.
15 What is crooked cannot be made straight,
and what is missing cannot be counted.
16 I said to myself, "I have gained great wisdom,
more than all who were before me in Jerusalem.
Yes, my heart has had great experience of wisdom and
knowledge."
17 I set my heart on knowing wisdom
and on knowing madness and foolishness.
I saw that this too is a chasing after wind.
18 For where there is much wisdom, there is much grief,
and whoever increases knowledge increases sorrow.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher has searched out everything, with great wisdom. His result: "A chasing after wind." You try to catch the wind with your hands, and still you have nothing in your hand.

Verse 15: Some things in the world are crooked, and we cannot bend them straight. Accepting that is also wisdom.

Verse 18: A surprising sentence: The more you know, the more you suffer. Whoever knows a lot also sees a lot of suffering and injustice. Not knowing can be more comfortable, but the Preacher chooses honesty.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 2

The great experiment

I tried pleasure VERSES 1–11

1 I said in my heart, "Come now, I will test you with joy.
So enjoy pleasure!"
But this too was vanity.
2 I said about laughter, "It is foolishness,"
and about joy, "What does it achieve?"
3 I searched in my heart
how I could cheer my body with wine,
while my heart was still guiding me with wisdom,
and how I could hold on to foolishness,
until I could see what is good for people
to do under heaven
all the days of their lives.
4 I made great works for myself.
I built houses for myself.
I planted vineyards for myself.
5 I made gardens and parks for myself,
and I planted trees with all kinds of fruit in them.
6 I made pools of water for myself,
to water the forest where trees were growing.
7 I bought male servants and female servants,
and I had servants who were born in my house.
I also had great possessions of herds and flocks,
more than all who were before me in Jerusalem.
8 I also gathered silver and gold for myself
and the treasures of kings and provinces.
I got male and female singers for myself,
and the delights of people:
musical instruments of all kinds.
9 So I became great and richer than all
who were before me in Jerusalem.
My wisdom also stayed with me.
10 Whatever my eyes wanted, I did not keep from them.
I did not hold my heart back from any joy,
for my heart was glad because of all my work,
and this was my share from all my work.
11 Then I looked at all the works that my hands had done,
and at the hard work I had worked so hard at,
and all was vanity and a chasing after wind,
and there was no profit under the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher carries out a big experiment: Does pleasure make you happy? He has everything: houses, gardens, parks, pools, servants, herds, gold, music, wine. He allows himself every wish.

The result: emptiness. Nothing is left that really counts.

This is still true today: Many rich and famous people say that possessions and success did not make them happy.

Verse 7: Owning slaves was normal back then. Today we know: No person may belong to another.

The wise person dies like the fool VERSES 12–17

12 I turned to look at wisdom, madness, and foolishness.
For what can the king's successor do?
Only what has already been done long ago.
13 Then I saw that wisdom is better than foolishness,
as light is better than darkness.
14 The wise person has his eyes in his head,
and the fool walks in darkness.
And yet I saw that the same thing happens to them all.
15 Then I said in my heart,
"What happens to the fool will happen to me too.
Why then have I been so much wiser?"
Then I said in my heart that this too is vanity.
16 For the wise person, just like the fool,
will not be remembered forever,
for in the days to come everything will long be forgotten.
Yes, the wise person must die just like the fool!
17 So I hated life,
for the work that is done under the sun was painful to me,
for all is vanity and a chasing after wind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: Wisdom is better than foolishness, as light is better than darkness. The Preacher says that too.

But: In the end both die, the wise person and the fool. And both are forgotten.

Verse 17: "So I hated life": a shockingly honest sentence. The Preacher does not hide his despair. The Bible has room for feelings like these.

If you feel this way yourself and can no longer bear life: Please talk with someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

What is it all for? VERSES 18–23

18 I hated all my hard work that I had worked at under the sun,
because I must leave it to the person who comes after me.
19 Who knows whether he will be wise or a fool?
And yet he will rule over all my hard work
that I worked at and in which I showed myself wise under the sun.
This too is vanity.
20 So I began to let my heart despair
over all the hard work that I had worked at under the

sun.
21 For there is a person who works with wisdom,
knowledge, and skill,
and yet he must leave it as a share to a person
who did not work for it.
This too is vanity and a great evil.
22 For what does a person get from all his hard work
and from the striving of his heart
that he works at under the sun?
23 For all his days are pain,
and his work is grief.
Yes, even at night his heart finds no rest.
This too is vanity.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher is upset: I worked my whole life and built everything up wisely. And who gets it after my death? Maybe a fool who throws everything away.

Verse 23: He describes what many people know: stress, worries, sleepless nights because of work. And in the end you ask yourself: What for?

Eat, drink and enjoy VERSES 24–26

24 There is nothing better for a person
than to eat and drink
and let his soul enjoy good things in his work.
I also saw this, that it comes from the hand of God.
25 For who can eat, or who can enjoy things, more than I?
26 For to the person who pleases him,
God gives wisdom, knowledge, and joy.
But to the sinner he gives the trouble of gathering and piling up,
to give it to the one who pleases God.
This too is vanity and a chasing after wind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After all the despair comes a surprising turn: Enjoy the simple things! Eating, drinking, joy in your work. This is not a reward that you earn, but a gift from God's hand.

This is a basic thought of the book: We cannot hold on to life or understand it completely. But we can accept the good moments thankfully from God's hand.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 3

For everything there is a season

A time for everything VERSES 1–8

1 Everything has its season.
There is a time for everything that happens under heaven:
2 a time to be born, and a time to die,
a time to plant, and a time to pull up what was planted,
3 a time to kill, and a time to heal,
a time to break down, and a time to build up,
4 a time to weep, and a time to laugh,
a time to mourn, and a time to dance,
5 a time to throw away stones, and a time to gather stones together,
a time to hug, and a time not to hug,
6 a time to search, and a time to lose,
a time to keep, and a time to throw away,
7 a time to tear, and a time to sew,
a time to keep silent, and a time to speak,
8 a time to love, and a time to hate,
a time for war, and a time for peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the best-known texts of the Bible. It is often read at funerals, weddings and birthdays.

There are 14 pairs of opposites, always two opposites in one line. They cover all of life: from birth to death, from weeping to laughing, from war to peace.

The message: Life has rhythms. Not everything is right at every time. There is a time to grieve and a time to celebrate. Whoever sees what is needed right now is wise.

Verses 3 and 8: "A time to kill," "a time to hate," "a time for war": The Preacher describes what happens in the world, the terrible things too. He does not say that killing or hatred are good. It is worth noticing: The list ends with "peace."

Verse 5: "A time to throw away stones, and a time to gather stones together": Maybe this means clearing a field of stones and gathering stones for a house. Some interpreters also think of tenderness, because the next line speaks of hugging.

Verse 7: "A time to tear": When someone died, people tore their clothes in grief. Later, when the time of mourning was over, they sewed them back together.

Eternity in the heart VERSES 9–15

9 What does a worker gain
from all his hard work?
10 I have seen the heavy load that God has given to people.
They have to struggle with it.
11 God has made everything beautiful in its time.
He has also set eternity in their hearts.
But people cannot understand the work that God has done
from the beginning to the end.
12 I know that there is nothing better for people
than to be happy and to do good as long as they live.
13 Every person should eat and drink
and enjoy the good things in all his work.
That is a gift from God.
14 I know that everything God does will last forever.
Nothing can be added to it.
Nothing can be taken away from it.
God has done this so that people will fear him.
15 What is now has been long ago.
What will be has also been long ago.
God looks again for what has passed away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11 is one of the deepest sentences of the Bible: God has "set eternity in their hearts." That is why we are never

completely satisfied with what passes away. We long for something that lasts. But we cannot fully understand God's great plan.

Augustine, a great teacher of the church, said later: "Our heart is restless until it rests in you, O God."

Verses 12–13: The Preacher's answer: be glad, do good, enjoy life thankfully. It is a gift from God.

Verse 15: "God looks again for what has passed away": With God, nothing is lost. He forgets nothing.

People and animals VERSES 16–22

16 I also saw this under the sun:
In the place where there should be justice, there was evil.
In the place where there should be what is right, there was evil.
17 I thought to myself,
"God will judge the righteous and the wicked.
There is a time there for everything that happens and for every deed."
18 I thought to myself,
"God tests people.
He wants them to see that they are like animals.
19 What happens to people also happens to animals.
The same thing happens to both.
As one dies, so the other dies.
They all have the same breath.
People have no advantage over animals.
Everything is vanity.
20 All go to the same place.
All come from the dust,
and all turn back into dust.
21 Who knows if the spirit of a person goes up?
And who knows if the spirit of an animal goes down into the earth?"
22 So I saw that there is nothing better for a person than to be happy in his work.
That is his share in life.
Who can show him what will happen after he is gone?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Even in the courts there is injustice. The Preacher sees this with pain.

Verse 17: But he believes: In the end, God will judge justly. Righteous means: living right before God.

Verses 18–21: A hard thought: People and animals die in the same way. Both come from the dust and become dust again (compare Genesis 3:19). The Preacher honestly asks: Who knows what comes after death?

He has no sure answer to this. Other parts of the Bible speak more clearly later about a hope beyond death (for example Daniel 12:2). Christians believe in the resurrection through Jesus Christ.

Verse 19: Vanity means: fleeting, like a breath of wind.

Verse 22: Since we do not know what comes afterward, we should enjoy our life and our work now.

ECCLESIASTES

Chapter 4

Two are better than one

The tears of the oppressed VERSES 1–3

1 Then I turned and saw all the oppression
that is done under the sun:
There were the tears of those who were oppressed,
and they had no comforter.
On the side of their oppressors there was power,
but they had no comforter.
2 So I praised the dead who have been dead a long time
more than the living who are still alive.
3 Yes, better than both of them is the one who has not yet been,
who has not seen the evil work
that is done under the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher sees the suffering of the oppressed. Twice he says: "They had no comforter." No one helps them.

Verses 2–3: In despair over so much suffering, he says: The dead are better off, and best of all would be never to have been born. That is an expression of deep grief over the injustice of the world, as with Job (Job 3). It is not a call to end your life.

In other places, the Bible answers this cry: God himself wants to be the comforter of the oppressed (Isaiah 40:1; 2 Corinthians 1:3–4). And we are to become comforters for others.

If you are in despair: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Envy and quietness VERSES 4–8

4 Then I saw all the hard work and success,
that it comes from one person's envy of another.
This too is vanity and a chasing after wind.
5 The fool folds his hands
and ruins himself.
6 Better one handful with quietness
than two handfuls with hard work and chasing after wind.
7 Then I turned and saw vanity under the sun.
8 There is someone who is alone,
and he has neither son nor brother.
Yet there is no end to all his hard work,
and his eyes are not satisfied with wealth.
"For whom am I working so hard
and keeping my soul from enjoyment?"
This too is vanity.
Yes, it is a miserable business.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: A lot of hard work and success comes from competition and envy: People want to be better than their neighbor. That does not make anyone happy.

Verses 5–6: Two extremes: The lazy person does nothing and is ruined. The stressed person works with both hands and has no rest. The middle is better: one handful, but with quietness.

Verse 8: A sad picture: A person works and works, becomes richer and richer, but he is completely alone. For whom, really? He allows himself nothing and has no one to share with.

Two are better than one VERSES 9–12

9 Two are better than one,
because they have a good reward for their hard work.
10 For if they fall, the one will help his friend up.
But how terrible for the one who is alone when he falls,
and there is no one else to help him up.
11 Also, if two lie down together, they keep warm.
But how can one keep warm alone?
12 If someone overpowers one person who is alone,
two will stand up against him.
And a cord of three strands is not quickly broken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wonderful text about community and friendship. It is often read at weddings.

Two together are stronger: They help each other up, keep each other warm, protect each other.

Verse 12: "A cord of three strands": Three threads twisted together are much stronger than one. At weddings, people often say: The third strand is God, who holds the couple together.

This text is a comfort for everyone who has community, and an invitation for everyone who is lonely: Look for people who will walk with you. And be there for others yourself.

The young king and the old king VERSES 13–16

13 Better a poor and wise young man
than an old and foolish king
who no longer knows how to accept a warning.
14 For he came out of prison to become king.
Yes, he was even born poor in his kingdom.
15 I saw all the living who walk under the sun,
that they were with the young man, the other one,
who took his place.
16 There was no end to all the people,
to all those over whom he was set.
And yet those who come later will not be glad about him.
Surely this too is vanity and a chasing after wind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A little story: An old king does not listen to anyone anymore. A poor young man, who was even in prison, becomes king in his place. Everyone cheers for him.

But his popularity does not last forever either. The next generation has already forgotten him.

Fame and popularity are fleeting. This too is "a chasing after wind."

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 5

Whoever loves money is never satisfied

Few words before God VERSES 1–7

1 Watch your steps when you go to God's house.
For coming near to listen is better
than giving the sacrifice of fools,
for they do not know that they are doing evil.
2 Don't be hasty with your mouth,
and don't let your heart rush to say anything before God,
for God is in heaven, and you are on earth.
So let your words be few.
3 For as a dream comes with many worries,
so a fool's speech comes with many words.
4 When you make a vow to God, don't delay in keeping it,
for he has no pleasure in fools.
Keep what you vow.
5 It is better not to make a vow
than to make a vow and not keep it.
6 Don't let your mouth lead you into sin.
Don't say before the messenger that it was a mistake.
Why should God be angry at your voice
and destroy the work of your hands?
7 For where there are many dreams, there are empty things,
and also where there are many words.
But you must fear God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: In worship, listening is more important than religious rituals without the heart.

Verse 2: "God is in heaven, and you are on earth. So let your words be few." God does not need long, beautiful prayers. Jesus says something similar (Matthew 6:7–8).

Verses 4–5: Keep what you promise God. Better not to promise anything at all than to break a promise.

Verse 6: "The messenger" is probably the priest before whom a vow was made. You should not try to talk your way out: "That was only a mistake."

Injustice in the state VERSES 8–9

8 If you see that the poor are oppressed in a district,
and justice and righteousness are taken away by force,
don't be surprised at the matter,
for one official is watched by a higher one,
and there are even higher officials over them.
9 Besides, the profit of the land is for all.
The king profits from the field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher describes soberly how things go in a big state: One official stands above another. Everyone wants a share. In the end, the poor suffer.

"Don't be surprised" does not mean "accept it." It means: Don't be shocked. That is how the world is. Other parts of

the Bible clearly call for standing up against such injustice (for example Amos 5:24).

Verse 9 is hard to understand in Hebrew. Maybe it means: Everyone lives from what the land produces, even the king.

Riches do not satisfy VERSES 10–17

10 Whoever loves silver will not be satisfied with silver,
and whoever loves abundance will not be satisfied with what he earns.
This too is vanity.
11 When possessions increase, those who eat them increase too.
And what good are they to the owner,
except that his eyes can feast on them?
12 The sleep of a worker is sweet,
whether he eats little or much,
but the abundance of the rich person does not let him sleep.
13 There is a terrible evil that I have seen under the sun:
riches kept by their owner to his own harm.
14 Those riches are lost through a misfortune,
and if he has a son,
there is nothing in his hand.
15 As he came out of his mother's womb,
so he will go again naked, as he came,
and he will take nothing for his hard work
that he could carry away in his hand.
16 This too is a terrible evil:
Exactly as he came, so he will go.
And what does he gain, he who works hard for the wind?
17 Also, all his days he eats in darkness.
He is full of frustration and has sickness and anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A timeless sentence: Whoever loves money never has enough. It is like drinking salt water: The more you drink, the thirstier you become.

Verse 11: Whoever has more also has more people around him who want to live from it.

Verse 12: A simple worker sleeps well. A rich person lies awake and worries about his money.

Verse 15: "So he will go again naked, as he came": We cannot take anything with us. Job (Job 1:21) and Paul (1 Timothy 6:7) say something similar. There is also a saying: Shrouds have no pockets.

Joy as a gift from God VERSES 18–20

18 This is what I have seen to be good and right:
that a person eats and drinks
and enjoys good things in all his hard work
that he works at under the sun,
all the days of his life that God has given him,
for this is his share.
19 And every person to whom God has given riches and wealth,
and to whom he has given the ability to eat of it,
to take his share and to be glad in his work,
that is the gift of God.
20 For he will not often think about the days of his life,
because God keeps him busy with the joy of his heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the Preacher's answer: Enjoy what God gives you. It is not money itself that makes you happy, but the ability to enjoy it thankfully. This ability too is a gift from God.

Verse 20: Whoever enjoys life does not keep brooding over how short it is. God fills his heart with joy.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 6

Who knows what is good for people?

Rich but not happy VERSES 1–6

1 There is an evil that I have seen under the sun,
and it lies heavily on people:
2 a person to whom God gives riches, wealth, and honor,
so that he lacks nothing of all that his soul desires,
and yet God does not give him the ability to eat of it,
but a stranger eats it.
This is vanity, and it is an evil sickness.
3 If a man has 100 children
and lives many years, so that the days of his years are many,
but his soul is not filled with good things,
and he does not even get a burial,
then I say: A stillborn child is better off than he is.
4 For it comes in vanity
and goes away in darkness,
and its name is covered with darkness.
5 Also, it has not seen the sun or known it.
It has more rest than the other.
6 Yes, even if he lived 1,000 years twice over
and yet could not enjoy good things,
don't all go to one place?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A sad picture: Someone has everything: money, honor, many children, a long life. But he cannot enjoy any of it. He dies unhappy and is not even properly buried.

Verses 3–5: The Preacher says: A child that is born dead is better off. At least it has rest. This is a very hard statement that is meant to show how terrible a life without joy is. It is no judgment about children who die before or at birth.

Parents who have lost a child can find help, for example, in support groups for bereaved parents. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

People are like a shadow VERSES 7–12

7 All of a person's hard work is for his mouth,
and yet his hunger is not satisfied.
8 For what advantage does the wise person have over the fool?

What does the poor person gain by knowing
how to behave before the living?
9 Better is what the eyes see
than the wandering of desire.
This too is vanity and a chasing after wind.
10 Whatever has been, its name was given long ago,
and it is known what a person is.
He cannot argue with the one who is stronger than he is.
11 For there are many words that increase vanity.
What good is that to a person?
12 For who knows what is good for a person in life,
all the days of his empty life, which he spends like a shadow?
For who can tell a person
what will be after him under the sun?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: We work in order to eat. But hunger comes back again and again. And the longing for more never stops.

Verse 9: "Better is what the eyes see": Enjoy what you have instead of always dreaming of more. That is contentment.

Verse 10: "The one who is stronger" is God. People cannot argue with him.

Verse 12: Our life is as short as a shadow. No one can tell us what comes afterward. These questions remain open. The book of Ecclesiastes lives with this tension.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 7

Better than ...

What is better? VERSES 1–6

1 A good name is better than fine perfume,
and the day of death better than the day of birth.
2 It is better to go to a house of mourning
than to go to a house of feasting,
for that is the end of all people,
and the living should take it to heart.
3 Sorrow is better than laughter,
for by a sad face the heart is made good.
4 The heart of the wise is in the house of mourning,
but the heart of fools is in the house of fun.
5 It is better to hear the correction of the wise
than for someone to hear the song of fools.
6 For like the crackling of thorns under a pot,
so is the laughter of the fool.
This too is vanity.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins a series of "better than" sayings.

Verse 1: In Hebrew, a play on words: "shem" (name) and "shemen" (oil). A good reputation is worth more than expensive perfume.

Verses 1–4: Surprising: Death and mourning are supposed to be better than birth and celebration? The Preacher means: Whoever goes to a funeral thinks about life. He becomes more serious and wiser. At a party, people don't think about it.

That does not mean that we should not celebrate. In other places, the Preacher praises joy. But whoever never thinks about death lives on the surface.

Verse 6: Thorns burn loudly and quickly, but they give little warmth. That is what the loud laughter of fools is like: a lot of noise about nothing.

Patience and wisdom VERSES 7–14

7 Surely taking money by force makes the wise person foolish,
and a bribe destroys understanding.
8 The end of a thing is better than its beginning.
The patient person is better than the proud person.
9 Don't be quick in your spirit to become angry,
for anger rests in the lap of fools.
10 Don't say, "Why were the former days better than these?"
For you do not ask this out of wisdom.
11 Wisdom is as good as an inheritance.
Yes, it is an advantage for those who see the sun.
12 For wisdom is a protection, just as money is a protection,
but the advantage of knowledge is
that wisdom keeps alive the one who has it.
13 Think about the work of God,
for who can make straight what he has made crooked?
14 On the day of good fortune, be joyful,
and on the day of misfortune, think:
Yes, God has put the one beside the other,
so that people cannot find out anything that comes after them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: You should not judge a thing before its end. Patience pays off.

Verse 9: Anger lives with fools. Whoever is wise does not get angry quickly.

Verse 10: "Why were the former days better than these?" People in every generation ask this. They mean: Everything was better in the past. The Preacher says: That is not a wise question. Every time has its good and its bad.

Verse 14: Wise advice: When things go well for you, be glad! When things go badly for you, think! Both good and hard days belong to life, and both come from God's hand.

Not too righteous, not too wicked VERSES 15–22

15 I have seen all this in my days of vanity:
There is a righteous person who perishes in his righteousness,
and there is a wicked person who lives long in his evil.
16 Don't be overly righteous,
and don't make yourself overly wise.
Why should you destroy yourself?
17 Don't be too wicked, and don't be a fool.
Why should you die before your time?

18 It is good that you hold on to the one thing.
Yes, and don't take your hand away from the other either,
for whoever fears God will come through it all.
19 Wisdom makes the wise person stronger
than 10 rulers who are in a city.
20 Surely there is not a righteous person on earth
who does good and does not sin.
21 Also, don't pay attention to every word that is spoken,
or you may hear your servant curse you,
22 for your own heart often knows
that you too have cursed others.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The Preacher looks honestly: Sometimes good people die young, and evil people live long. That does not fit the simple rule "Whoever is good does well."

Verses 16–17: Unusual advice: Don't be "overly righteous." This probably means: Don't be self-righteous and hard on yourself and others, as if you could earn everything by being religious. And of course, don't be wicked either.

Verse 18: Whoever fears God finds the right way between the extremes.

Verse 20: "There is not a righteous person on earth who does good and does not sin." Paul quotes this thought (Romans 3:10–12).

Verses 21–22: Wise advice: Don't listen to every bit of gossip about you. And remember: You too have already spoken badly about others.

What I looked for and did not find VERSES 23–29

23 I have tested all this with wisdom.
I said, "I will be wise,"
but it was far from me.
24 What exists is far away and very deep.
Who can find it out?
25 I turned, and my heart tried to know and to search out,
and to seek wisdom and the meaning of things,
and to know that wickedness is stupidity,
and that foolishness is madness.
26 I find more bitter than death the woman
whose heart is snares and traps,
and whose hands are chains.
Whoever pleases God will escape from her,
but the sinner will be caught by her.
27 "This is what I have found," says the Preacher,
"adding one thing to another to find an explanation,
28 which my soul is still looking for, but I have not found.
I have found one man among 1,000,
but I have not found a woman among all those.
29 This is the only thing I have found:
that God made people upright,
but they look for many schemes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–24: The Preacher admits: I wanted to become wise, but the truth is too deep for me.

Verse 26: Here he warns against a seductive woman, as Proverbs does (Proverbs 5 and 7). It is about a certain kind of woman, not about all women.

Verse 28: This verse sounds hostile to women and has often been misused that way. Many interpreters understand it like this: Among men too, the Preacher found almost no one who was really wise and upright, "one man among 1,000." He describes his personal, limited experience, probably from a royal court with many women who were not free partners. It is no judgment of God about women.

Other parts of the Bible praise many wise and good women, for example Ruth, Abigail, Deborah and the capable woman in Proverbs 31.

Verse 29: The most important result: God created people, man and woman, good and upright. But people have thought up many excuses and wrong ways. This is true for everyone alike.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 8

No one can find out God's work

People and the king VERSES 1–9

1 Who is like the wise person?
And who knows the meaning of a thing?
A person's wisdom makes his face shine,
and the hardness of his face is changed.
2 I say, "Keep the king's command!"
because of the oath before God.
3 Don't be in a hurry to leave his presence.
Don't stay with an evil thing,
for he does whatever he pleases,
4 for the king's word has power.
Who can say to him, "What are you doing?"
5 Whoever keeps the command will not come to harm,
and a wise heart will know the right time and the right way.
6 For there is a time and a way for every purpose,
even though a person's misery lies heavily on him.
7 For he does not know what will be.
For who can tell him how it will be?
8 No one has power over the spirit to hold back the spirit.
He also has no power over the day of death.
There is no release from service in war,
and wickedness will not save those who do it.
9 I have seen all this,
and I set my mind on every work that is done under the sun.
There is a time when one person has power over another to his harm.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Wisdom makes a face friendly. A wise person does not look hard, but shines.

Verses 2–5: A wise way of dealing with the powerful: be careful, take no hasty action. That does not mean that you have to obey every command, not even when it demands

something wrong. The Bible tells of people who obeyed God rather than kings (Daniel 3; Acts 5:29).

Verse 8: A sentence full of humility: No one can hold back the spirit, and no one can decide the day of his death. The Hebrew word for "spirit" can also mean "wind" or "breath." No one can hold back the wind either.

Verse 9: Power is often misused to harm others.

When punishment is slow to come VERSES 10–15

10 So I saw the wicked buried.
Yes, they even came from the holy place.
They went away and were forgotten in the city where they had done this.
This too is vanity.
11 Because the sentence against an evil deed is not carried out quickly,
the heart of people is fully set on doing evil.
12 Even if a sinner commits crimes 100 times and lives long,
yet I surely know that it will go better with those who fear God,
who have reverence before him.
13 But it will not go well with the wicked,
and he will not make his days longer like a shadow,
because he does not fear God.
14 There is a vanity that happens on the earth:
There are righteous people to whom things happen as if they had acted like the wicked.
And there are wicked people to whom things happen as if they had acted like the righteous.
I said that this too is vanity.
15 Then I praised joy,
for a person has nothing better under the sun
than to eat, to drink, and to be joyful.
For that will go with him in his hard work
all the days of his life that God has given him under the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: This sentence is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: Evil people, who even went in and out of the temple, received an honorable burial. Then people forgot what they had done.

Verse 11: When crimes are not punished quickly, people feel encouraged to keep doing evil. That is still true today for courts and society.

Verses 12–13: Still the Preacher believes: In the end, it will go well with those who fear God.

Verse 14: But he also sees the opposite: Good people do badly, evil people do well. He bears both side by side, without an easy answer.

Verse 15: His answer is again: Enjoy the life that God gives you.

God's work cannot be found out VERSES 16–17

16 When I set my heart on knowing wisdom
and on seeing the busy activity that happens on the earth
(even though the eyes see no sleep day or night),
17 then I saw all the work of God:
that people cannot find out the work that is done under the sun.
For however hard a person works to search it out, he will not find it.
Yes, even if a wise person thinks he can understand it, he will not be able to find it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Preacher has thought about it day and night. His result: No one can fully understand what God does, not even the wisest person.

This is not despair, but humility. We don't have to understand everything in order to trust God. Paul says: "No one can search out his judgments. No one can trace his ways" (Romans 11:33).

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 9

Eat your bread with joy

The same thing happens to everyone VERSES 1–6

1 For I took all this to heart, to search out all this:
that the righteous and the wise and their works are in God's hand.
Whether it is love or hatred, people do not know.
Everything lies before them.
2 Everything comes alike to all.
There is one fate for the righteous and the wicked,
for the good, for the clean and the unclean,
for the one who sacrifices and the one who does not sacrifice.
As it goes for the good, so it goes for the sinner,
for the one who takes an oath as for the one who is afraid of an oath.
3 This is an evil in all that is done under the sun,
that the same fate comes to all.
Yes, also the heart of people is full of evil,
and madness is in their heart while they live,
and after that they go to the dead.
4 For whoever is joined with all the living has hope,
for a living dog is better than a dead lion.
5 For the living know that they will die,
but the dead don't know anything,
and they have no more reward,
for the memory of them is forgotten.
6 Their love, their hatred, and their envy are also long gone,
and they will never again have a share
in anything that is done under the sun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: All people are in God's hand. But no one knows what the future will bring, love or hatred.

Verses 2–3: A hard thought: Death comes to everyone alike, good and evil people.

Verse 4: "A living dog is better than a dead lion." Back then, dogs were looked down on, and lions were admired. But life itself is precious. As long as you live, there is hope.

Verses 5–6: The Preacher looks at death soberly. He does not yet know about a resurrection. Later in the Bible, this hope grows (Daniel 12:2; 1 Corinthians 15). Christians believe that Jesus has defeated death.

Enjoy life VERSES 7–10

7 Go, eat your bread with joy,
and drink your wine with a glad heart,
for God has already accepted your works.
8 Let your clothes always be white,
and don't let your head lack oil.
9 Enjoy life with the wife whom you love
all the days of your life of vanity,
which he has given you under the sun,
all your days of vanity,
for that is your share in life
and in your hard work that you work at under the sun.
10 Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with all your strength,
for in Sheol (the world of the dead), where you are going,
there is no work, no plan, no knowledge, and no wisdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One of the most beautiful passages of the book: Because life is short, live it with joy!

Verse 7: "God has already accepted your works": You don't first have to earn God's goodwill. Enjoy life.

Verse 8: White clothes and oil on the head were signs of feasts and joy. Make every day a little bit of a feast.

Verse 9: Enjoy life with the person you love.

Verse 10: Whatever you do, do it with your whole heart. Don't put anything off. Time is limited.

Time and chance VERSES 11–12

11 I saw again under the sun
that the race is not won by the fast,
and the battle is not won by the strong,
and bread does not go to the wise,
and riches do not go to people of understanding,
and favor does not go to the skilled,
but time and chance happen to them all.
12 For people do not know their time either.
Like fish that are caught in a cruel net,
and like birds that are caught in a trap,
so people are trapped in an evil time,
when it falls on them suddenly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A very honest look: The best does not always win. Sometimes luck and chance decide. The fastest can stumble, the wisest can stay poor.

Verse 12: Misfortune often comes suddenly, like a net over a fish. No one can protect himself from it completely.

That is no reason to despair, but a reason to be humble. We do not have everything in our hands.

The poor wise man whom no one knows VERSES 13–18

13 I have also seen this wisdom under the sun,
and it seemed great to me:
14 There was a small city, and there were few men in it.
A great king came against it,
surrounded it, and built great siege works against it.
15 In it there was a poor, wise man,
and he saved the city by his wisdom.
Yet no one remembered that poor man.
16 Then I said, "Wisdom is better than strength."
But the poor man's wisdom is despised,
and no one listens to his words.
17 The words of the wise, heard in quiet,
are better than the shouting of someone who rules among fools.
18 Wisdom is better than weapons of war,
but one sinner destroys much good.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A little story: A poor, wise man saves his city from a mighty enemy. But afterward, everyone forgets him.

Verse 16: Wisdom is stronger than violence. But sadly, people often do not listen to the poor, even when they are wise.

Verse 17: Quiet, wise words are better than the loud shouting of a leader.

Verse 18: Wisdom is better than weapons. But a single person who does evil can destroy a lot of good.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 10

A little foolishness

Dead flies in the perfume VERSES 1–7

1 Dead flies make the perfumer's oil stink.
In the same way, a little foolishness outweighs wisdom and honor.
2 The heart of the wise is at his right hand,
but the heart of the fool is at his left.
3 Yes, even when the fool walks along the road,
his understanding fails him,
and he tells everyone that he is a fool.
4 If the anger of the ruler rises against you,
don't leave your place,
for calmness puts great wrongs to rest.
5 There is an evil that I have seen under the sun,
a kind of mistake that comes from the ruler:
6 Foolishness is set in high places of honor,
and the rich sit in low places.
7 I have seen servants on horses,
and princes walking on the ground like servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A well-known picture: Even one dead fly can spoil an expensive perfume. In the same way, even a small foolish act can destroy a good reputation.

Verse 2: Back then, "right" stood for what is good and skillful, "left" for what is clumsy. This is a picture from the language, not a judgment about left-handed people.

Verse 3: A fool gives himself away as soon as he goes out into the street.

Verse 4: When your boss is angry with you, don't run away. Stay calm. Calmness can settle a lot of trouble.

Verses 6–7: Sometimes the world is upside down: People who are not capable get high positions, and capable people are passed over.

Every job has its danger VERSES 8–11

8 Whoever digs a pit may fall into it,
and whoever breaks through a wall may be bitten by a snake.
9 Whoever cuts stones may be hurt by them.
Whoever splits wood may be put in danger by it.
10 If the ax is dull and you don't sharpen the edge,
then you must use more strength,
but skill brings success.
11 If the snake bites before it is charmed,
the snake charmer's tongue is of no use.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every job has its risks. You have to be careful.

Verse 10: Practical advice: First sharpen the ax! Whoever prepares wisely saves a lot of strength. Wisdom makes work easier.

Verse 11: Whoever comes too late gets no use from his skill. The right moment matters.

The words of the fool VERSES 12–15

12 The words from the mouth of the wise are gracious,
but the fool is swallowed up by his own lips.
13 The beginning of the words of his mouth is foolishness,
and the end of his talk is wicked madness.
14 The fool also makes many words.
People do not know what will be.
And what will be after him, who can tell him?
15 The hard work of fools makes every one of them tired,
for he does not even know how to get to the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fool talks a lot, but nothing good comes of it. He talks about the future as if he knew it.

Verse 15: A funny sentence: The fool is so unable that he cannot even find the way to the city. He works hard and gets nowhere.

Good and bad rulers VERSES 16–20

16 How terrible for you, land, when your king is a child
and your princes feast in the morning!
17 Happy are you, land, when your king is the son of nobles
and your princes eat at the right time,
to gain strength and not to get drunk!
18 Through laziness the roof sinks in,
and through idle hands the house leaks.
19 A feast is made for laughter,
and wine makes life glad,
and money is the answer for everything.
20 Don't curse the king, not even in your thoughts,
and don't curse the rich in your bedroom,
for a bird of the sky may carry your voice,
and something with wings may tell the matter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: A land suffers when its leaders are immature and only party. A land is happy when its leaders act responsibly.

Verse 18: Whoever does not take care of his house will soon have rain coming through the roof. That is true for a state too.

Verse 19: An ironic sentence: Some people think money solves all problems. The Preacher describes this attitude. He does not praise it.

Verse 20: People say: A little bird told me. This saying reminds us of this verse. Be careful about what you say about the powerful. It can come out. Today this is especially true for messages and posts on the internet.

ECCLESIASTES

CHAPTER 11

Throw your bread on the water

Dare to do something! VERSES 1–6

1 Throw your bread on the waters,
for after many days you will find it again.
2 Give a share to seven, yes, even to eight,
for you don't know what disaster will come on the earth.
3 When the clouds are full of rain,
they empty themselves on the earth.
And when a tree falls toward the south or toward the north,
it stays in the place where the tree fell.
4 Whoever watches the wind will not sow,
and whoever looks at the clouds will not harvest.
5 Just as you don't know which way the wind goes,
or how the bones grow in the womb of a pregnant woman,
so you also don't know the work of God, who does everything.
6 In the morning, sow your seed,
and in the evening, don't let your hand rest,
for you don't know which will succeed, this or that,
or whether both will be equally good.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Throw your bread on the waters": A puzzling picture. Many understand it as a call to be generous: Give without expecting something back right away. It will come back to you later. Others think of trade by sea: Dare to do something, send your goods across the sea.

Verse 2: Share with many, for you don't know when you yourself will need help. Or: Spread out your risk.

Verse 4: Whoever always waits for perfect weather never sows and never harvests. Whoever wants to make everything safe does nothing in the end.

Verse 5: We don't even understand how a child grows in its mother's womb. How could we understand everything God does?

Verse 6: So: Do what you can, morning and evening. What comes of it is in God's hand.

Enjoy your youth VERSES 7–10

7 Truly, the light is sweet,
and it is pleasant for the eyes to see the sun.
8 Yes, if a person lives many years,
let him be glad in all of them,
but let him remember the days of darkness,
for there will be many.
All that comes is vanity.
9 Be glad, young man, in your youth,
and let your heart make you cheerful in the days of your youth.
Walk in the ways of your heart
and after what your eyes see.
But know that for all these things God will bring you to judgment.
10 So remove sorrow from your heart,
and keep evil away from your body,
for youth and the dawn of life are vanity.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: A beautiful, simple sentence: The light is sweet. It is good to see the sun. Life is a gift.

Verse 8: Be glad in every year. But don't forget: Dark days will come too, old age and death.

Verse 9: An encouragement to young people: Enjoy your youth! Follow your heart! But remember: You are responsible to God for what you do. Freedom and responsibility belong together.

Verse 10: Youth passes quickly, like the dawn. So: Don't let worries steal your joy.

ECCLESIASTES

Chapter 12

Remember your Creator

Before the evil days come VERSES 1–8

1 Remember your Creator while you are young.
Remember him before the bad days come.
Remember him before the years come when you will say,
"I don't enjoy them anymore."
2 Remember him before the sun, the light, the moon,
and the stars grow dark,
and the clouds come back after the rain.
3 Then the keepers of the house will tremble.
The strong men will bend over.
The women who grind grain will stop, because there are only a few left.
Those who look out of the windows will see only darkness.
4 The doors to the street will be shut.
The sound of the grinding will be quiet.
People will get up when a bird starts to sing.
All the songs will become soft.
5 People will be afraid of high places.
They will be afraid of dangers on the road.
The almond tree will blossom.
The grasshopper will be a heavy load.
Desire will be gone.
For people go to their eternal home,
and the mourners walk around in the streets.
6 Remember him before the silver cord is cut,
or the golden bowl is broken,
or the jar is broken at the spring,
or the wheel is broken at the well.
7 Then the dust goes back to the earth, where it came from.
And the spirit goes back to God, who gave it.
8 "Vanity of vanities," says the Preacher.
"All is vanity!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Remember your Creator while you are young." That means: Think of him now. Don't wait until you are old and sick.

Verses 2–6 are a great poem about growing old. The pictures are very poetic. Many interpreters explain them like this:

The "keepers of the house" who tremble are the hands. The "strong men" who bend over are the legs. The women grinding grain who become few are the teeth. "Those who look out of the windows" and grow dark are the eyes. The low sound of the grinding is poor hearing. You wake up early, as soon as a bird sings. You are afraid of heights and of falling. The white blossoming almond tree is white hair. Even a small grasshopper becomes a burden.

Verse 6: Then the "silver cord" on which the golden lamp hangs is cut. The jar at the well breaks. These are pictures for death: Life breaks like a precious vessel.

Verse 7: The body becomes dust again, and the spirit, the breath of life, returns to God who gave it (compare Genesis 2:7).

Verse 8: The book ends as it began: "All is vanity," everything is a breath.

Old age also has its dignity and beauty. This text does not want to make old age look bad, but to encourage us to use our time well and to seek God early.

The final word VERSES 9–14

9 The Preacher was wise.
So he also taught the people what he knew.
He thought about many proverbs.
He studied them and put them in order.
10 The Preacher tried to find the right words.
He wrote honestly, and he wrote words of truth.
11 The words of the wise are like goads.
A goad is a pointed stick used to drive cattle.
The words of the teachers of the assemblies are like
nails that are driven in firmly.
They are given by one shepherd.
12 My son, be warned:
There is no end to making many books,
and much study makes the body tired.
13 This is the end of the matter. Everything has been
heard.
Fear God and keep his commandments.
That is what every person must do.
14 God will judge everything people do,
even everything that is hidden,
whether it is good or evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–12: Here someone speaks about the Preacher, perhaps a student. He praises him: He was wise, he searched and collected proverbs.

Verse 11: The words of the wise are like goads, pointed sticks used to drive cattle. They poke us and get us moving. And they hold firm like nails. The "one shepherd" is probably God himself, from whom all true wisdom comes.

Verse 12: A sentence that makes many students smile: "There is no end to making many books, and much study makes the body tired."

Verses 13–14 are the end of the whole book: "Fear God and keep his commandments." After all the questions and doubts, the most important thing remains: Take God seriously and live by his will. And: God sees everything, even what is hidden.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Ecclesiastes?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An honest book: The Preacher looks very closely at life "under the sun." He makes nothing look better than it is. He sees injustice, death, things passing away, and chance.

Everything is a breath: His key word "hevel" means breath or a puff of wind. Riches, success, wisdom, pleasure: None of it lasts. Everything disappears like breath on a cold day.

The great experiment: He tried everything: knowledge, pleasure, possessions, work. Nothing gave him the meaning of life.

And yet: joy! Again and again he says: Eat your bread with joy, drink your wine, enjoy life with the people you love. That is a gift of God (2:24; 3:13; 5:18; 9:7–9).

There is a time for everything: Life has rhythms. Wisdom means seeing what is right for now (Chapter 3).

Eternity in the heart: God has put a longing for eternity in our hearts. That is why nothing that passes away can fully satisfy us (3:11).

Questions without answers: The Preacher asks what comes after death and finds no sure answer. The Bible leaves these questions open. Later books give more hope. Christians believe in the resurrection through Jesus Christ.

The end: "Fear God and keep his commandments" (12:13). When everything passes away, God remains.

Who is this book for? For all who doubt, ask questions, and search. It shows: These thoughts too have a place in the Bible. In Judaism, it is read at the Feast of Booths, the most joyful feast of the year.

What comes next? Next comes the Song of Songs, a book full of love poems between a woman and a man. It celebrates love as a gift of God.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 22 OF 66

SONG OF SONGS

8 CHAPTERS

SONG OF SONGS

Chapter 1

Your love is better than wine

Before we begin: What is the Song of Songs?

In Hebrew, the Song of Songs is called "Shir ha-Shirim," "the Song of Songs." That means: the most beautiful of all songs.

It is a collection of love poems. A young woman and a young man speak to each other full of longing. They praise each other's beauty, they look for each other, they find each other. Sometimes a choir speaks too, the "daughters of Jerusalem" or the "friends."

The language is full of pictures: gardens, vineyards, gazelles, doves, spices, fruit. Love is also described in a bodily way, tenderly and poetically.

The name of God does not clearly appear anywhere in the whole book. Even so, it belongs to the Bible.

There are two main ways to understand the Song of Songs:

– Literally: It is a praise of love between a woman and a man. Love is a gift from God, beautiful and strong.

– As a picture: In Judaism, people see in it the love between God and his people Israel. It is read at the Passover festival. Christians have also seen in it the love between Christ and the church, or the individual soul.

Both ways of understanding do not exclude each other.

Our English source text has small notes showing who is speaking: "Beloved" (the woman), "Lover" (the man), "Friends." This edition keeps them.

The book is said to be by Solomon. Whether he wrote it himself is uncertain.

Longing for the one she loves VERSES 1–4

1 The Song of Songs, which is Solomon's.
2 Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth,
for your love is better than wine.
3 Your oils have a pleasing scent.
Your name is like oil poured out.
That is why the young women love you.
4 Take me with you! Let's hurry!
The king has brought me into his rooms.
Friends: We will be glad and rejoice in you.
We will praise your love more than wine!
Beloved: They are right to love you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book begins in the middle of longing: The young woman wishes for the kisses of the one she loves.

Verse 3: Scented oil was precious. The "name" stands for the whole person. Even his name is like a wonderful scent to her.

Verse 4: Different voices speak here: the woman, then the friends, then the woman again. Our English source text marks this.

"The king": In love poems, the man who is loved is often called "king." For her, he is the most important person.

Dark, but lovely VERSES 5–8

5 I am dark, but lovely, you daughters of Jerusalem,
like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Solomon.
6 Don't stare at me because I am dark,
because the sun has burned me.
My mother's sons were angry with me.
They made me keeper of the vineyards.
My own vineyard I have not kept.
7 Tell me, you whom my soul loves,
where you graze your flock,
where you let them rest at noon.
For why should I be like a woman wearing a veil
beside the flocks of your companions?
8 If you don't know, most beautiful among women,
then follow the tracks of the sheep,
and graze your young goats beside the shepherds'
tents.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: The woman is tanned by the sun because she had to work outside in the vineyard. Back then, light skin was thought beautiful in upper-class women. But she says with confidence: "I am dark, but lovely!" The tents of Kedar were woven from black goat hair.

This is a strong sentence against prejudice: Beauty does not depend on the color of your skin.

"My own vineyard I have not kept": She had no time for herself. In the Song of Songs, the "vineyard" often stands for the woman herself.

Verses 7–8: She is looking for the one she loves, a shepherd. "Like a woman wearing a veil": She does not want to wander around searching among strange shepherds.

How beautiful you are VERSES 9–17

9 I compare you, my love,
to a horse among Pharaoh's chariots.
10 Your cheeks are beautiful with earrings,
your neck with strings of jewels.
11 We will make you earrings of gold
with studs of silver.
12 While the king sat at his table,
my perfume spread its scent.
13 My beloved is to me a little bag of myrrh
that lies between my breasts.
14 My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms
from the vineyards of En Gedi.
15 How beautiful you are, my love!
How beautiful you are!
Your eyes are like doves.
16 How beautiful you are, my beloved, yes, delightful!
And our bed is green.
17 The beams of our house are cedars,
our rafters are firs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: A comparison that seems strange to us: Pharaoh's horses were the most beautiful and splendid ones, hung with jewelry. He means: You are wonderfully beautiful and stand out.

Verse 13: Women wore little bags of scented myrrh around their necks. That is how close and how precious the one she loves is to her.

Verse 14: En Gedi is a green oasis by the Dead Sea, in the middle of the desert.

Verses 15–16: Both say to each other: "How beautiful you are!" Their love goes both ways.

Verses 16–17: Their "house" is nature: The green grass is their bed, the trees are their roof.

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 2

The winter is past

A lily among thorns VERSES 1–7

1 I am a rose of Sharon,
a lily of the valleys.
2 Like a lily among thorns,
so is my love among the young women.
3 Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest,
so is my beloved among the young men.
I sat down in his shade.
I was full of joy.
His fruit tasted sweet to me.
4 He brought me to the banquet hall.
His banner over me is love.
5 Give me raisins to make me strong.
Give me apples to refresh me.
I am weak with love.
6 His left hand is under my head.
His right hand holds me close.
7 I make you promise, daughters of Jerusalem,
by the gazelles or by the female deer of the field,
that you do not stir up or awaken love
until it is ready.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The woman humbly calls herself a simple flower, one of many on the plain of Sharon.

Verse 2: He answers: To me you are like a lily among nothing but thorns. No one is like you.

Verse 3: She answers: And you are like an apple tree in the middle of the forest, giving shade and sweet fruit.

Verse 4: "His banner over me is love": A banner shows whom you belong to. His love is like a flag over her.

Verse 5: "Weak with love": Anyone who has been in love knows the feeling.

Verse 7: A sentence that appears three times in the book: Don't awaken love too early! Love needs its time. You should not force it.

Get up, my love VERSES 8–17

8 Listen! It is my beloved!
Look, he is coming!
He leaps over the mountains.
He jumps over the hills.
9 My beloved is like a gazelle or a young deer.
Look, he is standing behind our wall!
He looks in through the windows.
He peeks through the lattice.
10 My beloved spoke to me.
He said, "Get up, my love, my beautiful one.
Come away with me!
11 Look, the winter is over.
The rain has stopped and is gone.
12 Flowers are showing up all over the land.
The time of singing has come.
You can hear the turtledove in our land.
13 The fig tree is ripening its green figs.
The grapevines are blooming.
They smell sweet.
Get up, my love, my beautiful one.
Come away with me!"
14 My dove, you are hiding in the cracks of the rock,
in the hiding places on the mountainside.
Let me see your face.
Let me hear your voice.
Your voice is sweet, and your face is lovely.
15 Catch the foxes for us,
the little foxes that ruin the vineyards.
Our vineyards are in bloom.
16 My beloved is mine, and I am his.
He feeds among the lilies.
17 Until the day cools down and the shadows run away,
turn around, my beloved.
Be like a gazelle or a young deer
on the mountains of Bether.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–9: The man she loves comes leaping with joy like a young gazelle. Impatiently, he looks through the window. A lattice is a window screen made of crossed wooden strips.

Verses 10–13: One of the most beautiful spring poems in the world: The winter is past, the flowers are blooming, the birds are singing. Come with me! Love is like a new spring.

Verse 15: Little foxes eat the young grapes. Perhaps this means: Small troubles can ruin a young love. Watch out for them!

Verse 16: "My beloved is mine, and I am his": This sentence is often engraved in wedding rings. It expresses that they belong to each other.

Verse 17: "On the mountains of Bether": The name is uncertain, perhaps "rugged mountains."

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 3

I looked for the one my soul loves

Searching at night VERSES 1–5

1 At night on my bed,
I looked for the one my soul loves.
I looked for him, but I did not find him.
2 I will get up now and go around the city.
In the streets and in the squares I will look for
the one my soul loves.
I looked for him, but I did not find him.
3 The watchmen who go around the city found me.
"Have you seen the one my soul loves?"
4 I had hardly passed them
when I found the one my soul loves.
I held him and would not let him go
until I had brought him into my mother's house,
into the room of the woman who conceived me.
5 I make you promise, daughters of Jerusalem,
by the gazelles or by the female deer of the field,
that you do not stir up or awaken love
until it is ready.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The young woman cannot sleep. She longs for the one she loves. In the middle of the night, she looks for him all over the city.

Four times she says: "the one my soul loves." Her love is very deep.

Verse 4: When she finds him, she holds on to him and does not let him go.

Many people have also read these verses as a picture of the search for God: You search and search, and then you find him and don't want to let him go.

Solomon's wedding procession VERSES 6–11

6 Who is this coming up from the wilderness
like columns of smoke,
scented with myrrh and frankincense,
with all the spices of the merchant?
7 Look, it is Solomon's carriage!
60 mighty men are around it,
from the mighty men of Israel.
8 They all carry the sword
and are experienced in war.
Each one has his sword at his side
because of the terrors of the night.
9 King Solomon made himself a carriage
from the wood of Lebanon.
10 He made its posts of silver,
its floor of gold,
its seat of purple cloth.
Its inside is lovingly decorated
by the daughters of Jerusalem.
11 Go out, you daughters of Zion,
and see King Solomon
with the crown with which his mother crowned him
on the day of his wedding,
on the day of the joy of his heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A splendid wedding procession is coming: Solomon's carriage, a seat carried by people, made of precious wood, silver, gold and purple, surrounded by 60 bodyguards. A cloud of scent from frankincense and myrrh goes ahead of it.

Verse 10: "Lovingly decorated": The women of Jerusalem have decorated the inside with love.

Verse 11: On his wedding day, the groom wears a crown. This is still a custom at some weddings in the Middle East today. The wedding day is "the day of the joy of his heart."

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 4

You are all beautiful, my love

A song about her beauty VERSES 1–7

1 How beautiful you are, my love!
How beautiful you are!
Your eyes behind your veil are like doves.
Your hair is like a flock of goats
coming down Mount Gilead.
2 Your teeth are like a flock of sheep that were just
sheared.
They come up from being washed.
Each one has a twin.
Not one of them is missing.
3 Your lips are like a red thread.
Your mouth is lovely.
Your temples are like a piece of a pomegranate
behind your veil.
4 Your neck is like the tower of David.
It was built to store weapons.
1,000 shields hang on it.
They are all shields of mighty warriors.
5 Your two breasts are like two fawns,
twins of a gazelle.
They feed among the lilies.
6 Until the day cools down and the shadows run away,
I will go to the mountain of myrrh,
to the hill of frankincense.
7 You are beautiful in every way, my love.
There is no flaw in you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The man describes the beauty of the woman he loves from head to toe. In Arabic, such songs are called "wasf," a song of description. The pictures sound strange to us, but back then they were very beautiful:

Her black hair flows like a flock of black goats moving down a mountain. Her teeth are white like freshly washed sheep,

and complete, none is missing. Her neck is slim and proud like a tower, decorated with necklaces as if with shields.

Verse 3: The temples are the sides of the forehead.

Verse 6: Myrrh and frankincense are sweet-smelling spices.

Verse 7: "You are beautiful in every way, my love. There is no flaw in you." That is how love sees the other person. Christians have also applied this verse to the church, which Christ loves (Ephesians 5:27).

My sister, my bride VERSES 8–11

8 Come with me from Lebanon, my bride.
Come with me from Lebanon.
Look down from the top of Amana,
from the top of Senir and Hermon,
from the dens of the lions,
from the mountains of the leopards.
9 You have stolen my heart, my sister, my bride.
You have stolen my heart with one look from your eyes,
with one chain of your necklace.
10 Your love is so beautiful, my sister, my bride!
Your love is much better than wine.
Your perfume smells better than all kinds of spices!
11 My bride, your lips drip like a honeycomb.
Honey and milk are under your tongue.
Your clothes smell like Lebanon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: The high mountains in the north with wild animals are a picture that she seems far away and out of reach to him. He calls her to come to him.

Verse 9: "My sister, my bride": In the ancient Middle East, "sister" was a tender pet name for the woman one loved. It does not mean that they are related. It expresses great closeness and trust.

A single glance from her has stolen his heart.

Verse 11: Honey and milk remind us of the promised land, the land flowing with milk and honey. For him, she is like a paradise.

A locked garden VERSES 12–16

12 My sister, my bride, is a garden that is locked.
She is a locked spring, a sealed fountain.
13 Your shoots are an orchard of pomegranates,
with precious fruits,
with henna and nard plants,
14 nard and saffron,
calamus and cinnamon,
with every kind of incense tree,
myrrh and aloes,
and all the best spices.
15 You are a fountain for the gardens,
a well of fresh, flowing water,
streams that flow down from Lebanon.
16 Wake up, north wind!
Come, south wind!
Blow on my garden,
so that its sweet smells spread out.
Let my beloved come into his garden.
Let him taste his precious fruits.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The woman he loves is like a garden with a wall around it. Not everyone may go in. This is a tender picture that she is keeping herself for the one she loves.

Verses 13–14: Henna, nard, saffron, calamus, cinnamon, myrrh and aloes are plants that smell sweet.

Verses 13–15: The garden is full of precious plants and spices from all over the world. It even has its own spring. A paradise.

Verse 16: Now the woman answers: She invites the one she loves to come into "his" garden. She opens herself to him of her own free will. Love goes both ways and is freely given.

The Song of Songs speaks tenderly and openly about bodily love as something beautiful that God has given.

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 5

This is my beloved

In the garden VERSE 1

1 I have come into my garden, my sister, my bride.
I have gathered my myrrh and my spice.
I have eaten my honeycomb and my honey.
I have drunk my wine and my milk.
Friends: Eat, friends!
Drink! Yes, drink all you want, you who love each other!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The man she loves has accepted the invitation in 4:16. He has come into "his garden." This is a tender picture for the fulfillment of their love.

The friends are happy with the couple and wish that they may enjoy their love to the full.

He knocks, and then he is gone VERSES 2–8

2 I was asleep, but my heart was awake.
Listen! My beloved is knocking.
He says, "Open the door for me, my sister, my love,
my dove, my perfect one!
My head is wet with dew.
My hair is wet from the damp night."
3 I have already taken off my robe.
Do I really have to put it on again?
I have already washed my feet.
Do I really have to get them dirty again?
4 My beloved pushed his hand in through the opening by the latch.
My heart pounded for him.
5 I got up to open the door for my beloved.
My hands dripped with myrrh.
My fingers dripped with liquid myrrh
onto the handles of the lock.

6 I opened the door for my beloved.
But my beloved had left.
He was gone.
My heart sank when he spoke.
I looked for him, but I did not find him.
I called him, but he did not answer.
7 The watchmen who walk around the city found me.
They beat me.
They hurt me and left bruises.
The guards on the walls took my cloak away from me.
8 Daughters of Jerusalem, I make you promise:
If you find my beloved,
tell him that I am weak with love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A scene like a dream: She is already asleep when he knocks. She hesitates for a moment: "I'm already in bed!" When she then opens the door, he is gone.

Many people know this: You hesitate a moment too long and miss a chance. Afterward the longing is all the greater.

Verse 5: Myrrh is a sweet-smelling oil.

Verse 7: The watchmen treat her brutally when she is out alone at night. That is wrong. No one may use violence against a woman, no matter when and where she is out.

If you experience violence: US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

What is your beloved like? VERSES 9–16

9 Most beautiful of women,
how is your beloved better than any other?
How is your beloved better than any other,
that you make us promise this?
10 My beloved is fair and ruddy.
He is the best of 10,000.
11 His head is like the purest gold.
His hair is thick and wavy.
It is black like a raven.
12 His eyes are like doves by streams of water.
They are washed in milk.
They are set like jewels.
13 His cheeks are like a bed of spices.
They are like towers of perfume.
His lips are like lilies.
Liquid myrrh drips from them.
14 His hands are like rings of gold
set with beryl stones.
His body is like a work of ivory
covered with sapphires.
15 His legs are like pillars of marble.
They stand on bases of pure gold.
He looks like Lebanon.
He is as fine as the cedar trees.
16 His mouth is sweet.
Yes, everything about him is lovely.
This is my beloved, and this is my friend,
daughters of Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The women ask: What is so special about the one you love?

Now the woman describes the one she loves from head to toe, just as he described her in chapter 4. For her, he is like a precious statue of gold, ivory and jewels.

Verse 10: Ruddy means: with a healthy, reddish color.

Verse 14: Beryl is a shining jewel. No one knows for sure exactly which stones are meant in Hebrew.

Verse 16: The most beautiful part: "This is my beloved, and this is my friend." He is not only her lover, but also her friend. Love and friendship belong together.

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 6

I belong to my beloved

Where is your beloved? VERSES 1–3

1 Where has your beloved gone,
most beautiful among women?
Which way has your beloved turned,
so that we may look for him with you?
2 My beloved has gone down to his garden,
to the beds of spices,
to graze his flock in the gardens
and to gather lilies.
3 I belong to my beloved, and my beloved belongs to me.
He grazes among the lilies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The women offer to help her search. But the woman now knows where he is: in "his garden," that is, with her.

Verse 3: As in chapter 2:16, but the other way around: "I belong to my beloved, and my beloved belongs to me." This sentence is often engraved in wedding rings, in Hebrew "Ani le-dodi ve-dodi li."

One of a kind VERSES 4–10

4 You are beautiful, my love, like Tirzah,
lovely like Jerusalem,
awe-inspiring like an army with banners.
5 Turn your eyes away from me,
for they have overwhelmed me.
Your hair is like a flock of goats
lying along the slopes of Gilead.
6 Your teeth are like a flock of ewes
coming up from the washing.
Each of them has twins,
and none of them has lost its young.
7 Your temples are like a piece of a pomegranate
behind your veil.
8 There are 60 queens, 80 concubines,
and young women without number.
9 My dove, my perfect one, is one of a kind.
She is her mother's only daughter.
She is the favorite of the woman who gave birth to her.

The daughters saw her and called her blessed.
The queens and the concubines saw her and praised her.
10 Who is she who looks down like the morning,
beautiful as the moon, clear as the sun,
awe-inspiring like an army with banners?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Tirzah and Jerusalem were two splendid capital cities. That is how beautiful she is. And as impressive as an army with flags: Her beauty has power.

Verse 5: One glance from her overwhelms him.

Verses 5–7 repeat chapter 4:1–3 almost word for word. His love does not change.

Verses 8–9: A king may have many wives. But for him there is only one: her. True love sees something one of a kind in the other person.

Verse 10: She shines like the dawn, the moon and the sun.

In the nut grove VERSES 11–13

11 I went down to the nut grove
to see the green plants of the valley,
to see whether the vine had budded
and whether the pomegranates were in flower.
12 Before I knew it,
my desire set me among the chariots of my noble people.
13 Come back, come back, Shulammite!
Come back, come back, so that we may look at you!
Lover: Why do you want to look at the Shulammite as at the dance of Mahanaim?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: In spring, she goes into the garden to see whether everything is in bloom. A picture of love that is waking up.

Verse 12 is one of the hardest verses in Hebrew. No one knows exactly what it means. Perhaps: Her longing carries her away like a fast chariot.

Verse 13: Here the woman is named for the first time: "Shulammite." Perhaps this means "the woman from Shunem" or "the peaceful one," similar to the name Solomon (both are connected with "shalom," peace).

The people call out: Turn around, we want to see you! The man she loves asks: Why are you staring at her as at a dance? "Mahanaim" is a place name and means "two camps." What exactly this dance was is unknown.

In some Bibles, and in the Hebrew text, verse 13 is the first verse of chapter 7 (7:1).

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 7

Come, my beloved

How beautiful you are VERSES 1–9

1 Prince's daughter, your feet in sandals are so beautiful!
Your rounded thighs are like jewels.
A skilled artist made them.
2 Your body is like a round bowl.
It is never without mixed wine.
Your waist is like a heap of wheat
with lilies all around it.
3 Your two breasts are like two fawns,
twins of a gazelle.
4 Your neck is like a tower of ivory.
Your eyes are like the pools in Heshbon
by the gate of Bathrabbim.
Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon
that looks toward Damascus.
5 Your head is like Mount Carmel.
The hair on your head is like purple cloth.
The king is held captive in its locks.
6 You are so beautiful and so pleasant,
my love, with all your delights!
7 You are tall like a palm tree.
Your breasts are like its fruit.
8 I said, "I will climb up the palm tree.
I will take hold of its fruit."
Let your breasts be like bunches of grapes on the vine.
Let your breath smell like apples.
9 Your mouth is like the best wine.
It goes down smoothly for my beloved.
It glides over the lips of those who are asleep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again a song of description, this time from the feet to the head. Perhaps the woman is dancing, and the man admires her.

The pictures come from nature and from the landscape: pools, towers, Mount Carmel, a palm tree. To us, "your nose is like a tower" sounds strange. Back then it meant: proud, noble, upright.

Verse 5: "The king is held captive in its locks": This means the locks of her hair. A loving sentence. He is completely enchanted by her.

The Song of Songs speaks openly and tenderly about the beauty of the body and about bodily love. The Bible does not see the body as dirty, but as God's good creation.

Let's go out into the field VERSES 10–13

10 I belong to my beloved.
His desire is for me.
11 Come, my beloved!
Let's go out into the field.
Let's spend the night in the villages.
12 Let's get up early and go to the vineyards.
Let's see if the vines have buds,
if their blossoms have opened,
and if the pomegranate trees are in bloom.
There I will give you my love.
13 The mandrakes give off their sweet smell.
At our doors are all kinds of precious fruits,
new and old.
I have saved them for you, my beloved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "His desire is for me." A remarkable sentence: In Genesis 3:16, after the fall into sin, it says that the woman's desire will be for the man, and he will rule over her. Here it is the other way around, and there is no talk of ruling. In the Song of Songs, love is equal and goes both ways, as in paradise.

Verses 11–12: The woman takes the first step. She invites him to go out into nature with her.

Verse 13: Mandrakes are plants with a strong smell. They were thought to be plants that encourage love (compare Genesis 30:14–16).

In some Bibles, and in the Hebrew text, the verses of this chapter are shifted by one, because 6:13 is 7:1 there.

SONG OF SONGS

CHAPTER 8

Love is as strong as death

If only you were my brother VERSES 1–4

1 Oh, if only you were like my brother,
who nursed at my mother's breasts!
If I found you outside, I would kiss you,
yes, and no one would look down on me.
2 I would lead you and bring you into my mother's house,
who would teach me.
I would give you spiced wine to drink,
the juice of my pomegranate.
3 His left hand would be under my head,
and his right hand would embrace me.
4 I make you promise, daughters of Jerusalem,
that you do not stir up or awaken love
until it is ready.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Back then, a couple was not allowed to show their love in public. But brothers and sisters were allowed to kiss in the street. So she wishes: If only you were my brother, then I could kiss you anywhere!

Verse 4: For the third and last time, the warning: Don't awaken love before it is ready by itself.

Love is as strong as death VERSES 5–7

5 Who is this coming up from the wilderness,
leaning on her beloved?
Beloved: Under the apple tree I awakened you.
There your mother conceived you.
There she was in labor and gave birth to you.
6 Put me like a seal on your heart,
like a seal on your arm,
for love is as strong as death.
Its jealous passion is as cruel as Sheol (the world of the dead).
Its flames are flames of fire,
a flame of Yah.
7 Many waters cannot put out love,
and rivers cannot drown it.
If someone gave all the wealth of his house for love,
he would only be scorned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: The couple comes out of the wilderness together. She leans on him. Under the apple tree, where life begins, she awakened his love.

Verses 6–7 are the high point of the whole book and one of the most beautiful texts about love there is. It is often read at weddings.

"Put me like a seal on your heart": A seal was worn on a cord over the heart or as a ring. It was very personal and precious. She wants to belong to him forever.

"Love is as strong as death": Death defeats everyone. But love is just as strong.

"A flame of Yah": Here we find the short form of God's name, the only time in the whole book. Love is a fire that comes from God.

Verse 7: No water can put out this fire. And love cannot be bought. Whoever tries makes a fool of himself.

Christians also think here of God's love, which is stronger than death (Romans 8:38–39; 1 Corinthians 13).

Our little sister VERSES 8–10

8 We have a little sister.
She has no breasts yet.
What shall we do for our sister
on the day when someone asks to marry her?
9 If she is a wall,
we will build a tower of silver on her.
If she is a door,
we will close her in with boards of cedar.
10 I am a wall, and my breasts are like towers.
Then I was in his eyes like one who finds peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–9: The brothers talk about their little sister. They want to protect her until she is old enough to marry. "Wall" and "door" are pictures of whether she closes herself off or opens up.

Verse 10: The woman answers with confidence: I am grown up now. I decide for myself. And I have found peace with the one I love. In Hebrew, this is a play on words: "shalom" (peace), "Shulammite" and "Solomon."

Young people need protection. But adults may decide for themselves about their love.

My own vineyard VERSES 11–14

11 Solomon had a vineyard at Baal Hamon.
He rented out the vineyard to keepers.
Each was to bring 1,000 shekels of silver (about 25 pounds) for its fruit.
12 My own vineyard is before me.
The 1,000 are for you, Solomon,
and 200 for those who tend its fruit.
13 You who live in the gardens,
the friends are listening.
Let me hear your voice!

14 Hurry, my beloved,
and be like a gazelle or a young deer
on the mountains of spices!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: Solomon has a huge vineyard that brings in a lot of money. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver. But the woman says: My vineyard, that is, I myself, belongs to me. I give myself to whom I want. He can keep his wealth. Love cannot be bought (compare verse 7).

Verses 13–14: The book ends open: He asks to hear her voice. She calls him to come to her. The longing goes on. Love is never completely "finished."

Looking back: What have we read in the Song of Songs?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The most beautiful song: The Song of Songs is a collection of love poems. A woman and a man praise each other, look for each other and find each other.

The woman speaks the most: Amazing for such an old book: The woman has the most words. She is confident, takes the first step and decides for herself about her love.

Love that goes both ways: "My beloved is mine, and I am his" (2:16; 6:3; 7:10). Neither rules over the other. Their love is equal.

The body is good: The book speaks openly and tenderly about beauty and bodily love. The Bible sees love between a man and a woman as God's good gift.

Don't awaken love too early: This warning comes three times (2:7; 3:5; 8:4). Love needs time and freedom. It cannot be forced and cannot be bought.

Strong as death: The high point: "Love is as strong as death. … Many waters cannot put out love" (8:6–7).

A picture of God's love: Jews read the Song of Songs at Passover as a song of love between God and Israel. Christians have seen in it the love between Christ and his church. Both ways of understanding add to the literal reading.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Isaiah, the first of the great books of the prophets. It speaks of judgment and hope, of the Prince of Peace and of the suffering Servant of God.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 23 OF 66

ISAIAH

66 CHAPTERS

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 1

Come, let's settle this together

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHO WERE THE PROPHETS? WHAT IS THE BOOK OF ISAIAH?

With Isaiah, the books of the prophets begin.

A prophet is a person through whom God speaks. Prophets do not mainly predict the future. They tell the people of their own time what God wants from them. They criticize injustice, the oppression of the poor and false worship. And they give hope when everything seems lost.

Isaiah lived about 2,700 years ago in Jerusalem, from about 740 to 700 BC. At that time, mighty Assyria was a great threat. Isaiah gave advice to several kings of Judah.

The book of Isaiah has 66 chapters and is often divided into three parts:

– Chapters 1–39: Judgment and hope in Isaiah's time. Here we also find the promise of "Immanuel" and of the "Prince of Peace."

– Chapters 40–55: Comfort for the people in exile in Babylon, about 150 years later. "Comfort, comfort my people!" Here are the songs about the "Servant of God," who suffers for others.

– Chapters 56–66: Hope for the time after the return. A new heaven and a new earth.

Many scholars think that the later parts come from students of Isaiah, who kept on writing in his spirit. Others think Isaiah wrote the whole book.

No book of the prophets is quoted as often in the New Testament as Isaiah. Jews read Isaiah as God's word to Israel, full of hope for redemption. Christians see in many passages pointers to Jesus Christ.

A name for God that often appears in Isaiah: "the Holy One of Israel."

My people do not understand VERSES 1–9

1 The vision of Isaiah, the son of Amoz,
which he saw about Judah and Jerusalem
in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah,
kings of Judah.

2 Hear, you heavens, and listen, you earth,
for the LORD has spoken:
"I have raised children and brought them up,
but they have rebelled against me.

3 The ox knows its owner,
and the donkey its master's feeding trough,
but Israel does not know.
My people do not understand."

4 Oh, sinful nation,
a people loaded down with guilt,
children of evildoers,
children who act corruptly!
They have abandoned the LORD.
They have despised the Holy One of Israel.
They have turned away and gone backward.

5 Why do you want to be beaten even more,
that you rebel more and more?
The whole head is sick,
and the whole heart is weak.

6 From the sole of the foot to the head, there is nothing
healthy in it,
only wounds, welts, and open sores.
They have not been cleaned, not bandaged,
and not soothed with oil.

7 Your land is ruined.
Your cities are burned with fire.
Strangers eat up your land before your eyes,
and it is ruined, as if destroyed by strangers.

8 The daughter of Zion is left
like a shelter in a vineyard,
like a hut in a melon field,
like a city under siege.

9 If the LORD of Armies had not left us a very small
remnant,
we would have become like Sodom.
We would have been like Gomorrah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Isaiah worked under four kings. That is about 40 years.

Verses 2–3: God complains like a disappointed father: I raised my children, and they turn away. Even the ox and the donkey know where they belong. But my people do not know. This verse is where the ox and donkey at the manger in many Christmas scenes come from.

Verses 5–6: The people are like a body full of wounds, from head to toe. They are badly hurt by war and by their own guilt.

Verse 8: The "daughter of Zion" is Jerusalem. All around the city, everything is ruined. It stands alone like a little hut in an empty field. That happened when the Assyrians laid waste to the land in the year 701 BC.

Verse 9: God has left a "remnant." The idea of a "remnant" that is saved is very important in Isaiah.

God wants justice, not empty sacrifices VERSES 10–17

10 Hear the word of the LORD, you rulers of Sodom!
Listen to the teaching of our God, you people of
Gomorrah!

11 "What are your many sacrifices to me?" says the LORD.
"I have had enough of burnt offerings of rams
and the fat of fattened animals.
I take no pleasure in the blood of bulls,
of lambs, or of male goats.

12 When you come to appear before me,
who asked this of you,
to trample my courtyards?

13 Bring no more empty offerings!
Incense is disgusting to me.
New moons, Sabbaths, and gatherings:
I cannot stand evil gatherings.

14 My soul hates your New Moons and your feasts.
They are a burden to me.
I am tired of carrying them.
15 When you spread out your hands,
I will hide my eyes from you.
Yes, when you pray a lot, I will not listen.
Your hands are full of blood.
16 Wash yourselves! Make yourselves clean!
Put your evil deeds away from my eyes!
Stop doing evil!
17 Learn to do good!
Seek justice!
Help the oppressed!
Defend the orphans!
Plead the cause of the widow!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Isaiah calls the rulers of Jerusalem "rulers of Sodom." That is a shocking provocation. Sodom was the symbol of an evil city.

Verses 11–15: The people hold many worship services, bring sacrifices and pray a lot. But God does not want this! Why? Because their hands are "full of blood." They oppress others and do wrong.

God does not reject worship itself. He rejects worship that goes together with injustice in everyday life. Religion without justice is worthless.

Verses 16–17: What God really wants: Stop doing evil. Do good. Make sure there is justice. Help the weakest: the oppressed, orphans and widows. This message is still true today for everyone who believes in God.

Even if your sins are red as blood VERSES 18–20

18 "Come now, and let's settle this together," says the LORD.
"Though your sins are like scarlet,
they will be as white as snow.
Though they are red like crimson,
they will be like wool.
19 If you are willing and obey,
you will eat the good things of the land.
20 But if you refuse and rebel,
you will be eaten up by the sword,
for the mouth of the LORD has spoken it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18 is one of the most beautiful offers in the Bible. God invites: Come, let's settle the matter! Even if your guilt is as red as blood, I can make it white as snow. There is forgiveness and a new beginning.

Verses 19–20: But people have to decide: Do I want to turn back or not?

The faithful city has become unfaithful VERSES 21–31

21 How the faithful city has become a prostitute!
She was full of justice.
Righteousness lived in her,
but now murderers live there.
22 Your silver has become dross,
your wine is mixed with water.
23 Your princes are rebels and companions of thieves.
Everyone loves bribes and runs after gifts.
They do not defend the orphans,
and the cause of the widow does not come before them.
24 So the Lord, the LORD of Armies, the Mighty One of Israel, says:
"Oh, I will get relief from my opponents
and take revenge on my enemies.
25 I will turn my hand against you,
melt away your dross completely,
and remove all your tin.
26 I will restore your judges as at the first,
and your advisers as at the beginning.
Afterward you will be called
'The city of righteousness, a faithful city.'
27 Zion will be redeemed by justice,
and those in her who turn back, by righteousness.
28 But rebels and sinners will be broken together,
and those who abandon the LORD will be destroyed.
29 For they will be ashamed of the oaks that you desired,
and you will be put to shame because of the gardens that you chose.
30 For you will be like an oak whose leaves wither,
and like a garden that has no water.
31 The strong will be like tinder, and his work like a spark.
Both will burn together,
and no one will put out the fire."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: Jerusalem was once a city of justice. Now it has become unfaithful to God, like a woman who cheats on her husband. The prophets often use this picture for being unfaithful to God. Righteousness means: living right before God.

Verses 22–23: Everything is spoiled: The silver is worthless, the wine watered down, the leaders take bribes. And again: Orphans and widows get no justice. Dross is the worthless waste that is left when silver is melted.

Verses 25–26: God wants to clean the city like a smith who frees silver from dross in the fire. After that it will again be called the "city of righteousness." God's judgment has a goal: renewal.

Verse 29: "Oaks" and "gardens" were places where people worshiped foreign gods.

Verse 31: Whoever relies on his own strength burns up like tinder.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 2

Swords into plowshares

The mountain of the LORD VERSES 1–5

1 This is what Isaiah, the son of Amoz, saw about Judah
and Jerusalem.
2 It will happen in the last days
that the mountain of the LORD's house will stand firm
as the highest of the mountains,
and will be raised above the hills.
And all nations will stream to it.
3 Many peoples will go and say,
"Come, let's go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob!
He will teach us his ways,
and we will walk in his paths."
For the teaching will go out from Zion,
and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.
4 He will judge between the nations
and settle matters for many peoples.
They will beat their swords into plowshares
and their spears into pruning hooks.
Nation will not lift up sword against nation,
and they will not learn war anymore.
5 House of Jacob, come,
and let's walk in the light of the LORD!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the greatest visions of peace in the world.

Verses 2–3: In the future, all peoples will come to Jerusalem, not to conquer, but to learn from God.

Verse 4: Because God judges fairly between the peoples, no one needs weapons anymore. Swords become plows, spears become tools for the vineyard. No one learns war anymore.

In East Germany (the GDR), "Swords into plowshares" became the sign of the peace movement in the churches. A statue with this theme stands in front of the United Nations building in New York.

Almost the same text is also found in the prophet Micah (Micah 4:1–3).

Verse 5: Isaiah invites his people: Let's live this way already now, in God's light.

The day of the LORD against all pride VERSES 6–22

6 For you have abandoned your people, the house of
Jacob,
because they are full of what comes from the east,
with fortune-tellers like the Philistines,
and they shake hands with the children of foreigners.
7 Their land is full of silver and gold,
and there is no end to their treasures.
Their land is also full of horses,
and there is no end to their chariots.
8 Their land is also full of idols.
They worship the work of their own hands,
what their own fingers have made.
9 People are brought low,
and humanity is humbled.
So do not forgive them.
10 Go into the rock
and hide in the dust
from the terror of the LORD
and from the glory of his majesty.
11 The proud looks of people will be brought low,
and the arrogance of people will be bowed down,
and the LORD alone will be lifted up on that day.
12 For there will be a day of the LORD of Armies
against everything proud and arrogant
and against everything lifted up,
and it will be brought low,
13 against all the cedars of Lebanon that are high and
lifted up,
against all the oaks of Bashan,
14 against all the high mountains,
against all the hills that are lifted up,
15 against every high tower,
against every fortified wall,
16 against all the ships of Tarshish
and against all the beautiful images.
17 The pride of people will be bowed down,
and the arrogance of people will be brought low,
and the LORD alone will be lifted up on that day.
18 The idols will disappear completely.
19 People will go into the caves of the rocks
and into the holes of the earth
from the terror of the LORD
and from the glory of his majesty,
when he rises to shake the earth mightily.
20 On that day, people will throw away their idols of silver
and their idols of gold,
which they made for themselves to worship,
to the moles and to the bats,
21 to go into the caves of the rocks
and into the cracks of the jagged rocks
from the terror of the LORD
and from the glory of his majesty,
when he rises to shake the earth mightily.
22 Stop trusting in people,
who have only a breath in their nostrils!
For what are they worth?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–8: The people have become rich: silver, gold, horses, chariots. But they have forgotten God. They believe in fortune-tellers and worship idols they made themselves.

Verse 9: "Do not forgive them" is a harsh sentence. Isaiah is so shaken by his people turning away that he asks God not to simply look past it.

Verses 12–17: The "day of the LORD" is the day on which God steps in and brings low everything high and proud: tall trees, high mountains, high towers, great trading ships. Everything people are proud of loses its shine. Only God remains lifted up.

Verse 20: An almost funny picture: People throw away their golden idols, to the moles and bats, into the dark holes.

Verse 22: Don't put your trust in people. Their life is only one breath.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 3

Judgment on Jerusalem

Chaos among the leaders VERSES 1–12

1 For the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
is taking away from Jerusalem and from Judah
supply and support,
the whole supply of bread and the whole supply of
water,
2 the hero and the soldier,
the judge and the prophet,
the fortune-teller and the elder,
3 the captain of 50 and the respected man,
the adviser, the skilled craftsman,
and the clever magician.
4 "I will give them boys as their princes,
and children will rule over them.
5 The people will be oppressed, one by another,
and each by his neighbor.
The young will rise up against the old,
and the wicked against the respected.
6 Yes, a man will grab his brother in his father's house
and say,
'You still have a coat, you be our leader,
and let this heap of ruins be in your hands!'
7 On that day he will cry out,
'I will not be a healer,
for in my house there is neither bread nor clothing.
Don't make me leader of the people!'"
8 For Jerusalem is ruined, and Judah has fallen,
because their tongue and their deeds are against the
LORD,
to defy his glorious eyes.
9 The look on their faces testifies against them.
They show off their sin like Sodom.
They don't hide it.
How terrible for their souls!
For they have brought disaster on themselves.
10 Tell the righteous that it will go well with them,
for they will eat the fruit of their deeds.
11 How terrible for the wicked!
Disaster is coming on them,
for the deeds of their hands will be paid back to them.
12 As for my people: children are their oppressors,
and women rule over them.
My people, your leaders lead you astray
and destroy the way of your paths.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: God takes away from the land everything it relies on: food, water, soldiers, judges, advisers, craftsmen.

Verses 4–7: Without good leaders, chaos breaks out. Inexperienced, immature people come to power. No one wants to take responsibility anymore: "I have nothing myself, don't make me leader!"

Verses 10–11: A comfort in the middle of judgment: It will go well with the righteous.

Verse 12: "Children" and "women rule": Back then, this was seen as a sign that the order of things was upside down, because women usually held no public office. It describes the ideas of that time, not a judgment on whether women can lead well. The Bible also tells of strong women leaders like Deborah (Judges 4–5).

The real accusation comes at the end: "Your leaders lead you astray."

God accuses the powerful VERSES 13–15

13 The LORD stands up to argue his case,
and he stands to judge the peoples.
14 The LORD comes to judgment with the elders of his
people and with their princes:
"It is you who have eaten up the vineyard.
What you stole from the poor is in your houses.
15 How dare you crush my people
and grind the faces of the poor?"
says the Lord, the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God appears like a prosecutor in court. The accused are the powerful, the elders and princes.

Their crime: They have robbed the poor. What belongs to the poor is now in their houses.

"Grind the faces of the poor": a harsh picture for brutal oppression. God calls the poor "my people." He is on their side.

Against the pride of the daughters of Zion VERSES 16–26

16 The LORD also said,
"Because the daughters of Zion are proud
and walk with their necks stretched out,
with flirting eyes,
walking with little steps
and jingling the chains on their feet,
17 the Lord will cover the heads of the women of Zion
with sores,
and the LORD will make their heads bald."
18 On that day, the Lord will take away
the finery of their anklets, the headbands, the crescent
necklaces,
19 the earrings, the bracelets, the veils,
20 the headdresses, the ankle chains, the sashes,
the perfume bottles, the charms,
21 the signet rings, the nose rings,
22 the fine robes, the capes, the cloaks, the purses,
23 the hand mirrors, the fine linen clothes,
the tiaras, and the shawls.
24 And it will happen:
Instead of sweet scent, there will be rot,
instead of a belt, a rope,
instead of a beautiful hairstyle, baldness,
instead of a fine robe, sackcloth,
and instead of beauty, a brand.
25 Your men will fall by the sword,
and your heroes in war.
26 Her gates will lament and mourn.
She will sit on the ground, ruined.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaiah criticizes the rich women of Jerusalem. They strut through the city with expensive jewelry and clothes while

the poor suffer (verse 15). Their luxury is paid for with the misery of the poor.

Verses 18–23: A long list of jewelry and clothes, almost like a catalog. This shows how much wealth there was.

Verse 24: When war comes, they lose everything. Instead of perfume, a stench; instead of jewelry, a rope. "A brand": Back then, prisoners of war were branded.

Important: The criticism is not aimed at women or at beauty, but at pride and luxury at the expense of the poor. Isaiah criticizes the men in the same way (verses 14–15).

Verses 25–26: War will strike everyone. In the end, Jerusalem sits mourning on the ground like a widow.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 4

The Branch of the LORD

Seven women and one man VERSE 1

1 On that day, seven women will take hold of one man
and say,
"We will eat our own bread
and wear our own clothes.
Just let us be called by your name.
Take away our shame!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This verse still belongs to the end of chapter 3. After the war, so many men have been killed that seven women ask for one man.

Back then, it was considered a shame for a woman to stay unmarried and without children. Without a husband, women were often unprotected and without rights. This shows how cruel war is and how hard the situation of women was back then.

Today we know: A woman's worth does not depend on whether she is married.

New life after judgment VERSES 2–6

2 On that day, the Branch of the LORD will be beautiful
and glorious,
and the fruit of the land will be the pride and the glory
of the survivors of Israel.
3 It will happen:
Whoever is left in Zion and whoever remains in
Jerusalem
will be called holy,
everyone who is written down among the living in
Jerusalem,
4 when the Lord has washed away the filth of the
daughters of Zion
and has cleaned the bloodshed of Jerusalem from its
midst
by the spirit of judgment and by the spirit of burning.
5 Over the whole site of Mount Zion
and over its gatherings,
the LORD will create a cloud and smoke by day
and the shining of a flaming fire by night,
for over all the glory there will be a canopy.
6 There will be a shelter for shade in the daytime from
the heat,
and a refuge and protection from storm and rain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After judgment comes hope. God makes a new beginning.

Verse 2: "The Branch of the LORD": a young shoot growing out of the ground. A picture of new life. Later, the "Branch" becomes a name for the coming king from David's family (Jeremiah 23:5; Zechariah 3:8). Christians see in it a pointer to Christ.

Verse 3: Those who are left will be called "holy." They are written in God's "book of life."

Verse 5: A cloud by day and fire by night remind us of the exodus from Egypt, when God led his people through the wilderness this way (Exodus 13:21). God will protect Jerusalem like that again.

Verse 6: God is like a canopy against heat, storm and rain.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 5

The song of the vineyard

The song of the vineyard VERSES 1–7

1 Let me sing for my dear friend,
a song of my friend about his vineyard.
My friend had a vineyard
on a very fertile hill.
2 He dug it up, removed the stones,
planted it with the best vines,
built a tower in the middle of it,
and also cut out a winepress in it.
He expected it to produce grapes,
but it produced sour wild grapes.
3 "Now, you people of Jerusalem and you men of Judah,
please judge between me and my vineyard!
4 What more could have been done for my vineyard
that I have not done for it?
Why did it produce sour wild grapes
when I expected it to produce grapes?
5 Now I will tell you what I will do to my vineyard:
I will take away its hedge, and it will be eaten up.
I will break down its wall, and it will be trampled.
6 I will make it a wasteland.
It will not be pruned or hoed,
but briers and thorns will grow on it.

I will also command the clouds
not to rain any rain on it."

7 For the vineyard of the LORD of Armies is the house of Israel,
and the men of Judah are the plant he loves.
He looked for justice, but there was oppression.
He looked for righteousness, but there was a cry of distress.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaiah begins like a singer at a festival: I will sing you a love song about my friend's vineyard. At first, the listeners think of a love story.

The friend has done everything for his vineyard: dug it up, removed the stones, planted the best vines, built a watchtower. But only sour, wild grapes grow.

Verses 3–4: Then he asks the listeners: What more should I have done? Judge for yourselves!

Verse 7: The surprise: The vineyard is Israel, the friend is God. God has done everything for his people. He waited for justice, but he found injustice.

In Hebrew, this is a strong play on words: He waited for "mishpat" (justice), but there was "mispach" (oppression). For "tsedaqah" (righteousness), but there was "tse'aqah" (a cry for help).

Jesus tells a similar parable about the wicked tenant farmers (Mark 12:1–12).

How terrible for the greedy and the drinkers VERSES 8–17

8 How terrible for those who join house to house
and add field to field,
until there is no room left
and you live alone in the middle of the land!

9 In my ears, the LORD of Armies says:
"Surely many houses will be empty,
yes, great and beautiful ones, without anyone living in them.

10 For 10 acres of vineyard will produce only one bath,
and a homer of seed will produce only an ephah."

11 How terrible for those who get up early in the morning
to run after strong drink,
who stay up late into the night
until wine sets them on fire!

12 Harp, lyre, tambourine, and flute,
and wine are at their feasts,
but they pay no attention to the work of the LORD,
and they do not see what his hands are doing.

13 So my people go into captivity
because they lack knowledge.
Their noble men are starving,
and their crowds are dried up with thirst.

14 So Sheol (the world of the dead) has opened its throat wide
and opened its mouth without limit.
And their splendor, their crowds, their show,
and whoever is cheerful among them go down into it.

15 So people are brought low, humanity is humbled,
and the eyes of the proud are lowered.

16 But the LORD of Armies is lifted up in justice,
and God, the Holy One, shows himself holy in righteousness.

17 Then the lambs will graze as in their own pasture,
and strangers will eat in the ruins of the rich.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now come six cries of "How terrible" against the injustice among the people.

Verse 8: The first one is aimed at the rich who keep buying up more houses and land until the small farmers have nothing left. In the end, they live alone in their palaces. This is a criticism of greed and of pushing out the poor that is still relevant today.

Verse 10: The harvest will be tiny. A "bath" is about 6 gallons, a "homer" about 58 gallons, an "ephah" only a tenth of that. People harvest less than they sowed.

Verses 11–12: The second one is aimed at those who party and drink from morning to night and forget God while doing so.

Verse 16: God shows that he is holy by being just.

Whoever calls evil good VERSES 18–25

18 How terrible for those who drag guilt along with ropes of lies
and sin as if with cart ropes,

19 who say, "Let him hurry,
let him speed up his work, so that we may see it!
Let the plan of the Holy One of Israel come near and happen,
so that we may know it!"

20 How terrible for those who call evil good and good evil,
who put darkness for light and light for darkness,
who put bitter for sweet and sweet for bitter!

21 How terrible for those who are wise in their own eyes
and think themselves clever!

22 How terrible for those who are heroes at drinking wine
and champions at mixing strong drink,

23 who let the guilty go free for a bribe,
but deny the innocent their rights!

24 So, as the tongue of fire eats up the stubble,
and as dry grass sinks down in the flame,
their root will be like rot,
and their blossom will go up like dust,
because they have rejected the teaching of the LORD of Armies
and despised the word of the Holy One of Israel.

25 So the anger of the LORD burns against his people,
and he has stretched out his hand against them and struck them.
The mountains tremble,
and their dead bodies lie like garbage in the middle of the streets.
In spite of all this, his anger has not turned away,
but his hand is still stretched out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–19: Whoever does evil drags guilt behind him like a heavy cart. And he mocks God: "Let him hurry, let him speed up his work, so that we may see it!" That means: Let God come, if he exists!

Verse 20 is one of the best-known sentences of the book: How terrible for those who call evil good and good evil! When a society turns values upside down and calls injustice justice, it is ruined. People have seen this again and again in dictatorships.

Verses 22–23: They are "heroes," but only at drinking. And in court they take bribes.

Verse 25: "His hand is still stretched out": This phrase appears several times in Isaiah (chapters 9 and 10). The judgment is not over yet. These are terrible pictures of war. The prophets explain such disaster as a result of turning away from God. That does not mean that every disaster today is a punishment from God.

A people from far away VERSES 26–30

26 He will raise a banner for the nations far away,
and he will whistle for them from the end of the earth.
They will come quickly and swiftly.
27 None of them is tired or stumbles.
None of them dozes or sleeps.
The belt around their waist does not come loose,
and the strap of their sandals does not break.
28 Their arrows are sharp,
and all their bows are bent.
The hooves of their horses are like flint,
and their wheels like a whirlwind.
29 Their roar is like that of a lioness.
They roar like young lions.
Yes, they growl, seize the prey,
carry it off, and no one rescues it.
30 On that day, they will roar against it
like the roaring of the sea.
If someone looks at the land,
there is darkness and distress.
The light is darkened by its clouds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God calls a foreign people like a shepherd who whistles. This means the Assyrians, the most feared army in the world at that time.

Their soldiers never get tired. Their horses and chariots are as fast as a storm. They roar like lions.

Isaiah says: Even this mighty power is only a tool in God's hand. Later he will say that Assyria too will be judged (chapter 10).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 6

Here I am, send me!

Holy, holy, holy VERSES 1–7

1 In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord.
He was sitting on a throne.
The throne was high and lifted up.
The edge of his robe filled the temple.
2 Seraphim stood above him.
Each one had six wings.
With two wings each one covered his face.
With two he covered his feet.
With two he flew.
3 They called out to each other,
"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of Armies!
The whole earth is full of his glory!"
4 The voice of the one who called out
made the doorways shake down to their foundations.
The house filled with smoke.
5 Then I said, "How terrible for me!
I am lost.
I am a man with unclean lips.
And I live among a people with unclean lips.
Yet my eyes have seen the King, the LORD of Armies!"
6 Then one of the seraphim flew to me.
He had a burning coal in his hand.
He had taken it from the altar with tongs.
7 He touched my mouth with it.
He said, "Look, this has touched your lips.
Your guilt is taken away.
Your sin is forgiven."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is Isaiah's call to be a prophet, in the year 740 BC, when King Uzziah died.

Isaiah sees God in the temple on a huge throne. Even the edge of his robe fills the whole temple.

Verse 2: "Seraphim" means "the burning ones." They are heavenly beings. They cover their faces because even they cannot look at God directly.

Verse 3: "Holy, holy, holy": Three times holy means: completely holy, totally different from everything else. This song is still sung today in Jewish prayers (the "Kedushah") and in Christian worship services (the "Sanctus").

Verse 5: Isaiah is terrified. In front of God's holiness, he realizes how unclean he himself is.

Verses 6–7: But God makes him clean. The glowing coal touches his lips: His guilt is forgiven. Only then can he pass on God's word.

Whom shall I send? VERSES 8–13

8 I heard the voice of the Lord.
He said, "Whom shall I send? Who will go for us?"
Then I said, "Here I am. Send me!"
9 He said, "Go and tell this people:
'You hear and hear, but you do not understand.
You look and look, but you do not see what it means.'
10 Make the heart of this people dull.
Make their ears deaf.
Close their eyes.
Otherwise they might see with their eyes.
They might hear with their ears.
They might understand with their heart.
Then they would turn back and be healed."
11 Then I said, "Lord, how long?"
He answered, "Until the cities lie in ruins and no one lives in them.
Until the houses are empty of people.
Until the land is completely ruined.
12 Until the LORD has sent the people far away.
Until many places in the land are left empty.

13 Even if a tenth of the people are still left in the land,
they will be burned up again.
It will be like a terebinth tree or an oak tree.
When they are cut down, a stump is left.
The holy seed is its stump."
A terebinth is a large tree.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "Here I am. Send me!" A famous sentence. Isaiah volunteers. Many people have made this sentence their own prayer.

Verses 9–10: A very hard task: Isaiah is to preach, but the people will not listen. It sounds as if God wants them not to turn back.

Many interpreters understand it like this: God tells Isaiah in advance how the people will react. His preaching will not soften their hearts; instead, they will become even harder. Jesus quotes these words when many people do not want to understand him (Matthew 13:13–15).

Verse 11: "Lord, how long?" The answer is hard: until the land is destroyed and the people are carried away.

Verse 13: But at the end, a sign of hope: When a tree is cut down, a stump remains. And something can grow out of a stump again. This "holy seed" is the remnant from which God will make a new beginning (compare 11:1).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 7

The sign of Immanuel

Don't be afraid! VERSES 1–9

1 In the days of Ahaz, the son of Jotham, the son of
Uzziah, king of Judah,
Rezin, the king of Syria, and Pekah, the son of
Remaliah, the king of Israel,
went up to Jerusalem to make war against it,
but they could not defeat it.
2 The house of David was told, "Syria has joined forces
with Ephraim."
Then his heart trembled, and the heart of his people,
as the trees of the forest tremble in the wind.
3 Then the LORD said to Isaiah,
"Go out now to meet Ahaz,
you and your son Shearjashub,
at the end of the water channel of the upper pool,
on the road to the field where cloth is washed.
4 Tell him: 'Be careful, and stay calm!
Don't be afraid, and don't lose heart
because of these two smoking stubs of torches,
because of the fierce anger of Rezin and Syria
and of the son of Remaliah.
5 Because Syria, Ephraim, and the son of Remaliah have
planned evil against you,
saying,
6 "Let's go up against Judah, tear it apart,
divide it among ourselves,
and set up a king in it, the son of Tabeel,"
7 this is what the Lord GOD says:
"It will not stand, and it will not happen."
8 For the head of Syria is Damascus,
and the head of Damascus is Rezin.
Within 65 years, Ephraim will be broken to pieces,
so that it is no longer a people.
9 The head of Ephraim is Samaria,
and the head of Samaria is the son of Remaliah.
If you will not believe, surely you will not be
established.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The situation: In the year 734 BC, two neighboring kings attack Jerusalem, the king of Syria and the king of the northern kingdom of Israel (also called "Ephraim"). They want to remove King Ahaz from power. Ahaz and his people tremble with fear.

Verse 3: Isaiah takes his son with him. His name "Shearjashub" means "A remnant will return." The name itself is a message.

Verse 4: "Stay calm! Don't be afraid!" The two enemies are only "smoking stubs of torches": They are still smoking, but their fire will soon be out.

Verse 9: "If you will not believe, surely you will not be established." In Hebrew, this is a play on words: "believe" and "be established" come from the same word, from which "Amen" also comes. Whoever holds on to God has a firm footing.

The sign: God with us VERSES 10–17

10 The LORD spoke to Ahaz again and said,
11 "Ask for a sign from the LORD your God!
Ask for it from the depths or from the heights above."
12 But Ahaz said, "I will not ask.
I will not test the LORD."
13 Then he said, "Listen now, you house of David!
Is it not enough for you to try people's patience,
that you also try the patience of my God?
14 So the Lord himself will give you a sign:
Look, the virgin will become pregnant
and give birth to a son,
and she will call him Immanuel.
15 He will eat butter and honey
when he knows how to refuse evil and choose good.
16 For before the child knows how to refuse evil and
choose good,
the land whose two kings you dread
will be abandoned.
17 The LORD will bring on you, on your people, and on
your father's house
days such as have not come
since the day that Ephraim broke away from Judah:
the king of Assyria.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: God offers Ahaz a sign. Ahaz refuses with a pious excuse. In reality, he has already decided to get help from the king of Assyria instead of from God (2 Kings 16:7).

Verse 14 is one of the best-known verses of the Bible. "Immanuel" means: "God is with us."

In Hebrew, the word "almah" is used here. It means "young woman," a young woman of an age to marry. The ancient Greek translation translated it with "parthenos," "virgin." Our English source text writes "virgin."

In Judaism, the verse is usually understood like this: A young woman in Isaiah's time, perhaps the king's wife or Isaiah's wife, has a child. Even before this child is grown, the two enemy kings are defeated. The child is a sign: God is with us.

The Gospel of Matthew quotes this verse at the birth of Jesus (Matthew 1:22–23). Christians see in it an announcement that in Jesus, God is truly "with us."

Verses 15–16: "Butter and honey" is the food of people in a ruined land where farming is no longer possible, only raising animals. Before the child is old enough to tell good from evil, the enemies are gone.

Verse 17: But then an even greater threat comes: Assyria, the very power from which Ahaz is seeking help.

The land will be ruined VERSES 18–25

18 "On that day, the LORD will whistle for the fly
that is at the farthest end of the rivers of Egypt,
and for the bee that is in the land of Assyria.
19 They will come and all settle
in the ruined valleys, in the cracks of the rocks,
on all the thorn bushes, and on all the pastures.
20 On that day, the Lord will shave with a razor
hired from beyond the River,
that is, with the king of Assyria:
the head and the hair of the feet,
and it will also take away the beard.
21 It will happen on that day
that a man will keep alive a young cow and two sheep.
22 And it will happen that because of the plenty of milk
they give,
he will eat butter,
for everyone who is left in the land will eat butter and
honey.
23 It will happen on that day
that every place where there were 1,000 vines,
worth 1,000 silver shekels (about 25 pounds of silver),
will turn into briers and thorns.
24 People will go there with arrows and bow,
for the whole land will be full of briers and thorns.
25 And all the hills that were worked with the hoe,
you will no longer go there for fear of briers and
thorns,
but they will be used for letting the cattle loose,
and the sheep will trample on them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: The armies of Egypt and Assyria will come like swarms of flies and bees.

Verse 20: A humiliating picture: The king of Assyria, whom Ahaz himself has "hired," will shave Judah bald like a razor. Back then, prisoners of war were shaved to humiliate them.

Verse 23: A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver.

Verses 21–25: The fertile land becomes wilderness. Instead of vineyards, thorns grow. The few survivors keep only a few animals. Where there used to be fields, people only go hunting with bow and arrow.

The message to Ahaz: Whoever trusts in people instead of God brings disaster on himself in the end.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 8

God is with us

A child with a strange name VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD said to me,
"Take a large tablet and write on it in ordinary letters:
'For Maher Shalal Hash Baz.'
2 And I will take reliable witnesses for myself to testify:
Uriah the priest, and Zechariah the son of
Jeberechiah."
3 I went to the prophetess,
and she became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
Then the LORD said to me,
"Name him 'Maher Shalal Hash Baz.'
4 For before the child knows how to say 'My father' and
'My mother,'
the riches of Damascus and the plunder of Samaria
will be carried away by the king of Assyria."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaiah again has a son with a name that carries a message. "Maher Shalal Hash Baz" means: "Quick to the plunder, swift to the spoil."

The message: Even before the child can say "Daddy" and "Mommy," that is, in about a year, the two enemies, Syria (Damascus) and the northern kingdom of Israel (Samaria), will be robbed by Assyria. That is what happened in the year 732 BC.

Verse 3: "The prophetess" is Isaiah's wife. She too was a prophet.

The flood from Assyria VERSES 5–10

5 The LORD spoke to me again and said,
6 "Because this people has rejected the gently flowing
waters of Shiloah
and rejoices over Rezin and the son of Remaliah,
7 so the Lord is bringing on them
the mighty floodwaters of the River:
the king of Assyria and all his glory.
It will rise over all its channels
and overflow all its banks.
8 It will sweep on into Judah.
It will overflow and pass through.
It will reach up to the neck.
Its spreading wings will fill the width of your land,
O Immanuel.
9 Rage, you peoples, and be broken to pieces!
Listen, all you from distant lands:

Get ready for battle, and be shattered!
Get ready for battle, and be shattered!
10 Make plans together, and they will come to nothing.
Speak a word, and it will not stand,
for God is with us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Shiloah is a small water channel in Jerusalem. The water there flows calmly and quietly. It is a picture of God's quiet, reliable help. The people reject it.

Verses 7–8: Instead, a mighty flood comes: the "River" is the Euphrates, a picture for Assyria. The water will come up to Judah's neck.

Verses 8 and 10: Twice we hear an echo of "Immanuel": "O Immanuel" and "God is with us." That is the hope in the middle of danger: God is with his people. So the plans of the enemies will fail in the end.

Fear only God VERSES 11–15

11 For this is what the LORD said to me when his hand
took strong hold of me,
and he warned me not to walk in the way of this people.
He said,
12 "Don't call everything a conspiracy that this people
calls a conspiracy.
Don't fear their threats,
and don't let yourselves be terrified.
13 The LORD of Armies is the one you must treat as holy.
He is the one you must fear.
He is the one you must stand in awe of.
14 He will be a sanctuary,
but for both houses of Israel a stone to stumble over
and a rock that makes them fall.
For the people of Jerusalem he will be a trap and a
snare.
15 Many will stumble over it, fall, be broken,
be snared, and be caught."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Back then, many fears and rumors about conspiracies were spreading. God says to Isaiah: Don't let yourself be infected by them! That sounds very up to date.

Verse 13: The only "fear" we should have is awe before God. Whoever takes God seriously does not have to be afraid of anything else.

Verse 14: For those who trust him, God is a safe place. For those who reject him, he becomes a stone they stumble over. The New Testament takes up this picture (Romans 9:33; 1 Peter 2:8).

Waiting for the LORD VERSES 16–22

16 Tie up the covenant!
Seal the teaching among my disciples!
17 I will wait for the LORD,
who is hiding his face from the house of Jacob,
and I will look for him.
18 I and the children whom the LORD has given me
are signs and wonders in Israel
from the LORD of Armies, who lives on Mount Zion.
19 When they say to you,
"Ask the spirits of the dead and the fortune-tellers,
who whisper and mutter,"
shouldn't a people ask their God?
Should they ask the dead on behalf of the living?
20 Turn to the teaching and to the covenant!
If they do not speak according to this word,
then there is no morning for them.
21 They will wander through the land, very troubled and
hungry.
And it will happen: When they are hungry,
they will worry and curse their king and their God.
They will turn their faces upward,
22 then look at the earth
and see distress, darkness, and gloomy anguish.
They will be driven out into thick darkness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Because no one wants to listen, Isaiah has his message written down and sealed. His students are to keep it until the time comes. This is probably how the first parts of the book came about.

Verse 17: A sentence of trust: Even if God seems hidden right now, I will wait for him.

Verse 18: Isaiah and his children with their message names are themselves living signs.

Verse 19: In times of trouble, people run to fortune-tellers and people who call up the dead. Isaiah asks: Why do you ask the dead instead of the living God?

Verses 21–22: Whoever turns away from God ends up in deep darkness. But right after that comes the great light (chapter 9).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 9

A child is born to us

The people who live in darkness see a great light VERSES 1–7

1 But there will be no more darkness for her who was in
distress.
In the earlier time, he brought shame on the land of
Zebulun and the land of Naphtali,
but in the later time he has made it glorious:
the way of the sea, the land beyond the Jordan,
Galilee of the nations.
2 The people who walked in darkness
have seen a great light.
On those who lived in the land of the shadow of death,
a light has shone.
3 You have made the nation grow.
You have made their joy great.
They rejoice before you as people rejoice at the
harvest,
as people celebrate when they divide the plunder.

4 For the yoke that weighed them down,
the bar on their shoulders,
the rod of their oppressor,
you have broken as on the day of Midian.
5 For all the armor of the soldier in the noise of battle
and every coat rolled in blood
will be burned, fuel for the fire.
6 For a child is born to us,
a son is given to us,
and the government will be on his shoulders.
His name will be called
Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God,
Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.
7 There will be no end to the growth of his government
and of peace,
on the throne of David and over his kingdom,
to make it firm and to uphold it
with justice and righteousness
from now on and forever.
The zeal of the LORD of Armies will do this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the best-known texts of the Bible. In many churches, it is read at Christmas.

Verse 1: Zebulun and Naphtali are in the north, in Galilee. This region was the first to be conquered by Assyria (2 Kings 15:29). It is right there that the light is to shine first.

Verse 2: Whoever lives in deep darkness suddenly sees a great light. A picture of freedom and hope.

Verse 4: "As on the day of Midian": At that time, God set his people free through Gideon with only 300 men (Judges 7).

Verse 5: All the armor and bloody coats will be burned. The war is over. There are no more weapons.

Verse 6: How will this happen? Not through an army, but through a child. His names are mighty: Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.

In Judaism, this text is often applied to King Hezekiah or to the coming Messiah. The names are then read as praise of God, who acts through this child. Christians see Jesus Christ in this child (compare Matthew 4:13–16, where verses 1–2 are quoted). George Frideric Handel set these words to music in his "Messiah."

Verse 7: His rule brings peace without end, built on justice and righteousness.

His hand is still stretched out VERSES 8–12

8 The Lord sent a word against Jacob,
and it falls on Israel.
9 All the people will know it,
including Ephraim and the people of Samaria,
who say in pride and arrogance of heart,
10 "The bricks have fallen,
but we will build with cut stone.
The sycamore fig trees have been cut down,
but we will put cedars in their place."
11 So the LORD raises up the enemies of Rezin against him
and stirs up his enemies,
12 the Syrians in front and the Philistines behind.
They will swallow Israel with open mouth.
In spite of all this, his anger has not turned away,
but his hand is still stretched out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the great hope, Isaiah returns to the hard present. Now it is about the northern kingdom of Israel (Ephraim, Samaria).

Verse 10: After a disaster, people proudly say: Never mind! We'll build everything back even more beautiful! They do not ask why it happened, and they do not turn back.

The sentence "His hand is still stretched out" comes back again and again like a chorus: three times in this chapter and once more in 10:4. The judgment is not over yet, because the people do not turn back.

They do not turn back VERSES 13–17

13 Yet the people have not turned to the one who struck them,
and they have not looked for the LORD of Armies.
14 So the LORD will cut off from Israel head and tail,
palm branch and reed, in one day.
15 The elder and the respected man, that is the head,
and the prophet who teaches lies, that is the tail.
16 For those who lead this people lead them astray,
and those who are led by them are swallowed up.
17 So the Lord will not rejoice over their young men,
and he will not have mercy on their orphans and widows,
for all of them are godless and evildoers,
and every mouth speaks foolishness.
In spite of all this, his anger has not turned away,
but his hand is still stretched out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: The leaders and the lying prophets are to blame for the people going astray. That is why the judgment strikes them first.

Verse 17: A shocking sentence: God does not even have mercy on orphans and widows, whom he otherwise protects in a special way. That is how deep the corruption of the whole people has become. This is the language of the prophets, meant to show how serious the situation is. It does not cancel out that God loves the weak (Psalm 68:5).

Wickedness burns like fire VERSES 18–21

18 For wickedness burns like a fire.
It eats up briers and thorns.
Yes, it sets the thickets of the forest on fire,
and they roll upward in columns of smoke.
19 Through the anger of the LORD of Armies, the land is burned up,
and the people are like fuel for the fire.
No one spares his brother.
20 People grab food on the right and are still hungry,
and they eat on the left and are not satisfied.
Each one eats the flesh of his own arm:
21 Manasseh eats Ephraim, and Ephraim eats Manasseh,
and both together are against Judah.
In spite of all this, his anger has not turned away,
but his hand is still stretched out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: Wickedness itself is like a forest fire. Whoever does evil starts a fire that burns everyone in the end.

Verses 20–21: A picture of civil war: The tribes fight each other, Manasseh against Ephraim, brother against brother.

They "eat" themselves up. That is the worst disaster that can happen to a people.

ISAIAH

Chapter 10

Assyria is only the rod in God's hand

How terrible for those who make unjust laws VERSES 1–4

1 How terrible for those who make unjust laws,
and for the writers who write oppressive rules,
2 to push the needy away from justice
and to rob the poor among my people of their rights,
so that widows become their plunder
and they rob the orphans!
3 What will you do on the day of punishment,
in the disaster that comes from far away?
To whom will you run for help?
Where will you leave your wealth?
4 All that is left for them is to sink down among the prisoners
and to fall among the dead.
In spite of all this, his anger has not turned away,
but his hand is still stretched out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An especially sharp accusation: There are people who write laws in such a way that the poor lose their rights. Injustice that is poured into laws is especially bad, because it looks "legal."

God sees it. And when judgment comes, their wealth will not help the rich.

How terrible for Assyria, the proud one VERSES 5–19

5 How terrible for the Assyrian, the rod of my anger,
the staff in whose hand is my fury!
6 I will send him against a godless nation,
and against the people who make me angry I will give him orders
to take plunder and to seize spoil,
and to trample them down like mud in the streets.
7 But that is not what he intends,
and that is not what his heart thinks,
but in his heart is to destroy
and to wipe out many nations.
8 For he says, "Aren't all my princes kings?
9 Isn't Calno like Carchemish?
Isn't Hamath like Arpad?
Isn't Samaria like Damascus?
10 As my hand has found the kingdoms of the idols,
whose images were more than those of Jerusalem and Samaria,
11 shall I not do to Jerusalem and her idols
what I have done to Samaria and her idols?"
12 So it will happen:
When the Lord has finished all his work on Mount Zion and on Jerusalem,
I will punish the fruit of the proud heart of the king of Assyria
and the arrogance of his proud looks.
13 For he has said,
"By the strength of my hand I have done it,
and by my wisdom, for I am clever.
I have removed the borders of the peoples
and robbed their treasures.
Like a hero I have brought down their rulers.
14 My hand has found the riches of the peoples like a nest,
and as people gather abandoned eggs,
I have gathered the whole earth.
There was no one who moved a wing,
or opened its beak, or chirped."
15 Does the ax brag against the one who chops with it?
Does the saw boast against the one who saws with it?
As if a rod could lift up the one who lifts it,
or as if a staff could lift up someone who is not wood!
16 So the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
will send a wasting disease among his fat ones,
and under his glory a fire will be lit
like a burning fire.
17 The Light of Israel will become a fire,
and his Holy One a flame.
It will burn up and eat up his thorns and briers
in a single day.
18 He will destroy the glory of his forest and of his fertile field,
both soul and body.
It will be as when a flag bearer collapses.
19 The rest of the trees of his forest will be so few
that a child could write down their number.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: God uses Assyria like a rod to punish his unfaithful people.

Verses 7–11: But Assyria knows nothing about this. It only wants to conquer and destroy. The king of Assyria brags: I have conquered city after city (Calno, Carchemish, Hamath, Arpad, Damascus, Samaria). Jerusalem is next!

Verses 13–14: He is proud: I did everything by my own strength and cleverness. To me, the peoples were like a nest full of eggs, I only had to gather them up.

Verse 15: Isaiah's answer, with humor: Can an ax show off in front of the person who uses it? Assyria is only a tool. It has no reason to be proud.

Verses 16–19: So God will judge Assyria too. The mighty empire will be like a forest that burns down. So few trees will be left that a child can count them.

An important message: No world power lasts forever. Whoever thinks he is all-powerful will fall.

A remnant will return VERSES 20–27

20 On that day it will happen
that the remnant of Israel and the survivors of the house of Jacob
will no longer lean on the one who struck them,

but they will truly lean on the LORD,
the Holy One of Israel.
21 A remnant will return, the remnant of Jacob,
to the Mighty God.
22 For even if your people Israel are like the sand of the sea,
only a remnant of them will return.
A destruction has been decided,
overflowing with righteousness.
23 For the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
will make a full end, as decided, in the whole earth.
24 So the Lord, the LORD of Armies, says:
"My people who live in Zion,
don't be afraid of the Assyrian,
even if he strikes you with the rod
and raises his staff against you, as Egypt did.
25 For in just a very little while,
the fury against you will be over,
and my anger will turn to his destruction."
26 The LORD of Armies will raise up a whip against him,
as when Midian was struck down at the rock of Oreb.
His rod will be over the sea,
and he will raise it as he did against Egypt.
27 On that day it will happen
that his burden will be taken from your shoulder
and his yoke from your neck,
and the yoke will be broken because of the anointing oil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–21: "A remnant will return": That is exactly the name of Isaiah's son "Shearjashub" (Isaiah 7:3). Only a few will be left. But these few will rely completely on God.

Verse 21: "Mighty God" is the same title as in chapter 9:6.

Verses 24–26: A comfort for Jerusalem: Don't be afraid of Assyria! Soon it will be over. God will set you free as he did back then from Egypt and from the Midianites (Judges 7:25).

Verse 27: The heavy yoke will be broken. "Because of the anointing oil" is hard to understand in Hebrew. Perhaps it means the anointed king from the house of David, perhaps it is a picture of strength and plenty.

The enemy marches on Jerusalem VERSES 28–34

28 He has come to Aiath.
He has passed through Migron.
At Michmash he stores his baggage.
29 They have crossed the pass.
At Geba they have set up camp for the night.
Ramah trembles.
Gibeah of Saul has fled.
30 Cry out loud, daughter of Gallim!
Listen, Laishah! You poor Anathoth!
31 Madmenah is running away.
The people of Gebim flee to safety.
32 This very day he will stop at Nob.
He shakes his fist at the mountain of the daughter of Zion,
the hill of Jerusalem.
33 Look, the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
will cut off the branches with terror.
The tall will be cut down,
and the high will be brought low.
34 He will cut down the thickets of the forest with iron,
and Lebanon will fall by the Mighty One.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An exciting report like a live broadcast: The enemy army marches toward Jerusalem from the north, town by town, closer and closer. The villages flee in panic. Finally the enemy stands at Nob, right in front of Jerusalem, and shakes his fist.

Verses 33–34: But then the turn: God himself cuts down this mighty "forest" like a lumberjack. The proud enemy falls.

The next chapter continues: From the cut-down stump of Jesse, a new shoot grows (Isaiah 11:1).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 11

The shoot from the stump of Jesse

A new king VERSES 1–5

1 A shoot will come out of the stump of Jesse.
A branch will grow from his roots and bear fruit.
2 The Spirit of the LORD will rest on him.
It is the spirit of wisdom and understanding.
It is the spirit of good advice and strength.
It is the spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the LORD.
The fear of the LORD means: deep respect for the LORD.
3 He will find his joy in the fear of the LORD.
He will not judge by what his eyes see.
He will not decide by what his ears hear.
4 He will judge the poor in the right way.
He will make fair decisions for the humble people of the earth.
He will strike the earth with the rod of his mouth.
With the breath of his lips he will kill the wicked.
5 Doing what is right will be like the belt around his waist.
Faithfulness will be like the belt around his waist.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Jesse was the father of King David. David's royal family is like a tree that has been cut down; only a stump is left. But out of this stump, a new, fresh shoot grows.

A well-known German Christmas carol (in English: "Lo, How a Rose E'er Blooming") refers to this verse. It sings of a tender root that came from Jesse.

Verse 2: God's Spirit rests on this new king with all good gifts: wisdom, understanding, counsel, strength, knowledge, awe. In Christian tradition, people speak of the "gifts of the Holy Spirit."

Verses 3–4: He does not judge by outward appearance, but fairly. Above all, he gives justice to the poor and humble.

"With the rod of his mouth": He needs no weapons. His word alone is enough to defeat evil.

Jews expect this king as the Messiah. Christians see Jesus as this shoot from David's family.

The wolf will live with the lamb VERSES 6–9

6 The wolf will live with the lamb.
The leopard will lie down with the young goat.
The calf, the young lion and the fattened calf will be together.
A little child will lead them.
7 The cow and the bear will graze side by side.
Their young ones will lie down together.
The lion will eat straw like the ox.
8 The baby will play near the hole of a cobra.
The young child will put his hand on the den of a viper.
Cobras and vipers are poisonous snakes.
9 No one will hurt anyone or destroy anything
on all my holy mountain.
The earth will be full of the knowledge of the LORD,
as the waters cover the sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One of the most beautiful pictures in the Bible: paradise on earth. Predators and their prey live together in peace. A little child can play with snakes without fear.

The hostility between people and the snake that has existed since the fall into sin (Genesis 3:15) is over.

Verse 9: The reason for this peace: All people know God. Knowing him fills the earth the way water fills the sea.

This picture stands for a world without violence, without fear, without war. It is a hope that can already encourage us today to stand up for peace.

God gathers his people VERSES 10–16

10 On that day the nations will seek the root of Jesse.
He stands like a banner for the peoples.
A banner is a flag that people gather around.
The place where he rests will be glorious.
11 On that day the Lord will reach out his hand a second time.
He will bring back the rest of his people who are left.
He will bring them back from Assyria, from Egypt,
from Pathros, from Cush,
from Elam, from Shinar, from Hamath and from the islands of the sea.
12 He will raise a banner for the nations.
He will gather the people of Israel who were driven out.
He will bring together the scattered people of Judah
from the four corners of the earth.
13 Ephraim will not be jealous anymore.
Those who attack Judah will be cut off.
Ephraim will not be jealous of Judah.
And Judah will not attack Ephraim.
14 They will swoop down on the shoulders of the Philistines in the west.
Together they will rob the people of the east.
They will take power over Edom and Moab.
The people of Ammon will obey them.
15 The LORD will completely destroy the tongue of the Egyptian sea.
He will wave his hand over the River with his scorching wind.
He will split it into seven streams.
Then people will walk across it in sandals.
16 There will be a highway for the rest of his people who are left, from Assyria.
It will be like the highway for Israel
on the day Israel came up out of the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The new king from the "root of Jesse" will be like a flag that draws all peoples. Paul quotes this verse: The nations too will hope in him (Romans 15:12).

Verses 11–12: God will bring his scattered people back from all countries, "from the four corners of the earth." Pathros is Upper Egypt, Cush is today's Sudan, Elam lies in today's Iran, Shinar is Babylonia.

Verse 13: The divided people, the northern kingdom (Ephraim) and the southern kingdom (Judah), will be reconciled again.

Verse 14: Here the language of that time speaks of victory over the neighboring peoples. That is no permission for conquests today. In the context of the chapter, it is about God's kingdom of peace (verses 6–9).

Verses 15–16: As back then at the exodus from Egypt, God will make a way, a new exodus.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 12

A song of thanks

God is my salvation VERSES 1–6

1 On that day you will say,
"I thank you, LORD,
for though you were angry with me,
your anger has turned away, and you comfort me.
2 Look, God is my salvation.
I will trust and not be afraid,
for Yah, the LORD, is my strength and my song,
and he has become my salvation."
3 So with joy you will draw water
from the wells of salvation.
4 On that day you will say,
"Give thanks to the LORD! Call on his name!
Make his deeds known among the peoples!
Announce that his name is lifted up!
5 Sing to the LORD, for he has done glorious things!
Let this be known in all the earth!
6 Shout and sing for joy, you who live in Zion,
for the Holy One of Israel is great among you!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This short song of thanks closes the first great part of the book (chapters 1–12). After judgment and distress, praise

and joy come at the end.

Verse 1: God's anger is not the last word. He comforts again.

Verse 2: "The LORD is my strength and my song": These words also appear in the song of Moses after crossing the sea (Exodus 15:2).

Verse 3: "Draw water from the wells of salvation": A beautiful picture of the joy over God's help. In earlier times, water was drawn at the Jewish Festival of Booths. To this day, people in Israel sing a cheerful song with this verse: "U-sh'avtem mayim be-sason."

Verse 6: The most beautiful thing: The holy God lives in the midst of his people.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 13

The judgment on Babylon

The day of the LORD is coming VERSES 1–16

1 The burden about Babylon, which Isaiah, the son of
Amoz, saw.
2 Set up a banner on the bare mountain!
Raise your voice to them!
Wave your hand, so that they go in through the gates
of the nobles!
3 I have given orders to my holy ones.
Yes, I have called my mighty men for my anger,
those who proudly rejoice.
4 The noise of a crowd is on the mountains,
as of a great people.
The noise of the uproar of kingdoms,
of nations gathered together!
The LORD of Armies is gathering the army for battle.
5 They come from a distant land,
from the farthest end of the sky,
the LORD and the weapons of his fury,
to destroy the whole land.
6 Wail, for the day of the LORD is near!
It will come like destruction from the Almighty.
7 So all hands will go limp,
and every person's heart will melt.
8 They will be terrified.
Pains and pangs will seize them.
They will writhe like a woman in labor.
They will stare at one another in horror.
Their faces will glow like flames.
9 Look, the day of the LORD is coming,
cruel, with fury and fierce anger,
to make the land a wasteland
and to destroy its sinners from it.
10 For the stars of the sky and their constellations
will not give their light.
The sun will be dark when it rises,
and the moon will not let its light shine.
11 I will punish the world for its evil
and the wicked for their guilt.
I will put an end to the arrogance of the proud
and bring low the pride of the violent.
12 I will make people rarer than fine gold,
a person rarer than the pure gold of Ophir.
13 So I will make the heavens tremble,
and the earth will be shaken from its place
by the fury of the LORD of Armies
on the day of his fierce anger.
14 It will happen: Like a hunted gazelle
and like sheep that no one gathers,
each one will turn to his own people,
and each one will flee to his own land.
15 Everyone who is found will be stabbed.
Everyone who is caught will fall by the sword.
16 Their little children will also be smashed before their
eyes.
Their houses will be looted, and their wives raped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From chapter 13 on, there are words about foreign peoples (up to chapter 23). The first one is aimed at Babylon, the greatest and proudest empire.

"The burden": That is what prophetic words about peoples are called. A heavy message that the prophet must carry.

Verses 6–13: The "day of the LORD" is described like the end of the world: The sun, the moon and the stars grow dark, the earth shakes. This is picture language for a mighty overthrow. Jesus uses similar pictures (Matthew 24:29).

Verses 15–16: These verses are horrifying. They describe what happened to the defeated in war back then: Children were killed, women were raped. The prophet makes nothing look better than it is.

Important: These verses describe the cruelty of war. They are no permission and no approval. Violence against children and rape are always serious crimes, in war as in peace. Today, under international law, they are war crimes.

If you have experienced sexual violence yourself: In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The Medes are coming VERSES 17–22

17 Look, I will stir up the Medes against them,
who do not care about silver
and take no pleasure in gold.
18 Their bows will smash the young men.
They will have no pity on the fruit of the womb.
Their eyes will not spare the children.
19 Babylon, the jewel of kingdoms,
the proud beauty of the Chaldeans,
will be like when God destroyed Sodom and
Gomorrah.
20 It will never be lived in again,
and no one will live there from generation to
generation.
The Arab will not pitch a tent there,
and shepherds will not let their flocks rest there.

21 But wild animals of the desert will rest there,
and their houses will be full of jackals.
Ostriches will live there,
and wild goats will leap about there.
22 Hyenas will howl in their fortresses
and jackals in the splendid palaces.
Her time is near,
and her days will not be made longer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: The Medes lived in what is today Iran. Together with the Persians, they conquered Babylon in the year 539 BC. They cannot be bribed with money.

Verse 18: Again a description of terrible violence in war. Here too: This is no approval, but a description of how cruel wars are.

Verses 19–22: Splendid Babylon becomes a ruin where only wild animals live. In fact, the city fell apart over the centuries. Today only ruins can be seen in Iraq.

The message: Even the mightiest empire in the world passes away if it is proud and cruel.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 14

How you have fallen from heaven!

God has mercy on Israel VERSES 1–4

1 For the LORD will have mercy on Jacob,
and will choose Israel again,
and settle them in their own land.
The foreigner will join them,
and they will unite with the house of Jacob.
2 The peoples will take them
and bring them to their place.
The house of Israel will possess them in the LORD's land
as male and female servants.
They will take captive those whose captives they were,
and they will rule over their oppressors.
3 It will happen on the day
when the LORD gives you rest from your pain,
from your trouble, and from the hard labor
that you were forced to do,
4 that you will sing this mocking song against the king of Babylon
and say,
"How the oppressor has come to an end!
The golden city has come to an end!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the judgment on Babylon comes freedom for Israel. God brings his people back into their land.

Verse 1: Remarkable: Foreigners too will join Israel. God's people are open to others.

Verse 2: The roles are reversed: Those who were once oppressed now rule over their oppressors. That is the language of that time. But the Bible also shows that God does not want new injustice (compare Leviticus 19:33–34: You shall love the foreigner as yourself).

A mocking song about the king of Babylon VERSES 5–21

5 The LORD has broken the rod of the wicked,
the scepter of the rulers,
6 who struck the peoples in fury
with blows that never stopped,
who ruled the nations in anger
with a persecution that no one held back.
7 The whole earth is at rest and is quiet.
They break out in song.
8 Yes, even the cypress trees rejoice with you,
together with the cedars of Lebanon, and say,
"Since you were laid low,
no woodcutter has come up against us."
9 Sheol, the world of the dead below, is stirred up because of you,
to meet you when you arrive.
It wakes up the spirits of the dead for you,
all the rulers of the earth.
It makes all the kings of the nations rise from their thrones.
10 They will all answer and ask you,
"Have you also become as weak as we are?
Have you become like us?"
11 Your splendor has been brought down to Sheol,
with the sound of your harps.
Maggots are spread out under you,
and worms cover you.
12 How you have fallen from heaven,
shining one, son of the dawn!
How you have been cut down to the ground,
you who laid the nations low!
13 You said in your heart,
"I will go up into heaven!
I will raise my throne above the stars of God!
I will sit on the mountain of assembly,
in the far north!
14 I will go up above the heights of the clouds!
I will make myself like the Most High!"
15 Yet you will be brought down to Sheol,
to the depths of the pit.
16 Those who see you will stare at you.
They will think about you and say,
"Is this the man who made the earth tremble,
who shook kingdoms,
17 who made the world a wilderness
and destroyed its cities,
who did not let his prisoners go home?"
18 All the kings of the nations lie in honor,
each one in his own tomb.
19 But you are thrown out of your grave
like a disgusting branch,
covered with the dead who were stabbed with the

sword,
who go down to the stones of the pit,
like a dead body trampled underfoot.
20 You will not be joined with them in burial,
because you have destroyed your land.
You have killed your people.
The children of evildoers will never be named again.
21 Prepare a place of slaughter for his sons
because of the guilt of their fathers,
so that they do not rise up and take over the earth
and fill the surface of the world with cities.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A bitterly mocking song about the tyrant of Babylon.

Verses 7–8: When he dies, the whole world breathes a sigh of relief. Even the trees are glad, because no one comes anymore to cut them down for war machines.

Verses 9–11: In the world of the dead, the other dead kings greet him with mockery: Now you are as weak as we are! Instead of on silk, he lies on maggots.

Verse 12: "Shining one, son of the dawn": the morning star, which shines brightly and then fades. The Latin Bible translated this with "Lucifer" (light bearer). Later, people applied this verse to the fall of the devil. The text itself is about the proud king of Babylon.

Verses 13–14: His pride knew no limits: He wanted to be like God. That is why he falls so deep.

Verses 18–20: Other kings get an honorable grave, he does not. Because he killed his own people.

Verse 21: A harsh verse about the tyrant's sons. It expresses: His violent rule must not go on. This is no permission to punish children for what their parents did. Elsewhere, the Bible says clearly: Children are not to die for the guilt of their fathers (Deuteronomy 24:16; Ezekiel 18:20).

God's plan stands firm VERSES 22–27

22 "I will rise up against them," says the LORD of Armies,
"and cut off from Babylon name and remnant,
son and grandson," says the LORD.
23 "I will also make it a home for the porcupine
and pools of water.
I will sweep it away with the broom of destruction,"
says the LORD of Armies.
24 The LORD of Armies has sworn and said,
"Surely, as I have thought, so it will happen,
and as I have decided, so it will stand:
25 I will break the Assyrian in my land
and trample him on my mountains.
Then his yoke will leave them,
and his burden will leave their shoulders.
26 This is the plan that is decided for the whole earth.
This is the hand that is stretched out over all the
nations.
27 For the LORD of Armies has decided it,
and who can stop it?
His hand is stretched out,
and who can turn it back?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Babylon becomes a wilderness; only porcupines and pools of water are left.

Verses 24–27: Assyria too will be broken. God has a plan for the whole world. No person and no power can stop it.

Assyria was in fact driven back from Jerusalem in the year 701 BC (chapter 37), and it collapsed about 100 years later.

Don't rejoice too soon, Philistia VERSES 28–32

28 This burden came in the year that King Ahaz died.
29 Don't rejoice, all of Philistia,
because the rod that struck you is broken.
For an adder will come out of the snake's root,
and its fruit will be a fiery flying serpent.
30 The firstborn of the poor will eat,
and the needy will lie down in safety.
But I will kill your root with hunger,
and your remnant will be killed.
31 Wail, gate! Cry out, city!
You are melting away, all of Philistia!
For smoke is coming from the north,
and there is no one lagging behind in its ranks.
32 What will they answer the messengers of the nation?
That the LORD has founded Zion,
and that the afflicted of his people find refuge in her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines are glad because an enemy has died. But Isaiah warns: Don't rejoice too soon! An even more dangerous enemy will come.

Verse 29: "An adder" and "a fiery flying serpent" are pictures of more and more dangerous enemies.

Verses 30 and 32: A hope in the middle of judgment: The poor will be safe. In Zion, with God, the afflicted find refuge.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 15

Lament over Moab

Moab weeps VERSES 1–9

1 The burden about Moab.
For in one night, Ar of Moab is ruined and destroyed.
For in one night, Kir of Moab is ruined and destroyed.
2 They have gone up to Bayith and to Dibon,
to the high places, to weep.
Moab wails over Nebo and over Medeba.
Every head is shaved bald.
Every beard is cut off.
3 In their streets, they put on sackcloth.
In their streets and on their roofs, everyone wails
and melts into tears.
4 Heshbon cries out with Elealeh.
Their voice is heard as far as Jahaz.
So the soldiers of Moab cry out loud.
Their souls tremble within them.

5 My heart cries out for Moab!
Her nobles flee to Zoar, to Eglath Shelishiyah.
For they go up the slope of Luhith weeping.
For on the road to Horonaim,
they raise a cry over the destruction.
6 For the waters of Nimrim will be a wasteland.
For the grass has dried up, the young grass is gone,
there is nothing green anymore.
7 So they carry away the riches they have gained
and what they have stored up
across the Brook of the Willows.
8 For the cry has gone around the borders of Moab.
Its wailing reaches to Eglaim,
and its wailing to Beer Elim.
9 For the waters of Dimon are full of blood.
For I will bring even more on Dimon:
a lion on those of Moab who escape
and on the rest of the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab was a neighboring people of Israel, east of the Dead Sea, in what is today Jordan. The Moabites were related to Israel (Genesis 19:37). David's great-grandmother Ruth was a Moabite.

One city after another is destroyed in a single night. The people mourn: They shave their hair, cut off their beards, put on mourning clothes.

Verse 5: What is special: The prophet weeps with them! "My heart cries out for Moab!" Even though Moab was often an enemy, Isaiah feels with the suffering people. God's prophet does not rejoice over the misfortune of other peoples.

Verse 9: "The waters of Dimon": In Hebrew, Dimon sounds like "dam," blood. A play on words.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 16

Moab looks for refuge

Take in the refugees VERSES 1–5

1 Send the lambs for the ruler of the land
from Selah to the wilderness,
to the mountain of the daughter of Zion.
2 For it will be: Like birds fluttering about,
like a nest that has been scattered,
so the daughters of Moab will be at the fords of the
Arnon.
3 Give advice! Do justice!
Make your shade like the night in the middle of the
day!
Hide the outcasts!
Don't betray the refugee!
4 Let my outcasts live with you!
As for Moab, be a hiding place for him from the
destroyer!
For the one who squeezes others is gone.
The destruction stops.
The oppressors have disappeared from the land.
5 A throne will be set up in loving kindness.
Someone will sit on it in faithfulness,
in the tent of David,
who judges and seeks justice
and is quick to do what is right.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Moabites are fleeing. They are like startled birds at the Arnon River, the border of their land.

Verse 1: Moab is to send gifts to Jerusalem and ask for protection.

Verses 3–4: A moving call: Take in the refugees! Give them shade as in the night! Hide them! Don't betray them! This text is one of the strongest pleas in the Bible for protecting refugees.

Verse 5: A future king from David's family will rule with kindness, faithfulness and justice. Foreigners too will find refuge with him.

Lament over Moab's pride VERSES 6–14

6 We have heard of the pride of Moab, that he is very
proud,
of his arrogance, his pride, and his anger.
His bragging is nothing.
7 So Moab will wail for Moab.
Everyone will wail.
You will mourn for the raisin cakes of Kir Hareseth,
completely crushed.
8 For the fields of Heshbon have withered,
and the vine of Sibmah.
The lords of the nations have broken down its best
branches,
which reached as far as Jazer,
which spread into the wilderness.
Its shoots spread out.
They went across the sea.
9 So I will weep with the weeping of Jazer
for the vine of Sibmah.
I will water you with my tears, Heshbon and Elealeh,
for the battle cry has fallen
on your summer fruits and on your harvest.
10 Gladness and joy are taken away from the fertile field.
In the vineyards there is no more singing and no
shouting for joy.
No one treads out wine in the winepresses anymore.
I have put an end to the shouting.
11 So my heart sounds like a harp for Moab,
and my inner being for Kir Heres.
12 It will happen: When Moab appears,
when he wears himself out on the high place
and comes to his sanctuary to pray,
he will get nowhere.
13 This is the word that the LORD spoke about Moab in the
past.
14 But now the LORD has spoken and said,
"Within three years, as a worker under contract
would count them,

the glory of Moab will be despised,
with all his great crowds,
and the rest will be very small and weak."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Moab's problem was its pride.

Verses 7–10: Moab was famous for its vineyards. Now everything is destroyed. No more happy songs at the grape harvest.

Verses 9 and 11: Again the prophet weeps with them. His heart sounds sad like a harp. God's compassion is also for foreign peoples.

Verse 14: "As a worker under contract would count them": A worker counts the days of his contract exactly, not one day more and not one day less. That is how exactly God's word will come true.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 17

Damascus and the raging nations

Damascus will become a heap of ruins VERSES 1–6

1 The burden about Damascus.
"Look, Damascus will stop being a city
and will become a heap of ruins.
2 The cities of Aroer are abandoned.
They will belong to the flocks,
which will lie down there, and no one will scare them away.
3 The fortress will disappear from Ephraim,
and the kingdom from Damascus,
and the rest of Syria.
They will be like the glory of the people of Israel,"
says the LORD of Armies.
4 "On that day it will happen
that the glory of Jacob will grow thin,
and the fat of his body will grow lean.
5 It will be like when a harvester gathers the wheat
and cuts the heads of grain with his arm.
Yes, it will be like when someone gathers leftover grain in the Valley of Rephaim.
6 Yet some leftovers will remain there,
like when an olive tree is beaten:
two or three olives at the very top,
four or five on the outermost branches of the fruitful tree,"
says the LORD, the God of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Damascus was the capital of Syria. Together with the northern kingdom of Israel (Ephraim), it had attacked Jerusalem (chapter 7). Now Isaiah announces: Both will fall. That happened when Assyria conquered Damascus in the year 732 and Samaria in the year 722 BC.

Verses 5–6: A picture from the harvest: After the harvest, only a few heads of grain are left in the field and a few olives at the very top of the tree. In the same way, only a small remnant will be left. But a remnant will be left.

They will look to their Maker VERSES 7–11

7 On that day, people will look to their Maker,
and their eyes will look to the Holy One of Israel.
8 They will not look to the altars, the work of their hands,
and they will not pay attention to what their fingers have made,
neither the Asherah poles nor the incense altars.
9 On that day, their strong cities will be
like the abandoned places in the forest and on the mountaintop,
which were abandoned before the people of Israel,
and it will be a wasteland.
10 For you have forgotten the God of your salvation
and have not remembered the rock of your strength.
So you plant pleasant plants
and set out foreign seedlings.
11 On the day you plant, you fence them in.
In the morning you make your seed blossom,
but the harvest flees away on the day of grief
and of hopeless sorrow.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: In their distress, people will turn back to their Maker instead of to idols they made themselves. Asherah was a goddess whose sign was a wooden pole.

Verses 10–11: "Pleasant plants" and "foreign seedlings": This probably means small gardens for foreign fertility gods. They grow quickly, but bring no harvest. Whoever forgets God sows on sand.

The roaring of the nations VERSES 12–14

12 Oh, the roaring of many peoples,
who roar like the roaring of the seas,
and the rushing of nations,
who rush like the rushing of mighty waters!
13 The nations rush like the rushing of many waters,
but he will rebuke them, and they will flee far away
and be chased like chaff on the mountains before the wind
and like whirling dust before the storm.
14 In the evening, look, terror!
Before morning, they are gone.
This is the share of those who plunder us,
and the lot of those who rob us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The enemy peoples rage against Jerusalem like a wild sea. But one word from God is enough, and they blow away like chaff in the wind.

Verse 14: Fear in the evening, and in the morning the enemy has disappeared. That is exactly what happened later, when the Assyrian army in front of Jerusalem was gone overnight (Isaiah 37:36).

Chapter 18

A word to Cush

The land of whirring wings VERSES 1–7

1 Oh, land of whirring wings,
which lies beyond the rivers of Ethiopia,
2 which sends messengers by the sea,
in boats of papyrus on the waters, and says,
"Go, you swift messengers,
to a people tall and smooth-skinned,
to a people feared from their beginning on,
a nation that measures out and tramples down,
whose land the rivers divide!"
3 All you people of the world, you who live on the earth:
When a banner is raised on the mountains, look!
When the trumpet is blown, listen!
4 For this is what the LORD said to me:
"I will be still and watch from my dwelling place,
like shimmering heat in the sunshine,
like a cloud of dew in the heat of harvest."
5 For before the harvest, when the blossom is over
and the flower becomes a ripening grape,
he will cut off the shoots with pruning knives
and cut down and take away the spreading branches.
6 They will all be left to the birds of prey of the mountains
and to the animals of the earth.
The birds of prey will feed on them in the summer,
and all the animals of the earth in the winter.
7 At that time, a gift will be brought to the LORD of Armies
from a people tall and smooth-skinned,
from a people feared from their beginning on,
a nation that measures out and tramples down,
whose land the rivers divide,
to the place of the name of the LORD of Armies,
Mount Zion.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cush lay south of Egypt, in what is today Sudan. The WEB, our English source text, says "Ethiopia" here. At that time, kings from Cush also ruled over Egypt.

"The land of whirring wings": Perhaps this means the many insects along the Nile. The people there were tall, proud and famous for their strength.

Verse 2: The people of Cush send messengers in light papyrus boats to form an alliance against Assyria. But Isaiah says: Don't rely on alliances.

Verse 4: At first God watches calmly, like the sun in the midday heat. He has time. But at the right time he steps in, like a vinedresser who prunes the vines (verse 5).

Verse 7: In the end, even this distant, proud people comes to Jerusalem and brings gifts to God. All peoples will come to God. Acts 8:26–39 tells how a man from Cush (Ethiopia) goes on a pilgrimage to Jerusalem and is baptized.

Chapter 19

Blessed be Egypt, my people

Judgment on Egypt VERSES 1–15

1 The burden about Egypt.
"Look, the LORD is riding on a swift cloud
and is coming to Egypt.
The idols of Egypt will tremble before him,
and the heart of Egypt will melt within it.
2 I will stir up Egyptians against Egyptians,
and they will fight, each against his brother
and each against his neighbor,
city against city and kingdom against kingdom.
3 The spirit of the Egyptians will fail within them.
I will bring their plans to nothing.
They will consult the idols, the magicians,
those who talk to the spirits of the dead, and the fortune-tellers.
4 I will hand the Egyptians over to a cruel master.
A fierce king will rule over them,"
says the Lord, the LORD of Armies.
5 The waters of the sea will fail,
and the river will dry up and be empty.
6 The rivers will stink.
The streams of Egypt will shrink and dry up.
The reeds and rushes will wither.
7 The meadows by the Nile, on the bank of the Nile,
and all the sown fields of the Nile will dry up,
blow away, and be gone.
8 The fishermen will lament,
and all who fish in the Nile will mourn,
and those who spread nets on the water will waste away.
9 Also those who work with combed flax
and those who weave white cloth will be put to shame.
10 The pillars will be broken to pieces.
All who work for wages will be deeply sad.
11 The princes of Zoan are completely foolish.
The advice of Pharaoh's wisest advisers has become stupid.
How can you say to Pharaoh,
"I am a son of the wise, a son of ancient kings"?
12 Where are your wise men, then?
Let them tell you now,
and let them know what the LORD of Armies has planned for Egypt.
13 The princes of Zoan have become fools.
The princes of Memphis are deceived.

They have led Egypt astray,
they who are the cornerstone of her tribes.
14 The LORD has mixed a spirit of confusion within her,
and they have led Egypt astray in all it does,
as a drunk man staggers in his vomit.
15 There will be no work for Egypt
that head or tail, palm branch or reed, can do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Egypt was a great power and again and again a tempting partner for an alliance for Judah. Isaiah says: Egypt itself will fall into chaos.

Verse 1: God "is riding on a swift cloud." The gods of Egypt tremble before him.

Verse 2: Civil war tears the land apart.

Verses 5–10: The Nile was Egypt's lifeline. If it dries up, everything is lost: farming, fishing, weaving. The economy collapses.

Verses 11–14: The famous wise men of Egypt no longer know what to do. Their wisdom is worth nothing without God.

Egypt will come to know the LORD VERSES 16–25

16 On that day, the Egyptians will be like women.
They will tremble and be afraid
of the waving of the hand of the LORD of Armies,
which he waves over them.
17 The land of Judah will be a terror to Egypt.
Everyone who hears about it will be afraid
because of the plan that the LORD of Armies has
decided against it.
18 On that day, there will be five cities in the land of Egypt
that speak the language of Canaan
and swear by the LORD of Armies.
One will be called "The city of destruction."
19 On that day, there will be an altar to the LORD
in the middle of the land of Egypt,
and a pillar to the LORD at its border.
20 It will be a sign and a witness to the LORD of Armies
in the land of Egypt.
For they will cry out to the LORD because of their
oppressors,
and he will send them a savior and a defender,
and he will rescue them.
21 The LORD will make himself known to Egypt,
and the Egyptians will know the LORD on that day.
Yes, they will worship him with sacrifices and
offerings,
and they will make vows to the LORD and keep them.
22 The LORD will strike Egypt, striking and healing.
They will turn back to the LORD,
and he will listen to their prayers and heal them.
23 On that day, there will be a highway from Egypt to
Assyria.
The Assyrian will come to Egypt,
and the Egyptian to Assyria,
and the Egyptians will worship together with the
Assyrians.
24 On that day, Israel will be the third
together with Egypt and with Assyria,
a blessing in the middle of the earth,
25 because the LORD of Armies has blessed them and said,
"Blessed be Egypt, my people,
Assyria, the work of my hands,
and Israel, my inheritance."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: "Like women": Back then, women were thought to be weak and fearful. That is a prejudice of that time, not a judgment of the Bible about women. The Bible tells of many brave women.

Verses 18–25 are among the most amazing verses of the whole Old Testament.

Of all peoples, Egypt, where Israel lived as slaves, and Assyria, the most brutal enemy, will come to know God and worship him.

Verse 20: Just as Israel once cried out to God in Egypt, now the Egyptians themselves will cry out to God, and he will send a savior to them too.

Verse 22: God "strikes and heals." His judgment has healing as its goal.

Verse 23: A highway connects the old archenemies. They travel to each other and pray together.

Verse 25: God calls Egypt "my people" and Assyria "the work of my hands," titles that otherwise only Israel has. God's blessing is for all peoples. A vision of peace and reconciliation between enemy nations that still gives hope today.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 20

Naked and barefoot

A sign against Egypt and Cush VERSES 1–6

1 In the year that Tartan came to Ashdod,
when Sargon, the king of Assyria, sent him,
and he fought against Ashdod and captured it,
2 at that time the LORD spoke through Isaiah, the son of
Amoz:
"Go and take the sackcloth off your waist,
and take your sandals off your feet."
He did so, and walked around naked and barefoot.
3 The LORD said,
"Just as my servant Isaiah has walked naked and
barefoot for three years
as a sign and a wonder about Egypt and about Ethiopia,
4 so the king of Assyria will lead away the captives of
Egypt
and the exiles of Ethiopia,
young and old, naked and barefoot,
with their buttocks uncovered,
to the shame of Egypt.
5 They will be terrified and put to shame
because of Ethiopia, which they hoped in,
and because of Egypt, which they boasted about.

6 On that day, the people of this coastland will say,
'Look, this is what happened to our hope,
to which we ran for help
to be rescued from the king of Assyria.
And we, how will we escape?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the year 711 BC, the Assyrian army commander ("Tartan" is a title) conquered the Philistine city of Ashdod. The Philistines had hoped for help from Egypt.

Isaiah has to act out a sign: For three years he walks around naked, that is, only in a loincloth, and barefoot like a prisoner of war. For a respected man, that was a great humiliation.

The message: That is how the Egyptians and the people of Cush will be led away as prisoners. Whoever trusts in Egypt will be disappointed.

The WEB, our English source text, says "Ethiopia." This means Cush, south of Egypt.

Prophets often did not only speak, but also acted out their message, so that people could not overlook it.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 21

Watchman, what of the night?

Babylon has fallen VERSES 1–10

1 The burden about the wilderness of the sea.
As whirlwinds sweep through the South,
so it comes from the wilderness, from a terrible land.
2 A harsh vision has been shown to me.
The traitor betrays, and the destroyer destroys.
Go up, Elam! Attack!
I have put an end to all the sighing of Media.
3 So my body is filled with anguish.
Pains have seized me like the pains of a woman in labor.
I am in so much pain that I cannot hear.
I am so shaken that I cannot see.
4 My heart flutters.
Horror has terrified me.
The twilight I longed for
has turned into trembling for me.
5 They set the table.
They post the guard.
They eat. They drink.
Get up, you princes, oil the shield!
6 For the Lord said to me,
"Go, post a watchman.
Let him report what he sees.
7 When he sees a troop, horsemen in pairs,
a troop of donkeys, a troop of camels,
he must listen carefully, with great attention."
8 He cried out like a lion,
"Lord, I stand on the watchtower all day long,
and every night I stay at my post.
9 Look, here comes a troop of men, horsemen in pairs."
He answered,
"Fallen, fallen is Babylon,
and all the carved images of her gods are smashed to the ground.
10 You are the grain I have threshed, the grain of my threshing floor!"
What I have heard from the LORD of Armies,
the God of Israel, I have announced to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The wilderness of the sea" means Babylon, which lay on a plain by the Euphrates.

Verse 2: Elam and Media (in what is today Iran) attack Babylon.

Verses 3–4: The vision is so terrible that the prophet suffers in his body.

Verse 5: While the enemy is coming, the princes of Babylon are still celebrating a feast. Daniel 5 tells of such a feast in the night when Babylon fell.

Verses 6–9: A watchman stands on the tower, day and night. Finally he sees the messengers and cries out: "Fallen, fallen is Babylon!" This cry is taken up again in the Revelation to John (Revelation 14:8; 18:2).

Verse 10: God comforts his people, who were "threshed" like grain: Your oppressors have fallen.

Watchman, what of the night? VERSES 11–12

11 The burden about Dumah.
Someone calls to me from Seir,
"Watchman, what of the night?
Watchman, what of the night?"
12 The watchman said,
"The morning is coming, but also the night.
If you want to ask, then ask.
Come back again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A short, mysterious word. Dumah and Seir lie in Edom, south of the Dead Sea.

Someone calls out in despair in the night: Watchman, how much longer will the night last? How much longer will this hard time last?

The answer is honest: The morning is coming, but then another night will come too. Good and hard times take turns. Keep asking, come back!

Many people have asked this question in dark times. To this day, it is a picture of waiting for hope.

About Arabia VERSES 13–17

13 The burden about Arabia.
You will spend the night in the thickets in Arabia,
you caravans of the Dedanites.
14 They brought water to the thirsty.
The people of the land of Tema met the refugees with bread.
15 For they have fled from the swords,
from the drawn sword, from the bent bow,
and from the fury of battle.

16 For this is what the Lord said to me:
"Within a year, as a worker under contract would count it,
all the glory of Kedar will come to an end,
17 and the rest of the number of archers,
the mighty men of the people of Kedar, will be few,
for the LORD, the God of Israel, has spoken it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Arab tribes (Dedan, Tema, Kedar) are struck by war. The caravans have to hide in the bushes.

Verse 14: A beautiful detail: The people of Tema bring water and bread to the refugees. Hospitality toward refugees is a sign of humanity that the Bible praises.

Verse 16: Within a year, Kedar's power will be broken.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 22

The valley of vision

Jerusalem celebrates instead of mourning VERSES 1–14

1 The burden about the valley of vision.
What is the matter with you, that you have all gone up to the rooftops?
2 You noisy, wild city, you cheerful town:
Your dead were not killed by the sword,
and they did not die in battle.
3 All your leaders fled together.
They were tied up by the archers.
All of you who were found were tied up together.
They fled far away.
4 So I said, "Look away from me!
I will weep bitterly.
Don't try to comfort me
about the destruction of the daughter of my people.
5 For it is a day of confusion, of trampling, and of panic
from the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
in the valley of vision,
a tearing down of the walls
and a crying out to the mountains."
6 Elam carried the quiver,
with chariots full of men and horsemen,
and Kir uncovered the shield.
7 Your finest valleys were full of chariots,
and the horsemen took their positions at the gate.
8 He took away Judah's protective cover.
And on that day you looked to the weapons in the House of the Forest.
9 You saw that the cracks in the walls of the city of David were many,
and you collected the water of the lower pool.
10 You counted the houses of Jerusalem,
and you tore down houses to strengthen the wall.
11 You also made a reservoir between the two walls
for the water of the old pool.
But you did not look to the one who had done this,
and you did not pay attention to the one who planned it long ago.
12 On that day, the Lord, the LORD of Armies, called
for weeping, for mourning, for shaving the head,
and for putting on sackcloth.
13 But look, there is joy and celebration,
killing cattle and killing sheep,
eating meat and drinking wine:
"Let's eat and drink, for tomorrow we die!"
14 The LORD of Armies revealed himself in my ears:
"Surely this guilt will not be forgiven you until you die,"
says the Lord, the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The valley of vision" is Jerusalem, the city where God gave visions through prophets.

Verses 1–3: The city celebrates on the rooftops. Perhaps because the enemy has withdrawn. But Isaiah sees: The leaders have fled like cowards and have been captured. There is no reason to celebrate.

Verse 4: Isaiah weeps bitterly over his people.

Verses 8–11: The people prepare wisely for war: weapons from the armory (the "House of the Forest"), repairing walls, securing water. At that time, Hezekiah had a water tunnel built, which can still be seen in Jerusalem today (2 Kings 20:20). But the people have forgotten God, who holds everything in his hands.

Verse 13: "Let's eat and drink, for tomorrow we die!" Instead of turning back, they celebrate pointlessly. Paul quotes this sentence (1 Corinthians 15:32).

Verse 14: A very harsh sentence. It shows how seriously God takes this indifference.

Shebna and Eliakim VERSES 15–25

15 This is what the Lord, the LORD of Armies, says:
"Go to this steward,
to Shebna, who is in charge of the palace, and say,
16 'What are you doing here?
Who do you have here, that you have cut out a tomb for yourself here?'
He cuts out a tomb for himself up high
and chisels a home for himself in the rock!
17 Look, the LORD will overpower you
and hurl you away violently.
Yes, he will grab you firmly.
18 He will surely roll you up tightly
and throw you like a ball into a wide land.
There you will die,
and there your splendid chariots will be,
you disgrace to your master's house.
19 I will push you out of your office.
You will be pulled down from your position.
20 On that day it will happen
that I will call my servant Eliakim, the son of Hilkiah.
21 I will dress him in your robe
and strengthen him with your belt.
I will put your authority into his hand,

and he will be a father to the people of Jerusalem
and to the house of Judah.
22 I will lay the key of the house of David on his shoulder.
He will open, and no one will shut.
He will shut, and no one will open.
23 I will fasten him like a nail in a firm place.
He will be a throne of honor for his father's house.
24 They will hang on him all the glory of his father's
house,
the children and the descendants,
all the small vessels,
from the cups to all the jars.
25 On that day," says the LORD of Armies,
"the nail that was fastened in a firm place will give way.
It will be cut down and fall.
The load that hung on it will be cut off,
for the LORD has spoken it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shebna was a high official at the royal court. While the land is in danger, he has a splendid tomb cut into the rock for himself, so that he will be honored after his death. He only thinks of himself.

Verses 17–19: God will remove him from office and throw him far away like a ball.

Verses 20–22: In his place comes Eliakim. He is to be "a father" to the people. He receives the key to the palace.

Verse 22: "He will open, and no one will shut": In Revelation, this sentence is applied to Jesus (Revelation 3:7).

Verses 23–25: Eliakim is like a firm nail in the wall. But when the whole family hangs on him and wants to profit from him, even this nail will break out. A warning against favoring your relatives.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 23

The word about Tyre

Wail, you ships! VERSES 1–14

1 The burden about Tyre.
Wail, you ships of Tarshish!
For it is ruined, so that there is no house left and no
harbor to enter.
It has been revealed to them from the land of Kittim.
2 Be silent, you people of the coast,
whom the merchants of Sidon, who sail over the sea,
have made rich.
3 On great waters, the grain of the Shihor,
the harvest of the Nile, was her income.
She was the marketplace of the nations.
4 Be ashamed, Sidon,
for the sea has spoken, the fortress of the sea, saying,
"I have not been in labor or given birth,
I have not raised young men
or brought up young women."
5 When the news comes to Egypt,
they will be in anguish over the news about Tyre.
6 Cross over to Tarshish!
Wail, you people of the coast!
7 Is this your cheerful city,
whose beginning goes back to ancient days,
whose feet have carried her far away on her travels?
8 Who has planned this against Tyre,
the giver of crowns,
whose merchants were princes,
whose traders were the honored people of the earth?
9 The LORD of Armies has planned it,
to disgrace the pride of all glory
and to bring all the honored people of the earth into
contempt.
10 Pass through your land like the Nile, daughter of
Tarshish.
There is no barrier anymore.
11 He has stretched out his hand over the sea.
He has shaken the kingdoms.
The LORD has ordered the destruction of the
fortresses of Canaan.
12 He said, "You will no longer rejoice,
you oppressed virgin daughter of Sidon.
Get up, cross over to Kittim.
Even there you will have no rest."
13 Look at the land of the Chaldeans.
This people did not exist.
The Assyrians founded it for those who live in the
wilderness.
They set up their siege towers.
They destroyed its palaces.
They made it a ruin.
14 Wail, you ships of Tarshish,
for your fortress is ruined!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tyre and Sidon were rich port cities of the Phoenicians, in what is today Lebanon. Their ships sailed across the whole Mediterranean Sea as far as Tarshish, perhaps in what is today Spain. Kittim is Cyprus.

Tyre was a great center of trade, "the marketplace of the nations." They even traded grain from Egypt (verse 3).

Verse 4: The sea laments like a mother who no longer has children. The city is empty.

Verses 8–9: Who has brought down this rich city? God, to break the pride in wealth and power.

Verse 13: This verse is hard to understand. Perhaps it means: See what happened to Babylon (the land of the Chaldeans). The same will happen to you.

After 70 years VERSES 15–18

15 On that day it will happen
that Tyre will be forgotten for 70 years,
as long as the days of one king.
After the end of the 70 years, it will happen to Tyre
as in the song about the prostitute:

16 "Take a harp, go around the city,
you forgotten prostitute!
Play sweetly, sing many songs,
so that you will be remembered."
17 After the end of 70 years it will happen
that the LORD will visit Tyre.
She will go back to her wages
and act like a prostitute with all the kingdoms of the world on the earth.
18 But her profits and her wages will be holy to the LORD.
They will not be piled up or stored away,
for her profits will belong to those who live before the LORD,
so that they can eat their fill and have clothing that lasts.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After 70 years, a human lifetime, Tyre will flourish again.

Verses 15–17: Tyre's trade is compared with a prostitute who offers herself to anyone. This means: Tyre does business with everyone just to get rich, without asking about justice. This is a picture from the language of that time that criticizes ruthless trade without morals.

Verse 18: A surprising turn: In the end, the wealth of Tyre is no longer hoarded, but dedicated to God. It is used so that people have enough to eat and have clothing. A beautiful picture of how wealth can be used rightly.

With this, the words about the individual peoples (chapters 13–23) come to an end.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 24

The earth staggers

The whole earth will be ruined VERSES 1–13

1 Look, the LORD makes the earth empty and ruins it.
He turns it upside down and scatters its people.
2 It will be the same for the people as for the priest,
for the servant as for his master,
for the maid as for her mistress,
for the buyer as for the seller,
for the lender as for the borrower,
for the one who takes interest as for the one who pays interest.
3 The earth will be completely emptied and completely ruined,
for the LORD has spoken this word.
4 The earth mourns and fades away.
The world withers and fades away.
The high and mighty people of the earth wither.
5 The earth is also polluted by its people,
for they have broken the laws,
violated the rules,
and broken the everlasting covenant.
6 So the curse has eaten up the earth,
and those who live on it are found guilty.
So the people of the earth are burned,
and only a few people are left.
7 The new wine mourns.
The vine withers.
All who were cheerful sigh.
8 The joy of the tambourines stops.
The noise of those who celebrate ends.
The joy of the harp stops.
9 They no longer drink wine with a song.
Strong drink is bitter to those who drink it.
10 The city of confusion is broken down.
Every house is shut, so that no one can go in.
11 In the streets there is crying because of the wine.
All joy has grown dark.
The happiness of the land is gone.
12 The city is left in ruins,
and the gate is smashed to pieces.
13 For it will be like this in the middle of the earth among the peoples,
as when an olive tree is beaten,
as with the leftovers when the grape harvest is over.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With chapter 24, a part begins that is often called the "Isaiah Apocalypse" (chapters 24–27). It is no longer about individual peoples, but about the whole world.

Verse 2: The judgment strikes everyone alike: poor and rich, masters and servants. No one can buy their way out.

Verse 5: The reason: People have "broken the everlasting covenant." This reminds us of the covenant with Noah, which is for all people (Genesis 9). When people do wrong, the whole earth suffers with them. Today this can also be applied to the destruction of the environment.

Verses 7–11: All joy disappears: no more music, no more feasts, no more wine.

Verse 13: But as at the harvest, a remnant is left.

Praise from the end of the earth VERSES 14–16

14 These will raise their voices.
They will shout for joy over the majesty of the LORD.
They cry out loud from the sea.
15 So honor the LORD in the east,
the name of the LORD, the God of Israel, in the islands of the sea!
16 From the farthest end of the earth we have heard songs:
"Glory to the righteous!"
But I said, "I waste away! I waste away! How terrible for me!"
The unfaithful act unfaithfully.
Yes, the unfaithful act very unfaithfully.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of judgment, songs of praise are heard, from east to west, from the islands, from the end of the earth. The remnant that survived praises God.

Verse 16: But the prophet cannot rejoice with them yet. He still sees too much unfaithfulness and injustice.

Terror, pit, and trap VERSES 17–23

17 Terror, the pit, and the trap
are on you, people of the earth.
18 It will happen: Whoever flees from the sound of terror
will fall into the pit,
and whoever climbs up out of the pit
will be caught in the trap,
for the windows on high are opened,
and the foundations of the earth tremble.
19 The earth is completely broken.
The earth is torn apart.
The earth is shaken violently.
20 The earth will stagger like a drunk man
and sway back and forth like a hammock.
Its disobedience weighs heavily on it,
and it will fall and not rise again.
21 On that day it will happen
that the LORD will punish the army of the heights in the heights
and the kings of the earth on the earth.
22 They will be gathered together,
as prisoners are gathered in a pit,
and they will be locked up in prison,
and after many days they will be punished.
23 Then the moon will be put to shame and the sun disgraced,
for the LORD of Armies will reign as king
on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem,
and glory will be before his elders.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: There is no escape: Whoever escapes one disaster falls into the next. In Hebrew, the three words sound alike: "pachad, pachat, pach" (terror, pit, trap).

Verse 18: "The windows on high are opened": as in the great flood (Genesis 7:11).

Verse 20: The earth sways like a drunk man, back and forth like a hammock.

Verse 21: God judges not only the kings on earth, but also the powers "in the heights," that is, invisible powers that stand against God.

Verse 23: In the end, God himself rules as king. His light is so bright that the sun and moon fade beside it (compare Revelation 21:23).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 25

God will swallow up death forever

Praise for God's faithfulness VERSES 1–5

1 LORD, you are my God.
I will lift you up!
I will praise your name,
for you have done wonderful things,
plans made long ago,
in complete faithfulness and truth.
2 For you have made a city into a heap of stones,
a fortified city into a ruin,
a palace of foreigners into no city at all.
It will never be built again.
3 So a strong people will honor you.
A city of fierce nations will fear you.
4 For you have been a fortress for the poor,
a fortress for the needy in their distress,
a refuge from the storm,
a shade from the heat,
when the blast of the violent is like a storm against a wall.
5 Like heat in a dry land,
you quiet the noise of the foreigners.
Like heat by the shade of a cloud,
the victory song of the violent is silenced.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the judgment comes a song of praise. God has faithfully carried out his plans.

Verse 2: "A city": This means a city of violence and oppression, without a name. It stands for all powers that are against God and the weak.

Verse 4: A wonderful verse: God is a fortress for the poor, a refuge in the storm, a shade in the heat. Whoever is weak finds protection with God.

The great feast for all peoples VERSES 6–9

6 On this mountain, the LORD of Armies
will prepare a feast for all peoples,
a feast of fine food,
a feast of choice wines,
of fine food full of marrow,
of well-aged, choice wines.
7 On this mountain he will destroy the covering
that covers all peoples,
and the veil that is spread over all nations.
8 He has swallowed up death forever!
The Lord GOD will wipe away the tears from all faces.
He will take away the shame of his people from all the earth,
for the LORD has spoken it.
9 On that day people will say,
"Look, this is our God!
We have waited for him, and he will save us!
This is the LORD!
We have waited for him.
We will be glad and rejoice in his salvation!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most beautiful texts in the whole Bible.

Verse 6: God invites all peoples to a great feast on Mount Zion. The best food, the best wine. No one is left out. Jesus often speaks of the kingdom of God as a feast (Matthew 8:11; Luke 14:15–24).

Verse 7: The "covering" and the "veil" are perhaps veils of mourning. God takes the mourning away from all people.

Verse 8: "He has swallowed up death forever!" Death, which swallows everything, is itself swallowed up. And God himself wipes away every tear, as tenderly as a mother. Paul quotes this verse when he speaks of the resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:54). And Revelation takes it up: "He will wipe away every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death" (Revelation 21:4). This verse is often read at funerals.

Verse 9: "This is our God! We have waited for him." The long wait was worth it.

Moab will be brought low VERSES 10–12

10 For the hand of the LORD will rest on this mountain.
Moab will be trampled down where he is,
as straw is trampled down in the water of a manure pile.
11 He will spread out his hands in the middle of it,
as a swimmer spreads out his hands to swim,
but his pride will be humbled
together with the tricks of his hands.
12 He has torn down the high fortress of your walls,
brought it low, and brought it to the ground,
down to the dust.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Moab stands as an example of all who are proud. While the peoples celebrate on the mountain, pride sinks into the manure.

Verse 11: An almost funny picture: Moab tries desperately to swim, but it goes under.

The message: God's feast is open to everyone, but not to pride. Whoever raises himself above God shuts himself out.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 26

Your dead will live

A song about the strong city VERSES 1–6

1 On that day, this song will be sung in the land of Judah:
"We have a strong city.
God sets up salvation as its walls and ramparts.
2 Open the gates,
so that the righteous nation may enter,
the one that keeps faith.
3 You will keep in perfect peace
the one whose mind is steady,
because he trusts in you.
4 Trust in the LORD forever,
for in Yah, the LORD, is an everlasting Rock.
5 For he has brought down those who live on high,
the lofty city.
He brings it low.
He brings it low to the ground.
He brings it down to the dust.
6 The foot will trample it,
the feet of the poor
and the steps of the needy."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In contrast to the destroyed city of violence (Isaiah 25:2), here stands God's strong city. Its walls are not made of stone, but of God's salvation.

Verse 2: The gates open for all who are faithful.

Verse 3 is a well-known verse of comfort: Whoever trusts God finds "perfect peace." In Hebrew it says "shalom, shalom," double peace.

Verse 4: God is a rock that you can rely on forever.

Verse 6: The poor, who used to be trampled, now walk over the ruins of the proud city. Things are turned around.

At night I long for you VERSES 7–15

7 The way of the righteous is straight.
You, Upright One, make the path of the righteous level.
8 Yes, in the way of your judgments, LORD,
we have waited for you.
Your name and your fame
are the longing of our soul.
9 With my soul I have longed for you in the night.
Yes, with my spirit within me I will seek you eagerly,
for when your judgments are on the earth,
the people of the world learn righteousness.
10 If the wicked are shown kindness,
they still do not learn righteousness.
In the land of honesty they do wrong
and do not see the majesty of the LORD.
11 LORD, your hand is raised,
but they do not see it.
But they will see your zeal for the people and be disappointed.
Yes, fire will burn up your enemies.
12 LORD, you will give us peace,
for you have also done all our work for us.
13 LORD our God,
other lords besides you have ruled over us,
but we will only acknowledge your name.
14 The dead will not live.
The spirits of the dead will not rise.
That is why you have punished and destroyed them
and wiped out all memory of them.
15 You have made the nation grow, LORD.
You have made the nation grow!
You are glorified!
You have widened all the borders of the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–9: A deep longing for God that can be felt even at night.

Verse 12: A beautiful thought: All the good things we do are really things God has done in us.

Verses 13–14: Other lords, that is, foreign rulers, have ruled over the people. But they are dead and forgotten. They will not come back.

Like a woman in labor VERSES 16–19

16 LORD, in trouble they looked for you.
They poured out a prayer
when your discipline was on them.
17 Just as a pregnant woman who is about to give birth
is in pain and cries out in her labor,
so we have been before you, LORD.
18 We were pregnant. We were in pain.
We gave birth, it seems, only to wind.
We have not brought salvation to the earth,
and the people of the world have not fallen.
19 Your dead will live.
Their dead bodies will rise.
Wake up and sing for joy, you who live in the dust!
For your dew is like the dew of herbs,
and the earth will give up the spirits of the dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: An honest picture: The people suffered like a woman in labor. But in the end nothing came of it, "only wind." All the effort seemed to be for nothing.

Verse 19 is one of the most important verses of the Old Testament: "Your dead will live. Their dead bodies will rise." Unlike the dead tyrants (verse 14), God's dead will come back to life.

As the morning dew makes the plants bloom again, so God's dew will bring the dead back to life.

This is one of the first places where the Bible speaks clearly about the resurrection of the dead. Later, Daniel does so (Daniel 12:2). Jews and Christians believe in the resurrection of the dead.

Hide yourself for a moment VERSES 20–21

20 Come, my people, go into your rooms
and shut your doors behind you!
Hide yourself for a little moment,
until the anger has passed.
21 For look, the LORD is coming out of his dwelling place
to punish the people of the earth for their guilt.
The earth will also uncover the blood shed on it
and will no longer hide its dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: As in the night of Passover in Egypt, when Israel stayed in their houses until the disaster had passed (Exodus 12:22–23): Hide yourselves just for a short moment. Then it will be over.

Verse 21: The earth will uncover all the murders that have happened on it. No injustice stays hidden. Innocent blood that has been shed cries out to God (compare Genesis 4:10).

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 27

A beautiful vineyard

God defeats the dragon VERSE 1

1 On that day, the LORD with his hard, great, and strong sword
will punish Leviathan, the fleeing serpent,
Leviathan, the twisting serpent,
and he will kill the dragon that is in the sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Leviathan is a mythical sea monster (compare Job 41; Psalm 74:14). In the stories of the neighboring peoples, gods fought against such dragons of chaos.

Here Isaiah says: God defeats all powers of chaos and evil once and for all. Revelation takes up this picture: The dragon, the old serpent, is defeated (Revelation 12:9; 20:2).

The new song of the vineyard VERSES 2–6

2 On that day, sing about her:
"A delightful vineyard!
3 I, the LORD, am its keeper.
I water it every moment.
So that no one harms it,
I guard it night and day.
4 There is no anger in me.
But if I found briers and thorns,
I would fight against them!
I would march against them
and burn them all together.
5 Or else let them take hold of my strength,
so that they make peace with me.
Let them make peace with me."
6 In days to come, Jacob will take root.
Israel will blossom and bud.
They will fill the surface of the world with fruit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Do you remember the sad song of the vineyard in chapter 5? Back then, the vineyard produced only sour grapes, and God let it grow wild.

Now God sings a new, happy song of the vineyard. God himself is the gardener. He waters the vineyard all the time and guards it day and night.

Verse 4: "There is no anger in me." God is no longer angry with his people.

Verse 5: Even the enemies, the "briers and thorns," are invited to make peace with God. God's goal is peace, not destruction.

Verse 6: Israel will blossom, and its fruit will fill the whole world. God's people are meant to be a blessing for the world.

How God sets his people right VERSES 7–11

7 Has he struck them as he struck those who struck them?
Or have they been killed as those who killed them were killed?
8 In measure, when you sent them away, you argued with them.
He drove them away with his rough wind
on the day of the east wind.
9 So by this the guilt of Jacob will be forgiven,
and this is the full fruit of taking away his sin:
that he makes all the stones of the altar like chalk stones smashed to pieces,

so that the Asherah poles and the incense altars will
not rise again.
10 For the fortified city is lonely,
a home deserted and abandoned like the wilderness.
There the calf will graze,
there it will lie down and eat its branches.
11 When its branches are dry, they are broken off.
The women will come and set them on fire,
for it is a people without understanding.
So the one who made them will not have mercy on
them,
and the one who formed them will show them no
kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: God did punish his people, but "in measure," not as harshly as their enemies. The exile was like a strong east wind that blew them away.

Verse 9: The punishment has a goal: The guilt will be forgiven when the people destroy the altars of idols and turn completely to God.

Verses 10–11: The "fortified city" is again the city that stands against God. It becomes so empty that calves graze there and women gather firewood.

The great trumpet VERSES 12–13

12 On that day it will happen
that the LORD will thresh from the flowing Euphrates
River to the Brook of Egypt,
and you will be gathered up one by one,
you people of Israel.
13 On that day it will happen
that a great trumpet will be blown,
and those who were about to perish in the land of
Assyria
and the outcasts in the land of Egypt will come,
and they will worship the LORD
on the holy mountain in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: As every single grain is gathered at threshing time, God will gather every single person from his people. No one will be lost.

Verse 13: A great trumpet calls all the scattered people home, from Assyria and from Egypt, to worship in Jerusalem.

This "great trumpet" is still mentioned in Jewish prayer today: "Sound the great trumpet for our freedom." The New Testament also speaks of the trumpet when God gathers his people (Matthew 24:31; 1 Thessalonians 4:16).

With this, the "Isaiah Apocalypse" ends: with a great homecoming.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 28

The precious cornerstone

How terrible for the drunkards of Ephraim VERSES 1–6

1 How terrible for the proud crown of the drunkards of
Ephraim,
and for the fading flower of its glorious beauty,
which is on the head of the fertile valley,
of those who are overcome by wine!
2 Look, the Lord has someone mighty and strong.
Like a hailstorm, a destroying storm,
like a flood of mighty, overflowing waters,
he will throw them to the ground with his hand.
3 The proud crown of the drunkards of Ephraim
will be trampled underfoot.
4 The fading flower of its glorious beauty,
which is on the head of the fertile valley,
will be like the first ripe fig before summer:
Whoever sees it picks it and eats it right away.
5 On that day, the LORD of Armies
will be a crown of glory and a beautiful diadem
for the remnant of his people,
6 and a spirit of justice for the one who sits in judgment,
and strength for those who turn back the battle at the
gate.
A diadem is a royal headband, like a crown.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The proud crown of Ephraim" is Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom. It lay on a hill above a fertile valley, like a wreath on a head. But the upper class was drunk and arrogant.

Verses 2–4: Assyria will come like a hailstorm. Samaria will disappear as quickly as a ripe fig that someone picks and eats right away. That is what happened in the year 722 BC.

Verses 5–6: Not a city is to be the crown, but God himself. He gives justice to the judges and strength to the soldiers.

Priests and prophets stagger VERSES 7–13

7 These also stagger from wine
and reel from strong drink.
The priest and the prophet stagger from strong drink.
They are swallowed up by wine.
They reel from strong drink.
They make mistakes when they see visions.
They stumble when they judge.
8 For all the tables are completely full of disgusting
vomit and filth.
9 Whom will he teach knowledge?
To whom will he explain the message?
To those who have just been weaned from milk,
who have just been taken from the breast?
10 For it is: precept on precept, precept on precept,
line on line, line on line,
here a little, there a little.
11 But he will speak to this people with stammering lips
and in a foreign language,
12 he who had said to them,
"This is the resting place. Give rest to the weary!"

and, "This is the refreshing!"
But they would not listen.
13 So the word of the LORD will be to them:
precept on precept, precept on precept,
line on line, line on line,
here a little, there a little,
so that they go, fall backward,
and are broken, snared, and caught.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: Even the priests and prophets in Jerusalem are drunk. Their tables are full of vomit. How are they supposed to understand God's will like that?

Verses 9–10: The drunks mock Isaiah: He talks to us as if we were little children! In Hebrew, verse 10 sounds like baby talk: *tsav la-tsav, qav la-qav*. The WEB, our English source text, translates it as "precept on precept, line on line," and that is how it appears in the text here. The mockers are probably imitating Isaiah's preaching like baby babble.

Verses 11–13: Isaiah's answer: If you don't listen to me, God will speak to you in a foreign language, that is, through the Assyrian soldiers. Then you will understand only gibberish.

Verse 12: Yet God had actually offered them rest: "Give rest to the weary!" God's way would have been simple.

A covenant with death VERSES 14–22

14 So hear the word of the LORD, you mockers
who rule this people in Jerusalem:
15 "Because you have said,
'We have made a covenant with death,
and we have an agreement with Sheol, the world of the dead.
When the overflowing whip passes through,
it will not come to us,
for we have made lies our refuge
and have hidden ourselves under falsehood,'"
16 so the Lord GOD says,
"Look, I am laying in Zion a foundation stone,
a tested stone,
a precious cornerstone, firmly set.
Whoever believes will not be in a hurry.
17 I will make justice the measuring line
and righteousness the plumb line.
The hail will sweep away the refuge of lies,
and the waters will flood the hiding place.
18 Your covenant with death will be canceled,
and your agreement with Sheol will not stand.
When the overflowing whip passes through,
you will be trampled down by it.
19 As often as it passes through, it will seize you,
for morning after morning it will pass through, by day and by night,
and it will be nothing but terror to understand the message."
20 For the bed is too short to stretch out on,
and the blanket is too narrow to wrap yourself in.
21 For the LORD will rise up as on Mount Perazim.
He will be angry as in the Valley of Gibeon,
to do his work, his unusual work,
and to carry out his act, his extraordinary act.
22 So now, don't be mockers,
or your chains will be made stronger,
for I have heard from the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
a decision of destruction on the whole earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The leaders of Jerusalem feel safe. They have made alliances, probably with Egypt, and believe nothing can happen to them. Isaiah mockingly calls that a "covenant with death."

Verse 16: God's answer: Alliances do not give security, God himself does. He lays a firm foundation stone in Zion. Whoever trusts in it does not have to panic. The New Testament applies this "cornerstone" to Jesus Christ (Romans 9:33; 1 Peter 2:6).

Verse 17: God builds with a builder's tools: Justice is the measuring line, righteousness the plumb line.

Verse 20: A vivid picture: Their false security is like a bed that is too short and a blanket that is too narrow. You cannot rest in it.

Verse 21: At Perazim and Gibeon, God once fought for David and Joshua against their enemies (2 Samuel 5:20; Joshua 10). Now he fights against his own people. That is his "unusual," strange work.

The parable of the farmer VERSES 23–29

23 Listen and hear my voice!
Pay attention and hear what I say!
24 Does the one who plows to sow plow all day long?
Does he keep turning the soil and breaking up the clods?
25 When he has leveled the surface,
doesn't he plant the dill
and scatter the cumin seed
and put the wheat in rows,
the barley in its proper place,
and the spelt in its place?
26 For his God teaches him the right way
and instructs him.
27 For dill is not threshed with a sharp threshing sledge,
and a cart wheel is not rolled over the cumin,
but the dill is beaten out with a stick
and the cumin with a rod.
28 Grain for bread must be ground.
So he does not keep threshing it forever.
Even though he drives the wheel of his threshing cart over it,
his horses do not crush it.
29 This also comes from the LORD of Armies,
who is wonderful in counsel
and great in wisdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A little parable from farming: A farmer does not plow forever, but sows afterward. He treats each plant differently: Dill and cumin are beaten out carefully with a stick, grain with the heavy threshing cart. And even the grain is not crushed.

The message: Just as the farmer knows what each plant needs, God knows what each people needs. His judgment does not last forever, and it has a goal. He does not want to destroy his people, but to make them into "bread."

Chapter 29

They honor me with their lips

How terrible for Ariel VERSES 1–8

1 How terrible for Ariel!
Ariel, the city where David camped!
Add year to year,
let the feasts come around,
2 then I will bring distress on Ariel,
and there will be mourning and lament.
She will be to me like an altar hearth.
3 I will camp all around you
and surround you with troops.
I will build siege works against you.
4 You will be brought low
and will speak from the ground.
Your words will mumble out of the dust.
Your voice will come out of the ground
like the voice of someone who talks with the spirits of the dead,
and your words will whisper out of the dust.
5 But the crowd of your enemies will be like fine dust,
and the crowd of the violent like chaff that blows away.
Yes, it will happen in an instant, suddenly.
6 She will be visited by the LORD of Armies
with thunder, with earthquake, with great noise,
with whirlwind and storm,
and with the flame of a consuming fire.
7 The crowd of all the nations that fight against Ariel,
all who fight against her and her fortress and bring distress on her,
will be like a dream, like a vision in the night.
8 It will be like when a hungry man dreams,
and look, he is eating,
but he wakes up, and his hunger is not satisfied.
Or like when a thirsty man dreams,
and look, he is drinking,
but he wakes up, and look, he is faint and still thirsty.
That is how it will be for the crowd of all the nations
that fight against Mount Zion.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Ariel" is a name for Jerusalem. It perhaps means "lion of God" or "altar hearth." A play on words: Jerusalem itself will become like a burning altar.

Verse 1: Year after year, people celebrate the feasts in Jerusalem, purely out of habit. But God will bring the city into distress.

Verse 4: Jerusalem will be brought so low that her voice will sound only like a whisper from the ground.

Verses 5–8: But then the turn: The enemies suddenly disappear like dust in the wind. They wake up as if from a dream in which they ate, and they are still hungry. Their dream of conquering Jerusalem bursts.

A sealed book VERSES 9–14

9 Stop and be amazed!
Blind yourselves and be blind!
They are drunk, but not from wine.
They stagger, but not from strong drink.
10 For the LORD has poured out on you a spirit of deep sleep
and has closed your eyes, the prophets,
and covered your heads, the seers.
11 All vision has become for you like the words of a sealed book,
which people give to someone who can read, saying,
"Please read this!"
And he says, "I can't, for it is sealed."
12 And the book is given to someone who cannot read,
saying, "Please read this!"
And he says, "I can't read."
13 The Lord said,
"Because this people come near with their mouth
and honor me with their lips,
but keep their heart far from me,
and their fear of me is only a rule
that people have taught,
14 so, look, I will again do wonderful things with this people,
wonderful and amazing things.
The wisdom of their wise men will perish,
and the understanding of their clever men will be hidden."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–12: The people are spiritually blind. God's message is like a sealed book for them: The educated say "It is sealed," the uneducated say "I can't read." No one wants to make the effort to really understand God's word.

Verse 13 is a very important verse: People pray with their mouth, but their heart is far away from God. Their faith consists only of rules learned by heart. Jesus quotes this verse (Matthew 15:8–9).

This danger exists in every religion and at every time: pious words without a real heart.

Verse 14: Paul quotes this verse: God brings the wisdom of the wise to nothing (1 Corinthians 1:19).

The potter and the clay VERSES 15–24

15 How terrible for those who hide their plans deep from the LORD,
whose deeds are done in the dark, and who say,
"Who sees us?" and "Who knows us?"
16 You turn everything upside down!
Should the potter be thought of as equal to the clay,
so that the thing made could say about the one who made it,
"He did not make me,"
or the thing formed say about the one who formed it,
"He has no understanding"?
17 Isn't it only a very little while,
and Lebanon will be turned into a fruitful field,
and the fruitful field will be thought of as a forest?
18 On that day, the deaf will hear the words of the book,
and the eyes of the blind will see out of gloom and darkness.

19 The humble will also have more and more joy in the
LORD,
and the poor among people will rejoice in the Holy One
of Israel.
20 For the violent person will come to nothing,
and the mocker will be gone,
and all who are on the lookout to do evil will be cut off,
21 who make a person guilty by a word,
and set a trap for the one who speaks up for justice at
the gate,
and take away the rights of the innocent with false
testimony.
22 So the LORD, who redeemed Abraham,
says about the house of Jacob:
"Jacob will no longer be ashamed,
and his face will no longer turn pale.
23 But when he sees his children, the work of my hands,
among them,
they will treat my name as holy.
Yes, they will treat the Holy One of Jacob as holy
and will stand in awe of the God of Israel.
24 Those who go astray in spirit will also come to
understanding,
and those who grumble will accept teaching."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Some people believe they can hide their plans from God. They say: "Who sees us?" and "Who knows us?"

Verse 16: Isaiah's answer with a picture: Can the clay pot say about the potter, "He did not make me"? People are God's creatures and cannot put themselves above him. Paul takes up this picture (Romans 9:20–21).

Verses 17–19: Soon everything will be turned around: The deaf hear, the blind see, the poor rejoice. Jesus shows such signs in his work (Matthew 11:5).

Verses 20–21: The violent and the corrupt judges, who condemn innocent people with lies, will come to an end.

Verses 22–24: God will renew his people. Even the confused and the grumblers will understand.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 30

In quietness and confidence

Useless help from Egypt VERSES 1–7

1 "How terrible for the rebellious children," says the
LORD,
"who make plans, but not from me,
and who make an alliance, but not by my Spirit,
so that they pile sin on sin,
2 who set out to go down to Egypt
without asking my advice,
to make themselves strong in the strength of Pharaoh
and to take refuge in the shadow of Egypt!
3 So the strength of Pharaoh will be your shame,
and the refuge in the shadow of Egypt your disgrace.
4 For their princes are at Zoan,
and their messengers have come to Hanes.
5 They will all be put to shame
because of a people who cannot help them,
who are no help and no use,
but a shame and a disgrace."
6 The burden about the animals of the South.
Through the land of trouble and anguish,
of the lioness and the lion,
of the viper and the fiery flying serpent,
they carry their riches on the backs of young donkeys
and their treasures on the humps of camels
to a people who are no use.
7 For Egypt's help is useless and empty.
So I have called her "Rahab who sits still."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

King Hezekiah and his advisers send messengers to Egypt to make an alliance against Assyria. They do not ask God for advice.

Verse 6: With great effort they drag gifts through the dangerous desert, full of lions and snakes. All for nothing.

Verse 7: "Rahab" is a name for a sea monster and for Egypt. Isaiah makes fun of it: Egypt is a monster that only sits still and does nothing.

Just tell us pleasant things VERSES 8–14

8 Now go, write it on a tablet in front of them
and write it in a book,
so that it may remain for the time to come,
forever and ever.
9 For it is a rebellious people,
lying children,
children who will not listen to the teaching of the
LORD,
10 who say to the seers, "Don't see!"
and to the prophets, "Don't prophesy to us what is
right!
Tell us pleasant things!
Prophesy lies to us!
11 Get out of the way!
Turn off the path!
Take the Holy One of Israel away from us!"
12 So the Holy One of Israel says,
"Because you reject this word
and trust in oppression and crookedness
and rely on them,
13 this guilt will be for you
like a crack that threatens to collapse,
a bulge in a high wall,
whose collapse comes suddenly, in an instant.
14 He will break it as a clay pot is broken,
smashed without mercy,
so that among the pieces there is not one left
to take fire from the hearth
or to scoop water from the cistern."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: The people do not want to hear uncomfortable truth. They say to the prophets: Just tell us pleasant things! Go ahead and lie to us! That is a very human attitude that is still familiar today.

Verses 13–14: Their guilt is like a crack in a wall. At first you can hardly see it, but suddenly everything collapses. In the end not even one piece is left.

Turning back and rest VERSES 15–17

15 For this is what the Lord GOD, the Holy One of Israel, said:
"By turning back and rest you will be saved.
Your strength will be in quietness and confidence."
But you refused,
16 and you said, "No, we will flee on horses!"
So you will flee.
And, "We will ride on swift horses!"
So those who chase you will be swift.
17 At the threat of one, 1,000 will flee.
At the threat of five you will flee,
until you are left like a pole on a mountaintop
and like a banner on a hill.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 is one of Isaiah's best-known verses: "Your strength will be in quietness and confidence." God invites us not to panic, but to turn back, to become calm, and to trust him.

But the people would rather rely on fast horses, that is, on military strength. The result: They will have to flee.

A thought that still helps today: In stress and fear, it is often wiser to become quiet and trust God than to act in a rush.

God waits to be gracious VERSES 18–26

18 So the LORD waits to be gracious to you,
and so he rises up to have mercy on you,
for the LORD is a God of justice.
Blessed are all who wait for him.
19 For the people will live in Zion at Jerusalem.
You will weep no more.
He will surely be gracious to you when you cry for help.
When he hears you, he will answer you.
20 Even though the Lord gives you the bread of trouble
and the water of distress,
your teachers will not hide anymore,
but your eyes will see your teachers,
21 and when you turn to the right or to the left,
your ears will hear a voice behind you:
"This is the way. Walk in it!"
22 You will treat as unclean the silver covering of your carved idols
and the gold plating of your cast images.
You will throw them away like something unclean.
You will say to it, "Get out!"
23 He will give rain for your seed
that you sow in the ground,
and the bread from the produce of the ground will be rich and plentiful.
On that day, your cattle will graze in wide pastures.
24 The oxen and the young donkeys that work the ground will eat tasty feed
that has been winnowed with shovel and fork.
25 On every high mountain and on every lofty hill
there will be brooks and streams of water
on the day of the great slaughter, when the towers fall.
26 The light of the moon will be like the light of the sun,
and the light of the sun will be seven times brighter,
like the light of seven days,
on the day when the LORD binds up the broken bones of his people
and heals the wound they were struck with.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A wonderful thought: God himself is waiting to be able to be gracious. He longs to help his people.

Verse 19: "You will weep no more." God hears every cry for help.

Verses 20–21: A comforting picture: When you are unsure which way to go, you hear a voice behind you: "This is the way. Walk in it!" God goes with you like a good teacher.

Verses 23–26: A picture of a wonderful future: rain, a rich harvest, water everywhere, bright light. And above all: God binds up the wounds of his people and heals them.

God's judgment on Assyria VERSES 27–33

27 Look, the name of the LORD comes from far away,
burning with his anger and in thick rising smoke.
His lips are full of fury.
His tongue is like a consuming fire.
28 His breath is like an overflowing stream that reaches up to the neck,
to sift the nations with the sieve of destruction.
A bridle that leads to ruin will be in the jaws of the peoples.
29 You will have a song as in the night when a holy feast is kept,
and gladness of heart as when someone goes with a flute
to come to the mountain of the LORD, to the Rock of Israel.
30 The LORD will make his glorious voice heard
and will show his arm coming down
with the fury of his anger and the flame of a consuming fire,
with cloudburst, storm, and hailstones.
31 For at the voice of the LORD, the Assyrian will be terrified.
He will strike him with his rod.
32 Every blow of the rod of punishment that the LORD lays on him
will come to the sound of tambourines and harps.
He will fight against them in battles, swinging his weapon.
33 For his burning place has long been ready.
Yes, it is prepared for the king.
He has made its fire pit deep and wide,
with fire and plenty of wood.
The breath of the LORD, like a stream of sulfur, sets it on fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God himself comes like a mighty storm to judge Assyria.

Verse 29: For God's people it will be a feast, as in the night of the Passover festival, when people go on pilgrimage to

Jerusalem with songs and flutes.

Verse 33: "The burning place" in Hebrew is "Topheth." That was a place in the Valley of Hinnom near Jerusalem, where terrible child sacrifices had taken place (2 Kings 23:10).

Now the king of Assyria is to meet his end there. From the name of this valley ("Gehinnom"), the word "Gehenna" later came, a picture for hell.

ISAIAH

Chapter 31

The Egyptians are human, not God

How terrible for those who go to Egypt VERSES 1–3

1 How terrible for those who go down to Egypt for help
and rely on horses,
and trust in chariots because there are many of them,
and in horsemen because they are very strong,
but do not look to the Holy One of Israel
and do not seek the LORD!
2 Yet he too is wise.
He will bring disaster
and will not take back his words,
but he will rise up against the house of evildoers
and against the help of those who do wrong.
3 The Egyptians are human and not God,
and their horses are flesh and not spirit.
When the LORD stretches out his hand,
the helper will stumble,
and the one who is helped will fall,
and they will all perish together.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the warning against the alliance with Egypt. Egypt had many horses and chariots, the most modern military technology of that time.

Verse 3 is a clear sentence: "The Egyptians are human and not God, and their horses are flesh and not spirit." Human power is limited. Whoever relies only on it will be disappointed.

God protects Jerusalem like a bird VERSES 4–9

4 For this is what the LORD says to me:
"As the lion, the young lion, growls over its prey,
and when a crowd of shepherds is called together
against it,
it is not frightened by their shouting
and does not cower at their noise,
so the LORD of Armies will come down
to fight on Mount Zion and on its hill.
5 Like birds hovering,
so the LORD of Armies will protect Jerusalem.
He will protect it and rescue it.
He will pass over it and keep it safe."
6 Turn back to the one you have turned so far away from,
you people of Israel!
7 For on that day, everyone will throw away his idols of silver
and his idols of gold,
the sin that your own hands have made for you.
8 "The Assyrian will fall by a sword that is not a man's,
and a sword that is not human will eat him up.
He will flee from the sword,
and his young men will be put to forced labor.
9 His rock will pass away in terror,
and his princes will be afraid of the banner,"
says the LORD, whose fire is in Zion
and whose furnace is in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: God is like a lion that does not let any noise frighten it.

Verse 5: And at the same time, God is like a mother bird hovering protectively over her nest. Two pictures: strength and tenderness. "Pass over" reminds us in Hebrew of "Passover," when God passed over the houses of Israel and spared them.

Verse 6: The real call: Turn back to God!

Verse 8: Assyria will not fall by human hands, but because God steps in. That is what chapter 37:36 reports.

ISAIAH

Chapter 32

The work of righteousness will be peace

A righteous king VERSES 1–8

1 Look, a king will reign in righteousness,
and princes will rule with justice.
2 Each one will be like a hiding place from the wind
and a shelter from the storm,
like streams of water in a dry place,
like the shade of a great rock in a weary land.
3 The eyes of those who see will not be dim,
and the ears of those who hear will listen.
4 The heart of the rash will understand knowledge,
and the tongue of those who stammer will be ready to speak clearly.
5 The fool will no longer be called noble,
and the scoundrel will no longer be highly respected.
6 For the fool speaks foolishness,
and his heart plans wrong,
to act in a godless way
and to say false things about the LORD,
to leave the hungry empty
and to let the thirsty go without a drink.

7 The ways of the scoundrel are evil.
He makes wicked plans
to ruin the humble with lying words,
even when the needy are in the right.
8 But the noble person plans noble things,
and he will stand firm in noble things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: A picture of good government: A king and his ministers rule justly. For the people they are like a shelter from the storm, like water in the desert, like shade on a hot day. Good government protects people.

Verses 3–4: There will be clarity: People will see, hear and understand.

Verses 5–8: Things will be called by their right names again. A scoundrel will no longer be celebrated as "noble." You recognize the scoundrel by the fact that he lets the hungry and thirsty go away empty and cheats the poor with lies. You recognize the noble person by his good deeds.

A warning to the carefree women VERSES 9–14

9 Get up, you women who live at ease!
Hear my voice!
You careless daughters, listen to what I say!
10 In a little more than a year, you will tremble,
you careless women,
for the grape harvest will fail.
The harvest will not come.
11 Tremble, you women who live at ease!
Be terrified, you careless ones!
Strip, make yourselves bare,
and put sackcloth around your waist!
12 Beat your breasts for the pleasant fields,
for the fruitful vine.
13 Thorns and briers will grow on the land of my people,
yes, on all the houses of joy in the cheerful city.
14 For the palace will be abandoned.
The crowded city will be deserted.
The hill and the watchtower will become caves
forever,
a delight for wild donkeys, a pasture for flocks,

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaiah speaks to the rich women of Jerusalem, who live carefree, as if nothing could happen.

He warns: Soon the harvest will fail. Then the carefree life will be over.

Verses 11–12: Sackcloth and beating one's breast were signs of mourning.

As in chapter 3, this is not a criticism of women in general, but of an upper class that does not see the need in the land. Isaiah criticizes the men in the same way in many other places.

Verse 14 ends in the middle of a sentence. It continues in verse 15.

Until the Spirit is poured out VERSES 15–20

15 until the Spirit is poured out on us from on high,
and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field,
and the fruitful field is thought of as a forest.
16 Then justice will live in the wilderness,
and righteousness will stay in the fruitful field.
17 The work of righteousness will be peace,
and the result of righteousness, quietness and
confidence forever.
18 My people will live in a peaceful home,
in safe dwellings,
and in quiet resting places,
19 even if hail flattens the forest
and the city is leveled completely.
20 Blessed are you who sow beside all waters,
who let the ox and the donkey roam free.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The turning point comes when God pours out his Spirit. Then the wilderness becomes a garden. The prophets Joel and Ezekiel also speak about this (Joel 2:28; Ezekiel 36:26–27). Christians think of the feast of Pentecost (Acts 2).

Verse 17 is a wonderful sentence: "The work of righteousness will be peace." True peace only comes through justice. Without justice, there is no peace. This sentence was the motto of Pope Pius XII and is a guiding word of many peace movements.

Verse 18: God's people will live safely and quietly.

Verse 20: A picture of plenty: Everywhere there is enough water for sowing, and the animals can graze freely.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 33

Who can live with the consuming fire?

A prayer in distress VERSES 1–6

1 How terrible for you, destroyer, who have not been
destroyed yourself,
and traitor, whom no one has betrayed!
When you have finished destroying, you will be
destroyed,
and when you have finished betraying, you will be
betrayed.
2 LORD, be gracious to us!
We have waited for you.
Be our strength every morning,
our salvation also in the time of trouble.
3 At the noise of the thunder, the peoples have fled.
When you rise up, the nations are scattered.
4 Your plunder will be gathered as the caterpillar
gathers.
People will leap on it as locusts leap.
5 The LORD is lifted up, for he lives on high.
He has filled Zion with justice and righteousness.
6 There will be stability in your times,
plenty of salvation, wisdom, and knowledge.

The fear of the LORD is your treasure.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A cry of "How terrible" against the destroyer, probably Assyria. Whoever destroys and betrays others will in the end be destroyed and betrayed himself.

Verse 2: A beautiful short prayer: "LORD, be gracious to us! … Be our strength every morning!" You can pray it every morning.

Verse 6: The greatest treasure is the fear of God.

The land mourns VERSES 7–13

7 Look, their brave men cry out in the streets.
The messengers of peace weep bitterly.
8 The highways are deserted.
Travelers stay away.
The covenant is broken.
He has despised the cities.
He has no respect for anyone.
9 The land mourns and withers away.
Lebanon is ashamed and dries up.
Sharon is like a desert,
and Bashan and Carmel are stripped bare.
10 "Now I will rise up," says the LORD.
"Now I will lift myself up.
Now I will be lifted high.
11 You are pregnant with chaff.
You will give birth to stubble.
Your breath is a fire that will burn you up.
12 The peoples will be like lime being burned,
like thorns cut down and burned in the fire.
13 Hear, you who are far away, what I have done,
and you who are near, recognize my power!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: The peace talks have failed. The messengers of peace weep. The enemy does not keep any treaty. Hezekiah had paid tribute to Assyria, but the Assyrian king attacked anyway (2 Kings 18:14–17).

Verse 9: Even the most beautiful regions (Lebanon, Sharon, Bashan, Carmel) dry up.

Verse 10: Now God steps in: "Now I will rise up."

Verse 11: The plans of the enemies are like chaff. Their own breath, their rage, will burn them up.

Who may live with God? VERSES 14–16

14 The sinners in Zion are afraid.
Trembling has seized the godless.
"Who among us can live with the consuming fire?
Who among us can live with everlasting burning?"
15 Whoever lives righteously and speaks honestly,
whoever rejects profit from oppression,
whoever waves his hands to refuse a bribe,
whoever closes his ears so as not to hear of bloodshed
and shuts his eyes so as not to look at evil,
16 he will live on high.
His place of refuge will be a fortress of rock.
His bread will be given to him.
His water will never run dry.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: God is holy like a consuming fire. Who can stand in his presence?

Verse 15: The answer is very practical: whoever lives honestly, whoever does not profit from oppression, whoever does not take bribes, whoever does not join in plans for violence and does not stare at evil.

There are similar questions and answers in Psalm 15 and Psalm 24.

Verse 16: Such a person is safe with God as in a fortress of rock and is provided for.

You will see the king in his beauty VERSES 17–24

17 Your eyes will see the king in his beauty.
They will see a land that stretches far away.
18 Your heart will think back on the terror:
"Where is the one who counted?
Where is the one who weighed?
Where is the one who counted the towers?"
19 You will no longer see the fierce people,
a people of strange speech that you cannot understand,
with a foreign language that you cannot make sense of.
20 Look at Zion, the city of our festivals!
Your eyes will see Jerusalem,
a quiet home,
a tent that will not be taken down.
Its stakes will never be pulled up,
and none of its ropes will break.
21 But there the LORD will be with us in majesty,
a place of wide rivers and streams,
on which no galley with oars will go,
and no proud ship will pass by.
22 For the LORD is our judge.
The LORD is our lawgiver.
The LORD is our king.
He will save us.
23 Your ropes hang loose.
They could not hold the base of their mast firm.
They could not spread the sail.
Then a great amount of plunder was divided.
Even the lame carried off plunder.
24 No one who lives there will say, "I am sick."
The people who live there will be forgiven their guilt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Instead of the enemy rulers, they will see the true king in his beauty.

Verses 18–19: The time of terror is over: no more tax collectors, no more foreign soldiers whose language you cannot understand.

Verse 20: Jerusalem will be like a tent that is never taken down again. A picture of lasting safety.

Verse 21: God himself is like a wide river for Jerusalem that protects the city. But no enemy warships can sail on this river.

Verse 22: God holds all offices together: judge, lawgiver, king.

Verse 23: The enemy ship lies there helpless, and even the lame can carry off plunder.

Verse 24: The most beautiful thing: No one is sick anymore, and all guilt is forgiven.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 34

Judgment on Edom

Judgment on the nations VERSES 1–4

1 Come near, you nations, to hear!
Listen, you peoples!
Let the earth hear, and everything that fills it,
the world, and everything that comes from it.
2 For the LORD is angry with all the nations
and furious with all their armies.
He has completely destroyed them.
He has handed them over to slaughter.
3 Their dead will be thrown out,
and the stench of their bodies will rise.
The mountains will melt with their blood.
4 The whole army of the sky will dissolve.
The sky will be rolled up like a scroll,
and all its armies will wither,
as a leaf withers from the vine
or from the fig tree.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 34 and 35 belong together. They show two sides: judgment on the enemies (chapter 34) and rescue for God's people (chapter 35).

Verses 2–3: Terrible pictures of war and death. This is the language of prophecies of judgment, which wants to show: God does not let injustice go unpunished. These pictures are not a call for people to wage war.

Verse 4: Even the stars fall. The sky is rolled up like a book being closed. The book of Revelation takes up this picture (Revelation 6:13–14).

The sword over Edom VERSES 5–17

5 For my sword has drunk its fill in the sky.
Look, it will come down on Edom,
on the people I have put under my curse, for
judgment.
6 The sword of the LORD is full of blood.
It is covered with fat,
with the blood of lambs and goats,
with the kidney fat of rams,
for the LORD has a sacrifice in Bozrah
and a great slaughter in the land of Edom.
7 The wild oxen will fall with them,
and the young bulls with the mighty bulls.
Their land will be drunk with blood
and their dust greasy with fat.
8 For the LORD has a day of vengeance,
a year of payback for the cause of Zion.
9 Edom's streams will be turned into tar
and its dust into sulfur,
and its land will become burning tar.
10 It will not be put out, night or day.
Its smoke will rise forever.
From generation to generation it will lie in ruins.
No one will ever pass through it, forever and ever.
11 But the pelican and the porcupine will own it.
The owl and the raven will live in it.
He will stretch over it the measuring line of confusion
and the plumb line of emptiness.
12 They will call its nobles to the kingdom,
but no one will be there,
and all its princes will be nothing.
13 Thorns will grow in its palaces,
nettles and thistles in its fortresses.
It will be a home for jackals,
a yard for ostriches.
14 The wild animals of the desert will meet with the
wolves,
and the wild goat will call to its companion.
Yes, the night creature will settle there
and find herself a place to rest.
15 The arrow snake will make her nest there,
lay eggs, hatch them, and gather her young in her
shade.
Yes, the kites will gather there,
each one with her mate.
16 Search in the book of the LORD and read:
Not one of these will be missing.
None will be without her mate.
For my mouth has commanded it,
and his Spirit has gathered them.
17 He has cast the lot for them,
and his hand has divided it for them with a measuring
line.
They will own it forever.
From generation to generation they will live in it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom was a neighboring people south of the Dead Sea. The Edomites were descended from Esau, Jacob's brother. When Jerusalem was destroyed later, they rejoiced and helped (Obadiah 10–14; Psalm 137:7). That is why Edom stands here for all the enemies of God and his people.

Verse 6: The judgment is compared to a sacrifice. Bozrah was the capital of Edom. These pictures are very harsh. They belong to the language of that time and are meant to show: God will make sure there is justice. This is not a command for people to take revenge.

Verses 9–10: Edom will burn like Sodom and Gomorrah.

Verses 11–15: The land becomes a wilderness where only animals live. "Measuring line of confusion": God "measures" the land, but not to build it up, rather to make it empty. The Hebrew word for "night creature" is "Lilith," a being from ancient legends.

Verse 16: "Search in the book of the LORD": God's words come true exactly.

Chapter 35

The desert will bloom

Strengthen the tired hands VERSES 1–4

1 The wilderness and the dry land will be glad.
The desert will rejoice and bloom like a rose.
2 It will bloom richly
and rejoice, yes, with joy and singing.
The glory of Lebanon will be given to it,
the splendor of Carmel and Sharon.
They will see the glory of the LORD,
the splendor of our God.
3 Strengthen the weak hands
and make the shaking knees firm!
4 Tell those who have a fearful heart:
"Be strong! Do not be afraid!
Look, your God will come with vengeance,
with the payback of God.
He will come and save you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the dark chapter 34 comes one of the most hopeful chapters in the Bible.

Verses 1–2: The desert blooms like a rose garden. Where there was only sand before, flowers now grow. The desert receives the beauty of the greenest regions of Israel.

Verses 3–4: A task for everyone who trusts God: Encourage the tired and the fearful! Tell them: Be strong, do not be afraid! God is coming and will save you.

The letter to the Hebrews quotes verse 3 as encouragement (Hebrews 12:12).

If you are afraid or feel you cannot go on, you may hear these words as spoken to you.

The blind see, the lame leap VERSES 5–7

5 Then the eyes of the blind will be opened,
and the ears of the deaf will be unblocked.
6 Then the lame will leap like a deer,
and the tongue of those who cannot speak will sing,
for water will break out in the wilderness
and streams in the desert.
7 The burning sand will become a pool,
and the thirsty ground springs of water.
Where the jackals used to lie,
grass will grow with reeds and rushes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When God comes, everything will be made whole: The blind see, the deaf hear, the lame leap, those who cannot speak sing.

When John the Baptist sends to ask whether Jesus is the promised savior, Jesus answers with these words: "The blind see, the lame walk … the deaf hear" (Matthew 11:5).

Important: These verses are a hope for healing. They do not mean that people with disabilities are worth less. Every person is loved by God just as they are.

The holy way VERSES 8–10

8 A highway will be there, a road,
and it will be called "The Holy Way."
No one who is unclean will travel on it,
but it will be for those who walk on the Way.
Wicked fools will not go there.
9 No lion will be there,
and no wild beast will go up on it.
They will not be found there,
but the redeemed will walk there.
10 Then the people the LORD has set free will return
and come to Zion with singing,
and everlasting joy will be on their heads.
They will receive gladness and joy,
and sorrow and sighing will run away."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A road leads through the blooming desert, "The Holy Way." On it, those who have been set free return home safely. No wild animals, no danger.

Verse 10: One of the most beautiful verses in the Bible: Those who have been set free come home singing, with everlasting joy like a crown on their heads. Sorrow and sighing run away.

Johannes Brahms set this verse to music in his "German Requiem."

This ends the first large part of the book of Isaiah. Next come four chapters with stories about King Hezekiah (chapters 36–39).

ISAIAH

Chapter 36

Rabshakeh threatens Jerusalem

Who are you trusting? VERSES 1–10

1 In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah,
Sennacherib, the king of Assyria, attacked all the fortified cities of Judah
and captured them.
2 The king of Assyria sent Rabshakeh from Lachish to Jerusalem
to King Hezekiah with a large army.
He stood by the water channel of the upper pool,
on the road to the washer's field.
3 Then Eliakim the son of Hilkiah, who was in charge of the palace,
and Shebna the scribe,
and Joah the son of Asaph, the recorder, came out to him.
4 Rabshakeh said to them,
"Tell Hezekiah: 'This is what the great king, the king of

Assyria, says:
"What is this confidence that you are trusting in?
5 I say: Your advice and your strength for war are only
empty words.
Who are you trusting in, that you have rebelled
against me?
6 Look, you are trusting in the staff of this broken reed,
in Egypt.
If anyone leans on it,
it goes into his hand and pierces it.
That is what Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, is like for all
who trust in him.
7 But if you say to me, 'We trust in the LORD our God,'
isn't he the one whose high places and altars Hezekiah
has removed,
and who has said to Judah and Jerusalem,
'You shall worship in front of this altar'?"
8 So now, make a bet with my master, the king of Assyria:
I will give you 2,000 horses
if you can find riders for them on your side.
9 How then could you drive back even one officer,
the least of my master's servants?
And you trust in Egypt for chariots and horsemen!
10 Have I come up against this land without the LORD
to destroy it?
The LORD said to me,
"Go up against this land and destroy it!"'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 36–39 tell stories from the time of King Hezekiah. Almost exactly the same stories are also found in 2 Kings 18–20.

In the year 701 BC, the Assyrian king Sennacherib marches into Judah with a huge army. He captures 46 fortified cities. An Assyrian inscription, the so-called "Sennacherib Prism," also reports this. Only Jerusalem is left.

"Rabshakeh" is a title, something like "chief cupbearer," a high official.

He stands exactly at the spot where Isaiah once called King Ahaz to trust (Isaiah 7:3).

His speech is clever war propaganda: Egypt is a broken reed that will hurt you. And your God? Hezekiah tore down his altars! (Hezekiah had closed the many places of worship and brought worship together in Jerusalem.) He even claims that God himself sent him.

The speech to the people on the wall VERSES 11–22

11 Then Eliakim, Shebna and Joah said to Rabshakeh,
"Please speak to your servants in Aramaic, for we
understand it.
Do not speak to us in the Jews' language
in the hearing of the people on the wall."
12 But Rabshakeh said,
"Has my master sent me only to your master and to
you
to speak these words,
and not to the men sitting on the wall,
who will eat their own dung
and drink their own urine with you?"
13 Then Rabshakeh stood
and called out with a loud voice in the Jews' language
and said,
"Hear the words of the great king, the king of Assyria!
14 This is what the king says:
'Do not let Hezekiah deceive you,
for he will not be able to rescue you.
15 Do not let Hezekiah make you trust in the LORD
when he says, "The LORD will surely rescue us.
This city will not be handed over to the king of
Assyria."'
16 Do not listen to Hezekiah,
for this is what the king of Assyria says:
'Make peace with me and come out to me.
Then each of you will eat from his own vine
and each from his own fig tree,
and each of you will drink the water from his own
well,
17 until I come and take you away to a land like your own
land,
a land of grain and new wine,
a land of bread and vineyards.
18 Be careful that Hezekiah does not mislead you
when he says, "The LORD will rescue us."
Have any of the gods of the nations
rescued their land from the hand of the king of
Assyria?
19 Where are the gods of Hamath and Arpad?
Where are the gods of Sepharvaim?
Did they rescue Samaria from my hand?
20 Which of all the gods of these countries
has rescued its country from my hand,
that the LORD should rescue Jerusalem from my
hand?'"
21 But they kept silent and did not answer him a word,
for the king had commanded, "Do not answer him!"
22 Then Eliakim the son of Hilkiah, who was in charge of
the palace,
and Shebna the scribe,
and Joah the son of Asaph, the recorder,
came to Hezekiah with their clothes torn
and told him the words of Rabshakeh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Aramaic was the language of diplomats at that time. "The Jews' language" means Hebrew. Hezekiah's officials do not want the ordinary people on the wall to understand everything and become afraid.

Verses 12–13: But that is exactly what Rabshakeh wants. He speaks to the people in Hebrew on purpose. He threatens them with famine because of the siege.

Verses 16–17: He tempts them with promises: Surrender, and you will be well off. But in the end, he wants to deport them anyway.

Verses 18–20: His biggest mistake: He compares the God of Israel with the idols of other nations. By doing this, he insults God himself.

Verse 21: The people wisely keep silent, as the king had commanded.

Verse 22: Torn clothes were a sign of great distress and mourning.

Chapter 37

Hezekiah's prayer and the rescue of Jerusalem

Hezekiah sends to Isaiah VERSES 1–7

1 When King Hezekiah heard this, he tore his clothes,
covered himself with sackcloth,
and went into the house of the LORD.
2 He sent Eliakim, who was in charge of the palace,
and Shebna the scribe,
and the elders of the priests, covered with sackcloth,
to the prophet Isaiah, the son of Amoz.
3 They said to him,
"This is what Hezekiah says:
'Today is a day of trouble, of rebuke and of disgrace,
for the children have come to the moment of birth,
but there is no strength to give birth.
4 Perhaps the LORD your God will hear the words of
Rabshakeh,
whom his master, the king of Assyria, has sent
to mock the living God,
and will punish the words that the LORD your God has
heard.
So lift up your prayer for the remnant that is still
left.'"
5 So the servants of King Hezekiah came to Isaiah.
6 Isaiah said to them,
"Tell your master:
'This is what the LORD says:
"Do not be afraid of the words you have heard,
with which the servants of the king of Assyria have
insulted me.
7 Look, I will put a spirit in him,
and he will hear news
and return to his own land.
I will make him fall by the sword in his own land."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah reacts very differently from his father Ahaz (chapter 7). Instead of relying on alliances, he goes into the temple and asks Isaiah to pray.

Verse 3: A powerful picture: like a birth in which the mother has no strength left. The situation seems hopeless.

Verse 6: God's answer through Isaiah: "Do not be afraid!"

A threatening letter VERSES 8–13

8 Rabshakeh returned
and found the king of Assyria fighting against Libnah,
for he had heard that the king had left Lachish.
9 The king heard news about Tirhakah, the king of
Ethiopia:
"He has come out to fight against you."
When he heard this, he sent messengers to Hezekiah,
saying,
10 "This is what you shall say to Hezekiah, the king of
Judah:
'Do not let your God, whom you trust, deceive you
when he says, "Jerusalem will not be handed over to
the king of Assyria."
11 Look, you have heard what the kings of Assyria
have done to all the lands,
destroying them completely.
And will you be rescued?
12 Did the gods of the nations rescue them,
the nations my ancestors destroyed:
Gozan, Haran, Rezeph, and the people of Eden who
were in Telassar?
13 Where is the king of Hamath, and the king of Arpad,
and the king of the city of Sepharvaim, of Hena and
Ivvah?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sennacherib has to fight against an army from Cush and Egypt that is coming under King Tirhakah. The WEB, our English source text, says "Ethiopia." That is why he sends a threatening letter to Jerusalem: Don't think your God can save you!

He lists the many cities and kings that Assyria has already defeated. He wants to frighten Hezekiah.

Hezekiah's prayer VERSES 14–20

14 Hezekiah took the letter from the hand of the
messengers and read it.
Then Hezekiah went up to the house of the LORD
and spread it out before the LORD.
15 Hezekiah prayed to the LORD and said,
16 "LORD of Armies, God of Israel,
you who are enthroned among the cherubim,
you alone are God over all the kingdoms of the earth.
You have made heaven and earth.
17 Turn your ear, LORD, and hear!
Open your eyes, LORD, and see!
Hear all the words of Sennacherib,
who has sent to mock the living God.
18 It is true, LORD,
the kings of Assyria have destroyed all the countries
and their land
19 and have thrown their gods into the fire,
for they were not gods,
but the work of human hands, wood and stone.
That is why they destroyed them.
20 So now, LORD our God, save us from his hand,
so that all the kingdoms of the earth may know
that you are the LORD, you alone."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: A moving picture: Hezekiah takes the threatening letter and lays it out in the temple before God. In this way he says: God, look at this! This is an example for prayer: You may "spread out" your worries, even a letter, very concretely before God.

Verses 16–20: Hezekiah admits that Assyria has defeated many countries. But the gods of these countries were only wood and stone. The God of Israel is the living God, the Creator.

Verse 20: Hezekiah does not only ask for his own rescue, but that all nations may know God.

God's answer to Sennacherib's pride VERSES 21–35

21 Then Isaiah the son of Amoz sent a message to
Hezekiah:
"This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'Because you have prayed to me about Sennacherib,
the king of Assyria,
22 this is the word the LORD has spoken about him:
The virgin daughter of Zion despises you and laughs at
you.
The daughter of Jerusalem shakes her head at you.
23 Whom have you mocked and insulted?
Against whom have you raised your voice
and lifted your eyes in pride?
Against the Holy One of Israel!
24 Through your servants you have mocked the Lord
and have said,
"With my many chariots I have climbed to the tops of
the mountains,
to the innermost parts of Lebanon.
I will cut down its tall cedars
and its finest cypress trees.
I will enter its farthest height,
the forest of its fruitful field.
25 I have dug wells and drunk water,
and with the soles of my feet I will dry up all the rivers
of Egypt."
26 Have you not heard that I did it long ago
and planned it in ancient times?
Now I have let it happen
that you could destroy fortified cities
and turn them into heaps of ruins.
27 That is why their inhabitants had little strength.
They were dismayed and ashamed.
They were like the grass of the field and like green
plants,
like the grass on the rooftops
and like a field before the grain has grown.
28 But I know when you sit down,
when you go out and when you come in,
and how you rage against me.
29 Because you rage against me
and your arrogance has reached my ears,
I will put my hook in your nose
and my bridle in your mouth,
and I will turn you back on the road by which you
came.
30 This will be the sign for you:
This year you will eat what grows by itself,
and in the second year what springs up from that.
But in the third year sow and harvest,
plant vineyards and eat their fruit.
31 The remnant of the house of Judah that has escaped
will again put down roots below
and bear fruit above.
32 For a remnant will go out from Jerusalem,
and survivors from Mount Zion.
The zeal of the LORD of Armies will do this.'
33 Therefore this is what the LORD says about the king of
Assyria:
'He will not come into this city
or shoot an arrow there.
He will not come before it with a shield
or build up a siege ramp against it.
34 He will go back by the road he came,
and he will not come into this city,'
says the LORD.
35 'For I will defend this city to save it,
for my own sake and for the sake of my servant
David.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: Jerusalem is pictured as a young woman who shakes her head at the boasting Sennacherib and laughs.

Verses 24–25: Sennacherib boasts: I have conquered the highest mountains, I even dry up the rivers of Egypt!

Verses 26–27: God's answer: You only managed all this because I allowed it. You are only a tool.

Verse 29: A humiliating picture: God puts a hook in Sennacherib's nose like an animal and leads him back. The Assyrians themselves often led prisoners away like this.

Verses 30–32: A sign for Hezekiah: For two years they eat what grows by itself; in the third year, they sow normally again. The remnant of Judah will put down roots again and bear fruit.

Verses 33–35: Sennacherib will not shoot a single arrow at Jerusalem.

The rescue of Jerusalem VERSES 36–38

36 Then the angel of the LORD went out
and struck down 185,000 men in the camp of the
Assyrians.
When people got up early in the morning,
look, they were all dead bodies.
37 So Sennacherib, the king of Assyria, broke camp,
went away, returned to Nineveh and stayed there.
38 As he was worshiping in the house of his god Nisroch,
his sons Adrammelech and Sharezer struck him down
with the sword.
They escaped into the land of Ararat.
And his son Esar Haddon became king in his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: In a single night, a large part of the Assyrian army dies. The Bible says: The angel of the LORD struck them down. Some think of a plague in the camp. The Greek historian Herodotus tells of a sudden disaster in the Assyrian army in Egypt. The Bible sees God stepping in.

The Assyrian inscriptions report that Sennacherib shut Hezekiah up in Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage." They do not report a conquest of Jerusalem. Jerusalem was not taken.

Verse 38: About 20 years later, Sennacherib was murdered by two of his sons, of all times while praying to his god. Assyrian sources also report this. Isaiah's announcement (verse 7) came true.

The story shows: God keeps his promises. Whoever trusts him will not be disappointed.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 38

Hezekiah's illness and healing

Set your house in order VERSES 1–8

1 In those days, Hezekiah became deathly ill.
The prophet Isaiah, the son of Amoz, came to him
and said to him,
"This is what the LORD says:
'Set your house in order, for you will die and not live.'"
2 Then Hezekiah turned his face to the wall
and prayed to the LORD,
3 and said,
"Please, LORD, remember
how I have lived before you in truth and with an
undivided heart
and have done what is good in your eyes."
And Hezekiah wept bitterly.
4 Then the word of the LORD came to Isaiah:
5 "Go and tell Hezekiah:
'This is what the LORD, the God of your father David,
says:
"I have heard your prayer.
I have seen your tears.
Look, I will add 15 years to your life.
6 I will rescue you and this city from the hand of the king
of Assyria,
and I will defend this city.
7 And this will be the sign to you from the LORD
that the LORD will do what he has said:
8 Look, I will make the shadow on the sundial of Ahaz,
which has gone down with the sun,
go back 10 steps."'"
So the sun went back 10 steps on the sundial
on which it had gone down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hezekiah becomes seriously ill. Isaiah tells him: You will die. "Set your house in order" means: Put your affairs in order, settle your inheritance.

Verses 2–3: Hezekiah turns to the wall to be alone with God, and he weeps and prays.

Verse 5: God answers: "I have heard your prayer. I have seen your tears." A sentence full of comfort. God sees every tear.

Verse 8: The "sundial" was probably a staircase on which the shadow moved on step by step. God makes the shadow go back as a sign that he is giving Hezekiah more time to live.

Not every prayer for healing is answered like this. That is a hard experience. But this story shows: God listens, and praying is not pointless.

Hezekiah's song of thanks VERSES 9–20

9 The writing of Hezekiah, the king of Judah,
after he had been ill and had recovered from his illness:
10 I said, "In the middle of my life
I must go through the gates of Sheol, the world of the
dead.
The rest of my years is taken from me."
11 I said, "I will not see Yah anymore,
Yah in the land of the living.
I will not see people anymore
among those who live in the world.
12 My home is taken down
and carried away from me like a shepherd's tent.
I have rolled up my life like a weaver.
He will cut me off from the loom.
From day to night you will make an end of me.
13 I waited patiently until morning.
Like a lion, he breaks all my bones.
From day to night you will make an end of me.
14 I chirped like a swallow or a crane.
I moaned like a dove.
My eyes grow weak from looking upward.
Lord, I am in distress. Be my security!"
15 What shall I say?
He has spoken to me, and he himself has done it.
I will walk carefully all my years
because of the bitterness of my soul.
16 Lord, people live by these things,
and in all of them my spirit finds life.
You restore me and let me live.
17 Look, instead of peace I had great bitterness,
but in love you have rescued my soul
from the pit of destruction,
for you have thrown all my sins behind your back.
18 For Sheol cannot praise you.
Death cannot celebrate you.
Those who go down into the pit
cannot hope for your truth.
19 The living, the living, they praise you,
as I do today.
The father makes your truth known to the children.
20 The LORD will save me.
So we will play my songs on stringed instruments
all the days of our life in the house of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After his healing, Hezekiah writes a song. It honestly describes his fear of death:

Verses 10–12: In the middle of my life I must die. My life is taken down like a tent, cut off like cloth from the loom. "Sheol" is the Hebrew name for the world of the dead. "Yah" is a short form of God's name.

Verse 14: In his weakness, he could only chirp softly like a little bird.

Verse 17: "You have thrown all my sins behind your back": a beautiful picture of forgiveness. God no longer looks at them.

Verses 18–19: Hezekiah says: Only the living can praise God. That is why he is so glad that he may go on living. And he wants to tell his children about God's faithfulness and truth.

The fig poultice VERSES 21–22

21 For Isaiah had said,
"Let them take a cake of figs
and lay it as a poultice on the boil,
and he will recover."
A poultice is a soft paste that is laid on a sore.

22 And Hezekiah had said,
"What is the sign that I will go up to the house of the LORD?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These two verses are added somewhat later, at the end. In 2 Kings 20:7–8 they are in the middle of the story.

Interesting: God heals through prayer, but Isaiah also prescribes a remedy, a poultice made of figs. Faith and medicine belong together. If you are sick, you may pray and go to the doctor.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 39

The envoys from Babylon

Hezekiah shows everything VERSES 1–8

1 At that time, Merodach-baladan the son of Baladan, the king of Babylon,
sent letters and a gift to Hezekiah,
for he had heard that Hezekiah had been ill and had recovered.
2 Hezekiah was pleased with them
and showed them his treasure house:
the silver, the gold, the spices and the precious oil,
his whole armory,
and everything that was found among his treasures.
There was nothing in his house or in his whole kingdom
that Hezekiah did not show them.
3 Then the prophet Isaiah came to King Hezekiah and asked him,
"What did these men say?
Where did they come to you from?"
Hezekiah said,
"They have come to me from a faraway country, from Babylon."
4 Then he asked,
"What have they seen in your house?"
Hezekiah answered,
"They have seen everything in my house.
There is nothing among my treasures that I have not shown them."
5 Then Isaiah said to Hezekiah,
"Hear the word of the LORD of Armies:
6 'Look, the days are coming
when everything in your house,
and everything your ancestors have stored up until today,
will be carried off to Babylon.
Nothing will be left,' says the LORD.
7 'They will take away your sons, who will come from you,
whom you will father,
and they will be eunuchs in the palace of the king of Babylon.'"
8 Then Hezekiah said to Isaiah,
"The word of the LORD that you have spoken is good."
And he went on,
"For there will be peace and truth in my days."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king of Babylon sends a delegation to Hezekiah, supposedly to congratulate him on his recovery. In reality, Babylon was probably looking for allies against Assyria.

Verse 2: Hezekiah is flattered and proudly shows the foreigners all his treasures and weapons. That was unwise. He trusted in alliances instead of God, and he showed a foreign power all his riches.

Verses 6–7: Isaiah announces: One day Babylon will take all this away, and descendants of Hezekiah will serve as eunuchs at the court in Babylon. This happened about 100 years later, when Nebuchadnezzar conquered Jerusalem (2 Kings 24–25; Daniel 1:3).

"Eunuchs": These were servants and officials at the royal court, who were often castrated. Sometimes the word also simply means high court officials.

Verse 8: Hezekiah's answer is shocking: He is relieved that it will only happen after his time. The main thing is that there is peace during my lifetime. A very human but selfish attitude.

With this look ahead to Babylon, the first part of the book of Isaiah ends. From chapter 40 on, Isaiah speaks to the people who live in exile in Babylon: "Comfort, comfort my people!"

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 40

Comfort, comfort my people!

Comfort my people VERSES 1–11

1 "Comfort, comfort my people," says your God.
2 "Speak kindly to Jerusalem,
and call out to her that her hard service is over,
that her guilt is forgiven,
that she has received from the LORD's hand double for all her sins."
3 A voice calls out,
"Prepare the way of the LORD in the wilderness!
Make a level highway in the desert for our God!
4 Every valley shall be raised up,
and every mountain and hill shall be made low.
The uneven ground shall be made level,
and the rough places a plain.

5 The glory of the LORD will be revealed,
and all people together will see it,
for the mouth of the LORD has spoken."
6 A voice says, "Call out!"
Someone said, "What shall I call out?"
"All people are like grass,
and all their beauty is like the flower of the field.
7 The grass withers, the flower fades,
because the breath of the LORD blows on it.
Surely the people are like grass.
8 The grass withers, the flower fades,
but the word of our God stands forever."
9 You who bring good news to Zion,
go up on a high mountain!
You who bring good news to Jerusalem,
lift up your voice with strength!
Lift it up! Do not be afraid!
Say to the cities of Judah, "Look, here is your God!"
10 Look, the Lord GOD comes as a mighty one,
and his arm rules for him.
Look, his reward is with him,
and his payment goes before him.
11 He will feed his flock like a shepherd.
He will gather the lambs in his arm
and carry them close to his heart.
He will gently lead the mother sheep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With chapter 40, a new part of the book of Isaiah begins, the "Book of Comfort" (chapters 40–55). It speaks to the people who live in exile in Babylon, about 150 years after Isaiah. Jerusalem is destroyed, the temple burned. Many think: God has forgotten us.

Verses 1–2: The first words are: "Comfort, comfort my people!" The punishment is over. The guilt is forgiven. God speaks "kindly" again, literally: "to the heart" of Jerusalem.

Verses 3–5: A road is built through the desert, on which God leads his people home. All obstacles are removed. The Gospels connect this voice with John the Baptist, who prepares the way for Jesus (Mark 1:2–3).

Verses 6–8: People are as short-lived as grass. But God's word stands forever. That is the reason for hope. Peter quotes these verses (1 Peter 1:24–25).

Verse 9: A woman bringing good news is to climb a mountain and call out loudly: "Look, here is your God!"

Verse 11: A tender picture: God is like a shepherd who takes the little lambs in his arms and gently leads the mother animals. Handel set this verse to music in his "Messiah."

Who is like God? VERSES 12–26

12 Who has measured the waters in the hollow of his hand
and marked off the sky with the width of his hand,
and held the dust of the earth in a measuring basket,
and weighed the mountains on scales
and the hills in a balance?
13 Who has directed the Spirit of the LORD
or taught him as his adviser?
14 Whom did he ask for advice,
and who instructed him
and taught him the path of justice,
and taught him knowledge,
and showed him the way of understanding?
15 Look, the nations are like a drop in a bucket
and are thought of as a speck of dust on the scales.
Look, he lifts up the islands like a tiny thing.
16 Lebanon is not enough for firewood,
and its animals are not enough for a burnt offering.
17 All the nations are like nothing before him.
He regards them as less than nothing, as emptiness.
18 To whom, then, will you compare God?
Or what image will you set beside him?
19 A craftsman casts an idol,
and the goldsmith covers it with gold
and casts silver chains for it.
20 Whoever is too poor for such an offering
chooses wood that will not rot.
He looks for a skilled craftsman
to set up a carved idol that will not wobble.
21 Don't you know? Haven't you heard?
Haven't you been told from the beginning?
Haven't you understood since the earth was founded?
22 He is the one who sits above the circle of the earth,
and its inhabitants are like grasshoppers.
He stretches out the heavens like a curtain
and spreads them out like a tent to live in.
23 He brings princes to nothing.
He makes the judges of the earth meaningless.
24 Hardly are they planted,
hardly are they sown,
hardly has their stem taken root in the ground,
when he just blows on them, and they wither,
and the storm carries them away like stubble.
25 "To whom, then, will you compare me?
Who is my equal?" says the Holy One.
26 Lift up your eyes on high and see
who has created these.
He brings out their army by number.
He calls them all by name.
Because of his great might, and because he is strong in power,
not one is missing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people in exile ask: Isn't our God weaker than the gods of Babylon? Isaiah answers with mighty pictures:

Verse 12: God measures the oceans in the hollow of his hand and weighs the mountains on scales.

Verse 15: The great world empires, Babylon too, are like a drop in a bucket to him.

Verses 18–20: The gods of Babylon are made by craftsmen. They have to be nailed down so that they don't fall over. How can anyone compare the living God with something like that?

Verse 22: Seen from above, people are as small as grasshoppers.

Verse 26: Look at the starry sky! The Babylonians worshiped the stars as gods. Isaiah says: God created them all. He knows every star by name.

New strength for the tired VERSES 27–31

27 Why do you say, Jacob, and why do you speak, Israel:
"My way is hidden from the LORD,
and my God ignores my rights"?

28 Don't you know? Haven't you heard?
The everlasting God, the LORD,
the Creator of the ends of the earth,
does not grow faint or weary.
His understanding cannot be searched out.
29 He gives power to the weak,
and he increases the strength of those who have no might.
30 Even young people grow faint and weary,
and young men stumble and fall.
31 But those who wait for the LORD will renew their strength.
They will rise up on wings like eagles.
They will run and not grow weary.
They will walk and not grow faint.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: The people complain: God no longer sees us. We don't matter to him.

Verses 28–29: Isaiah's answer: God never grows tired. And he gives strength to the tired.

Verse 31 is one of the most loved verses in the Bible. Whoever hopes in God receives new strength, like an eagle that lets the wind carry it upward. Many people have found courage in this verse in hard times.

If you are exhausted right now and have no strength left: You may accept help, from God and from people. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 41

Do not be afraid, for I am with you

Who has stirred up the man from the east? VERSES 1–7

1 "Be silent before me, you islands,
and let the peoples renew their strength.
Let them come near, then let them speak.
Let us come together for judgment.
2 Who has stirred up one from the east?
Who has called him in righteousness to follow him?
He hands nations over to him
and lets him rule over kings.
He makes them like dust before his sword,
like stubble blown away before his bow.
3 He chases them and passes on safely,
on a road his feet have never walked before.
4 Who has worked and done this,
calling the generations from the beginning?
I, the LORD, am the first,
and with the last, I am he."
5 The islands have seen it and are afraid.
The ends of the earth tremble.
They come near and arrive.
6 Everyone helps his neighbor.
They say to their brothers, "Be strong!"
7 So the craftsman encourages the goldsmith.
The one who smooths with the hammer encourages the one who strikes the anvil,
and says of the soldering, "It is good."
And he fastens it with nails so that it will not wobble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God calls the nations as if to a court hearing.

Verses 2–3: This is about "one from the east." That is Cyrus, the king of Persia. He conquered one country after another, and in the year 539 BC he also conquered Babylon. Isaiah says: God has called him.

Verse 4: God is the first and the last. He guides all of history.

Verses 6–7: The nations become afraid and encourage each other by quickly building new idols and nailing them down. Isaiah describes this with mockery.

Do not be afraid VERSES 8–16

8 "But you, Israel, my servant,
Jacob, whom I have chosen,
descendant of Abraham, my friend,
9 you whom I have taken hold of from the ends of the earth
and called from its farthest corners,
and to whom I said,
'You are my servant.
I have chosen you and have not rejected you':
10 Do not be afraid, for I am with you.
Do not be discouraged, for I am your God.
I will strengthen you.
Yes, I will help you.
Yes, I will uphold you with the right hand of my righteousness.
11 Look, all who rage against you
will be disappointed and put to shame.
Those who fight with you will be like nothing and will perish.
12 You will look for them and not find them,
those who fight with you.
Those who wage war against you will be like nothing,
like something that does not exist.
13 For I, the LORD your God,
hold your right hand
and say to you, 'Do not be afraid! I will help you.'
14 Do not be afraid, you worm Jacob,
and you men of Israel.
I will help you," says the LORD.
"Your Redeemer is the Holy One of Israel.
15 Look, I have made you into a new, sharp threshing sledge with teeth.
You will thresh the mountains and crush them
and make the hills like chaff.
16 You will winnow them, and the wind will carry them away,
and the storm will scatter them.
You will rejoice in the LORD.
You will boast in the Holy One of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: God calls Abraham "my friend." What an honor! And Israel is his "servant," whom he has chosen.

Verse 10 is one of the most comforting verses in the Bible: "Do not be afraid, for I am with you. … I will strengthen you. Yes, I will help you. Yes, I will uphold you."

Verse 13: God holds the hand of his people, the way a father or mother holds a child by the hand.

Verse 14: "You worm Jacob": In exile, Israel feels as small and weak as a worm. God says: It is you I will help. The Hebrew word for "Redeemer" is "Go'el": a relative who stands up for a family member in need and buys them free. In the same way, God stands up for his people.

Verses 15–16: With God's help, the weak people become as strong as a threshing sledge that crushes mountains. This is a picture of God removing all obstacles.

Water in the desert VERSES 17–20

17 The poor and needy look for water, and there is none.
Their tongue is dry with thirst.
I, the LORD, will answer them.
I, the God of Israel, will not abandon them.
18 I will open rivers on the bare heights
and springs in the middle of the valleys.
I will make the wilderness a pool of water
and the dry land springs of water.
19 I will put cedar, acacia, myrtle and oil trees in the wilderness.
I will set cypress, pine and box trees together in the desert,
20 so that they may see, know, consider and understand together
that the hand of the LORD has done this
and the Holy One of Israel has created it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God takes care of the poor and the thirsty. The desert through which those returning home travel becomes a garden with water and trees.

This recalls the journey through the wilderness after the exodus from Egypt, when God gave water from the rock.

Verse 20: Everyone is to recognize from this that God is the Creator.

The idols can do nothing VERSES 21–29

21 "Present your case," says the LORD.
"Bring out your strong arguments!" says the King of Jacob.
22 "Let them announce and tell us what will happen!
Tell us the former things, what they were,
so that we may think about them and know how they turned out.
Or let us hear the things to come.
23 Tell us what is going to happen in the future,
so that we may know that you are gods.
Yes, do good or do evil,
so that we may be terrified and see it together.
24 Look, you are nothing, and your work is nothing.
Whoever chooses you is detestable.
25 I have stirred up one from the north, and he has come,
from the rising of the sun, one who calls on my name.
He will trample rulers like mortar,
as the potter treads clay.
26 Who announced it from the beginning, so that we might know,
and beforehand, so that we might say, 'He is right'?
Surely, there is no one who announced it.
Surely, there is no one who showed it.
Surely, there is no one who hears your words.
27 I am the first to say to Zion, 'Look, here they are!'
And I will give Jerusalem a messenger of good news.
28 When I look, there is no one,
and among them there is no adviser
who can answer a word when I ask.
29 Look, all their deeds are empty and nothing.
Their cast idols are wind and confusion."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another court hearing: God challenges the gods of Babylon. If you are gods, then tell us what will happen! Or at least do something, good or evil!

But the idols are silent. They can do nothing.

Verse 25: Cyrus comes "from the north" and "from the rising of the sun," that is, from the northeast. Persia lay to the east, but Cyrus first conquered regions in the north.

Verse 27: Only the living God can foretell and fulfill what he promises.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 42

The first song of God's servant

My servant brings justice VERSES 1–9

1 "Look, my servant, whom I uphold,
my chosen one, in whom my soul delights:
I have put my Spirit on him.
He will bring justice to the nations.
2 He will not shout or raise his voice
or make it heard in the street.
3 He will not break a bruised reed,
and he will not put out a dimly burning wick.
He will faithfully bring justice.
4 He will not grow faint or be discouraged
until he has set up justice on the earth,
and the islands wait for his teaching."
5 This is what God, the LORD, says,
who created the heavens and stretched them out,
who spread out the earth and what comes from it,
who gives breath to the people on it
and spirit to those who walk on it:
6 "I, the LORD, have called you in righteousness.
I will hold your hand.
I will keep you

and make you a covenant for the people,
a light for the nations,
7 to open the blind eyes,
to bring the prisoners out of the dungeon,
and those who sit in darkness out of the prison.
8 I am the LORD. That is my name.
I will not give my glory to anyone else,
or my praise to carved idols.
9 Look, the former things have happened,
and I announce new things.
Before they spring up, I tell you about them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins the first of four songs about the "Servant of God" (the others are in chapters 49, 50 and 52–53).

Who is this servant? He is chosen by God, God's Spirit rests on him, and he brings justice to all nations.

Verses 2–3: He does not do it with noise and violence, but very gently. He does not break off a "bruised reed," and he does not blow out a wick that has almost gone out. He treats the weak and the hurt with care. A beautiful picture of gentleness.

Verses 6–7: He becomes "a light for the nations": He opens blind eyes and sets prisoners free.

In Judaism, the servant is mostly understood as the people of Israel itself (compare chapter 41:8), which is to be a light for the nations, or also as the prophet. The New Testament connects these words with Jesus (Matthew 12:18–21). At the baptism of Jesus, verse 1 is echoed: "You are my Son. I love you. I am very pleased with you" (Mark 1:11).

A new song VERSES 10–17

10 Sing to the LORD a new song,
his praise from the end of the earth,
you who go down to the sea, and everything in it,
you islands and those who live there.
11 Let the wilderness and its cities raise their voices,
the villages where Kedar lives.
Let the people of Sela sing.
Let them shout for joy from the tops of the mountains!
12 Let them give glory to the LORD
and announce his praise in the islands.
13 The LORD goes out like a hero.
He stirs up his zeal like a warrior.
He raises a war cry.
Yes, he shouts aloud.
He wins the victory over his enemies.
14 "I have been silent for a long time.
I have been quiet and held myself back.
Now I will cry out like a woman giving birth.
I will gasp and pant at the same time.
15 I will lay waste mountains and hills
and dry up all their plants.
I will turn rivers into islands
and dry up the pools.
16 I will lead the blind by a way they do not know.
I will guide them on paths they do not know.
I will turn the darkness before them into light
and make the crooked places straight.
These are the things I will do,
and I will not abandon them.
17 Those who trust in carved idols,
who say to cast images, 'You are our gods,'
will be turned back.
They will be completely disappointed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–12: The whole world is to sing a new song to God: from the sea to the desert, from the islands to the mountains.

Verses 13–14: Two strong pictures of God: a hero going into battle, and a woman in labor who cries out and pants. God has been silent for a long time. Now something new is breaking out like a birth. The Bible sometimes also speaks of God with female pictures.

Verse 16: A comforting verse: God leads the blind on ways they do not know. He makes the darkness light. He does not abandon them. This is true for everyone who cannot see their way.

The blind and deaf people VERSES 18–25

18 "Hear, you deaf,
and look, you blind, so that you may see!
19 Who is blind but my servant?
Or who is as deaf as my messenger whom I send?
Who is as blind as the one who is at peace,
and as blind as the servant of the LORD?
20 You see many things, but you do not pay attention.
His ears are open, but he does not listen.
21 It pleased the LORD, for the sake of his righteousness,
to make the law great and glorious.
22 But this is a robbed and plundered people.
All of them are trapped in holes
and hidden away in prisons.
They have become captives, and no one rescues them,
plunder, and no one says, 'Give them back!'
23 Who among you will listen to this?
Who will pay attention and listen for the time to come?
24 Who handed Jacob over to be plundered
and Israel to the robbers?
Was it not the LORD, against whom we have sinned?
For they would not walk in his ways,
and they did not obey his law.
25 So he poured out on him the heat of his anger
and the violence of war.
It set him on fire all around, but he did not understand.
It burned him, but he did not take it to heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Israel is addressed as God's "servant," but as a blind and deaf servant. The people were meant to be a light for the nations, but they themselves did not see and hear.

Verse 22: In exile, the people are like prisoners in holes, robbed, and no one helps.

Verses 24–25: This happened because the people did not listen to God. And even in their misfortune, they did not understand why.

This honesty about one's own guilt is part of the Book of Comfort. But in the next chapter God says: "Do not be afraid, for I have redeemed you!" (Isaiah 43:1).

ISAIAH

Chapter 43

I have called you by your name

You are mine VERSES 1–7

1 But now this is what the LORD says, who created you,
Jacob,
and who formed you, Israel:
"Do not be afraid, for I have redeemed you.
I have called you by your name.
You are mine.
2 When you pass through the waters, I will be with you,
and through the rivers, they will not sweep over you.
When you walk through the fire, you will not be
burned,
and the flame will not scorch you.
3 For I am the LORD your God,
the Holy One of Israel, your Savior.
I have given Egypt as your ransom,
Ethiopia and Seba in your place.
4 Because you are precious and honored in my eyes,
and I love you,
I will give people in your place
and nations in exchange for your life.
5 Do not be afraid, for I am with you.
I will bring your descendants from the east
and gather you from the west.
6 I will say to the north, 'Give them up!'
and to the south, 'Do not hold them back!
Bring my sons from far away
and my daughters from the ends of the earth,
7 everyone who is called by my name,
whom I have created for my glory,
whom I have formed, yes, whom I have made.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 is one of the best-known verses in the Bible: "Do not be afraid, for I have redeemed you. I have called you by your name. You are mine." Many people are given it as a Bible verse to take with them at their baptism or confirmation. God knows every person by name.

Verse 2: God does not promise that there will be no dangers, no water and no fire. But he promises: I am with you, right in the middle of it.

Verses 3–4: God says to his people: You are so precious to me that I would give up whole countries for you. This is the language of love. The WEB, our English source text, has "Ethiopia" here. It means Cush, the land south of Egypt. Later, the Persians did in fact conquer Egypt after they had set Israel free. This is not about other nations being worth less, but about how valuable Israel is to God.

Verses 5–7: God will bring his children home from every direction, expressly sons and daughters.

You are my witnesses VERSES 8–13

8 Bring out the people who are blind, even though they
have eyes,
and the deaf, even though they have ears.
9 Let all the nations gather together,
and let the peoples assemble.
Who among them can announce this
and show us the former things?
Let them bring their witnesses to prove they are right,
or let them listen and say, "That is true."
10 "You are my witnesses," says the LORD,
"together with my servant whom I have chosen,
so that you may know and believe me
and understand that I am he.
Before me no god was formed,
and there will be none after me.
11 I, I am the LORD.
Besides me there is no savior.
12 I have announced, I have saved, and I have shown it,
and there was no foreign god among you.
So you are my witnesses," says the LORD,
"and I am God.
13 Yes, since the first day, I am he.
There is no one who can rescue from my hand.
I act, and who can stop it?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another court hearing. The nations are to bring witnesses for their gods. God also has witnesses: his people Israel. Even though they are "blind" and "deaf" (verse 8), they can bear witness to what God has done.

Verses 10–11: "Before me no god was formed, and there will be none after me. … Besides me there is no savior." Here it is said very clearly: There is only one single God.

I am doing a new thing VERSES 14–21

14 The LORD, your Redeemer, the Holy One of Israel, says:
"For your sake I have sent to Babylon,
and I will bring all of them down as refugees,
even the Chaldeans, in the ships they were so proud of.
15 I am the LORD, your Holy One,
the Creator of Israel, your King."
16 The LORD, who makes a way in the sea
and a path through the mighty waters,
17 who brings out chariot and horse,
the army and the warrior
(they lie down together, they will not rise again;
they are snuffed out, put out like a wick), says:
18 "Do not remember the former things,
and do not keep thinking about the things of the past.
19 Look, I am doing a new thing.
Now it springs up. Don't you see it?
I will make a way in the wilderness
and rivers in the desert.
20 The animals of the field will honor me,
the jackals and the ostriches,
because I give water in the wilderness
and rivers in the desert,
to give drink to my people, my chosen ones,
21 the people I formed for myself,
so that they may announce my praise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Babylon will fall. The Chaldeans are the Babylonians. The ships in which they used to sail proudly and happily on the Euphrates become boats for running away.

Verses 16–17: This recalls the exodus from Egypt: God made a way through the sea, and Pharaoh's chariots sank.

Verses 18–19: And yet God says: Do not only think of the old things! "Look, I am doing a new thing." The return home from Babylon will be a new exodus, with a road through the desert. These verses still give courage today: God can open a new way even in a hopeless situation.

I blot out your sins VERSES 22–28

22 But you have not called on me, Jacob;
instead, you have grown tired of me, Israel.
23 You have not brought me your sheep for burnt offerings,
and you have not honored me with your sacrifices.
I have not burdened you with offerings
or worn you out with incense.
24 You have not bought me sweet cane with money,
and you have not filled me with the fat of your sacrifices,
but you have burdened me with your sins.
You have worn me out with your wrongdoings.
25 I, I am the one who blots out your rebellious acts for my own sake,
and I will not remember your sins.
26 Remind me! Let us argue the case together!
Present your case, so that you may be proved right.
27 Your first father sinned,
and your teachers have rebelled against me.
28 So I will dishonor the princes of the sanctuary,
and I will hand Jacob over to the curse and Israel to scorn."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–24: God complains: You have not honestly sought me. You have not worn me out with sacrifices, but with your sins. God does not ask for much at all, but the people have loaded burdens on him.

Verse 25: Even so, this is the heart of it: God himself blots out the guilt, "for my own sake." Not because the people deserved it, but because that is what God is like. And he no longer wants to remember the sins.

Verse 27: The "first father" probably means Jacob. There was guilt right from the beginning.

Verse 28: That is why the exile came: The temple was dishonored, the people mocked. But verse 25 is stronger: Forgiveness has the last word.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 44

I am the first and the last

My Spirit for your children VERSES 1–8

1 But listen now, Jacob, my servant,
and Israel, whom I have chosen.
2 This is what the LORD says, who made you
and formed you from the womb, who will help you:
"Do not be afraid, Jacob, my servant,
and you, Jeshurun, whom I have chosen.
3 For I will pour water on the thirsty
and streams on the dry ground.
I will pour my Spirit on your descendants
and my blessing on your children.
4 They will spring up among the grass
like willows by the streams of water.
5 One will say, 'I belong to the LORD.'
Another will call himself by the name of Jacob.
And another will write on his hand, 'The LORD's,'
and honor the name of Israel."
6 This is what the LORD says, the King of Israel,
and his Redeemer, the LORD of Armies:
"I am the first, and I am the last,
and besides me there is no God.
7 Who is like me? Who will call it out
and announce it and lay it out before me,
since I established the ancient people?
Let them announce what is coming
and what will happen.
8 Do not fear, and do not be afraid.
Haven't I announced it to you long ago and shown it?
You are my witnesses.
Is there a God besides me?
No, there is none.
I do not know any other Rock."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Jeshurun" is a loving name for Israel. It means something like "the upright one" or "the darling" (as in Deuteronomy 32:15 and 33:5).

Verses 3–4: God pours out his Spirit like water on dry ground. The children will grow like trees by a stream.

Verse 5: People joyfully declare that they belong to God: "I belong to the LORD." Some even write it on their hand, as a sign of belonging.

Verse 6: "I am the first, and I am the last." God was there before everything and will be there after everything. The book of Revelation takes up these words (Revelation 1:17 and 22:13).

Verse 8: God is the only "Rock" you can rely on.

How foolish it is to make an idol! VERSES 9–20

9 All who make a carved idol are worthless.
The things they delight in are of no use.
Their own witnesses do not see or know,
so they will be put to shame.
10 Who has shaped a god
or cast an idol that is good for nothing?
11 Look, all his companions will be put to shame,
and the craftsmen are only human.
Let them all gather together. Let them stand up.

They will be afraid.
They will be put to shame together.

12 The blacksmith takes an ax,
works it in the coals,
shapes it with hammers
and works it with his strong arm.
He gets hungry, and his strength fails.
He drinks no water and grows faint.

13 The carpenter stretches out a measuring line.
He marks it out with a pencil.
He shapes it with planes.
He marks it out with a compass
and shapes it in the form of a man,
with the beauty of a human being,
so that it can live in a house.

14 He cuts down cedars for himself,
and takes a cypress and an oak,
and lets one grow strong among the trees of the forest.
He plants a cypress tree, and the rain makes it grow.

15 Then it is used by people for burning.
He takes some of it and warms himself.
Yes, he lights a fire and bakes bread.
Yes, he makes a god from it and worships it.
He makes a carved idol from it and bows down before it.

16 He burns part of it in the fire.
With part of it he eats meat.
He roasts a roast and is full.
Yes, he warms himself and says, "Aha! I am warm. I have seen the fire."

17 The rest of it he makes into a god, his carved idol.
He bows down before it and worships it,
and prays to it and says,
"Save me, for you are my god!"

18 They do not know and do not understand,
for he has shut their eyes, so that they cannot see,
and their hearts, so that they cannot understand.

19 No one stops to think,
and there is no knowledge or understanding to say,
"I burned part of it in the fire.
Yes, I also baked bread on its coals.
I roasted meat and ate it.
Shall I make the rest of it into something detestable?
Shall I bow down to a block of wood?"

20 He feeds on ashes.
A deceived heart has led him astray.
He cannot save his soul
or say, "Isn't there a lie in my right hand?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most mocking passages in the Bible. Isaiah describes very precisely how an idol is made:

Verse 12: The blacksmith works so hard that he gets hungry and thirsty. A god whose maker grows tired!

Verses 14–17: A man cuts down a tree. With one half he heats his home and roasts his meat. From the other half he carves a god and prays: "Save me!"

Verses 19–20: Doesn't he notice that he is bowing down to a block of wood? He is holding a lie in his hand.

For us today: We probably do not carve gods out of wood. But today, too, people can turn things they have made themselves into their "god," for example money, success or reputation, and expect to be saved by them.

I have redeemed you VERSES 21–23

21 Remember these things, Jacob and Israel,
for you are my servant.
I have formed you. You are my servant.
Israel, I will not forget you.

22 I have blotted out your rebellious acts like a thick cloud
and your sins like a cloud.
Return to me, for I have redeemed you.

23 Sing, you heavens, for the LORD has done it!
Shout, you depths of the earth!
Break out into singing, you mountains,
you forest and all your trees,
for the LORD has redeemed Jacob
and will show his glory in Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: "I will not forget you." The idols have to be made by people. But Israel is made by God, and he does not forget it.

Verse 22: The sins are gone like a cloud that disappears. First comes forgiveness, then the invitation: "Return to me!" God does not wait until the people improve.

Verse 23: The whole creation is to shout for joy about this: heaven, earth, mountains and trees.

Cyrus, my shepherd VERSES 24–28

24 The LORD, your Redeemer,
who formed you from the womb, says:
"I am the LORD, who makes all things,
who alone stretches out the heavens,
who spreads out the earth all by myself,

25 who makes the signs of liars fail
and makes fools of fortune-tellers,
who turns the wise back
and makes their knowledge foolish,

26 who confirms the word of his servant
and carries out the plans of his messengers,
who says of Jerusalem, 'She will be lived in,'
and of the cities of Judah, 'They will be built,'
and, 'I will raise up their ruins again,'

27 who says to the deep, 'Dry up!'
and, 'I will dry up your rivers,'

28 who says of Cyrus, 'He is my shepherd,
and he will carry out everything I want,'
and says of Jerusalem, 'She will be built,'
and of the temple, 'Your foundation will be laid.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Babylon was famous for its astrologers and fortune-tellers. God says: Their predictions will turn out to be false.

Verses 26–28: But God keeps his word. Jerusalem and the temple will be rebuilt.

Verse 28: Here the name is mentioned for the first time: Cyrus, the king of the Persians. God calls him "my shepherd," even though he is a foreign king who does not know God. In the year 538 BC, Cyrus really did allow the Jews to return home and rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:1–4).

Many scholars think that this part of the book of Isaiah was written at the time of Cyrus by a later prophet in Isaiah's

tradition. Others, especially in Jewish and Christian tradition, see here a prediction by Isaiah long before the time of Cyrus.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 45

Cyrus, the LORD's anointed

I have called you by your name, Cyrus VERSES 1–8

1 This is what the LORD says to his anointed, to Cyrus,
whose right hand I have held
to bring nations down before him
and strip kings of their armor,
to open the doors before him,
so that the gates will not stay shut:
2 "I will go before you
and make the rough places smooth.
I will break the doors of bronze in pieces
and cut through the bars of iron.
3 I will give you the treasures of darkness
and hidden riches from secret places,
so that you may know that it is I, the LORD,
who calls you by your name, the God of Israel.
4 For the sake of Jacob, my servant,
and Israel, my chosen one,
I have called you by your name.
I have given you a title of honor,
even though you have not known me.
5 I am the LORD, and there is no one else.
Besides me there is no God.
I will strengthen you,
even though you have not known me,
6 so that people may know from the rising of the sun
and from the west that there is no one besides me.
I am the LORD, and there is no one else.
7 I form the light and create darkness.
I make peace and create disaster.
I am the LORD, who does all these things.
8 Rain down, you heavens, from above,
and let the skies pour down righteousness.
Let the earth open up so that it produces salvation,
and let it make righteousness spring up with it.
I, the LORD, have created it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Something truly astonishing: God calls the Persian king Cyrus his "anointed." In Hebrew this is "Mashiach," the word that "Messiah" comes from. Otherwise, only the kings and priests of Israel were called this. A foreign king who does not know God (verses 4–5) becomes God's tool to set Israel free.

Verse 3: "Treasures of darkness" are hidden treasures in treasure chambers. Cyrus conquered rich cities like Sardis and Babylon.

Verse 7: A difficult verse: God creates light and darkness, peace and disaster. Isaiah wants to say: There is no second god, no god of darkness next to the god of light, as the Persians believed. Everything lies in the hand of the one God. This does not mean that God enjoys misfortune. In the Jewish morning prayer, this verse is prayed in a changed form: God is the one *who makes peace and creates all things*.

Verse 8: A beautiful picture: Righteousness falls from heaven like rain and grows out of the earth like plants. The old Latin version of this verse ("Rorate caeli," "Drop down, you heavens") is sung during Advent.

The clay and the potter VERSES 9–13

9 How terrible for the one who argues with his Maker,
a clay pot among the clay pots of the earth!
Shall the clay say to the one who shapes it, 'What are you making?'
or your work say, 'He has no hands'?
10 How terrible for the one who says to a father, 'What are you fathering?'
or to a mother, 'What are you giving birth to?'"
11 The LORD, the Holy One of Israel and his Maker, says:
"You ask me about the things that are to come,
about my sons,
and you want to give me orders about the work of my hands!
12 I have made the earth
and created human beings on it.
I, my own hands, stretched out the heavens.
I commanded all their army.
13 I have stirred him up in righteousness,
and I will make all his ways straight.
He will build my city,
and he will let my exiles go free,
not for a price and not for a reward,"
says the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some among the people were probably outraged: A foreign king is supposed to be our savior? That cannot be God's plan!

Verses 9–10: Isaiah answers with a picture: A clay pot cannot tell the potter what to do. A child cannot blame its parents for having given birth to it.

Verse 13: Cyrus will have Jerusalem rebuilt and set the exiles free, without a ransom. That is really what happened (Ezra 1).

Turn to me, all the ends of the earth VERSES 14–25

14 This is what the LORD says:
"The produce of Egypt, and the goods of Ethiopia,
and the Sabeans, tall men,
will come over to you, and they will be yours.
They will follow behind you.
They will come over in chains.
They will bow down before you.
They will plead with you:
'Surely God is with you, and there is no one else.
There is no other god.
15 Truly, you are a God who hides himself,
God of Israel, the Savior.'"

16 They will be disappointed, yes, put to shame, all of
them.
The makers of idols will go off in disgrace together.
17 Israel will be saved by the LORD
with an everlasting salvation.
You will not be disappointed or put to shame
forever and ever.
18 For this is what the LORD says, who created the
heavens,
the God who formed the earth and made it,
who established it
and did not create it to be empty,
who formed it to be lived in:
"I am the LORD. There is no other.
19 I have not spoken in secret,
in some place in a land of darkness.
I did not say to the descendants of Jacob,
'Seek me in vain!'
I, the LORD, speak righteousness.
I announce what is right.
20 Gather together and come!
Come near together, you who have escaped from the
nations!
Those who carry around the wood of their carved idol
have no knowledge,
and they pray to a god that cannot save.
21 Announce it and present it!
Yes, let them consult with each other.
Who told of this from ancient times?
Who announced it long ago?
Wasn't it I, the LORD?
There is no other God besides me,
a righteous God and a Savior.
There is no one besides me.
22 Look to me and be saved,
all the ends of the earth!
For I am God, and there is no other.
23 I have sworn by myself.
The word has gone out of my mouth in righteousness
and will not be taken back:
To me every knee will bow,
every tongue will swear loyalty.
24 They will say about me,
'Only in the LORD is there righteousness and
strength.'"
People will come to him.
All who raged against him will be disappointed.
25 All the descendants of Israel will be declared righteous
in the LORD
and will rejoice!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Nations from the south (Egypt, Cush and Sheba, the land of the Sabeans) come to Israel and recognize: The true God is with you. For Cush, the WEB, our English source text, says "Ethiopia" here. The picture with the chains comes from the language of that time, when defeated nations had to hand over prisoners. But the tone of the passage is not violence, but that all nations will recognize the one God. The Bible does not justify oppressing people.

Verse 15: "You are a God who hides himself." God is not easy to see or to understand. Many people know this experience.

Verse 18: God did not create the earth to be an empty desert, but so that people could live there.

Verse 22: An invitation to the whole world: "Look to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth!" God's salvation is not only for Israel, but for all nations.

Verse 23: "To me every knee will bow." Paul takes up these words in his letter to the Philippians (2:10–11) and applies them to Jesus. In Judaism, the thought that one day all nations will acknowledge the one God is part of the prayer "Aleinu."

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 46

I will carry you into old age

The gods of Babylon have to be carried VERSES 1–7

1 Bel bows down. Nebo stoops.
Their idols are loaded on animals and on livestock.
The things you carried around are heavy loads,
a burden for the weary animal.
2 They stoop and bow down together.
They could not rescue the burden,
but they themselves have gone into captivity.
3 "Listen to me, house of Jacob,
and all the remnant of the house of Israel,
you who have been carried since your birth,
you who have been carried from the womb.
4 Even into your old age I am he,
and even when your hair is gray I will carry you.
I have made you, and I will bear you.
Yes, I will carry you and will rescue you.
5 To whom will you compare me and make me equal,
and measure me, as if we were alike?
6 Some pour out gold from the bag
and weigh silver on the scales.
They hire a goldsmith, and he makes it into a god.
They fall down, yes, they worship.
7 They lift it onto their shoulder.
They carry it and set it in its place, and there it stands.
It cannot move from its place.
Yes, someone may cry out to it, but it cannot answer.
It cannot save anyone from their trouble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Bel (another name for Marduk) was the chief god of Babylon, Nebo (Nabu) his son. Their statues were carried around in processions at great festivals. Isaiah sees a different scene: The idols lie as a heavy load on exhausted pack animals, in flight or as plunder. The gods cannot even save themselves.

Verses 3–4: The contrast: The idols have to be carried by people. But Israel's God carries his people, from birth into old age, "even when your hair is gray." A wonderful comfort

for older people: God still carries you even when your strength fades.

Verse 7: An idol just stands there. People cry out to it, but it does not answer.

My plan will stand VERSES 8–13

8 Remember this and show yourselves to be men!
Take it to heart again, you rebels.
9 Remember the former things of long ago,
for I am God, and there is no other.
I am God, and there is no one like me.
10 I announce the end from the beginning,
and from ancient times what has not yet been done.
I say: My plan will stand,
and I will do everything I please.
11 I call a bird of prey from the east,
the man of my plan from a faraway land.
Yes, I have spoken, and I will make it happen.
I have planned it, and I will do it.
12 Listen to me, you stubborn-hearted,
who are far from righteousness!
13 I bring my righteousness near.
It is not far away, and my salvation will not be delayed.
I will give salvation to Zion,
my glory to Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: God knows the end from the beginning. He has a plan for history, and this plan will succeed.

Verse 11: The "bird of prey from the east" is Cyrus again. He swoops down on his prey quickly, like an eagle.

Verses 12–13: The message also goes out to those who do not want to believe: God's salvation is very near. It will not come at some point far away, but soon.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 47

A song of mourning over Babylon

Come down, daughter of Babylon VERSES 1–7

1 "Come down and sit in the dust,
virgin daughter of Babylon!
Sit on the ground without a throne,
daughter of the Chaldeans!
For you will no longer be called tender and delicate.
2 Take the millstones and grind flour!
Take off your veil, lift up your skirt,
uncover your legs and wade through the rivers!
3 Your nakedness will be uncovered.
Yes, your shame will be seen.
I will take vengeance and will spare no one."
4 Our Redeemer, the LORD of Armies is his name,
is the Holy One of Israel.
5 "Sit in silence and go into the darkness,
daughter of the Chaldeans!
For you will no longer be called the mistress of kingdoms.
6 I was angry with my people.
I dishonored my inheritance
and handed them over to you.
You showed them no mercy.
You laid a very heavy yoke on the old.
7 You said, 'I will be a princess forever,'
so you did not take these things to heart
and did not think about the consequences.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is a mocking song about the city of Babylon. The city is pictured as a noble young woman, the "daughter of Babylon." People often spoke of cities in this way at that time.

Verses 1–3: The proud mistress has to come down from the throne and becomes a slave: She has to grind flour and wade through rivers without a veil. That is what happened to prisoners in those days. The pictures of being exposed describe how the mighty city is humiliated. They are a picture of a city and its power. They never justify exposing women, humiliating them or doing violence to them. If you experience violence, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verse 3: "Vengeance" here means that God restores justice. Babylon had treated many nations cruelly.

Verse 6: God handed his people over to Babylon as a punishment. But Babylon went far beyond every limit: It had no mercy, not even on the old. For this it will be held responsible.

"I am, and there is no one else"? VERSES 8–15

8 But now hear this, you lover of pleasure,
who sit there without a care,
who say in your heart,
'I am, and there is no one else besides me.
I will not sit as a widow,
and I will not know the loss of children.'
9 But both these things will come upon you
in a moment, in one day:
the loss of children and widowhood.
They will come upon you in full measure,
in spite of your many sorceries
and the great number of your spells.
10 For you have trusted in your wickedness.
You have said, 'No one sees me.'
Your wisdom and your knowledge have led you astray.
You have said in your heart,
'I am, and there is no one else besides me.'
11 So disaster will come upon you.
You will not know when it dawns.
Ruin will fall on you.
You will not be able to turn it away.
Destruction will come on you suddenly,
which you do not understand.
12 Stand up now with your spells
and with your many sorceries,
which you have worked hard at since your youth,

as if you might gain something from them,
as if you might win.
13 You are worn out by all your many plans.
Now let the astrologers stand up,
the stargazers and those who make predictions every month,
and save you from what is coming upon you.
14 Look, they are like stubble.
The fire will burn them up.
They will not save themselves from the power of the flame.
It will not be a coal to warm yourself at
or a fire to sit by.
15 This is how it will be with all you worked so hard for:
Those who have traded with you since your youth
will each wander off on their own way.
There will be no one to save you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8 and 10: Babylon says: "I am, and there is no one else besides me." That is exactly what God says about himself (Isaiah 45:5–6). Babylon has put itself in God's place. That is the deepest reason for its fall.

Verse 9: To become a widow and childless was the worst misfortune for a woman in those days. For the city it means: It loses its king and its inhabitants.

Verses 12–13: Babylon was famous for astrology and spells. Isaiah mocks: Let the astrologers save you now!

Verse 14: Their wisdom burns like straw. There is not even a cozy fire left to warm yourself.

For us today: No person, no company and no state should think: "I am the greatest, and no one sees what I do." Power without responsibility leads to ruin. In the book of Revelation (chapter 18), "Babylon" becomes a picture of every godless, arrogant power.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 48

Leave Babylon!

You are stubborn VERSES 1–11

1 "Hear this, house of Jacob,
you who are called by the name of Israel
and have come from the waters of Judah.
You swear by the name of the LORD
and speak of the God of Israel,
but not in truth and not in righteousness.
2 For they call themselves citizens of the holy city
and rely on the God of Israel.
The LORD of Armies is his name.
3 I announced the former things long ago.
Yes, they went out from my mouth, and I made them known.
Suddenly I did them, and they happened.
4 Because I knew that you are stubborn,
and your neck is an iron sinew,
and your forehead is bronze,
5 I announced it to you long ago.
Before it happened, I showed it to you,
so that you would not say, 'My idol did it.
My carved idol and my cast idol commanded it.'
6 You have heard it. Now look at all of this.
And you, won't you announce it?
From now on I am showing you new things,
hidden things that you have not known.
7 They are created now, and not long ago.
Before today you did not hear of them,
so that you cannot say, 'Look, I already knew them.'
8 Yes, you did not hear.
Yes, you did not know.
Yes, from long ago your ear was not open,
for I knew that you act very unfaithfully
and were called a rebel from the womb.
9 For the sake of my name I hold back my anger,
and for the sake of my praise I restrain it for you,
so that I do not cut you off.
10 Look, I have refined you, but not like silver.
I have chosen you in the furnace of affliction.
11 For my own sake, for my own sake I will do it.
For how could my name be dishonored?
I will not give my glory to anyone else.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: God speaks honestly with his people: You call yourselves devout and talk about God, but your life does not match it.

Verses 4–5: Israel is stubborn. God says: I knew "that you are stubborn, and your neck is an iron sinew, and your forehead is bronze." That is why God announced the events long in advance. So no one could say: "My idol did it."

Verses 6–7: But now God is doing something completely new, the liberation from Babylon. No one could have known it beforehand.

Verse 10: The exile was like a furnace. In a furnace, metal is cleaned of slag. The suffering was hard, but God did not abandon his people in it: "I have chosen you in the furnace of affliction."

Verses 9 and 11: God does not save his people because they are so good, but "for my own sake," because he is true to himself and to his word.

I am the first and the last VERSES 12–16

12 Listen to me, Jacob,
and Israel, whom I have called:
I am he. I am the first.
I am also the last.
13 Yes, my hand laid the foundation of the earth,
and my right hand spread out the heavens.
When I call to them, they all stand up together.
14 Gather together, all of you, and listen!
Who among them has announced these things?
The one the LORD loves will do what he wants with Babylon,
and his arm will be against the Chaldeans.

15 I, I have spoken.
Yes, I have called him.
I have brought him, and he will succeed in his way.
16 Come near to me and hear this:
From the beginning I have not spoken in secret.
From the time it happened, I was there."
And now the Lord GOD has sent me with his Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: "The one the LORD loves" is Cyrus again. God has called him to conquer Babylon.

Verse 16: At the end, suddenly an "I" speaks who is not God himself: "The Lord GOD has sent me with his Spirit." This is probably the prophet himself, speaking here about his task. Christian interpreters have also seen in this verse a hint of the Father, the Son and the Spirit.

If only you had listened to me! VERSES 17–22

17 This is what the LORD says, your Redeemer, the Holy One of Israel:
"I am the LORD your God,
who teaches you what is good for you,
who leads you on the way you should go.
18 Oh, if only you had paid attention to my commandments!
Then your peace would have been like a river
and your righteousness like the waves of the sea.
19 Your descendants would also have been like the sand
and your children like its grains.
Their name would never be cut off or destroyed before me."
20 Leave Babylon!
Flee from the Chaldeans!
Announce it with shouts of joy,
make it heard to the end of the earth!
Say, "The LORD has redeemed his servant Jacob!"
21 They did not go thirsty when he led them through the deserts.
He made water flow from the rock for them.
He split the rock, and the water gushed out.
22 "There is no peace," says the LORD, "for the wicked."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A sad and at the same time tender sentence from God: "Oh, if only you had paid attention to my commandments! Then your peace would have been like a river." God wants good things for his people. His commandments are meant to help them live.

Verses 20–21: The call to set out: "Leave Babylon!" As at the exodus from Egypt long ago, God will lead his people through the desert and give them water from the rock.

Verse 22: This sentence closes the first part of the Book of Comfort (it comes again in chapter 57:21). Whoever sets themselves against God finds no inner peace.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 49

I will not forget you

The second song of God's servant VERSES 1–7

1 Listen to me, you islands!
Listen, you peoples far away!
The LORD called me from the womb.
From inside my mother he spoke my name.
2 He made my mouth like a sharp sword.
He hid me in the shadow of his hand.
He made me into a polished arrow.
He kept me hidden close to him in his quiver.
3 He said to me, "You are my servant,
Israel, in whom I will show my glory."
4 But I said, "I have worked hard in vain.
I have used up my strength for nothing, for no purpose.
Yet surely my right is with the LORD,
and my reward is with my God."
5 But now the LORD says,
who formed me from the womb to be his servant,
to bring Jacob back to him
and to gather Israel to him,
for I am honored in the eyes of the LORD,
and my God has become my strength.
6 Yes, he says:
"It is too small a thing for you to be my servant
to raise up the tribes of Jacob
and to bring back those of Israel who were kept safe.
I will also make you a light for the nations,
so that my salvation may reach to the end of the earth."
7 This is what the LORD says, the Redeemer of Israel, his Holy One,
to the one whom people despise,
to the one whom the nation hates,
to a servant of rulers:
"Kings will see it and stand up,
princes, and they will bow down,
because of the LORD, who is faithful,
the Holy One of Israel, who has chosen you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the second song of God's servant. This time, the servant himself speaks.

Verses 1–2: God called him even before he was born. His word is as sharp as a sword; he is like an arrow that God keeps ready.

Verse 3: Here the servant is expressly called "Israel." This is what the Jewish interpretation is based on, that the servant is the people of Israel.

Verse 4: The servant feels: Everything was for nothing. Many people know this feeling. But he trusts: My right lies with God.

Verses 5–6: At the same time, the servant has a task for Israel: to bring the people back to God. That is why some interpreters see the servant as a single person, for example the prophet himself. And the task is even bigger: "a light for the nations," so that God's salvation reaches to the end of the earth. The New Testament applies this to Jesus (Luke 2:32) and to the mission of the apostles (Acts 13:47).

Verse 7: The servant is despised. But in the end, kings will stand up before him.

The day of salvation VERSES 8–13

8 This is what the LORD says:
"At a time of favor I have answered you,
and on a day of salvation I have helped you.
I will protect you
and make you a covenant for the people,
to restore the land,
to give out again the inheritances that lie in ruins,
9 and to say to the prisoners, 'Come out!'
and to those in darkness, 'Show yourselves!'
They will graze along the roads,
and their pasture will be on all the bare heights.
10 They will not be hungry or thirsty.
Neither heat nor sun will strike them,
for the one who has mercy on them will lead them.
He will guide them to springs of water.
11 I will turn all my mountains into a road,
and my highways will be raised up.
12 Look, these will come from far away,
and look, these from the north and from the west,
and these from the land of Sinim."
13 Sing, you heavens, and be joyful, earth!
Break out into singing, you mountains!
For the LORD has comforted his people
and will have compassion on his suffering ones.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "At a time of favor I have answered you, and on a day of salvation I have helped you." Paul quotes this verse and says: "Look, now is the acceptable time. Look, now is the day of salvation" (2 Corinthians 6:2).

Verses 9–10: Those returning home will be like a flock led by a good shepherd, without hunger, without thirst, to fresh springs. The book of Revelation takes up verse 10 (7:16–17).

Verse 12: The "land of Sinim" is not known for certain. Many think of Syene, today's Aswan in the south of Egypt. A Jewish community lived there later.

Can a woman forget her child? VERSES 14–21

14 But Zion said, "The LORD has abandoned me,
and the Lord has forgotten me."
15 "Can a woman forget her nursing child,
so that she has no compassion on the son she gave birth to?
Yes, these may forget,
but I will not forget you!
16 Look, I have engraved you on the palms of my hands.
Your walls are always before me.
17 Your children hurry back.
Those who destroyed you and laid you waste are leaving you.
18 Lift up your eyes and look around:
They are all gathering together and coming to you.
As surely as I live," says the LORD,
"you will put them all on like jewelry
and adorn yourself with them like a bride.
19 For your ruins and your deserted places
and your destroyed land,
surely now the land will be too small for those who live there,
and those who swallowed you up will be far away.
20 The children you thought you had lost
will yet say in your ears,
'This place is too small for me.
Give me room, so that I can live here.'
21 Then you will say in your heart,
'Who has given birth to these for me?
I had lost my children and was alone,
an exile, wandering about.
Who has brought these up?
Look, I was left all alone.
Where have these come from?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Zion, that is, Jerusalem, is pictured as a woman who complains: "The LORD has abandoned me, and the Lord has forgotten me."

Verse 15: God's answer is one of the most tender verses in the Bible: Can a mother forget her baby? Even if that should happen: "But I will not forget you!" God's love is like a mother's love, and even more faithful.

Verse 16: "I have engraved you on the palms of my hands." As when you write something important on your hand so that you never forget it. God always has his people before his eyes.

Verses 18–21: The lonely, childless city will suddenly be full of children, so many that there is not enough room. Zion is amazed: Where have they all come from?

If you feel abandoned by everyone right now: This verse says that God does not forget you. And you may talk to someone about it. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

I will save your children VERSES 22–26

22 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will lift up my hand to the nations
and raise my banner to the peoples.
They will bring your sons in their arms,
and your daughters will be carried on their shoulders.
23 Kings will be your foster fathers,
and their queens your nursing mothers.
They will bow down to you with their faces to the ground
and lick the dust of your feet.
Then you will know that I am the LORD,
and that those who wait for me will not be disappointed."
24 Can plunder be taken from the mighty,
or can lawful captives be set free?
25 But this is what the LORD says:
"Even the captives of the mighty will be taken away,
and the plunder of the violent will be rescued.
For I will fight with the one who fights with you,
and I will save your children.
26 I will feed your oppressors with their own flesh,
and they will be drunk with their own blood as with sweet wine.
Then all people will know
that I, the LORD, am your Savior
and your Redeemer, the Mighty One of Jacob."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–23: The nations themselves will carry the people of Israel home. Kings and queens will care for them like foster parents. "Licking the dust" is an old picture of complete surrender. What it means is: Things are turned around; the despised nation is honored.

Verses 24–25: Can a mighty man's captives be taken away from him again? Yes, God can do it. He fights for his people and saves the children.

Verse 26: A harsh picture. Many interpreters understand it like this: In the end, the oppressors destroy themselves, for example by fighting each other. This is not a call to violence. It describes how violence turns against those who use it. It is God who brings about justice.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 50

The third song of God's servant

Is my hand too short? VERSES 1–3

1 This is what the LORD says:
"Where is your mother's certificate of divorce
with which I sent her away?
Or to which of my creditors did I sell you?
Look, you were sold because of your wrongdoings,
and your mother was sent away because of your
rebellious acts.
2 Why was no one there when I came?
Why did no one answer when I called?
Is my hand too short to redeem?
Or do I have no power to rescue?
Look, with my rebuke I dry up the sea.
I turn the rivers into a desert.
Their fish stink because there is no water,
and they die of thirst.
3 I clothe the heavens in blackness.
I make sackcloth their covering."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The people in exile ask: Has God rejected us for good, like a man sending his wife away with a certificate of divorce? Has he sold us, the way children were sold because of debts? God asks back: Where is the certificate of divorce, then? There is none! The separation came because of your guilt, but it is not final. The relationship continues.

Verses 2–3: God's hand is not too short. He can rescue. He has power over the sea and the sky. The problem was that no one listened to him.

I offered my back VERSES 4–9

4 The Lord GOD has given me the tongue of those who
are taught,
so that I know how to lift up the weary with a word.
He wakes me morning by morning,
he wakes my ear to listen like those who are taught.
5 The Lord GOD has opened my ear.
I was not rebellious.
I did not turn back.
6 I offered my back to those who beat me,
and my cheeks to those who pulled out my beard.
I did not hide my face from shame and spitting.
7 For the Lord GOD will help me.
That is why I have not been disgraced.
That is why I have set my face like flint,
and I know that I will not be put to shame.
8 The one who declares me right is near.
Who will bring charges against me?
Let us stand up together!
Who is my opponent?
Let him come near to me.
9 Look, the Lord GOD will help me!
Who is the one who will condemn me?
Look, they will all wear out like a garment.
The moths will eat them up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the third song of God's servant. Again the servant himself speaks.

Verse 4: Every morning he listens to God like a student (a "disciple") listens to his teacher. And he is given the gift of lifting up tired people with words. A beautiful task for every person.

Verse 6: The servant is beaten, mocked and spat on. He does not run away. The Gospels tell that Jesus was treated this way (Matthew 26:67; 27:30). That is why Christians see a reference to Jesus here. In the Jewish interpretation, the servant stands for Israel or for the prophet, who have suffered much for their faith.

Verses 7–9: The servant holds on because he knows: God stands by me. Paul takes up this thought: "Who could bring a charge against God's chosen ones? It is God who justifies" (Romans 8:33).

Important: This text describes a person who bears suffering for his task. It does not mean that you should simply put up with violence, for example in your family or relationship. If you are being hit, you may and should get help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Whoever walks in the dark VERSES 10–11

10 Who among you fears the LORD
and listens to the voice of his servant?
Whoever walks in darkness and has no light,
let him trust in the name of the LORD
and rely on his God.
11 Look, all of you who light a fire,
who surround yourselves with torches,
walk into the flame of your own fire
and among the torches you have lit.
This is what you will receive from my hand:
You will lie down in pain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A comforting verse for everyone who is walking in the dark right now and sees no way forward: Trust in God and hold on to him. Even without light, you are not alone.

Verse 11: The others try to make their own light, with their own torches, without God. But in the end their own fire burns them.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 51

Wake up, arm of the LORD!

Look to Abraham and Sarah VERSES 1–8

1 "Listen to me, you who pursue righteousness,
you who seek the LORD!
Look to the rock you were cut from,
and to the quarry you were dug from.
2 Look to Abraham, your father,
and to Sarah, who gave birth to you.
For when he was only one, I called him.
I blessed him and made him many.
3 For the LORD has comforted Zion.
He has comforted all her ruins.
He has made her wilderness like Eden
and her desert like the garden of the LORD.
Joy and gladness will be found in her,
thanksgiving and the sound of songs.
4 Listen to me, my people,
and hear me, my nation!
For teaching will go out from me,
and I will set up my justice as a light for the peoples.
5 My righteousness is near.
My salvation has gone out,
and my arms will judge the peoples.
The islands will wait for me,
and they will trust in my arm.
6 Lift up your eyes to the heavens
and look at the earth below.
For the heavens will vanish like smoke,
and the earth will wear out like a garment.
Its inhabitants will die in the same way.
But my salvation will last forever,
and my righteousness will never come to an end.
7 Listen to me, you who know righteousness,
you people who have my teaching in your heart!
Do not fear the scorn of people,
and do not be terrified by their insults.
8 For the moth will eat them up like a garment,
and the worm will eat them like wool.
But my righteousness will last forever
and my salvation for all generations."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The people in exile feel few and weak. God says: Think of Abraham and Sarah! They were only two old people without children. And yet a great people came from them. In the same way, God can make something great out of you again.

Verse 3: Destroyed Jerusalem will be like the Garden of Eden again, full of joy and music.

Verse 6: Even heaven and earth are not eternal. But God's salvation lasts forever.

Verses 7–8: Whoever carries God's teaching in their heart does not need to be afraid of people's mockery. The mockers pass away; God's righteousness remains.

The redeemed come home VERSES 9–16

9 Wake up, wake up, put on strength, arm of the LORD!
Wake up as in the days of old,
in the generations of long ago!
Wasn't it you who cut Rahab to pieces,
who pierced the monster?
10 Wasn't it you who dried up the sea,
the waters of the great deep,
who made the depths of the sea into a road
for the redeemed to cross over?
11 Those the LORD has set free will return
and come to Zion with singing.
Everlasting joy will be on their heads.
They will receive gladness and joy.
Sorrow and sighing will run away.
12 "I, I am the one who comforts you.
Who are you, that you are afraid of a human being
who will die,
and of a mortal who will wither like grass?
13 Have you forgotten the LORD, your Maker,
who stretched out the heavens
and laid the foundations of the earth?
Do you live in constant fear all day long
because of the rage of the oppressor
when he gets ready to destroy?
But where is the rage of the oppressor?
14 The captive exile will soon be set free.
He will not die and go down into the pit.
He will not run out of bread.
15 For I am the LORD your God,
who stirs up the sea so that its waves roar.
The LORD of Armies is his name.
16 I have put my words in your mouth
and covered you in the shadow of my hand,
to plant the heavens
and lay the foundations of the earth
and to say to Zion, 'You are my people.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: The prophet calls out to God: "Wake up!" Like a person who cannot understand why God has been silent for so long. "Rahab" here is not a person, but a name for a sea monster from ancient stories, a picture of chaos and also of Egypt. God has defeated chaos.

Verse 10: At the exodus from Egypt, God made a way through the sea.

Verse 11: That is why those who have been set free will come home rejoicing now, too. "Sorrow and sighing will run

away." (The same verse is already found in chapter 35:10.)

Verses 12–13: God comforts: Why are you so afraid of mortal people? They wither like grass. Where is the rage of the oppressor? It will soon be over.

The cup of staggering VERSES 17–23

17 Wake up, wake up!
Stand up, Jerusalem,
you who have drunk from the LORD's hand
the cup of his anger!
You have drunk the bowl, the cup of staggering,
and drained it.
18 There is no one to guide her
among all the sons she has given birth to.
And there is no one to take her by the hand
among all the sons she has brought up.
19 These two things have happened to you
(who will grieve with you?):
ruin and destruction,
famine and the sword.
How can I comfort you?
20 Your sons have fainted.
They lie at the corner of every street
like an antelope in a net.
They are full of the LORD's anger,
the rebuke of your God.
21 So now hear this, you who are suffering,
you who are drunk, but not with wine:
22 This is what your Lord, the LORD, says,
your God, who stands up for his people:
"Look, I have taken the cup of staggering out of your hand,
the bowl, the cup of my anger.
You will never drink it again.
23 I will put it into the hand of those who torment you,
who have said to you,
'Bow down, so that we can walk over you!'
And you made your back like the ground,
like a street for those who walk over it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Jerusalem is described as a woman who has drunk from a cup and now staggers. The cup is a picture of the disaster that came over the city: destruction, hunger and war (verse 19).

Verses 18 and 20: No one is there to support her. Her children lie exhausted in the streets.

Verse 22: But now God takes the cup out of her hand: "You will never drink it again." God himself stands up for his people, like a lawyer.

Verse 23: The oppressors had forced Jerusalem to throw herself to the ground so they could walk over her. A picture of the deepest humiliation. That time is over. God is on the side of those who have been humiliated.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 52

How beautiful are the feet of the messenger

Wake up, Zion! VERSES 1–6

1 Wake up, wake up!
Put on your strength, Zion!
Put on your beautiful clothes, Jerusalem, the holy city!
For from now on, the uncircumcised and the unclean
will no longer come into you.
2 Shake off the dust!
Get up, sit up straight, Jerusalem!
Loosen the chains from your neck,
captive daughter of Zion!
3 For this is what the LORD says:
"You were sold for nothing,
and you will be redeemed without money."
4 For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"At first my people went down to Egypt to live there,
and the Assyrian oppressed them without cause.
5 And now, what am I doing here," says the LORD,
"since my people have been taken away for nothing?
Those who rule over them mock," says the LORD,
"and my name is insulted constantly, all day long.
6 Therefore my people will know my name.
Therefore they will know on that day
that I am the one who speaks.
Look, here I am."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: As in chapter 51:17, it says again: "Wake up!" But now Jerusalem is not to stagger anymore, but to put on beautiful clothes, shake off the dust and loosen the chains. The time of mourning is over.

"The uncircumcised and the unclean" here means the foreign conquerors who had destroyed and dishonored the holy city. This is not about shutting out people of other nations in general. In chapter 56, God expressly invites foreigners into his house.

Verse 3: Israel was "sold for nothing": The conquerors paid God nothing for it. That is why God does not have to pay a ransom to bring his people back either.

Verses 4–5: The people were already oppressed in Egypt and under Assyria. Now again in Babylon. God cannot watch this any longer.

Your God reigns! VERSES 7–12

7 How beautiful on the mountains are the feet of the one
who brings good news,
who announces peace,
who brings good news,
who announces salvation,
who says to Zion, "Your God reigns!"
8 Your watchmen lift up their voices.
Together they shout for joy.
For they see with their own eyes
the LORD returning to Zion.

9 Break out into joy!
Sing together, you ruins of Jerusalem!
For the LORD has comforted his people.
He has redeemed Jerusalem.
10 The LORD has bared his holy arm
in the sight of all the nations.
All the ends of the earth have seen the salvation of our God.
11 Leave! Leave! Go out from there!
Touch nothing unclean!
Go out from the middle of her!
Make yourselves clean, you who carry the LORD's vessels!
12 For you will not go out in a hurry,
and you will not leave in flight.
For the LORD will go before you,
and the God of Israel will be your rear guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: One of the most beautiful verses in the Bible. A messenger runs over the mountains to Jerusalem and brings the good news: Peace! Rescue! "Your God reigns!" People are already glad at the sight of his feet when they see him coming from far away. In the Greek New Testament, the word for "good news" is "gospel." Paul quotes this verse (Romans 10:15).

Verse 8: The watchmen on the city wall see with their own eyes how God himself returns home.

Verse 10: God "has bared his holy arm." That means: He rolls up his sleeves and shows his power before all nations.

Verses 11–12: Those returning home are to carry the holy vessels of the temple back to Jerusalem (compare Ezra 1:7–11). Unlike the exodus from Egypt, they do not have to flee in a hurry. God goes before them and also protects them from behind.

The fourth song of God's servant begins VERSES 13–15

13 Look, my servant will act wisely.
He will be raised and lifted up
and will be very high.
14 Just as many were horrified at you
(his appearance was so disfigured, more than any man's,
and his form more than that of any human being),
15 so he will cleanse many nations.
Kings will shut their mouths because of him.
For they will see what they had not been told,
and they will understand what they had not heard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins the fourth and best-known song of God's servant. It goes to the end of chapter 53.

Verse 13: The end comes right at the beginning: In the end, the servant will be lifted up very high.

Verse 14: But first he is so disfigured that people are horrified by him. He hardly looks human anymore.

Verse 15: And then even kings are amazed. They understand something completely new that no one had told them. The WEB, our English source text, translates "he will cleanse"; other translations have "he will startle" or "sprinkle." The Hebrew word is not completely clear.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 53

By his wounds we are healed

The despised servant VERSES 1–3

1 Who has believed our message?
To whom has the arm of the LORD been revealed?
2 For he grew up before him like a tender shoot
and like a root out of dry ground.
He has no good looks and no majesty.
When we see him, there is no beauty
that would make us desire him.
3 He was despised and rejected by people,
a man of suffering, familiar with sickness.
He was despised like someone people hide their faces from,
and we did not respect him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now "we" speak, a group of people who are thinking about the servant. Who this "we" is, is understood in different ways: the kings of the nations from chapter 52:15, or people from Israel.

Verse 2: The servant is as plain as a small shoot in dry soil. There is nothing impressive about him.

Verse 3: He is a "man of suffering," sick and despised. People look away when they see him. Many people who are sick or shut out have found themselves in this verse.

He carried our suffering VERSES 4–6

4 Surely he has carried our sickness
and taken our suffering on himself.
But we thought he was punished,
struck down by God and made to suffer.
5 But he was pierced for our rebellious acts.
He was crushed for our wrongdoings.
The punishment that brought us peace was on him,
and by his wounds we are healed.
6 All of us went astray like sheep.
Each one turned to his own way.
And the LORD has laid on him the guilt of us all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the turning point of the song. The "we" realize something shattering:

Verse 4: We thought God had punished him because he was bad. But in truth, he carried our sickness and our suffering.

Verse 5: He suffered because of our guilt, and his suffering brings us peace and healing.

Verse 6: All of us are like sheep that have lost their way. Each one went his own way.

These verses are among the most important texts of the Christian faith. The New Testament understands them as a description of Jesus, who suffered on the cross for the guilt of humanity (for example 1 Peter 2:24–25; Matthew 8:17).

In Jewish interpretation, the servant is mostly understood as the people of Israel, who have suffered much innocently in their history and through this suffering show something to the nations. Other Jewish interpreters thought of the prophet, of a righteous person or of the Messiah.

Both readings take the text seriously. It has helped Jews and Christians for thousands of years to understand the suffering of innocent people.

Like a lamb VERSES 7–9

7 He was mistreated,
yet when he suffered, he did not open his mouth.
Like a lamb that is led to the slaughter,
and like a sheep that is silent before its shearers,
so he did not open his mouth.
8 By oppression and judgment he was taken away.
And who of his generation considered
that he was cut off from the land of the living
and struck down for the disobedience of my people?
9 They made his grave with the wicked,
and with a rich man in his death,
although he had done no violence,
and there was no deceit in his mouth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: The servant does not defend himself. He is silent like a lamb. The Gospels tell that Jesus was silent before his judges (Mark 14:61; 15:5). An official from Ethiopia reads exactly these verses and asks: "Who is the prophet talking about?" (Acts 8:26–35). Philip explains the verses to him in the light of Jesus.

Verse 8: He was condemned and killed in an unjust trial. Hardly anyone understood why.

Verse 9: Even though he did not use violence and did not lie, he is buried like a criminal. The Gospels report that Jesus was buried in the tomb of a rich man, Joseph of Arimathea (Matthew 27:57–60).

Important: This text describes the suffering of an innocent person in order to lament it and understand it. It does not mean that people should silently put up with violence and injustice. If you experience violence, you may get help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

He will see the light VERSES 10–12

10 Yet it pleased the LORD to crush him.
He made him suffer.
When you make his soul an offering for sin,
he will see his descendants.
He will live a long life,
and the LORD's purpose will succeed in his hand.
11 After the suffering of his soul,
he will see the light and be satisfied.
By his knowledge my righteous servant will make
many righteous,
and he will carry their wrongdoings.
12 So I will give him a share among the great,
and he will divide the plunder with the strong,
because he poured out his soul to death
and was counted among the rebels.
Yet he carried the sins of many
and stood up for the rebels.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A hard sentence: "It pleased the LORD to crush him." This does not mean that God enjoys suffering. What it means is: Even this terrible suffering was not pointless. God took it into his plan in order to save many. The suffering becomes an "offering for sin," a gift that makes up for guilt.

Verses 10–11: And then the surprising turn: The servant who has died will "see his descendants," "live a long life" and "see the light." Suffering is not the end. Christians see here a reference to the resurrection of Jesus.

Verse 11: The servant makes "many righteous" by carrying their guilt.

Verse 12: He was counted among the criminals (compare Luke 22:37, where Jesus applies this verse to himself), but he stood up for them. On the cross, Jesus prayed for those who crucified him: "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

Chapter 53 is one of the most-read texts in the whole Bible. It tells of a suffering that is not in vain, and of a love that is stronger than guilt and death.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 54

My loving kindness will not depart from you

Sing, you who are childless! VERSES 1–10

1 "Sing, you who are childless, who have not given birth!
Break out into singing and shout for joy, you who have
not been in labor!
For the children of the lonely woman are more
than the children of the married woman," says the
LORD.
2 "Make the place of your tent wider,
and let them stretch out the curtains of your home.
Do not hold back!
Make your ropes longer,
and make your stakes firm.
3 For you will spread out to the right and to the left,
and your descendants will take possession of nations
and settle in deserted cities.
4 Do not be afraid, for you will not be put to shame.
Do not be dismayed, for you will not be disappointed.
For you will forget the shame of your youth.
You will no longer remember the disgrace of being a
widow.
5 For your Maker is your husband.
The LORD of Armies is his name.
The Holy One of Israel is your Redeemer.
He will be called the God of the whole earth.
6 For the LORD has called you
like a wife who was abandoned and is grieved in spirit,
like a wife married young, when she has been
rejected,"
says your God.

7 "For a brief moment I abandoned you,
but with great compassion I will gather you.
8 In a flood of anger I hid my face from you
for a moment,
but with everlasting loving kindness I will have mercy
on you,"
says the LORD, your Redeemer.
9 "For this is like the waters of Noah to me:
As I swore that the waters of Noah
would never again cover the earth,
so I have sworn that I will no longer be angry with you
and will no longer rebuke you.
10 For the mountains may depart
and the hills be shaken,
but my loving kindness will not depart from you,
and my covenant of peace will not be shaken,"
says the LORD, who has mercy on you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem is again described as a woman: She was childless and lonely, like an abandoned wife or a widow. In those days, that was a great disgrace.

Verses 1–3: Now she is to rejoice, because she will have so many children that the tent has to be made bigger. This means those returning home, who will fill Jerusalem with people again.

Verse 5: God himself is like a loving husband to his people.

Verses 7–8: God admits: For a moment I turned away. But my love is everlasting. The anger lasts a moment; the compassion lasts forever.

Verse 9: Just as God promised after the flood that he would never again flood the earth (Genesis 9:11), he now promises: I will never be so angry with you again.

Verse 10 is a much-loved verse of comfort: "For the mountains may depart and the hills be shaken, but my loving kindness will not depart from you." Even when the most solid things collapse, God's love remains.

A note: In the Bible, God is compared to a husband who takes his wife back. This says something about God's faithfulness. It does not mean that people in a marriage must simply put up with rejection, coldness or violence.

The city made of jewels VERSES 11–17

11 "You who are suffering, tossed by storms, not
comforted!
Look, I will set your stones in beautiful colors
and lay your foundations with sapphires.
12 I will make your towers of rubies,
your gates of sparkling jewels,
and all your walls of precious stones.
13 All your children will be taught by the LORD,
and your children's peace will be great.
14 You will be established in righteousness.
You will be far from oppression, for you will not be
afraid,
and far from terror, for it will not come near you.
15 Look, they may gather together, but not because of me.
Whoever gathers against you will fall because of you.
16 Look, I have created the blacksmith
who fans the coals into flame
and forges a weapon for his work.
And I have created the destroyer to destroy.
17 No weapon that is made against you will succeed.
And you will condemn every tongue
that rises against you in court.
This is the inheritance of the servants of the LORD,
and their righteousness comes from me," says the
LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: The destroyed city will be rebuilt more beautifully than ever before, out of sapphires, rubies and jewels. The book of Revelation takes up this picture for the "new Jerusalem" (Isaiah 21:18–21).

Verse 13: "All your children will be taught by the LORD." Jesus quotes this verse (John 6:45).

Verse 14: A city without oppression and without fear: that is God's goal.

Verses 16–17: The weapon makers, too, are God's creatures. He has power over them. That is why no weapon will succeed against his people. This is a promise of protection, not a call to fight.

Verse 17: From here on, the book no longer speaks of the one "servant," but of the "servants of the LORD," that is, of all who are faithful to God.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 55

Come to the waters!

An invitation to everyone VERSES 1–5

1 "Hey! Come, everyone who is thirsty, to the waters!
Come, you who have no money, buy and eat!
Yes, come, buy wine and milk
without money and without cost!
2 Why do you spend money on what is not bread,
and your work on what does not satisfy?
Listen carefully to me and eat what is good,
and let your soul enjoy the richest food.
3 Turn your ear and come to me!
Listen, and your soul will live.
I will make an everlasting covenant with you,
the sure acts of loving kindness promised to David.
4 Look, I have made him a witness to the peoples,
a leader and commander for the peoples.
5 Look, you will call a nation you do not know,
and a nation that did not know you will run to you,
because of the LORD your God
and for the sake of the Holy One of Israel,
for he has given you glory."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Like a trader at the market, God calls out: "Hey! Come, everyone!" But with him, you do not have to pay

anything. Water, wine and milk are free. God's gifts are a present.

Verse 2: A question that still matters today: Why do you spend your money and your strength on things that do not really satisfy you? What truly feeds a person comes from God.

Verses 3–4: God had promised King David an everlasting covenant (2 Samuel 7). Now this promise is extended to the whole people.

Verse 5: Foreign nations will come to Israel because they see how God acts toward it.

Jesus takes up this picture: "If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink!" (John 7:37). The book of Revelation, too, invites at the end: "Whoever is thirsty should come. Whoever wants it may take the water of life as a free gift" (Revelation 22:17).

My thoughts are not your thoughts VERSES 6–13

6 Seek the LORD while he may be found!
Call on him while he is near!
7 Let the wicked leave his way
and the unrighteous his thoughts.
Let him return to the LORD, and he will have mercy on him,
to our God, for he will forgive generously.
8 "For my thoughts are not your thoughts,
and your ways are not my ways," says the LORD.
9 "For as the heavens are higher than the earth,
so are my ways higher than your ways
and my thoughts than your thoughts.
10 For as the rain and the snow come down from the sky
and do not return there,
but water the earth
and make it grow and sprout,
and give seed to the sower and bread to the eater,
11 so is my word that goes out from my mouth:
It will not return to me empty,
but it will accomplish what I please,
and it will succeed in what I sent it to do.
12 For you will go out with joy
and be led out in peace.
The mountains and the hills will break out into singing before you,
and all the trees of the field will clap their hands.
13 Instead of the thornbush, the cypress will grow,
and instead of the brier, the myrtle will grow.
This will make a name for the LORD,
an everlasting sign that will never be cut off."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: An urgent invitation: Now is the time to turn back to God! He forgives "generously," lavishly, without being stingy.

Verses 8–9: "My thoughts are not your thoughts." God thinks differently from us humans. He is more generous and more merciful than we can imagine. We might not forgive, but God does.

Verses 10–11: A beautiful picture: Just as the rain does not fall for nothing but makes the earth fruitful, so God's word works. It does not come back empty. What God says happens.

Verse 12: Those returning home leave Babylon with joy. All of nature celebrates with them: The mountains sing, the trees clap their hands.

Verse 13: Instead of thorns, beautiful trees grow. The world becomes whole again.

With chapter 55, the "Book of Comfort" (chapters 40–55) ends. It ends the way it began (Isaiah 40:8): with the promise that God's word stands and does its work.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 56

A house of prayer for all peoples

Foreigners and eunuchs are welcome VERSES 1–8

1 This is what the LORD says:
"Hold on to justice and do what is right,
for my salvation is near,
and my righteousness will soon be revealed.
2 Blessed is the person who does this,
and the human being who holds on to it,
who keeps the Sabbath and does not dishonor it,
and keeps his hand from doing any evil."
3 The foreigner who has joined himself to the LORD
must not say,
"The LORD will surely separate me from his people."
And the eunuch must not say,
"Look, I am a dry tree."
4 For this is what the LORD says:
"To the eunuchs who keep my Sabbaths
and choose what pleases me
and hold on to my covenant,
5 I will give in my house and within my walls
a memorial and a name
better than sons and daughters.
I will give them an everlasting name
that will never be cut off.
6 And the foreigners who join themselves to the LORD
to serve him and to love the name of the LORD,
to be his servants,
everyone who keeps the Sabbath and does not dishonor it,
and who hold on to my covenant,
7 these I will bring to my holy mountain
and give them joy in my house of prayer.
Their burnt offerings and their sacrifices will be accepted on my altar.
For my house will be called a house of prayer for all peoples."
8 The Lord GOD, who gathers the outcasts of Israel, says:
"I will gather still others to him,
in addition to those already gathered."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With chapter 56, the third part of the book of Isaiah begins (chapters 56–66). Many scholars think it comes from the time after the return from exile, when Jerusalem was being rebuilt.

Verse 3: Two groups were afraid that they did not belong: foreigners who believe in the God of Israel, and eunuchs, that is, men who could not father children, often because they had been mutilated as court officials. According to the law in Deuteronomy 23:1 (in some Bibles 23:2), eunuchs were not allowed to enter the assembly. A eunuch felt like a "dry tree" without a future because he had no children.

Verses 4–5: God answers surprisingly: Whoever is faithful receives a name in my house that is better than sons and daughters. No one is shut out just because their body is different or because they cannot start a family.

Verses 6–7: Foreigners who love God are also welcome in the temple. "My house will be called a house of prayer for all peoples." Jesus quotes this verse when he drives the traders out of the temple (Mark 11:17).

In the book of Acts (8:27–39), a eunuch from Ethiopia is baptized. He is a foreigner and a eunuch at the same time, and he belongs.

Blind watchmen and mute dogs VERSES 9–12

9 All you animals of the field, come and eat,
all you animals in the forest!
10 Its watchmen are blind.
They all know nothing.
They are all mute dogs.
They cannot bark.
They dream, lie around and love to sleep.
11 Yes, the dogs are greedy.
They never have enough.
They are shepherds who cannot understand.
They have all turned to their own way,
each one to his own gain, from every side.
12 "Come," they say, "I will get wine,
and let us fill ourselves with strong drink.
And tomorrow will be like today, great beyond measure."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes a sharp criticism of the leaders of the people, the "watchmen" and "shepherds."

Verse 9: The wild animals are invited: Come, here is easy prey! For the flock is unprotected.

Verse 10: The watchmen are like guard dogs that do not bark. They sleep instead of warning of danger.

Verses 11–12: They only think of their own advantage and hold drinking parties. They say: "Tomorrow will be like today, great beyond measure." They do not notice that the people are in danger.

For today: Whoever is responsible for others, in politics, church, community or family, should be watchful and think of the weak, not of their own gain.

If you yourself have problems with alcohol, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For addiction, US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 57

Peace to those far away and to those near

The righteous perish VERSES 1–2

1 The righteous perish, and no one takes it to heart.
Merciful people are taken away,
and no one considers
that the righteous are taken away from the evil.
2 They enter into peace.
They rest on their beds,
everyone who has lived uprightly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Good people die, and no one cares. That is a bitter complaint.

But the prophet also sees a comfort: The righteous person is spared from the coming disaster. He is now at peace and resting.

If you are mourning someone you love, you can find comfort in this verse: Whoever has lived uprightly is at peace with God. And if you don't want to be alone in your grief, you can call someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

An accusation against idol worship VERSES 3–13

3 "But you, come here,
you sons of a sorceress,
you descendants of adulterers and prostitutes!
4 Whom are you making fun of?
At whom do you open your mouth wide
and stick out your tongue?
Aren't you children of disobedience
and descendants of lies,
5 you who burn with lust among the oaks,
under every green tree,
who kill the children in the valleys,
under the clefts of the rocks?
6 Among the smooth stones of the valley is your share.
They, they are your lot.
You have even poured out drink offerings to them.
You have brought offerings.
Should I be calm about these things?
7 On a high and lofty mountain you have made your bed.
You also went up there to offer sacrifices.
8 Behind the door and the doorposts you have set up your sign.
For you have uncovered yourself to someone other than me
and have gone up.
You have made your bed wide
and made a covenant for yourself with them.
You loved what you saw on their bed.

9 You went to the king with oil
and used more and more perfumes.
You sent your messengers far away
and lowered yourself even to Sheol, the world of the dead.
10 You were worn out by your many journeys,
and yet you did not say, 'It is hopeless.'
You found new strength,
so you did not grow faint.
11 Whom did you dread and fear,
so that you lie
and have not remembered me
or taken it to heart?
Haven't I kept silent for a long time,
and so you do not fear me?
12 I will announce your righteousness,
and as for your works, they will not help you.
13 When you cry out, let those you have gathered save you!
But the wind will carry them all away.
A breath will take them all.
But whoever takes refuge in me will possess the land
and inherit my holy mountain."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This passage is a harsh accusation against people in the nation who serve other gods.

Verses 3 and 8: The Bible often describes idol worship with the picture of adultery and prostitution. What is meant: The people have become unfaithful to God, like a spouse who cheats. It is a picture of unfaithfulness to God, not a judgment on people who live in prostitution.

Verse 5: The worst thing: Some even sacrificed children, in valleys near Jerusalem (compare 2 Kings 23:10). The Bible condemns this as a terrible crime. Harming or killing children can never be justified, in any religion or under any circumstances.

Verses 6–7: Smooth stones and high mountains were places where foreign gods were worshiped.

Verse 9: The people sought help from foreign kings and gods and lowered themselves deeper and deeper. "Sheol" is the Hebrew name for the world of the dead.

Verse 13: The idols are blown away by the wind. But whoever takes refuge in God is kept safe.

I live with the crushed VERSES 14–21

14 He will say, "Build up, build up, prepare the road!
Remove every obstacle from the way of my people!"
15 For this is what the High and Lofty One says,
who lives forever, whose name is Holy:
"I live in the high and holy place,
and also with the one who is crushed and humble in spirit,
to give new life to the spirit of the humble
and to give new life to the heart of the crushed.
16 For I will not argue forever,
and I will not always be angry,
for then the spirit would grow faint before me,
and the souls I have made.
17 Because of the guilt of his greed I was angry
and struck him.
I hid myself and was angry,
and he kept turning away on the path of his own heart.
18 I have seen his ways,
and I will heal him.
I will also lead him
and give comfort again to him and to those who mourn with him.
19 I create the fruit of the lips:
Peace, peace, to those far away and to those near," says the LORD,
"and I will heal them."
20 But the wicked are like the stormy sea,
for it cannot rest,
and its waters throw up mud and dirt.
21 "There is no peace," says my God,
"for the wicked."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 is a wonderful verse: God is the Most High; he lives in eternity. And at the same time, he lives with those who are crushed and pressed down. It is with them especially that he is, to make them alive again.

Verse 16: God does not want to be angry forever. He knows that people could not bear it.

Verse 18: "I have seen his ways, and I will heal him." God sees the mistakes, and he still wants to heal.

Verse 19: "Peace, peace, to those far away and to those near." God's peace is for everyone, for those who are near to him and for those who are far away. Paul takes up these words and says: Through Christ, Jews and non-Jews are united in one peace (Ephesians 2:17).

Verses 20–21: Whoever lives against God is restless inside like the stormy sea. The sentence from verse 21 already appeared in chapter 48:22.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 58

The fast that pleases God

Why doesn't God see our fasting? VERSES 1–5

1 "Shout out loud! Don't hold back!
Lift up your voice like a trumpet!
Tell my people about their disobedience
and the house of Jacob about their sins!
2 Yet they seek me every day
and are glad to know my ways.
Like a nation that has done what is right
and has not abandoned the laws of its God,
they ask me for righteous judgments.
They are glad to come near to God.
3 'Why have we fasted,' they say, 'and you don't see it?
Why have we humbled ourselves, and you don't notice?'

Look, on the day of your fast, you do whatever you like
and oppress all your workers.
4 Look, you fast only to quarrel and fight
and to hit with a wicked fist.
The way you fast today
will not make your voice heard on high.
5 Is this the kind of fast I have chosen?
A day for a person to humble himself?
Is it to bow your head like a reed
and to lie down on sackcloth and ashes?
Will you call that a fast
and a day that pleases the LORD?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: The people are very devout. They pray, fast and ask about God. And they complain: "Why have we fasted … and you don't see it?"

Verses 3–4: God's answer: You fast, but at the same time you exploit your workers, you quarrel and you hit. That does not fit together.

Verse 5: Just hanging your head and sitting in ashes, that alone is not what God wants.

Share your bread with the hungry VERSES 6–12

6 Isn't this the kind of fast I have chosen:
to loosen the chains of wickedness,
to untie the straps of the yoke,
to set the oppressed free
and to break every yoke?
7 Isn't it to share your bread with the hungry
and to bring the poor who have been thrown out into your house?
When you see someone naked, to clothe him,
and not to hide yourself from your own flesh and blood?
8 Then your light will break out like the dawn,
and your healing will spring up quickly.
Then your righteousness will go before you,
and the glory of the LORD will be your rear guard.
9 Then you will call, and the LORD will answer.
You will cry for help, and he will say, 'Here I am.'
If you take away the yoke from among you,
the pointing of the finger and the wicked talk,
10 and if you pour out your soul for the hungry
and satisfy the one who is suffering,
then your light will rise in the darkness,
and your gloom will be like the middle of the day.
11 And the LORD will always guide you
and satisfy your soul in dry places
and make your bones strong.
You will be like a watered garden
and like a spring of water whose waters never fail.
12 Your descendants will rebuild the ancient ruins.
You will raise up the foundations of many generations.
You will be called Repairer of the Breach,
Restorer of Streets to Live In.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important texts in the Bible about true devotion.

Verses 6–7: The fast that God wants: setting the oppressed free, sharing bread with the hungry, taking in the homeless, giving clothes to the naked. "Not to hide yourself from your own flesh and blood" means: Do not turn away from people who are just as human as you are.

Verses 8–10: To whoever acts like this, God promises: Your light will rise like the dawn. When you call, God says: "Here I am." The "pointing of the finger," that is, blaming and despising others, is to stop as well.

Verse 11: Whoever gives becomes like a watered garden themselves, like a spring that never runs dry.

Verse 12: Such people rebuild what has been destroyed. They are called "Repairer of the Breach": they mend what is broken, in the city and in the community.

On the Jewish Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur), a day of fasting, this chapter is read in the synagogue. Jesus says something similar: "I was hungry, and you gave me food to eat" (Matthew 25:35).

The Sabbath as a delight VERSES 13–14

13 If you keep your foot from breaking the Sabbath,
from doing whatever you like on my holy day,
and if you call the Sabbath a delight
and the LORD's holy day honorable,
and if you honor it
by not going your own ways,
not doing whatever you like
and not speaking your own words,
14 then you will find your delight in the LORD,
and I will make you ride on the heights of the earth
and feed you with the inheritance of your father Jacob."
For the mouth of the LORD has spoken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sabbath is the seventh day, the day of rest. It is not meant to be a burden, but a "delight," a joy.

On this day, you are not to go about your business, but to have time for God and for people. This also does the person good.

For us today: A day of rest each week is a gift. It helps us not to live only for work and money.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 59

A Redeemer will come to Zion

Your sins separate you from God VERSES 1–8

1 Look, the LORD's hand is not too short to save,
and his ear is not too dull to hear.
2 But your wrongdoings have separated you from your God,
and your sins have hidden his face from you,
so that he does not hear.

3 For your hands are stained with blood
and your fingers with wrongdoing.
Your lips have spoken lies.
Your tongue mutters wickedness.
4 No one brings a lawsuit in righteousness,
and no one argues a case in truth.
They trust in empty things and speak lies.
They are pregnant with trouble and give birth to
wrongdoing.
5 They hatch the eggs of snakes
and weave spider webs.
Whoever eats their eggs dies,
and when one is crushed, a viper breaks out.
6 Their webs will not make clothes.
They cannot cover themselves with their works.
Their works are works of wrongdoing,
and acts of violence are in their hands.
7 Their feet run to evil,
and they hurry to shed innocent blood.
Their thoughts are thoughts of wrongdoing.
Ruin and destruction are on their roads.
8 They do not know the way of peace,
and there is no justice in their ways.
They have made crooked paths for themselves.
Whoever walks on them does not know peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The people ask: Why doesn't God help? The prophet answers: God's hand is not too short and his ear is not deaf. But your guilt stands like a wall between you and God.

Verses 3–8: A list of injustice: violence, lies, unjust courts, murder of innocent people. The pictures are strong: Evil plans are like snake eggs that hatch poison, and like spider webs that are no good for clothes.

Verses 7–8: Paul quotes these verses in his letter to the Romans (3:15–17) to show that all people need God's grace.

We grope like the blind VERSES 9–15

9 So justice is far from us,
and righteousness does not reach us.
We look for light, but there is darkness,
for brightness, but we walk in gloom.
10 We grope for the wall like the blind.
Yes, we grope like those who have no eyes.
We stumble at noon as if it were twilight.
Among the strong we are like the dead.
11 We all growl like bears
and moan sadly like doves.
We look for justice, but there is none,
for salvation, but it is far from us.
12 For our rebellious acts are many before you,
and our sins testify against us.
For our rebellious acts are with us,
and our wrongdoings, we know them:
13 rebelling against the LORD and denying him,
and turning away from following our God,
speaking of oppression and revolt,
thinking up lies in our hearts and speaking them.
14 Justice is pushed back,
and righteousness stands far away.
For truth has fallen in the street,
and honesty cannot come in.
15 Yes, truth is missing,
and whoever turns away from evil becomes prey.
The LORD saw it,
and it displeased him that there was no justice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the people themselves speak: "we." They admit their guilt.

Verses 9–11: We look for light, but it stays dark. We grope like the blind. We growl like bears and moan like doves. An honest prayer in distress.

Verses 12–13: "Our wrongdoings, we know them." The people see their guilt. That is the first step toward turning back.

Verses 14–15: A society where truth lies in the street and no one picks it up. Whoever is honest becomes prey. Sadly, this description fits many times and places. But at the end of verse 15 it says: The LORD saw it, and it displeased him.

God steps in himself VERSES 16–21

16 He saw that there was no one,
and he was amazed that no one stepped in.
So his own arm brought him salvation,
and his righteousness held him up.
17 He put on righteousness like a breastplate
and a helmet of salvation on his head.
He put on garments of vengeance as his clothing
and wrapped himself in zeal like a cloak.
18 He will repay them according to their deeds, as is
fitting:
anger to his opponents, payback to his enemies.
He will repay the islands what they deserve.
19 So they will fear the name of the LORD from the west
and his glory from the rising of the sun.
For he will come like a rushing stream
driven by the breath of the LORD.
20 "A Redeemer will come to Zion,
and to those in Jacob who turn away from
disobedience," says the LORD.
21 "As for me, this is my covenant with them," says the
LORD:
"My Spirit, who is on you,
and my words, which I have put in your mouth,
will not depart from your mouth,
or from the mouth of your descendants,
or from the mouth of your descendants' descendants,"
says the LORD,
"from now on and forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: God sees that there is no justice and that no one steps in. So he steps in himself.

Verse 17: God puts on "armor": righteousness as a breastplate, salvation as a helmet. This is a picture. God does not fight with weapons, but with righteousness and rescue. Paul takes up this picture and speaks of the "armor of God" for Christians (Ephesians 6:14–17): truth, righteousness, peace, faith and God's word. This has nothing to do with real weapons or violence.

Verse 18: God makes sure that injustice does not go unpunished. Judgment is his business, not the business of people who want revenge.

Verse 20: "A Redeemer will come to Zion" to those who turn back. Paul quotes this verse in Romans 11:26.

Verse 21: God's Spirit and God's word are to stay with his people, from generation to generation, forever.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 60

Arise, shine!

Your light has come VERSES 1–9

1 "Arise, shine, for your light has come,
and the glory of the LORD has risen on you!
2 For look, darkness will cover the earth,
and thick darkness the peoples.
But the LORD will rise on you,
and his glory will be seen on you.
3 Nations will come to your light,
and kings to the brightness of your rising.
4 Lift up your eyes and look around:
They all gather together; they come to you.
Your sons will come from far away,
and your daughters will be carried in arms.
5 Then you will see it and shine with joy,
and your heart will tremble and swell,
because the riches of the sea will be turned to you.
The wealth of the nations will come to you.
6 Crowds of camels will cover you,
the young camels of Midian and Ephah.
All from Sheba will come.
They will bring gold and frankincense
and will announce the praises of the LORD.
7 All the flocks of Kedar will be gathered to you.
The rams of Nebaioth will serve you.
They will be accepted as offerings on my altar,
and I will make my glorious house beautiful.
8 Who are these who fly along like a cloud,
and like doves to their nesting holes?
9 Surely the islands will wait for me,
and the ships of Tarshish first,
to bring your sons from far away,
their silver and their gold with them,
for the name of the LORD your God
and for the Holy One of Israel,
because he has given you glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: A shining beginning: "Arise, shine!" The world lies in darkness, but God's light rises over Jerusalem like the sun. And the nations come to this light. In many churches, this text is read at the feast of Epiphany (January 6).

Verse 4: The scattered children come home; the little ones are carried.

Verse 6: Nations from Arabia bring "gold and frankincense." This reminds Christians of the wise men from the East who brought gold, frankincense and myrrh to the child Jesus (Matthew 2:11). The tradition that the wise men were kings and came on camels also comes from here and from Psalm 72.

Verse 8: A beautiful picture: The ships with those returning home look like a cloud of doves flying back to their dovecote.

Your gates are always open VERSES 10–16

10 Foreigners will rebuild your walls,
and their kings will serve you.
For in my anger I struck you,
but in my favor I have had mercy on you.
11 Your gates will always stand open.
They will not be shut by day or by night,
so that people can bring you the wealth of the nations,
with their kings led as captives.
12 For the nation and the kingdom that will not serve you
will perish.
Yes, those nations will be completely destroyed.
13 The glory of Lebanon will come to you,
the cypress, the pine and the box tree together,
to make the place of my sanctuary beautiful.
And I will make the place where my feet rest glorious.
14 The sons of those who oppressed you will come bowing
to you,
and all who despised you
will bow down at the soles of your feet.
They will call you "City of the LORD,
Zion of the Holy One of Israel."
15 Instead of being abandoned and hated,
so that no one passed through you,
I will make you an everlasting pride,
a joy for many generations.
16 You will also drink the milk of the nations
and nurse at the breasts of kings.
Then you will know that I, the LORD, am your Savior,
your Redeemer, the Mighty One of Jacob.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: God says: My anger was short; my mercy is great.

Verse 11: The gates of Jerusalem stand open day and night. No one has to be afraid of enemies anymore. The book of Revelation takes up this picture for the new Jerusalem (21:25–26).

Verses 12 and 14: Here the language of that time can be heard: The nations that oppressed Israel will now bow before it. Things are turned around. This is a hope of the oppressed for justice, not a justification for ruling over other nations.

Verse 16: A loving picture: Jerusalem is cared for like a baby nursed by queens.

The LORD is your everlasting light VERSES 17–22

17 Instead of bronze I will bring gold,
instead of iron, silver,
instead of wood, bronze,
and instead of stones, iron.
I will also make peace your government
and righteousness your ruler.

18 Violence will no longer be heard of in your land,
nor ruin or destruction within your borders.
But you will call your walls "Salvation"
and your gates "Praise."
19 The sun will no longer be your light by day,
and the brightness of the moon will no longer shine on you.
But the LORD will be your everlasting light,
and your God will be your glory.
20 Your sun will never set again,
and your moon will no longer fade.
For the LORD will be your everlasting light,
and the days of your mourning will come to an end.
21 Then your people will all be righteous.
They will inherit the land forever,
the shoot that I planted,
the work of my hands, so that I may be glorified.
22 The smallest one will become 1,000,
and the least one a strong nation.
I, the LORD, will do it quickly when the time comes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Everything becomes better and more valuable. And the city is not ruled by tyrants, but by "peace" and "righteousness."

Verse 18: A world without violence! The walls are called "Salvation" and the gates "Praise." What a hope for everyone who suffers under war and violence.

Verses 19–20: God himself will be the light, a light that never sets. "The days of your mourning will come to an end." The book of Revelation also takes up this picture (21:23; 22:5).

Verse 22: The small remnant becomes a great people. God does it when the time has come.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 61

The Spirit of the Lord is on me

Good news for the poor VERSES 1–3

1 The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on me.
The LORD has anointed me.
Anointed means: chosen and set apart for a task.
He has chosen me to bring good news to the humble.
He has sent me to bandage those whose hearts are broken.
He has sent me to announce freedom to the captives.
Those who are tied up will be set free.
2 He has sent me to announce the year of the LORD's favor.
I am to announce the day when our God takes revenge.
I am to comfort all who mourn.
3 I am to care for those who mourn in Zion.
I am to give them a garland of flowers instead of ashes.
I am to give them the oil of joy instead of sorrow.
I am to give them clothes of praise instead of a heavy heart.
Then people will call them "trees of righteousness."
They will call them "the planting of the LORD."
And the LORD will be honored.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here someone speaks on whom God's Spirit rests. He is "anointed," that is, given a task. His task:

– to bring good news to the poor and humble,

– to bind up people with broken hearts, the way you bandage a wound,

– to announce freedom to prisoners,

– to comfort those who mourn.

"The year of the LORD's favor" recalls the Year of Jubilee (Leviticus 25): Every 50 years, debts were to be canceled and slaves set free. A new beginning for everyone.

Verse 3: Instead of ashes on their heads (a sign of mourning), those who mourn receive a festive garland. Instead of mourning, the oil of joy.

In the synagogue in Nazareth, Jesus read these verses aloud and said: "Today these words of Scripture have come true, while you are listening" (Luke 4:21). He stopped in the middle of verse 2, after the words about the year of the LORD's favor, and did not read aloud the words about the day when God takes revenge. In Judaism, the speaker is mostly understood as the prophet himself, who brings this message to Israel.

You will be called priests of the LORD VERSES 4–9

4 They will rebuild the old ruins.
They will rebuild the places that were destroyed long ago.
They will repair the ruined cities.
These cities have been in ruins for many generations.
5 Strangers will stand and feed your flocks.
Foreigners will work your fields and your vineyards.
6 But you will be called "priests of the LORD."
People will call you "servants of our God."
You will eat the wealth of the nations.
You will boast about their glory.
7 You had shame.
Instead you will receive twice as much.
You had disgrace.
Instead they will rejoice over their share.
So in their land they will own twice as much.
They will have joy that lasts forever.
8 "I, the LORD, love justice.
I hate robbery and wrongdoing.
I will give them their reward faithfully.
I will make a covenant with them that lasts forever.
9 Their children will be known among the nations.
Their descendants will be known among the peoples.
All who see them will recognize them.
They will see: These are the children the LORD has blessed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Those returning home rebuild the destroyed cities.

Verses 5–6: All of Israel becomes "priests of the LORD." Just as the priests were there for the people, Israel is to be there

for the whole world and show God to the nations (compare Exodus 19:6). The other nations help it do this.

Verse 7: For the shame they suffered, there is double joy.

Verse 8: "I, the LORD, love justice. I hate robbery and wrongdoing." That is a principle for everything God does. A covenant is a binding agreement.

I rejoice in the LORD VERSES 10–11

10 I will be very happy in the LORD!
My soul will be full of joy in my God.
He has dressed me in clothes of salvation.
He has wrapped me in a robe of righteousness.
It is like a bridegroom who puts on a garland of flowers.
It is like a bride who puts on her jewels.

11 The earth makes its plants sprout.
A garden makes the seeds sown in it spring up.
In the same way, the Lord GOD will make righteousness and praise
spring up in front of all the nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A song of joy. God has given the speaker new clothes, with salvation and righteousness, as beautiful as a bride and bridegroom on their wedding day. Mary sings in a similar way: "My soul magnifies the Lord. My spirit has rejoiced in God my Savior" (Luke 1:46–47).

Verse 11: Righteousness grows like a plant in a garden. God makes it spring up, slowly but surely.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 62

For Zion's sake I will not keep silent

A new name VERSES 1–5

1 I will not keep quiet, because I care about Zion.
I will not rest, because I care about Jerusalem.
I will not stop until her righteousness shines out like the dawn.
I will not stop until her rescue shines like a burning torch.

2 The nations will see your righteousness.
All kings will see your glory.
You will get a new name.
The LORD himself will give you that name.

3 You will be a beautiful crown in the hand of the LORD.
You will be a royal crown in the hand of your God.

4 People will no longer call you "Forsaken."
Forsaken means: left all alone.
They will no longer call your land "Desolate."
Desolate means: empty and ruined.
But you will be called "Hephzibah."
And your land will be called "Beulah."
For the LORD delights in you.
And your land will be married.

5 A young man marries a young woman.
In the same way, your sons will marry you.
A bridegroom is happy about his bride.
In the same way, your God will be happy about you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The prophet says: I will not stop praying and calling out for Jerusalem until rescue has come.

Verses 2–4: Jerusalem receives a new name. Before, she was called "Forsaken" and "Desolate." Now she is called "Hephzibah," which means "My delight is in her," and the land is called "Beulah," which means "Married."

Verse 5: God rejoices over his people like a bridegroom over his bride. A very tender picture of God's love. That the "sons" "marry" the city means: The inhabitants will be firmly bound to their city again.

Watchmen on the walls VERSES 6–9

6 Jerusalem, I have placed watchmen on your walls.
They will never be silent, by day or by night.
You who call on the LORD, do not rest.

7 Give him no rest
until he makes Jerusalem strong again.
Give him no rest until he makes Jerusalem a city that the whole earth praises.

8 The LORD has made a promise.
He has sworn by his right hand and by his strong arm:
"I will never again give your grain to your enemies as food.
Foreigners will no longer drink your new wine.
You worked hard for it.

9 Those who harvest the grain will eat it.
And they will praise the LORD.
Those who gather the grapes will drink the wine
in the courtyards of my holy place."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: The "watchmen" here are people who pray. They are to keep reminding God day and night until he rebuilds Jerusalem. A bold picture: We may "give God no rest" with our requests. Jesus tells a similar parable about a widow who does not give up (Luke 18:1–8).

Verses 8–9: In the past, enemies stole the harvest. Now God promises: Whoever works should also enjoy the fruit of their work. That is justice.

Prepare the way! VERSES 10–12

10 Go through, go through the gates!
Prepare the way for the people!
Build up, build up the highway!
Clear away the stones!
Raise a banner for the peoples!

11 Look, the LORD has announced to the ends of the earth:
"Say to the daughter of Zion,
'Look, your salvation is coming!
Look, he brings his reward with him.
He brings his payment with him!'"

12 People will call them "The Holy People, the LORD's
Redeemed."
Redeemed means: set free and bought back.
And you will be called "Sought Out, a City Not
Forsaken."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: As in chapter 40, a road is to be built on which the people can return home. All stones are to be cleared out of the way.

Verse 11: "Say to the daughter of Zion, 'Look, your salvation is coming!'" Matthew's Gospel connects these words with Jesus entering Jerusalem (Matthew 21:5).

Verse 12: New names again: "The Holy People," "the LORD's Redeemed," "Sought Out," "a City Not Forsaken." Whoever has felt abandoned now hears: You are sought out and wanted.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 63

You, LORD, are our Father

The one who treads the winepress, coming from Edom
VERSES 1–6

1 Who is this who comes from Edom,
with garments dyed red from Bozrah?
Who is this, splendid in his clothing,
marching in the greatness of his strength?
"It is I, who speak in righteousness,
mighty to save."
2 Why are your clothes red,
and your garments like those of someone who treads
the winepress?
3 "I have trodden the winepress alone.
Of the peoples, no one was with me.
Yes, I trod them in my anger
and trampled them in my fury.
Their lifeblood has splashed on my garments,
and I have stained all my clothing.
4 For the day of vengeance was in my heart,
and the year of my redeemed has come.
5 I looked, and there was no one to help.
And I was amazed that there was no one to support me.
So my own arm brought me salvation,
and my fury held me up.
6 I trampled the peoples in my anger
and made them drunk in my fury.
I poured out their lifeblood on the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A frightening picture: God comes from Edom (a neighboring people who were often hostile to Israel) like a winegrower treading grapes in the winepress. His clothes are red, not from grape juice, but from the blood of the enemies.

The picture describes God's judgment on the powers that oppressed Israel. God acts alone because no human being stepped in (verse 5, as in chapter 59:16).

Important: Here God acts, not people. The text gives no one the right to use violence or take revenge in God's name. Judgment and payback are God's business alone (compare Romans 12:19). At the center stands this sentence: "The year of my redeemed has come" (63:4). It is about setting the oppressed free.

The book of Revelation takes up this picture (19:13–15). The song *Mine eyes have seen the glory* (the "Battle Hymn of the Republic") also alludes to it.

God's goodness in history
VERSES 7–14

7 I will tell of the loving kindnesses of the LORD,
the praises of the LORD,
for all that the LORD has done for us,
and the great goodness toward the house of Israel,
which he has shown them in his compassion
and in his many acts of loving kindness.
8 For he said, "Surely they are my people,
children who will not be false."
So he became their Savior.
9 In all their suffering he suffered too,
and the angel of his presence saved them.
In his love and in his pity he redeemed them.
He lifted them up and carried them all the days of old.
10 But they rebelled
and grieved his Holy Spirit.
So he turned and became their enemy,
and he himself fought against them.
11 Then he remembered the days of old,
Moses and his people, and said:
"Where is the one who brought them up out of the sea
with the shepherds of his flock?
Where is the one who put his Holy Spirit among
them?"
12 Who made his glorious arm go at the right hand of
Moses?
Who divided the waters before them
to make an everlasting name for himself?
13 Who led them through the depths,
like a horse in the open country,
so that they did not stumble?
14 Like cattle going down into the valley,
the Spirit of the LORD gave them rest.
That is how you led your people,
to make a glorious name for yourself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins a long prayer of the people. It goes to the end of chapter 64.

Verses 7–9: First the people remember God's goodness. Verse 9 is especially beautiful: "In all their suffering he suffered too." God suffers with his people. He is not far away, but feels the pain with them.

Verse 10: But the people have "grieved" God's Holy Spirit, that is, made him sad. Paul takes up these words (Ephesians 4:30).

Verses 11–14: The people remember the exodus from Egypt: God led them safely through the sea like horses through flat land, and his Spirit gave them rest.

Look down from heaven! VERSES 15–19

15 Look down from heaven and see,
from your holy and glorious home!
Where are your zeal and your mighty acts?
The longing of your heart and your compassion
are held back from me.
16 For you are our Father,
even though Abraham does not know us
and Israel does not recognize us.
You, LORD, are our Father.
"Our Redeemer from everlasting" is your name.
17 LORD, why do you let us wander from your ways
and harden our hearts so that we do not fear you?
Return for the sake of your servants,
the tribes that are your inheritance.
18 Your holy people possessed it only for a little while.
Our enemies have trampled down your sanctuary.
19 We have become like those you never ruled over,
like those who were not called by your name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The people cry out: God, look down! Where has your love gone?

Verse 16: "You, LORD, are our Father." Even if Abraham and Jacob, the great ancestors of the people, no longer recognized them, God remains their Father. This is one of the few places in the Old Testament where God is called "our Father" directly in prayer. Jesus teaches his disciples to pray: "Our Father in heaven" (Matthew 6:9).

Verse 17: An honest, desperate question: Why do you let us go astray? The Bible allows such questions to God.

Verses 18–19: The temple is destroyed. The people feel as if they had never belonged to God.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 64

Oh, that you would tear open the heavens!

Come down! VERSES 1–7

1 Oh, that you would tear open the heavens and come down,
that the mountains would shake before you,
2 as when fire sets brushwood alight
and the fire makes water boil!
Make your name known to your enemies,
so that the nations tremble before you!
3 When you did awesome things that we did not expect,
you came down,
and the mountains shook before you.
4 For since ancient times no one has heard,
no ear has perceived,
and no eye has seen a God besides you,
who acts for the one who waits for him.
5 You meet the one who rejoices and does what is right,
those who remember you in your ways.
Look, you were angry, and we sinned.
We have been in sin for a long time.
Shall we be saved?
6 For we have all become like someone who is unclean,
and all our righteousness is like a dirty garment.
We all wither like a leaf,
and our wrongdoings carry us away like the wind.
7 There is no one who calls on your name,
who stirs himself to take hold of you.
For you have hidden your face from us
and let us waste away because of our wrongdoings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A passionate cry: "Oh, that you would tear open the heavens and come down!" The people long for God himself to step in. A German Advent hymn (in English: "O Savior, Rend the Heavens Wide") takes up this verse. Christians see the birth of Jesus as the answer to this cry.

Verse 4: No other god acts for those who wait for him. Paul quotes this verse freely: "No eye has seen these things … These things God has prepared for those who love him" (1 Corinthians 2:9).

Verse 6: An honest confession: Even our best deeds are like a dirty garment. We wither like a leaf in autumn.

Verse 7: No one holds on to God anymore. The people feel as if God has turned away.

We are the clay, you are the potter VERSES 8–12

8 But now, LORD, you are our Father.
We are the clay, and you are our potter.
We are all the work of your hand.
9 Do not be so very angry, LORD,
and do not remember our guilt forever.
Please look, we beg you: We are all your people.
10 Your holy cities have become a wilderness.
Zion has become a wilderness, Jerusalem a ruin.
11 Our holy and beautiful house,
where our ancestors praised you,
has been burned with fire.
Everything we loved lies in ruins.
12 Will you hold yourself back after all this, LORD?
Will you keep silent and punish us so severely?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: In spite of everything: "You are our Father. We are the clay, and you are our potter." The people put themselves completely in God's hands. A potter can reshape a pot that has gone wrong. In the same way, God can make his people new.

Verse 9: "We are all your people." An appeal to God's faithfulness.

Verses 10–11: The lament over destroyed Jerusalem and the burned temple, "our holy and beautiful house, where our ancestors praised you."

Verse 12: The prayer ends with an open question: Will you keep silent? In the next chapter, God answers.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 65

A new heaven and a new earth

I have held out my hands VERSES 1–7

1 "I let myself be sought by those who did not ask for me.
I let myself be found by those who did not seek me.
I said, 'See me, see me!'
to a nation that was not called by my name.
2 I have held out my hands all day long
to a rebellious people,
who walk on a way that is not good,
following their own thoughts,
3 a people who constantly provoke me to my face,
who sacrifice in gardens
and burn incense on bricks,
4 who sit among the graves
and spend the nights in secret places,
who eat pork,
and the broth of disgusting things is in their pots,
5 who say, 'Keep to yourself, don't come near me,
for I am holier than you!'
These are smoke in my nose,
a fire that burns all day long.
6 Look, it is written before me:
I will not keep silent, but I will repay,
yes, I will repay them in full,
7 your own wrongdoings and the wrongdoings of your ancestors together,"
says the LORD,
"who burned incense on the mountains
and insulted me on the hills.
So I will first measure out what they have done into their laps."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: God answers the prayer of chapters 63–64: But I was always there! I called out: "See me, see me!" All day long I held out my hands, like parents who want to take their child in their arms. But the people did not listen.

Verses 3–4: Some among the people practiced foreign worship: sacrifices in sacred gardens, calling up the dead at graves, forbidden foods.

Verse 5: And on top of that, they consider themselves holier than others: "Don't come near me!" God says: This arrogance is like smoke in my nose.

Paul applies verses 1–2 to people from the nations who found God without seeking him (Romans 10:20–21).

My servants and those who turn away VERSES 8–16

8 This is what the LORD says:
"As when new wine is found in a cluster of grapes, and someone says,
'Don't destroy it, for there is a blessing in it,'
so I will act for the sake of my servants,
so that I do not destroy them all.
9 I will bring descendants out of Jacob
and out of Judah an heir to my mountains.
My chosen ones will inherit it,
and my servants will live there.
10 Sharon will become a pasture for flocks
and the Valley of Achor a resting place for cattle,
for my people who have sought me.
11 But you who abandon the LORD,
who forget my holy mountain,
who set a table for Fortune
and fill cups of mixed wine for Destiny:
12 I will destine you for the sword,
and you will all bow down to be slaughtered.
For when I called, you did not answer.
When I spoke, you did not listen,
but you did what is evil in my eyes
and chose what I do not delight in."
13 Therefore this is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, my servants will eat,
but you will be hungry.
Look, my servants will drink,
but you will be thirsty.
Look, my servants will rejoice,
but you will be disappointed.
14 Look, my servants will sing for joy of heart,
but you will cry out with sorrow of heart
and wail in anguish of spirit.
15 You will leave your name to my chosen ones as a curse,
and the Lord GOD will kill you.
But he will call his servants by another name,
16 so that whoever blesses himself on the earth
will bless himself by the God of truth,
and whoever swears an oath on the earth
will swear by the God of truth.
For the troubles of the past are forgotten
and hidden from my eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A picture from winegrowing: If there is still some good juice in a bad cluster of grapes, you don't throw it away. In the same way, God will not destroy the whole people, for the sake of the faithful.

Verse 10: Sharon in the west and the Valley of Achor in the east will become fertile pasture again.

Verse 11: "Fortune" (Gad) and "Destiny" (Meni) were names of gods to whom people offered sacrifices in order to have good luck. Today we might think of superstition or gambling. If you have problems with gambling, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For addiction, US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357.

Verses 12–15: The ways part: The faithful eat, drink and rejoice; those who turn away go empty. This is a serious

warning, not a task for people to judge or punish others. The judgment belongs to God.

Verse 16: God is called the "God of truth," literally "God of Amen." What he says holds true.

Everything will be new VERSES 17–25

17 "For look, I am creating new heavens and a new earth,
and the former things will not be remembered
and will not come to mind.
18 But be glad and rejoice forever
in what I am creating.
For look, I am creating Jerusalem to be a delight
and her people to be a joy.
19 I will rejoice over Jerusalem
and be glad in my people.
The sound of weeping will no longer be heard in her,
nor the sound of crying.
20 There will no longer be a baby there who lives only a few days,
nor an old person who does not live out his days.
For a child will die at 100 years old,
and the sinner who is 100 years old will be cursed.
21 They will build houses and live in them.
They will plant vineyards and eat their fruit.
22 They will not build for someone else to live in.
They will not plant for someone else to eat.
For the days of my people will be like the days of a tree,
and my chosen ones will long enjoy the work of their hands.
23 They will not work hard for nothing,
or give birth to children only for disaster.
For they are the descendants of those the LORD has blessed,
and their children with them.
24 And this is how it will be: Before they call, I will answer.
While they are still speaking, I will hear.
25 The wolf and the lamb will graze together.
The lion will eat straw like the ox.
And dust will be the serpent's food.
They will do no harm and cause no destruction
on all my holy mountain," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the greatest hopes in the Bible: God creates new heavens and a new earth.

Verse 19: No more weeping and no more crying. The book of Revelation takes this up: "He will wipe away every tear from their eyes" (Revelation 21:4).

Verse 20: No baby dies young anymore. All people live long lives. Whoever dies at 100 still counts as young. For all parents who have lost a child, this is a comforting hope.

Verses 21–23: No more exploitation: Whoever builds a house also lives in it. Whoever plants also eats the fruit. No one works for nothing.

Verse 24: God answers even before people call.

Verse 25: As in chapter 11:6–9: Wolf and lamb live together in peace. No one does evil anymore. A picture of perfect peace in all creation.

ISAIAH

CHAPTER 66

As a mother comforts her child

Heaven is my throne VERSES 1–6

1 This is what the LORD says:
"Heaven is my throne,
and the earth is my footstool.
What kind of house will you build for me?
Where will my resting place be?
2 For my hand has made all these things,
and so all these things came to be," says the LORD.
"But this is the one I look to:
the one who is poor and crushed in spirit
and who trembles at my word.
3 Whoever kills an ox is like someone who kills a person.
Whoever sacrifices a lamb is like someone who breaks a dog's neck.
Whoever brings an offering is like someone who offers pig's blood.
Whoever burns incense is like someone who blesses an idol.
Yes, they have chosen their own ways,
and their soul delights in their disgusting things.
4 So I too will choose their delusions
and bring on them what they fear,
because when I called, no one answered,
and when I spoke, they did not listen,
but they did what is evil in my eyes
and chose what I do not delight in."
5 Hear the word of the LORD,
you who tremble at his word:
"Your brothers who hate you,
who throw you out for the sake of my name,
have said, 'Let the LORD be glorified,
so that we may see your joy!'
But they will be put to shame.
6 A sound of uproar from the city,
a sound from the temple,
the sound of the LORD repaying his enemies what they deserve.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: God is so great that no building can contain him. Heaven is his throne. But God looks to the poor and humble, to those who take his word seriously. Stephen quotes these verses (Acts 7:49–50).

Verse 3: A harsh verse: Sacrifices without an honest heart are as bad as crimes to God. Whoever holds worship services but at the same time goes his own evil ways, his worship is worthless.

Verse 5: Faithful people are shut out and mocked by their own "brothers." God says: In the end, the mockers will be put to shame.

Rejoice with Jerusalem! VERSES 7–14

7 Before she went into labor, she gave birth.
Before her pain came, she gave birth to a son.
8 Who has ever heard of such a thing?
Who has ever seen such things?
Can a land be born in one day?
Can a nation be born all at once?
For as soon as Zion went into labor, she gave birth to her children.
9 "Shall I bring a child to the point of birth and not let it be born?" says the LORD.
"Shall I, who cause birth, close the womb?" says your God.
10 "Rejoice with Jerusalem and be glad for her,
all you who love her!
Rejoice with her in joy,
all you who mourn over her,
11 so that you may nurse and be satisfied
at her comforting breasts,
so that you may drink deeply and delight
in the abundance of her glory."
12 For this is what the LORD says:
"Look, I will make peace flow to her like a river,
and the glory of the nations like an overflowing stream,
and you will nurse.
You will be carried on her hip
and bounced on her knees.
13 As a mother comforts her child,
so I will comfort you.
You will be comforted in Jerusalem."
14 You will see it, and your heart will rejoice,
and your bones will flourish like new grass.
The LORD's hand will be known among his servants,
and he will be angry with his enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9: Zion becomes like a mother who has children very suddenly and without pain: a whole people in one day. God finishes what he has begun.

Verses 10–12: Jerusalem is like a mother who nurses her children, carries them on her hip and bounces them on her knees.

Verse 13 is one of the most tender verses in the Bible: "As a mother comforts her child, so I will comfort you." God comforts like a mother. In Germany, this verse was chosen as the Bible verse for the year 2016.

Verse 14: "Your bones will flourish like new grass": new life and new strength for everyone who was sad.

All nations will come VERSES 15–24

15 For look, the LORD will come with fire,
and his chariots will be like the whirlwind,
to pay back his anger with fury
and his rebuke with flames of fire.
16 For the LORD will carry out judgment with fire and with his sword
on all people,
and those killed by the LORD will be many.
17 "Those who make themselves holy and purify themselves to go into the gardens,
following one in the middle,
eating pork, disgusting things and mice,
will come to an end together," says the LORD.
18 "For I know their works and their thoughts.
The time is coming when I will gather all nations and languages,
and they will come and see my glory.
19 I will set up a sign among them,
and I will send some of those who have escaped to the nations,
to Tarshish, Pul and Lud, who draw the bow,
to Tubal and Javan, to the faraway islands
that have not heard of my fame
and have not seen my glory.
And they will announce my glory among the nations.
20 They will bring all your brothers out of all the nations
as an offering to the LORD,
on horses, in chariots, in litters, on mules and on camels,
to my holy mountain Jerusalem," says the LORD,
"just as the people of Israel bring their offering in a clean vessel
into the house of the LORD.
21 I will also choose some of them to be priests and Levites,"
says the LORD.
22 "For as the new heavens and the new earth that I will make
will remain before me," says the LORD,
"so your descendants and your name will remain.
23 And this is how it will be: From one new moon to the next
and from one Sabbath to the next,
all people will come to worship before me," says the LORD.
24 "And they will go out and look at the dead bodies of the people
who have rebelled against me.
For their worm will not die,
and their fire will not be put out,
and they will be disgusting to all people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–17: Once more a picture of judgment: God comes with fire. It strikes those who follow foreign worship. Judgment is God's business, not the business of people who want to punish others.

Verses 18–19: Then the great goal: God gathers all nations and languages. Messengers go out into the whole world, to the farthest countries: Tarshish (in the west, perhaps Spain), Lud and Pul (probably in Africa or Asia Minor), Tubal (on the Black Sea) and Javan (Greece).

Verses 20–21: The nations bring the scattered Israelites home. And the astonishing thing: God even takes people from the nations to be priests and Levites. No one is shut out.

Verses 22–23: Like the new heavens and the new earth, God's people will also remain forever. And all people will worship God.

Verse 24: The book ends with a dark picture: Those who set themselves against God are dead. Jesus takes up this picture when he warns of ruin (Mark 9:48). In the synagogue, verse 23 is read once more after verse 24, so that the reading does not end with judgment, but with hope: All people will come to worship God.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Isaiah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prophet: Isaiah lived about 2,700 years ago in Jerusalem. He was a prophet under four kings of Judah. His name means "The LORD saves," and that is the theme of the whole book.

Three parts: Chapters 1–39 take place in Isaiah's time, when Assyria was the great threat. Chapters 40–55 speak to the exiles in Babylon (the "Book of Comfort"). Chapters 56–66 speak to those who had returned home to Jerusalem. Many scholars think that later prophets in Isaiah's tradition wrote parts 2 and 3. Others see the whole book as Isaiah's work.

Holy, holy, holy: Isaiah sees God as "the Holy One of Israel" (chapter 6). God is high and lifted up, but he lives with the crushed (57:15).

Justice: Isaiah sharply criticizes people who act devout but oppress the poor (chapters 1 and 58). "Learn to do good! Seek justice!" (1:17).

The Prince of Peace: "For a child is born to us" (9:6; in some Bibles 9:5) and the shoot from the stump of Jesse (chapter 11). Wolf and lamb will live together. Christians see Jesus announced here; in Judaism, people expect the Messiah or apply it to King Hezekiah.

Swords into plowshares: All nations come to God's mountain and no longer learn war (2:4).

Comfort my people: After the judgment comes comfort (chapter 40). "Do not be afraid, for I have redeemed you" (43:1). "But I will not forget you!" (49:15).

The Servant of God: Four songs tell of a servant who suffers in silence and makes many whole (42; 49; 50; 52–53). Jews mostly see Israel in him, Christians above all Jesus.

For all nations: God's house is "a house of prayer for all peoples" (56:7). In the end, all people will come to worship God (66:23).

Everything will be new: God creates new heavens and a new earth, without weeping and without violence (65:17–25). And he comforts like a mother (66:13).

What comes next? Next comes the book of Jeremiah. Jeremiah lived about 100 years after Isaiah and lived through the destruction of Jerusalem himself.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 24 OF 66

JEREMIAH

52 CHAPTERS

JEREMIAH

Chapter 1

Before I formed you in the womb

Before we begin: Who was Jeremiah?

Jeremiah lived about 100 years after Isaiah, roughly from 627 until after 587 BC. He came from a family of priests from the village of Anathoth, not far from Jerusalem.

Jeremiah lived through a very hard time: The empire of Babylon became more and more powerful. For decades Jeremiah warned: If you do not turn back to God, Jerusalem will be destroyed. Many people did not want to hear this. Jeremiah was mocked, beaten, thrown into prison and put into a cistern. In the year 587 BC, Jerusalem really was destroyed by the Babylonians.

Jeremiah is the prophet whose feelings we learn the most about. He laments, weeps and argues with God. That is why he is sometimes called the "weeping prophet."

But Jeremiah also brings great hope: God promises a "new covenant," in which he writes his law on people's hearts (Chapter 31).

The book has 52 chapters. It contains speeches, prayers, laments and stories from Jeremiah's life. Jeremiah's scribe was called Baruch. He wrote down many of Jeremiah's words.

Jews and Christians read Jeremiah as God's word in a time of collapse. His message: God is not far away, even in judgment, and he gives a new beginning.

Jeremiah is called VERSES 1–10

1 These are the words of Jeremiah, the son of Hilkiah.
He was one of the priests who lived in Anathoth in the land of Benjamin.
2 The LORD's word came to him in the days of Josiah,
the son of Amon, king of Judah,
in the thirteenth year of his rule.
3 It came also in the days of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah,
until the end of the eleventh year of Zedekiah, the son of Josiah, king of Judah,
until the people of Jerusalem were carried away as captives in the fifth month.
4 The LORD's word came to me. He said:
5 "Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you.
Before you were born, I made you holy.
I have appointed you as a prophet to the nations."
6 Then I said, "Oh, Lord GOD!
Look, I don't know how to speak,
because I am a child."
7 But the LORD said to me,
"Don't say, 'I am a child.'
For you must go to everyone I send you to,
and you must say everything I command you.
8 Don't be afraid of them,
for I am with you to rescue you," says the LORD.
9 Then the LORD stretched out his hand and touched my mouth.
And the LORD said to me,
"Look, I have put my words in your mouth.
10 Look, today I have set you over the nations and over the kingdoms,
to pull up and to tear down,
to destroy and to overthrow,
to build and to plant."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Jeremiah worked for about 40 years: from the thirteenth year of King Josiah (627 BC) until the destruction of Jerusalem (587 BC).

Verse 5: A wonderful verse: God already knew Jeremiah before he was born. Every person is wanted and known by God, even before birth.

Verse 6: Jeremiah resists: "I don't know how to speak, because I am a child." Many people feel too small for a big task. Moses also hesitated like this (Exodus 4:10).

Verses 7–8: God's answer: "Don't say, 'I am a child.' … Don't be afraid of them, for I am with you." God trusts young people with something too.

Verse 9: God touches Jeremiah's mouth and puts his words into it.

Verse 10: Six verbs describe Jeremiah's task: Four of them are hard (pull up, tear down, destroy, overthrow), two are full of hope (build, plant). The whole book will be like this: much judgment, but a new beginning at the end.

Two pictures: an almond branch and a boiling pot VERSES 11–19

11 The LORD's word came to me again. He said,
"Jeremiah, what do you see?"
I said, "I see a branch of an almond tree."
12 Then the LORD said to me,
"You have seen well,
for I watch over my word to make it happen."
13 The LORD's word came to me a second time. He said,
"What do you see?"
I said, "I see a boiling pot,
and it is tipping away from the north."
14 Then the LORD said to me,
"Out of the north, disaster will break out
on all the people who live in the land.
15 For look, I will call all the families of the kingdoms of the north," says the LORD.
"They will come, and each of them will set up his throne
at the entrance of the gates of Jerusalem,
and against all its walls all around,
and against all the cities of Judah.
16 I will speak my judgments against them
because of all their evil,
because they have left me,
and have burned incense to other gods,
and have worshiped the works of their own hands.

17 "But you, put your belt around your waist.
Get up, and tell them everything that I command you.
Don't be terrified of them,
or I will terrify you in front of them.
18 For look, today I have made you a fortified city,
an iron pillar, and bronze walls against the whole land:
against the kings of Judah, against its princes,
against its priests, and against the people of the land.
19 They will fight against you,
but they will not defeat you,
for I am with you," says the LORD, "to rescue you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: A play on words in Hebrew: The almond tree is called "shaked," which means "the watchful one," because in spring it is the first tree to bloom, as if it were already awake. God says: I am "shoked," I watch over my word. What I say happens.

Verses 13–15: The boiling pot that boils over from the north is a picture of the enemies who will come from the north. Babylon actually lay to the east, but the armies came to Israel by way of the north, because they had to go around the desert.

Verse 16: The reason for the disaster: The people have left God and worshiped idols.

Verses 17–19: Jeremiah will meet a lot of opposition: from kings, priests and the people. But God makes him strong like a fortress, an iron pillar. "I am with you ... to rescue you." This does not mean that Jeremiah will not suffer, but he will not be destroyed.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 2

The spring of living water

I remember the love of your youth VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD spoke his word to me.
He said,
2 "Go and call out so that the people of Jerusalem hear it.
Say: 'This is what the LORD says:
"I remember how kind you were when you were young.
I remember how you loved me as a bride.
You followed me in the wilderness,
in a land where no one planted seeds.
3 Israel was holy to the LORD.
Israel was like the first part of his harvest.
Everyone who eats it up will be held guilty.
Disaster will come on them,"' says the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God remembers the beginning with his people, the journey through the wilderness after the exodus from Egypt. Back then, Israel was like a young bride who follows her bridegroom everywhere, even into the wilderness.

Verse 3: Israel was holy to God, like the first fruits of the harvest that belonged to God. Whoever attacked Israel became guilty.

This loving memory is the background for the complaint that follows: What has become of this love?

My people have left me VERSES 4–13

4 House of Jacob, hear the word of the LORD!
All you families of the house of Israel, hear it!
5 This is what the LORD says:
"What wrong did your ancestors find in me?
Why did they go so far away from me?
They followed worthless idols.
And they became worthless themselves.
6 They did not ask,
'Where is the LORD?
He brought us up out of the land of Egypt.
He led us through the wilderness,
through a land of deserts and pits,
through a land of drought and deep darkness,
through a land where no one travels
and where no one lives.'
7 I brought you into a rich land.
You could eat its fruit and its good things.
But when you came in, you made my land unclean.
You made the land I gave you disgusting.
8 The priests did not ask, 'Where is the LORD?'
Those who teach the law did not know me.
The rulers turned against me.
The prophets spoke in the name of Baal.
They followed gods that do not help.
9 "That is why I will still bring charges against you," says the LORD.
"And I will bring charges against your grandchildren.
10 Go over to the islands of Kittim and look.
Send someone to Kedar and think about it carefully.
See if anything like this has ever happened.
11 Has a nation ever exchanged its gods?
And their gods are not even real gods!
But my people have traded their glory
for something that does not help.
12 "Heavens, be shocked at this!
Shake with horror!
Be completely empty," says the LORD.
13 "My people have done two evil things.
They have left me, the spring of living water.
And they have dug water tanks for themselves.
But those tanks are cracked.
They cannot hold water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: God asks like a disappointed lover: What did I do to you, that you have left me?

Verses 6–8: No one asked about God, not the people, not the priests, not the rulers, not the prophets. They forgot who freed them from Egypt.

Verses 10–11: Kittim is Cyprus in the west, Kedar is a people in Arabia in the east. God says: Look around everywhere! No nation changes its gods, even though they are not even real gods. But Israel has left the true God.

Verse 13 is the best-known picture of this chapter: God is like a fresh spring that always flows. The people have left this spring and dug cisterns (water tanks) for themselves, that is, holes in the rock in which rainwater is collected. But these cisterns are cracked and hold no water. Whoever leaves God looks for happiness where it cannot be found.

What do you gain? VERSES 14–19

14 Is Israel a slave?
Was he born a slave?
Then why has he become a prisoner?
15 Young lions have roared at him.
They have roared loudly.
They have turned his land into a wasteland.
His cities are burned down.
No one lives in them.
16 The people of Memphis and Tahpanhes
have also broken the crown of your head.
17 "You brought this on yourself, didn't you?
You left the LORD your God,
while he was leading you on the way.
18 Now what do you gain by going to Egypt
to drink the water of the Shihor?
Why do you go on the road to Assyria
to drink the water of the River?
19 "Your own evil will punish you.
Your turning away from me will correct you.
So know it and see it:
It is evil and bitter that you have left the LORD your God.
It is evil and bitter that you do not fear me," says the Lord, the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: Israel was free, but now it is being robbed by enemies, as if by lions. Memphis and Tahpanhes are cities in Egypt. Verse 16: "Broken the crown of your head" means: They have hurt you badly.

Verse 18: The Shihor is a branch of the Nile in Egypt, "the River" is the Euphrates in Assyria. Judah looked for help sometimes from Egypt, sometimes from Assyria, instead of from God. That is like drinking water from foreign rivers instead of from your own spring.

Verse 19: The consequences of your own mistakes are themselves the punishment. Whoever leaves God realizes at some point how bitter that is.

Like a wild vine VERSES 20–28

20 "Long ago I broke the yoke off your neck.
I tore off your chains.
But you said, 'I will not serve you.'
On every high hill and under every green tree
you bowed down and acted like a prostitute.
21 I had planted you as a fine vine.
I planted you from pure and good seed.
So how did you turn into the wild, spoiled branches
of a foreign vine?
22 You may wash yourself with lye.
You may use a lot of soap.
But your guilt is still a stain in front of me," says the Lord GOD.
Lye is a strong cleaning powder.
23 "How can you say, 'I am not unclean.
I have not followed the Baals'?
Look at what you did in the valley.
Admit what you have done.
You are like a fast young camel
that runs this way and that way.
24 You are like a wild donkey that is used to the wilderness.
She sniffs the wind in her strong desire.
When she is in heat, who can hold her back?
All who look for her do not need to wear themselves out.
In her season, they will find her.
25 "Keep your feet from going bare.
Keep your throat from getting dry.
But you said, 'It is no use.
No! I love strangers, and I will follow them.'
26 A thief is ashamed when he is caught.
In the same way, the house of Israel is ashamed:
they, their kings, their princes, their priests and their prophets.
27 They say to a piece of wood, 'You are my father.'
They say to a stone, 'You gave birth to me.'
They have turned their backs to me, not their faces.
But when they are in trouble, they will say,
'Get up and save us!'
28 "But where are the gods you made for yourselves?
Let them get up, if they can save you when you are in trouble!
Judah, you have as many gods as you have towns.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: The Bible often describes idol worship with the picture of unfaithfulness in marriage or prostitution. What is meant is: The people have become unfaithful to God. It is a picture of the relationship with God, not a judgment on women or on people in prostitution. Foreign gods were worshiped "on every high hill and under every green tree."

Verse 21: God had planted Israel as a noble vine (as in Isaiah 5). But it has become a wild, spoiled vine.

Verse 22: Guilt cannot simply be washed off with soap.

Verses 23–24: Strong pictures from the animal world: The people run after foreign gods like an animal driven by its urges.

Verse 27: Bitter mockery: They say "father" to a piece of wood. But when they are in trouble, they still call on God for help.

Verse 28: Every town in Judah had its own god. But none of them can help.

I have not sinned? VERSES 29–37

29 "Why do you argue with me?
All of you have turned against me," says the LORD.
30 "I punished your children, but it was no use.
They did not accept correction.
Your own sword has killed your prophets,
like a lion that tears its prey apart.
31 People of today, pay attention to the word of the LORD!
Have I been like a wilderness to Israel?
Have I been like a land of deep darkness?
Why do my people say, 'We are free now.
We will never come back to you'?

32 "Can a young woman forget her jewelry?
Can a bride forget her wedding clothes?
But my people have forgotten me
for more days than anyone can count.
33 You know so well how to find your way to lovers!
You have even taught your ways to wicked women.
34 And on the edges of your clothes
there is the blood of innocent, poor people.
You did not catch them breaking into your house.
But it is because of all these things.
35 "Still you say, 'I am innocent.
Surely his anger has turned away from me.'
"Look, I will judge you,
because you say, 'I have not sinned.'
36 Why do you keep running around and changing your ways?
You will be ashamed of Egypt too,
just as you were ashamed of Assyria.
37 You will leave that place too, with your hands on your head.
The LORD has rejected those you trust.
They will not help you succeed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 30: The people even killed prophets who called them to turn back.

Verse 31: God asks: Was I really so bad to you, like a wilderness? Why do you not want to have anything to do with me anymore?

Verse 32: A bride does not forget her wedding jewelry. But God's people have forgotten God.

Verse 34: A serious accusation: The blood of poor, innocent people sticks to their clothes. These people were killed even though they had done nothing. Injustice against the poor is a crime in God's eyes.

Verse 35: The worst thing is when someone says, "I have not sinned." Whoever does not see their guilt cannot turn back.

Verse 37: To leave "with your hands on your head" shows grief and shame.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 3

Return, you unfaithful children!

Come back to me VERSES 1–5

1 "They say, 'If a man sends his wife away,
and she leaves him and becomes another man's wife,
should he go back to her again?'
Wouldn't that land be made very unclean?
But you have acted like a prostitute with many lovers.
Yet come back to me," says the LORD.
2 "Lift up your eyes to the bare hilltops, and look!
Where have you not been slept with?
You have sat by the road waiting for them,
like an Arab in the wilderness.
You have made the land unclean
with your prostitution and with your evil.
3 That is why the showers have been held back,
and there has been no spring rain.
Yet you have had the forehead of a prostitute,
and you refused to be ashamed.
4 From now on, won't you call out to me,
'My Father, you are the guide of my youth!'?
5 "'Will he stay angry forever?
Will he keep it up to the end?'
Look, you have talked like this,
and you have done evil things,
and you have had your way."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: According to the law (Deuteronomy 24:1–4), a man was not allowed to marry his divorced wife again if she had married someone else in the meantime. God says: According to this law, a return would be impossible. And yet God invites his unfaithful people: "Come back to me!" God's love is greater than the law.

Verses 2–3: Again the picture of unfaithfulness and prostitution for idol worship. It is about the people's unfaithfulness to God, not a judgment on individual women. The drought is understood as a consequence of this unfaithfulness.

Verses 4–5: The people do call out "My Father!", but they keep doing evil. They think: God will surely not be angry forever.

The two sisters Israel and Judah VERSES 6–11

6 In the days of King Josiah, the LORD also said to me,
"Have you seen what unfaithful Israel has done?
She has gone up on every high mountain and under every green tree,
and has acted like a prostitute there.
7 After she had done all these things, I said,
'She will come back to me.'
But she didn't come back,
and her unfaithful sister Judah saw it.
8 I saw that, because unfaithful Israel had committed adultery,
I had sent her away and given her a certificate of divorce.
Yet her sister, unfaithful Judah, was not afraid.
She also went and acted like a prostitute.
9 Because she took her prostitution lightly,
the land was made unclean,
and she committed adultery with stones and with wood.
10 Yet in spite of all this, her unfaithful sister Judah
has not come back to me with her whole heart,
but only in pretense," says the LORD.
11 The LORD said to me,
"Unfaithful Israel has shown herself more righteous
than unfaithful Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here two sisters are compared: Israel (the northern kingdom) and Judah (the southern kingdom with

Jerusalem). The northern kingdom had already been destroyed by Assyria about 100 years earlier (722 BC).

Verse 8: The "certificate of divorce" is a picture of the exile of the northern kingdom.

Verse 9: "Adultery with stones and with wood" means worshiping images of gods made of stone and wood.

Verse 10: Under King Josiah there was a great reform (2 Kings 22–23). But Jeremiah says: Many only went along with it on the outside, not with their heart.

Verse 11: Surprisingly, Judah is worse than Israel, because Judah saw what happened to her sister and still learned nothing.

Return, you unfaithful children! VERSES 12–18

12 Go, and call out these words toward the north, and say,
'Come back, unfaithful Israel,' says the LORD.
'I will not look at you in anger,
for I am merciful,' says the LORD.
'I will not stay angry forever.
13 Only admit your guilt:
that you have rebelled against the LORD your God,
and have run here and there to strangers under every green tree,
and you have not obeyed my voice,'" says the LORD.
14 "Return, unfaithful children," says the LORD,
"for I am a husband to you.
I will take one of you from a city,
and two from a family,
and I will bring you to Zion.
15 I will give you shepherds who follow my heart.
They will feed you with knowledge and understanding.
16 In those days, when you have become many in the land," says the LORD,
"they will no longer say, 'the ark of the LORD's covenant!'
It will not come to mind.
They won't remember it.
They won't miss it,
and no other will be made.
17 At that time they will call Jerusalem 'The LORD's Throne.'
All the nations will be gathered to it,
to the LORD's name, to Jerusalem.
They will no longer follow the stubbornness of their evil heart.
18 In those days the house of Judah will walk with the house of Israel.
Together they will come out of the land of the north
to the land that I gave to your ancestors as an inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–13: God even calls back the northern kingdom that was destroyed long ago: "Come back, unfaithful Israel ... for I am merciful." Only one thing is needed: to admit your own guilt.

Verse 14: "Return, unfaithful children!" God is ready to bring home even the few, "one of you from a city, and two from a family." Every single person counts.

Verse 15: God promises good shepherds, that is, leaders who guide the people with knowledge and understanding.

Verse 16: Amazing: People will no longer miss the ark of the covenant, the holiest object in the temple. For all of Jerusalem will be God's throne (verse 17). God's nearness will then no longer be tied to an object. We do not know what later happened to the ark of the covenant. After the destruction of Jerusalem, the Bible does not mention it anymore.

Verses 17–18: All nations come to Jerusalem, and Israel and Judah are united again.

A prayer of turning back VERSES 19–25

19 "But I said,
'How I want to put you among my children,
and give you a pleasant land,
the most beautiful inheritance among the nations!'
And I said, 'You will call me "My Father,"
and you will not turn away from following me.'
20 "But as a wife is unfaithful and leaves her husband,
so you have been unfaithful to me, house of Israel,"
says the LORD.
21 A voice is heard on the bare hilltops:
the weeping and the pleading of the people of Israel,
because they have twisted their way.
They have forgotten the LORD their God.
22 Return, unfaithful children,
and I will heal your unfaithfulness.
"Look, we come to you,
for you are the LORD our God.
23 Truly, the help from the hills,
the noise on the mountains, is useless.
Truly, the salvation of Israel is in the LORD our God.
24 But the shameful thing has eaten up what our ancestors worked for, since our youth:
their flocks and their herds,
their sons and their daughters.
25 Let us lie down in our shame,
and let our disgrace cover us.
For we have sinned against the LORD our God,
we and our ancestors,
from our youth until this day.
We have not obeyed the voice of the LORD our God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: God had wanted so much for his people to call him "My Father" and to stay with him.

Verse 21: On the hills where foreign gods used to be worshiped, weeping and praying can now be heard.

Verse 22: God calls: "Return, unfaithful children, and I will heal your unfaithfulness." And the people answer: "Look, we come to you!" A beautiful example of what turning back looks like.

Verse 23: The people realize: The idols on the hills could not help. Only God saves.

Verse 24: "The shameful thing" is a scornful name for the idol Baal. Idol worship has eaten up everything, even sons and daughters. This probably also refers to the terrible sacrifices of children (compare Jeremiah 7:31).

Verse 25: An honest confession of guilt. It is the first step toward a new beginning.

Chapter 4

Disaster comes from the north

Break up new ground! VERSES 1–4

1 "If you will return, Israel," says the LORD,
"if you will return to me,
and if you will put your disgusting idols out of my sight,
then you will not be driven away.
2 You will swear, 'As surely as the LORD lives,'
in truth, in justice, and in righteousness.
Then the nations will bless themselves in him,
and they will be proud of him."
3 For the LORD says to the men of Judah and to Jerusalem,
"Break up your unplowed ground,
and don't sow among thorns.
4 Circumcise yourselves for the LORD.
Take away the foreskins of your heart,
you men of Judah and people of Jerusalem.
Otherwise my anger will go out like fire,
and burn so that no one can put it out,
because of the evil of your deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: God invites them once more: If you turn back, you can stay. And then even the other nations will be blessed through you, as was promised to Abraham (Genesis 12:3).

Verse 3: A picture from farming: A field that has not been plowed for a long time is hard and full of thorns. You first have to plow it up before you sow. In the same way, the heart must first be "plowed up" so that God's word can grow.

Verse 4: Circumcision was the sign of the covenant with God. But Jeremiah says: It is not only the outward sign that matters, but the heart. The heart should be open to God (compare Deuteronomy 10:16; Romans 2:29).

The lion has set out VERSES 5–18

5 Announce it in Judah, and make it known in Jerusalem.
Say, 'Blow the trumpet in the land!'
Shout loudly and say,
'Gather together! Let's go into the fortified cities!'
6 Raise a signal flag toward Zion.
Run for safety! Don't wait!
For I will bring disaster from the north,
and a great destruction."
7 A lion has come up from his thicket,
a destroyer of nations.
He is on his way.
He has gone out from his place
to make your land a waste,
so that your cities will be ruined, with no one living in them.
8 Because of this, put on sackcloth.
Mourn and wail,
for the fierce anger of the LORD hasn't turned away from us.
9 "On that day," says the LORD,
"the king will lose his courage,
and so will the princes.
The priests will be shocked,
and the prophets will be amazed."
10 Then I said, "Oh, Lord GOD!
Surely you have badly deceived this people and Jerusalem,
by saying, 'You will have peace,'
while the sword reaches to the heart."
11 At that time it will be said to this people and to Jerusalem,
"A hot wind blows from the bare hilltops in the wilderness
toward the daughter of my people.
It is not a wind for separating grain from chaff,
and not for cleaning.
12 A wind too strong for that will come at my command.
Now I will also speak judgments against them."
13 Look, he will come up like clouds.
His chariots will be like the whirlwind.
His horses are faster than eagles.
How terrible for us! For we are ruined.
14 Jerusalem, wash your heart clean of evil,
so that you may be saved.
How long will your evil thoughts stay inside you?
15 For a voice announces it from Dan,
and makes disaster known from the hills of Ephraim:
16 "Tell the nations, look,
announce it against Jerusalem:
'Watchers are coming from a far country.
They raise their voices against the cities of Judah.
17 Like guards of a field,
they surround her on every side,
because she has rebelled against me,'" says the LORD.
18 "Your way and your deeds have brought these things on you.
This is your evil.
Yes, it is bitter.
Yes, it reaches to your heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: The trumpet, a ram's horn (shofar), is blown as an alarm signal. Everyone is to flee into the fortified cities.

Verse 7: The "lion" is the army of Babylon, which swallows up whole nations.

Verse 10: Jeremiah accuses God: Have you deceived the people? There were prophets who had promised peace in God's name. Jeremiah is in despair because these promises were false. He dares to express his despair openly before God.

Verses 11–13: The enemy comes like a burning desert wind, like a storm, faster than eagles.

Verse 14: In the middle of the warning, another invitation: "Jerusalem, wash your heart clean of evil, so that you may be saved."

Verse 15: Dan lies in the far north of the land, Ephraim in the middle. The news of the enemy is coming closer and closer.

Verse 18: The disaster is the result of their own deeds.

My anguish, my anguish! VERSES 19–31

19 My anguish, my anguish!
I am in pain deep in my heart!
My heart pounds inside me.
I can't keep quiet,
because you have heard, my soul,
the sound of the trumpet,
the alarm of war.
20 Destruction after destruction is announced,
for the whole land is ruined.
Suddenly my tents are destroyed,
and my curtains are gone in a moment.
21 How long must I see the signal flag
and hear the sound of the trumpet?
22 "For my people are foolish.
They don't know me.
They are foolish children,
and they have no understanding.
They are skillful at doing evil,
but they don't know how to do good."
23 I looked at the earth, and it was without form and
empty.
I looked at the heavens, and they had no light.
24 I looked at the mountains, and they were shaking,
and all the hills were rocking back and forth.
25 I looked, and there was no human being,
and all the birds of the sky had fled.
26 I looked, and the fruitful land was a wilderness.
All its cities were broken down before the LORD,
before his fierce anger.
27 For the LORD says,
"The whole land will be a waste.
Yet I will not make a complete end.
28 Because of this the earth will mourn,
and the heavens above will be black,
because I have spoken it.
I have planned it, and I have not changed my mind.
I will not turn back from it."
29 Every city runs away at the noise of the horsemen and
archers.
They go into the thickets and climb up on the rocks.
Every city is abandoned,
and no one lives in them.
30 And you, when you are ruined, what will you do?
Even if you dress in scarlet,
even if you put on gold jewelry,
even if you make your eyes bigger with makeup,
you make yourself beautiful for nothing.
Your lovers despise you.
They want to kill you.
31 For I have heard a cry like that of a woman in labor,
the anguish like that of a woman giving birth to her
first child.
It is the cry of the daughter of Zion,
who gasps for breath, who stretches out her hands,
and says,
"How terrible for me now!
For I am fainting before the murderers."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 19–21: Jeremiah is not a cold prophet of judgment. He suffers with his people. He hears the war horn, and his heart hurts. He cannot keep quiet. Anyone who has ever been very afraid understands these words.

Verse 22: God laments: My people are skillful at doing evil, but they have forgotten how to do good.

Verses 23–26: A shocking vision: Jeremiah sees the earth "without form and empty," in Hebrew the same words as in Genesis 1:2 before creation. No light, no human being, no birds. It is as if creation were being undone. That is how terrible war is.

Verse 27: And yet: "I will not make a complete end." A small spark of hope.

Verse 30: Jerusalem is described as a woman who makes herself beautiful to win foreign lovers (foreign powers like Egypt). But they turn against her.

Verse 31: The daughter of Zion cries out like a woman in hard labor, without hope. A picture of the distress of people in war. Sadly, there are such cries in many wars to this day. If you are weighed down by war or violence, you can get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 5

Is there anyone who does what is right?

Look for one righteous person! VERSES 1–9

1 "Run back and forth through the streets of Jerusalem.
Look now, and find out.
Search in its town squares
to see if you can find one person,
if there is anyone who acts with justice,
who looks for the truth.
Then I will forgive the city.
2 Even though they say, 'As surely as the LORD lives,'
they certainly swear falsely."
3 LORD, don't your eyes look for truth?
You have struck them, but they felt no pain.
You have crushed them, but they have refused to
accept correction.
They have made their faces harder than a rock.
They have refused to turn back.
4 Then I said, "These are only the poor.
They are foolish,
for they don't know the LORD's way,
or the law of their God.
5 I will go to the important men and speak to them,
for they know the way of the LORD,
and the law of their God."
But all of them together have broken the yoke
and torn off the chains.
6 That is why a lion out of the forest will kill them.
A wolf of the evening will destroy them.

A leopard will lie in wait near their cities.
Everyone who goes out there will be torn to pieces,
because their rebellions are many,
and they have turned away more and more.
7 "How can I forgive you?
Your children have left me,
and sworn by things that are no gods.
When I had fed them until they were full,
they committed adultery,
and crowded together at the houses of prostitutes.
8 They were like well-fed horses running around.
Each one neighed after his neighbor's wife.
9 Shouldn't I punish them for these things?" says the LORD.
"Shouldn't I take revenge on such a nation as this?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A famous verse: God says: Search all of Jerusalem for one single person who is righteous and looks for the truth, then I will forgive the whole city. This is a reminder of Abraham, who bargained for Sodom (Genesis 18).

Verses 4–5: At first Jeremiah thinks: The simple people don't know any better. I will go to the educated and powerful. But it is exactly these people who have most ignored God's commandments.

Verse 6: Lion, wolf and leopard are pictures of the enemies who will come.

Verses 7–8: There is unfaithfulness toward God, and also real unfaithfulness in marriages. God sees both. Faithfulness in marriage is a high value. If you experience violence or abuse in your marriage, you may get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verse 9: "Revenge" here means that God restores justice. It is not permission for people to take revenge.

They deny the LORD VERSES 10–19

10 "Go up on her walls and destroy,
but don't make a complete end.
Take away her branches,
for they do not belong to the LORD.
11 For the house of Israel and the house of Judah
have been very unfaithful to me," says the LORD.
12 They have denied the LORD and said,
"He won't do anything.
Disaster won't come on us.
We won't see sword or famine.
13 The prophets are nothing but wind,
and the word is not in them.
Let this happen to them."
14 That is why the LORD, the God of Armies, says,
"Because you speak this way,
look, I will make my words in your mouth fire,
and this people wood,
and it will burn them up.
15 Look, I will bring a nation against you from far away,
house of Israel," says the LORD.
"It is a mighty nation.
It is an ancient nation,
a nation whose language you don't know.
You don't understand what they say.
16 Their quiver is like an open grave.
They are all mighty warriors.
17 They will eat up your harvest and your bread,
which your sons and your daughters should eat.
They will eat up your flocks and your herds.
They will eat up your vines and your fig trees.
With the sword they will break down your fortified cities,
the cities you trust in.
18 "But even in those days," says the LORD,
"I will not make a complete end of you.
19 When you ask, 'Why has the LORD our God done all these things to us?'
then you will say to them,
'Just as you have left me and served foreign gods in your land,
so you will serve strangers in a land that is not yours.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The enemies will come, but God sets a limit: "Don't make a complete end."

Verses 12–13: The people say: God won't do anything to us. The prophets are only talking hot air.

Verse 14: God answers: Jeremiah's words will be like fire, and the people like wood.

Verses 15–17: The foreign nation with the unknown language is the Babylonians. They will take away everything people need to live.

Verse 18: Again the hope: "I will not make a complete end of you." God leaves a remnant.

Verse 19: Whoever serves foreign gods will have to serve foreigners. The punishment fits the guilt: the exile in Babylon.

A people with eyes that do not see VERSES 20–31

20 "Announce this in the house of Jacob,
and make it known in Judah. Say:
21 'Hear this now, you foolish people without understanding,
who have eyes, but don't see,
who have ears, but don't hear:
22 Don't you fear me?' says the LORD.
'Won't you tremble in front of me?
I have placed the sand as the border of the sea,
by a law that lasts forever, so that it can't cross it.
Even if its waves toss, they can't win.
Even if they roar, they still can't cross over it.'
23 "But this people has a stubborn and rebellious heart.
They have turned away and gone off.
24 They don't say in their heart,
'Let's fear the LORD our God,
who gives rain, both the autumn rain and the spring rain, at the right time,
who keeps for us the weeks set for the harvest.'
25 "Your wrongdoings have turned these things away.
Your sins have kept good things from you.
26 For wicked men are found among my people.
They watch like bird hunters lying in wait.
They set a trap.
They catch people.
27 As a cage is full of birds,
so their houses are full of deceit.

That is how they have become powerful and rich.
28 They have grown fat.
They are sleek.
Yes, they go beyond all limits in doing evil.
They don't plead the case of the orphan,
so that it may go well for him.
And they don't defend the rights of the needy.
29 "Shouldn't I punish for these things?" says the LORD.
"Shouldn't I take revenge on such a nation as this?
30 "Something shocking and horrible has happened in the land.
31 The prophets prophesy lies,
and the priests rule as they please,
and my people love it this way.
What will you do when the end comes?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: The people have eyes and ears, but they do not want to see or hear.

Verse 22: Even the wild sea keeps to the border God has set for it. But God's people keep to no border.

Verse 24: No one thanks God for the rain and the harvest.

Verses 26–28: Sharp social criticism: Rich people set traps for others like bird hunters. They become rich and fat through deceit. But they do not help orphans and the poor. God sees this. Injustice toward the weak matters to him.

Verse 31: The worst thing: Prophets lie, priests do what they want, "and my people love it this way." People would rather hear pleasant lies than uncomfortable truth.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 6

Peace, peace – when there is no peace

Jerusalem is besieged VERSES 1–8

1 "Run for safety, you people of Benjamin,
out of the middle of Jerusalem!
Blow the trumpet in Tekoa,
and raise a signal on Beth Haccherem,
for disaster looks out from the north,
with a great destruction.
2 I will destroy the beautiful and delicate one,
the daughter of Zion.
3 Shepherds with their flocks will come to her.
They will set up their tents against her all around.
Each one will graze his flock in his own place."
4 "Get ready for war against her!
Get up! Let's attack at noon.
How terrible for us! For the day is ending,
and the shadows of the evening are growing long.
5 Get up! Let's attack by night,
and let's destroy her palaces."
6 For the LORD of Armies said,
"Cut down trees,
and build a ramp of earth against Jerusalem.
This is the city that must be punished.
She is full of oppression inside.
7 As a well pours out its water,
so she pours out her evil.
Violence and destruction are heard in her.
Sickness and wounds are always in front of me.
8 Accept the warning, Jerusalem,
or I will turn away from you,
or I will make you a waste,
a land where no one lives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Tekoa and Beth Haccherem are places south of Jerusalem. The people are to flee south, because the enemy comes from the north.

Verse 3: The "shepherds with their flocks" are the enemy commanders with their soldiers.

Verses 4–5: We hear the enemies talking: They are so eager that they even want to attack at noon and at night.

Verses 6–7: God says: Jerusalem is full of oppression and violence inside. Evil pours out of the city like water out of a well.

Verse 8: Here too there is a last warning: Accept the warning before it is too late!

They say "peace," but there is no peace VERSES 9–15

9 The LORD of Armies says,
"They will completely pick clean what is left of Israel,
like a vine.
Pass your hand over the branches again,
like someone who gathers grapes into baskets."
10 Who should I speak to and warn,
so that they may hear?
Look, their ears are uncircumcised,
and they can't listen.
Look, the LORD's word has become something they mock.
They have no joy in it.
11 That is why I am full of the LORD's anger.
I am tired of holding it in.
"Pour it out on the children in the street,
and on the young men gathered together.
For even the husband with the wife will be taken,
the old with the very old.
12 Their houses will be given to others,
their fields and their wives together,
for I will stretch out my hand against the people who live in the land," says the LORD.
13 "For from the least to the greatest of them,
everyone is greedy for gain.
From the prophet to the priest,
everyone acts falsely.
14 They have treated the wound of my people as if it were not serious.
They say, 'Peace, peace!'
when there is no peace.

15 Were they ashamed when they had done disgusting
things?
No, they were not ashamed at all.
They didn't even know how to blush.
That is why they will fall among those who fall.
When I punish them, they will be thrown down," says
the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Jeremiah is in despair: No one listens. Their ears are "uncircumcised," that is, closed.

Verse 11: Jeremiah can no longer hold back God's message. The disaster will hit everyone, children, young and old. This is not Jeremiah's wish, but a painful announcement.

Verse 13: From the least to the greatest, everyone only thinks about their own gain.

Verse 14 is a famous verse: The false prophets say "Peace, peace!" when there is no peace. They cover a deep wound with only a bandage. They tell people what they want to hear. Real peace needs honesty and justice.

Verse 15: They are not even ashamed anymore of the evil they do.

Ask for the old paths VERSES 16–21

16 The LORD says,
"Stand by the roads and look.
Ask for the old paths:
'Where is the good way?'
Walk in it,
and you will find rest for your souls.
But they said, 'We will not walk in it.'
17 I set watchmen over you, and said,
'Listen to the sound of the trumpet!'
But they said, 'We will not listen!'
18 So hear, you nations,
and know, you assembly, what is going on among
them.
19 Hear, earth!
Look, I will bring disaster on this people,
the fruit of their own plans,
because they have not listened to my words,
and they have rejected my law.
20 What good is it to me when incense comes from Sheba,
and sweet-smelling cane from a far country?
Your burnt offerings are not acceptable,
and your sacrifices do not please me."
21 That is why the LORD says,
"Look, I will put stumbling blocks in front of this
people.
Fathers and sons together will stumble over them.
Neighbors and friends will die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16 is a beautiful, often quoted verse: If you don't know where to go, stand still, look around, and ask for the proven paths. Walk on the good way, and you will find rest for your soul. Jesus says something similar: "And you will find rest for your souls" (Matthew 11:29).

But the people answer: "We will not!"

Verse 17: The "watchmen" are the prophets who warn. But no one listens to them.

Verse 20: Expensive offerings from far countries are of no use if the heart is not with God.

A cruel people from the north VERSES 22–30

22 The LORD says,
"Look, a people is coming from the land of the north.
A great nation will be stirred up from the ends of the
earth.
23 They hold bow and spear.
They are cruel and have no mercy.
Their voice roars like the sea.
They ride on horses,
each one lined up like a man ready for battle,
against you, daughter of Zion."
24 We have heard the news about them.
Our hands hang weak.
Anguish has seized us,
pains like those of a woman in labor.
25 Don't go out into the field,
or walk along the road,
for the enemy has a sword,
and there is terror on every side.
26 Daughter of my people, put on sackcloth,
and roll in ashes!
Mourn as for an only son,
with the most bitter weeping,
for the destroyer will suddenly come on us.
27 "I have made you a tester of metals and a fortress
among my people,
so that you may know and test their way.
28 They are all the worst kind of rebels.
They go around spreading lies about others.
They are bronze and iron.
All of them act corruptly.
29 The bellows blow hard.
The lead is burned up in the fire.
They go on refining for nothing,
because the wicked are not removed.
30 People will call them rejected silver,
because the LORD has rejected them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–23: The army from the north is cruel and without mercy. Jeremiah honestly describes how terrible war is.

Verses 24–26: The people are paralyzed with fear. No one dares to go outside anymore. "There is terror on every side" is an expression that appears more often in Jeremiah. The grief is as deep as the grief for an only child.

Verses 27–30: God makes Jeremiah a "tester," like someone who tests metal in the fire. When the metal is melted, the pure silver is supposed to be separated from what is impure. But no matter how much is melted, nothing pure is left. A sad result.

Anyone who suffers from war, having to flee, or fear today finds in Jeremiah's words someone who knows this pain. And no one has to stay alone with it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Chapter 7

The temple speech

Don't trust in lying words VERSES 1–15

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 "Stand in the gate of the LORD's house,
and call out this word there. Say,
'Hear the LORD's word, all you people of Judah
who go in through these gates to worship the LORD.'"
3 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
"Change your ways and your deeds,
and I will let you live in this place.
4 Don't trust in lying words that say,
'This is the LORD's temple, the LORD's temple, the
LORD's temple.'
5 For if you really change your ways and your deeds,
if you really do justice between one person and
another,
6 if you don't oppress the foreigner, the orphan, and the
widow,
and don't shed innocent blood in this place,
and don't follow other gods, which only harms you,
7 then I will let you live in this place,
in the land that I gave to your ancestors,
from long ago and forever.
8 Look, you trust in lying words that are of no use.
9 Will you steal, murder, commit adultery, swear falsely,
burn incense to Baal,
and follow other gods that you have not known,
10 and then come and stand in front of me in this house,
which is called by my name, and say, 'We are safe,'
so that you can go on doing all these disgusting things?
11 Has this house, which is called by my name,
become a den of robbers in your eyes?
Look, I myself have seen it," says the LORD.
12 "But go now to my place which was in Shiloh,
where I first made my name live,
and see what I did to it because of the evil of my people
Israel.
13 Now, you have done all these things," says the LORD.
"I spoke to you again and again,
but you didn't listen.
I called you, but you didn't answer.
14 That is why I will do to the house which is called by my
name,
which you trust in,
and to the place which I gave to you and to your
ancestors,
what I did to Shiloh.
15 I will throw you out of my sight,
as I have thrown out all your brothers,
all the descendants of Ephraim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is Jeremiah's famous "temple speech." He stands at the gate of the temple, where everyone goes in, and speaks there.

Verse 4: People thought: As long as the temple stands, nothing can happen to us. After all, God lives here! Three times they say "the LORD's temple" like a magic formula. Jeremiah says: These are lying words. A building does not protect you.

Verses 5–7: What matters: doing justice, not oppressing foreigners, orphans and widows, not shedding innocent blood.

Verses 9–10: The people break almost all of the Ten Commandments and then come into the temple and say: "We are safe!"

Verse 11: "Has this house ... become a den of robbers?" After their raids, robbers go back to their den, where they are safe. That is how people used the temple. Jesus quotes this verse when he drives the traders out of the temple (Mark 11:17).

Verses 12–14: Shiloh was earlier the place where the ark of the covenant stood (1 Samuel 1–4). Shiloh was later destroyed. Jeremiah says: The same can happen to the temple in Jerusalem. Jeremiah was almost killed for this speech (Chapter 26).

Don't pray for this people VERSES 16–20

16 "So don't pray for this people.
Don't raise a cry or prayer for them,
and don't plead with me for them,
for I will not hear you.
17 Don't you see what they do in the cities of Judah
and in the streets of Jerusalem?
18 The children gather wood,
the fathers light the fire,
and the women knead the dough,
to make cakes for the queen of the sky.
And they pour out drink offerings to other gods,
to make me angry.
19 Is it me they make angry?" says the LORD.
"Isn't it themselves they hurt, to their own shame?"
20 That is why the Lord GOD says:
"Look, my anger and my fury will be poured out on
this place,
on people, on animals,
on the trees of the field, and on the fruit of the ground.
It will burn and will not be put out."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: A shocking sentence: God says to Jeremiah: Don't pray for this people anymore. This shows how serious the situation is. Even so, Jeremiah later prayed and lamented for his people again and again.

Verse 18: Whole families take part in idol worship: children, fathers and mothers. The "queen of the sky" was a goddess who was worshiped in the ancient Near East (probably Ishtar or Astarte). People baked cakes for her.

Verse 19: Whoever leaves God harms above all themselves in the end.

Obedience instead of sacrifice VERSES 21–28

21 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Add your burnt offerings to your sacrifices,
and eat the meat.

22 For on the day that I brought your ancestors out of the
land of Egypt,
I didn't speak to them or command them about burnt
offerings or sacrifices.
23 But this is what I commanded them:
'Listen to my voice,
and I will be your God,
and you will be my people.
Walk in all the way that I command you,
so that it may go well with you.'
24 But they didn't listen or pay attention.
They followed their own plans
and the stubbornness of their evil heart.
They went backward, and not forward.
25 Since the day that your ancestors came out of the land
of Egypt until today,
I have sent you all my servants the prophets,
sending them every day, again and again.
26 Yet they didn't listen to me or pay attention,
but they made their necks stiff.
They did worse than their ancestors.
27 "You will speak all these words to them,
but they will not listen to you.
You will call to them,
but they will not answer you.
28 Tell them,
'This is the nation that has not listened to the voice of
the LORD their God,
and has not accepted correction.
Truth has died.
It has disappeared from their mouth.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: An ironic sentence: You might as well eat your sacrifices yourselves; they mean nothing to me.

Verses 22–23: God says: When I brought you out of Egypt, it was not sacrifices that mattered most to me, but that you listen to me. "I will be your God, and you will be my people." That is the heart of the covenant. The laws about sacrifices came later and were not the most important thing.

Verse 24: They "went backward, and not forward." A strong picture.

Verse 28: "Truth has died." A sad judgment on a society.

The valley of slaughter VERSES 29–34

29 Cut off your hair and throw it away.
Sing a song of mourning on the bare hilltops,
for the LORD has rejected and left
the generation that made him angry.
30 "For the people of Judah have done what is evil in my
eyes," says the LORD.
"They have put their disgusting idols in the house
which is called by my name,
to make it unclean.
31 They have built the high places of Topheth,
which is in the valley of the son of Hinnom,
to burn their sons and their daughters in the fire.
I didn't command it,
and it never came into my mind.
32 So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when it will no longer be called 'Topheth'
or 'The valley of the son of Hinnom,'
but 'The valley of Slaughter.'
For they will bury in Topheth
until there is no room left to bury.
33 The dead bodies of this people will be food for the birds
of the sky
and for the animals of the earth.
No one will scare them away.
34 Then I will put an end in the cities of Judah and in the
streets of Jerusalem
to the sound of joy and the sound of gladness,
the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,
for the land will become a ruin."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29: Cutting off your hair was a sign of mourning.

Verse 31: The most terrible thing: In the valley of the son of Hinnom near Jerusalem, some people burned their own children as sacrifices to foreign gods. God says very clearly: I never commanded this, "it never came into my mind." Sacrificing children or doing violence to them is a crime that God hates.

Verse 32: The valley becomes "The valley of Slaughter." From the name "Ge-Hinnom" (valley of Hinnom) later came the word "Gehenna," which in the New Testament refers to hell.

Verse 34: No more weddings, no more joy, no more laughter. This is the picture of a completely destroyed city.

If you know of violence against children or have experienced it yourself, help is available: In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 8

Is there no balm in Gilead?

The bones are dug up VERSES 1–3

1 "At that time," says the LORD,
"they will bring out of their graves
the bones of the kings of Judah,
the bones of its princes,
the bones of the priests,
the bones of the prophets,
and the bones of the people of Jerusalem.
2 They will spread them out in front of the sun, the
moon, and all the stars of the sky,
which they have loved, which they have served,
which they have followed, which they have looked for,
and which they have worshiped.

The bones will not be gathered or buried.
They will be like manure on the surface of the ground.
3 All who are left of this evil family,
who are left in all the places where I have driven them,
will choose death rather than life," says the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A gruesome picture: The graves are opened, and the bones lie in front of the sun, moon and stars that the people worshiped. These heavenly bodies cannot help them now.

In the ancient Near East, it was a great disgrace not to be buried.

Verse 3: The survivors in exile will be so desperate that they would rather die. This shows how deep the suffering is. If you have such thoughts today, you should not stay alone with them: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Even the stork knows its time VERSES 4–13

4 "Tell them also, 'The LORD says:
"'When people fall, don't they get up again?
When someone turns away, doesn't he come back?
5 Why then have the people of Jerusalem turned away,
and keep on turning away?
They hold on to deceit.
They refuse to come back.
6 I listened and heard,
but they didn't say what is right.
No one is sorry for his evil and says,
"What have I done?"
Everyone runs his own way,
like a horse that charges into battle.
7 Yes, the stork in the sky knows her seasons.
The turtledove, the swallow, and the crane
keep the time of their return.
But my people don't know the LORD's law.
8 "'How can you say, "We are wise,
and the LORD's law is with us"?
But look, the lying pen of the scribes
has turned it into a lie.
9 The wise men are put to shame.
They are terrified and trapped.
Look, they have rejected the LORD's word.
What kind of wisdom do they have?
10 So I will give their wives to others,
and their fields to new owners.
For everyone from the least to the greatest is greedy for gain.
From the prophet to the priest, everyone acts falsely.
11 They have treated the wound of the daughter of my people
as if it were not serious.
They say, "Peace, peace,"
when there is no peace.
12 Were they ashamed when they had done disgusting things?
No, they were not ashamed at all.
They didn't know how to blush.
That is why they will fall among those who fall.
When the time of their punishment comes, they will be thrown down, says the LORD.
13 "'I will completely sweep them away, says the LORD.
There will be no grapes on the vine,
and no figs on the fig tree,
and the leaves will wither.
What I have given them will be taken away from them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: A simple question: Whoever falls gets up again! Whoever goes the wrong way turns back! Why do my people not do this?

Verse 6: No one asks himself, "What have I done?" This question is the beginning of every turning back.

Verse 7: A beautiful picture from nature: Migrating birds like storks, swallows and cranes know exactly when they must return. But God's people do not know when it is time to return to God.

Verse 8: The scribes say: But we have the law! But they have explained it in such a way that it became a lie.

Verses 10–12: These verses repeat Jeremiah 6:12–15 almost word for word: "Peace, peace," when there is no peace.

Verse 13: A fig tree without fruit. Jesus uses a similar picture (Mark 11:13–14; Luke 13:6–9).

The harvest is over VERSES 14–22

14 "Why are we sitting still?
Gather together!
Let's go into the fortified cities,
and let's be silent there.
For the LORD our God has silenced us,
and given us poisoned water to drink,
because we have sinned against the LORD.
15 We hoped for peace, but nothing good came.
We hoped for a time of healing, but there was terror!
16 The snorting of his horses is heard from Dan.
The whole land shakes at the sound of the neighing of his strong horses.
For they have come and have eaten up the land and everything in it,
the city and those who live in it."
17 "For look, I will send snakes among you,
poisonous snakes that can't be charmed.
They will bite you," says the LORD.
18 Oh, if only I could find comfort in my sorrow!
My heart is sick inside me.
19 Listen, the cry of the daughter of my people
from a land very far away:
"Isn't the LORD in Zion?
Isn't her King in her?"
"Why have they made me angry with their carved images,
and with foreign idols?"
20 "The harvest is over.
The summer has ended,
and we are not saved."
21 Because the daughter of my people is broken, I am broken.
I mourn.
Horror has seized me.
22 Is there no balm in Gilead?
Is there no doctor there?

Why then hasn't the daughter of my people been healed?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: The people now realize that disaster is coming. They flee into the fortresses, but without hope.

Verse 18: Now Jeremiah himself is speaking. His heart is sick with sorrow.

Verse 19: You can already hear the voices from exile: "Isn't the LORD in Zion?" And God answers sadly: Why have they hurt me with idols?

Verse 20: A famous verse: "The harvest is over. The summer has ended, and we are not saved." The time when they could still have turned back is over.

Verse 21: Jeremiah suffers with his people. He is "broken" because his people are broken.

Verse 22: Gilead (east of the Jordan) was famous for its healing balm, a resin. Jeremiah asks in despair: Is there no medicine and no doctor for my people? An African American spiritual answers: *There Is a Balm in Gilead*, a balm that heals the wounded.

Balm is a healing ointment.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 9

Whoever wants to boast

Oh, if only my head were water! VERSES 1–11

1 Oh, if only my head were water,
and my eyes a spring of tears,
so that I could weep day and night
for those who were killed among the daughter of my people!

2 Oh, if only I had a place to stay in the wilderness,
a shelter for travelers,
so that I could leave my people and go away from them!
For they are all adulterers,
a crowd of unfaithful people.

3 "They bend their tongue like a bow to shoot lies.
They have grown strong in the land, but not for the truth.
For they go from one evil to the next,
and they don't know me," says the LORD.

4 "Everyone, watch out for your neighbor,
and don't trust any brother.
For every brother cheats,
and every neighbor goes around spreading lies.

5 Friends deceive each other,
and will not speak the truth.
They have taught their tongue to speak lies.
They wear themselves out doing wrong.

6 You live in the middle of deceit.
Because of their deceit, they refuse to know me," says the LORD.

7 That is why the LORD of Armies says,
"Look, I will melt them and test them,
for what else can I do with the daughter of my people?

8 Their tongue is a deadly arrow.
It speaks deceit.
With his mouth a person speaks peacefully to his neighbor,
but in his heart he plans to ambush him.

9 Shouldn't I punish them for these things?" says the LORD.
"Shouldn't I take revenge on a nation like this?

10 I will weep and wail for the mountains,
and sing a song of mourning for the pastures of the wilderness,
because they are burned up, so that no one passes through.
No one hears the sound of the livestock.
Both the birds of the sky and the animals have fled.
They are gone.

11 "I will make Jerusalem heaps of ruins,
a place where jackals live.
I will make the cities of Judah a waste,
with no one living in them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Note: In some Bibles, verse 1 of this chapter is the last verse of chapter 8 (8:23). That is why all the verses of chapter 9 are shifted by one there. Here we follow the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

Verse 1: Jeremiah wishes his head were full of water and his eyes a spring, so that he could weep enough over the many dead. That is why he is called the "weeping prophet."

Verse 2: At the same time, he would like most of all to run away, far away into the wilderness. Many people know what it is like to feel both at the same time: compassion and the wish to run away.

Verses 3–8: No one can trust anyone anymore. Friends and brothers and sisters lie to each other. People speak in a friendly way but plan evil. Lies and slander destroy a community from the inside.

Verse 10: God laments too. He weeps over the burned mountains and the empty pastures.

Why is the land destroyed? VERSES 12–16

12 Who is wise enough to understand this?
To whom has the LORD spoken, so that he can explain it?
Why is the land ruined and burned up like a wilderness,
so that no one passes through?

13 The LORD says,
"Because they have left my law, which I set before them,
and have not obeyed my voice or walked in my ways.

14 Instead, they have followed the stubbornness of their own heart,
and the Baals, as their ancestors taught them."

15 That is why the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
"Look, I will feed this people with wormwood,
and give them poisoned water to drink.

16 I will scatter them among nations
that neither they nor their ancestors have known.

I will send the sword after them,
until I have destroyed them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The big question: Why did all this happen?

Verses 13–14: The answer: Because the people left God's law and followed idols.

Verse 15: Wormwood is a very bitter plant. Life becomes as bitter as wormwood.

Verse 16: The exile is announced: being scattered among foreign nations.

Call for the mourning women! VERSES 17–22

17 The LORD of Armies says,
"Think about it, and call for the mourning women to come.
Send for the most skillful women to come.
18 Let them hurry and start wailing for us,
so that our eyes run with tears,
and our eyelids pour out water.
19 For a sound of wailing is heard out of Zion:
'How we are ruined!
We are deeply ashamed, because we have left the land,
because they have thrown down our homes.'"
20 Yet hear the LORD's word, you women.
Let your ears take in the word of his mouth.
Teach your daughters to wail.
Each of you, teach her neighbor a song of mourning.
21 For death has climbed in through our windows.
It has come into our palaces,
to take away the children from the streets,
and the young men from the town squares.
22 Say, "The LORD says,
'The dead bodies of people will fall like manure on the open field,
and like grain left behind by the harvester.
No one will gather them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: In the ancient Near East, there were mourning women. They were experts in grief and helped others to express their pain. God himself calls them: You must lament now!

Verse 20: The women are to teach their daughters and neighbors to lament. Grief needs words and community.

Verse 21: "Death has climbed in through our windows" like a thief. It takes away children and young people.

These verses show: It is right to express grief and pain out loud. The Bible has a whole book full of laments. Whoever mourns may weep. And no one has to be alone with it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

What to be proud of VERSES 23–26

23 The LORD says,
"Don't let the wise man boast about his wisdom.
Don't let the strong man boast about his strength.
Don't let the rich man boast about his riches.
24 But whoever boasts, let him boast about this:
that he understands and knows me,
that I am the LORD, who shows faithful love, justice,
and righteousness on the earth,
for I delight in these things," says the LORD.
25 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will punish all those who are circumcised only in their body:
26 Egypt, Judah, Edom, the people of Ammon, Moab,
and all who cut the hair at the sides of their head,
who live in the wilderness.
For all the nations are uncircumcised,
and the whole house of Israel is uncircumcised in heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–24 are among the most important sentences in Jeremiah: Don't be proud of your cleverness, your strength or your money. If you want to be proud of something, be proud that you know God, the God who shows faithful love, justice and righteousness and delights in them. Righteousness means: living right before God.

Paul takes this up: "He who boasts, let him boast in the Lord" (1 Corinthians 1:31).

Verses 25–26: Many nations at that time were circumcised, not only Israel. Jeremiah says: The outward sign alone does no good. If someone has an "uncircumcised heart," that is, a heart that is closed to God, the sign on the body does not help them either. This applies to all nations and also to Israel. Cutting the hair at the sides of the head was a hairstyle of certain Arab tribes.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 10

The LORD is the true God

Idols can do nothing VERSES 1–16

1 Hear the word which the LORD speaks to you, house of Israel!
2 The LORD says,
"Don't learn the way of the nations,
and don't be terrified by the signs in the sky,
even though the nations are terrified by them.
3 For the customs of the peoples are worthless.
Someone cuts down a tree in the forest,
and a craftsman works it with his ax.
4 They decorate it with silver and with gold.
They fasten it with nails and with hammers,
so that it can't fall over.
5 They are like a palm tree made on a lathe, and they don't speak.
They must be carried, because they can't walk.
Don't be afraid of them,
for they can't do harm,
and they can't do good either."
6 There is no one like you, LORD.
You are great,

and your name is great in power.
7 Who would not fear you, King of the nations?
For you deserve it.
Among all the wise men of the nations,
and in all their kingdoms,
there is no one like you.
8 But they are all stupid and foolish.
What they learn from idols is worthless.
It is just wood.
9 Silver is beaten into thin plates and brought from Tarshish,
and gold from Uphaz.
It is the work of the carver and of the goldsmith's hands.
Their clothing is blue and purple.
They are all the work of skillful men.
10 But the LORD is the true God.
He is the living God, and a King forever.
When he is angry, the earth shakes.
The nations can't stand up to his fury.
11 "Say this to them:
'The gods that have not made the heavens and the earth
will disappear from the earth, and from under the heavens.'"
12 God has made the earth by his power.
He has set the world in place by his wisdom.
By his understanding he has stretched out the heavens.
13 When he speaks, the waters in the heavens roar.
He makes the clouds rise from the ends of the earth.
He makes lightning for the rain,
and brings the wind out of his storehouses.
14 Every person has become stupid and without knowledge.
Every goldsmith is put to shame by his carved image,
for his cast image is a lie,
and there is no breath in them.
15 They are worthless, a work of deception.
In the time of their punishment they will be destroyed.
16 The portion of Jacob is not like these,
for he is the maker of all things,
and Israel is the tribe of his inheritance.
The LORD of Armies is his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: The Babylonians interpreted the stars and were afraid of signs in the sky like eclipses of the sun. God says: Don't be afraid of them! I made the stars.

Verses 3–5: Again mockery of the idols: A tree is cut down, carved, covered with gold and nailed down so that it does not fall over. It cannot speak and cannot walk. Other translations here compare the idol to a scarecrow in a cucumber field. "Don't be afraid of them, for they can't do harm, and they can't do good either."

Verses 6–7: A song of praise: "There is no one like you, LORD."

Verse 10: "The LORD is the true God. He is the living God." That is the opposite of the dead idols.

Verse 11: This verse is written in Aramaic, not in Hebrew. Aramaic was the language that people understood at that time in Babylon and throughout the Near East. Probably the exiles were meant to be able to say this sentence to the Babylonians in their own language.

Verses 12–13: God is the Creator. He makes rain, lightning and wind.

Verse 16: Israel's "portion," that is, its treasure, is God himself, the Creator of everything.

My wound is serious VERSES 17–25

17 Gather up your belongings from the land,
you who live under siege.
18 For the LORD says,
"Look, at this time I will throw out
the people who live in the land, as with a sling.
I will bring distress on them,
so that they may feel it."
19 How terrible for me because of my injury!
My wound is serious.
But I said, "Truly, this is my suffering,
and I must bear it."
20 My tent is destroyed,
and all my ropes are broken.
My children have gone away from me,
and they are no more.
There is no one left to put up my tent again,
or to hang up my curtains.
21 For the shepherds have become stupid,
and have not asked the LORD for advice.
That is why they have not succeeded,
and all their flocks are scattered.
22 Listen, the news is coming:
a great noise from the land of the north,
to make the cities of Judah a waste,
a place where jackals live.
23 LORD, I know that a person's way is not in his own power.
It is not up to the one who walks to direct his steps.
24 LORD, correct me, but gently,
not in your anger,
or you will make me nothing.
25 Pour out your anger on the nations that don't know you,
and on the families that don't call on your name.
For they have eaten up Jacob.
Yes, they have eaten him up and destroyed him,
and have ruined his home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: Pack your things! The exile is coming.

Verses 19–20: Jerusalem speaks like a mother whose tent is destroyed and whose children are gone. "Truly, this is my suffering, and I must bear it."

Verse 21: The "shepherds," the leaders of the people, did not ask God for advice. That is why the flock is scattered.

Verse 23 is a well-known verse: "It is not up to the one who walks to direct his steps." We do not have our life completely under control. We depend on God.

Verse 24: A humble prayer: God, correct me, but gently, not in anger.

Verse 25: A prayer that God's anger may hit the nations that destroyed Israel. This is a cry of the oppressed for justice, as in some psalms (Psalm 79:6–7). It is addressed to God and

leaves the judgment to him. It is not permission to do violence to other nations.

JEREMIAH

Chapter 11

The broken covenant

Hear the words of this covenant VERSES 1–17

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 "Hear the words of this covenant,
and speak to the men of Judah and to the people of Jerusalem.
3 Say to them, The LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'Cursed is the man who doesn't listen to the words of this covenant,
4 which I commanded your ancestors on the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt,
out of the iron furnace.'
I said, 'Obey my voice,
and do everything that I command you.
So you will be my people,
and I will be your God.
5 Then I will keep the oath which I swore to your ancestors,
to give them a land flowing with milk and honey,'
as it is today."
Then I answered, "Amen, LORD."
6 The LORD said to me,
"Call out all these words in the cities of Judah,
and in the streets of Jerusalem. Say,
'Hear the words of this covenant, and do them.
7 For I warned your ancestors seriously
on the day that I brought them up out of the land of Egypt,
and until this day I warned them again and again. I said,
"Obey my voice."
8 Yet they didn't obey or pay attention.
Each one followed the stubbornness of his evil heart.
So I brought on them all the words of this covenant,
which I commanded them to do, but they didn't do them.'"
9 The LORD said to me,
"A conspiracy has been found among the men of Judah,
and among the people of Jerusalem.
10 They have turned back to the sins of their ancestors,
who refused to listen to my words.
They have followed other gods to serve them.
The house of Israel and the house of Judah
have broken my covenant which I made with their ancestors.
11 That is why the LORD says,
'Look, I will bring disaster on them,
which they will not be able to escape.
They will cry to me,
but I will not listen to them.
12 Then the cities of Judah and the people of Jerusalem
will go and cry to the gods they burn incense to,
but these will not save them at all in the time of their trouble.
13 For you have as many gods as you have cities, Judah.
And as many streets as Jerusalem has,
so many altars you have set up to the shameful thing,
altars to burn incense to Baal.'
14 "So don't pray for this people.
Don't raise a cry or prayer for them,
for I will not listen when they cry to me because of their trouble.
15 What is my beloved doing in my house,
since she has done shameful things with many?
The holy meat has been taken away from you.
When you do evil, you are happy."
16 The LORD called you by the name
"A green olive tree, beautiful, with good fruit."
With the noise of a great roar he has set it on fire,
and its branches are broken.
17 For the LORD of Armies, who planted you,
has announced disaster against you,
because of the evil of the house of Israel and of the house of Judah,
which they have done to themselves.
They made me angry by burning incense to Baal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–5: God reminds them of the covenant at Sinai. The heart of it is: "Obey my voice ... So you will be my people, and I will be your God." Egypt is called the "iron furnace," a picture of the hard slavery there.

Verse 5: Jeremiah answers with "Amen." "Amen" means: That is true, so be it.

Perhaps this chapter is connected with the reform of King Josiah. At that time a book of the law was found in the temple, and the covenant was renewed (2 Kings 22–23).

Verses 9–10: But the people broke the covenant and turned to other gods again.

Verse 14: Again God says to Jeremiah: Don't pray for this people (as in 7:16). This shows how serious the situation is.

Verse 16: Israel was like a beautiful, green olive tree. Now it is struck by fire. Later, Paul uses the picture of the olive tree for Israel (Romans 11:17–24).

Like a lamb led to the slaughter VERSES 18–23

18 The LORD let me know it, and I knew it.
Then you showed me what they were doing.
19 But I was like a gentle lamb that is led to the slaughter.
I didn't know that they had made plans against me.
They said,
"Let's destroy the tree with its fruit,
and let's cut him off from the land of the living,
so that no one remembers his name anymore."
20 But, LORD of Armies, you judge rightly.
You test the heart and the mind.

Let me see your revenge on them,
for I have put my case in your hands.
21 "That is why the LORD says this about the men of Anathoth,
who want to kill you, and say,
'Don't prophesy in the LORD's name,
or you will die by our hand.'
22 That is why the LORD of Armies says,
'Look, I will punish them.
The young men will die by the sword.
Their sons and their daughters will die by famine.
23 None of them will be left,
for I will bring disaster on the men of Anathoth,
in the year of their punishment.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–19: Jeremiah learns that men from his own home village Anathoth want to kill him, perhaps even relatives (compare 12:6). He suspected nothing, like a lamb that is led to the slaughter. This picture is a reminder of the servant of God in Isaiah 53:7.

Verse 20: Jeremiah does not take revenge himself. He hands his case over to God, who judges rightly and sees into the heart. He asks God for justice. This is an important difference: He does not take revenge into his own hands.

Verses 21–23: God announces the judgment on the men of Anathoth.

If you are threatened by people who are close to you, get help: In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JEREMIAH

Chapter 12

Why do the wicked do so well?

Jeremiah argues with God VERSES 1–6

1 You are righteous, LORD,
when I argue with you.
Yet I want to bring my case to you:
Why does the way of the wicked succeed?
Why do all who are very unfaithful live in comfort?
2 You have planted them.
Yes, they have taken root.
They grow.
Yes, they produce fruit.
You are near in their mouth,
but far from their heart.
3 But you, LORD, know me.
You see me, and test how my heart is toward you.
Drag them away like sheep to be slaughtered,
and set them apart for the day of slaughter.
4 How long will the land mourn,
and the plants of the whole country wither?
Because of the evil of those who live in it,
the animals and birds are swept away,
because the people said, "He won't see what happens to us in the end."
5 "If you have run with men on foot,
and they have tired you out,
then how can you race against horses?
If you feel safe in a land of peace,
then what will you do in the thick forest of the Jordan?
6 For even your brothers,
and the family of your father,
even they have been unfaithful to you!
Even they have shouted loudly after you!
Don't believe them,
even though they speak beautiful words to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Jeremiah asks a question that people still ask today: Why do evil people do so well? They talk piously, but their heart is far away from God. And still they are successful. Job and Psalm 73 also ask this question.

Verse 1: Jeremiah begins with "You are righteous," and yet he argues with God. Faith and honest questions belong together.

Verse 3: Jeremiah is so hurt that he asks God to punish the evil people. He expresses his anger openly before God, but he does not act himself.

Verse 5: God's answer is surprising: He does not explain anything, but says: It is going to get even harder! If you get tired running with people on foot, how will you keep up with horses? The "thick forest of the Jordan" was a dangerous jungle full of lions.

Verse 6: Even Jeremiah's own family betrayed him. An especially painful experience.

God laments over his inheritance VERSES 7–13

7 "I have left my house.
I have abandoned my inheritance.
I have given the beloved of my soul
into the hands of her enemies.
8 My inheritance has become to me like a lion in the forest.
She has roared against me.
That is why I have hated her.
9 Is my inheritance to me like a speckled bird of prey?
Are the birds of prey against her all around?
Go, gather all the wild animals.
Bring them to eat.
10 Many shepherds have destroyed my vineyard.
They have trampled my portion under their feet.
They have made my pleasant portion a ruined wilderness.
11 They have made it a ruin.
It lies ruined and mourns before me.
The whole land is ruined,
because no one cares.
12 Destroyers have come on all the bare hilltops in the wilderness,

for the sword of the LORD eats up the land from one
end to the other end.
No one has peace.
13 They have sown wheat, and have harvested thorns.
They have worn themselves out, and gained nothing.
You will be ashamed of your harvest,
because of the LORD's fierce anger."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here God himself speaks, and you can feel his pain: "I have given the beloved of my soul into the hands of her enemies." God does not do this gladly. It hurts him like someone who has lost their love.

Verse 8: "That is why I have hated her" is the language of hurt love. The people have turned against God like a roaring lion.

Verses 10–11: The "shepherds" here are the enemy commanders who destroy the land. And no one cares.

Verse 13: They sow wheat and harvest thorns. All their work is for nothing.

There is hope for the neighboring nations too VERSES 14–17

14 The LORD says,
"About all my evil neighbors,
who attack the inheritance which I gave my people
Israel:
Look, I will pull them up out of their land,
and I will pull up the house of Judah from among
them.
15 After I have pulled them up,
I will turn back and have compassion on them.
I will bring them back again,
each one to his inheritance,
and each one to his land.
16 And if they will carefully learn the ways of my people,
to swear by my name, 'As surely as the LORD lives,'
just as they taught my people to swear by Baal,
then they will be built up among my people.
17 But if they will not listen,
then I will pull up that nation,
pull it up and destroy it," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: The neighboring nations that attacked Israel will themselves be pulled out of their land.

Verse 15: But then the surprise: God will also have compassion on them and bring them back to their land! God's mercy is not only for Israel.

Verse 16: If the other nations learn to honor the true God, they will get a place among God's people. The door is open to everyone.

Here the words from Jeremiah's call come back: "pull up" and "build" (1:10).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 13

The ruined belt

An acted-out sign with a belt VERSES 1–11

1 The LORD said to me,
"Go and buy yourself a linen belt.
Put it around your waist,
and don't put it in water."
2 So I bought a belt, as the LORD had said,
and put it around my waist.
3 The LORD's word came to me a second time. He said,
4 "Take the belt that you have bought, which is around
your waist.
Get up, go to the Euphrates,
and hide it there in a crack in the rock."
5 So I went and hid it by the Euphrates,
as the LORD commanded me.
6 After many days, the LORD said to me,
"Get up, go to the Euphrates,
and take from there the belt which I commanded you
to hide there."
7 Then I went to the Euphrates and dug.
I took the belt from the place where I had hidden it.
And look, the belt was ruined.
It was good for nothing.
8 Then the LORD's word came to me. He said,
9 "The LORD says,
'In the same way I will ruin the pride of Judah,
and the great pride of Jerusalem.
10 This evil people refuse to listen to my words.
They follow the stubbornness of their heart.
They have followed other gods to serve them and to
worship them.
They will be like this belt,
which is good for nothing.
11 For as the belt clings to a man's waist,
so I made the whole house of Israel and the whole
house of Judah cling to me,' says the LORD,
'so that they would be my people,
and bring me fame, praise, and glory.
But they would not listen.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah carries out an "acted-out sign": He acts out God's message so that people see it and do not only hear it.

He wears a new linen belt, then hides it by the Euphrates. When he gets it again, it has rotted. (Some interpreters think that instead of the far-away Euphrates, a place called Parah near Anathoth is meant. In Hebrew both names sound the same.)

Verse 11: The meaning: Israel was as closely connected to God as a belt is to the body. At that time, a belt was a beautiful, important piece of clothing. But through idol worship, the people have "rotted." The Euphrates points to Babylon: That is where the people will be in exile.

The wine jars VERSES 12–14

12 "So speak this word to them:
'The LORD, the God of Israel, says,

"Every jar should be filled with wine."'
They will say to you,
'Don't we know very well that every jar should be filled with wine?'
13 Then tell them, 'The LORD says,
"Look, I will fill all the people who live in this land with drunkenness:
the kings who sit on David's throne,
the priests, the prophets,
and all the people of Jerusalem.
14 I will smash them against each other,
the fathers and the sons together," says the LORD.
"I will not pity them, or spare them, or have compassion on them.
Nothing will keep me from destroying them."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah says something that sounds like a drinking toast: "Every jar should be filled with wine." The people answer: "Yes, of course, we know that!"

But Jeremiah means it differently: The people themselves are like jars. They will be made "drunk," that is: confused and without direction. Then they will smash each other like jars that bump into each other. A picture of quarreling and chaos that destroys a people from the inside.

Give God glory before it gets dark VERSES 15–27

15 Listen, and pay attention.
Don't be proud, for the LORD has spoken.
16 Give glory to the LORD your God,
before he brings darkness,
and before your feet stumble on the dark mountains.
While you are looking for light,
he will turn it into the shadow of death,
and make it deep darkness.
17 But if you will not listen,
I will weep in secret because of your pride.
My eyes will weep bitterly and run with tears,
because the LORD's flock has been taken captive.
18 Say to the king and to the queen mother,
"Make yourselves low.
Sit down,
for your crowns have fallen from your heads,
your beautiful crowns.
19 The cities of the South are shut up,
and there is no one to open them.
Judah is carried away as captives, all of it.
They are completely carried away as captives.
20 Lift up your eyes,
and look at those who come from the north.
Where is the flock that was given to you,
your beautiful flock?
21 What will you say when he puts over you as rulers
those you yourself taught to be your friends?
Won't pains seize you,
like a woman in labor?
22 And if you say in your heart,
"Why have these things happened to me?"
It is because your sins are so great
that your skirts are lifted up,
and your heels suffer violence.
23 Can the Ethiopian change his skin,
or the leopard its spots?
Then you could also do good,
you who are used to doing evil.
24 "So I will scatter them like straw
that is blown away by the desert wind.
25 This is your lot,
the share I have measured out to you," says the LORD,
"because you have forgotten me,
and trusted in lies."
26 So I will also lift your skirts up over your face,
and your shame will be seen.
27 I have seen your disgusting deeds,
your adulteries and your neighing,
your shameful prostitution
on the hills in the fields.
How terrible for you, Jerusalem!
You will not be made clean.
How much longer will it be?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Give God glory while it is still light! Like a hiker who has to get down from the mountains before it gets dark.

Verse 17: Jeremiah will weep in secret if the people do not listen. He is not a prophet who is glad when others suffer.

Verse 18: The king is probably Jehoiachin, the queen mother is his mother Nehushta. Both were carried off to Babylon in 597 BC (2 Kings 24:8–15).

Verse 21: Judah had earlier looked to Babylon as an ally. Now Babylon becomes the ruler over Judah.

Verses 22 and 26: Jerusalem is pictured as a woman who is publicly put to shame. This is how people at that time spoke about the humiliation of a conquered city. These pictures are a picture for a city, not a justification for putting women to shame or doing violence to them. If you experience violence: Domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 23: "Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard its spots?" The Hebrew word here is "Cushite." The WEB, our English source text, has "Ethiopian."

Cush lay south of Egypt, and the people there had dark skin. All that is meant is: Something that is deeply rooted is not easy to change. The people are so used to evil that they can no longer change themselves. The verse says nothing bad about dark skin. In other places, the Bible speaks very respectfully of people from Cush, for example of Ebedmelech, who saves Jeremiah's life (Chapter 38).

Verse 27: "How much longer will it be?" God is still waiting for his people to become clean.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 14

The great drought

No rain in the land VERSES 1–6

1 This is the LORD's word that came to Jeremiah about
the drought:
2 "Judah mourns,
and its gates are weak.
They sit in black on the ground.
The cry of Jerusalem goes up.
3 Their important people send their servants for water.
They come to the cisterns and find no water.
They come back with empty jars.
They are disappointed and ashamed,
and they cover their heads.
4 Because the ground is cracked,
because there has been no rain in the land,
the farmers are disappointed.
They cover their heads.
5 Yes, even the doe in the field gives birth
and leaves her young,
because there is no grass.
6 The wild donkeys stand on the bare hilltops.
They gasp for air like jackals.
Their eyes grow dim,
because there are no plants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A terrible drought hits the land. Jeremiah describes it exactly:

Verse 3: The servants find no water in the cisterns and come back with empty jars.

Verse 4: The ground is cracked; the farmers cannot sow anything.

Verses 5–6: Even the animals suffer: A doe leaves her newborn because she cannot find food. Wild donkeys gasp for air.

Today too, many people and animals suffer from droughts. The Bible takes this suffering seriously.

A prayer in distress VERSES 7–12

7 Even though our sins speak against us,
act for the sake of your name, LORD.
For we have turned away from you many times.
We have sinned against you.
8 You hope of Israel,
its Savior in the time of trouble,
why are you like a foreigner in the land,
and like a traveler who stops only to stay for a night?
9 Why are you like a man who is taken by surprise,
like a warrior who can't save?
Yet you, LORD, are among us,
and we are called by your name.
Don't leave us.
10 The LORD says this about this people:
"They have loved to wander like this.
They have not held back their feet.
That is why the LORD does not accept them.
Now he will remember their guilt,
and punish them for their sins."
11 The LORD said to me,
"Don't pray for the good of this people.
12 When they fast, I will not listen to their cry.
When they offer burnt offerings and grain offerings, I
will not accept them.
Instead, I will destroy them by the sword, by famine,
and by disease."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9: A beautiful prayer of the people: "You hope of Israel ... why are you like a foreigner in the land, and like a traveler who stops only to stay for a night? ... You, LORD, are among us ... Don't leave us." People can still pray words like these in times of trouble today.

Verses 10–12: But God's answer is hard: The people have gone too far away. Fasting and sacrifices alone do not help now if their life does not change. For the third time God says to Jeremiah: Don't pray for this people.

The false prophets VERSES 13–18

13 Then I said, "Oh, Lord GOD!
Look, the prophets tell them,
'You will not see the sword,
and you will not have famine.
I will give you lasting peace in this place.'"
14 Then the LORD said to me,
"The prophets are prophesying lies in my name.
I didn't send them.
I didn't command them.
I didn't speak to them.
They prophesy to you a false vision,
fortune-telling, worthless things,
and the deceit of their own heart.
15 That is why the LORD says this about the prophets
who prophesy in my name, though I didn't send them,
and who say, 'There will be no sword and famine in this
land':
Those prophets will be destroyed by sword and famine.
16 The people they prophesy to will be thrown out into the
streets of Jerusalem,
because of the famine and the sword.
There will be no one to bury them,
not them, their wives, their sons, or their daughters,
for I will pour out their own evil on them.
17 "Say this word to them:
'Let my eyes run with tears night and day,
and let them not stop.
For the virgin daughter of my people is broken with a
great break,
with a very serious wound.
18 If I go out into the field,
look, there are those killed by the sword!
If I go into the city,
look, there are those sick from hunger!
For both the prophet and the priest wander through
the land,
and they don't know what they are doing.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Jeremiah tries to excuse his people: The false prophets deceived them! They promised peace.

Verse 14: God says: These prophets did not speak on my behalf. They made up their message themselves. It is important to test whether someone really speaks in God's name or only says what people want to hear.

Verses 17–18: Jeremiah weeps day and night. In the field he sees those who were killed, in the city those who are starving. A shocking picture of war.

Don't reject us! VERSES 19–22

19 Have you completely rejected Judah?
Do you hate Zion?
Why have you struck us,
so that there is no healing for us?
We hoped for peace, but nothing good came.
We hoped for a time of healing, but there was terror!
20 LORD, we admit our evil,
and the guilt of our ancestors,
for we have sinned against you.
21 Do not hate us, for the sake of your name.
Do not dishonor the throne of your glory.
Remember, and don't break your covenant with us.
22 Can any of the worthless idols of the nations make it rain?
Or can the sky give showers?
Isn't it you, LORD our God?
So we will hope in you,
for you have made all these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A second prayer, even more urgent than the first.

Verse 20: The people honestly confess their guilt.

Verse 21: They remind God of his own name and of his covenant: God, you promised to be faithful!

Verse 22: A strong confession: None of the idols can make rain. Only you, God. "So we will hope in you." Even in the deepest distress, the people do not give up their hope in God.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 15

Your words became my food

Not even Moses and Samuel could help VERSES 1–9

1 Then the LORD said to me,
"Even if Moses and Samuel stood in front of me,
my heart would not turn toward this people.
Throw them out of my sight,
and let them go away!
2 When they ask you, 'Where should we go?'
then tell them, 'The LORD says:
"Those meant for death, to death.
Those meant for the sword, to the sword.
Those meant for famine, to famine.
Those meant for captivity, to captivity."'
3 "I will send four kinds of destroyers against them," says the LORD:
"the sword to kill,
the dogs to tear apart,
and the birds of the sky and the animals of the earth,
to eat and to destroy.
4 I will make them be tossed back and forth among all the kingdoms of the earth,
because of Manasseh, the son of Hezekiah, king of Judah,
because of what he did in Jerusalem.
5 For who will have pity on you, Jerusalem?
Who will mourn for you?
Who will stop to ask how you are?
6 You have rejected me," says the LORD.
"You have gone backward.
That is why I have stretched out my hand against you and destroyed you.
I am tired of showing compassion.
7 I have separated them with a winnowing fork in the gates of the land.
I have taken their children from them.
I have destroyed my people.
They didn't turn back from their ways.
8 Their widows have become more than the sand of the seas.
At noon I have brought a destroyer against the mother of the young men.
I have made anguish and terror fall on her suddenly.
9 She who had seven children grows weak.
She has breathed her last.
Her sun has gone down while it was still day.
She has been put to shame and disgraced.
Those who are left of them I will hand over to the sword
in front of their enemies," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Moses and Samuel were the great intercessors of Israel. They often prayed for the people, and God heard them (Exodus 32; 1 Samuel 7). But now, God says, not even their prayer would help. That is how bad the situation is.

Verse 4: King Manasseh ruled about 50 years before Jeremiah. He was especially bad: He brought in idol worship and had much innocent blood shed (2 Kings 21). The consequences of his deeds lasted a long time.

Verse 7: A winnowing fork is a farm tool. With it, farmers separated the grain from the chaff.

Verses 8–9: A moving picture: A mother who had seven children loses them all. "Her sun has gone down while it was still day." That is what endless grief feels like.

Important: The text explains Jerusalem's disaster as a consequence of guilt. This does not mean that every person who suffers or loses a child is to blame for it. In other places the Bible clearly rejects this idea (Job; John 9:1–3). If you are grieving, you can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

How terrible for me, my mother, that you gave birth to me! VERSES 10–14

10 How terrible for me, my mother,
that you gave birth to me,
a man everyone fights with,
a man the whole land argues with!
I have not lent money,
and no one has lent money to me.
Yet every one of them curses me.

11 The LORD said,
"I will certainly make you strong for good.
I will certainly make the enemy beg you for help
in the time of disaster and in the time of trouble.
12 Can anyone break iron,
iron from the north, and bronze?
13 I will give away your wealth and your treasures as
plunder, without payment,
because of all your sins,
in all your territory.
14 I will make them go with your enemies
in a land which you don't know,
for a fire has been lit by my anger,
and it will burn against you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Jeremiah is at the end of his strength. He laments: "How terrible for me, my mother, that you gave birth to me." He is a man everyone fights with. He has not lent anyone money or owed anyone money (which often led to quarrels), and yet everyone curses him. He is hated only because he speaks God's word.

Verses 11–12: God comforts him: I will make you strong. The "iron from the north" is Babylon. No one can stop it.

Verses 13–14: These verses are addressed to the people: The treasures will be robbed, and the people will be led into exile.

If you feel like Jeremiah here, so alone and desperate that you wish you had never been born, talk to someone. Help is there day and night: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Your words became my food VERSES 15–21

15 LORD, you know.
Remember me, take care of me,
and pay back those who persecute me.
You are patient, so don't take me away.
Know that I have suffered insults for your sake.
16 Your words were found, and I ate them.
Your words were a joy to me,
and the delight of my heart,
for I am called by your name,
LORD, God of Armies.
17 I didn't sit with the people who celebrate and have fun.
I sat alone because your hand was on me,
for you have filled me with anger.
18 Why does my pain never end,
and why is my wound incurable?
It refuses to be healed.
Will you really be to me like a stream that dries up,
like water that is not there when you need it?
19 That is why the LORD says,
"If you turn back, then I will bring you back,
so that you may stand in front of me.
If you separate what is precious from what is
worthless,
you will be my mouth.
They will turn to you,
but you will not turn to them.
20 I will make you a fortified bronze wall against this
people.
They will fight against you,
but they will not defeat you,
for I am with you to save you and to rescue you," says
the LORD.
21 "I will rescue you out of the hand of the wicked,
and I will free you out of the hand of the cruel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Jeremiah asks God: Remember me! I am suffering for you.

Verse 16 is a beautiful verse: "Your words were found, and I ate them. Your words were a joy to me." God's word was like food for Jeremiah. It filled him and made him happy.

Verse 17: But his calling also makes him lonely. He cannot celebrate happily with the others.

Verse 18: Jeremiah's most bitter accusation: God, are you like a stream that dries up in summer when you need it? Earlier, God had called himself "the spring of living water" (2:13). Now Jeremiah feels abandoned by this spring. The Bible allows such honest words.

Verse 19: God does not answer with pity, but with an invitation: Turn back, Jeremiah! Let go of your despair. Then you can be my mouth again.

Verses 20–21: God repeats the promise from Jeremiah's call (1:18–19): "I am with you to save you and to rescue you."

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 16

Jeremiah's lonely life

Don't marry! VERSES 1–9

1 Then the LORD's word came to me. He said,
2 "You must not take a wife,
and you must not have sons or daughters in this
place."
3 For the LORD says this about the sons and the
daughters who are born in this place,
and about their mothers who gave birth to them,
and about their fathers who fathered them in this
land:
4 "They will die terrible deaths.
No one will mourn for them,
and they will not be buried.
They will be like manure on the surface of the ground.
They will be destroyed by the sword and by famine.
Their dead bodies will be food for the birds of the sky
and for the animals of the earth."
5 For the LORD says,
"Don't go into a house where people are mourning.
Don't go there to mourn,
and don't show them sympathy.
For I have taken my peace away from this people," says

the LORD,
"and my faithful love and my compassion.
6 Both great and small will die in this land.
They will not be buried.
No one will mourn for them,
or cut themselves, or shave their heads for them.
7 No one will break bread for those who mourn,
to comfort them for the dead.
No one will give them the cup of comfort to drink
for their father or for their mother.
8 "You must not go into a house where people are feasting,
to sit with them, to eat and to drink."
9 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Look, before your eyes and in your days,
I will put an end in this place
to the sound of joy and the sound of gladness,
the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah's whole life becomes a message:

Verse 2: He is not to marry or have children. At that time, this was very unusual. Jeremiah's loneliness shows: The time that is coming is so terrible that people should not start a family.

Verses 5–7: He is not to go to funerals or comfort anyone. At that time it was customary to bring bread and a "cup of comfort" to people who were mourning.

Verse 6: At that time some people cut their skin out of grief. The law of Israel forbade this (Leviticus 19:28). If you hurt yourself today out of despair, get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 8–9: He is also not to go to feasts. For soon there will be no more weddings.

Giving all this up was very hard for Jeremiah. It shows how seriously he took his calling.

Why is God doing this? VERSES 10–13

10 When you tell this people all these words,
they will ask you,
'Why has the LORD announced all this great disaster against us?'
or 'What is our guilt?'
or 'What sin have we committed against the LORD our God?'
11 Then tell them,
'Because your ancestors have left me,' says the LORD,
'and have followed other gods,
have served them, have worshiped them,
have left me, and have not kept my law.
12 You have done more evil than your ancestors,
for look, each of you follows the stubbornness of his evil heart,
so that you don't listen to me.
13 That is why I will throw you out of this land
into a land that you have not known,
neither you nor your ancestors.
There you will serve other gods day and night,
for I will show you no kindness.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people ask in surprise: What have we done wrong? They do not even notice their own guilt.

God answers: Your ancestors left me, and you are even worse.

Verse 13: A bitter irony: You wanted to serve foreign gods; now you can do that day and night in a foreign land.

A new exodus VERSES 14–21

14 "So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when people will no longer say,
'As surely as the LORD lives,
who brought the people of Israel up out of the land of Egypt.'
15 Instead they will say,
'As surely as the LORD lives,
who brought the people of Israel up from the land of the north,
and from all the countries where he had driven them.'
I will bring them back into their land that I gave to their ancestors.
16 "Look, I will send for many fishermen," says the LORD,
"and they will catch them like fish.
Afterward I will send for many hunters,
and they will hunt them from every mountain, from every hill,
and out of the cracks in the rocks.
17 For my eyes are on all their ways.
They are not hidden from me.
Their guilt is not hidden from my eyes.
18 First I will pay them back double for their guilt and their sin,
because they have made my land unclean
with the dead bodies of their hateful idols,
and have filled my inheritance with their disgusting things."
19 LORD, my strength, my fortress,
and my refuge in the day of trouble,
the nations will come to you from the ends of the earth,
and will say,
"Our ancestors inherited nothing but lies,
worthless things that do no good.
20 Can a person make gods for himself,
which are not gods at all?"
21 "So look, I will make them know.
This time I will make them know my hand and my power.
Then they will know that my name is the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: In the middle of the message of judgment, a ray of light: God will bring his people back from exile. This freedom will be so great that people will celebrate it even more than the exodus from Egypt.

Verses 16–17: Fishermen and hunters are a picture of judgment here: No one can hide from God. (Later, Jesus calls his disciples "fishers for people," but in a completely different, good sense: Mark 1:17.)

Verses 19–20: A wonderful prayer of Jeremiah: God is his strength and refuge. And he sees ahead: One day all nations

will realize that the idols are nothing, and they will come to God.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 17

Like a tree by the water

Sin is written on the heart VERSES 1–4

1 "The sin of Judah is written with an iron pen,
and with the point of a diamond.
It is carved on the tablet of their heart,
and on the horns of your altars.
2 Even their children remember their altars and their Asherah poles
by the green trees on the high hills.
3 My mountain in the open country,
I will give away your wealth and all your treasures as plunder,
and your high places too,
because of the sin throughout all your territory.
4 You yourself will lose your inheritance
that I gave you.
I will make you serve your enemies
in a land which you don't know,
for you have lit a fire by my anger
which will burn forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Sin is not just on the surface. It is deeply carved, as if with a diamond into stone, on the "tablet of their heart." This is a reminder of the tablets of the law from Sinai. Instead of God's commandments, sin is written in the heart. (In Jeremiah 31:33 God promises to write his law on the heart in a new way.)

Verse 2: Even the children know the idol altars. The Asherah poles were wooden poles for the goddess Asherah.

Cursed and blessed VERSES 5–11

5 The LORD says:
"Cursed is the man who trusts in human beings,
who relies on human strength,
and whose heart turns away from the LORD.
6 For he will be like a bush in the desert.
He will not see it when good comes.
He will live in the dry places in the wilderness,
in a salty land where no one lives.
7 "Blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD,
and whose confidence is in the LORD.
8 For he will be like a tree planted by the water,
that spreads out its roots by the stream.
It will not be afraid when heat comes.
Its leaves will stay green.
It will not worry in the year of drought.
It will not stop producing fruit.
9 The heart is deceitful above all things,
and it is very sick.
Who can understand it?
10 "I, the LORD, search the mind.
I test the heart,
to give each person what his ways deserve,
what the fruit of his deeds deserves."
11 Like the partridge that sits on eggs which she has not laid,
so is the one who gets rich in the wrong way.
In the middle of his life his riches will leave him.
At his end, he will be a fool.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–8 are among the most beautiful texts in Jeremiah. They are similar to Psalm 1.

Whoever trusts only in people and in their own strength is like a dry bush in the desert.

But whoever trusts in God is like a tree by a stream. Its roots reach down to the water. Even when heat and drought come, its leaves stay green. It always produces fruit.

This does not mean that you may not trust other people. It means: Your deepest support in life should be God, not people or power.

Verse 9: "The heart is deceitful." We humans can deceive ourselves. Often we do not fully know our own heart.

Verse 10: But God knows it. He sees into the depths. Where the WEB, our English source text, says "mind," the Hebrew says "kidneys." At that time, the kidneys were seen as the place of the feelings.

Verse 11: People at that time believed that the partridge sometimes hatches other birds' eggs. When the chicks hatch, they run away. It is the same with riches gained wrongly: They do not stay.

Heal me, LORD! VERSES 12–18

12 A glorious throne, set on high from the beginning,
is the place of our sanctuary.
13 LORD, the hope of Israel,
all who leave you will be put to shame.
Those who turn away from me will be written in the dust,
because they have left the LORD,
the spring of living water.
14 Heal me, LORD, and I will be healed.
Save me, and I will be saved,
for you are the one I praise.
15 Look, they ask me,
"Where is the LORD's word?
Let it come true now!"
16 As for me, I have not run away from being a shepherd who follows you.
I haven't wanted the day of disaster.
You know it.
What came out of my lips was in front of you.
17 Don't be a terror to me.
You are my refuge in the day of disaster.

18 Let those who persecute me be put to shame,
but don't let me be put to shame.
Let them be terrified,
but don't let me be terrified.
Bring on them the day of disaster,
and destroy them with double destruction.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Whoever leaves God will be "written in the dust," that is, quickly forgotten, like writing in the sand. Once Jesus wrote with his finger in the dust when people wanted to stone a woman (John 8:6–8). Some interpreters see this as a reference to this verse.

Verse 14: A prayer that many people pray in sickness and trouble: "Heal me, LORD, and I will be healed. Save me, and I will be saved."

Verse 15: The people mock: Where is the disaster you keep announcing?

Verse 16: Jeremiah says: I did not wish for the disaster. I only said what God told me to say.

Verse 18: Jeremiah asks God to punish his persecutors. He is hurt and angry and says so openly in prayer. But he leaves it to God and does not take revenge into his own hands.

Keep the Sabbath holy VERSES 19–27

19 The LORD said this to me:
"Go and stand in the People's Gate,
through which the kings of Judah come in and go out,
and in all the gates of Jerusalem.
20 Tell them, 'Hear the LORD's word,
you kings of Judah, all Judah,
and all the people of Jerusalem
who come in through these gates.
21 The LORD says,
"Be careful,
and carry no load on the Sabbath day,
and don't bring it in through the gates of Jerusalem.
22 Don't carry a load out of your houses on the Sabbath day.
Don't do any work,
but keep the Sabbath day holy,
as I commanded your ancestors.
23 But they didn't listen or pay attention.
They made their necks stiff,
so that they would not hear
and would not accept correction.
24 If you really listen to me," says the LORD,
"and bring no load through the gates of this city on the Sabbath day,
but keep the Sabbath day holy,
and do no work on it,
25 then kings and princes who sit on David's throne
will come in through the gates of this city,
riding in chariots and on horses,
they and their princes,
the men of Judah and the people of Jerusalem.
And this city will be lived in forever.
26 People will come from the cities of Judah,
and from the places around Jerusalem,
from the land of Benjamin,
from the lowland, from the hill country, and from the South.
They will bring burnt offerings, sacrifices, grain offerings, and incense,
and they will bring thank offerings to the LORD's house.
27 But if you will not listen to me,
to keep the Sabbath day holy,
and not to carry a load and come in through the gates of Jerusalem on the Sabbath day,
then I will set its gates on fire,
and the fire will burn up the palaces of Jerusalem.
It will not be put out."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah is to speak at the city gates about the Sabbath. On the Sabbath, the seventh day of the week, no one was supposed to work. The traders were not supposed to bring goods into the city.

The Sabbath is a gift: a day of rest for everyone, also for male and female servants and for animals (Deuteronomy 5:14). Whoever ignores it shows that money and business are more important to them than God and people.

Verses 24–26: If the people keep the Sabbath, Jerusalem will be lived in forever, and people from all regions will come to the temple.

Verse 27: If not, fire will destroy the city. That happened in the year 587 BC.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 18

At the potter's house

Like clay in the potter's hand VERSES 1–12

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 "Get up, and go down to the potter's house,
and there I will let you hear my words."
3 So I went down to the potter's house.
And look, he was working at the wheel.
4 When the pot that he was making from the clay was spoiled in the potter's hand,
he made it into another pot,
as the potter thought best.
5 Then the LORD's word came to me. He said,
6 "House of Israel, can't I do with you as this potter does?" says the LORD.
"Look, as the clay is in the potter's hand,
so are you in my hand, house of Israel.
7 At one moment I may speak about a nation or a kingdom,
that I will pull it up, break it down, and destroy it.
8 But if that nation I spoke about turns away from its evil,
I will change my mind about the disaster that I planned to do to it.

9 At another moment I may speak about a nation or a
kingdom,
that I will build it and plant it.
10 But if it does what is evil in my eyes,
and does not obey my voice,
then I will change my mind about the good that I said I
would do for it.
11 "So now, speak to the men of Judah and to the people of
Jerusalem. Say,
'The LORD says:
"Look, I am shaping disaster against you,
and making a plan against you.
Now, each of you, turn back from your evil way,
and change your ways and your deeds."'
12 But they say,
'It is no use!
For we will follow our own plans,
and each of us will follow the stubbornness of his evil
heart.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah goes to a potter and watches him at work. When a pot does not turn out well, the potter does not throw the clay away, but makes a new pot out of it.

Verse 6: That is how Israel is in God's hand. God can make something new out of the "spoiled" people.

Verses 7–10: An important thought: God's announcements are not fixed forever. If a nation turns back, God does not bring the disaster he announced (as with Nineveh in the book of Jonah). And if a nation does evil, God takes back his good promise. God responds to what people do. The future is open.

Verse 11: That is why the invitation: Turn back! It is not too late yet.

Verse 12: But the people answer: "It is no use! For we will follow our own plans."

The picture of the potter is comforting: Even if something in our life goes wrong, God can shape something new out of it.

My people have forgotten me VERSES 13–17

13 That is why the LORD says:
"Ask now among the nations,
'Who has heard of such things?'
The virgin Israel has done a very horrible thing.
14 Does the snow of Lebanon ever disappear from the
rocky slopes?
Do the cold waters that flow down from far away ever
dry up?
15 But my people have forgotten me.
They have burned incense to false gods.
They have been made to stumble in their ways,
on the ancient paths,
to walk on side paths,
on a road that is not built up.
16 They make their land a horror,
something people will always hiss at.
Everyone who passes by it will be horrified,
and shake his head.
17 I will scatter them in front of the enemy,
as with an east wind.
I will show them my back, and not my face,
on the day of their disaster."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Nature is faithful: The snow on the mountains of Lebanon stays; the cold mountain streams always flow. But God's people have become unfaithful.

Verse 15: They have left the old, good paths and are walking on bumpy side paths (compare 6:16).

Verse 16: Whoever passes by the destroyed land will shake their head in horror. "Hissing" was an expression of horror at that time.

Verse 17: The east wind is a hot desert wind. God will turn away: "I will show them my back, and not my face."

A plot against Jeremiah VERSES 18–23

18 Then they said,
"Come! Let's make plans against Jeremiah.
For the priest will not run out of teaching,
the wise man will not run out of advice,
and the prophet will not run out of words.
Come, let's attack him with our tongues,
and let's not pay attention to any of his words."
19 Pay attention to me, LORD,
and listen to what those who argue against me are
saying.
20 Should evil be paid back for good?
For they have dug a pit for me.
Remember how I stood in front of you
to speak good for them,
to turn your anger away from them.
21 So hand over their children to famine,
and give them over to the power of the sword.
Let their wives become childless and widows.
Let their men be killed,
and their young men struck down by the sword in
battle.
22 Let a cry be heard from their houses,
when you suddenly bring an army against them.
For they have dug a pit to catch me,
and hidden traps for my feet.
23 Yet, LORD, you know all their plans against me to kill
me.
Don't forgive their guilt.
Don't wipe out their sin from your sight.
Let them be thrown down in front of you.
Deal with them in the time of your anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: Jeremiah's opponents say: We don't need him. We have our priests, wise men and prophets. Let's finish him off with words, by slander.

Verse 20: Jeremiah is deeply hurt. He even prayed for these people, and now they want to kill him.

Verses 21–23: Jeremiah prays a harsh prayer of cursing against his enemies and their families. These words are frightening. They show how desperate and hurt Jeremiah was. The Bible does not hide such feelings. It shows a person who brings all his anger before God, instead of using violence himself.

Important: These words are not an instruction to wish evil on others or to do evil to them. Jesus showed another way: "Love your enemies ... And pray for those who treat you badly and persecute you" (Matthew 5:44). On the cross he prayed: "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

If you are bullied or threatened by others, you may get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JEREMIAH

Chapter 19

The broken jar

A message in the valley of the son of Hinnom VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD said,
"Go and buy a clay jar from a potter.
Take some of the elders of the people
and some of the elders of the priests with you.
2 Go out to the valley of the son of Hinnom,
which is by the entrance of the Harsith Gate,
and call out there the words that I will tell you.
3 Say, 'Hear the LORD's word, kings of Judah and people
of Jerusalem:
The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
"Look, I will bring such a disaster on this place
that the ears of everyone who hears about it will ring.
4 For they have left me,
and have made this place unclean.
They have burned incense in it to other gods that they
didn't know:
they, their ancestors, and the kings of Judah.
They have filled this place with the blood of innocent
people.
5 They have built the high places of Baal,
to burn their children in the fire as burnt offerings to
Baal.
I didn't command it, and I didn't speak of it,
and it didn't even come into my mind.
6 So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when this place will no longer be called 'Topheth,'
or 'The valley of the son of Hinnom,'
but 'The valley of Slaughter.'
7 "'"In this place I will make the plans of Judah and
Jerusalem empty.
I will make them fall by the sword in front of their
enemies,
and by the hand of those who want to kill them.
I will give their dead bodies as food
to the birds of the sky and to the animals of the earth.
8 I will make this city a horror,
something people hiss at.
Everyone who passes by it will be horrified,
and hiss because of all its wounds.
9 I will make them eat the flesh of their sons
and the flesh of their daughters.
Each one will eat the flesh of his friend,
during the siege and in the distress
that their enemies and those who want to kill them
will bring on them."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah goes with the elders into the valley of the son of Hinnom. Children were sacrificed there (compare 7:31). God says very clearly again: I never wanted that, "it didn't even come into my mind." Killing or tormenting children is a terrible crime.

Verse 3: The news will be so terrible that people's "ears will ring."

Verse 9: A dreadful picture: In a long siege, hunger becomes so great that people in their despair even eat human flesh. Such things really did happen in sieges (compare Lamentations 4:10). Jeremiah does not describe this because God wants it, but to show where the people's path leads.

The jar is broken VERSES 10–15

10 "Then break the jar
in front of the men who go with you,
11 and tell them, 'The LORD of Armies says:
"In the same way I will break this people and this city,
as someone breaks a potter's jar,
which can't be made whole again.
They will bury the dead in Topheth,
until there is no room left to bury.
12 This is what I will do to this place," says the LORD,
"and to the people who live in it.
I will make this city like Topheth.
13 The houses of Jerusalem and the houses of the kings of
Judah
will be unclean like the place of Topheth:
all the houses on whose roofs they have burned
incense to all the stars of the sky,
and have poured out drink offerings to other gods."'"
14 Then Jeremiah came back from Topheth,
where the LORD had sent him to prophesy.
He stood in the courtyard of the LORD's house,
and said to all the people:
15 "The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
'Look, I will bring on this city and on all its towns
all the disaster that I have announced against it,
because they have made their necks stiff,
so that they will not hear my words.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again an acted-out sign: Jeremiah breaks a clay jar in front of the elders.

In the chapter before (Chapter 18), the clay was still soft, and the potter could shape it again. Now the jar has been fired and is hard. When it breaks, it cannot be made whole again. This shows: The people have refused to listen for so long that the judgment is now unavoidable.

Verse 13: On the flat roofs of the houses, people worshiped the stars as gods.

Verses 14–15: Jeremiah repeats the message in the temple in front of all the people. This has consequences, as the next chapter shows.

Chapter 20

Like a burning fire

Jeremiah in the stocks VERSES 1–6

1 Now Pashhur, the son of Immer, the priest,
who was the chief officer in the LORD's house,
heard Jeremiah prophesying these things.
2 Then Pashhur struck Jeremiah the prophet,
and put him in the stocks that were in the upper
Benjamin Gate,
which was in the LORD's house.
3 The next day, Pashhur let Jeremiah out of the stocks.
Then Jeremiah said to him,
"The LORD has not called your name Pashhur,
but Magormissabib.
4 For the LORD says,
'Look, I will make you a terror to yourself and to all
your friends.
They will fall by the sword of their enemies,
and your eyes will see it.
I will give all Judah into the hand of the king of
Babylon.
He will carry them away as captives to Babylon,
and will kill them with the sword.
5 I will also give all the wealth of this city,
all it has worked for, and all its precious things,
yes, all the treasures of the kings of Judah,
into the hand of their enemies.
They will rob them, take them, and carry them to
Babylon.
6 You, Pashhur, and everyone who lives in your house
will go into captivity.
You will come to Babylon,
and there you will die,
and there you will be buried,
you and all your friends,
to whom you have prophesied lies.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Pashhur, a high priest in the temple, has Jeremiah beaten and put in the "stocks" for a night. That was a wooden frame in which feet, hands or the neck were locked. It was painful and humiliating, and everyone could see the prisoner.

Verse 3: Jeremiah gives Pashhur a new name: "Magormissabib," which means "Terror on every side." Pashhur himself will experience what he did to Jeremiah.

Verse 6: Pashhur had acted as a prophet himself and told lies, probably that everything would be fine.

Here Babylon is named openly as the enemy for the first time.

Jeremiah's lament: You persuaded me VERSES 7–13

7 LORD, you persuaded me,
and I let myself be persuaded.
You are stronger than I am,
and you have won.
I have become a joke all day long.
Everyone mocks me.
8 For every time I speak, I cry out.
I shout, "Violence and destruction!"
For the LORD's word has brought me insults
and mockery all day long.
9 If I say, "I will not mention him,
or speak anymore in his name,"
then there is something in my heart like a burning
fire,
shut up in my bones.
I am tired of holding it in.
I can't.
10 For I have heard many people whispering:
"Terror on every side!
Report him, and we will report him!"
All my close friends say this,
those who watch for me to fall.
"Perhaps he will be tricked,
and we will win against him,
and we will take our revenge on him."
11 But the LORD is with me like a mighty warrior who
inspires fear.
That is why those who persecute me will stumble,
and they won't win.
They will be completely put to shame,
because they have not acted wisely.
Their disgrace will last forever.
It will never be forgotten.
12 But LORD of Armies, you test the righteous.
You see the heart and the mind.
Let me see your revenge on them,
for I have put my case in your hands.
13 Sing to the LORD!
Praise the LORD,
for he has rescued the life of the needy
from the hand of evil people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most honest and moving laments in the Bible.

Verse 7: Jeremiah accuses God: You persuaded me to become a prophet. You were stronger than I was. And now everyone laughs at me.

Verse 8: His message is always just "Violence and destruction!" He has no good news, and that is why he is mocked.

Verse 9 is famous: Jeremiah wants to stop speaking God's word. But he cannot. It burns inside him like a fire shut up in his bones. God's word does not let him go.

Verse 10: Even his friends are waiting for him to make a mistake. They mock him with his own words: "Terror on every side!"

Verses 11–13: And then suddenly a turn: "The LORD is with me like a mighty warrior." Jeremiah trusts again and even sings a song of praise. God rescues the poor.

Cursed is the day I was born VERSES 14–18

14 Cursed is the day on which I was born.
Don't let the day on which my mother gave birth to me

be blessed.
15 Cursed is the man who brought the news to my father,
and said, "A son is born to you,"
and made him very glad.
16 Let that man be like the cities
which the LORD destroyed without changing his mind.
Let him hear a cry in the morning,
and shouting at noon,
17 because he didn't kill me before I was born.
Then my mother would have been my grave,
and her womb would have stayed pregnant forever.
18 Why did I come out of the womb
to see trouble and sorrow,
so that my days are used up in shame?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after the song of praise, Jeremiah falls back into the deepest despair. He curses the day of his birth. He wishes he had never been born.

This shows what it is like for people in a crisis: Hope and despair take turns, sometimes very quickly. Job also lamented like this (Job 3).

The Bible does not hide such feelings. It shows: Even a great prophet, a man of God, can be this desperate. And God does not let him fall. After this lament, Jeremiah lived and worked for many more years.

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JEREMIAH

Chapter 21

The way of life and the way of death

King Zedekiah asks Jeremiah VERSES 1–7

1 This is the word which came to Jeremiah from the LORD,
when King Zedekiah sent Pashhur, the son of Malchijah,
and Zephaniah, the son of Maaseiah, the priest, to him. They said,
2 "Please ask the LORD for us,
for Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, is making war against us.
Perhaps the LORD will do for us one of all his wonderful works,
so that he goes away from us."
3 Then Jeremiah said to them, "Tell Zedekiah:
4 'The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
"Look, I will turn back the weapons of war that are in your hands,
with which you fight against the king of Babylon,
and against the Chaldeans who are besieging you outside the walls.
I will gather them into the middle of this city.
5 I myself will fight against you
with an outstretched hand and with a strong arm,
in anger, in fury, and in great rage.
6 I will strike the people who live in this city,
both people and animals.
They will die of a terrible disease.
7 Afterward," says the LORD,
"I will hand over Zedekiah, king of Judah, his servants, and the people,
those who are left in this city after the disease, the sword, and the famine,
into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
into the hand of their enemies,
and into the hand of those who want to kill them.
He will strike them with the edge of the sword.
He will not spare them, or pity them, or have mercy on them."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the story jumps forward about 20 years: It is the time of the last siege of Jerusalem (588–587 BC). Zedekiah is the last king of Judah.

This Pashhur is a different man from the Pashhur in chapter 20.

Verse 2: Zedekiah hopes for a miracle, as back then, when God saved Jerusalem from the Assyrians (2 Kings 19).

Verses 4–7: But Jeremiah's answer is hard: This time God will not help. The city will fall.

Choose between life and death VERSES 8–10

8 "Say to this people,
'The LORD says:
"Look, I set before you the way of life and the way of death.
9 Whoever stays in this city will die by the sword, by famine, and by disease.
But whoever goes out and surrenders to the Chaldeans who are besieging you will live.
He will escape with his life.
10 For I have set my face against this city for disaster, and not for good," says the LORD.
"It will be handed over to the king of Babylon,
and he will burn it with fire."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "Look, I set before you the way of life and the way of death." This is a reminder of Moses (Deuteronomy 30:15–19). But here it is very concrete.

Verse 9: Jeremiah's advice is shocking: Whoever wants to live should surrender to the enemy. To many people this sounded like treason. But Jeremiah wanted to save lives. He saw that resistance would only bring even more deaths.

"He will escape with his life" means: He will lose everything, but he will get away alive.

A word to the royal house VERSES 11–14

11 "To the house of the king of Judah: Hear the LORD's
word!
12 House of David, the LORD says,
'Do justice in the morning,
and rescue the one who has been robbed
out of the hand of the oppressor.
Otherwise my anger will go out like fire,
and burn so that no one can put it out,
because of the evil of your deeds.
13 Look, I am against you, you who live in the valley,
on the rock of the plain,' says the LORD.
'You say, "Who could come down against us?"
or, "Who could get into our homes?"
14 I will punish you as the fruit of your deeds deserves,'
says the LORD.
'I will set her forest on fire,
and it will burn up everything around her.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The most important task of a king: to make sure there is justice every morning and to protect those who have been robbed from the oppressors. This still applies today to everyone who has power.

Verse 13: Jerusalem felt safe on its rocks and hills. The people said: "Who could come down against us?" But God says: This false security will not protect you.

Verse 14: The "forest" is probably the royal palace, which was built with a lot of cedar wood (it was called the "House of the Forest of Lebanon," 1 Kings 7:2).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 22

Words to the kings of Judah

Do justice and righteousness VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD said,
"Go down to the house of the king of Judah,
and speak this word there:
2 'Hear the LORD's word, king of Judah,
who sits on David's throne,
you, your servants, and your people who come in
through these gates.
3 The LORD says:
"Do justice and righteousness.
Rescue the one who has been robbed out of the hand of
the oppressor.
Do no wrong.
Do no violence to the foreigner, the orphan, or the
widow.
Don't shed innocent blood in this place.
4 For if you really do this,
then kings who sit on David's throne
will come in through the gates of this house,
riding in chariots and on horses,
they, their servants, and their people.
5 But if you will not listen to these words,
I swear by myself," says the LORD,
"that this house will become a ruin."'"
6 For the LORD says this about the house of the king of
Judah:
"You are like Gilead to me,
like the top of Lebanon.
Yet I will surely make you a wilderness,
cities where no one lives.
7 I will get destroyers ready against you,
each with his weapons.
They will cut down your best cedars,
and throw them into the fire.
8 "Many nations will pass by this city,
and each will ask his neighbor,
'Why has the LORD done this to this great city?'
9 Then they will answer,
'Because they abandoned the covenant of the LORD
their God,
and worshiped other gods and served them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah goes straight into the royal palace and tells the king what God expects of him.

Verse 3: This is the program for every good ruler: do justice and righteousness, protect those who have been robbed, do not oppress foreigners, orphans and widows, do not shed innocent blood. These groups had no protection at that time. God takes their side.

Verses 6–7: The palace was built of cedar wood and was as magnificent as the forests of Gilead and Lebanon. But the enemies will burn it.

Verses 8–9: Foreigners will ask: Why is this great city destroyed? The answer: Because they abandoned God's covenant.

Weep for the one who goes away VERSES 10–12

10 Don't weep for the dead.
Don't mourn for him.
But weep bitterly for the one who goes away,
for he will never come back
and see the country where he was born.
11 For the LORD says this about Shallum, the son of
Josiah, king of Judah,
who became king in the place of his father Josiah,
and who went away from this place:
"He won't come back here anymore.
12 He will die in the place where they have taken him as a
captive.
He will never see this land again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "dead" one is the good King Josiah, who fell in a battle against Egypt in 609 BC. The whole people mourned for him.

Shallum is another name for King Jehoahaz, his son. He ruled for only three months. Then Pharaoh took him prisoner and brought him to Egypt, where he died (2 Kings 23:31–34).

Jeremiah says: Weep more for the one who has to go into a foreign land alive and never comes back. Life in exile is worse than death.

How terrible for the one who builds by injustice

VERSES 13–19

13 "How terrible for him who builds his house by unrighteousness,
and his upper rooms by injustice,
who makes his neighbor work for nothing,
and doesn't give him his wages.
14 He says, 'I will build myself a big house
with large upper rooms.'
He cuts out windows for it,
covers it with cedar,
and paints it red.
15 "Does it make you a king
to compete with others in cedar?
Didn't your father eat and drink,
and do justice and righteousness?
Then it went well with him.
16 He defended the cause of the poor and needy,
and then it went well.
Isn't this what it means to know me?" says the LORD.
17 "But your eyes and your heart are only on your own gain,
on shedding innocent blood,
on oppression, and on violence."
18 That is why the LORD says this about Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah:
"They won't mourn for him, saying,
'Oh, my brother!' or, 'Oh, sister!'
They won't mourn for him, saying,
'Oh, lord!' or, 'Oh, his glory!'
19 He will be buried as a donkey is buried:
dragged away and thrown out
outside the gates of Jerusalem."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

King Jehoiakim (609–598 BC) built himself a magnificent palace with cedar wood and red paint. But he made the workers work without wages.

Verse 13: "How terrible for him who … makes his neighbor work for nothing, and doesn't give him his wages." This is one of the clearest sentences in the Bible against exploitation. Fair wages are God's will (compare Deuteronomy 24:14–15; James 5:4).

Verses 15–16: A wonderful thought: Jehoiakim's father Josiah lived well, ate and drank, but he also took care of the poor. And God says: "Isn't this what it means to know me?" Knowing God does not only mean knowing something about God, but acting justly.

Verses 18–19: Jehoiakim will have no one to mourn him and no honorable burial, like a dead donkey that is thrown outside the city.

A lament over Jerusalem and Coniah VERSES 20–30

20 "Go up to Lebanon, and cry out.
Raise your voice in Bashan,
and cry out from Abarim,
for all your lovers have been destroyed.
21 I spoke to you when things were going well for you,
but you said, 'I will not listen.'
This has been your way since your youth:
You didn't obey my voice.
22 The wind will shepherd all your shepherds away,
and your lovers will go into captivity.
Then you will surely be ashamed and disgraced
because of all your evil.
23 You who live in Lebanon,
who make your nest in the cedars,
how much you will be pitied when pains come on you,
pain like that of a woman in labor!
24 "As surely as I live," says the LORD,
"even if Coniah, the son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah,
were the signet ring on my right hand,
I would still pull you off from there.
25 I would give you into the hand of those who want to kill you,
into the hand of those you are afraid of,
into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
and into the hand of the Chaldeans.
26 I will throw you and your mother who gave birth to you
into another country, where you were not born,
and there you will die.
27 But they will not come back to the land
they long to return to."
28 Is this man Coniah a despised, broken pot?
Is he a jar that no one wants?
Why are he and his children thrown out,
and thrown into a land which they don't know?
29 Land, land, land,
hear the LORD's word!
30 The LORD says,
"Write this man down as childless,
a man who will not succeed in his lifetime.
For no man among his descendants will succeed
in sitting on David's throne
and ruling in Judah anymore."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: Lebanon, Bashan and Abarim are mountains in the north and east. Jerusalem is to lament from there, because all its allies ("lovers") have been defeated.

Verse 22: A play on words: The "shepherds" (leaders) will be "shepherded" by the wind, that is, blown away.

Verse 24: Coniah (also called Jehoiachin or Jeconiah) was Jehoiakim's son. He ruled for only three months and was carried off to Babylon with his mother in 597 BC. A signet ring was a very valuable personal possession. Even if Coniah were that valuable to God, God would throw him away.

Verse 28: A sad question: Is he just a broken jar that no one wants anymore?

Verse 30: "Childless" here means: None of his descendants will become king. Coniah actually had children (1 Chronicles 3:17), but none of them sat on David's throne. His grandson Zerubbabel later became governor, but not king. In Haggai 2:23, God again calls Zerubbabel his "signet ring," a sign that God has not completely given up his faithfulness to David's family.

Chapter 23

The LORD is our righteousness

The bad shepherds and the righteous Branch VERSES 1–8

1 "How terrible for the shepherds
who destroy and scatter the sheep of my pasture!" says the LORD.
2 That is why the LORD, the God of Israel,
says this against the shepherds who take care of my people:
"You have scattered my flock,
and driven them away,
and have not looked after them.
Look, I will punish you for the evil of your deeds," says the LORD.
3 "I will gather what is left of my flock
out of all the countries where I have driven them.
I will bring them back to their pastures,
and they will have many young and become many.
4 I will set up shepherds over them who will take care of them.
They will no longer be afraid or terrified,
and none of them will be missing," says the LORD.
5 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch.
He will rule as king and act wisely,
and he will do justice and righteousness in the land.
6 In his days Judah will be saved,
and Israel will live in safety.
This is the name by which he will be called:
The LORD our righteousness.
7 "So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when people will no longer say,
'As surely as the LORD lives,
who brought the people of Israel up out of the land of Egypt.'
8 Instead they will say,
'As surely as the LORD lives,
who brought up and led the descendants of the house of Israel
out of the land of the north,
and from all the countries where I had driven them.'
Then they will live in their own land."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The "shepherds" are the kings and leaders. They did not take care of the people, but led them into disaster.

Verses 3–4: God himself will be the good shepherd. He gathers the scattered sheep and gives them good shepherds, so that none of them is missing anymore.

Verses 5–6: A great promise: From David's family a "righteous Branch" will come, a king who rules wisely and justly. His name: "The LORD our righteousness" (in Hebrew: "Yahweh Tsidkenu"). Interesting: The last king was called Zedekiah, which means "My righteousness is the LORD." But he did not live up to his name. The coming king will.

In Judaism, this promise is applied to the Messiah who is still to come. Christians see it fulfilled in Jesus, the descendant of David.

Verses 7–8: The return from exile will be a new exodus, greater than the one from Egypt (as already in 16:14–15).

Against the false prophets VERSES 9–22

9 About the prophets:
My heart is broken inside me.
All my bones shake.
I am like a drunk man,
like a man who has had too much wine,
because of the LORD,
and because of his holy words.
10 "For the land is full of adulterers.
Because of the curse, the land mourns.
The pastures of the wilderness have dried up.
They run on an evil course,
and they use their power wrongly.
11 For both prophet and priest are godless.
Yes, even in my house I have found their evil," says the LORD.
12 "That is why their way will be like slippery paths in the dark.
They will be pushed and fall there.
For I will bring disaster on them
in the year of their punishment," says the LORD.
13 "I have seen foolish things among the prophets of Samaria.
They prophesied by Baal,
and led my people Israel astray.
14 Among the prophets of Jerusalem I have also seen a horrible thing:
They commit adultery and live in lies.
They strengthen the hands of evil people,
so that no one turns away from his evil.
They have all become like Sodom to me,
and the people who live there like Gomorrah."
15 That is why the LORD of Armies says this about the prophets:
"Look, I will feed them with wormwood,
and make them drink poisoned water.
For from the prophets of Jerusalem,
godlessness has spread through the whole land."
16 The LORD of Armies says,
"Don't listen to the words of the prophets who prophesy to you.
They teach you worthless things.
They speak a vision from their own heart,
and not from the mouth of the LORD.
17 Again and again they say to those who despise me,
'The LORD has said, "You will have peace."'
And to everyone who follows the stubbornness of his own heart they say,
'No disaster will come on you.'
18 For who has stood in the council of the LORD,
so that he has seen and heard his word?
Who has paid attention to my word and heard it?
19 Look, the LORD's storm, his anger, has gone out.
Yes, a whirling storm!

It will burst on the head of the wicked.
20 The LORD's anger will not turn back
until he has done and carried out what his heart has planned.
In the last days you will understand it clearly.
21 I didn't send these prophets,
yet they ran.
I didn't speak to them,
yet they prophesied.
22 But if they had stood in my council,
then they would have let my people hear my words,
and would have turned them away from their evil way,
and from the evil of their deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Jeremiah is shaken. God's words stir him up so much that he trembles like a drunk man.

Verse 14: The prophets in Jerusalem themselves live immorally and encourage others to do evil. They are worse than the prophets of Baal in the north.

Verses 16–17: How do you recognize false prophets? They say to people who despise God: "You will have peace." And: "No disaster will come on you." They confirm people in their wrong way.

Verses 18 and 22: A true prophet has stood in the "council of the LORD," that is, he has really listened to God. A true prophet calls people to turn back. A false prophet only calms people down.

Verse 21: "I didn't send these prophets, yet they ran." Not everyone who speaks in God's name has really been sent by God.

God's word is like a hammer VERSES 23–32

23 "Am I only a God who is near," says the LORD,
"and not a God who is far away?
24 Can anyone hide himself in secret places
so that I can't see him?" says the LORD.
"Don't I fill heaven and earth?" says the LORD.
25 "I have heard what the prophets have said,
who prophesy lies in my name.
They say, 'I had a dream! I had a dream!'
26 How long will this go on in the heart of the prophets
who prophesy lies,
the prophets who speak the deceit of their own heart?
27 They plan to make my people forget my name
through their dreams, which they tell one another,
just as their ancestors forgot my name because of Baal.
28 The prophet who has a dream, let him tell his dream.
But the one who has my word, let him speak my word faithfully.
What does straw have to do with wheat?" says the LORD.
29 "Isn't my word like fire?" says the LORD,
"and like a hammer that breaks the rock into pieces?
30 "So look, I am against the prophets," says the LORD,
"who steal my words from one another.
31 Look, I am against the prophets," says the LORD,
"who use their own tongues, and say, 'He says.'
32 Look, I am against those who prophesy lying dreams," says the LORD,
"who tell them, and lead my people astray
by their lies and by their empty bragging.
Yet I didn't send them or command them.
They don't help this people at all," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–24: God is not only a "God who is near," whom people can shape to fit their wishes. He is also far away, great, and fills heaven and earth. No one can hide from him.

Verses 25–28: The false prophets tell their dreams and claim they come from God. God says: A dream is a dream. But my word is something different. The difference is like the difference between straw and wheat: Straw looks similar, but it does not feed you.

Verse 29 is a famous verse: God's word is like fire that burns, and like a hammer that breaks rocks. It is not comfortable, but powerful. It can break open hard hearts.

Verse 30: Some prophets simply "stole" the words of others and passed them off as their own message.

The "message" of the LORD VERSES 33–40

33 "When this people, or a prophet, or a priest asks you,
'What is the message from the LORD?'
then tell them,
'"What message? I will throw you off," says the LORD.'
34 As for the prophet, the priest, and the people who say,
'The message from the LORD,'
I will punish that man and his household.
35 This is what each of you will say to his neighbor and to his brother:
'What has the LORD answered?'
and, 'What has the LORD said?'
36 You will not mention 'the message from the LORD' anymore,
for each man's own word has become his message.
For you have twisted the words of the living God,
of the LORD of Armies, our God.
37 This is what you will say to the prophet:
'What has the LORD answered you?'
and, 'What has the LORD said?'
38 But if you say, 'The message from the LORD,'
then the LORD says:
'Because you say this word, "The message from the LORD,"
even though I sent word to you, telling you not to say,
"The message from the LORD,"
39 look, I will completely forget you,
and I will throw you away from my presence,
together with the city that I gave to you and to your ancestors.
40 I will bring on you a disgrace that lasts forever,
and a shame that never ends,
which will not be forgotten.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There is a play on words here in Hebrew: The word "massa" means both "message, saying" and "burden." The WEB, our English source text, translates it as "message."

Many other Bibles translate it as "burden," so that the play on words can be understood.

People asked Jeremiah mockingly: "What is the LORD's 'message' (or 'burden') today?" They made fun of his messages.

God answers with the play on words: You ask about the "burden"? You yourselves are the burden! "I will throw you off."

Verses 35–36: Instead of talking mockingly about the "burden," the people should seriously ask: "What has the LORD answered?" and, "What has the LORD said?" God's word should be treated with respect, not as a joke.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 24

Two baskets of figs

Good figs and bad figs VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD showed me something.
I saw two baskets of figs.
They were set down in front of the LORD's temple.
This happened after Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, had taken people away as captives.
He took Jeconiah, the son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah.
He also took the princes of Judah,
the craftsmen and the metalworkers.
He took them away from Jerusalem and brought them to Babylon.
2 One basket had very good figs.
They were like the figs that ripen first.
The other basket had very bad figs.
They were so bad that no one could eat them.
3 Then the LORD asked me,
"What do you see, Jeremiah?"
I said, "Figs.
The good figs are very good.
The bad figs are very bad.
They are so bad that no one can eat them."
4 Then the LORD spoke his word to me.
He said,
5 "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'The captives from Judah are like these good figs.
I sent them away from this place into the land of the Chaldeans.
But I will see them as good.
6 I will watch over them for their good.
I will bring them back to this land.
I will build them, and not tear them down.
I will plant them, and not pull them up.
7 I will give them a heart to know me.
They will know that I am the LORD.
They will be my people, and I will be their God.
For they will return to me with their whole heart.
8 "'But others are like the bad figs.
They are so bad that no one can eat them,' says the LORD.
'That is how I will treat Zedekiah, the king of Judah, and his princes.
I will treat the rest of the people of Jerusalem the same way,
those who are still in this land
and those who live in the land of Egypt.
9 I will hand them over to be tossed back and forth among all the kingdoms of the earth.
Bad things will happen to them.
People will look down on them.
People will tell stories about them and make fun of them.
People will use their name as a curse.
This will happen in all the places where I will drive them.
10 I will send the sword, famine, and disease among them.
They will be wiped out from the land
that I gave to them and to their ancestors.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: In the year 597 BC, King Jeconiah (Jehoiachin) was carried off to Babylon with many princes and craftsmen. Those who stayed behind in Jerusalem thought: We are the good ones; those who were carried off have been punished.

Verses 2–7: God turns this opinion around: The exiles in Babylon are the "good figs." God will watch over them, bring them back and give them a new heart. "They will be my people, and I will be their God."

Verse 6: "I will build them, and not tear them down. I will plant them, and not pull them up." Here the words from Jeremiah's call come back again (1:10).

Verse 7: God himself gives the heart that knows him. Turning back is not only the work of people, but God's gift.

Verses 8–10: Those who stayed in Jerusalem and feel safe are the "bad figs." They have learned nothing.

This message was surprising and comforting for the exiles: God has not forgotten you. It is precisely in a foreign land that something new will grow. In fact, Judaism put down important roots during the exile in Babylon.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 25

70 years and the cup of anger

For 23 years you have not listened VERSES 1–7

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah about all the people of Judah,
in the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah.
(This was the first year of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon.)
2 Jeremiah the prophet spoke it to all the people of Judah,

and to all the people of Jerusalem:

3 From the thirteenth year of Josiah, the son of Amon,
king of Judah,
until today, for these 23 years,
the LORD's word has come to me.
I have spoken to you early and tirelessly,
but you have not listened.

4 The LORD has sent you all his servants the prophets,
early and tirelessly,
but you have not listened or paid attention.

5 They said, "Now, each of you, turn back from your evil
way,
and from the evil of your deeds.
Then you can live in the land that the LORD has given
to you and to your ancestors,
from long ago and forever.

6 Don't follow other gods to serve them or worship
them,
and don't make me angry with the work of your
hands.
Then I will do you no harm."

7 "Yet you have not listened to me," says the LORD.
"You have made me angry with the work of your
hands,
and that only harms you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The fourth year of Jehoiakim is 605 BC. In that year Nebuchadnezzar defeated the Egyptians at Carchemish and became king of Babylon. A turning point in world history.

Verse 3: Jeremiah has been preaching for 23 years, "early and tirelessly," but no one listens. What endurance!

Verses 5–6: The message was always the same and very simple: Turn back, then you may stay in the land.

70 years VERSES 8–14

8 That is why the LORD of Armies says:
"Because you have not listened to my words,

9 look, I will send for all the families of the north," says
the LORD,
"and I will send for Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
my servant.
I will bring them against this land,
and against the people who live in it,
and against all these nations around it.
I will completely destroy them,
and make them a horror,
something people hiss at,
and ruins that last forever.

10 I will take away from them
the sound of joy and the sound of gladness,
the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,
the sound of the millstones,
and the light of the lamp.

11 This whole land will be a ruin and a horror,
and these nations will serve the king of Babylon for 70
years.

12 "When the 70 years are over,
I will punish the king of Babylon and that nation for
their guilt," says the LORD.
"I will make the land of the Chaldeans a waste forever.

13 I will bring on that land all the words which I have
spoken against it,
everything that is written in this book,
which Jeremiah has prophesied against all the
nations.

14 For many nations and great kings will make slaves of
them too.
I will pay them back for their deeds,
and for the work of their hands."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Amazing: God calls Nebuchadnezzar, the enemy king, "my servant." He is a tool in God's hand without knowing it.

Verse 10: A very moving picture of a destroyed land: No more laughter, no more weddings, no more sound of the hand mills that ground flour every morning, no more light in the houses in the evening. Ordinary everyday life stops.

Verses 11–12: The "70 years" are a round number for a human lifetime. From the first carrying away (605 BC) until the return home after the decree of Cyrus (538 BC), about 70 years passed. Later, Daniel (Daniel 9:2) and Chronicles (2 Chronicles 36:21) thought about this number.

Verses 12–14: Babylon too will be called to account. No power lasts forever.

The cup of the wine of anger VERSES 15–29

15 For the LORD, the God of Israel, says to me:
"Take this cup of the wine of anger from my hand,
and make all the nations I send you to drink it.

16 They will drink, and stagger back and forth,
and go out of their minds,
because of the sword that I will send among them."

17 Then I took the cup from the LORD's hand,
and made all the nations drink it that the LORD had
sent me to:

18 Jerusalem and the cities of Judah,
with its kings and its princes,
to make them a ruin, a horror,
something people hiss at and curse,
as it is today;

19 Pharaoh, king of Egypt,
with his servants, his princes, and all his people;

20 and all the mixed peoples,
and all the kings of the land of Uz,
all the kings of the Philistines,
Ashkelon, Gaza, Ekron, and what is left of Ashdod;

21 Edom, Moab, and the people of Ammon;

22 and all the kings of Tyre,
all the kings of Sidon,
and the kings of the islands across the sea;

23 Dedan, Tema, Buz,
and all who cut off the corners of their beards;

24 and all the kings of Arabia,
and all the kings of the mixed peoples who live in the
wilderness;

25 and all the kings of Zimri,
all the kings of Elam,
and all the kings of the Medes;

26 and all the kings of the north, far and near, one after
another;
and all the kingdoms of the world on the face of the

earth.
The king of Sheshach will drink after them.
27 "Tell them, 'The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Drink, and get drunk, and vomit,
and fall, and don't get up again,
because of the sword which I will send among you."'
28 If they refuse to take the cup from your hand to drink,
then tell them, 'The LORD of Armies says:
"You must drink it!
29 For look, I am beginning to bring disaster on the city which is called by my name.
Should you go completely unpunished?
You will not go unpunished,
for I am calling for a sword against all the people who live on the earth,
says the LORD of Armies."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "cup of the wine of anger" is a picture: Whoever drinks from it staggers like a drunk person. What is meant is the disaster of war that comes on many nations.

Verses 18–26: A long list of nations around Israel: Egypt, the Philistines, Edom, Moab, Ammon, Tyre, Sidon, Arab tribes, Elam and the Medes in the east. All of them will feel the power of Babylon.

Verse 26: "Sheshach" is a secret name for Babylon. To make it, the letters of the Hebrew alphabet were swapped: the first with the last, the second with the second to last, and so on. That is how "Babel" becomes "Sheshach." ("Babel" is the Hebrew name for Babylon.) Babylon's turn comes last.

Verse 29: If God begins the judgment with his own city, then the other nations will certainly not be spared. (Compare 1 Peter 4:17: "For the time has come for judgment to begin with the household of God.")

The LORD roars like a lion VERSES 30–38

30 "So prophesy all these words against them, and tell them,
'The LORD will roar from on high,
and raise his voice from his holy home.
He will roar loudly against his pasture.
He will shout, like those who stamp on grapes,
against all the people who live on the earth.
31 A noise will reach the end of the earth,
for the LORD has a case against the nations.
He will go to court with all people.
As for the wicked, he will hand them over to the sword,' says the LORD."
32 The LORD of Armies says,
"Look, disaster will go out from nation to nation,
and a great storm will be stirred up from the ends of the earth."
33 On that day, those killed by the LORD will lie
from one end of the earth to the other end of the earth.
No one will mourn for them.
They won't be gathered or buried.
They will be like manure on the surface of the ground.
34 Wail, you shepherds, and cry out.
Roll in the dust, you leaders of the flock,
for the days of your slaughter have come,
and you will be scattered.
You will fall and break like a precious jar.
35 The shepherds will have no place to run to.
The leaders of the flock will have no escape.
36 Listen to the cry of the shepherds,
and the wailing of the leaders of the flock,
for the LORD is destroying their pasture.
37 The peaceful pastures are silenced
because of the fierce anger of the LORD.
38 He has left his hiding place like a lion,
for their land has become a horror
because of the fierce oppression,
and because of his fierce anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 30–31: God "roars" like a lion. He has a case in court against all nations. All the injustice of the world is brought before God.

Verses 34–36: The "shepherds," the kings and the powerful who led their nations badly, will be held responsible.

These verses describe judgment as God's business. They are not a call for people to wage war. War is described here as a terrible disaster, not as something good.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 26

Jeremiah on trial

Jeremiah must die VERSES 1–9

1 At the beginning of the rule of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah,
this word came from the LORD:
2 "The LORD says:
'Stand in the courtyard of the LORD's house,
and speak to all the people of the cities of Judah who come to worship in the LORD's house.
Tell them all the words that I command you to speak to them.
Don't leave out a word.
3 Perhaps they will listen,
and each one will turn back from his evil way.
Then I will change my mind about the disaster which I plan to bring on them because of the evil of their deeds.'"
4 Tell them, "The LORD says:
'If you will not listen to me,
and walk in my law which I have set before you,
5 and listen to the words of my servants the prophets,
whom I send to you early and tirelessly,
though you have not listened,

6 then I will make this house like Shiloh,
and I will make this city a curse to all the nations of the earth.'"
7 The priests, the prophets, and all the people heard Jeremiah
speaking these words in the LORD's house.
8 When Jeremiah had finished speaking everything that the LORD had commanded him to speak to all the people,
the priests, the prophets, and all the people seized him and said,
"You must die!
9 Why have you prophesied in the LORD's name,
'This house will be like Shiloh,
and this city will be a ruin, with no one living in it'?"
All the people crowded around Jeremiah in the LORD's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter tells what happened after the temple speech in chapter 7.

Verse 2: "Don't leave out a word." Jeremiah is to pass on God's message completely, even if it is uncomfortable. (That is exactly what we want with this Bible too: not to leave out a word.)

Verse 3: "Perhaps they will listen." God still hopes that they will turn back. The threat is not meant to destroy, but to move people to turn back.

Verse 8: The reaction is fierce: "You must die!" To the people, it was blasphemy to say that the temple could be destroyed.

The trial VERSES 10–19

10 When the princes of Judah heard these things,
they came up from the king's house to the LORD's house,
and they sat down at the entrance of the New Gate of the LORD's house.
11 Then the priests and the prophets spoke to the princes and to all the people. They said,
"This man deserves to die,
for he has prophesied against this city,
as you have heard with your own ears."
12 Then Jeremiah spoke to all the princes and to all the people. He said,
"The LORD sent me to prophesy against this house and against this city
all the words that you have heard.
13 So now, change your ways and your deeds,
and obey the voice of the LORD your God.
Then the LORD will change his mind about the disaster
that he has announced against you.
14 But as for me, look, I am in your hands.
Do with me whatever you think is good and right.
15 Only know for sure that if you put me to death,
you will bring innocent blood on yourselves,
on this city, and on the people who live in it.
For it is true: The LORD has sent me to you
to speak all these words so that you can hear them."
16 Then the princes and all the people said to the priests and to the prophets:
"This man does not deserve to die,
for he has spoken to us in the name of the LORD our God."
17 Then some of the elders of the land stood up,
and spoke to the whole assembly of the people. They said,
18 "Micah the Morashtite prophesied in the days of Hezekiah, king of Judah.
He spoke to all the people of Judah and said,
'The LORD of Armies says:
"Zion will be plowed like a field,
and Jerusalem will become heaps of ruins,
and the mountain of the temple will become like hills covered with forest."'
19 Did Hezekiah, king of Judah, and all Judah put him to death?
Didn't he fear the LORD and ask the LORD for mercy?
And the LORD changed his mind about the disaster which he had announced against them.
We would be doing great harm to ourselves that way!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The princes, that is, the king's officials, come to the temple gate as judges.

Verses 12–15: Jeremiah's defense is brave: He takes nothing back. He repeats: Turn back! And he says: I am in your hands. But if you kill me, you will shed innocent blood.

Verse 16: The princes and the people decide: Jeremiah is innocent.

Verses 17–19: The elders remember the prophet Micah (Micah 3:12). About 100 years earlier he had said something similar. King Hezekiah did not kill him, but turned back, and God spared Jerusalem. A beautiful example of how people can learn from history.

The prophet Uriah is killed VERSES 20–24

20 There was also another man who prophesied in the LORD's name:
Uriah, the son of Shemaiah, from Kiriath Jearim.
He prophesied against this city and against this land, just as Jeremiah had.
21 When King Jehoiakim, with all his warriors and all the princes, heard his words,
the king tried to put him to death.
But when Uriah heard about it, he was afraid.
He fled and went to Egypt.
22 Then King Jehoiakim sent Elnathan, the son of Achbor,
and some men with him to Egypt.
23 They brought Uriah out of Egypt to King Jehoiakim, who killed him with the sword,
and threw his dead body into the graves of the common people.
24 But Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, protected Jeremiah, so that they didn't hand him over to the people to be put to death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–23: Another prophet, Uriah, had the same message as Jeremiah. He fled to Egypt, but King Jehoiakim had him brought back and killed. This shows how dangerous Jeremiah's situation was. Prophets who told the

truth were persecuted, and that still happens today in many countries.

Verse 24: Jeremiah survived because Ahikam protected him. Ahikam was a high official. His family (Shaphan) helped Jeremiah again and again. Ahikam's son Gedaliah later became governor (Chapter 40). Courage and protection from influential people can save lives.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 27

The yoke on the neck

A message to the neighboring kings VERSES 1–11

1 At the beginning of the rule of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah,
this word came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 The LORD says to me:
"Make straps and bars,
and put them on your neck.
3 Then send them to the king of Edom, to the king of Moab,
to the king of the people of Ammon, to the king of Tyre, and to the king of Sidon,
through the messengers who come to Jerusalem to Zedekiah, king of Judah.
4 Give them a message for their masters. Say,
'The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
"Tell your masters:
5 'I have made the earth,
and the people and the animals that are on the face of the earth,
by my great power and by my outstretched arm.
I give it to whoever I think is right.
6 Now I have given all these lands into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, my servant.
I have also given him the wild animals to serve him.
7 All the nations will serve him,
and his son, and his grandson,
until the time comes for his own land.
Then many nations and great kings will make him their slave.
8 "'"'If a nation or a kingdom will not serve this Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
and will not put its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon,
I will punish that nation,' says the LORD,
'with the sword, with famine, and with disease,
until I have destroyed them by his hand.
9 But as for you, don't listen to your prophets,
to your fortune-tellers, to your dreams,
to those who read signs, or to your sorcerers,
who say to you,
"You will not serve the king of Babylon."
10 For they prophesy a lie to you.
It will only take you far away from your land,
so that I will drive you out,
and you will die.
11 But the nation that puts its neck under the yoke of the king of Babylon,
and serves him,
I will let that nation stay in its own land,' says the LORD.
'They will farm it and live in it.'"'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The WEB, our English source text, names King Jehoiakim here, like the Hebrew text. But from the rest of the chapter (verses 3 and 12) it becomes clear that this is about the time of King Zedekiah. That is why many translations have "Zedekiah" here.

Verse 2: Another acted-out sign: Jeremiah puts a yoke on his neck, like the yoke that is put on oxen. A yoke means: You have to serve someone.

Verse 3: Messengers from the neighboring countries were in Jerusalem to plan an uprising against Babylon together. Jeremiah sends them a message: Don't do it!

Verses 5–7: God is the Creator of the whole world. He gives power to whoever he wants. Now he has given it to Nebuchadnezzar, but not forever: After three generations, it will be Babylon's turn too.

Verses 9–11: Jeremiah's advice is politically wise: Submit to Babylon, then you may stay in your land and live. An uprising only leads to ruin.

Words to King Zedekiah and to the priests VERSES 12–22

12 I spoke all these same words to Zedekiah, king of Judah. I said,
"Put your necks under the yoke of the king of Babylon, and serve him and his people, and live.
13 Why should you die, you and your people,
by the sword, by famine, and by disease,
as the LORD has said about the nation that will not serve the king of Babylon?
14 Don't listen to the words of the prophets who say to you,
'You will not serve the king of Babylon.'
For they prophesy a lie to you.
15 For I have not sent them," says the LORD,
"but they prophesy lies in my name.
The result will be that I drive you out,
and you will die,
you and the prophets who prophesy to you."
16 I also spoke to the priests and to all this people. I said,
The LORD says,
"Don't listen to the words of your prophets who prophesy to you and say,
'Look, the objects of the LORD's house will soon be brought back from Babylon.'
For they prophesy a lie to you.
17 Don't listen to them.
Serve the king of Babylon, and live.
Why should this city become a ruin?

18 But if they are prophets,
and if the LORD's word is with them,
let them now plead with the LORD of Armies,
so that the objects which are left in the LORD's house,
in the house of the king of Judah, and in Jerusalem,
don't go to Babylon.
19 For the LORD of Armies speaks about the pillars,
about the Sea, about the stands,
and about the rest of the objects that are left in this city,
20 which Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, didn't take
when he carried away from Jerusalem to Babylon as captives
Jeconiah, the son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah,
and all the nobles of Judah and Jerusalem.
21 Yes, the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says this about the objects
that are left in the LORD's house,
and in the house of the king of Judah, and in Jerusalem:
22 'They will be carried to Babylon,
and there they will stay,
until the day that I come for them,' says the LORD.
'Then I will bring them up,
and bring them back to this place.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–15: Jeremiah says the same thing to his own king, Zedekiah: Submit, then you will live. The false prophets who preach resistance are lying.

Verse 16: When the first group was carried away in 597 BC, the Babylonians had taken many precious objects from the temple with them. False prophets said: They will come back soon!

Verse 18: Jeremiah's answer: If you are real prophets, then pray instead that the rest will not be taken away too!

Verse 19: The "pillars" (Jachin and Boaz), the "Sea" (a huge water basin made of bronze) and the "stands" were large bronze objects in the temple (1 Kings 7).

Verse 22: But here too there is hope: One day God will bring the objects back. That really happened under King Cyrus (Ezra 1:7–11).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 28

Jeremiah and the prophet Hananiah

Hananiah breaks the yoke VERSES 1–11

1 This happened in that same year.
It was at the beginning of the rule of Zedekiah, king of Judah,
in the fourth year, in the fifth month.
Hananiah, the son of Azzur, was a prophet from Gibeon.
He spoke to me in the house of the LORD.
The priests and all the people were there.
Hananiah said,
2 "This is what the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon.
3 Within two full years I will bring back to this place
all the objects from the LORD's house.
Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, took them away from this place.
He carried them to Babylon.
4 I will also bring back to this place Jeconiah, the son of Jehoiakim, king of Judah.
And I will bring back all the captives from Judah who went to Babylon,' says the LORD.
'For I will break the yoke of the king of Babylon.'"
5 Then the prophet Jeremiah answered the prophet Hananiah.
The priests were there,
and all the people who were standing in the LORD's house.
6 The prophet Jeremiah said,
"Amen! May the LORD do so.
May the LORD fulfill your words.
May he do what you have prophesied.
May he bring the objects of the LORD's house back from Babylon to this place,
and all the captives too.
7 But now listen to what I say.
You and all the people should hear it:
8 There were prophets long ago, before me and before you.
They prophesied against many countries and against great kingdoms.
They spoke of war, disaster and disease.
9 But a prophet may prophesy peace.
When his word comes true,
then people will know that the LORD has really sent him."
10 Then the prophet Hananiah took the bar off the neck of the prophet Jeremiah.
He broke it.
11 Hananiah spoke in front of all the people.
He said, "This is what the LORD says:
'In the same way, I will break the yoke of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon.
I will break it off the neck of all the nations within two full years.'"
Then the prophet Jeremiah went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet against a prophet: Hananiah says the opposite of Jeremiah in God's name: In two years it will all be over!

Verse 6: Jeremiah's answer is amazing: "Amen! May the LORD do so. May the LORD fulfill your words." Jeremiah does not want the disaster. He would be glad if Hananiah were right.

Verses 8–9: But Jeremiah gives them something to think about: The true prophets of the past mostly warned of disaster. Whoever promises peace must first prove that he is right. Whether a prophet really comes from God is shown by

whether his word comes true (compare Deuteronomy 18:22).

Verses 10–11: Hananiah breaks Jeremiah's wooden yoke in front of everyone. A strong gesture.

Verse 11: Jeremiah does not argue any further. He quietly goes away. Sometimes it is wiser not to answer right away.

A yoke of iron VERSES 12–17

12 The prophet Hananiah had broken the bar off the neck
of the prophet Jeremiah.
After that, the LORD spoke his word to Jeremiah.
He said,
13 "Go and tell Hananiah:
'This is what the LORD says:
"You have broken the bars of wood.
But in their place you have made bars of iron."
14 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"I have put a yoke of iron on the neck of all these
nations.
They must serve Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon.
And they will serve him.
I have even given him the wild animals."'"
15 Then the prophet Jeremiah said to the prophet
Hananiah,
"Listen, Hananiah!
The LORD has not sent you.
But you make this people trust in a lie.
16 That is why the LORD says:
'Look, I will remove you from the face of the earth.
This year you will die,
because you have told people to turn against the
LORD.'"
17 The prophet Hananiah died that same year,
in the seventh month.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: Later Jeremiah receives an answer from God: The wooden yoke can be broken, but that only makes things worse. Now an iron yoke is coming. Whoever gives false hope makes the situation worse.

Verse 15: Jeremiah tells Hananiah clearly: God has not sent you. You make the people trust in a lie.

Verses 16–17: Hananiah dies two months later. This shows who the true prophet was.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 29

A letter to the exiles

Seek the peace of the city VERSES 1–9

1 These are the words of the letter that Jeremiah the
prophet sent from Jerusalem
to the elders who were left among the captives,
and to the priests, to the prophets,
and to all the people whom Nebuchadnezzar had
carried away as captives
from Jerusalem to Babylon.
2 (This was after King Jeconiah, the queen mother, the
court officials,
the princes of Judah and Jerusalem, the craftsmen,
and the metalworkers
had left Jerusalem.)
3 He sent it with Elasah, the son of Shaphan,
and Gemariah, the son of Hilkiah,
whom Zedekiah, king of Judah, sent to Babylon,
to Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon.
The letter said:
4 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel,
says to all the captives whom I have had carried away
from Jerusalem to Babylon:
5 "Build houses and live in them.
Plant gardens and eat their fruit.
6 Marry and have sons and daughters.
Find wives for your sons,
and give your daughters in marriage,
so that they have sons and daughters.
Become many there, and don't become fewer.
7 Seek the peace of the city where I have had you carried
away as captives,
and pray to the LORD for it,
for in its peace you will have peace."
8 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Don't let your prophets and your fortune-tellers who
are among you deceive you.
Don't listen to the dreams that you encourage them to
dream.
9 For they prophesy lies to you in my name.
I have not sent them," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah writes a letter to the people who had been carried off to Babylon in 597 BC. The letter is taken along by messengers whom the king sends to Babylon.

Verses 5–6: Jeremiah's advice is very practical: Settle in! Build houses, plant gardens, marry, have children. The exile will last a long time. Don't live as if you were just waiting, but live your life.

Verse 7 is one of the most important verses in Jeremiah: "Seek the peace of the city … and pray to the LORD for it, for in its peace you will have peace." The exiles are to pray for Babylon, for the city of their enemies! That is revolutionary. To this day, this verse is a guiding word for people who live in a foreign land, for migrants and refugees, and for everyone who works for the common good. The Hebrew word for peace, "shalom," also means well-being.

Verses 8–9: In Babylon too there are false prophets who say: Soon we will go home! Jeremiah warns: Don't believe them.

Thoughts of peace VERSES 10–14

10 For the LORD says,
"When 70 years are over for Babylon,
I will come to you,
and keep my good promise to you,
to bring you back to this place.

11 For I know the thoughts that I think toward you," says
the LORD,
"thoughts of peace, and not of disaster,
to give you hope and a future.
12 You will call on me,
and you will come and pray to me,
and I will listen to you.
13 You will seek me and find me,
when you search for me with all your heart.
14 I will let you find me," says the LORD,
"and I will turn your fate around.
I will gather you from all the nations,
and from all the places where I have driven you," says
the LORD.
"I will bring you back to the place
from which I had you carried away as captives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11 is one of the most loved verses in the whole Bible: "For I know the thoughts that I think toward you ... thoughts of peace, and not of disaster, to give you hope and a future." It has given courage to many people in hard times.

It was first spoken to people who had lost everything and were living in a foreign land. It is to them in particular that God says: I have a good plan for you.

Verse 13: "You will seek me and find me, when you search for me with all your heart." God can be found in Babylon too, even without a temple. That was an important insight: People can worship God everywhere.

About those who stayed in Jerusalem VERSES 15–19

15 Because you have said,
"The LORD has raised up prophets for us in Babylon,"
16 the LORD says this about the king who sits on David's
throne,
and about all the people who live in this city,
your brothers who haven't gone with you into
captivity.
17 The LORD of Armies says:
"Look, I will send the sword, the famine, and disease
against them.
I will make them like rotten figs
that are so bad they can't be eaten.
18 I will chase them with the sword, with famine, and
with disease.
I will make them be tossed back and forth among all
the kingdoms of the earth.
They will be a horror, something that shocks people,
something people hiss at,
and a disgrace among all the nations where I have
driven them,
19 because they have not listened to my words," says the
LORD,
"which I sent to them through my servants the
prophets, early and tirelessly.
But you would not listen," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The exiles hoped that Jerusalem would remain standing and that they could soon return. Jeremiah says: It is Jerusalem that will fall. Those who stayed there are the "bad figs" from chapter 24.

False prophets in Babylon VERSES 20–32

20 So hear the LORD's word,
all you captives whom I have sent away from
Jerusalem to Babylon.
21 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says this
about Ahab, the son of Kolaiah,
and about Zedekiah, the son of Maaseiah,
who prophesy a lie to you in my name:
"Look, I will hand them over to Nebuchadnezzar, king
of Babylon,
and he will kill them in front of your eyes.
22 Because of them, all the captives of Judah who are in
Babylon
will use this curse:
'May the LORD make you like Zedekiah and like Ahab,
whom the king of Babylon roasted in the fire.'
23 For they have done shameful things in Israel.
They have committed adultery with their neighbors'
wives,
and have spoken lies in my name,
which I didn't command them.
I am the one who knows, and I am a witness," says the
LORD.
24 Say this about Shemaiah the Nehelamite:
25 "The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says,
'You have sent letters in your own name
to all the people who are in Jerusalem,
and to Zephaniah, the son of Maaseiah, the priest,
and to all the priests. You wrote:
26 "The LORD has made you priest in the place of Jehoiada
the priest,
so that there are officers in the LORD's house.
They must deal with every man who is crazy and acts
like a prophet.
You should put him in the stocks and in chains.
27 So why have you not punished Jeremiah from
Anathoth,
who acts like a prophet among you?
28 For he has sent us a message in Babylon:
The captivity will be long.
Build houses, and live in them.
Plant gardens, and eat their fruit."'"
29 Zephaniah the priest read this letter
so that Jeremiah the prophet heard it.
30 Then the LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
31 "Send this message to all the captives:
'The LORD says this about Shemaiah the Nehelamite:
"Shemaiah has prophesied to you,
though I didn't send him,
and he has made you trust in a lie."
32 That is why the LORD says,
"Look, I will punish Shemaiah the Nehelamite and his
descendants.
No man of his family will be left to live among this
people.
He won't see the good that I will do for my people," says
the LORD,
"because he has spoken rebellion against the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–23: Two false prophets in Babylon, Ahab and Zedekiah, told lies and committed adultery. The

Babylonian king had them executed, probably because they called for an uprising. The Bible mentions this cruel punishment as part of the history; it does not approve of it.

Verses 24–28: Another man in Babylon, Shemaiah, was angry about Jeremiah's letter. He wrote to the priest in Jerusalem: Why do you let Jeremiah run around freely? Put him in the stocks!

Verse 29: Zephaniah reads this letter out to Jeremiah. Perhaps he wanted to warn Jeremiah.

Verses 31–32: God says: Shemaiah will not live to see the return home.

This chapter shows: Even in a foreign land, there was argument about who speaks in God's name. The uncomfortable truth was harder to bear than the beautiful lie.

JEREMIAH

Chapter 30

I will heal you

Write everything in a book VERSES 1–3

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 "The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Write all the words that I have spoken to you in a book.
3 For look, the days are coming,' says the LORD,
'when I will turn around the fate of my people Israel and Judah,' says the LORD.
'I will bring them back to the land that I gave to their ancestors,
and they will own it.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With chapter 30 a special part of the book of Jeremiah begins: the "Book of Comfort" (Chapters 30–33). After so many words about judgment, now come words of hope.

Verse 2: Jeremiah is to write these words down so that later generations can read them. The hope is also for the future.

Verse 3: God will "turn around the fate" of his people: The exiles will return home, both from the northern kingdom of Israel and from Judah.

A time of fear, but rescue VERSES 4–11

4 These are the words that the LORD spoke about Israel and about Judah.
5 For the LORD says:
"We have heard a sound of trembling,
a sound of fear, and not of peace.
6 Ask now, and see:
Can a man give birth to a child?
Then why do I see every man with his hands on his belly,
like a woman in labor?
Why have all faces turned pale?
7 Oh, that day is great!
There is no other day like it.
It is the time of Jacob's trouble,
but he will be saved out of it.
8 On that day," says the LORD of Armies,
"I will break his yoke off your neck,
and I will tear off your chains.
Foreigners will no longer make them their slaves.
9 Instead they will serve the LORD their God,
and David their king, whom I will raise up for them.
10 So don't be afraid, Jacob my servant," says the LORD.
"Don't be terrified, Israel.
For look, I will save you from far away,
and save your descendants from the land of their captivity.
Jacob will come back,
and will be quiet and at ease.
No one will make him afraid.
11 For I am with you to save you," says the LORD.
"I will make a complete end of all the nations where I have scattered you,
but I will not make a complete end of you.
I will correct you with fairness,
but I will not leave you unpunished."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: The fear is so great that even strong men bend over like women in labor.

Verse 7: "It is the time of Jacob's trouble, but he will be saved out of it." The suffering is great, but it is not the end.

Verses 8–9: God will break the yoke, the yoke of Babylon from chapters 27–28. And the people will serve a king from David's family. In Judaism this is applied to the Messiah; Christians see it fulfilled in Jesus.

Verses 10–11: "So don't be afraid, Jacob my servant… For I am with you." These words are a reminder of Isaiah 41 and 43. God punishes "with fairness," not without limits, and he never lets his people be completely destroyed.

I will heal you VERSES 12–17

12 For the LORD says,
"Your injury is incurable.
Your wound is serious.
13 There is no one to plead your case,
no one to bandage you.
You have no medicine that heals.
14 All your lovers have forgotten you.
They don't care about you.
For I have wounded you as an enemy would,
with the punishment of someone cruel,
because your guilt is so great,
because your sins have become so many.
15 Why do you cry over your injury?
Your pain is incurable.
Because your guilt is so great,
because your sins have become so many,
I have done these things to you.
16 Therefore all those who eat you up will be eaten up.
All your enemies, every one of them, will go into captivity.

Those who rob you will be robbed.
I will make all who prey on you become prey.
17 For I will make you healthy again,
and I will heal your wounds," says the LORD,
"because they have called you an outcast and said,
'It is Zion, whom no one cares about.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–15: The people's wound seems incurable. No doctor, no medicine, no friends. And God says honestly: This wound comes from your guilt.

Verses 16–17: But then the surprising turn: "Therefore" – precisely because the wound is incurable and no one cares – "I will heal your wounds." What is impossible for people, God can do.

Verse 17: The others said about Zion: "It is Zion, whom no one cares about." That is exactly why God cares about her. God turns to those whom everyone else has given up on.

You will be my people VERSES 18–24

18 The LORD says:
"Look, I will turn around the fate of Jacob's tents,
and have compassion on his homes.
The city will be built again on its own hill,
and people will live in the palace in its own place.
19 Songs of thanks will come out of them,
with the sound of people celebrating.
I will make them many, and they will not be few.
I will give them honor, and they will not be looked down on.
20 Their children will be as they were before,
and their community will be firmly established in front of me.
I will punish all who oppress them.
21 Their prince will be one of their own,
and their ruler will come from among them.
I will bring him near, and he will come close to me.
For who would dare on his own to come close to me?"
says the LORD.
22 "You will be my people,
and I will be your God.
23 Look, the LORD's storm, his anger, has gone out,
a sweeping storm.
It will burst on the head of the wicked.
24 The fierce anger of the LORD will not turn back
until he has done and carried out what his heart has planned.
In the last days you will understand it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: Jerusalem will be rebuilt on its own hill of ruins. Old cities in the Near East were often rebuilt on the ruins of the earlier city.

Verses 19–20: Instead of laments, thanks and laughter will be heard again. Children will play in the streets again.

Verse 21: The new ruler will not be a foreign king, but one of their own people. And he may come very close to God, like a priest.

Verse 22: "You will be my people, and I will be your God." That is the covenant formula, the heart of the relationship between God and Israel. It is being renewed.

Verses 23–24: These verses already appear almost word for word in 23:19–20. God's judgment hits the wicked, not his people, whom he heals.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 31

The new covenant

Loved with an everlasting love VERSES 1–6

1 "At that time," says the LORD,
"I will be the God of all the families of Israel,
and they will be my people."
2 The LORD says,
"The people who survived the sword
found favor in the wilderness,
Israel, when I went to give him rest."
3 Long ago the LORD appeared to me and said,
"Yes, I have loved you with an everlasting love.
That is why I have drawn you to me with faithful love.
4 I will build you again, and you will be built,
virgin Israel.
Again you will put on your tambourines,
and go out in the dances of those who celebrate.
5 Again you will plant vineyards on the mountains of Samaria.
Those who plant them will plant,
and will enjoy the fruit.
6 For a day will come when the watchmen on the hills of Ephraim will call out,
'Get up! Let's go up to Zion, to the LORD our God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: As back then in the wilderness after the exodus from Egypt, God will show favor to his people again.

Verse 3 is one of the most beautiful love verses in the Bible: "I have loved you with an everlasting love. That is why I have drawn you to me with faithful love." God's love never ends.

Verses 4–5: The future looks joyful: dancing, music, vineyards, harvest.

Verse 6: Samaria and Ephraim belonged to the northern kingdom, which had separated from Jerusalem. Now the people from the north too will come back to Jerusalem to the temple. The split will be overcome.

They will come with weeping VERSES 7–14

7 For the LORD says,
"Sing with joy for Jacob,
and shout for the greatest of the nations.
Announce it, praise, and say,
'LORD, save your people,
what is left of Israel!'
8 Look, I will bring them from the land of the north,
and gather them from the ends of the earth.
Among them will be the blind and the lame,

the pregnant woman and the woman in labor
together.
They will come back as a great crowd.
9 They will come with weeping.
I will lead them as they pray.
I will lead them along streams of water,
on a straight path where they won't stumble,
for I am a father to Israel.
Ephraim is my firstborn.
10 "Hear the LORD's word, you nations,
and announce it in the islands far away.
Say, 'He who scattered Israel will gather him,
and guard him, as a shepherd guards his flock.'
11 For the LORD has set Jacob free,
and rescued him from the hand of someone stronger
than he was.
12 They will come and sing on the heights of Zion.
They will stream to the good gifts of the LORD:
to the grain, to the new wine, to the oil,
and to the young of the flock and of the herd.
Their life will be like a watered garden.
They will not grieve anymore at all.
13 Then the young women will be glad and dance,
and the young men and the old together.
For I will turn their mourning into joy,
and I will comfort them,
and give them joy instead of sorrow.
14 I will fill the priests with rich food,
and my people will be satisfied with my good gifts," says
the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A wonderful picture: God brings everyone home, especially the weak: the blind, the lame, pregnant women, women in labor. No one is left behind.

Verse 9: They come weeping, out of joy and deep emotion. God leads them like a father. He calls Ephraim (the northern kingdom) his "firstborn," his favorite child.

Verse 13: "I will turn their mourning into joy." Young and old dance together. A picture full of hope for all who mourn.

Rachel weeps for her children VERSES 15–22

15 The LORD says:
"A voice is heard in Ramah,
mourning and bitter weeping:
Rachel is weeping for her children.
She refuses to be comforted for her children,
because they are no more."
16 The LORD says:
"Stop your weeping,
and hold back the tears from your eyes,
for your work will be rewarded," says the LORD.
"They will come back from the land of the enemy.
17 There is hope for your future," says the LORD.
"Your children will come back to their own land.
18 "I have surely heard Ephraim mourning like this:
'You have disciplined me,
and I was disciplined,
like a calf that is not trained.
Bring me back, and I will come back,
for you are the LORD my God.
19 Truly, after I was brought back, I was sorry.
After I understood, I struck my thigh in grief.
I was ashamed, yes, even disgraced,
because I carried the disgrace of my youth.'
20 Is Ephraim my dear son?
Is he the child I delight in?
For as often as I speak against him,
I still remember him with love.
That is why my heart longs for him.
I will surely have mercy on him," says the LORD.
21 "Set up road signs.
Put up guideposts.
Pay attention to the highway,
the way by which you went.
Come back, virgin Israel.
Come back to these cities of yours.
22 How long will you wander here and there,
you unfaithful daughter?
For the LORD has created a new thing on the earth:
a woman will surround a man."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Rachel was Jacob's favorite wife and the ancestral mother of Ephraim and Benjamin. Her grave was near Ramah (Genesis 35:19; 1 Samuel 10:2). Jeremiah imagines Rachel weeping for her children who are being led into exile. Ramah was a gathering place for the prisoners (compare 40:1). The Gospel of Matthew quotes this verse in the story of the killing of the children in Bethlehem (Matthew 2:18).

Verses 16–17: God comforts Rachel: Stop weeping! There is hope. Your children will come back.

If you are grieving for a child, you will find in Rachel someone who knows this pain. Help is available, for example: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 18–19: Ephraim is sorry and prays: "Bring me back, and I will come back." Turning back is God's gift.

Verse 20: A moving verse: God speaks like a father who is disappointed by his child, but still cannot forget it. "My heart longs for him."

Verse 22: "A woman will surround a man" is a puzzling sentence. Many understand it like this: Things will be turned around; something completely new will happen. Interpreters do not agree on the exact meaning.

A refreshing sleep VERSES 23–30

23 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"When I turn around their fate,
people in the land of Judah and in its cities will say
these words again:
'May the LORD bless you, home of righteousness, holy
mountain.'
24 Judah and all its cities will live there together,
the farmers and those who move around with flocks.
25 For I have refreshed the tired soul,
and I have filled every sad soul."
26 At this I woke up and looked around.
My sleep had been sweet to me.
27 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will sow the house of Israel and the house of

Judah
with the seed of people and with the seed of animals.
28 Just as I have watched over them to pull up and to break down,
to overthrow, to destroy, and to bring disaster,
so I will watch over them to build and to plant," says the LORD.
29 "In those days they will no longer say,
'The fathers have eaten sour grapes,
and the children's teeth are set on edge.'
30 But everyone will die for his own guilt.
Every person who eats the sour grapes,
his own teeth will be set on edge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: "I have refreshed the tired soul." God refreshes the exhausted.

Verse 26: Jeremiah wakes up and says: "My sleep had been sweet to me." After all the hard messages, this message was like a beautiful dream.

Verse 28: Again the words from Jeremiah's call (1:10): God has pulled up and broken down. Now he will build and plant.

Verses 29–30: A saying at that time went: The fathers have sinned, and the children must pay for it. God says: This will no longer apply. Everyone is responsible for his own deeds. (Ezekiel 18 says this too.)

The new covenant VERSES 31–34

31 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will make a new covenant
with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah.
32 It will not be like the covenant that I made with their ancestors
on the day that I took them by the hand
to bring them out of the land of Egypt.
They broke my covenant,
even though I was a husband to them," says the LORD.
33 "But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days," says the LORD:
"I will put my law inside them,
and I will write it on their heart.
I will be their God,
and they will be my people.
34 They will no longer teach each other, neighbor and brother, and say,
'Know the LORD.'
For they will all know me,
from the least of them to the greatest," says the LORD,
"for I will forgive their guilt,
and I will remember their sin no more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important texts in the whole Old Testament.

Verses 31–32: God promises a "new covenant" with Israel and Judah. The old covenant from Sinai was broken by the people, although God was faithful like a husband.

Verse 33: What is new: God's law is no longer only on tablets of stone, but is written on the heart. People will then do God's will no longer because they are forced to, but from the inside, because they want to.

Verse 34: Everyone will know God, from the least to the greatest. No one will need a teacher anymore. And the foundation is forgiveness: "I will remember their sin no more."

In Judaism this promise is applied to Israel: God renews his covenant with his people, and the law (the Torah) is written on the heart.

In the New Testament this text is applied to Jesus. At the Last Supper Jesus says: "This cup is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20). The letter to the Hebrews quotes the whole passage (Hebrews 8:8–12).

Important: The new covenant is made explicitly with Israel and Judah. God has not rejected his people Israel (compare verses 35–37; Romans 11:1–2).

As sure as the sun and the moon VERSES 35–40

35 The LORD gives the sun as a light by day,
and sets the order of the moon and of the stars as a light by night.
He stirs up the sea, so that its waves roar.
The LORD of Armies is his name.
He says:
36 "If this order ever disappears from in front of me," says the LORD,
"then the descendants of Israel will also stop being a nation in front of me forever."
37 The LORD says:
"If the heavens above can be measured,
and the foundations of the earth below can be explored,
then I will also reject all the descendants of Israel
for all that they have done," says the LORD.
38 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when the city will be rebuilt for the LORD,
from the Tower of Hananel to the Corner Gate.
39 The measuring line will go out farther, straight ahead
to the hill Gareb,
and will turn toward Goah.
40 The whole valley of the dead bodies and of the ashes,
and all the fields as far as the Kidron Valley,
to the corner of the Horse Gate toward the east,
will be holy to the LORD.
It will never be pulled up or thrown down again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 35–37: God's faithfulness to Israel is as sure as the order of the sun, moon and stars. Only if these stopped would God reject Israel, that is, never. And just as no one can measure the heavens, God will never cast off his people.

Verses 38–40: Jerusalem will be rebuilt bigger. Even the "valley of the dead bodies and of the ashes," probably the valley of the son of Hinnom, where children were sacrificed, will be holy to God. The place of the greatest horror will be transformed.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 32

Jeremiah buys a field

Jeremiah in prison VERSES 1–5

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD
in the tenth year of Zedekiah, king of Judah,
which was the eighteenth year of Nebuchadnezzar.
2 At that time the army of the king of Babylon was
besieging Jerusalem.
Jeremiah the prophet was locked up in the courtyard
of the guard,
which was in the palace of the king of Judah.
3 For Zedekiah, king of Judah, had locked him up. He
had said,
"Why do you prophesy and say,
'The LORD says,
"Look, I will give this city into the hand of the king of
Babylon,
and he will capture it.
4 Zedekiah, king of Judah, won't escape out of the hand
of the Chaldeans,
but he will surely be handed over to the king of
Babylon.
He will speak with him face to face,
and see him with his own eyes.
5 He will take Zedekiah to Babylon,
and he will be there until I come for him," says the
LORD.
"Even if you fight against the Chaldeans,
you will not succeed"'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is the year 588/587 BC. Jerusalem is under siege, shortly before it falls. King Zedekiah has locked Jeremiah up in the "courtyard of the guard" of the palace, because he keeps announcing: The city will fall.

A purchase contract in the middle of war VERSES 6–15

6 Jeremiah said, "The LORD's word came to me. He said,
7 'Look, Hanamel, the son of your uncle Shallum, will
come to you and say,
"Buy my field that is in Anathoth,
for you have the right to buy it back for the family."'
8 "So my cousin Hanamel came to me in the courtyard of
the guard,
just as the LORD had said, and said to me,
'Please buy my field that is in Anathoth, in the land of
Benjamin,
for you have the right of inheritance,
and the right to buy it back is yours.
Buy it for yourself.'
"Then I knew that this was the LORD's word.
9 I bought the field in Anathoth from my cousin
Hanamel,
and weighed out the money for him: 17 shekels of
silver (about 7 ounces).
10 I signed the deed and sealed it.
I called witnesses,
and weighed out the money for him on the scales.
11 Then I took the deed of purchase,
both the sealed copy, which contained the terms and
conditions,
and the open copy.
12 I gave the deed of purchase to Baruch, the son of
Neriah, the son of Mahseiah,
in front of my cousin Hanamel,
and in front of the witnesses who had signed the deed
of purchase,
in front of all the Jews who were sitting in the
courtyard of the guard.
13 "In front of them I commanded Baruch:
14 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Take these deeds,
this deed of purchase which is sealed,
and this deed which is open,
and put them in a clay jar,
so that they last for a long time.'
15 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Houses and fields and vineyards will again be bought
in this land.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An amazing story: In the middle of the siege, while the enemies stand at the gates and the land seems lost, Jeremiah buys a field in his home village Anathoth. The village was already in the area held by the Babylonians.

Verses 7–8: According to the law, a close relative had the right and the duty to buy a family plot of land so that it would stay in the family (Leviticus 25:25).

Verses 10–14: Jeremiah does everything very properly: contract, seal, witnesses, money. There are two copies: one sealed, one open to read. They are put into a clay jar so that they will last a long time. (The Dead Sea Scrolls were also kept like this.)

Verse 15: The message: There is a future! People will buy houses and fields in this land again. Jeremiah invests in hope, even though everything seems lost.

Shekels were pieces of silver that were weighed out as money. One shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

Here Baruch is mentioned for the first time, Jeremiah's faithful scribe and friend.

Jeremiah's prayer: Nothing is too hard for you VERSES 16–25

16 After I had given the deed of purchase to Baruch, the
son of Neriah,
I prayed to the LORD. I said,
17 "Oh, Lord GOD!
Look, you have made the heavens and the earth
by your great power and by your outstretched arm.
There is nothing too hard for you.
18 You show faithful love to thousands,
but you pay back the guilt of the ancestors
into the lap of their children after them.
The great and mighty God, the LORD of Armies, is
your name.
19 You are great in your plans and mighty in your deeds.
Your eyes are open to all the ways of people,
to give each person what his ways deserve,
and what the fruit of his deeds deserves.

20 You did signs and wonders in the land of Egypt,
and you still do them to this day,
both in Israel and among other people.
You have made a name for yourself, as it is today.
21 You brought your people Israel out of the land of Egypt
with signs, with wonders, with a strong hand,
with an outstretched arm, and with great terror.
22 You gave them this land,
which you swore to their ancestors to give them,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
23 They came in and took it over,
but they didn't obey your voice,
and didn't walk in your law.
They have done nothing of all that you commanded them to do.
That is why you have brought all this disaster on them.
24 "Look, siege ramps have been built against the city to capture it.
Because of the sword, the famine, and disease,
the city is handed over to the Chaldeans who are fighting against it.
What you have said has happened.
Look, you see it.
25 Yet you have said to me, Lord GOD,
'Buy the field for money, and call witnesses,'
while the city is handed over to the Chaldeans."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: "There is nothing too hard for you." Jeremiah trusts God's power.

Verses 18–23: He remembers God's great deeds in history, the exodus from Egypt and the land that God gave. But the people did not listen.

Verses 24–25: And then the honest question: God, the enemies are standing outside the city, and you tell me to buy a field? How does that fit together? Jeremiah obeys, but he does not fully understand it.

God's answer: judgment VERSES 26–35

26 Then the LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
27 "Look, I am the LORD, the God of all people.
Is there anything too hard for me?
28 So the LORD says:
Look, I will give this city into the hand of the Chaldeans,
and into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
and he will capture it.
29 The Chaldeans who are fighting against this city will come
and set this city on fire.
They will burn it down,
with the houses on whose roofs people have burned incense to Baal,
and poured out drink offerings to other gods,
to make me angry.
30 "For the people of Israel and the people of Judah have done only what was evil in my eyes, since their youth.
The people of Israel have only made me angry with the work of their hands, says the LORD.
31 For this city has stirred up my anger and my fury
from the day that they built it until today,
so that I must remove it from my sight,
32 because of all the evil of the people of Israel and of the people of Judah,
which they have done to make me angry:
they, their kings, their princes,
their priests, their prophets,
the men of Judah, and the people of Jerusalem.
33 They have turned their backs to me, and not their faces.
I taught them early and tirelessly,
but they have not listened or accepted correction.
34 Instead, they put their disgusting idols in the house which is called by my name,
to make it unclean.
35 They built the high places of Baal in the valley of the son of Hinnom,
to make their sons and their daughters pass through the fire to Molech.
I didn't command them to do it.
It didn't even come into my mind
that they should do this disgusting thing,
and make Judah sin."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: God takes up Jeremiah's words: "Is there anything too hard for me?" Rescue after the judgment is not too hard for God either.

Verses 28–35: But first comes the judgment. God lists once more why: idol worship, making the temple unclean, and the worst crime, sacrificing children to the god Molech. God says again: That never came into my mind. Killing children is something disgusting to God.

God's answer: hope VERSES 36–44

36 So now the LORD, the God of Israel, says this about this city,
about which you say,
"It is handed over to the king of Babylon
by the sword, by famine, and by disease":
37 "Look, I will gather them out of all the countries where I have driven them in my anger, in my fury, and in great rage.
I will bring them back to this place,
and I will let them live in safety.
38 Then they will be my people,
and I will be their God.
39 I will give them one heart and one way,
so that they will fear me forever,
for their own good and the good of their children after them.
40 I will make a covenant with them that lasts forever:
I will not turn away from them,
but I will do them good.
I will put the fear of me in their hearts,
so that they will not turn away from me.
41 Yes, I will be glad to do them good,
and I will plant them firmly in this land
with my whole heart and with my whole soul."
42 For the LORD says:
"Just as I have brought all this great disaster on this people,

so I will bring on them all the good that I have
promised them.
43 Fields will be bought in this land,
about which you say,
'It is a waste, without people or animals.
It is handed over to the Chaldeans.'
44 People will buy fields for money,
sign the deeds, seal them, and call witnesses,
in the land of Benjamin,
and in the places around Jerusalem,
in the cities of Judah,
in the cities of the hill country,
in the cities of the lowland,
and in the cities of the South.
For I will turn around their fate," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the judgment comes hope:

Verses 37–38: God will bring his people back. "Then they will be my people, and I will be their God."

Verses 39–40: "A covenant ... that lasts forever," similar to the new covenant in chapter 31: God gives a new heart so that the people stay with him.

Verse 41 is especially beautiful: God is glad to do good. He says: I do it "with my whole heart and with my whole soul." Here God speaks of his whole heart and his whole soul, just as people are to love God with all their heart and all their soul (Deuteronomy 6:5).

Verses 43–44: And now it becomes clear why Jeremiah was to buy the field: It was a sign that life goes on. One day people will buy fields again all over the land.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 33

Call to me, and I will answer you

I will heal the city VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD's word came to Jeremiah a second time,
while he was still locked up in the courtyard of the
guard. He said,
2 "The LORD who does it,
the LORD who shapes it to make it firm,
the LORD is his name, says:
3 'Call to me, and I will answer you,
and I will show you great and hidden things,
which you don't know.'
4 For the LORD, the God of Israel,
says this about the houses of this city,
and about the houses of the kings of Judah,
which have been torn down to defend against the siege
ramps and against the sword:
5 'People come to fight against the Chaldeans,
but they will only fill these houses with the dead bodies
of people
whom I have struck down in my anger and in my fury.
For I have hidden my face from this city
because of all their evil.
6 But look, I will bring it health and healing,
and I will heal them.
I will show them great peace and faithfulness.
7 I will turn around the fate of Judah and Israel,
and I will build them as they were at the beginning.
8 I will make them clean from all their guilt
by which they have sinned against me.
I will forgive all their sins
by which they have sinned against me
and rebelled against me.
9 This city will bring me fame and joy,
praise and glory,
in front of all the nations of the earth.
They will hear about all the good that I do for them.
They will be afraid and tremble
because of all the good and all the peace that I give to
it.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jeremiah is still in prison, and outside the war is raging.

Verse 3 is a very popular verse: "Call to me, and I will answer you, and I will show you great and hidden things." God invites us to talk with him. He has answers that we cannot think up ourselves.

Verses 4–5: During the siege, houses are torn down so that their stones can strengthen the walls. The situation is hopeless.

Verses 6–9: And yet: God will heal the city, give it peace and faithfulness and forgive all its guilt. Jerusalem will be a place of joy again.

Sounds of joy again VERSES 10–13

10 The LORD says:
"About this place you say,
'It is a waste, without people and without animals.'
But in the cities of Judah,
and in the streets of Jerusalem,
that are ruined, without people, without anyone
living there, and without animals,
there will again be heard
11 the sound of joy and the sound of gladness,
the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,
the voice of those who say,
'Give thanks to the LORD of Armies,
for the LORD is good,
for his faithful love endures forever!'
as they bring thank offerings into the LORD's house.
For I will turn around the fate of the land
and make it as it was at the beginning," says the LORD.
12 The LORD of Armies says:
"In this place, which is a waste, without people and
without animals,
and in all its cities,
there will again be pastures
where shepherds let their flocks lie down.
13 In the cities of the hill country,
in the cities of the lowland,
in the cities of the South,

in the land of Benjamin,
in the places around Jerusalem,
and in the cities of Judah,
the flocks will again pass under the hands of the one
who counts them," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Jeremiah had announced several times that the voices of the bride and bridegroom would fall silent (7:34; 16:9; 25:10). Now this is reversed: People will celebrate weddings again and praise God: "Give thanks to the LORD of Armies, for the LORD is good, for his faithful love endures forever!" (as in Psalm 136). Jewish wedding blessings still recall these verses today.

Verses 12–13: The shepherds are counting their sheep again, a picture of peace and normal life.

The righteous Branch and God's faithfulness VERSES 14–26

14 "Look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will fulfill the good promise
which I have spoken about the house of Israel and
about the house of Judah.
15 "In those days and at that time,
I will make a righteous Branch grow up for David.
He will do justice and righteousness in the land.
16 In those days Judah will be saved,
and Jerusalem will live in safety.
This is the name by which she will be called:
The LORD our righteousness."
17 For the LORD says:
"David will never be without a man
to sit on the throne of the house of Israel.
18 The Levitical priests will never be without a man in
front of me
to offer burnt offerings,
to burn grain offerings,
and to offer sacrifices every day."
19 The LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
20 "The LORD says:
'If you can break my covenant with the day and my
covenant with the night,
so that day and night no longer come at their right
time,
21 then my covenant with David my servant could also be
broken,
so that he would have no son to rule on his throne,
and my covenant with the Levitical priests, who serve
me.
22 As the stars of the sky can't be counted,
and the sand of the sea can't be measured,
so I will make the descendants of David my servant
many,
and the Levites who serve me.'"
23 The LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
24 "Haven't you noticed what this people has said?
'Has the LORD rejected the two families which he
chose?'
That is how they despise my people,
as if they were no longer a nation in their eyes."
25 The LORD says:
"If my covenant with day and night fails,
if I have not set the laws of heaven and earth,
26 then I will also reject the descendants of Jacob and of
David my servant,
so that I will not take any of his descendants
to rule over the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and
Jacob.
But I will turn around their fate,
and I will have mercy on them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: The promise of David's "righteous Branch" from chapter 23:5–6 is repeated. This time Jerusalem itself is called "The LORD our righteousness." In Judaism this is applied to the coming Messiah; Christians apply it to Jesus.

Verses 17–18: God promises that there will always be a king from David's family and priests from the tribe of Levi. After the exile there was no king for a long time, and the temple was later destroyed. That is why Jews understand this promise as a hope for the future. Christians see it fulfilled in Jesus, whom the New Testament describes as a king from David's family and as high priest (Hebrews 7).

Verses 20–22: God's covenant is as sure as day and night. No one can break it.

Verses 24–26: Some said: God has rejected Israel and Judah. God answers: Never! As surely as there is day and night, I will have mercy on my people. This is a clear rejection of everyone who thinks God has cast off the Jewish people.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 34

The broken promise of freedom

A word to King Zedekiah VERSES 1–7

1 This is the word which came to Jeremiah from the
LORD,
when Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
with all his army,
and all the kingdoms of the earth that were under his
rule,
and all the peoples,
were fighting against Jerusalem and against all its
cities:
2 "The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Go and speak to Zedekiah, king of Judah, and tell him,
The LORD says,
"Look, I will give this city into the hand of the king of
Babylon,
and he will burn it with fire.
3 You won't escape out of his hand,
but you will surely be captured and handed over to
him.
You will see the king of Babylon with your own eyes,
and he will speak with you face to face.
You will go to Babylon."'

4 "Yet hear the LORD's word, Zedekiah, king of Judah.
The LORD says this about you:
'You won't die by the sword.
5 You will die in peace.
As people burned spices in honor of your ancestors,
the earlier kings who came before you,
so they will burn spices in your honor.
They will mourn for you and say, "Oh, lord!"
For I have spoken the word,' says the LORD."
6 Then Jeremiah the prophet spoke all these words to
Zedekiah, king of Judah, in Jerusalem,
7 while the army of the king of Babylon was fighting
against Jerusalem,
and against all the cities of Judah that were left,
against Lachish and against Azekah.
For these were the only fortified cities of Judah that
were left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: Again Jeremiah tells King Zedekiah: The city will fall, and you will be taken prisoner.

Verses 4–5: But Jeremiah also has a gentle word for him: Zedekiah will not die by the sword, but in peace, with an honorable burial. Burning spices was a custom of honor at the burial of kings (2 Chronicles 16:14).

Verse 7: Only three fortified cities were still holding out: Jerusalem, Lachish and Azekah. In Lachish, archaeologists have found pieces of pottery with letters from this time. In one of them an officer writes that the fire signals of Azekah can no longer be seen.

The slaves are set free – and taken back VERSES 8–22

8 The word came to Jeremiah from the LORD
after King Zedekiah had made a covenant with all the
people who were in Jerusalem,
to announce freedom to them:
9 Everyone was to set free his male and female slaves
who were Hebrews, men or women,
so that no one would keep a fellow Jew as a slave.
10 All the princes and all the people who had entered into
the covenant obeyed.
Everyone set free his male and female slaves,
so that no one would keep them as slaves anymore.
They obeyed and let them go.
11 But afterward they changed their minds.
They brought back the male and female slaves whom
they had set free,
and forced them to be slaves again.
12 That is why the LORD's word came to Jeremiah from
the LORD. He said,
13 "The LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I made a covenant with your ancestors
on the day that I brought them out of the land of
Egypt,
out of the house of slavery. I said:
14 At the end of seven years, each of you must set free his
fellow Hebrew
who has been sold to you and has served you for six
years.
You must let him go free.
But your ancestors didn't listen to me or pay attention.
15 Now you had turned back,
and had done what is right in my eyes,
by each of you announcing freedom to his neighbor.
You had made a covenant in front of me
in the house which is called by my name.
16 But then you turned around and dishonored my name.
Each of you brought back his male and female slaves,
whom you had set free to go wherever they wanted.
You forced them to be your slaves again.'"
17 That is why the LORD says:
"You have not listened to me
and announced freedom, each to his brother and to his
neighbor.
Look, now I announce a 'freedom' for you," says the
LORD,
"freedom for the sword, for disease, and for famine.
I will make you be tossed back and forth among all the
kingdoms of the earth.
18 I will hand over the men who have broken my
covenant,
who have not kept the words of the covenant which
they made in front of me,
when they cut the calf in two and walked between its
halves:
19 the princes of Judah, the princes of Jerusalem,
the court officials, the priests, and all the people of the
land,
who walked between the halves of the calf.
20 I will give them into the hand of their enemies,
and into the hand of those who want to kill them.
Their dead bodies will be food for the birds of the sky
and for the animals of the earth.
21 "I will give Zedekiah, king of Judah, and his princes
into the hands of their enemies,
into the hands of those who want to kill them,
and into the hands of the army of the king of Babylon,
which has withdrawn from you.
22 Look, I will give the command," says the LORD,
"and bring them back to this city.
They will fight against it, capture it, and burn it with
fire.
I will make the cities of Judah a waste,
with no one living in them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–10: During the siege, King Zedekiah had all Hebrew slaves set free. At that time, someone who could not pay his debts could sell himself as a servant. According to God's law, he had to be set free after six years (Exodus 21:2; Deuteronomy 15:12).

Verse 11: But then the Babylonians withdrew for a short time (compare verse 21; 37:5), and the rich simply took their slaves back. A broken promise as soon as the danger seemed to be over.

Verse 17: God answers with a bitter play on words: You have not announced "freedom"? Then I will announce a "freedom" for you, namely for the sword, disease and famine.

Verse 18: When a solemn covenant was made, an animal was cut in two and people walked between the halves. That meant: May the same happen to me if I break the covenant (compare Genesis 15:9–17).

Important: The Bible shows here that God is on the side of those who are not free, and that people must not be exploited. Today we know: No human being may belong to another. Human trafficking and forced labor still exist today. If you are affected by it or notice something, you can go to the police: In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 35

The faithful Rechabites

The Rechabites drink no wine VERSES 1–11

1 This is the word which came to Jeremiah from the LORD
in the days of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah:
2 "Go to the family of the Rechabites, and speak to them.
Bring them into the LORD's house, into one of the rooms,
and give them wine to drink."
3 Then I took Jaazaniah, the son of Jeremiah, the son of Habazziniah,
with his brothers, all his sons,
and the whole family of the Rechabites.
4 I brought them into the LORD's house,
into the room of the sons of Hanan, the son of Igdaliah, the man of God.
It was next to the room of the princes,
above the room of Maaseiah, the son of Shallum, the doorkeeper.
5 I set bowls full of wine and cups in front of the men of the Rechabite family,
and I said to them, "Drink wine!"
6 But they said, "We will drink no wine.
For Jonadab, the son of Rechab, our ancestor, commanded us:
'You must never drink wine,
neither you nor your children, forever.
7 You must not build a house, sow seed, or plant a vineyard,
or own any of these.
Instead, you must live in tents all your life,
so that you may live many days in the land where you live as nomads.'
8 We have obeyed the voice of Jonadab, the son of Rechab, our ancestor,
in everything he commanded us.
We drink no wine all our lives,
we, our wives, our sons, and our daughters.
9 We don't build houses to live in.
We have no vineyard, field, or seed.
10 We have lived in tents,
and have obeyed, and done everything that our ancestor Jonadab commanded us.
11 But when Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, came up into the land, we said,
'Come! Let's go to Jerusalem,
because we are afraid of the army of the Chaldeans
and of the army of the Syrians.
So we will live in Jerusalem.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Rechabites were a group who lived by the rules of their ancestor Jonadab (he is mentioned in 2 Kings 10:15–23, about 250 years earlier). They drank no wine, built no houses and lived in tents like nomads. That was how they wanted to live simply and faithfully to God, without tying themselves to the wealth of the land.

Verses 5–6: Jeremiah puts them to the test: He offers them wine in the temple. But they refuse. They stay faithful to their promise, even after so many generations.

Verse 11: They moved into the city only because of the war, out of need, not out of unfaithfulness.

If you have problems with alcohol, you can find help. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

An example for the people VERSES 12–19

12 Then the LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
13 "The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Go and tell the men of Judah and the people of Jerusalem,
"Won't you accept correction and listen to my words?" says the LORD.
14 "The words of Jonadab, the son of Rechab, have been kept.
He commanded his sons not to drink wine,
and to this day they drink none,
for they obey their ancestor's command.
But I have spoken to you early and tirelessly,
and you have not listened to me.
15 I have also sent you all my servants the prophets,
early and tirelessly.
They said, 'Each of you, turn back now from your evil way,
change your deeds,
and don't follow other gods to serve them.
Then you will live in the land which I have given to you and to your ancestors.'
But you have not paid attention or listened to me.
16 The sons of Jonadab, the son of Rechab, have kept the command
that their ancestor gave them,
but this people has not listened to me."'
17 "That is why the LORD, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Look, I will bring on Judah and on all the people of Jerusalem
all the disaster that I have announced against them,
because I have spoken to them, but they have not listened,
and I have called to them, but they have not answered.'"

18 Jeremiah said to the family of the Rechabites,
"The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'You have obeyed the command of your ancestor
Jonadab,
and kept all his rules,
and done everything that he commanded you.'
19 That is why the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Jonadab, the son of Rechab, will never be without a
man
to stand in front of me.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God uses the Rechabites as an example: For generations they have faithfully kept the command of a human being, their ancestor. But God's people do not even listen to God himself, although he has called them again and again.

Verse 19: The Rechabites receive a promise: Their family will never die out and will always stand before God. Faithfulness is rewarded.

The message is not that all people should drink no wine or live in tents. It is about being faithful to what you have promised.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 36

The king burns the scroll

Baruch writes and reads aloud VERSES 1–10

1 In the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah,
this word came to Jeremiah from the LORD:
2 "Take a scroll,
and write in it all the words that I have spoken to you against Israel, against Judah, and against all the nations,
from the day I first spoke to you, in the days of Josiah, until today.
3 Perhaps the house of Judah will hear
about all the disaster which I plan to bring on them,
so that they turn back, each from his evil way.
Then I can forgive their guilt and their sin."
4 Then Jeremiah called Baruch, the son of Neriah.
As Jeremiah spoke, Baruch wrote on a scroll
all the words that the LORD had spoken to him.
5 Jeremiah commanded Baruch:
"I am kept away.
I can't go into the LORD's house.
6 So you go,
and read the LORD's words from the scroll which you have written as I spoke.
Read them to the people in the LORD's house on the day of fasting.
Also read them to all the people of Judah who come in from their cities.
7 Perhaps they will bring their prayer for mercy to the LORD,
and each will turn back from his evil way.
For the LORD has announced great anger and fury against this people."
8 Baruch, the son of Neriah, did everything that Jeremiah the prophet commanded him.
He read the LORD's words from the book in the LORD's house.
9 In the fifth year of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah, king of Judah, in the ninth month,
all the people in Jerusalem,
and all the people who came from the cities of Judah to Jerusalem,
announced a fast before the LORD.
10 Then Baruch read the words of Jeremiah from the book in the LORD's house,
in the room of Gemariah, the son of Shaphan, the scribe,
in the upper courtyard, at the entrance of the New Gate of the LORD's house,
so that all the people heard it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: Jeremiah is to write down all the messages of the last 23 years. The reason: "Perhaps the house of Judah will hear … so that they turn back … Then I can forgive their guilt and their sin." God does not want to punish; he wants to forgive.

Verse 4: Jeremiah dictates, Baruch writes. That is probably how part of the book of Jeremiah came into being.

Verse 5: Jeremiah is no longer allowed into the temple, probably after the temple speech (Chapters 7 and 26).

Verses 6 and 9: Baruch reads the scroll aloud on a day of fasting, when many people are in the temple. Perhaps the fast had been announced because of the threat from Babylon.

The officials listen VERSES 11–19

11 Micaiah, the son of Gemariah, the son of Shaphan, heard all the LORD's words from the book.
12 Then he went down to the king's palace, into the scribe's room.
And look, all the princes were sitting there:
Elishama the scribe,
Delaiah the son of Shemaiah,
Elnathan the son of Achbor,
Gemariah the son of Shaphan,
Zedekiah the son of Hananiah,
and all the other princes.
13 Then Micaiah told them all the words that he had heard when Baruch read the book to the people.
14 So all the princes sent Jehudi, the son of Nethaniah, the son of Shelemiah, the son of Cushi, to Baruch.
They told him, "Take the scroll that you read to the people,
and come."
So Baruch, the son of Neriah, took the scroll in his hand,
and came to them.

15 They said to him,
"Sit down now, and read it to us."
So Baruch read it to them.
16 When they had heard all the words,
they turned to one another in fear,
and said to Baruch,
"We must tell the king all these words."
17 They asked Baruch,
"Tell us now, how did you write all these words?
Did he dictate them to you?"
18 Baruch answered them,
"He spoke all these words to me,
and I wrote them in the book with ink."
19 Then the princes said to Baruch,
"You and Jeremiah, go and hide.
Don't let anyone know where you are."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The officials are shocked by what they hear. They take the words seriously.

Verses 17–18: They want to know exactly whether these are really Jeremiah's words. Baruch explains: Jeremiah dictated; I wrote with ink.

Verse 19: The officials know their king. They know that he is dangerous (compare the murder of Uriah, 26:20–23). That is why they warn Baruch and Jeremiah: Hide!

The king burns the scroll VERSES 20–26

20 They went in to the king in the courtyard,
but they had left the scroll in the room of Elishama the scribe.
They told the king all the words.
21 So the king sent Jehudi to get the scroll,
and he took it out of the room of Elishama the scribe.
Jehudi read it to the king,
and to all the princes who stood beside the king.
22 The king was sitting in the winter house.
It was the ninth month,
and a fire was burning in the fire pot in front of him.
23 Whenever Jehudi had read three or four columns,
the king cut them off with a knife,
and threw them into the fire in the fire pot,
until the whole scroll was burned up in the fire.
24 The king and his servants who heard all these words
were not afraid,
and they didn't tear their clothes.
25 Elnathan, Delaiah, and Gemariah had begged the king
not to burn the scroll,
but he would not listen to them.
26 The king commanded Jerahmeel, the king's son,
Seraiah, the son of Azriel,
and Shelemiah, the son of Abdeel,
to arrest Baruch the scribe and Jeremiah the prophet.
But the LORD hid them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A dramatic scene: It is winter; the king is sitting by the warm fire pot. Jehudi reads aloud. After each part, the king cuts off what has been read with a knife and throws it into the fire. Piece by piece, until the whole scroll is burned.

Verse 24: No one is afraid, no one tears his clothes (a sign of being sorry). What a contrast to Jehoiakim's father Josiah: When a book of the law was read to him, he tore his clothes in shock and turned back (2 Kings 22:11).

Verse 25: Only three officials have the courage to ask the king not to burn the scroll.

Verse 26: The king wants to have Jeremiah and Baruch arrested, but God has hidden them.

A new scroll VERSES 27–32

27 After the king had burned the scroll
with the words which Baruch had written as Jeremiah spoke,
the LORD's word came to Jeremiah. He said,
28 "Take another scroll,
and write in it all the words that were in the first scroll,
which Jehoiakim, king of Judah, has burned.
29 And say about Jehoiakim, king of Judah,
'The LORD says:
"You have burned this scroll, and said,
'Why have you written in it:
"The king of Babylon will certainly come and destroy this land,
and will wipe out both people and animals from it"?'"
30 That is why the LORD says this about Jehoiakim, king of Judah:
"He will have no one to sit on David's throne.
His dead body will be thrown out,
into the heat by day and into the frost by night.
31 I will punish him, his descendants, and his servants for their guilt.
I will bring on them, on the people of Jerusalem, and on the men of Judah,
all the disaster that I have announced against them.
But they didn't listen."'"
32 Then Jeremiah took another scroll,
and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah.
As Jeremiah spoke, Baruch wrote in it
all the words of the book which Jehoiakim, king of Judah, had burned in the fire.
And many similar words were added to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: God's word cannot be burned. Jeremiah and Baruch write everything down again.

Verse 30: Jehoiakim's son Jehoiachin ruled for only three months, then he was carried off (compare 22:30). And Jehoiakim himself was not to have an honorable burial (compare 22:19).

Verse 32: The new scroll was even longer than the first. You can burn a book, but not the truth that is in it. In the course of history, powerful people have burned books and Bibles again and again, but God's word has remained.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 37

Jeremiah in prison

The Babylonians withdraw for a short time VERSES 1–10

1 Zedekiah, the son of Josiah, ruled as king
in the place of Coniah, the son of Jehoiakim.
Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, had made Zedekiah
king in the land of Judah.
2 But neither he, nor his servants, nor the people of the land
listened to the LORD's words,
which he spoke through the prophet Jeremiah.
3 King Zedekiah sent Jehucal, the son of Shelemiah,
and Zephaniah, the son of Maaseiah, the priest,
to the prophet Jeremiah. They said,
"Please pray to the LORD our God for us."
4 At that time Jeremiah could still come and go among the people,
for they had not put him in prison yet.
5 Pharaoh's army had come out of Egypt.
When the Chaldeans who were besieging Jerusalem
heard the news about them,
they withdrew from Jerusalem.
6 Then the LORD's word came to the prophet Jeremiah.
He said,
7 "The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Tell the king of Judah, who sent you to me to ask me:
"Look, Pharaoh's army, which has come out to help you,
will go back to Egypt, to its own land.
8 The Chaldeans will come back,
and fight against this city.
They will capture it and burn it with fire."'
9 "The LORD says,
'Don't deceive yourselves by saying,
"The Chaldeans will surely go away from us,"
for they will not go away.
10 For even if you had defeated the whole army of the Chaldeans who fight against you,
and only wounded men were left among them,
each of them would get up in his tent
and burn this city with fire.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Zedekiah asks Jeremiah to pray. He respects Jeremiah, but he still does not listen to him. He is a weak king who cannot make up his mind.

Verse 5: Suddenly hope rises: Egypt sends an army, and the Babylonians withdraw. Everyone thinks: We are saved!

Verses 7–10: But Jeremiah says: Don't deceive yourselves! The Egyptians will turn back, and the Babylonians will return. Even if only wounded men were left, they would capture the city. God's plan stands firm.

Jeremiah is arrested VERSES 11–21

11 When the army of the Chaldeans had withdrawn from Jerusalem
out of fear of Pharaoh's army,
12 Jeremiah set out from Jerusalem to go to the land of Benjamin,
to receive his share of land there among the people.
13 When he was at the Benjamin Gate,
a captain of the guard was there whose name was Irijah,
the son of Shelemiah, the son of Hananiah.
He seized Jeremiah the prophet and said,
"You are deserting to the Chaldeans!"
14 Jeremiah said, "That is a lie!
I am not deserting to the Chaldeans."
But Irijah didn't listen to him.
He seized Jeremiah and brought him to the princes.
15 The princes were angry with Jeremiah.
They beat him and put him in prison in the house of Jonathan the scribe,
for they had turned it into a prison.
16 Jeremiah was put into a dungeon, into the cells,
and he stayed there many days.
17 Then King Zedekiah sent for him and had him brought out.
The king asked him secretly in his palace,
"Is there any word from the LORD?"
Jeremiah said, "There is."
And he said, "You will be handed over to the king of Babylon."
18 Jeremiah also said to King Zedekiah,
"What wrong have I done against you, against your servants, or against this people,
that you have put me in prison?
19 Where are your prophets now who prophesied to you
and said,
'The king of Babylon will not come against you or against this land'?
20 Now please listen, my lord the king.
Please accept my request,
and don't send me back to the house of Jonathan the scribe,
or I will die there."
21 Then King Zedekiah gave the command,
and they kept Jeremiah in the courtyard of the guard.
Every day they gave him a loaf of bread from the Bakers' Street,
until all the bread in the city was gone.
So Jeremiah stayed in the courtyard of the guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Jeremiah wants to use the short break to settle a family matter in his home area of Benjamin, perhaps an inheritance.

Verses 13–15: But he is suspected of deserting to the enemy. Because he had always said that people should surrender, no one believes him. He is beaten and thrown into an underground prison.

Verse 17: The king secretly sends for him and asks: "Is there any word from the LORD?" Jeremiah stays honest, even though it is dangerous: "There is." … "You will be handed over to the king of Babylon."

Verse 19: Jeremiah rightly asks: Where are the prophets now who said that Babylon would not come?

Verses 20–21: Jeremiah asks not to have to go back to the terrible underground prison. The king has pity and has him

kept in the courtyard of the guard, with one loaf of bread a day.

Anyone today who is persecuted or locked up though innocent can recognize themselves in Jeremiah. Many people in many countries still suffer in prison today because of their faith or their opinion.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 38

In the cistern

Jeremiah is thrown into the cistern VERSES 1–6

1 Shephatiah, the son of Mattan,
Gedaliah, the son of Pashhur,
Jucal, the son of Shelemiah,
and Pashhur, the son of Malchijah,
heard the words that Jeremiah was speaking to all the people. He said,
2 "The LORD says,
'Whoever stays in this city will die by the sword, by famine, and by disease.
But whoever goes out to the Chaldeans will live.
He will escape with his life, and he will live.'
3 The LORD says,
'This city will surely be handed over to the army of the king of Babylon,
and he will capture it.'"
4 Then the princes said to the king,
"Please have this man put to death.
For by speaking such words,
he is making the soldiers who are left in this city lose courage,
and all the people too.
This man is not looking for the good of this people,
but for their harm."
5 King Zedekiah said,
"Look, he is in your hands,
for the king can't do anything against you."
6 Then they took Jeremiah
and threw him into the cistern of Malchijah, the king's son,
which was in the courtyard of the guard.
They let Jeremiah down with ropes.
There was no water in the cistern, only mud,
and Jeremiah sank into the mud.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: The princes say: Jeremiah is destroying the soldiers' courage. He is a traitor. In times of war, uncomfortable voices are often called traitors.

Verse 5: King Zedekiah is so weak that he simply hands Jeremiah over: "Look, he is in your hands, for the king can't do anything against you."

Verse 6: Jeremiah is thrown into an empty cistern, a deep hole in the rock in which rainwater was collected. At the bottom there is only mud. Jeremiah sinks into it. They leave him there to die, without laying a hand on him themselves.

Ebedmelech saves Jeremiah VERSES 7–13

7 Ebedmelech the Ethiopian, a court official, was in the king's palace.
He heard that they had put Jeremiah into the cistern.
At that time the king was sitting in the Benjamin Gate.
8 Ebedmelech went out of the king's palace,
and spoke to the king. He said,
9 "My lord the king,
these men have done evil in everything they have done to Jeremiah the prophet.
They have thrown him into the cistern.
He will die of hunger where he is,
for there is no more bread in the city."
10 Then the king commanded Ebedmelech the Ethiopian:
"Take 30 men from here with you,
and pull Jeremiah the prophet up out of the cistern before he dies."
11 So Ebedmelech took the men with him,
and went into the king's palace, to a room under the treasury.
From there he took old rags and worn-out clothes,
and let them down with ropes into the cistern to Jeremiah.
12 Ebedmelech the Ethiopian said to Jeremiah,
"Put these old rags and worn-out clothes under your armpits,
under the ropes."
Jeremiah did so.
13 So they pulled Jeremiah up with the ropes,
and lifted him out of the cistern.
And Jeremiah stayed in the courtyard of the guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The hero of this story is Ebedmelech. His name means "servant of the king." He is a Cushite, that is, an African from the land south of Egypt (the WEB has "the Ethiopian"). He is a foreigner and a eunuch, that is, a court official, who often had little respect. Yet he is the one who has the courage that the king and the princes do not have.

Verse 9: He goes straight to the king and says publicly: What these men have done is evil!

Verses 11–12: A beautiful detail: Ebedmelech thinks of everything. He gets old rags so that the ropes will not cut into Jeremiah's armpits. He does not only save his life; he is also caring and gentle.

Ebedmelech shows: Humanity and courage do not depend on where you come from, the color of your skin or your position. God rewards him for it later (39:15–18).

A secret conversation with the king VERSES 14–28

14 Then King Zedekiah sent for Jeremiah the prophet,
and had him brought to him at the third entrance of the LORD's house.
The king said to Jeremiah,

"I will ask you something.
Don't hide anything from me."
15 Then Jeremiah said to Zedekiah,
"If I tell you, won't you surely put me to death?
And if I give you advice, you will not listen to me."
16 So King Zedekiah swore secretly to Jeremiah. He said,
"As surely as the LORD lives, who gave us our life,
I will not put you to death,
and I will not hand you over to these men who want to kill you."
17 Then Jeremiah said to Zedekiah,
"The LORD, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'If you will surrender to the princes of the king of Babylon,
then your life will be spared,
and this city will not be burned with fire.
You and your family will live.
18 But if you will not surrender to the princes of the king of Babylon,
then this city will be handed over to the Chaldeans.
They will burn it with fire,
and you won't escape out of their hand.'"
19 King Zedekiah said to Jeremiah,
"I am afraid of the Jews who have deserted to the Chaldeans.
They might hand me over to them,
and they will make fun of me."
20 But Jeremiah said, "They won't hand you over.
Please obey the LORD's voice in what I am telling you.
Then it will go well with you,
and your life will be spared.
21 But if you refuse to surrender,
this is what the LORD has shown me:
22 'Look, all the women who are left in the palace of the king of Judah
will be brought out to the princes of the king of Babylon.
Those women will say,
"Your close friends have deceived you,
and they have won against you.
Now that your feet are sunk in the mud,
they have turned away from you."
23 They will bring out all your wives and your children to the Chaldeans.
You won't escape out of their hand,
but you will be captured by the king of Babylon.
And you will be the cause of this city being burned with fire.'"
24 Then Zedekiah said to Jeremiah,
"Don't let anyone know about these words,
and you won't die.
25 But if the princes hear that I have talked with you,
and they come to you and say to you,
'Tell us now what you said to the king.
Don't hide it from us, and we will not put you to death.
Also tell us what the king said to you,'
26 then tell them,
'I was begging the king
not to send me back to Jonathan's house to die there.'"
27 Then all the princes came to Jeremiah and asked him,
and he told them exactly what the king had commanded.
So they stopped questioning him,
for no one had heard the conversation.
28 So Jeremiah stayed in the courtyard of the guard
until the day that Jerusalem was captured.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: Once more a secret meeting. The king wants to hear the truth, but Jeremiah is careful: Will you kill me? Will you even listen?

Verses 17–18: Jeremiah's advice is clear: Surrender, then you will save your life, your family and the city.

Verse 19: Zedekiah's real problem is fear, fear of mockery and humiliation. He knows what would be right, but he does not have the courage to do it.

Verse 22: A mocking song: "Your feet are sunk in the mud." That is bitter: Jeremiah really had sunk into the mud. Now the king himself will be "stuck in the mud."

Verses 24–27: The king is more afraid of his own princes than of God. Jeremiah tells the princes only part of the truth to protect his life.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 39

Jerusalem falls

The city is captured VERSES 1–10

1 In the ninth year of Zedekiah, king of Judah, in the tenth month,
Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, and his whole army came against Jerusalem,
and besieged it.
2 In the eleventh year of Zedekiah, in the fourth month,
on the ninth day of the month,
the city wall was broken through.
3 All the princes of the king of Babylon came in,
and sat down in the Middle Gate:
Nergal Sharezer, Samgarnebo,
Sarsechim the Rabsaris,
Nergal Sharezer the Rabmag,
and all the rest of the princes of the king of Babylon.
4 When Zedekiah, king of Judah, and all the soldiers saw them,
they fled and left the city by night,
by way of the king's garden,
through the gate between the two walls.
The king went out toward the Arabah.
5 But the army of the Chaldeans chased them,
and caught up with Zedekiah in the plains of Jericho.
They captured him and brought him up
to Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, at Riblah in the land of Hamath.
There Nebuchadnezzar passed judgment on him.

6 Then the king of Babylon killed Zedekiah's sons in Riblah,
in front of his eyes.
The king of Babylon also killed all the nobles of Judah.
7 He also put out Zedekiah's eyes,
and bound him in chains to take him to Babylon.
8 The Chaldeans burned the king's palace and the people's houses with fire,
and broke down the walls of Jerusalem.
9 Then Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
carried away to Babylon as captives
the rest of the people who were left in the city,
and the deserters who had gone over to him,
and the rest of the people who were left.
10 But Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
left some of the poor people, who had nothing, in the land of Judah.
At that time he gave them vineyards and fields.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now what Jeremiah had announced for 40 years happens.

Verses 1–2: The siege lasted about a year and a half (588–587 BC). Then the Babylonians broke through the wall.

Verse 3: "Rabsaris" and "Rabmag" are Babylonian titles, something like "chief court official" and "chief of the magicians" (advisers).

Verses 4–5: King Zedekiah flees during the night, but is captured near Jericho.

Verses 6–7: What happens next is cruel: Zedekiah has to watch his sons being killed. After that, his eyes are put out. The last thing he saw was the death of his children. The Bible reports this cruelty soberly. It shows how terrible war is. Violence against prisoners and children is a crime.

Verse 8: The royal palace and the houses are burned, and the walls are torn down. (The destruction of the temple is told in chapter 52.)

Verse 10: A surprising turn: The poor, who had nothing, stay in the land and even receive vineyards and fields. Things are turned around.

Anyone who has been traumatized by war and violence needs help. Help is available: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Jeremiah is set free VERSES 11–14

11 Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, gave Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
a command about Jeremiah. He said,
12 "Take him, and look after him.
Do him no harm,
but do for him whatever he asks you."
13 So Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
Nebushazban the Rabsaris,
Nergal Sharezer the Rabmag,
and all the chief officers of the king of Babylon
14 sent and took Jeremiah out of the courtyard of the guard.
They handed him over to Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan,
to take him home.
So he lived among the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Of all people, it is the enemy king who treats Jeremiah well. Perhaps he had heard that Jeremiah had advised surrender.

Verse 14: Jeremiah is handed over to Gedaliah. Gedaliah is the son of Ahikam, who had already saved Jeremiah earlier (26:24). The family of Shaphan stays loyal to Jeremiah. Gedaliah soon becomes governor of the land (Chapter 40).

(Jeremiah 40:1–6 tells about this release somewhat differently and in more detail.)

A promise for Ebedmelech VERSES 15–18

15 The LORD's word had come to Jeremiah
while he was locked up in the courtyard of the guard.
He said,
16 "Go and speak to Ebedmelech the Ethiopian. Say,
'The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Look, I will make my words come true against this city,
for disaster and not for good.
On that day they will happen in front of your eyes.
17 But I will rescue you on that day," says the LORD.
"You will not be handed over to the men you are afraid of.
18 For I will surely save you.
You won't fall by the sword,
but you will escape with your life,
because you have put your trust in me," says the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God does not forget what Ebedmelech did for Jeremiah. The foreign man from Cush who had the courage to pull Jeremiah out of the mud is saved.

Verse 18: The reason: "Because you have put your trust in me." Ebedmelech was not an Israelite, but he trusted God. God's rescue is for everyone who trusts him, no matter where they come from.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 40

Gedaliah, the governor

Jeremiah may choose VERSES 1–6

1 This is the word which came to Jeremiah from the LORD,
after Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard, had let him go from Ramah.
He had taken him there bound in chains
among all the captives of Jerusalem and Judah
who were being carried away to Babylon.
2 The captain of the guard took Jeremiah and said to him,

"The LORD your God announced this disaster against this place.
3 And the LORD has brought it about,
and has done just as he said.
Because you have sinned against the LORD,
and have not obeyed his voice,
this has happened to you.
4 Now look, today I am setting you free
from the chains on your hands.
If you want to come with me to Babylon, come,
and I will take care of you.
But if you don't want to come with me to Babylon,
don't.
Look, the whole land is in front of you.
Go wherever you think it is good and right to go."
5 Before Jeremiah turned to go, Nebuzaradan said,
"Go back to Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan,
whom the king of Babylon has made governor over the cities of Judah,
and live with him among the people.
Or go wherever you think it is right to go."
So the captain of the guard gave him food and a gift, and let him go.
6 Then Jeremiah went to Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, at Mizpah,
and lived with him among the people who were left in the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Jeremiah had first been put in chains with the other prisoners and taken as far as Ramah. Ramah was a gathering place for those being carried off (compare 31:15: Rachel weeps in Ramah).

Verses 2–3: Amazing: A Babylonian officer says what Jeremiah had always said: This happened because the people did not listen to God. Even a foreigner sees it.

Verse 4: Jeremiah may choose: to go to Babylon and be taken care of, or to stay in the destroyed land. Jeremiah decides to stay with his people, with the poor in the land.

(Jeremiah 39:14 tells more briefly that Jeremiah was taken out of the courtyard of the guard and handed over to Gedaliah. Probably he afterward ended up among the lines of prisoners and was set free again in Ramah.)

Gedaliah gathers the people VERSES 7–12

7 All the army commanders who were out in the countryside, they and their men,
heard that the king of Babylon had made Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, governor in the land.
They heard that he had put him in charge of men, women, and children,
and of the poorest people of the land,
those who had not been carried away to Babylon.
8 So they came to Gedaliah at Mizpah:
Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah,
Johanan and Jonathan, the sons of Kareah,
Seraiah, the son of Tanhumeth,
the sons of Ephai the Netophathite,
and Jezaniah, the son of the Maacathite,
they and their men.
9 Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan,
swore an oath to them and to their men. He said,
"Don't be afraid to serve the Chaldeans.
Live in the land,
and serve the king of Babylon,
and it will go well with you.
10 As for me, look, I will live at Mizpah,
to represent you in front of the Chaldeans who come to us.
But you, gather wine, summer fruit, and oil,
and put them in your storage jars,
and live in your towns that you have taken over."
11 All the Jews who were in Moab,
and among the people of Ammon,
and in Edom,
and in all the other countries,
also heard that the king of Babylon had left some people in Judah,
and that he had put Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, over them.
12 Then all the Jews came back from all the places where they had been driven.
They came to the land of Judah, to Gedaliah at Mizpah,
and gathered a very large harvest of wine and summer fruit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: After the war, groups of soldiers are still scattered throughout the land. Their leaders come to Gedaliah.

Verses 9–10: Gedaliah gives the same advice Jeremiah gave: Submit to Babylon and live in peace. Harvest, lay up supplies, build a life for yourselves.

Verses 11–12: Many refugees return from the neighboring countries. There is a rich harvest. For a short time it looks as if a new beginning could succeed in the destroyed land.

A warning that is not heeded VERSES 13–16

13 Johanan, the son of Kareah,
and all the army commanders who had been out in the countryside,
came to Gedaliah at Mizpah,
14 and said to him,
"Do you know that Baalis, the king of the people of Ammon,
has sent Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, to kill you?"
But Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, didn't believe them.
15 Then Johanan, the son of Kareah, spoke to Gedaliah secretly in Mizpah. He said,
"Please let me go, and I will kill Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah.
No one will know about it.
Why should he kill you,
so that all the Jews who have gathered around you are scattered,
and the rest of Judah is destroyed?"
16 But Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, said to Johanan, the son of Kareah,
"You must not do this,
for what you are saying about Ishmael is not true."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gedaliah is warned of a plot to murder him. Johanan offers to kill Ishmael secretly beforehand.

Gedaliah refuses. He does not want anyone to be killed on mere suspicion, and he believes in the good in Ishmael.

That is honorable, but sadly too trusting, as the next chapter shows.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 41

The murder of Gedaliah

Ishmael kills Gedaliah VERSES 1–10

1 In the seventh month,
Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, the son of Elishama,
who was from the royal family and one of the king's chief officers,
came with 10 men to Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, at Mizpah.
There at Mizpah they ate a meal together.
2 Then Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, and the 10 men who were with him got up.
They struck down Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, with the sword,
and killed him,
the man whom the king of Babylon had made governor over the land.
3 Ishmael also killed all the Jews who were with Gedaliah at Mizpah,
and the Chaldean soldiers who were there.
4 On the second day after he had killed Gedaliah,
before anyone knew about it,
5 80 men came from Shechem, from Shiloh, and from Samaria.
Their beards were shaved, their clothes were torn, and they had cut themselves.
They had grain offerings and frankincense in their hands,
to bring them to the LORD's house.
6 Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, went out from Mizpah to meet them,
weeping all the way as he went.
When he met them, he said to them,
"Come to Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam."
7 When they came into the middle of the city,
Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, and the men who were with him
killed them and threw them into a pit.
8 But there were 10 men among them who said to Ishmael,
"Don't kill us!
For we have supplies hidden in the field:
wheat, barley, oil, and honey."
So he held back, and didn't kill them along with their companions.
9 Ishmael threw all the dead bodies of the men he had killed
along with Gedaliah into a large pit.
King Asa had made it when he was afraid of Baasha, king of Israel.
Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, filled it with those he had killed.
10 Then Ishmael took captive all the rest of the people who were in Mizpah,
including the king's daughters,
all the people who remained in Mizpah,
whom Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard, had put in the care of Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam.
Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, took them captive,
and set out to go over to the people of Ammon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Ishmael comes as a guest, eats a meal with Gedaliah, and then murders him. Abusing hospitality was considered especially shameful. Ishmael came from the royal family. Perhaps he wanted to rule himself, or he saw Gedaliah as a traitor because he worked together with Babylon.

Verse 5: A group of 80 pilgrims from the north come in mourning to offer sacrifices at the destroyed temple. Ishmael lures them into the city with false tears and murders them. A cruel, senseless crime.

Verse 8: The 10 men save their lives because they offer supplies. Greed is stronger than the lust to kill.

To this day, Jews remember this murder with a day of fasting, the "Fast of Gedaliah," shortly after the Jewish New Year. It destroyed the last hope for a life in the land after the destruction of Jerusalem.

Violence breeds new violence. No political goal justifies murder.

Johanan frees the captives VERSES 11–18

11 But Johanan, the son of Kareah, and all the army commanders who were with him
heard about all the evil that Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, had done.
12 So they took all their men,
and went to fight against Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah.
They found him by the great pool in Gibeon.
13 When all the people who were with Ishmael
saw Johanan, the son of Kareah, and all the army commanders who were with him,
they were glad.
14 So all the people whom Ishmael had taken captive from Mizpah
turned around and came back,
and went over to Johanan, the son of Kareah.
15 But Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, escaped from Johanan with eight men,
and went to the people of Ammon.
16 Then Johanan, the son of Kareah, and all the army commanders who were with him
took all the rest of the people from Mizpah,
whom he had rescued from Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah,
after Ishmael had killed Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam:
the soldiers, the women, the children, and the

eunuchs,
whom he had brought back from Gibeon.
17 They set out and stayed at Geruth Chimham, near Bethlehem,
on their way to go to Egypt,
18 because of the Chaldeans.
For they were afraid of them,
because Ishmael, the son of Nethaniah, had killed Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam,
whom the king of Babylon had made governor over the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–15: Johanan pursues Ishmael and frees the captives. Ishmael himself escapes.
Verses 16–18: Now the survivors are very afraid: The Babylonians could punish them for the murder of their governor. They want to flee to Egypt.
Verse 16: "Eunuchs" were officials at the royal court.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 42

Should we go to Egypt?

The people ask Jeremiah for advice VERSES 1–6

1 Then all the army commanders,
Johanan, the son of Kareah,
Jezaniah, the son of Hoshaiah,
and all the people, from the least to the greatest, came near.
2 They said to Jeremiah the prophet,
"Please listen to our request,
and pray for us to the LORD your God,
for all of us who are left.
For only a few of us are left out of many,
as you can see with your own eyes.
3 Pray that the LORD your God may show us the way we should go,
and what we should do."
4 Then Jeremiah the prophet said to them,
"I have heard you.
Look, I will pray to the LORD your God as you have asked.
Whatever the LORD answers you, I will tell you.
I will keep nothing back from you."
5 Then they said to Jeremiah,
"May the LORD be a true and faithful witness among us,
if we don't do everything that the LORD your God sends you to tell us.
6 Whether it is good or bad,
we will obey the voice of the LORD our God, to whom we are sending you,
so that it may go well with us
when we obey the voice of the LORD our God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The survivors come to Jeremiah and ask him: Ask God for us what we should do.
Verses 5–6: They solemnly promise: Whatever God says, whether we like it or not, we will obey.
A beautiful promise. But you can tell: They have actually already decided to go to Egypt (41:17).

God's answer: Stay in the land! VERSES 7–22

7 After 10 days, the LORD's word came to Jeremiah.
8 Then he called Johanan, the son of Kareah,
and all the army commanders who were with him,
and all the people, from the least to the greatest.
9 He said to them,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, to whom you sent me to bring your request, says:
10 'If you will stay in this land,
then I will build you up, and not tear you down.
I will plant you, and not pull you up.
For I am sorry about the disaster that I have brought on you.
11 Don't be afraid of the king of Babylon,
whom you fear.
Don't be afraid of him,' says the LORD,
'for I am with you to save you,
and to rescue you from his hand.
12 I will show you mercy,
so that he will have mercy on you
and let you return to your own land.
13 But suppose you say, "We will not stay in this land,"
and so you don't obey the voice of the LORD your God.
14 Suppose you say, "No, we will go to the land of Egypt,
where we will see no war,
nor hear the sound of the trumpet,
nor go hungry for bread.
We will live there."
15 Then hear the LORD's word, you who are left of Judah!
The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"If you are determined to go to Egypt,
and go to live there,
16 then the sword that you fear
will catch up with you there in the land of Egypt.
The famine that you are afraid of
will follow close behind you there in Egypt,
and you will die there.
17 So it will be with all the men who are determined to go to Egypt to live there.
They will die by the sword, by famine, and by disease.
None of them will survive or escape
from the disaster that I will bring on them."
18 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Just as my anger and my fury were poured out on the people of Jerusalem,
so my fury will be poured out on you
when you go to Egypt.
You will become an object of horror and shock,
a curse and a disgrace,
and you will never see this place again."'

19 The LORD has spoken to you, you who are left of Judah:
'Don't go to Egypt!'
Know for certain that I have warned you today.
20 For you have deceived yourselves.
You sent me to the LORD your God, saying,
'Pray for us to the LORD our God.
Tell us everything the LORD our God says,
and we will do it.'
21 I have told you today,
but you have not obeyed the voice of the LORD your God
in anything he has sent me to tell you.
22 So now know for certain
that you will die by the sword, by famine, and by disease
in the place where you want to go to live."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Jeremiah waits 10 days for God's answer. He does not answer from his own opinion, but waits patiently for God.

Verse 10: God's answer is full of kindness: Stay in the land, then I will build you up. "I am sorry about the disaster that I have brought on you." God shows compassion for his suffering people.

Verses 11–12: Don't be afraid of Babylon! I am with you.

Verse 14: Egypt seemed to be the safe place: no war, no hunger. But God warns: What you fear will catch up with you there.

Verses 20–21: Jeremiah realizes that they never really wanted to listen. They had already decided. You cannot ask God for advice and then only do what you wanted to do anyway.

Note: This text is not a general statement against people who flee from war and hardship. It is about a specific situation in which God had expressly told the people to stay in the land. In many places the Bible tells of flight and of finding shelter in a foreign land, for example of Jesus and his parents, who flee to Egypt (Matthew 2:13–15).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 43

The journey to Egypt

They do not listen and go to Egypt VERSES 1–7

1 Jeremiah finished telling all the people
all the words of the LORD their God,
all the words that the LORD their God had sent him to tell them.
2 Then Azariah, the son of Hoshaiah,
Johanan, the son of Kareah,
and all the proud men said to Jeremiah,
"You are lying!
The LORD our God has not sent you to say,
'You must not go to Egypt to live there.'
3 Instead, Baruch, the son of Neriah, has turned you against us,
to hand us over to the Chaldeans,
so that they can put us to death,
or carry us away as captives to Babylon."
4 So Johanan, the son of Kareah,
and all the army commanders,
and all the people
didn't obey the LORD's voice to stay in the land of Judah.
5 Instead, Johanan, the son of Kareah, and all the army commanders
took all the people who were left of Judah,
who had come back from all the nations where they had been driven,
to live in the land of Judah:
6 the men, the women, the children, the king's daughters,
and everyone whom Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
had left with Gedaliah, the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan,
and also Jeremiah the prophet,
and Baruch, the son of Neriah.
7 They went into the land of Egypt,
for they didn't obey the LORD's voice.
They came as far as Tahpanhes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: Even though they had promised to listen to God, they now call Jeremiah a liar. And they blame Baruch: He supposedly influenced Jeremiah. When people don't want to hear a message, they often attack the messenger.

Verse 6: Jeremiah and Baruch are taken along against their will. Jeremiah, the old prophet, has to leave his homeland and probably dies in Egypt.

Verse 7: Tahpanhes was an Egyptian border town in the Nile Delta.

Stones in front of Pharaoh's palace VERSES 8–13

8 Then the LORD's word came to Jeremiah in Tahpanhes. He said,
9 "Take some large stones in your hands,
and hide them in the mortar of the brick pavement
at the entrance to Pharaoh's palace in Tahpanhes,
while the men of Judah are watching.
10 Tell them: The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Look, I will send for Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, my servant.
I will set his throne on these stones that I have hidden,
and he will spread his royal canopy over them.
11 He will come and strike the land of Egypt.
Those who are meant for death will go to death.
Those who are meant for captivity will go into captivity.
Those who are meant for the sword will go to the sword.
12 I will set fire to the temples of the gods of Egypt.
He will burn them, and carry their gods away as captives.

He will wrap himself in the land of Egypt,
as a shepherd wraps himself in his cloak,
and he will leave there in peace.
13 He will also break the sacred pillars of Beth Shemesh in the land of Egypt,
and he will burn the temples of the gods of Egypt with fire.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another symbolic act: Jeremiah buries large stones in front of Pharaoh's palace. One day Nebuchadnezzar will set up his throne there.

The message: Egypt is not a safe place. Babylon will come here too. The people fled from what they feared, and it will catch up with them.

Verse 13: Beth Shemesh means *house of the sun*. This refers to the Egyptian city of Heliopolis, with its sun temple and its obelisks (stone pillars).

Nebuchadnezzar did in fact attack Egypt later (around 568 BC).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 44

The dispute about the queen of the sky

Have you learned nothing? VERSES 1–14

1 This is the word that came to Jeremiah
about all the Jews who lived in the land of Egypt,
who lived at Migdol, at Tahpanhes, at Memphis,
and in the region of Pathros. He said,
2 "The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'You have seen all the disaster that I have brought on Jerusalem
and on all the cities of Judah.
Look, today they are in ruins,
and no one lives in them,
3 because of the evil they did to provoke me to anger.
They went to burn incense and to serve other gods
whom they did not know,
neither they, nor you, nor your ancestors.
4 Yet I sent all my servants the prophets to you,
early and tirelessly, to say,
"Oh, don't do this detestable thing that I hate!"
5 But they didn't listen or pay attention.
They didn't turn from their evil,
to stop burning incense to other gods.
6 So my fury and my anger were poured out,
and burned in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem.
They have become ruins and wasteland, as they are today.'
7 So now the LORD, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Why are you doing such great harm to yourselves?
You are cutting off from Judah man and woman,
child and nursing baby,
so that you leave no one remaining.
8 You provoke me to anger with what your hands have made,
by burning incense to other gods in the land of Egypt,
where you have gone to live.
So you will be cut off,
and become a curse and a disgrace among all the nations of the earth.
9 Have you forgotten the evil of your ancestors,
the evil of the kings of Judah,
the evil of their wives,
your own evil,
and the evil of your wives,
which they did in the land of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem?
10 To this day they have not humbled themselves.
They have not feared me,
nor followed my law and my rules,
which I set before you and before your ancestors.'
11 So the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'Look, I will set my face against you for disaster,
to cut off all Judah.
12 I will take those who are left of Judah,
who were determined to go to the land of Egypt to live there,
and they will all come to an end.
They will fall in the land of Egypt.
They will come to an end by the sword and by famine.
They will die, from the least to the greatest,
by the sword and by famine.
They will become an object of horror and shock,
a curse and a disgrace.
13 For I will punish those who live in the land of Egypt,
as I have punished Jerusalem,
by the sword, by famine, and by disease.
14 None of those who are left of Judah,
who have gone to live in the land of Egypt,
will escape or survive to return to the land of Judah,
though they long to return and live there.
For no one will return except a few who escape.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

By now Jews were living in various places in Egypt: Migdol and Tahpanhes in the north, Memphis in the middle, and Pathros, that is, Upper Egypt in the south.

Verses 2–6: Jeremiah reminds them: You saw how Jerusalem was destroyed. And why? Because of the worship of idols.

Verse 4: A touching sentence from God: "Oh, don't do this detestable thing that I hate!" God is almost pleading.

Verses 7–10: And yet in Egypt they go on in exactly the same way. They have learned nothing.

The people's answer VERSES 15–19

15 Then all the men who knew that their wives burned incense to other gods,
and all the women standing there, a great crowd,

all the people who lived in Pathros in the land of Egypt,
answered Jeremiah. They said,

16 "As for the message that you have spoken to us in the
LORD's name,
we will not listen to you.

17 Instead, we will certainly do everything we have said
we would do.
We will burn incense to the queen of the sky,
and pour out drink offerings to her,
as we used to do, we and our ancestors,
our kings and our leaders,
in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem.
For then we had plenty of food,
and were well off, and saw no disaster.

18 But since we stopped burning incense to the queen of
the sky,
and pouring out drink offerings to her,
we have lacked everything,
and have been coming to an end by the sword and by
famine."

19 And the women said,
"When we burned incense to the queen of the sky,
and poured out drink offerings to her,
did we make cakes for her to worship her,
and pour out drink offerings to her,
without our husbands?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people's answer is shockingly open: We will not listen to you!

Verses 17–18: They have a completely different explanation for their misfortune: In the past, when we worshiped the queen of the sky, things went well for us. Since King Josiah banned this cult (2 Kings 23), things have gone badly for us. So stopping was to blame!

This shows: The same events can be interpreted in completely different ways. Jeremiah says: The disaster came because of the worship of idols. The people say: It came because we stopped worshiping idols.

Verse 19: The women stress: We didn't do this alone; our husbands agreed. Men and women share the responsibility together. The text does not put the blame on the women alone.

Jeremiah's answer VERSES 20–30

20 Then Jeremiah said to all the people,
to the men and to the women,
to all the people who had given him this answer:

21 "The incense that you burned in the cities of Judah
and in the streets of Jerusalem,
you and your ancestors, your kings and your leaders,
and the people of the land,
didn't the LORD remember it?
Didn't it come to his mind?

22 The LORD could no longer bear
the evil of your deeds
and the detestable things you had done.
That is why your land has become a ruin,
an object of shock and a curse,
without anyone living in it, as it is today.

23 You burned incense,
and you sinned against the LORD.
You did not obey the LORD's voice,
nor follow his law, his rules, and his instructions.
That is why this disaster has happened to you, as it is
today."

24 Jeremiah also said to all the people, including all the
women,
"Hear the LORD's word, all you people of Judah who
are in the land of Egypt!

25 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
'You and your wives have said it with your mouths,
and done it with your hands.
You said, "We will surely carry out the vows we have
made,
to burn incense to the queen of the sky,
and to pour out drink offerings to her."
Then keep your vows, and carry out your vows!'

26 So hear the LORD's word, all you people of Judah who
live in the land of Egypt:
'Look, I have sworn by my great name,' says the LORD,
'that my name will never again be spoken
by the mouth of any man of Judah in all the land of
Egypt,
saying, "As the Lord GOD lives."

27 Look, I am watching over them for disaster, and not for
good.
All the men of Judah who are in the land of Egypt
will come to an end by the sword and by famine,
until they are all gone.

28 Those who escape the sword
will return from the land of Egypt to the land of
Judah,
but they will be few in number.
Then all who are left of Judah,
who have gone to live in the land of Egypt,
will know whose word will stand, mine or theirs.

29 This will be the sign to you,' says the LORD,
'that I will punish you in this place,
so that you may know that my words against you
will surely come true for disaster.'

30 The LORD says:
'Look, I will hand Pharaoh Hophra, king of Egypt,
over to his enemies
and to those who want to kill him,
just as I handed Zedekiah, king of Judah,
over to Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
his enemy, who wanted to kill him.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–23: Jeremiah disagrees: No, God remembered your worship of idols. That is why the disaster came.

Verse 25: A bitter, ironic sentence from God: "Then keep your vows, and carry out your vows!" Anyone who will not listen, God lets go their own way.

Verse 26: The Jews in Egypt will no longer use God's name in their oaths, because they have turned away from him.

Verse 28: The people from Judah will recognize "whose word will stand, mine or theirs." Time will tell.

Verse 30: As a sign, Jeremiah names this: Pharaoh Hophra will be overthrown. Hophra (in Greek, Apries) was in fact overthrown in an uprising around 570 BC.

These are the last recorded words of Jeremiah. The Bible does not tell how he died.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 45

A word for Baruch

Are you looking for great things? VERSES 1–5

1 This is the message that the prophet Jeremiah spoke to
Baruch, the son of Neriah.
Baruch was writing these words in a book.
Jeremiah told him what to write.
This was in the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the son of
Josiah, king of Judah.
Jeremiah said,
2 "Baruch, the LORD, the God of Israel, says this to you:
3 'You said, "How terrible for me now!
The LORD has added sorrow to my pain!
I am worn out from groaning.
I find no rest."'
4 "Tell him: This is what the LORD says:
'Look, I will tear down what I have built.
I will pull up what I have planted.
I will do this in the whole land.
5 Are you looking for great things for yourself?
Do not look for them!
Look, I will bring disaster on all people,' says the
LORD.
'But wherever you go, I will let you escape with your
life.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This short chapter is a personal word to Baruch, Jeremiah's faithful scribe. It comes from the time when Baruch wrote the first scroll (Chapter 36, in the year 605 BC).

Verse 3: Baruch is exhausted: "How terrible for me now! ... I am worn out from groaning. I find no rest." The prophets' helpers also suffered under the heavy message. Anyone who helps others can become tired and exhausted themselves.

Verse 4: God answers: It hurts me too. I have to tear down what I myself have built.

Verse 5: "Are you looking for great things for yourself? Do not look for them!" Perhaps Baruch had hoped for respect or a career. God says: In this hard time, that is not important. But I promise you: You will survive, wherever you go.

A comforting word for all who feel exhausted: Great successes are not what counts, but that God protects your life. If you feel burned out, you may get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 46

Words about Egypt

The battle of Carchemish VERSES 1–12

1 This is the LORD's word which came to Jeremiah the
prophet about the nations.
2 About Egypt:
about the army of Pharaoh Necoh, king of Egypt,
which was by the Euphrates River at Carchemish,
and which Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, defeated
in the fourth year of Jehoiakim, the son of Josiah,
king of Judah.
3 "Get your small shields and large shields ready,
and march out to battle!
4 Harness the horses!
Mount up, you riders!
Take your positions with your helmets on!
Polish the spears!
Put on your armor!
5 Why do I see this?
They are terrified and are turning back.
Their warriors are beaten down.
They flee in haste and don't look back.
There is terror on every side," says the LORD.
6 "Don't let the swift flee away,
or the warrior escape.
In the north, by the Euphrates River,
they have stumbled and fallen.
7 Who is this who rises like the Nile,
like rivers whose waters surge?
8 Egypt rises like the Nile,
like rivers whose waters surge.
Egypt says, 'I will rise up.
I will cover the earth.
I will destroy cities and the people who live in them.'
9 Charge, you horses!
Rush wildly, you chariots!
Let the warriors march out:
Cush and Put, who carry the shield,
and the Ludim, who handle and bend the bow.
10 For that day belongs to the Lord, the LORD of Armies.
It is a day of vengeance,
when he takes vengeance on his enemies.
The sword will devour and be satisfied,
and will drink its fill of their blood.
For the Lord, the LORD of Armies, has a sacrifice
in the land of the north by the Euphrates River.
11 Go up to Gilead and get balm,
virgin daughter of Egypt.
You use many medicines in vain.
There is no healing for you.
12 The nations have heard of your shame.
The earth is full of your cry.
For warrior has stumbled against warrior,
and they both fall together."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Chapter 46 the "words about the nations" begin (Chapters 46–51). God had, after all, "appointed you as a prophet to the nations" (1:5). God is not only the God of Israel, but Lord over the whole world.

Verse 2: The battle of Carchemish on the Euphrates in the year 605 BC was one of the most important battles of the ancient world. The young Nebuchadnezzar defeated the Egyptian army. After that, Babylon was the greatest power.

Verses 3–6: A vivid picture: First the Egyptians proudly arm themselves for battle. Then they flee in panic.

Verses 7–8: Egypt wanted to spread out like the Nile in flood.

Verse 9: Cush, Put, and Lud were peoples from Africa who fought in the Egyptian army.

Verse 10: "The sword will devour and be satisfied, and will drink its fill of their blood." This is the harsh language of war of that time. It describes God's judgment on an arrogant power. It is not a call to violence and not a justification of war.

Verse 11: Like Judah (8:22), Egypt also finds no balm that heals.

Nebuchadnezzar will come to Egypt VERSES 13–26

13 This is the word that the LORD spoke to Jeremiah the prophet,
about how Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, would come and strike the land of Egypt:

14 "Announce it in Egypt,
proclaim it in Migdol,
and proclaim it in Memphis and in Tahpanhes.
Say, 'Take your positions and get ready,
for the sword has devoured those around you.'

15 Why are your strong ones swept away?
They didn't stand,
because the LORD pushed them down.

16 He made many stumble.
Yes, they fell over one another.
They said, 'Get up!
Let's go back to our own people,
to the land where we were born,
away from the oppressor's sword.'

17 There they cried out,
'Pharaoh, king of Egypt, is only a noise.
He has let the right moment pass by.'

18 As I live," says the King,
whose name is the LORD of Armies,
"surely, like Tabor among the mountains,
and like Carmel by the sea,
so he will come.

19 You daughter who lives in Egypt,
pack your bags to go into captivity!
For Memphis will become a wasteland.
It will be burned down,
without anyone living in it.

20 Egypt is a very beautiful young cow,
but destruction from the north has come.
It has come.

21 Even her hired soldiers among her
are like fattened calves,
for they too have turned back.
They have fled together.
They didn't stand,
for the day of their disaster has come on them,
the time of their punishment.

22 Her sound will go like a snake,
for the enemy will march with an army,
and come against her with axes,
like woodcutters.

23 They will cut down her forest," says the LORD,
"though it is impossible to get through,
because they are more numerous than locusts,
and cannot be counted.

24 The daughter of Egypt will be put to shame.
She will be handed over to the people of the north."

25 The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Look, I will punish Amon of No,
and Pharaoh, and Egypt,
with her gods and her kings,
Pharaoh and those who trust in him.

26 I will hand them over to those who want to kill them,
to Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
and to his officials.
Afterward it will be inhabited again, as in the days of old," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: The very cities to which the Jews had fled (Migdol, Tahpanhes, Memphis) are named.

Verse 17: A mocking name for Pharaoh: "Only a noise," a lot of talk, but nothing behind it.

Verse 18: Nebuchadnezzar will come as surely as the mountains Tabor and Carmel stand out above the plain.

Verse 25: "Amon of No": Amon was the chief god of the city of No, which today is called Thebes (Luxor).

Verse 26: At the end, a surprising hope even for Egypt: "Afterward it will be inhabited again, as in the days of old." God's judgment is not the last word, not even for other nations.

Don't be afraid, Jacob VERSES 27–28

27 "But don't be afraid, Jacob my servant.
Don't be terrified, Israel.
For look, I will save you from far away,
and save your descendants from the land of their captivity.
Jacob will come back,
and will be quiet and at ease.
No one will make him afraid.

28 Don't be afraid, Jacob my servant," says the LORD,
"for I am with you.
I will make a complete end of all the nations where I have driven you,
but I will not make a complete end of you.
I will correct you with fairness,
but I will not leave you unpunished."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses appear almost word for word already in Jeremiah 30:10–11. In the middle of the words about the great world powers, God reminds his small people: Don't be afraid! I am with you. The great powers pass away, but God's people will remain.

Chapter 47

Words about the Philistines

A flood from the north VERSES 1–7

1 This is the LORD's word that came to Jeremiah the
prophet about the Philistines,
before Pharaoh attacked Gaza.
2 The LORD says:
"Look, waters are rising out of the north.
They will become a flooding river.
They will flood the land and everything in it,
the city and those who live in it.
The people will cry out,
and everyone who lives in the land will wail.
3 At the noise of the stamping hoofs of his strong horses,
at the rushing of his chariots,
at the rumbling of his wheels,
fathers don't look back for their children,
because their hands hang so weak.
4 This is because of the day that is coming
to destroy all the Philistines,
to cut off from Tyre and Sidon
every helper who is left.
For the LORD will destroy the Philistines,
those who are left from the island of Caphtor.
5 Gaza has shaved its head bald.
Ashkelon is silenced.
You who are left in their valley,
how long will you cut yourselves?
6 Oh, you sword of the LORD,
how long will it be before you are quiet?
Put yourself back into your sheath!
Rest, and be still!
7 But how can it be quiet,
since the LORD has given it a command?
Against Ashkelon and against the seashore,
there he has appointed it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines lived on the coast in the southwest of Israel, in cities such as Gaza and Ashkelon. They were often enemies of Israel. They originally came from the island of Caphtor, probably Crete.

Verse 2: The Babylonian army comes like a flood wave from the north.

Verse 3: A shocking detail: The fathers are so full of fear that they do not even look for their children. War destroys even the love between parents and children.

Verse 5: Heads shaved bald and cuts in the skin were signs of mourning.

Verse 6: A moving cry: "Oh, you sword of the LORD, how long will it be before you are quiet? Put yourself back into your sheath!" Even in the middle of the announcement of judgment, you can hear the longing for the war to finally stop. This cry is still relevant today, wherever there is war.

Anyone who hurts themselves out of despair should get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Chapter 48

Words about Moab

Moab is laid waste VERSES 1–10

1 About Moab.
The LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"How terrible for Nebo! For it is laid waste.
Kiriathaim is put to shame.
It is captured.
Misgab is put to shame and broken down.
2 Moab's glory is no more.
In Heshbon they have planned disaster against her:
'Come! Let's cut her off from being a nation.'
You too, Madmen, will be silenced.
The sword will chase you.
3 Listen! A cry from Horonaim:
ruin and great destruction!
4 Moab is destroyed.
Her little ones cry out.
5 For they go up the slope of Luhith,
weeping as they go.
For on the road down to Horonaim
they have heard the cries of distress over the
destruction.
6 Flee! Save your lives!
Be like a juniper bush in the wilderness.
7 For because you trusted in your works and in your
treasures,
you too will be captured.
Chemosh will go into captivity,
his priests and his leaders together.
8 The destroyer will come against every city,
and no city will escape.
The valley also will be ruined,
and the plain will be destroyed,
as the LORD has said.
9 Give wings to Moab,
so that she may fly away.
Her cities will become a wasteland,
without anyone living in them.
10 Cursed is anyone who does the LORD's work carelessly,
and cursed is anyone who holds back his sword from
blood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab lay east of the Dead Sea, in today's Jordan. The Moabites were related to Israel (Genesis 19:37). Ruth, David's great-grandmother, was a Moabite. Still, there was often conflict and war between the two peoples.

Many cities are named; this makes it clear: The whole land is affected.

Verse 7: Moab trusted in its treasures and in its god Chemosh. But even Chemosh will "go into captivity," meaning his statue will be carried away.

Verse 10: A very harsh verse. It is directed at the Babylonians, whom God uses as a tool of judgment on Moab: They are to carry out their task. This verse is not a general instruction and gives no one the right to use violence. Sadly, people in history have misused such verses to justify violence. That goes against the will of God, who loves "faithful love, justice, and righteousness" (9:24).

Wine that was never poured off VERSES 11–17

11 "Moab has been at ease from his youth.
He has settled on his dregs like wine,
and has not been poured from jar to jar.
He has not gone into captivity.
So his flavor remains in him,
and his smell has not changed.
12 So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will send to him people who pour off wine,
and they will pour him off.
They will empty his jars,
and smash his containers to pieces.
13 Moab will be ashamed of Chemosh,
just as the people of Israel were ashamed of Bethel,
in which they trusted.
14 How can you say, 'We are warriors,
strong men for battle'?
15 Moab is laid waste.
The enemy has gone up into his cities.
His best young men have gone down to the slaughter,"
says the King, whose name is the LORD of Armies.
16 "Moab's disaster is near,
and his misery is coming quickly.
17 All you who live around him, mourn for him!
All you who know his name, say,
'How the strong staff is broken,
the beautiful rod!'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: A picture from winemaking: Wine that lies on its yeast for a long time and is never poured into another jar keeps its old taste. Moab never experienced war or deportation. It has become self-satisfied and has never changed. Now it is being "poured off," that is, torn out of its comfort.

Verse 13: Bethel was a shrine in the northern kingdom of Israel with a golden bull statue (1 Kings 12:28–29). It could not save Israel. Neither will Chemosh save Moab.

Verse 17: The neighbors are to feel pity. Even in judgment, compassion can be heard.

Lament over the cities of Moab VERSES 18–28

18 You daughter who lives in Dibon,
come down from your glory,
and sit on the thirsty ground.
For the destroyer of Moab has come up against you.
He has destroyed your fortresses.
19 You who live in Aroer,
stand by the road and watch.
Ask the man who flees and the woman who escapes.
Say, 'What has happened?'
20 Moab is put to shame,
for it is broken down.
Wail and cry out!
Announce it by the Arnon
that Moab is laid waste.
21 Judgment has come on the plateau:
on Holon, on Jahzah, on Mephaath,
22 on Dibon, on Nebo, on Beth Diblathaim,
23 on Kiriathaim, on Beth Gamul, on Beth Meon,
24 on Kerioth, on Bozrah,
and on all the cities of the land of Moab, far and near.
25 Moab's horn is cut off,
and his arm is broken," says the LORD.
26 "Make him drunk,
for he has made himself great against the LORD.
Moab will roll around in his vomit,
and he too will be laughed at.
27 For wasn't Israel laughed at by you?
Was he caught among thieves,
that every time you speak of him, you shake your head?
28 You who live in Moab,
leave the cities, and live among the rocks.
Be like the dove that makes her nest
above the opening of a deep gorge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–24: A long list of cities: Every single one is struck by the judgment. Dibon is today Dhiban in Jordan. There, in 1868, the famous "Mesha Stone" was found, an inscription of King Mesha of Moab from the 9th century BC.

Verse 25: The "horn" is a picture for strength and power.

Verses 26–27: Moab had made fun of Israel and shaken its head when Israel was doing badly. Now Moab itself is mocked. Anyone who mocks others in their misfortune will become a laughingstock themselves.

Verse 28: The people are to hide in the rocks like doves in the cliffs.

Moab's pride VERSES 29–39

29 "We have heard of Moab's pride.
He is very proud:
his loftiness, his pride, his arrogance,
and the haughtiness of his heart.
30 I know his rage," says the LORD,
"but it is nothing.
His boasting has achieved nothing.
31 That is why I will wail for Moab.
Yes, I will cry out for all Moab.
People will mourn for the men of Kir Heres.
32 With more than the weeping of Jazer
I will weep for you, vine of Sibmah.
Your branches reached across the sea.
They reached as far as the sea of Jazer.
The destroyer has fallen on your summer fruit
and on your grape harvest.

33 Gladness and joy are taken away
from the fruitful field and from the land of Moab.
I have made the wine stop flowing from the
winepresses.
No one will tread the grapes with shouts of joy.
The shouting will be no shouting of joy.
34 From the cry of Heshbon as far as Elealeh,
as far as Jahaz, they have raised their voices,
from Zoar as far as Horonaim,
to Eglath Shelishiyah.
For even the waters of Nimrim will dry up.
35 I will also put an end in Moab," says the LORD,
"to anyone who offers sacrifices on the shrine on the
hill
and burns incense to his gods.
36 That is why my heart moans for Moab like flutes,
and my heart moans like flutes for the men of Kir
Heres.
That is why the wealth he gained has been lost.
37 For every head is shaved bald,
and every beard is cut off.
There are cuts on all the hands,
and sackcloth around the waist.
38 On all the rooftops of Moab
and in its streets
there is mourning everywhere.
For I have broken Moab
like a jar that no one wants," says the LORD.
39 "How it is broken down!
How they wail!
How Moab has turned its back in shame!
So Moab will become an object of laughter and terror
to all who live around him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 29–30: The reason for the judgment is Moab's pride. It is described here with many words one after another. Moab was proud and arrogant. But its boasting was empty.

Verses 31–32 and 36: The amazing thing: God (or the prophet) weeps for Moab! "That is why my heart moans for Moab like flutes." Flutes were played at funerals. God does not rejoice over the misfortune of a people, not even an enemy people. He mourns with them.

Verses 32–33: Moab was famous for its wine. Now there is no joyful grape harvest anymore.

Verse 37: Heads shaved bald, cuts, mourning clothes: signs of deep grief.

Many verses in this chapter are similar to Isaiah 15–16.

Terror, pit, and trap VERSES 40–47

40 For the LORD says:
"Look, the enemy will swoop down like an eagle,
and spread out his wings over Moab.
41 Kerioth is captured,
and the fortresses are seized.
On that day the hearts of Moab's warriors
will be like the heart of a woman in labor.
42 Moab will be destroyed and no longer be a people,
because he has made himself great against the LORD.
43 Terror, the pit, and the trap are coming on you,
you who live in Moab," says the LORD.
44 "Whoever flees from the terror
will fall into the pit.
Whoever climbs out of the pit
will be caught in the trap.
For I will bring on Moab
the year of their punishment," says the LORD.
45 "Those who fled stand without strength
in the shadow of Heshbon.
For a fire has gone out from Heshbon,
a flame from the middle of Sihon.
It has burned up the corner of Moab,
and the tops of the heads of the noisy ones.
46 How terrible for you, Moab!
The people of Chemosh are lost.
For your sons are taken away as captives,
and your daughters into captivity.
47 Yet in the last days I will turn around the fate of Moab,"
says the LORD.
This is the end of the judgment on Moab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 40: Babylon comes like an eagle swooping down on its prey.

Verses 43–44: "Terror, the pit, and the trap": In Hebrew these three words sound alike (pachad, pachat, pach). There is no escape: Whoever escapes one falls into the next.

Verse 45: Heshbon used to be the city of the Amorite king Sihon (Numbers 21:26–28). This old song is taken up here.

Verse 47: And at the end, after all the judgment, the surprising hope: "I will turn around the fate of Moab." God does not give up even on the hostile neighboring people. His mercy reaches beyond Israel.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 49

Words about Ammon, Edom, Damascus, Kedar, and Elam

About Ammon VERSES 1–6

1 About the people of Ammon.
The LORD says:
"Has Israel no sons?
Has he no heir?
Why then has Malcam taken over Gad,
and why do his people live in its cities?
2 So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will make the battle cry heard
against Rabbah of the people of Ammon.
It will become a heap of ruins,
and its villages will be burned with fire.
Then Israel will take over the land of those who took
over his land,"
says the LORD.

3 "Wail, Heshbon, for Ai is laid waste!
Cry out, you daughters of Rabbah!
Put on sackcloth.
Mourn, and run back and forth among the walls,
for Malcam will go into captivity,
his priests and his leaders together.
4 Why do you boast about your valleys,
your valley overflowing with plenty,
you unfaithful daughter?
You trusted in your treasures, saying,
'Who will come to me?'
5 Look, I will bring terror on you,"
says the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
"from all who are around you.
Each of you will be driven out headlong,
and no one will gather the refugees.
6 But afterward I will turn around the fate of the people
of Ammon,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ammon lay east of the Jordan, around its capital Rabbah (today Amman, the capital of Jordan).

Verse 1: Malcam (also Milcom) was the god of the Ammonites. When the northern kingdom of Israel was conquered by Assyria, the Ammonites took over the territory of the tribe of Gad. God asks: Does Israel have no heirs left?

Verse 4: Ammon was proud of its fertile valleys and felt safe: "Who will come to me?"

Verse 6: Here too, at the end: God will turn around the fate of Ammon. His mercy is also for foreign peoples.

About Edom VERSES 7–22

7 About Edom.
The LORD of Armies says:
"Is there no more wisdom in Teman?
Has good advice disappeared from the wise?
Has their wisdom vanished?
8 Flee! Turn back!
Hide in deep places, you who live in Dedan!
For I will bring disaster on Esau
when I punish him.
9 If grape pickers came to you,
wouldn't they leave a few grapes?
If thieves came by night,
wouldn't they steal only as much as they wanted?
10 But I have stripped Esau bare.
I have uncovered his hiding places,
and he will not be able to hide.
His descendants are destroyed,
and his relatives and his neighbors,
and he is no more.
11 Leave your fatherless children.
I will keep them alive.
And let your widows trust in me."
12 For the LORD says:
"Look, those who did not deserve to drink the cup
will certainly drink it.
Are you the one who will go completely unpunished?
You won't go unpunished,
but you will surely drink it.
13 For I have sworn by myself," says the LORD,
"that Bozrah will become an object of shock and
disgrace,
a ruin and a curse.
All its cities will be ruins forever."
14 I have heard news from the LORD.
A messenger has been sent among the nations to say,
"Gather together, and come against her!
Get up for battle!"
15 "For look, I have made you small among the nations,
and despised among people.
16 The terror you cause
and the pride of your heart have deceived you,
you who live in the clefts of the rock,
who hold the height of the hill.
Even if you build your nest as high as the eagle,
I will bring you down from there," says the LORD.
17 "Edom will become an object of horror.
Everyone who passes by will be shocked,
and will hiss at all its wounds.
18 As when Sodom and Gomorrah and the towns around
them were overthrown,"
says the LORD,
"no one will live there,
and no human being will stay there.
19 Look, someone will come up like a lion
from the thick forest of the Jordan
against the strong pasture.
For I will suddenly make Edom run away from it,
and I will appoint over it whoever I choose.
For who is like me?
Who can set a time for me?
What shepherd can stand against me?"
20 So hear the plan that the LORD has made against Edom,
and what he has decided against those who live in
Teman:
Surely the little ones of the flock will be dragged away.
Surely he will make their pasture a wasteland because
of them.
21 The earth trembles at the noise of their fall.
There is a cry!
Its noise is heard at the Red Sea.
22 Look, the enemy will rise and swoop down like an eagle,
and spread out his wings over Bozrah.
On that day the hearts of Edom's warriors
will be like the heart of a woman in labor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom lay south of the Dead Sea. The Edomites were descendants of Esau, Jacob's brother. Teman and Bozrah were important cities. Edom was famous for its wisdom (compare Job 2:11) and for its mountain fortresses in the rocks.

Verses 9–10: Even grape pickers and thieves leave something behind. But in Edom nothing will be left.

Verse 11 is a surprisingly tender verse in the middle of the judgment: "Leave your fatherless children. I will keep them alive. And let your widows trust in me." God cares for the weakest, even among an enemy people.

Verse 16: Edom felt as safe in its rock cities as an eagle in its nest. But pride deceives.

Many verses here are similar to the small book of Obadiah, which is entirely about Edom.

About Damascus VERSES 23–27

23 About Damascus.
"Hamath and Arpad are confused,
for they have heard bad news.
They melt away in fear.
There is sorrow on the sea.
It cannot be calm.
24 Damascus has grown weak.
She turns to flee,
and trembling has seized her.
Pain and anguish have taken hold of her,
like a woman giving birth.
25 How is it that the city of praise is not abandoned,
the city of my joy?
26 So her young men will fall in her streets,
and all her soldiers will be silenced on that day,"
says the LORD of Armies.
27 "I will set fire to the wall of Damascus,
and it will burn up the palaces of Ben Hadad."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Damascus was the capital of Syria (Aram). Hamath and Arpad were cities in the north.

Verse 25: Damascus is called the "city of praise" and the "city of my joy," a beautiful, famous city.

Verse 27: Ben Hadad was a common name of the kings of Damascus.

Sadly, Damascus has also been struck by war and suffering in our own time. The Bible takes the suffering of all cities seriously.

About Kedar and Hazor VERSES 28–33

28 About Kedar and the kingdoms of Hazor,
which Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, defeated.
The LORD says:
"Get up, go up against Kedar,
and destroy the people of the east.
29 They will take their tents and their flocks.
They will carry off their tent curtains,
all their goods, and their camels.
They will shout to them,
'Terror on every side!'
30 Flee! Run far away!
Hide in deep places, you who live in Hazor," says the LORD,
"for Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, has made a plan against you,
and has decided to attack you.
31 Get up! Go up against a nation that is at ease,
that lives without worry," says the LORD,
"that has neither gates nor bars,
that lives alone.
32 Their camels will be taken as loot,
and their many cattle as plunder.
I will scatter to every wind
those who cut off the corners of their beards,
and I will bring disaster on them from every side," says the LORD.
33 "Hazor will become a home for jackals,
a wasteland forever.
No one will live there,
and no human being will stay there."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Kedar was a tribe of Arab nomads with tents and camels. Hazor here is probably a name for settlements in the Arabian desert, not the well-known city in Galilee.

Verse 31: These people lived peacefully, without walls and gates. They felt safe because they were far away. But Babylon reached them too.

About Elam VERSES 34–39

34 This is the LORD's word that came to Jeremiah the prophet about Elam,
at the beginning of the reign of Zedekiah, king of Judah. He said,
35 "The LORD of Armies says:
'Look, I will break the bow of Elam,
the source of their strength.
36 I will bring against Elam the four winds
from the four corners of the sky,
and will scatter them to all those winds.
There will be no nation
where the refugees from Elam will not go.
37 I will make Elam terrified before their enemies,
and before those who want to kill them.
I will bring disaster on them,
my burning anger,' says the LORD.
'I will send the sword after them,
until I have finished them off.
38 I will set my throne in Elam,
and destroy its king and leaders there,' says the LORD.
39 'But in the last days I will turn around the fate of Elam,'
says the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elam lay far to the east, in today's Iran. The Elamites were famous as archers.

Verse 38: "I will set my throne in Elam": God is Lord even over the most distant lands.

Verse 39: And again at the end: God will "turn around the fate of Elam." In the Acts of the Apostles (2:9), "Elamites" are also present at Pentecost, hearing God's great deeds in their own language.

Altogether, Chapter 49 shows: God is the Lord of all nations. He judges pride and injustice everywhere, but he also promises foreign nations a future (Verses 6 and 39).

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 50

Babylon has fallen

Babylon is captured, Israel comes home VERSES 1–10

1 This is the word that the LORD spoke about Babylon,
about the land of the Chaldeans,
through Jeremiah the prophet.
2 "Announce it among the nations and proclaim it!
Raise a signal flag!
Proclaim it, and don't hide it.
Say, 'Babylon is captured!
Bel is put to shame!
Merodach is terrified!
Her images are put to shame.
Her idols are terrified.'
3 For a nation is coming against her out of the north.
It will make her land a wasteland,
and no one will live in it.
Both people and animals have fled.
They are gone.
4 In those days, and at that time," says the LORD,
"the people of Israel will come,
they and the people of Judah together.
They will weep as they walk along,
and will seek the LORD their God.
5 They will ask the way to Zion,
with their faces turned toward it.
They will say, 'Come, let's join ourselves to the LORD
in a covenant that lasts forever and will never be
forgotten.'
6 My people have been lost sheep.
Their shepherds have led them astray.
They have let them wander on the mountains.
They have gone from mountain to hill.
They have forgotten their resting place.
7 All who found them have devoured them.
Their enemies said, 'We are not guilty,
because they have sinned against the LORD,
the home of righteousness,
the LORD, the hope of their ancestors.'
8 Flee out of the middle of Babylon!
Go out of the land of the Chaldeans,
and be like the male goats that lead the flock.
9 For look, I will stir up a crowd of great nations from the
land of the north,
and bring them up against Babylon.
They will take up their positions against her.
From there she will be captured.
Their arrows will be like those of a skilled warrior.
None of them will come back empty.
10 Chaldea will be plundered.
All who plunder her will have their fill," says the
LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 50–51 are the longest words about a nation: about Babylon, the great power that destroyed Jerusalem.

Verse 2: Bel and Merodach (Marduk) were the chief gods of Babylon. They are "put to shame."

Verse 3: A nation "out of the north" will conquer Babylon. These were the Medes and Persians under Cyrus in the year 539 BC.

Verses 4–5: In the middle of the announcement about Babylon, a wonderful scene: Israel and Judah come back together, weeping, and seek God. They want "a covenant that lasts forever and will never be forgotten."

Verse 6: God's people were like a lost flock because the shepherds (the leaders) failed. Jesus has compassion on the people, "because they were like sheep without a shepherd" (Mark 6:34).

Verse 7: The enemies thought they could oppress Israel without punishment because Israel had sinned. But God also sees their guilt.

Payback for Babylon VERSES 11–20

11 "You are glad and you rejoice,
you who plunder my inheritance.
You jump around like a young cow threshing grain,
and neigh like stallions.
12 So your mother will be deeply ashamed.
She who gave birth to you will be disgraced.
Look, she will be the least of the nations,
a wilderness, a dry land, and a desert.
13 Because of the LORD's anger, no one will live in her.
She will be completely deserted.
Everyone who passes by Babylon will be shocked,
and will hiss at all her wounds.
14 Take up your positions against Babylon on every side,
all you who bend the bow.
Shoot at her!
Spare no arrows,
for she has sinned against the LORD.
15 Raise the battle cry against her on every side!
She has surrendered.
Her towers have fallen.
Her walls have been torn down.
For this is the LORD's vengeance.
Take vengeance on her.
As she has done, do to her.
16 Cut off from Babylon the one who sows,
and the one who swings the sickle at harvest time.
For fear of the oppressor's sword,
each will return to his own people,
and each will flee to his own land.
17 Israel is a hunted sheep.
The lions have driven him away.
First the king of Assyria devoured him,
and now at last Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, has
crushed his bones."
18 So the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"Look, I will punish the king of Babylon and his land,
as I punished the king of Assyria.
19 I will bring Israel back to his pasture,
and he will graze on Carmel and Bashan.
He will eat his fill
on the hills of Ephraim and in Gilead.
20 In those days, and at that time," says the LORD,
"people will search for Israel's guilt,
but there will be none,
and for Judah's sins,
but they will not be found.
For I will forgive those whom I leave as a remnant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Babylon had rejoiced over the plundering of Jerusalem. Anyone who rejoices in the misfortune of others will be held accountable.

Verse 15: "As she has done, do to her." God's judgment matches what Babylon did to others. This language of war describes God's judgment on a cruel power. It is not general permission for revenge among people. Jesus teaches: Do not repay evil with evil (Matthew 5:38–44; Romans 12:17–21).

Verse 17: Israel is like a sheep hunted by lions: first by Assyria, then by Babylon.

Verse 19: Israel returns to its green pastures.

Verse 20 is a wonderful verse: People will search for Israel's guilt and find nothing, "For I will forgive those whom I leave as a remnant." When God forgives, the guilt is truly gone.

The hammer of the whole earth is broken VERSES 21–32

21 "Go up against the land of Merathaim,
against it, and against the people of Pekod.
Kill them and destroy them completely," says the LORD,
"and do everything that I have commanded you.
22 The noise of battle is in the land,
and of great destruction.
23 How the hammer of the whole earth
is cut down and broken!
How Babylon has become a wasteland
among the nations!
24 I set a trap for you,
and you were caught, Babylon,
before you knew it.
You were found and captured,
because you fought against the LORD.
25 The LORD has opened his armory,
and has brought out the weapons of his anger.
For the Lord, the LORD of Armies, has work to do
in the land of the Chaldeans.
26 Come against her from far away.
Open her storehouses.
Pile her up like heaps of grain.
Destroy her completely.
Let nothing of her be left.
27 Kill all her young bulls.
Let them go down to the slaughter.
How terrible for them!
For their day has come,
the time of their punishment.
28 Listen! Refugees and survivors are fleeing from the land of Babylon,
to announce in Zion the vengeance of the LORD our God,
the vengeance for his temple.
29 Call together the archers against Babylon,
all those who bend the bow.
Camp against her on every side.
Let no one escape.
Pay her back for what she has done.
Do to her everything she has done to others.
For she has been arrogant against the LORD,
against the Holy One of Israel.
30 So her young men will fall in her streets.
All her soldiers will be silenced on that day," says the LORD.
31 "Look, I am against you, you arrogant one,"
says the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
"for your day has come,
the time when I will punish you.
32 The arrogant one will stumble and fall,
and no one will help him up.
I will set fire to his cities,
and it will burn up everything around him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: "Merathaim" and "Pekod" are plays on words. Merathaim means *double rebellion*, and Pekod sounds like *punishment*. Both are also names of regions in Babylonia.

Verse 23: Babylon was like a "hammer" that smashed the whole world. Now the hammer itself is broken.

Verse 28: The refugees from Babylon announce in Jerusalem: God has not forgotten the destruction of his temple.

Verses 31–32: The main reason for Babylon's fall: arrogance, pride against God. "The arrogant one will stumble and fall."

The strong Redeemer VERSES 33–40

33 The LORD of Armies says:
"The people of Israel and the people of Judah
are oppressed together.
All who took them captive hold on to them tightly.
They refuse to let them go.
34 Their Redeemer is strong.
The LORD of Armies is his name.
He will surely take up their case,
so that he may give rest to the earth,
and unrest to the people of Babylon.
35 A sword against the Chaldeans," says the LORD,
"and against the people of Babylon,
against her leaders,
and against her wise men!
36 A sword against the boasters,
and they will become fools!
A sword against her warriors,
and they will be terrified!
37 A sword against their horses and their chariots,
and against all the foreign troops among her,
and they will become like women!
A sword against her treasures,
and they will be plundered!
38 A drought against her waters,
and they will dry up!
For it is a land of carved images,
and they go mad over their idols.
39 So desert animals will live there with the wolves.
Ostriches will live there.
No one will ever live there again.
No one will settle there for all generations.
40 As when God overthrew Sodom and Gomorrah
and the towns around them," says the LORD,
"so no one will live there,
and no human being will stay there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 33–34: Israel and Judah are captive, and their oppressors refuse to let them go, as Pharaoh did back then in Egypt. But their "Redeemer" is strong. He takes up their case like a lawyer in court.

Verses 35–38: Five times it says, "A sword against…": against the leaders, the wise men, the boasters, the

warriors, the horses, and the treasures. Everything Babylon was proud of will be broken.

Verse 37: "They will become like women" is a saying of that time for soldiers who lose their courage. It reflects the thinking of that time. Today we know: Women are not weaker or less brave than men.

Verse 38: Babylon was a land full of images of gods. The canals that watered the land will also dry up.

Verses 39–40: Over the centuries Babylon was in fact abandoned. Today only ruins are left in Iraq.

A people from the north VERSES 41–46

41 "Look, a people is coming from the north.
A great nation and many kings
will be stirred up from the ends of the earth.
42 They hold bow and spear.
They are cruel and have no mercy.
Their voice roars like the sea.
They ride on horses,
each one lined up like a man ready for battle,
against you, daughter of Babylon.
43 The king of Babylon has heard the news about them,
and his hands hang weak.
Anguish has seized him,
pains like those of a woman in labor.
44 Look, the enemy will come up like a lion
from the thickets of the Jordan
against the strong pasture.
For I will suddenly make them run away from it,
and I will appoint over it whoever I choose.
For who is like me?
Who can set a time for me?
What shepherd can stand against me?"
45 So hear the plan that the LORD has made against
Babylon,
and what he has decided against the land of the
Chaldeans:
Surely the little ones of the flock will be dragged away.
Surely he will make their pasture a wasteland because
of them.
46 The earth trembles at the noise of Babylon's capture.
The cry is heard among the nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 41–43: These verses repeat almost word for word what Jeremiah had said earlier about the army coming against Jerusalem (6:22–24). But now it is directed against Babylon. Whoever brought terror to others now experiences it themselves.

Verses 44–46: These verses were also already spoken about Edom (49:19–21). Now they apply to Babylon. No power in the world can stand before God.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 51

Babylon will sink

Flee from Babylon! VERSES 1–14

1 The LORD says:
"Look, I will stir up a destroying wind
against Babylon,
and against those who live in Lebkamai.
2 I will send strangers to Babylon,
who will winnow her like grain.
They will empty her land.
For in the day of trouble
they will be against her on every side.
3 Let the archer bend his bow against the one who bends
his bow,
and against the one who stands up proudly in his
armor!
Don't spare her young men!
Destroy her whole army completely!
4 They will fall down dead in the land of the Chaldeans,
pierced through in her streets.
5 For Israel and Judah have not been abandoned
by their God, the LORD of Armies,
even though their land is full of guilt
against the Holy One of Israel.
6 Flee out of the middle of Babylon!
Everyone, save your own life!
Don't be destroyed because of her guilt,
for it is the time of the LORD's vengeance.
He will pay her back what she deserves.
7 Babylon has been a golden cup in the LORD's hand,
which made the whole earth drunk.
The nations have drunk her wine.
That is why the nations have gone mad.
8 Babylon has suddenly fallen and been shattered!
Wail for her!
Get balm for her pain.
Perhaps she can be healed.
9 'We tried to heal Babylon,
but she could not be healed.
Leave her, and let's each go to our own country.
For her judgment reaches up to heaven,
and rises up to the skies.'
10 'The LORD has brought out our righteousness.
Come, let's tell in Zion
what the LORD our God has done.'
11 Sharpen the arrows!
Hold the shields firmly!
The LORD has stirred up the spirit of the kings of the
Medes,
because his plan is against Babylon, to destroy it.
For this is the LORD's vengeance,
the vengeance for his temple.
12 Raise a signal flag against the walls of Babylon!
Strengthen the guard!
Post the watchmen!
Prepare the ambushes!
For the LORD has both planned and done
what he said about the people of Babylon.

13 You who live by many waters,
rich in treasures,
your end has come,
the measure of your greed.
14 The LORD of Armies has sworn by himself:
'I will surely fill you with men, as with locusts,
and they will raise a battle cry against you.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Lebkamai" is a secret name for Chaldea (Babylonia), again formed by swapping letters, like "Sheshach" (25:26).

Verses 3–4: Harsh language of war. It describes the end of the cruel great power Babylon. It is not permission for people to wage war or to take revenge.

Verse 5: A comforting sentence: Israel and Judah have not been "abandoned" by their God. The Hebrew word makes us think of a widow who is left alone. God has not abandoned his people, even though it has become guilty.

Verse 7: Babylon was like a golden cup from which the nations drank an intoxicating wine. The Book of Revelation takes up this picture (Revelation 17:4; 18:3).

Verses 8–9: People try to heal Babylon, but it is no longer possible.

Verse 11: The Medes (together with the Persians) conquered Babylon in 539 BC.

Verse 13: Babylon lay "by many waters": on the Euphrates with many canals.

The Creator and the idols VERSES 15–19

15 "God has made the earth by his power.
He has set the world in place by his wisdom.
By his understanding he has stretched out the heavens.
16 When he speaks, the waters in the heavens roar.
He makes the clouds rise from the ends of the earth.
He makes lightning for the rain,
and brings the wind out of his storehouses.
17 Every person has become stupid and without knowledge.
Every goldsmith is put to shame by his carved image,
for his cast images are a lie,
and there is no breath in them.
18 They are worthless, a work of deception.
In the time of their punishment they will be destroyed.
19 The portion of Jacob is not like these,
for he is the maker of all things,
including the tribe of his inheritance.
The LORD of Armies is his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses appear almost word for word already in Jeremiah 10:12–16. In the middle of the words about Babylon, Jeremiah reminds: The gods of Babylon are dead images. The God of Israel is the Creator of heaven and earth.

The smashing hammer VERSES 20–26

20 "You are my battle ax, my weapon for battle.
With you I smash nations.
With you I destroy kingdoms.
21 With you I smash the horse and its rider.
22 With you I smash the chariot and its driver.
With you I smash man and woman.
With you I smash the old and the young.
With you I smash the young man and the young woman.
23 With you I smash the shepherd and his flock.
With you I smash the farmer and his team of oxen.
With you I smash governors and officials.
24 But I will pay back Babylon and all the people of Chaldea
for all the evil they have done in Zion,
before your very eyes," says the LORD.
25 "Look, I am against you, you destroying mountain,"
says the LORD,
"you who destroy the whole earth.
I will stretch out my hand against you,
roll you down from the cliffs,
and make you a burned-out mountain.
26 No one will take a cornerstone from you,
nor a stone for a foundation.
You will be a wasteland forever," says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–23: Babylon was God's "battle ax," his hammer, with which he smashed nations. Nine times it says, "With you I smash ..." These verses show how terrible Babylon's wars were for all people: for men and women, old and young, shepherds and farmers.

Verses 24–25: But now the hammer itself is smashed, because it has done so much evil. Babylon, the "destroying mountain," becomes a burned-out mountain.

Verse 26: Not even a stone will be left for new buildings.

These verses describe how God can use powers and then judge them again. They do not justify violence against innocent people, but show it as a terrible injustice for which Babylon is held responsible.

The nations are called VERSES 27–33

27 "Raise a signal flag in the land!
Blow the trumpet among the nations!
Prepare the nations for war against her!
Call together against her the kingdoms of Ararat,
Minni, and Ashkenaz!
Appoint a commander against her!
Bring up the horses like swarming locusts!
28 Prepare the nations for war against her:
the kings of the Medes,
their governors and all their officials,
and all the lands they rule!
29 The land trembles and writhes in pain,
for the LORD's plans against Babylon stand firm:
to make the land of Babylon a wasteland
where no one lives.
30 Babylon's warriors have stopped fighting.
They stay in their fortresses.
Their strength has failed.
They have become like women.
Her houses are set on fire.
The bars of her gates are broken.
31 One runner runs to meet another,
and one messenger to meet another,
to tell the king of Babylon
that his city is captured from end to end.

32 The river crossings are seized.
The reeds are burned with fire.
The soldiers are terrified."
33 For the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel, says:
"The daughter of Babylon is like a threshing floor
at the time it is trampled down.
In just a little while,
the time of harvest will come for her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: Ararat, Minni, and Ashkenaz were peoples in the north, in the area of today's Armenia and northern Iran.

Verse 30: "They have become like women" is a saying of that time for soldiers who lose their courage (like 50:37). Today we know: Courage does not depend on whether you are a man or a woman.

Verse 31: A vivid picture: Messengers run from all sides to the king to report to him: The city has fallen!

Verse 33: The threshing floor is a hard-packed place for threshing grain. Soon the "harvest" comes for Babylon, that is, the judgment.

God takes up his people's case VERSES 34–44

34 "Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, has devoured me.
He has crushed me.
He has made me an empty jar.
Like a monster, he has swallowed me up.
He has filled his stomach with my delicacies.
He has spit me out.
35 May the violence done to me and to my body be on
Babylon,"
the people of Zion will say.
"May my blood be on the people of Chaldea,"
Jerusalem will say.
36 So the LORD says:
"Look, I will take up your case,
and take vengeance for you.
I will dry up her sea,
and make her springs run dry.
37 Babylon will become heaps of ruins,
a home for jackals,
an object of horror and hissing,
without anyone living there.
38 They will roar together like young lions.
They will growl like lion cubs.
39 When they are heated up,
I will prepare a feast for them,
and make them drunk,
so that they celebrate,
and then sleep forever and never wake up," says the
LORD.
40 "I will bring them down like lambs to the slaughter,
like rams and male goats.
41 How Sheshach is captured!
How the pride of the whole earth is seized!
How Babylon has become an object of horror
among the nations!
42 The sea has risen over Babylon.
She is covered by its many waves.
43 Her cities have become a wasteland,
a dry land and a desert,
a land where no one lives,
and through which no human being passes.
44 I will punish Bel in Babylon,
and make him spit out what he has swallowed.
The nations will no longer stream to him.
Yes, the wall of Babylon will fall.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 34–35: Jerusalem laments: Nebuchadnezzar has devoured me like a monster and spit me out again. The city asks that the injustice not be forgotten.

Verse 36: God answers: "I will take up your case." God himself becomes Jerusalem's lawyer. The victims do not have to take revenge themselves.

Verse 39: A feast after which no one wakes up again. The Greek historians tell that Babylon was captured during a night of feasting (compare also Daniel 5).

Verse 44: Bel, the god of Babylon, has to "spit out" what he has swallowed: the treasures and the captives of the nations.

My people, go out! VERSES 45–58

45 "My people, go out of the middle of her!
Each of you, save yourselves
from the LORD's burning anger.
46 Don't lose heart,
and don't be afraid of the news that will be heard in the
land.
For news will come one year,
and after that, more news in another year,
and violence in the land,
ruler against ruler.
47 So look, the days are coming
when I will punish the carved idols of Babylon.
Her whole land will be put to shame,
and all her dead will fall in the middle of her.
48 Then heaven and earth and everything in them
will shout for joy over Babylon,
for the destroyers will come against her from the
north," says the LORD.
49 "Just as Babylon caused the dead of Israel to fall,
so the dead of the whole land will fall at Babylon.
50 You who have escaped the sword,
go! Don't stand still!
Remember the LORD from far away,
and let Jerusalem come to your mind."
51 "We are ashamed, because we have heard insults.
Shame has covered our faces,
for strangers have entered the holy places of the
LORD's house."
52 "So look, the days are coming," says the LORD,
"when I will punish her carved idols,
and throughout her land the wounded will groan.
53 Even if Babylon climbs up to the sky,
and even if she fortifies her high stronghold,
destroyers will still come against her from me," says
the LORD.
54 "Listen! A cry from Babylon,
the sound of great destruction from the land of the
Chaldeans!
55 For the LORD is laying Babylon waste.
He is silencing her loud noise.

The waves of the enemy roar like many waters.
The noise of their voices rings out.
56 For the destroyer has come against her, against Babylon.
Her warriors are captured.
Their bows are broken,
for the LORD is a God who pays back.
He will surely repay.
57 I will make her leaders and her wise men drunk,
her governors, her officials, and her warriors.
They will sleep forever and never wake up,"
says the King, whose name is the LORD of Armies.
58 The LORD of Armies says:
"The thick walls of Babylon will be completely torn down.
Her high gates will be burned with fire.
The peoples will work hard for nothing,
and the nations will wear themselves out
only for the fire."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 45: "My people, go out!" The Book of Revelation takes up this call (Revelation 18:4).

Verse 46: Comforting advice for unsettled times: Don't be afraid of all the news of war and power struggles! God keeps history in his hand. That is true today too, when we hear bad news every day.

Verse 50: "Remember the LORD from far away, and let Jerusalem come to your mind." Even in exile, people should not forget their homeland and their God (compare Psalm 137:5).

Verse 53: Even if Babylon built up to the sky (compare the Tower of Babel, Genesis 11), it could not protect itself from God.

Verse 58: Everything the nations worked for to make Babylon great was in vain.

The scroll in the Euphrates VERSES 59–64

59 This is the message that Jeremiah the prophet gave to Seraiah,
the son of Neriah, the son of Mahseiah,
when he went with Zedekiah, king of Judah, to Babylon
in the fourth year of his reign.
Seraiah was the officer in charge of the king's quarters on the journey.
60 Jeremiah wrote in a book all the disaster that would come on Babylon,
all these words that are written about Babylon.
61 Jeremiah said to Seraiah,
"When you come to Babylon,
make sure you read all these words aloud.
62 Then say,
'LORD, you have said about this place
that you will destroy it,
so that no one will live in it,
neither people nor animals,
but that it will be a wasteland forever.'
63 When you have finished reading this book,
tie a stone to it,
and throw it into the middle of the Euphrates.
64 Then say,
'In the same way Babylon will sink,
and will never rise again,
because of the disaster that I will bring on her.
And they will be worn out.'"
This is the end of the words of Jeremiah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 59: Seraiah was Baruch's brother (both were sons of Neriah). In the year 594/593 BC, he traveled with King Zedekiah to Babylon.

Verses 60–64: One last symbolic act: Seraiah is to read the words about Babylon aloud in Babylon, then tie a stone to the scroll and throw it into the Euphrates. Just as the scroll sinks, Babylon will sink.

The Book of Revelation also takes up this picture: An angel throws a large stone into the sea and says: "In the same way Babylon, the great city, will be thrown down with violence" (Revelation 18:21).

"This is the end of the words of Jeremiah." The last chapter (52) is a historical appendix that tells about the fall of Jerusalem.

JEREMIAH

CHAPTER 52

The fall of Jerusalem

Zedekiah and the siege VERSES 1–11

1 Zedekiah was 21 years old when he became king.
He ruled for 11 years in Jerusalem.
His mother's name was Hamutal, the daughter of Jeremiah of Libnah.
2 He did what was evil in the LORD's sight,
just as Jehoiakim had done.
3 It was because of the LORD's anger
that this happened in Jerusalem and Judah,
until he threw them out of his presence.
And Zedekiah rebelled against the king of Babylon.
4 In the ninth year of his reign,
in the tenth month, on the tenth day of the month,
Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon, came with his whole army against Jerusalem.
They set up camp against it,
and built siege walls all around it.
5 So the city was under siege
until the eleventh year of King Zedekiah.
6 In the fourth month, on the ninth day of the month,
the famine in the city was so severe
that there was no food for the people of the land.
7 Then the city wall was broken through,
and all the soldiers fled.
They left the city by night
through the gate between the two walls,
near the king's garden,

while the Chaldeans were surrounding the city.
They went toward the Arabah.
8 But the army of the Chaldeans chased the king,
and caught up with Zedekiah in the plains of Jericho.
His whole army was scattered away from him.
9 Then they captured the king,
and brought him up to the king of Babylon at Riblah in the land of Hamath.
There he passed judgment on him.
10 The king of Babylon killed Zedekiah's sons in front of his eyes.
He also killed all the leaders of Judah in Riblah.
11 He put out Zedekiah's eyes.
The king of Babylon bound him in chains,
took him to Babylon,
and put him in prison until the day of his death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last chapter is a historical appendix. It matches 2 Kings 24:18–25:30 almost word for word. It shows: Everything Jeremiah had announced came true.

Verse 4: The tenth day of the tenth month is still a Jewish day of fasting today (Asarah BeTevet), on which people remember the beginning of the siege.

Verse 6: There was terrible hunger in the city.

Verses 10–11: Zedekiah's cruel fate is told once more (compare 39:6–7). Violence against prisoners and children is a crime. The Bible reports it so that the suffering will not be forgotten.

The temple is burned VERSES 12–23

12 In the fifth month, on the tenth day of the month,
in the nineteenth year of King Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
who served the king of Babylon,
came to Jerusalem.
13 He burned the LORD's house and the king's palace.
He burned all the houses of Jerusalem,
every important building, with fire.
14 The whole army of the Chaldeans
who were with the captain of the guard
tore down all the walls around Jerusalem.
15 Then Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
carried away as captives some of the poorest people,
the rest of the people who were left in the city,
the deserters who had gone over to the king of Babylon,
and the rest of the crowd.
16 But Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,
left some of the poorest people of the land
to take care of the vineyards and fields.
17 The Chaldeans broke into pieces
the bronze pillars that were in the LORD's house,
the stands, and the bronze Sea that was in the LORD's house,
and carried all the bronze to Babylon.
18 They also took away the pots, the shovels, the wick trimmers,
the basins, the spoons,
and all the bronze utensils used in the temple service.
19 The captain of the guard took away
the cups, the fire pans, the basins, the pots,
the lampstands, the spoons, and the bowls,
everything made of pure gold or pure silver.
20 The two pillars, the one Sea,
and the 12 bronze bulls under the stands,
which King Solomon had made for the LORD's house:
the bronze of all these things was too much to weigh.
21 As for the pillars,
each pillar was about 27 feet high,
and it took a cord of about 18 feet to go around it.
It was about 3 inches thick,
and hollow.
22 On top of it was a bronze capital.
The capital was about 7½ feet high,
with a network and pomegranates all around it,
all made of bronze.
The second pillar was the same, with pomegranates.
23 There were 96 pomegranates on the sides.
In all, there were 100 pomegranates
on the network all around.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–13: In the year 587 BC, Solomon's temple was burned, after almost 400 years. To this day, Jews remember the destruction of the first and the second temple on the 9th day of the month of Av (Tisha B'Av). (Here it says the 10th day, in 2 Kings 25:8 the 7th day; the traditions give different days.)

Verse 16: Again the poorest are left in the land to work the fields.

Verses 17–23: An exact list of the temple objects. The huge bronze pillars (about 27 feet high), the great water basin (the "Sea"), and the 12 bronze bulls were smashed. The Bible lists them lovingly, the way people list what they lost in a disaster.

The Bible gives the measurements in cubits and fingers: 18 cubits, 12 cubits, 5 cubits, and 4 fingers. A cubit is about 18 inches. A finger is about ¾ of an inch.

The deportations VERSES 24–30

24 The captain of the guard took Seraiah the chief priest,
Zephaniah the second priest,
and the three doorkeepers.
25 From the city he took an officer who was in charge of the soldiers,
seven of the king's advisers who were found in the city,
the secretary of the army commander,
who called up the people of the land for the army,
and 60 men of the people of the land
who were found in the city.
26 Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard, took them,
and brought them to the king of Babylon at Riblah.
27 The king of Babylon struck them down
and put them to death at Riblah in the land of Hamath.
So Judah was carried away as captives out of its land.
28 This is the number of the people whom
Nebuchadnezzar carried away as captives:
in the seventh year, 3,023 Jews;
29 in the eighteenth year of Nebuchadnezzar,
832 people from Jerusalem;
30 in the twenty-third year of Nebuchadnezzar,
Nebuzaradan, the captain of the guard,

carried away 745 Jews.
In all, there were 4,600 people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24–27: The leading men of the city are executed, among them the chief priest Seraiah.

Verses 28–30: An exact count of those carried away, in three waves (597, 587, and 582 BC): 4,600 people altogether. Probably only the men were counted, or only certain groups. 2 Kings 24:14 gives different numbers for the first deportation.

Behind these numbers are people and families who lost their homeland.

A ray of hope: Jehoiachin is pardoned VERSES 31–34

31 In the thirty-seventh year of the captivity of
Jehoiachin, king of Judah,
in the twelfth month, on the twenty-fifth day of the month,
Evilmerodach, king of Babylon,
in the first year of his reign,
showed favor to Jehoiachin, king of Judah,
and released him from prison.
32 He spoke kindly to him,
and gave him a seat of honor
above the seats of the other kings who were with him in Babylon.
33 Jehoiachin took off his prison clothes,
and ate at the king's table regularly
for the rest of his life.
34 The king of Babylon gave him a regular allowance,
a portion every day until the day of his death,
for the rest of his life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends with a small ray of hope: After 37 years in prison, King Jehoiachin is released and may eat at the Babylonian king's table. Archaeologists have found clay tablets in Babylon that record food rations for "Jehoiachin, king of Judah."

This shows: David's family has not died out. God's promise lives on, even in exile. There is hope.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Jeremiah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prophet: Jeremiah was active for about 40 years, from 627 BC until after 587 BC. He lived through the downfall of Judah and the destruction of Jerusalem.

Called from the womb: "Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you" (1:5). Jeremiah felt too young, but God said: "I am with you."

A suffering prophet: No other prophet shows his feelings so openly. He laments, weeps, argues with God, and even wishes he had never been born (Chapter 20). He was beaten, locked up, and thrown into a muddy cistern. But God's word was in him "like a burning fire" (20:9).

Honesty instead of false comfort: Jeremiah stood up against false prophets who cried "Peace, peace!" where there was no peace (6:14). He told the uncomfortable truth.

True worship: A temple alone does not protect (Chapter 7). God wants justice and righteousness, protection for foreigners, orphans, and widows (22:3).

The potter: God can shape something new out of what went wrong (Chapter 18).

Seek the peace of the city: The letter to the exiles (Chapter 29): Live, build, pray for the city where you are. God has for you "thoughts of peace, and not of disaster, to give you hope and a future" (29:11).

The new covenant: "I will put my law inside them, and I will write it on their heart" (31:33). Jews see in it God's faithfulness to Israel; Christians also relate it to the new covenant in Jesus. God's faithfulness to Israel is as certain as the sun and the moon (31:35–37).

Hope in the middle of downfall: Jeremiah bought a field when everything seemed lost (Chapter 32). He believed in the future.

Faithful helpers: Baruch the scribe, Ebedmelech from Cush, and the family of Shaphan stood by Jeremiah.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Lamentations. It mourns for destroyed Jerusalem. Tradition attributes it to Jeremiah.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 25 OF 66

LAMENTATIONS

5 CHAPTERS

LAMENTATIONS

CHAPTER 1

How lonely the city sits

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHAT IS THE BOOK OF LAMENTATIONS?

Lamentations is five poems about the destruction of Jerusalem in the year 587 BC. They express the deep pain of the people: The city is destroyed, the temple is burned, and many people are dead or taken away.

An old tradition says that the prophet Jeremiah wrote them. That is why in many Bibles they come right after the book of Jeremiah. The text itself names no author.

The first four poems are built with great skill: Each verse (or each group of verses) begins with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet, from Aleph to Tav. In this way the pain is spoken out "from A to Z."

In Judaism, Lamentations is read on the day of mourning called Tisha B'Av. On that day people remember the destruction of the temples. Lamentations is also read in Christian worship services during Holy Week.

Lamentations shows: You may lament, weep, and ask questions before God. Grief needs words. In the middle of the lament there is also a famous sentence of hope: "It is because of the LORD's loving kindness that we are not destroyed, because his mercies do not fail. They are new every morning" (3:22–23).

Jerusalem sits alone like a widow VERSES 1–11

1 How lonely the city sits,
the city that was full of people!
She has become like a widow,
she who was great among the nations!
She who was a princess among the provinces
has become a slave!

2 She weeps bitterly in the night.
Her tears are on her cheeks.
Among all her lovers
she has no one to comfort her.
All her friends have betrayed her.
They have become her enemies.

3 Judah has gone away as a prisoner
because of suffering and because of hard slavery.
She lives among the nations.
She finds no rest.
All who hunted her caught up with her
in the middle of her trouble.

4 The roads to Zion mourn,
because no one comes to the holy festivals.
All her gates are empty and ruined.
Her priests sigh.
Her young women are in pain,
and she herself is full of bitterness.

5 Her enemies have become her masters.
Her enemies do well.
For the LORD has made her suffer
because of her many sins.
Her young children have gone away as prisoners
in front of the enemy.

6 All her glory has left the daughter of Zion.
Her princes have become like deer
that find no pasture.
They have gone without strength
in front of the one who hunts them.

7 In the days of her suffering and her misery,
Jerusalem remembers
all her precious things
that she had from the days long ago.
She remembers when her people fell into the enemy's hands,
and no one helped her.
The enemies saw her.
They mocked her ruins.

8 Jerusalem has sinned terribly.
That is why she has become unclean.
All who honored her now look down on her,
because they have seen her nakedness.
Yes, she sighs and turns away.

9 Her filth was on her skirts.
She did not think about how she would end.
That is why she has fallen so shockingly low.
She has no comforter.
"LORD, see my suffering,
for the enemy has made himself great."

10 The enemy has reached out his hand
to take all her precious things.
For she has seen the nations go into her holy place.
But you had commanded
that they should not come into your assembly.

11 All her people sigh.
They look for bread.
They have given their precious things for food
to keep themselves alive.
"Look, LORD, and see,
for I have become despised."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The first word in Hebrew is "Ekhah." It means "How ...!" It is a cry of horror. That is where the book gets its Hebrew name. Jerusalem used to be full of people and was a "princess." Now she sits alone like a widow.

Verse 2: She weeps all night, and no one comforts her. Five times this chapter says that she has no one to comfort her (verses 2, 9, 16, 17, 21). That is the great theme of this poem: being alone in suffering.

Verse 4: Even the roads "mourn," because no pilgrims come to the festivals anymore.

Verses 5 and 8: The poems say honestly: The disaster has to do with the guilt of the people. But the pain is not made small.

Verses 8–9: The city is described as a woman whose shame can be seen. This is a picture of the humbled city. It is not a judgment about women.

Verse 11: The hunger is so great that people trade their valuable things for bread.

Is there any sorrow like my sorrow? VERSES 12–22

12 "Does it mean nothing to you,
all you who pass by?
Look, and see
if there is any sorrow like my sorrow,
the sorrow that was brought on me,
the sorrow the LORD has made me suffer
on the day of his burning anger.
13 "From on high he has sent fire into my bones,
and it is too strong for them.
He has spread a net for my feet.
He has turned me back.
He has made me empty and ruined,
and I am weak all day long.
14 "My sins are tied together like a yoke by his hand.
They are woven together.
They have come up on my neck.
He has made my strength fail.
The Lord has handed me over
to people I cannot stand up against.
15 "The Lord has thrown away
all my strong men among me.
He has called a festival against me
to crush my young men.
The Lord has trampled the virgin daughter of Judah
as grapes are trampled in a winepress.
16 "That is why I weep.
My eye, my eye runs with tears,
because the comforter who should make me strong
again
is far from me.
My children are lost and alone,
because the enemy has won."
17 Zion spreads out her hands.
There is no one to comfort her.
The LORD has given a command about Jacob:
the people around him should be his enemies.
Jerusalem has become among them
like something unclean.
18 "The LORD is righteous,
for I have rebelled against his commandment.
Please listen, all you peoples,
and see my sorrow.
My young women and my young men
have gone away as prisoners.
19 "I called for my lovers,
but they deceived me.
My priests and my elders
died in the city
while they looked for food
to keep themselves alive.
20 "Look, LORD, for I am in trouble.
My heart is troubled.
My heart turns over inside me,
for I have rebelled terribly.
Outside, the sword takes away the children.
At home, it is like death.
21 "They have heard that I sigh.
There is no one to comfort me.
All my enemies have heard of my trouble.
They are glad that you have done it.
You will bring the day that you have announced,
and then they will be like me.
22 "Let all their evil come before you.
Do to them as you have done to me
because of all my sins.
For my sighs are many,
and my heart is weak."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 is one of the best-known verses: "Does it mean nothing to you, all you who pass by? Look, and see if there is any sorrow like my sorrow." The city calls out to the people walking by: Do you not see my suffering? Christians have often connected this verse with the suffering of Jesus on Good Friday.

Verse 16: "My eye, my eye runs with tears." Tears without end.

Verse 18: In spite of everything: "The LORD is righteous." Righteous means: he always does what is right. Jerusalem admits its guilt.

Verse 20: "Outside, the sword takes away the children. At home, it is like death." War outside, hunger and sickness inside. There is no safe place anymore.

Verses 21–22: The city asks God to also hold the enemies responsible, the ones who are glad about its disaster. It leaves the judgment to God.

This poem shows: It is allowed to lament before God and to speak your own pain out loud. If you are grieving or in despair, you should not stay alone: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

LAMENTATIONS

CHAPTER 2

God has become like an enemy

The anger of the Lord VERSES 1–10

1 How the Lord has covered the daughter of Zion
with a cloud in his anger!
He has thrown the beauty of Israel down from heaven
to the earth.
On the day of his anger
he has not remembered his footstool.
2 The Lord has swallowed up all the homes of Jacob
without pity.
In his anger he has torn down
the strong fortresses of the daughter of Judah.
He has brought them down to the ground.
He has made the kingdom and its princes unholy.
3 In burning anger he has cut off all the strength of
Israel.

The Hebrew word for this means "horn." A horn is a picture of strength.
He has pulled back his right hand when the enemy came.
He has burned up Jacob like a flaming fire
that eats up everything around it.
4 He has bent his bow like an enemy.
He has stood with his right hand raised like an enemy.
He has killed all who were pleasant to look at.
In the tent of the daughter of Zion
he has poured out his anger like fire.
5 The Lord has become like an enemy.
He has swallowed up Israel.
He has swallowed up all her palaces.
He has destroyed his strong fortresses.
He has made the mourning and weeping great
in the daughter of Judah.
6 He has violently torn down his tent,
as if it were only a garden.
He has destroyed the place where people met with him.
The LORD has made Zion forget
the holy festivals and the Sabbath.
In his burning anger
he has rejected the king and the priest.
7 The Lord has thrown away his altar.
He hates his holy place.
He has handed over the walls of her palaces to the enemy.
They have made noise in the LORD's house,
as on the day of a holy festival.
8 The LORD has decided
to destroy the wall of the daughter of Zion.
He has stretched out the measuring line.
He has not pulled back his hand from destroying.
He has made the outer wall and the city wall mourn.
They grow weak together.
9 Her gates have sunk into the ground.
He has destroyed and broken the bars of her gates.
Her king and her princes are among the nations,
where there is no law.
Yes, her prophets find no vision from the LORD.
10 The elders of the daughter of Zion sit on the ground.
They are silent.
They have thrown dust on their heads.
They have put on sackcloth.
Sackcloth is rough cloth. People wore it when they were mourning.
The young women of Jerusalem
bow their heads down to the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This second poem speaks even more harshly: God himself "has become like an enemy" (verse 5). The poet dares to say it: It feels as if God himself has destroyed Jerusalem.

Verse 1: The "footstool" is the temple or the ark of the covenant. God did not remember even that.

Verses 6–7: The temple is destroyed. Festivals and the Sabbath are no longer celebrated. Enemies make noise in the temple as if at a festival.

Verse 9: There is no more law and no vision from the prophets. God seems to be silent.

Verse 10: The elders sit silently on the ground. Sometimes silence is the only answer to great suffering (compare Job 2:13).

These words are honest and shocking. The Bible allows people to speak about God like this when they have lived through something terrible. God can bear even such a lament.

The children grow faint VERSES 11–17

11 My eyes are worn out from crying.
My heart is troubled.
My insides are poured out on the ground
because my people are destroyed,
because the young children and the babies faint
in the streets of the city.
12 They ask their mothers,
"Where is grain and wine?"
They faint like wounded people
in the streets of the city.
Their life slips away
in their mothers' arms.
13 What can I say to you?
What can I compare you with, daughter of Jerusalem?
What can I compare to you, so that I can comfort you,
virgin daughter of Zion?
For your wound is as big as the sea.
Who can heal you?
14 Your prophets have seen false and foolish visions for you.
They have not shown you your sin,
so that your fate could have been turned around.
Instead, they have seen false messages for you,
messages that led you away into exile.
15 All who pass by clap their hands at you.
They hiss and shake their heads at the daughter of Jerusalem.
They say,
"Is this the city that people called
'The perfection of beauty, the joy of the whole earth'?"
16 All your enemies have opened their mouths wide against you.
They hiss and grind their teeth.
They say, "We have swallowed her up.
Yes, this is the day we were waiting for.
We have found it. We have seen it."
17 The LORD has done what he planned.
He has kept the word that he commanded in the days long ago.
He has torn down and has not had pity.
He has let the enemy cheer over you.
He has made your enemies strong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: The worst thing for the poet is the suffering of the children. They ask their mothers for bread and die in their arms. It is a heartbreaking picture. Sadly, it is still real today in every war and every famine.

Verse 13: "Your wound is as big as the sea. Who can heal you?" There are no words to comfort such great suffering.

Verse 14: The false prophets did not show the people their sin. Whoever keeps the truth quiet does not help but does harm.

Verses 15–16: The enemies mock the city that was once so beautiful.

Verse 17: The poet sees: God has done what he had announced through the prophets.

Pour out your heart like water VERSES 18–22

18 Their heart cried out to the Lord.
Wall of the daughter of Zion,
let tears run down like a river day and night!
Give yourself no rest.
Do not let your eyes rest.
19 Get up, cry out in the night,
when the night watches begin!
Pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord!
Lift up your hands to him
for the life of your young children,
who faint from hunger at the corner of every street.
20 "Look, LORD, and see
who it is that you have done this to!
Should women eat their own children,
the children they held and bounced on their knees?
Should the priest and the prophet be killed
in the holy place of the Lord?
21 "The young and the old lie on the ground in the streets.
My young women and my young men have been killed
by the sword.
You have killed them on the day of your anger.
You have slaughtered them and have not had pity.
22 "You have called my terrors from every side,
as people are called to the day of a holy festival.
On the day of the LORD's anger
no one escaped, and no one was left.
My enemy has destroyed
the children I cared for and raised."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19 is a famous verse: "Pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord!" In prayer you may bring everything to God: pain, fear, anger, and despair. You should pray especially for the children.

Verse 20: A terrible question to God: Look at what is happening! In the famine during the siege, mothers even eat their children. The Bible does not keep quiet about this horror. It is an accusation against war and its terrors. Children must never be harmed.

Verses 21–22: The poem ends without comfort. Sometimes there is no quick comfort in grief. The Bible lets that stand.

If you are living through such deep pain or suffer from memories of violence, you can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

LAMENTATIONS

CHAPTER 3

His mercies are new every morning

I am the man who has seen suffering VERSES 1–20

1 I am the man who has seen suffering
under the rod of his anger.
2 He has led me and made me walk in darkness,
and not in light.
3 Yes, he turns his hand against me
again and again, all day long.
4 He has made my flesh and my skin old.
He has broken my bones.
5 He has built walls against me.
He has surrounded me with bitterness and hardship.
6 He has made me live in dark places,
like people who have been dead for a long time.
7 He has built a wall around me, so that I cannot get out.
He has made my chain heavy.
8 Yes, when I cry out and call for help,
he shuts out my prayer.
9 He has blocked my ways with a wall of cut stone.
He has made my paths crooked.
10 To me he is like a bear lying in wait,
like a lion in hiding.
11 He has turned me off my path and torn me to pieces.
He has left me alone and ruined.
12 He has bent his bow
and made me the target for his arrow.
13 He has shot the arrows from his quiver
deep into my body.
A quiver is a bag for carrying arrows.
14 All my people laugh at me.
They sing songs about me all day long.
15 He has filled me with bitterness.
He has filled me up with wormwood.
Wormwood is a very bitter plant.
16 He has broken my teeth on gravel.
He has covered me with ashes.
17 You have taken my soul far away from peace.
I have forgotten what it is like to do well.
18 I said, "My strength is gone,
and so is my hope in the LORD."
19 Remember my suffering and my misery,
the wormwood and the bitterness.
20 My soul still remembers them,
and it is bowed down inside me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The third poem is the heart of the whole book. It is built differently from the others: Every three verses begin with the same Hebrew letter. That is why it has 66 verses.

Here a single person speaks: "I am the man who has seen suffering." He describes his suffering with many pictures: darkness, prison, chains, a bear lying in wait, arrows.

Verse 8: The worst thing is this: He prays, but God does not seem to hear.

Verse 18: He is at the end of his strength: "My strength is gone, and so is my hope in the LORD."

Many people who go through a serious illness, depression, or a great loss find themselves in these words. It is good to know: Feelings like these also have a place in the Bible. If you feel this way, you may look for help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

New every morning VERSES 21–33

21 But this is what I call back to my mind,
and that is why I have hope:
22 It is because of the LORD's loving kindness
that we are not destroyed,
because his mercies do not fail.
23 They are new every morning.
Great is your faithfulness.
24 "The LORD is my share," says my soul.
"That is why I will hope in him."
25 The LORD is good to those who wait for him,
to the soul who looks for him.
26 It is good for a man to hope
and to wait quietly for the LORD to save.
27 It is good for a man
to carry the yoke while he is young.
28 Let him sit alone and be silent,
because the LORD has put it on him.
29 Let him put his mouth in the dust.
Maybe there is still hope.
30 Let him turn his cheek to the one who hits him.
Let him be filled with insults.
31 For the Lord will not reject anyone forever.
32 Even if he brings grief,
he will still have mercy,
because his loving kindness is so great.
33 For he does not like to make people suffer.
He does not like to bring them grief.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–23: In the middle of the deepest despair, everything turns around. The poet remembers something that gives him hope: God's loving kindness does not end. "His mercies do not fail. They are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness." These verses are among the best-known in the Bible. They stand exactly in the middle of the book, like a light in the middle of the darkness. Every new morning is a sign of God's faithfulness.

Verse 24: "The LORD is my share." Even when everything is lost, God remains.

Verse 26: Being able to hope quietly and wait is a kind of strength.

Verses 27–30: These verses describe how someone bears suffering patiently. They are not a command to accept violence or abuse. If you are being hit or mistreated, you may and should get help: In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). Domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 31–33: A wonderful comfort: God does not reject anyone forever. And God does not like to bring suffering. His heart is full of mercy.

Let us turn back VERSES 34–47

34 When people crush all the prisoners of the earth under
their feet,
35 when they take away a person's rights
before the face of the Most High,
36 when they twist the case of a person in court,
the Lord does not approve.
37 Who can speak and have it happen,
if the Lord has not commanded it?
38 Do not both bad things and good things
come from the mouth of the Most High?
39 Why should a living person complain,
a man who is punished for his sins?
40 Let us look closely at our ways and test them,
and let us turn back to the LORD.
41 Let us lift up our hearts and our hands
to God in heaven.
42 "We have sinned and have rebelled.
You have not forgiven.
43 "You have covered us with anger and chased us.
You have killed. You have not had pity.
44 You have covered yourself with a cloud,
so that no prayer can get through.
45 You have made us like dirt and garbage
among the peoples.
46 "All our enemies have opened their mouths wide
against us.
47 Terror and the pit have come on us,
ruin and destruction."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 34–36: The Lord does not approve when prisoners are mistreated and people are denied their rights. God is on the side of the oppressed.

Verses 37–38: In the end, everything is in God's hand, even the hard things. This is an attempt to understand what cannot be understood. It does not mean that God enjoys suffering (compare verse 33).

Verses 40–41: Instead of only lamenting, the poet invites us: Let us test our lives and turn back to God. Lift up your hearts and hands to God!

Verses 42–47: An honest prayer together: We have sinned. And it feels as if you have covered yourself with a cloud that no prayer can get through.

You heard my voice VERSES 48–66

48 My eye runs with streams of tears,
because my people are destroyed.
49 My eye pours out tears and does not stop,
without any break,
50 until the LORD looks down
and sees from heaven.
51 What my eye sees hurts my soul
because of all the daughters of my city.
52 They have hunted me without stopping like a bird,
those who are my enemies for no reason.
53 They have tried to end my life in the dungeon.
They have thrown a stone on me.
54 Water flowed over my head.
I said, "I am lost."

55 I called on your name, LORD,
out of the lowest dungeon.
56 You heard my voice:
"Do not close your ear to my sighing and my cry."
57 You came near on the day I called on you.
You said, "Do not be afraid."
58 Lord, you have stood up for me in my case.
You have saved my life.
59 LORD, you have seen the wrong done to me.
Judge my case.
60 You have seen all their revenge
and all their plans against me.
61 You have heard their insults, LORD,
and all their plans against me.
62 You have heard what the people who rise up against me say,
and how they plot against me all day long.
63 You see them when they sit down and when they get up.
They sing songs about me.
64 You will pay them back, LORD,
for what their hands have done.
65 You will make their hearts hard.
Your curse will be on them.
66 You will chase them in anger
and destroy them from under the LORD's heavens.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 48–51: The poet weeps without a break until God looks down from heaven.

Verses 53–55: These words remind us of Jeremiah, who was thrown into a cistern (Jeremiah 38:6). A cistern is a deep pit for collecting water. He called to God "out of the lowest dungeon" (3:55).

Verses 56–58: And God heard! "You came near on the day I called on you. You said, 'Do not be afraid.'" That is what many people have experienced: In the deepest trouble, God is near.

Verses 59–66: The poet asks God to give him justice and to punish those who hunt him. He brings his anger to God and leaves the judgment to God, instead of taking revenge himself. Later, Jesus shows an even greater way: to pray for your enemies (Luke 23:34).

LAMENTATIONS

CHAPTER 4

How the gold has lost its shine!

The children of Zion VERSES 1–10

1 How the gold has lost its shine!
The purest gold has changed!
The stones of the holy place are thrown out
at the corner of every street.
2 The precious sons of Zion
were worth as much as fine gold.
But now people think of them as clay jars,
made by the hands of a potter!
3 Even the jackals give their milk.
They nurse their young.
But the daughter of my people has become cruel,
like the ostriches in the wilderness.
4 The tongue of the nursing baby
sticks to the roof of his mouth because he is so thirsty.
The young children ask for bread,
and no one breaks any for them.
5 Those who used to eat fine food
are lost and alone in the streets.
Those who grew up wearing purple
now lie on piles of garbage.
Purple cloth was very expensive. Only rich people wore it.
6 For the guilt of the daughter of my people
is greater than the sin of Sodom.
Sodom was destroyed in a moment,
and no hands were raised against her.
7 Her nobles were purer than snow.
They were whiter than milk.
Their bodies were redder than rubies.
They looked like polished sapphire.
8 Now they look blacker than coal.
No one recognizes them in the streets.
Their skin sticks to their bones.
It is dried out.
It has become like wood.
9 Those who are killed by the sword are better off
than those who are killed by hunger.
For the hungry waste away, as if they had been stabbed,
because there is no food from the fields.
10 Women who used to be so loving
have boiled their own children with their own hands.
The children became their food
when my people were destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fourth poem begins again with "How …!" (in Hebrew: "Ekhah").

Verses 1–2: The gold has lost its shine. The people who were once as precious as gold are treated like cheap clay jars.

Verses 3–4: Even wild animals nurse their young. But in the famine, mothers have nothing left to give their children. The children ask for bread, and no one has any. In those days the ostrich was thought to be a bird that does not take care of its eggs (compare Job 39:14–16).

Verses 5–8: The rich, who used to wear purple and eat fine food, are now thin and black from hunger. Hunger makes all people equal.

Verse 9: A terrible sentence: Someone who dies by the sword is better off than someone who slowly starves to death.

Verse 10: Again the horror is described: Desperate mothers ate their own children during the famine (compare 2:20). The Bible does not keep quiet about this. It is an accusation against war and the siege that bring people into such a situation.

Children still suffer in wars and famines today. These verses call us to look and to help.

The guilt of the prophets and priests VERSES 11–16

11 The LORD has finished pouring out his anger.
He has poured out his burning anger.
He has lit a fire in Zion,
and it has burned up her foundations.
12 The kings of the earth did not believe it,
and neither did any of the people living in the world,
that the enemy and the foe
would come in through the gates of Jerusalem.
13 It happened because of the sins of her prophets
and the guilt of her priests.
They spilled the blood of righteous people
in the middle of the city.
14 They wander like blind men in the streets.
They are so stained with blood
that no one can touch their clothes.
15 "Go away!" people shouted at them. "Unclean!
Go away! Go away! Do not touch anything!"
When they ran away and wandered around,
people among the nations said,
"They cannot live here anymore."
16 The LORD's anger has scattered them.
He will not care for them anymore.
People did not respect the priests.
They did not show kindness to the elders.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: No one had thought that Jerusalem could ever fall. People believed that no one could take the city.

Verse 13: An important reason for the destruction: Of all people, the religious leaders, the prophets and priests, killed innocent people. When those who are supposed to speak for God do wrong, it is especially bad.

Verses 14–15: Now they themselves are like people with leprosy. Everyone shouts: "Go away! Unclean!" No one wants them.

Our hope was in vain VERSES 17–22

17 Our eyes are still worn out
from looking for help that never comes.
From our watchtower we have watched
for a nation that could not save us.
18 They hunt our steps,
so that we cannot walk in our own streets.
Our end is near.
Our days are over,
for our end has come.
19 Those who chased us were faster
than the eagles in the sky.
They chased us over the mountains.
They waited to attack us in the wilderness.
20 The breath of our life, the LORD's anointed king,
was caught in their pits.
He is the one we talked about.
We said, "Under his shadow we will live among the nations."
21 Be happy and glad, daughter of Edom,
you who live in the land of Uz.
The cup will be passed to you too.
You will get drunk and will make yourself naked.
22 The punishment for your guilt is finished, daughter of Zion.
He will not take you away as a prisoner anymore.
But he will punish your guilt, daughter of Edom.
He will uncover your sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Jerusalem had hoped for help from Egypt, but in vain.

Verse 20: "The LORD's anointed king" is King Zedekiah. The people had hoped to live under his protection, but he was captured (Jeremiah 39:5).

Verse 21: Edom was glad when Jerusalem fell. But Edom will soon have to drink the "cup" too.

Verse 22: And then the first ray of light in a long time: "The punishment for your guilt is finished, daughter of Zion." The worst is over. God will not take you away again. This reminds us of Isaiah 40:2. There, God says that people should call out to Jerusalem that her guilt is forgiven.

LAMENTATIONS

CHAPTER 5

Bring us back to you

Remember, LORD, what has happened to us VERSES 1–18

1 Remember, LORD, what has happened to us.
Look, and see how we are put to shame.
2 The land we inherited has been handed over to strangers.
Our houses have been handed over to foreigners.
3 We are orphans without fathers.
Our mothers are like widows.
4 We must pay money for the water we drink.
We have to buy our own wood.
5 Those who chase us are right on our necks.
We are tired, and we have no rest.
6 We have reached out our hands to the Egyptians
and to the Assyrians
to get enough bread to eat.
7 Our ancestors sinned, and they are gone.
We have carried the punishment for their sins.
8 Slaves rule over us.
There is no one to save us from their hands.
9 We risk our lives to get our bread,
because of the sword in the wilderness.
10 Our skin is black like an oven
from the burning heat of hunger.
11 They raped the women in Zion,
the young women in the cities of Judah.

12 Princes were hung up by their hands.
No one showed honor to the elders.
13 The young men have to carry millstones.
Millstones are heavy stones for grinding grain.
The children stumbled under loads of wood.
14 The elders no longer sit at the city gate.
The young men no longer play their music.
15 The joy of our hearts has ended.
Our dancing has turned into mourning.
16 The crown has fallen from our head.
How terrible for us, for we have sinned!
17 That is why our hearts are weak.
That is why our eyes are dim:
18 because of Mount Zion, which lies empty and ruined.
Foxes walk around on it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fifth poem is a prayer of the whole people together: "Remember, LORD… Look, and see." It is not built on the alphabet. But it has 22 verses, as many as there are letters in the Hebrew alphabet.

Verses 2–4: Life in an occupied land: Houses belong to strangers. People even have to pay a lot for water and firewood.

Verse 7: "Our ancestors sinned, and they are gone. We have carried the punishment for their sins." The children suffer because of the mistakes of the generation before them. Jeremiah, on the other hand, says that in the future each person will answer only for their own guilt (Jeremiah 31:29–30).

Verse 11: Sexual violence against women is a war crime, then as now. The Bible names this wrong and brings it before God as an accusation. If you have experienced sexual violence, you can find help: In the US: RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 13: Even children have to do hard forced labor.

Verses 14–15: No more court at the city gate, no more music, no more dancing. All life has died away.

Verse 18: On the temple mountain, where God used to be worshiped, foxes now run around.

But you, LORD, remain forever VERSES 19–22

19 You, LORD, remain forever.
Your throne lasts from generation to generation.
20 Why do you forget us forever?
Why do you leave us alone for so long?
21 Bring us back to yourself, LORD,
and we will come back.
Make our days new again, as they were long ago.
22 But you have completely rejected us.
You are very angry with us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: In the middle of all the suffering, a firm confession: "You, LORD, remain forever." Everything is destroyed, but God remains.

Verse 20: And yet the honest question: "Why do you forget us forever? Why do you leave us alone for so long?"

Verse 21 is a famous prayer: "Bring us back to yourself, LORD, and we will come back. Make our days new again, as they were long ago." The people know: We cannot turn back on our own. God has to bring us back. This verse is sung in Jewish worship when the Torah scroll is put back into the ark.

Verse 22: The book ends with a bitter sentence: "You have completely rejected us." Some translations read it as a question: Or have you completely rejected us? There is no quick answer. In the synagogue, verse 21 is read once more after verse 22. That way the book ends with the prayer for renewal and not with anger.

Looking back: What have we read in Lamentations?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Five poems about a disaster: Lamentations mourns for Jerusalem, which was destroyed in the year 587 BC. The poems describe hunger, death, people taken away, and the burned temple.

Grief from A to Z: The first four poems are built on the Hebrew alphabet. The pain is spoken out completely. Nothing is left out.

Honest lament: The poems say openly: "The Lord has become like an enemy" (2:5). The Bible allows us to tell God everything, even anger and despair.

No one comforts: "She has no comforter" (Chapter 1). The suffering is also a deep loneliness.

The children: Again and again the poems speak about the suffering of children in war and hunger. They call us to look.

Guilt and suffering: The poems say honestly that the people sinned. But they do not make the suffering small.

Hope in the middle: Right in the heart of the book it says: "His mercies do not fail. They are new every morning. Great is your faithfulness" (3:22–23).

Bring us back: At the end comes the prayer: "Bring us back to yourself, LORD, and we will come back" (5:21).

For today: Lamentations helps everyone who is grieving to find words for their pain. If you are grieving, you do not have to stay alone: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Ezekiel. Ezekiel was a priest who lived in Babylon. There he had visions of God's glory.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 26 OF 66

EZEKIEL

48 CHAPTERS

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 1

The glory of the LORD

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHO WAS EZEKIEL?

Ezekiel was a priest from Jerusalem. In the year 597 BC, he was taken away to Babylon together with King Jehoiachin and many others. There he lived with other exiles by the river Chebar.

Five years later, around 593 BC, God called him to be a prophet. So Ezekiel worked at the same time as Jeremiah, but not in Jerusalem. He worked in Babylon.

His name means "God makes strong."

Ezekiel had powerful visions: He saw God's glory on a throne chariot. He saw God's glory leave the temple. And he saw a field full of dry bones that come to life again. He acted out many unusual signs to make his message visible.

The book has 48 chapters and three parts:

– Chapters 1–24: Judgment on Jerusalem, before the city is destroyed.

– Chapters 25–32: Words about the neighboring peoples.

– Chapters 33–48: Hope after the destruction: a new heart, a new spirit, the good shepherd, the bones that come to life, and a new temple.

Again and again God calls Ezekiel "son of man." That simply means "human being." It shows how small a human being is before the great God.

Jews and Christians read Ezekiel as a book of hope: God is with his people even in exile, and he can make dead things live.

The vision by the river Chebar VERSES 1–14

1 It was in the thirtieth year, in the fourth month, on the fifth day of the month.
I was among the captives by the river Chebar.
Then the heavens opened, and I saw visions of God.
2 It was on the fifth day of the month.
That was the fifth year since King Jehoiachin was taken captive.
3 The LORD's word came to Ezekiel the priest, the son of Buzi,
in the land of the Chaldeans by the river Chebar.
The Chaldeans are the Babylonians.
And the LORD's hand was on him there.
4 I looked, and I saw a storm wind coming out of the north.
There was a great cloud with flashing lightning,
and a bright light all around it.
In the middle of it, in the middle of the fire,
there was something like glowing metal.
5 Out of the middle of it came something like four living creatures.
This is what they looked like:
They had the shape of a man.
6 Each one had four faces,
and each one of them had four wings.
7 Their feet were straight.
The soles of their feet were like the sole of a calf's foot.
They sparkled like polished bronze.
8 Under their wings, on their four sides,
they had the hands of a man.
All four of them had faces and wings like this:
9 Their wings touched one another.
They did not turn when they moved.
Each one went straight forward.
10 This is what their faces looked like:
They had the face of a man.
All four had the face of a lion on the right side.
All four had the face of an ox on the left side.
All four also had the face of an eagle.
11 Those were their faces.
Their wings were spread out above.
Two wings of each one touched the wings of another,
and two wings covered their bodies.
12 Each one went straight forward.
Wherever the spirit wanted to go, they went.
They did not turn when they moved.
13 The living creatures looked like burning coals of fire,
like torches.
The fire moved back and forth among the living creatures.
The fire was bright, and lightning came out of the fire.
14 The living creatures ran back and forth
like flashes of lightning.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Ezekiel is 30 years old (the "thirtieth year" probably means his age). At that age, priests usually began their service in the temple (Numbers 4:3). But Ezekiel is far away from the temple, in exile. And right there the heavens open! God is not tied to Jerusalem. He also comes to the exiles.

Verse 4: A mighty storm, a cloud, fire, and lightning: These are signs that God is coming (compare Exodus 19:16).

Verses 5–14: Ezekiel tries to describe what cannot be described. He often uses the word "like." For example, the creatures "looked like burning coals of fire." The four creatures have four faces: a man, a lion, an ox, and an eagle. These are the wisest, the strongest, the most powerful, and the fastest of the living things. Later Ezekiel calls them "cherubim" (Chapter 10).

In Christian tradition, the four faces became symbols of the four Gospel writers: Matthew (man), Mark (lion), Luke (ox), and John (eagle). The book of Revelation describes similar creatures (Revelation 4:6–8).

Wheels full of eyes VERSES 15–21

15 As I looked at the living creatures,
I saw one wheel on the ground beside the living creatures,
one for each of their four faces.
16 The wheels and the way they were made looked like beryl.

All four of them looked the same.
They looked as if one wheel was inside another wheel.
17 When they moved, they went in any of their four directions.
They did not turn when they moved.
18 Their rims were high and frightening.
The rims of all four were full of eyes all around.
19 When the living creatures moved, the wheels moved beside them.
When the living creatures rose up from the ground, the wheels rose up too.
20 Wherever the spirit wanted to go, they went.
The spirit wanted to go there.
The wheels rose up beside them,
because the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels.
21 When the creatures moved, the wheels moved.
When the creatures stood still, the wheels stood still.
When the creatures rose up from the ground,
the wheels rose up beside them,
because the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Beside each creature there is a wheel, as if one wheel was inside another wheel. That way they can move in all directions without turning. The wheels are full of eyes: God sees everything.

The whole thing is like a moving throne chariot. The message is: God's throne is not fixed in one place. It is not only in the temple in Jerusalem. God can go anywhere, even to his people in exile in Babylon.

In Judaism this vision is called "Merkavah" (throne chariot). Later it became the basis for a whole branch of Jewish mysticism.

Verse 16: The WEB, our English source text, has "beryl." This means a precious stone that shines green or blue.

The throne and the glory VERSES 22–28

22 Over the heads of the living creatures
there was something like an expanse.
An expanse is a wide, open space.
It looked like amazing crystal,
stretched out high above their heads.
23 Under the expanse their wings were stretched out straight,
one toward the other.
Each one had two wings that covered it on this side,
and two wings that covered its body on that side.
24 When they moved, I heard the noise of their wings.
It was like the noise of great waters,
like the voice of the Almighty,
a loud roar like the noise of an army.
When they stood still, they let their wings down.
25 There was a voice from above the expanse over their heads.
When they stood still, they let their wings down.
26 Above the expanse over their heads
there was something like a throne.
It looked like a sapphire stone.
High up on the throne
there was a shape that looked like a man.
27 From what looked like his waist upward,
I saw something like glowing metal,
with something like fire all around it inside.
From what looked like his waist downward,
I saw something that looked like fire.
There was a bright light all around him.
28 The bright light all around him looked like the rainbow that is in the clouds on a rainy day.
This is what the likeness of the LORD's glory looked like.
When I saw it, I fell on my face.
And I heard the voice of someone speaking.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Above the creatures there is a kind of crystal ceiling. Above that there is a throne like sapphire. And on the throne there is a shape "that looked like a man," surrounded by fire and light.

Verse 28: Ezekiel is very careful with his words. He does not say, I saw God. He says, "This is what the likeness of the LORD's glory looked like." God is too great to be described directly.

The rainbow reminds us of God's covenant with Noah (Genesis 9:13). In the middle of fire and storm, a sign of faithfulness shines.

Ezekiel falls on his face. Meeting God's holiness overwhelms him.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 2

Ezekiel is sent

Son of man, stand on your feet VERSES 1–7

1 He said to me,
"Son of man, stand up on your feet,
and I will speak with you."
2 When he spoke to me, the Spirit came into me
and set me on my feet.
And I heard the one who was speaking to me.
3 He said to me,
"Son of man, I am sending you to the people of Israel,
to a nation of rebels who have rebelled against me.
They and their ancestors have sinned against me
until this very day.
4 The children are rude and stubborn.
I am sending you to them.
You must say to them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says.'
5 They may listen, or they may refuse to listen,
for they are a rebellious people.
But either way, they will know
that there has been a prophet among them.

6 And you, son of man, do not be afraid of them.
Do not be afraid of their words,
even if thorn bushes and thorns are all around you,
and you live among scorpions.
Do not be afraid of their words.
Do not be frightened by the way they look at you,
even though they are a rebellious people.
7 You must speak my words to them,
whether they listen or refuse to listen,
for they are very rebellious.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: God calls Ezekiel "son of man" (in Hebrew: "ben adam"). That simply means "human being." In the book of Ezekiel, God speaks to him this way more than 90 times. It shows how small a human being is before God. At the same time, it shows that God wants to speak with this human being. (Later Jesus often calls himself "Son of Man," taking up Daniel 7:13.)

Verse 2: Ezekiel is lying on his face. God's Spirit sets him back on his feet. God himself gives him the strength to stand.

Verse 5: Whether the people listen or not, they will know "that there has been a prophet among them." Ezekiel's task is not to be successful. His task is to pass on God's word faithfully.

Verse 6: For him, the people will be like thorns and scorpions, painful and dangerous. But God says three times: "Do not be afraid!"

The scroll VERSES 8–10

8 But you, son of man, listen to what I tell you.
Do not be rebellious like that rebellious people.
Open your mouth, and eat what I give you."
9 When I looked, I saw a hand reaching out to me.
In it was a scroll.
A scroll is a long roll of writing material.
10 He spread it out in front of me.
There was writing on the front and on the back.
Words of lament, mourning, and sorrow were written on it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God gives Ezekiel a scroll. Usually people wrote on only one side. This scroll has writing on both sides, so much is written on it. And what it says is hard: laments, mourning, and words of sorrow. That is the message Ezekiel must pass on: judgment on Jerusalem.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 3

The watchman

Ezekiel eats the scroll VERSES 1–11

1 He said to me,
"Son of man, eat what you find.
Eat this scroll,
and go and speak to the people of Israel."
2 So I opened my mouth,
and he gave me the scroll to eat.
3 He said to me,
"Son of man, eat this scroll that I am giving you.
Fill your stomach and your insides with it."
Then I ate it.
It was as sweet as honey in my mouth.
4 He said to me,
"Son of man, go to the people of Israel,
and speak my words to them.
5 For I am not sending you to a people
whose language is strange and hard to understand.
I am sending you to the people of Israel.
6 I am not sending you to many peoples
whose language is strange and hard to understand,
whose words you cannot understand.
If I sent you to them,
they would certainly listen to you.
7 But the people of Israel will not listen to you,
because they will not listen to me.
For all the people of Israel are stubborn and hard-hearted.
8 Look, I have made your face as hard as their faces,
and your forehead as hard as their foreheads.
9 I have made your forehead like a diamond,
harder than flint.
Do not be afraid of them.
Do not be frightened by the way they look at you,
even though they are a rebellious people."
10 He also said to me,
"Son of man, take into your heart all my words that I speak to you,
and listen to them with your ears.
11 Go to the captives,
to the people of your own nation.
Speak to them and tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says,'
whether they listen or refuse to listen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Ezekiel eats the scroll. This is a picture: God's word should go deep into him and become a part of him. And even though the message is bitter, it tastes "as sweet as honey." Receiving God's word is a gift, even when the message is hard (compare Jeremiah 15:16; Psalm 119:103; Revelation 10:9–10).

Verses 5–7: A sad irony: Foreign peoples with a foreign language would listen to Ezekiel. But his own people, who understand his language, do not want to listen.

Verses 8–9: Because the people have hard foreheads, God makes Ezekiel's forehead even harder, "like a diamond." This is a play on his name: Ezekiel means "God makes strong."

Seven days without words VERSES 12–15

12 Then the Spirit lifted me up.
Behind me I heard the sound of a great rushing noise:

"Blessed be the LORD's glory from his place!"
13 I heard the noise of the wings of the living creatures
as they touched one another,
and the noise of the wheels beside them,
the sound of a great rushing noise.
14 So the Spirit lifted me up and took me away.
I went full of bitterness, with my spirit burning inside me.
And the LORD's hand was strong on me.
15 Then I came to the captives at Tel Aviv,
who lived by the river Chebar.
I came to the place where they lived.
I sat there among them for seven days,
completely shaken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "Blessed be the LORD's glory from his place!" This sentence is part of an important Jewish prayer, the "Kedushah," together with "Holy, holy, holy" from Isaiah 6:3.

Verse 14: Ezekiel is shaken and bitter. Meeting God has upset him deeply.

Verse 15: Tel Aviv (many Bibles write "Tel Abib") means "hill of ears of grain." The modern city of Tel Aviv in Israel (founded in 1909) got its name from here in a roundabout way: The Hebrew translation of Theodor Herzl's book "Old New Land" was called "Tel Aviv," and that title was taken from this verse. Ezekiel sits among the exiles for seven days without speaking. Seven days was the usual time of mourning.

I am making you a watchman VERSES 16–21

16 At the end of the seven days, the LORD's word came to me.
He said,
17 "Son of man, I have made you a watchman for the people of Israel.
So listen to the word from my mouth,
and warn them for me.
18 I may say to a wicked man, 'You will certainly die.'
If you do not warn him,
and you do not speak to warn him to leave his wicked way
so that he can save his life,
then that wicked man will die because of his sin.
But I will hold you responsible for his death.
19 But if you warn the wicked man,
and he does not turn away from his wickedness and his wicked way,
he will die because of his sin.
But you have saved yourself."
20 "And when a righteous man turns away from doing what is right
and does wrong,
and I put a stumbling block in front of him,
he will die.
Because you did not warn him,
he will die in his sin.
The good things he did will not be remembered.
But I will hold you responsible for his death.
21 But if you warn the righteous man not to sin,
and he does not sin,
he will certainly live, because he listened to the warning.
And you have saved yourself."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the past, a watchman stood on the city wall. If he saw danger, he had to sound the alarm. If he stayed silent, he was to blame for the disaster.

In the same way, Ezekiel is to be a "watchman" for his people: He is to warn them. Whether the people listen is their responsibility. But if he does not warn them, he shares the responsibility.

Verses 20–21: Righteous means: living right before God.

This is also a message for today: Whoever sees wrong and stays silent shares the responsibility. Sometimes it is our task to warn people honestly, even when it is uncomfortable.

Ezekiel cannot speak VERSES 22–27

22 The LORD's hand was on me there.
He said to me,
"Get up, go out into the plain,
and I will talk with you there."
23 So I got up and went out into the plain.
And the LORD's glory was standing there,
like the glory I had seen by the river Chebar.
Then I fell on my face.
24 Then the Spirit came into me and set me on my feet.
He spoke with me and said to me,
"Go, shut yourself inside your house.
25 And you, son of man,
they will put ropes on you and tie you up with them.
You will not be able to go out among the people.
26 I will make your tongue stick to the roof of your mouth,
so that you cannot speak
and cannot correct them,
for they are a rebellious people.
27 But when I speak with you,
I will open your mouth.
Then you must tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says.'
Whoever wants to listen, let him listen.
Whoever refuses, let him refuse.
For they are a rebellious people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel must shut himself inside his house and be silent. He may only speak when God gives him something to say. This makes it clear: Ezekiel does not speak his own thoughts, but only God's word.

This silence lasts until the destruction of Jerusalem (compare 24:27; 33:22).

Verse 27: "Whoever wants to listen, let him listen." Jesus says something similar: "Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!" (Matthew 13:9).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 4

Signs of the siege

Jerusalem on a brick VERSES 1–8

1 "And you, son of man, take a brick.
Put it in front of you,
and draw a city on it: Jerusalem.
2 Put the city under siege.
Build towers against it,
and pile up a ramp of earth against it.
Also set up army camps against it,
and put battering rams all around it.
3 Take an iron pan,
and set it up as a wall of iron between you and the city.
Then turn your face toward the city.
It will be under siege, and you will attack it.
This will be a sign for the people of Israel.
4 "Then lie down on your left side,
and put the guilt of the people of Israel on it.
For as many days as you lie on that side,
you will carry their guilt.
5 For I have turned the years of their guilt
into a number of days for you:
390 days.
That is how long you will carry the guilt of the people
of Israel.
6 "When you have finished these days,
lie down on your right side,
and carry the guilt of the people of Judah.
I have given you 40 days,
one day for each year.
7 Turn your face toward Jerusalem under siege,
with your arm bare,
and prophesy against it.
8 Look, I will tie you up with ropes,
so that you cannot turn from one side to the other
until you have finished the days of your siege.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel cannot speak (Ezekiel 3:26). That is why he "preaches" with sign actions, like street theater. He draws Jerusalem on a clay brick and acts out the siege, with ramps, camps, and battering rams. The exiles in Babylon hoped that Jerusalem would be spared. Ezekiel shows them: The city will be put under siege.

Verse 2: A siege is when an army surrounds a city and attacks it. Battering rams are heavy beams for breaking down walls and gates.

Verse 3: The iron pan shows a separation: God has turned away from the city, as if behind a wall of iron.

Verses 4–6: 390 days on the left side for Israel (the northern kingdom), 40 days on the right side for Judah. Each day stands for one year of guilt. What exactly the numbers mean is still uncertain today. Bible scholars have suggested different explanations.

Ezekiel probably did not lie there day and night without a break, but for a certain time each day. After all, he also had to bake bread (verses 9–12).

Verse 7: The "bare arm" is a sign of being ready to fight, like rolling up your sleeves.

Bread by weight VERSES 9–17

9 "Also take wheat, barley, beans, lentils, millet, and
spelt,
and put them into one pot.
Make bread out of it.
You will eat it for as many days as you lie on your side:
390 days.
10 The food you eat must be weighed:
20 shekels (about 8 ounces) a day.
Eat it at set times.
11 You must also measure the water you drink:
one sixth of a hin (about 1 to 2 pints).
Drink it at set times.
12 Eat it as you would eat barley cakes.
Bake it where the people can see you,
using human dung as fuel."
13 The LORD said,
"In the same way, the people of Israel will eat their
bread unclean
among the nations where I will drive them."
14 Then I said,
"Oh, Lord GOD!
I have never made myself unclean.
From the time I was young until now,
I have never eaten an animal that died by itself
or was torn apart by wild animals.
No disgusting meat has ever come into my mouth!"
15 Then he said to me,
"All right, I will let you use cow dung instead of
human dung.
You may bake your bread on it."
16 He also said to me,
"Son of man, I will break the staff of bread in
Jerusalem.
They will weigh their bread and eat it with worry.
They will measure their water and drink it in fear.
17 They will run out of bread and water.
They will look at one another in horror.
They will waste away because of their guilt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Ezekiel must bake an emergency bread out of all kinds of grains, beans, and lentils. That is how people eat when food runs short and they scrape together whatever is left.

Verses 10–11: A shekel is a weight of about 0.4 ounces. 20 shekels are about 8 ounces of bread a day. A hin is a measure for liquids. One sixth of a hin is about 1 to 2 pints of water. Those are starvation rations, as in a city under siege.

Verses 12–15: In the ancient Near East, dried dung was a common fuel. But human waste was thought to be unclean. Ezekiel is a priest and protests: All his life he has kept the food laws. And God listens to him! He allows cow dung instead of human dung. This shows: God is willing to talk with us. Honest objections in prayer are allowed.

Verse 13: The message is: In exile, among foreign peoples, it will be hard to live by God's commandments.

Verse 16: The "staff of bread" is a picture: Bread supports life like a walking stick. When this staff breaks, hunger comes.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 5

The shaved hair

Hair in the fire, by the sword, and in the wind VERSES 1–4

1 "And you, son of man, take a sharp sword.
Use it like a barber's razor.
Shave your head and your beard with it.
Then take scales for weighing, and divide the hair into parts.
2 When the days of the siege are over,
burn one third of the hair in the fire in the middle of the city.
Take another third,
and strike it with the sword all around the city.
Scatter the last third into the wind.
And I will pull out a sword and go after them.
3 Take a few of the hairs,
and tie them up in the folds of your robe.
4 Take some of these again,
and throw them into the middle of the fire, and burn them up.
From there a fire will spread to all the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The next sign: Ezekiel shaves his head and beard with a sword. Really this was forbidden for a priest (Leviticus 21:5). A shaved head was a sign of mourning and shame.

The hair is divided into three parts. They show what will happen to the people in Jerusalem: One part dies in the city, one part by the sword, and one part is scattered to all the winds.

Verse 3: A few hairs are kept in the robe. That is a small ray of hope: A remnant is kept safe. But even some of this remnant is burned (verse 4). Even those who are rescued are not simply safe.

This is Jerusalem VERSES 5–17

5 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'This is Jerusalem.
I have put her in the middle of the nations,
with other countries all around her.
6 But she has rebelled against my laws.
She has done more evil than the nations.
She has rebelled against my rules
more than the countries around her.
For her people have rejected my laws,
and they have not lived by my rules.'
7 "That is why the Lord GOD says:
'You have been more unruly than the nations around you.
You have not lived by my rules.
You have not kept my laws.
You have not even followed the laws of the nations around you.
8 That is why the Lord GOD says:
I, yes, I myself, am against you.
I will carry out judgments among you
while the nations watch.
9 Because of all your disgusting deeds,
I will do something to you that I have never done before,
and I will never do anything like it again.
10 That is why among you fathers will eat their sons,
and sons will eat their fathers.
I will carry out judgments on you.
I will scatter all of you who are left
to all the winds.
11 That is why, as surely as I live,' says the Lord GOD,
'because you have made my holy place unclean
with all your disgusting idols and all your disgusting deeds,
I will also cut you down.
My eye will not spare you,
and I will have no pity.
12 One third of you will die of disease
or will be destroyed by hunger inside the city.
One third will be killed by the sword around you.
And one third I will scatter to all the winds,
and I will pull out a sword and go after them.
13 "'That is how my anger will come to an end.
I will let my anger against them come to rest,
and I will be comforted.
When I have finished pouring out my anger on them,
they will know that I, the LORD, have spoken in my burning love.
14 "'I will also make you a ruin
and a shame among the nations around you,
in front of everyone who passes by.
15 You will be a shame and a mockery,
a warning and a horror
to the nations around you,
when I carry out judgments on you
in anger, in fury, and with angry punishments.
I, the LORD, have spoken.
16 I will shoot the deadly arrows of hunger at them,
arrows that bring destruction.
I will send them to destroy you.
I will make the hunger worse and worse for you,
and I will break your staff of bread.
17 I will send hunger and wild animals against you,
and they will take your children from you.
Disease and bloodshed will sweep through you.
I will bring the sword against you.
I, the LORD, have spoken.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: God says about Jerusalem: "I have put her in the middle of the nations." She was meant to be an example, a light for the other peoples. But Jerusalem behaved even worse than her neighbors.

Verses 9–10: These words are terrible. During long sieges, there really was such terrible hunger that people became cannibals (compare Lamentations 2:20; 4:10). Ezekiel describes the disaster that is coming without making anything sound nicer than it is.

Verses 11–13: God speaks very harshly here: "I will have no pity." Words like these show how seriously God takes wrongdoing. But they do not stand alone: Later in the book, God says that he takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked. He wants the wicked to turn from his way and live (Ezekiel 33:11; compare 18:23).

Important: These texts describe God's judgment in a certain situation. They give no one the right to do violence to other people or to explain suffering as a "punishment from God."
Verse 13: "I will be comforted" is what the WEB, our English source text, says. It means: God's anger comes to rest.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 6

Against the mountains of Israel

The high places will be destroyed VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
2 "Son of man, turn your face toward the mountains of Israel,
and prophesy to them.
3 Say,
'You mountains of Israel, listen to the word of the Lord GOD!
This is what the Lord GOD says
to the mountains and to the hills,
to the streams and to the valleys:
"I, yes, I myself, will bring a sword against you,
and I will destroy your high places.
4 Your altars will be ruined,
and your incense altars will be broken.
I will throw down your dead in front of your idols.
5 I will lay the dead bodies of the people of Israel
in front of their idols.
I will scatter your bones all around your altars.
6 Wherever you live,
the cities will be ruined,
and the high places will be empty and destroyed.
Then your altars will be ruined and destroyed.
Your idols will be broken and will be gone.
Your incense altars will be cut down.
And the things you have made will be wiped out.
7 People will be killed and will fall among you.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the mountains and hills of Israel there were many "high places." Foreign gods were worshiped there. Often the LORD was also worshiped there, mixed with foreign customs.

God announces: These places will be destroyed. The idols the people trusted cannot save them. The dead bodies lie in front of the idols, and the idols can do nothing.

Verse 7: "Then you will know that I am the LORD." This sentence comes more than 60 times in the book of Ezekiel. It is the goal of everything: People should come to know who God really is.

A remnant will remember VERSES 8–10

8 "'"But I will leave a remnant.
Some of you will escape the sword among the nations,
when you are scattered through the countries.
9 Those of you who escape
will remember me among the nations
where they have been taken as captives.
They will remember how I was broken
by their unfaithful hearts, which turned away from me,
and by their eyes, which were unfaithful to me and chased after their idols.
Then they will be disgusted with themselves
because of the evil things they did
with all their disgusting deeds.
10 They will know that I am the LORD.
I did not say for nothing
that I would bring this disaster on them."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the judgment, hope comes: A remnant will survive. A remnant is a small group of people who are left. In exile they will remember God.

Verse 9: A touching sentence: God says that he "was broken" by their unfaithful hearts. God is not cold and without feeling. The unfaithfulness of his people hurts him, like a person whose love has been betrayed.

The Hebrew text uses a picture of prostitution here. It describes being unfaithful to God, like adultery. It is a picture of the relationship between God and his people. It says nothing bad about women or about people in prostitution.

"Disgusted with themselves" means: seeing honestly what they have done wrong. That is the first step toward turning back. But it is not about hating yourself forever. God wants people to turn back and live.

A lament over Israel VERSES 11–14

11 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'Clap your hands and stamp your foot,
and say, "How terrible!"
because of all the evil and disgusting deeds of the people of Israel.
For they will die by the sword, by hunger, and by disease.
12 Whoever is far away will die of disease.
Whoever is near will be killed by the sword.
Whoever is left and is shut in by the siege will die of hunger.
That is how I will finish pouring out my anger on them.
13 You will know that I am the LORD
when their dead lie among their idols,
all around their altars,
on every high hill, on all the mountaintops,
under every green tree and under every thick oak.
Those are the places where they offered sweet-smelling

sacrifices
to all their idols.
14 I will reach out my hand against them.
I will make the land empty and ruined,
from the wilderness to Diblah,
in all the places where they live.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Ezekiel is to clap his hands and stamp his foot. These are gestures of lament and horror.

Verse 12: No one can escape, not far away, not nearby, and not in the city under siege.

Verse 13: "Under every green tree": Foreign gods were often worshiped under shady trees on hills (compare Deuteronomy 12:2; Jeremiah 2:20).

Verse 14: "Diblah" is a place no one knows. Many scholars think that "Riblah" is meant, a city far in the north. The Hebrew letters for d and r look very much alike. Then it would mean: from the wilderness in the south to Riblah in the north, so the whole land.

These chapters are hard to read. They show the disaster that came on Jerusalem. If pictures of war and violence weigh on you, you can talk with someone about it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 7

The end is coming

An end! The end has come! VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
2 "You, son of man, this is what the Lord GOD says to the land of Israel:
'An end!
The end has come on the four corners of the land.
3 Now the end has come on you.
I will send my anger against you,
and I will judge you for the way you have lived.
I will make you pay for all your disgusting deeds.
4 My eye will not spare you,
and I will have no pity.
I will make you pay for the way you have lived,
and your disgusting deeds will be right among you.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.'
5 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'A disaster! A disaster like no other!
Look, it is coming.
6 An end has come.
The end has come!
It has woken up against you.
Look, it is coming.
7 Your doom has come on you,
you who live in the land!
The time has come!
The day is near.
It is a day of panic on the mountains,
not a day of happy shouting.
8 Soon I will pour out my anger on you.
I will finish my anger against you,
and I will judge you for the way you have lived.
I will make you pay for all your disgusting deeds.
9 My eye will not spare,
and I will have no pity.
I will punish you for the way you have lived.
Your disgusting deeds will be right among you.
Then you will know that I, the LORD, am the one who strikes you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter sounds like alarm bells: "An end! The end has come!" The words are repeated again and again, short and hard. The people are meant to wake up.

The "four corners of the land" means: the whole land, from one end to the other.

Verses 3–4: "I will send my anger against you, and I will judge you for the way you have lived." God brings the evil that the people have done back on themselves. Wrongdoing has consequences.

Compare also Amos 8:2: "The end has come for my people Israel."

The day is here VERSES 10–13

10 "'Look, the day!
Look, it is coming!
Your doom has gone out.
The rod has blossomed.
Pride has budded.
11 Violence has grown into a rod of wickedness.
None of them will be left,
none of their crowds,
none of their riches.
Nothing of value will be left among them.
12 The time has come!
The day is coming near.
Do not let the buyer be glad,
and do not let the seller be sad,
for my anger is on all the crowds of the land.
13 For the seller will not get back what he sold,
even if they are both still alive.
For the vision is about all the crowds of the land.
None of them will come back.
No one will make himself strong
while living in his sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: The "rod" has blossomed. The picture means: Evil has grown like a plant and has put out blossoms: pride and violence. Now it becomes a stick that strikes.

Verses 12–13: Usually a buyer is glad about a good purchase, and a seller is sad when he has to sell his land. According to the law, land that had been sold could come back to its owner in the Year of Jubilee (Leviticus 25). But now that

does not matter: Everyone will lose the land. Business and property lose their value when the disaster comes.

No one goes to battle VERSES 14–22

14 "'They have blown the trumpet
and made everything ready.
But no one goes to battle,
for my anger is on all the crowds of the land.
15 "'The sword is outside,
and disease and hunger are inside.
Whoever is in the field will die by the sword.
Whoever is in the city will be eaten up by hunger and disease.
16 Those who escape will get away.
They will be on the mountains like doves of the valleys.
All of them will moan,
each one because of his sin.
17 All hands will be weak,
and all knees will be as weak as water.
18 They will put on sackcloth,
and horror will cover them.
Shame will be on every face,
and every head will be shaved bald.
19 They will throw their silver into the streets,
and their gold will be like something unclean.
Their silver and their gold will not be able to save them on the day of the LORD's anger.
These things will not satisfy their hunger
or fill their stomachs.
For their silver and gold made them stumble into sin.
20 He had made his beautiful jewel glorious.
But they used it to make the images of their disgusting and hateful idols.
That is why I have made it unclean for them.
21 I will hand it over to strangers as loot,
and to the wicked people of the earth as plunder.
They will make it unholy.
22 I will also turn my face away from them,
and they will make my hidden place unholy.
Robbers will go into it and make it unholy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: The trumpet calls people to battle, but no one goes. The people have no courage left.

Verse 16: The refugees moan on the mountains like doves. To people in those days, the cooing of doves sounded like lamenting.

Verse 19: The people throw their money away. Silver and gold cannot save them, and they cannot be eaten. Riches were more important to them than God, and now they are worth nothing. (Compare Zephaniah 1:18.)

Verses 20–22: The "beautiful jewel" is probably the temple, or the gold and silver from which idols were made. God's "hidden place" is probably the Most Holy Place in the temple. Foreigners will go into it and make it unholy. That happened in 586 BC, when the Babylonians destroyed the temple.

They will look for peace VERSES 23–27

23 "'Make chains,
for the land is full of crimes of bloodshed,
and the city is full of violence.
24 That is why I will bring the worst of the nations,
and they will take over their houses.
I will also put an end to the pride of the strong.
Their holy places will be made unholy.
25 Destruction is coming!
They will look for peace,
but there will be none.
26 Disaster will come on disaster,
and one rumor will follow another.
They will look for a vision from the prophet.
But the priest will have no more teaching from the law,
and the elders will have no more advice.
27 The king will mourn,
and the prince will be clothed in despair.
The hands of the people of the land will shake.
I will deal with them the way they have lived.
I will judge them by their own standards.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: "Make chains": The people will be taken away into captivity in chains. The reason is clearly named: violence and bloodshed in the land.

Verse 26: In the crisis, people look for advice from prophets, priests, and elders. But no one knows what to do anymore. All the leaders are at a loss.

Verse 27: "I will judge them by their own standards." God measures them with the measure they used for others. Jesus says something similar: "With the measure you use to measure, it will be measured to you" (Matthew 7:2).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 8

Disgusting things in the temple

Ezekiel is brought to Jerusalem VERSES 1–6

1 It was in the sixth year, in the sixth month, on the fifth day of the month.
I was sitting in my house,
and the elders of Judah were sitting in front of me.
Then the hand of the Lord GOD came on me there.
2 I looked, and I saw a shape that looked like fire.
From what looked like his waist downward, there was fire.
From his waist upward, there was something like a bright light,
like glowing metal.
3 He reached out something that looked like a hand,
and he took hold of me by a lock of my hair.
The Spirit lifted me up between the earth and the sky.
In visions from God, he brought me to Jerusalem,
to the entrance of the inner court gate that faces north.

That is where the idol of jealousy stood,
the idol that makes God jealous.
4 And there was the glory of the God of Israel,
just as I had seen it in the plain.
5 Then he said to me,
"Son of man, now look toward the north."
So I looked toward the north.
North of the altar gate, in the entrance,
I saw this idol of jealousy.
6 He said to me,
"Son of man, do you see what they are doing?
Do you see the terrible, disgusting things that the people of Israel are doing here?
These things are driving me far away from my holy place.
But you will see even more terrible, disgusting things."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This is in the year 592 BC, a little more than a year after Ezekiel was called. The elders of the exiles are sitting with him, maybe to ask for advice.

Verse 3: In a vision, Ezekiel is brought to Jerusalem. His body stays in Babylon, but in the Spirit he sees what is happening in the temple.

The "idol of jealousy" is an idol right at the temple. It makes God jealous. God does not want his people to serve other gods, just as a loving partner does not want unfaithfulness (compare Exodus 20:5).

Verse 6: Because of these disgusting things, God has to go far away from his holy place. That is the great message of Chapters 8–11: God's glory leaves the temple.

Secret idols in the dark VERSES 7–13

7 He brought me to the entrance of the court.
When I looked, I saw a hole in the wall.
8 Then he said to me,
"Son of man, now dig into the wall."
When I had dug into the wall,
I saw a door.
9 He said to me,
"Go in, and see the evil, disgusting things they are doing here."
10 So I went in and looked.
All around on the wall
there were pictures of every kind of crawling thing and disgusting animal,
and of all the idols of the people of Israel.
11 70 of the elders of the people of Israel
were standing in front of them.
Jaazaniah the son of Shaphan was standing in the middle of them.
Each man had his incense burner in his hand,
and a sweet-smelling cloud of incense was rising up.
12 Then he said to me,
"Son of man, have you seen what the elders of the people of Israel are doing in the dark,
each man in his own room full of idol pictures?
For they say,
'The LORD does not see us.
The LORD has left the land.'"
13 He also said to me,
"You will see even more terrible, disgusting things that they are doing."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Behind a wall, in secret, 70 elders worship pictures of animals and idols. These men were supposed to lead the people.

Verse 11: Jaazaniah is a son of Shaphan. It is not certain whether this Shaphan is the same as the scribe under King Josiah, whose family helped Jeremiah. If so, that would be especially sad: a son from a faithful family among the idol worshipers.

Verse 12: "The LORD does not see us." That is the excuse of many people who do wrong in secret. But the vision shows: God sees everything, even what happens in the dark (compare Psalm 139:11–12).

Women weep for Tammuz VERSES 14–15

14 Then he brought me to the entrance of the gate of the LORD's house
that faces north.
I saw women sitting there,
weeping for Tammuz.
15 Then he said to me,
"Have you seen this, son of man?
You will see even more terrible, disgusting things than these."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tammuz was a god from Mesopotamia. According to the myth, he died and went down into the world of the dead. Every year there were rituals in which people wept for him. He was connected with the growing and dying of plants.

Right at the temple of the LORD, people are weeping for a foreign god. What is criticized here is the foreign worship, not the women as women. In Chapter 8, men are criticized in the same way (the 70 elders and the 25 men).

By the way: One month in the Jewish calendar is still called "Tammuz" today.

Worshiping the sun VERSES 16–18

16 He brought me into the inner court of the LORD's house.
At the entrance of the LORD's temple,
between the porch and the altar,
there were about 25 men.
Their backs were toward the LORD's temple,
and their faces were toward the east.
They were bowing down to the sun in the east.
17 Then he said to me,
"Have you seen this, son of man?
Is it a small thing for the people of Judah
to do the disgusting things they are doing here?
They have also filled the land with violence,
and they make me angry again and again.
Look, they are holding the branch to their nose.
18 That is why I will act in anger too.
My eye will not spare them,
and I will have no pity.
Even if they shout into my ears with a loud voice,
I will not listen to them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: The worst disgusting thing comes at the end: In the innermost court, right in front of the temple, 25 men turn their backs to God and worship the sun. That is a strong picture: They literally turn their backs on God.

Verse 17: Idol worship and violence go together: "They have also filled the land with violence." People who leave God often also lose respect for other people.

"Holding the branch to their nose" was probably a ritual of the foreign religion. What exactly it means is no longer known for certain today.

Verse 18: God will no longer listen. That is frightening. It shows: There is a point where it is too late. But the book of Ezekiel does not end with judgment. It ends with a new beginning (Chapters 36–48).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 9

The mark on the forehead

A mark for those who sigh VERSES 1–4

1 Then he shouted into my ears with a loud voice,
"Bring near the men who are in charge of the city,
each man with his weapon for destroying in his hand!"
2 Then six men came from the direction of the upper gate,
which faces north.
Each man had his weapon for killing in his hand.
One man among them was dressed in linen.
He had a writer's ink case at his side.
They went in and stood beside the bronze altar.
3 The glory of the God of Israel rose up
from the cherub it had been on,
and moved to the doorway of the temple.
He called to the man dressed in linen,
who had the writer's ink case at his side.
4 The LORD said to him,
"Go through the middle of the city, through the middle of Jerusalem.
Put a mark on the foreheads of the men
who sigh and cry
over all the disgusting things that are being done in it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a vision, a picture in Ezekiel's mind. It is not a description of something people are supposed to do. The six men are heavenly messengers of judgment. The seventh man, dressed in linen, is like God's scribe. Linen was the clothing of the priests and of the angels (compare Daniel 10:5).

Verse 3: God's glory leaves its place above the cherubim in the Most Holy Place and moves to the doorway of the temple. That is the first step: God begins to leave the temple.

Verse 4: Before the judgment comes, God takes care of the righteous. Whoever is sad about the wrongdoing, whoever "sighs and cries," gets a mark on the forehead and is spared. God sees the people who do not take part.

The Hebrew word for "mark" is "tav." That is also the name of the last letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In the old writing it looked like a cross or an X. Later, many Christians saw in it a hint of the cross. Compare also Exodus 12:13 (the blood on the doors) and Revelation 7:3 (the seal on the forehead).

The judgment begins at the holy place VERSES 5–11

5 I heard him say to the others,
"Follow him through the city, and strike.
Do not let your eye spare anyone.
Do not have pity.
6 Kill them all: old men, young men, young women,
little children, and women.
But do not come near anyone who has the mark.
Begin at my holy place."
So they began with the elders who were in front of the temple.
7 He said to them,
"Make the temple unclean,
and fill the courts with the dead.
Go out!"
So they went out and struck people down in the city.
8 While they were killing,
I was left alone.
I fell on my face
and cried out,
"Oh, Lord GOD!
Will you destroy everyone who is left in Israel
when you pour out your anger on Jerusalem?"
9 Then he said to me,
"The sin of the people of Israel and Judah is very, very great.
The land is full of blood,
and the city is full of injustice.
For they say,
'The LORD has left the land,
and the LORD does not see.'
10 So my eye will not spare them either,
and I will have no pity.
I will bring on their own heads what they have done."
11 Then the man dressed in linen,
who had the ink case at his side,
came back with a report.
He said,
"I have done what you commanded me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This text is very hard to read. In a vision, it describes the destruction of Jerusalem that really happened in the year 586 BC through the Babylonians. Children, women, and old people also died then. The Bible does not keep quiet about this horror.

Very important: This text is not an order for people to follow. No one may use it as an excuse to do violence to others. Judgment belongs to God alone (compare Romans 12:19). Violence against children and defenseless people is always wrong.

Verse 6: "Begin at my holy place." The judgment begins with those who should have known best: with the elders at the temple. Compare 1 Peter 4:17: "For the time has come for judgment to begin with the household of God."

Verse 8: Ezekiel throws himself down and cries out: "Will you destroy everyone who is left in Israel?" He speaks up for his people, as Abraham did for Sodom (Genesis 18) and Moses did for Israel (Exodus 32). A prophet is not cold. He suffers along with the people.

Verse 11: At the end the scribe reports: "I have done what you commanded me." That means: The people with the mark were protected. God did not forget those who lamented over the wrongdoing.

If texts like this shake you or remind you of your own experiences of violence, you are not alone. You can talk with someone for free and without giving your name: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

EZEKIEL

Chapter 10

The glory leaves the temple

Fire between the cherubim VERSES 1–8

1 Then I looked.
In the expanse over the heads of the cherubim,
I saw something above them like a sapphire stone.
It looked like the shape of a throne.
2 He spoke to the man dressed in linen and said,
"Go in between the whirling wheels, under the cherub.
Fill both your hands with burning coals
from between the cherubim,
and scatter them over the city."
And he went in while I watched.
3 The cherubim were standing on the right side of the temple
when the man went in.
And the cloud filled the inner court.
4 The LORD's glory rose up from the cherub
and stood over the doorway of the temple.
The temple was filled with the cloud,
and the court was full of the bright light of the LORD's glory.
5 The sound of the cherubim's wings could be heard
as far as the outer court.
It sounded like the voice of God Almighty when he speaks.
6 He gave the man dressed in linen this command:
"Take fire from between the whirling wheels,
from between the cherubim."
Then the man went in and stood beside a wheel.
7 One cherub reached out his hand from between the cherubim
to the fire that was between the cherubim.
He took some of it
and put it into the hands of the man dressed in linen.
The man took it and went out.
8 Under the wings of the cherubim
I could see something that looked like a man's hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel sees the throne chariot from Chapter 1 again. Now he calls the living creatures "cherubim" (one of them is called a cherub). Cherubim are heavenly beings who surround God's throne. In the temple there were figures of cherubim above the ark of the covenant (Exodus 25:18–22).

Verse 2: Before this, the man in linen had marked the righteous (Chapter 9). Now he is to scatter burning coals over the city. This is a picture of the fire that will destroy Jerusalem.

In Isaiah 6:6–7, a burning coal from the altar touches Isaiah's lips and makes him clean. Here the fire is a fire of judgment.

The wheels and the cherubim VERSES 9–17

9 I looked, and I saw four wheels beside the cherubim,
one wheel beside each cherub.
The wheels looked like beryl stone.
10 As for the way they looked,
all four of them looked the same,
like a wheel inside a wheel.
11 When they moved, they went in any of their four directions.
They did not turn as they moved.
Wherever the head faced, they followed it.
They did not turn as they moved.
12 Their whole bodies, their backs, their hands, their wings,
and the wheels were full of eyes all around.
That was true of the wheels of all four of them.
13 I heard the wheels being called
"the whirling wheels."
14 Each one had four faces.
The first face was the face of the cherub.
The second face was the face of a man.
The third face was the face of a lion.
The fourth was the face of an eagle.
15 The cherubim rose up.
These were the living creatures I had seen by the river Chebar.
16 When the cherubim moved, the wheels moved beside them.
When the cherubim lifted their wings to rise up from the ground,
the wheels did not leave their side.
17 When the cherubim stood still, the wheels stood still.
When the cherubim rose up, the wheels rose up with them,
for the spirit of the living creature was in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This description repeats much of Chapter 1. Ezekiel wants to make it clear: It is the same God, the same glory, that he saw by the river Chebar.

Verse 14: Here there is a difference from Ezekiel 1:10: Instead of the face of an ox, verse 14 says: the face of the cherub. Why is not completely clear. Maybe the face of an ox was the typical face of a cherub.

Verse 13: "Whirling wheels": The Hebrew word "galgal" means something that turns, like a whirlwind.

The glory goes to the east gate VERSES 18–22

18 The LORD's glory left the doorway of the temple
and stood over the cherubim.
19 As I watched, the cherubim lifted their wings
and rose up from the ground as they went out.
The wheels were beside them.
They stopped at the entrance of the east gate of the
LORD's house,
and the glory of the God of Israel was high above them.
20 These were the living creatures
that I had seen under the God of Israel by the river
Chebar.
And I knew that they were cherubim.
21 Each one had four faces,
and each one had four wings.
Under their wings was something that looked like a
man's hands.
22 Their faces looked
just like the faces I had seen by the river Chebar.
They looked the same, and they were the same.
Each one went straight forward.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now something unthinkable happens: God's glory leaves the temple step by step. First it went to the doorway (9:3; 10:4). Now it gets onto the throne chariot and goes to the east gate (verse 19).

For the people in Jerusalem, it was clear: God lives in the temple. So nothing can happen to them (compare Jeremiah 7:4). Ezekiel shows: God is not tied to the building. If the people leave him, he can also leave the temple.

But God goes slowly, step by step. It is as if he is hesitating, as if he is waiting to see whether his people will turn back after all.

In Chapter 43, the glory will come back through the east gate!

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 11

A new heart

The pot and the meat VERSES 1–13

1 Then the Spirit lifted me up
and brought me to the east gate of the LORD's house,
which faces east.
At the entrance of the gate there were 25 men.
Among them I saw Jaazaniah the son of Azzur
and Pelatiah the son of Benaiah, leaders of the people.
2 He said to me,
"Son of man, these are the men who plan evil
and give wicked advice in this city.
3 They say,
'The time to build houses is not near.
This city is the cooking pot, and we are the meat.'
4 So prophesy against them.
Prophesy, son of man."
5 Then the LORD's Spirit came on me,
and he said to me,
"Say, 'This is what the LORD says:
"That is what you have said, people of Israel.
I know the thoughts that come into your minds.
6 You have killed many people in this city.
You have filled its streets with the dead."
7 "'That is why the Lord GOD says:
"The dead you have left lying in the middle of the city
are the meat, and this city is the pot.
But you will be brought out of it.
8 You have been afraid of the sword,
and I will bring the sword against you,"
says the Lord GOD.
9 "I will bring you out of the city
and hand you over to strangers.
I will carry out judgments on you.
10 You will be killed by the sword.
I will judge you at the border of Israel.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
11 This city will not be your cooking pot,
and you will not be the meat in it.
I will judge you at the border of Israel.
12 You will know that I am the LORD.
For you have not lived by my rules.
You have not kept my laws.
Instead, you have followed the laws of the nations
around you."'"
13 While I was prophesying, Pelatiah the son of Benaiah
died.
Then I fell down on my face.
I cried out with a loud voice,
"Oh, Lord GOD!
Will you completely destroy all who are left in Israel?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: The powerful men in Jerusalem are proud. They say: "This city is the cooking pot, and we are the meat." That means: We are the best part, well protected in the city like meat in a pot. The others, who were taken away, are the garbage. There is no need to "build houses" somewhere else, because we are staying here.

Verses 6–7: God turns the picture around: The real "meat" in the pot is the innocent people these men have killed. The powerful men themselves will be taken out of the city and judged.

Verse 10: "At the border of Israel": This came true in Riblah, far in the north. There the king of Babylon had the leaders of Judah executed (2 Kings 25:18–21).

Verse 13: While Ezekiel is prophesying, Pelatiah dies. Ezekiel is not glad about it. He is shocked and cries out to God. Again he speaks up for his people. By the way, the name Pelatiah means "The LORD rescues." That makes Ezekiel's question even more urgent.

God will be their holy place VERSES 14–21

14 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
15 "Son of man, the people of Jerusalem have spoken to your brothers,
yes, your brothers, the men of your own family,
and to all the people of Israel, all of them.
They have said to them,
'Go far away from the LORD.
This land has been given to us to own.'
16 "So say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I have sent them far away among the nations.
I have scattered them among the countries.
But for a little while I will be a holy place for them
in the countries where they have gone."'
17 "So say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will gather you from the peoples.
I will bring you together out of the countries
where you have been scattered.
And I will give you the land of Israel."
18 "'They will come there,
and they will remove from it all its hateful idols
and all its disgusting things.
19 I will give them one heart,
and I will put a new spirit inside them.
I will take the heart of stone out of their bodies,
and I will give them a heart of flesh.
20 Then they will live by my rules,
and they will keep my laws and obey them.
They will be my people,
and I will be their God.
21 But some people's hearts will keep following
their hateful idols and their disgusting things.
I will bring on their own heads what they have done,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The people in Jerusalem say to the exiles: "Go far away from the LORD. This land has been given to us to own." They think they are the winners.

Verse 16: But God says the opposite: He wants to be with the exiles! He himself will be their "holy place," even without a temple. That is a great comfort: God is there even in a foreign land. You can find him anywhere. (Later, in Judaism, this verse was also connected with the synagogues, as a "little holy place.")

Verse 19: One of the most beautiful promises in the Bible: God takes away the "heart of stone," which is hard and cold. He gives a "heart of flesh," which is alive and can feel. God himself changes people from the inside. This promise comes again in Ezekiel 36:26.

Compare Jeremiah 31:33. There God promises to put his law inside his people and to write it on their hearts.

The glory goes to the Mount of Olives VERSES 22–25

22 Then the cherubim lifted their wings,
and the wheels were beside them.
The glory of the God of Israel was high above them.
23 The LORD's glory rose up from the middle of the city
and stopped on the mountain east of the city.
24 The Spirit lifted me up.
In the vision given by the Spirit of God,
he brought me to Chaldea, to the captives.
Then the vision I had seen left me.
25 And I told the captives everything
that the LORD had shown me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: Now God's glory leaves the city completely and stops on the mountain east of Jerusalem. That is the Mount of Olives. From there it can still look at the city.

Interesting: In the New Testament, the Mount of Olives plays a big part. Jesus weeps over Jerusalem there (Luke 19:37–41), and from there he goes up into heaven (Acts 1:9–12).

Verses 24–25: The vision is over. Ezekiel is back with the exiles in Babylon and tells them everything. The message to the exiles is: The temple in Jerusalem is no longer safe. But God is with you.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 12

Bags packed for exile

Ezekiel packs his bags VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
2 "Son of man, you live among a rebellious people.
They have eyes to see, but they do not see.
They have ears to hear, but they do not hear,
for they are a rebellious people.
3 "So, son of man,
pack your bags as if you were moving away,
and move out during the day while they watch.
While they watch, move from your place to another place.
Maybe they will understand,
even though they are a rebellious people.
4 Bring out your bags during the day while they watch,
like bags for moving away.
Then in the evening, go out yourself while they watch,
like people who are going into exile.
5 While they watch, dig through the wall,
and carry your bags out through the hole.

6 While they watch, carry the bags on your shoulder,
and take them out in the dark.
Cover your face, so that you cannot see the land.
For I have made you a sign to the people of Israel."
7 I did what I was commanded.
During the day I brought out my bags, like bags for moving away.
In the evening I dug through the wall with my hand.
I took my bags out in the dark
and carried them on my shoulder while they watched.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "They have eyes to see, but they do not see." Jesus takes up these words later (Mark 8:18).

A new sign action: Ezekiel packs a bag for running away, like someone who has to leave his home. In the evening he digs a hole through the wall of the house and slips away with his face covered. In those days, houses were often made of clay bricks, so it was possible to dig a hole in them.

Verse 3: "Maybe they will understand." God does not give up hope.

Today many millions of people around the world have to flee from their homes, often with only one bag. This text can help us imagine what it is like to be a refugee.

The prince will run away VERSES 8–16

8 In the morning the LORD's word came to me.
He said,
9 "Son of man, the people of Israel, that rebellious people,
have asked you, 'What are you doing?'
10 "Tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"This burden is about the prince in Jerusalem
and all the people of Israel who live there."'
11 "Say,
'I am a sign for you.
What I have done will be done to them.
They will go into exile, into captivity.
12 "'The prince who is among them
will carry his bags on his shoulder in the dark
and go out.
They will dig through the wall to carry things out through it.
He will cover his face,
because he will not see the land with his eyes.
13 I will also spread my net over him,
and he will be caught in my trap.
I will bring him to Babylon, to the land of the Chaldeans.
But he will not see it,
even though he will die there.
14 All who are around him to help him,
and all his troops,
I will scatter to every wind.
I will pull out a sword and go after them.
15 "'They will know that I am the LORD
when I scatter them among the nations
and spread them through the countries.
16 But I will let a few of them escape
from the sword, from hunger, and from disease.
Then they can tell about all their disgusting deeds
among the nations where they go.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "Burden": The Hebrew word "massa" means both "burden" and "message" (of a prophecy). Ezekiel carries a real burden on his shoulder, and at the same time it is a message. (Compare Jeremiah 23:33–40.)

The "prince" is King Zedekiah, the last king of Judah. That is exactly what happened: When Jerusalem fell in 586 BC, Zedekiah ran away at night through an opening in the wall. He was caught, and his eyes were put out. Then he was taken to Babylon (2 Kings 25:4–7; Jeremiah 39:4–7).

Verse 13: "I will bring him to Babylon, to the land of the Chaldeans. But he will not see it, even though he will die there." That sounds like a riddle, but it came true word for word: Zedekiah was blind when he came to Babylon.

Verse 16: A few survivors will tell the other nations what happened and why.

Eating with trembling VERSES 17–20

17 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
18 "Son of man, shake while you eat your bread.
Tremble and be afraid while you drink your water.
19 Tell the people of the land,
'This is what the Lord GOD says
about the people who live in Jerusalem and in the land of Israel:
"They will eat their bread with fear
and drink their water in horror.
Their land will be stripped empty of everything in it,
because of the violence of all who live there.
20 The cities where people live will be destroyed,
and the land will be an empty ruin.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another sign: Ezekiel eats and drinks while trembling with fear. That is how it will be for the people in Jerusalem when the siege comes.

Verse 19: Again the reason is named: "because of the violence." Violence destroys not only the victims. In the end it also destroys the community where it happens.

God's word will not be delayed VERSES 21–28

21 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
22 "Son of man, what is this saying that you have in the land of Israel:
'The days go on and on,
and every vision comes to nothing'?
23 So tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will put an end to this saying.
People will not use it as a saying in Israel anymore."'
Instead, tell them,
'"The days are near
when every vision will come true.
24 For there will be no more false visions
and no more flattering fortune-telling among the people of Israel.

25 For I am the LORD.
I will speak,
and the word I speak will be done.
It will not be put off any longer.
For in your days, you rebellious people,
I will speak the word, and I will do it,"
says the Lord GOD.'"
26 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
27 "Son of man, the people of Israel are saying,
'The vision he sees is for many days from now.
He is prophesying about times far in the future.'
28 "So tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"None of my words will be put off any longer.
The word I speak will be done,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people have two excuses:

Verse 22: The people have a saying: "The days go on and on, and every vision comes to nothing." That means: The prophets always talk about disaster, but it never happens.

Verse 27: The people say: "The vision he sees is for many days from now." That means: Maybe it will happen someday, but not in our time.

God answers: My word will come true, and soon, "in your days." And in fact, Jerusalem was destroyed a few years later.

Today, too, people like to push warnings away: "It won't be that bad," or, "It doesn't affect me." The text reminds us: It is wise to take warnings seriously and to turn back in time (compare 2 Peter 3:9).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 13

False prophets

How terrible for the foolish prophets VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
2 "Son of man, prophesy against the prophets of Israel
who are prophesying.
Say to those who prophesy out of their own hearts,
'Listen to the LORD's word!
3 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"How terrible it will be for the foolish prophets
who follow their own spirit
and have seen nothing!
4 Israel, your prophets have been like foxes among the
ruins.
5 You have not gone up into the gaps in the wall.
You have not built up the wall for the people of Israel,
so that they could stand firm in the battle on the day of
the LORD.
6 They have seen false things and told lying fortunes.
They say, 'The LORD says,'
but the LORD has not sent them.
And they have made people hope
that their words would come true.
7 Have you not seen a false vision?
Have you not told a lying fortune
when you say, 'The LORD says,'
even though I have not spoken?"
8 "'That is why the Lord GOD says:
"You have spoken false things and seen lies.
That is why I am against you,"
says the Lord GOD.
9 "My hand will be against the prophets
who see false visions and tell lying fortunes.
They will not be in the council of my people.
They will not be written in the list of the people of
Israel.
They will not come into the land of Israel.
Then you will know that I am the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time there were many prophets. Some said only what people wanted to hear. They spoke "out of their own hearts," that is, their own wishes and ideas. And then they claimed: "The LORD says."

Verse 4: "Foxes among the ruins": Foxes look for a comfortable spot in ruins, but they do not build anything up. That is what the false prophets are like: They use the crisis for themselves.

Verse 5: A true prophet would have gone "into the gaps," that is, into the holes in a broken wall, to protect the people. He would have called the people to turn back.

Verse 9: The false prophets will not be in the "list" of the people (like a list of citizens). They no longer belong.

Today, too: Not everyone who speaks "in God's name" tells the truth. It is good to test things carefully (compare 1 John 4:1).

The whitewashed wall VERSES 10–16

10 "'They have led my people astray.
They say, "Peace,"
when there is no peace.
When someone builds a wall,
they cover it with whitewash.
11 Tell those who cover it with whitewash
that it will fall.
A pouring rain will come.
You, great hailstones, will fall.
A storm wind will tear it apart.
12 When the wall has fallen,
people will ask you,
"Where is the whitewash you put on it?"
13 "'That is why the Lord GOD says:
"In my anger I will tear it apart with a storm wind.
In my anger a pouring rain will come,
and great hailstones in my fury will destroy it.
14 I will break down the wall you covered with
whitewash.

I will knock it down to the ground,
so that its foundation is laid bare.
It will fall,
and you will be destroyed under it.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
15 That is how I will pour out all my anger on the wall
and on those who covered it with whitewash.
And I will tell you,
'The wall is gone,
and so are those who covered it with whitewash.
16 They are the prophets of Israel who prophesy about Jerusalem
and see visions of peace for her,
when there is no peace,'"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "Peace," the false prophets say, "everything will be fine." But there is no peace. (Jeremiah says the same thing: Jeremiah 6:14; 8:11.)

Whitewash is a thin white paint. The picture: The people build a shaky wall, that is, an uncertain hope. The false prophets paint it nicely white, so that it looks strong. But when the storm comes, it falls down anyway. Nice paint does not make a bad wall stronger.

Today we would say: "Whitewashing" problems or talking them up does not solve them. Honesty is better than false comfort.

Compare also Jesus: the house on the sand and the house on the rock (Matthew 7:24–27).

Against the false prophetesses VERSES 17–23

17 "And you, son of man, turn your face against the women of your people
who prophesy out of their own hearts.
Prophesy against them.
18 Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"How terrible it will be for the women who sew magic bands on everyone's elbows
and make veils for the heads of people of every size,
to hunt people's souls!
Will you hunt the souls of my people
and keep souls alive for your own gain?
19 You have dishonored me among my people
for a few handfuls of barley and a few pieces of bread.
You kill people who should not die,
and you keep alive people who should not live,
by lying to my people, who listen to lies."
20 "'That is why the Lord GOD says:
"I am against your magic bands
that you use to hunt souls as if they were birds.
I will tear them off your arms.
I will set free the souls
that you trap like birds.
21 I will also tear off your veils
and save my people from your hands.
They will no longer be in your power to be trapped.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
22 With your lies, you have made the hearts of righteous people sad,
when I have not made them sad.
You have encouraged wicked people,
so that they do not turn from their wicked ways
and save their lives.
23 That is why you will no longer see false visions
or tell fortunes.
I will save my people from your hands.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Besides false prophets, there were also women who worked with magic and fortune-telling. With magic bands and veils, they made people afraid or gave them false hope, and they let people pay them for it. What exactly the bands and veils were is no longer known for certain today.

Important: They are criticized not because they are women, but because they lie and manipulate people. The Bible knows many true prophetesses, for example Miriam (Exodus 15:20), Deborah (Judges 4:4), and Huldah (2 Kings 22:14). The male false prophets are criticized just as harshly (verses 1–16).

Verse 19: "For a few handfuls of barley": They sell God's name for a small profit.

Verse 22: The worst thing is: They make good people sad and encourage evil people to keep going. That is the exact opposite of what God wants.

Verses 20–21: God himself frees people from these traps. Today, too, there are people who manipulate others with fear, "curses," or false promises and make money from it. God wants people to be free.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 14

Noah, Daniel, and Job

Idols in the heart VERSES 1–11

1 Then some of the elders of Israel came to me
and sat down in front of me.
2 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
3 "Son of man, these men have taken their idols into their hearts.
They have put in front of their faces the things that make them stumble into sin.
Should I let them ask me anything at all?
4 So speak to them and tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Suppose someone from the people of Israel
takes his idols into his heart
and puts in front of his face the things that make him stumble into sin,
and then he comes to the prophet.

I, the LORD, will answer him there myself,
in a way that fits his many idols.
5 I will do this to take hold of the hearts of the people of Israel,
because they have all turned away from me through their idols."'
6 "So tell the people of Israel,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Turn back! Turn away from your idols!
Turn your faces away from all your disgusting things.
7 "'"Suppose someone from the people of Israel,
or one of the foreigners who live in Israel,
separates himself from me.
He takes his idols into his heart.
He puts in front of his face the things that make him stumble into sin.
Then he comes to the prophet to ask me something for himself.
I, the LORD, will answer him myself.
8 I will turn my face against that man.
I will make him a horror,
a warning sign and a saying people repeat.
I will cut him off from my people.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
9 "'"If the prophet is deceived and speaks a message,
then I, the LORD, have deceived that prophet.
I will reach out my hand against him
and destroy him from among my people Israel.
10 They will carry the punishment for their guilt.
The prophet's guilt will be the same as the guilt of the one who asks him.
11 Then the people of Israel will no longer wander away from me.
They will no longer make themselves unclean with all their sins.
Instead, they will be my people,
and I will be their God,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The elders come to Ezekiel to ask God for advice. On the outside they seem to be devout. But in their hearts they cling to idols.

"Idols in the heart": This does not have to be a figure made of wood or stone. An idol is anything that is more important to us than God: money, power, success, reputation. You can have an idol in your heart even if you look devout on the outside.

Verse 6: In the middle of the hard words is the call: "Turn back!" God does not want to punish. He wants people to come back.

Verse 9: A difficult sentence: "Then I, the LORD, have deceived that prophet." In the Bible, everything is often traced back to God, even hard things (compare 1 Kings 22:19–23). It probably means: Whoever does not want the truth gets, in the end, the deception he is looking for. God lets the lie run its course.

Verse 11: The goal is not destruction but relationship. God does all this so that "they will be my people, and I will be their God."

Only their own lives VERSES 12–20

12 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
13 "Son of man, suppose a land sins against me by being unfaithful.
And suppose I reach out my hand against it.
I break its staff of bread and send hunger on it.
I wipe out both people and animals from it.
14 Even if these three men, Noah, Daniel, and Job, were in it,
their righteousness would save only their own lives,"
says the Lord GOD.
15 "Suppose I send wild animals through the land,
and they leave it without people,
and it becomes an empty ruin,
so that no one can travel through it because of the animals.
16 Even if these three men were in it,
as surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"they could not save their sons or their daughters.
Only they themselves would be saved,
but the land would be an empty ruin.
17 "Or suppose I bring a sword against that land and say,
'Sword, go through the land,'
and I wipe out both people and animals from it.
18 Even if these three men were in it,
as surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"they could not save their sons or their daughters.
Only they themselves would be saved.
19 "Or suppose I send a disease into that land
and pour out my anger on it with bloodshed,
to wipe out both people and animals from it.
20 Even if Noah, Daniel, and Job were in it,
as surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"they could not save a son or a daughter.
Their righteousness would save only their own lives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Noah, Daniel, and Job were famous for being righteous people. Noah was saved from the flood. Job stayed faithful in his suffering.

About "Daniel" there are two opinions: Many people think of the prophet Daniel, who lived in Babylon at the same time as Ezekiel. Other scholars think of a very old, famous righteous man named "Danel," who appears in texts from the neighbors of Israel. The Hebrew spelling here fits that. Both are possible.

The message is: The people in Jerusalem may have thought: There are a few good people among us. Because of them, God will spare the city (compare Abraham and Sodom, Genesis 18:23–32). But God says: Not this time. Each person is responsible for himself. You cannot hide behind the faith of other people.

The theme of personal responsibility is explained in detail in Chapter 18.

A remnant will come VERSES 21–23

21 For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"How much worse it will be
when I send my four terrible judgments on Jerusalem,
the sword, hunger, wild animals, and disease,
to wipe out both people and animals from it!

22 But a remnant will be left in it.
Some sons and daughters will be brought out.
They will come out to you,
and you will see how they live and what they do.
Then you will be comforted about the disaster
that I have brought on Jerusalem,
about everything I have brought on it.
23 They will comfort you
when you see how they live and what they do.
Then you will know
that I did not do without a reason
all that I have done in it,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some people from Jerusalem will survive and come to the exiles in Babylon. When the exiles see how these people have lived, they will understand why the disaster came.

"You will be comforted" means here: You will understand and be able to accept it. It does not mean that the suffering was good. But it was not meaningless, and it was not random.

Important: This text explains one particular disaster in history. It must not be used today to claim that people who suffer are to blame for it themselves (compare Jesus in John 9:2–3 and Luke 13:1–5).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 15

The wood of the vine

What is the wood of the vine good for? VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
2 "Son of man, how is the wood of the vine better than
any other tree,
the branch of the vine among the trees of the forest?
3 Do people take its wood to make anything?
Do they make a peg from it to hang a pot on?
4 No, it is thrown into the fire as fuel.
The fire has burned up both of its ends,
and the middle is burned black.
Is it good for anything now?
5 When it was whole,
it was not good for anything.
How much less is it good for anything
after the fire has burned it
and it is burned black!"
6 That is why the Lord GOD says:
"The wood of the vine among the trees of the forest
is something I have given to the fire as fuel.
In the same way I will give up the people who live in
Jerusalem.
7 I will turn my face against them.
They will come out of one fire,
but the fire will still burn them up.
Then you will know that I am the LORD,
when I turn my face against them.
8 I will make the land an empty ruin,
because they have been unfaithful,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, Israel was often compared to a vine (Psalm 80:8–16, in some Bibles 80:9–17; Isaiah 5:1–7). A vine is valuable, but only because of its fruit. Its wood is crooked and soft. You cannot even make a hook out of it. When a vine does not bring grapes, it is only good as firewood.

Verses 4–5: Jerusalem is like a piece of vine wood that has already been burned at both ends. The ends probably stand for the disasters the people have already lived through (the destruction of the northern kingdom and the first exile in 597 BC). What is left will also be burned.

Jesus takes up this picture in the New Testament: "I am the vine. You are the branches. If you remain in me and I remain in you, you will bear much fruit" (John 15:1–8). For Jesus, it is above all an invitation: Stay connected with me, then you will grow and bring fruit.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 16

Jerusalem, the abandoned baby

First: How should we read this chapter?

Ezekiel 16 is one of the longest and harshest chapters in the Bible. In it, Jerusalem is pictured as a woman: first as an abandoned baby whom God rescues, then as a wife who is unfaithful to him.

This picture is a metaphor for the relationship between God and his people. "Unfaithfulness" and "prostitution" mean worshiping idols and trusting in foreign great powers instead of God. The message is spoken to all the people of Jerusalem, men and women alike, and above all to the powerful.

Some pictures in this chapter are violent and shaming. They come from a time and culture in which women had few rights. Many readers today find them hurtful, and that is understandable.

Very important: This chapter never justifies violence against women or against any person. Anyone who experiences violence deserves protection and help, not blame.

The chapter does not end with punishment but with God's faithfulness: an everlasting covenant and forgiveness (verses 60–63).

The abandoned child VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
2 "Son of man, make Jerusalem see her disgusting deeds.
3 Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says to Jerusalem:
"You come from the land of the Canaanites.
You were born there.
Your father was an Amorite,
and your mother was a Hittite.
4 On the day you were born,
no one cut your cord.
No one washed you with water to make you clean.
No one rubbed you with salt
or wrapped you in cloths.
5 No one looked at you with pity.
No one did any of these things for you
or showed you kindness.
Instead, you were thrown out into the open field,
because people hated you on the day you were born.
6 "'"Then I passed by you
and saw you kicking about in your blood.
I said to you,
'Even though you are lying in your blood, live!'
Yes, I said to you,
'Even though you are lying in your blood, live!'
7 I made you grow like the plants in the field.
You grew and became tall
and became very beautiful.
Your breasts were formed,
and your hair grew.
But you were still naked and bare.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Jerusalem was first a Canaanite city, before David captured it (2 Samuel 5:6–9). The message is: Jerusalem has no reason to be proud of where it came from. Everything it is, it owes to God.

Verses 4–5: In those days, a newborn baby was washed, rubbed with salt (people believed this was good for the skin), and wrapped in cloths. This baby got none of that. It was abandoned, unwanted and hated. Sadly, abandoning babies, often girls, did happen in the ancient world.

Verse 6: One of the most touching verses in the Bible: God passes by, sees the helpless child, and says: "Live!" Twice! God rescues where no one else helps. In Judaism, this verse is spoken at the circumcision of a baby boy, and it is connected with the Passover festival.

God makes a covenant VERSES 8–14

8 "'"Later I passed by you again and looked at you.
You were old enough for love.
So I spread my cloak over you
and covered your nakedness.
Yes, I promised myself to you
and made a covenant with you,"
says the Lord GOD,
"and you became mine.
9 "'"Then I washed you with water.
Yes, I washed all your blood off you,
and I rubbed you with oil.
10 I also dressed you in clothes with colorful embroidery
and put leather sandals on your feet.
I wrapped you in fine linen
and covered you with silk.
11 I decorated you with jewelry.
I put bracelets on your arms
and a necklace around your neck.
12 I put a ring in your nose,
earrings in your ears,
and a beautiful crown on your head.
13 So you were decorated with gold and silver.
Your clothes were made of fine linen, silk, and embroidered cloth.
You ate fine flour, honey, and oil.
You became very, very beautiful,
and you rose to be a queen.
14 You became famous among the nations for your beauty.
It was perfect
because of the glory I had put on you,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: God says: "I spread my cloak over you." This was a sign that a man wanted to marry and protect someone (compare Ruth 3:9). God enters into a covenant, a firm bond full of faithfulness. This means the covenant at Mount Sinai.

Verses 9–13: God does everything the parents failed to do: washing, rubbing with oil, dressing, decorating, feeding. The despised abandoned baby becomes a queen. This reminds us of the great time of Jerusalem under David and Solomon.

Verse 14: The beauty did not come from Jerusalem itself, but "because of the glory I had put on you." Everything was a gift.

The unfaithfulness VERSES 15–22

15 "But you trusted in your beauty.
You used your fame to become a prostitute.
You poured out your prostitution on everyone who passed by.
You gave yourself to anyone.
16 You took some of your clothes
and made colorful high places for yourself.
You acted like a prostitute on them.
Such things should not happen, and they must never be.
17 You also took your beautiful jewelry
made of my gold and my silver, which I had given you.
You made images of men for yourself
and acted like a prostitute with them.
18 You took your embroidered clothes and covered the images with them.
You set my oil and my incense in front of them.
19 You also took my bread that I had given you,
the fine flour, oil, and honey I fed you with,
and you set it in front of them as a sweet-smelling offering.
That is what happened," says the Lord GOD.
20 "You also took your sons and your daughters,
whom you had given birth to for me,
and you sacrificed them to the idols as food.
Was your prostitution not bad enough?

21 You killed my children
and gave them up
by making them pass through the fire for the idols.
22 In all your disgusting deeds and your prostitution,
you did not remember the days when you were young,
when you were naked and bare
and were kicking about in your blood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem takes God's gifts, clothes, gold, silver, flour, oil, and honey, and gives them to the idols. That is what "prostitution" means here: being unfaithful to God, who has given everything. The picture describes the relationship between God and his people. It is not a statement about women, and it does not look down on people in prostitution.

Verses 20–21: The worst thing: child sacrifice. At times, children really were burned for foreign gods in Judah (compare 2 Kings 16:3; 21:6; Jeremiah 7:31). God calls them "my children." He is on the side of the children.

Verse 22: Jerusalem has forgotten where it came from. Ungratefulness and forgetting are often the beginning of moving away from God.

Alliances with foreign powers VERSES 23–34

23 "'"After all your wickedness
– how terrible, how terrible for you!" says the Lord GOD –
24 "you built yourself a shrine with a vaulted roof,
and you made yourself a raised place in every street.
25 You built your raised place at the start of every road.
You turned your beauty into something disgusting.
You offered yourself to everyone who passed by,
and you did more and more prostitution.
26 You also slept around with the Egyptians,
your neighbors with the big bodies.
You did more and more prostitution to make me angry.
27 So I have reached out my hand against you.
I have made your share smaller.
I have handed you over to the will of those who hate you,
the daughters of the Philistines.
Even they are ashamed of your shameless ways.
28 You also acted like a prostitute with the Assyrians,
because you could never get enough.
Yes, you acted like a prostitute with them,
and still you were not satisfied.
29 You did even more prostitution
with the land of merchants, with Chaldea.
And still this did not satisfy you.
30 "'"How weak your heart is," says the Lord GOD,
"since you do all these things,
the things a shameless prostitute does!
31 You build your vaulted shrine at the start of every road,
and you make your raised place in every street.
But you are not like a prostitute,
because you refuse to be paid.
32 "'"You are an unfaithful wife
who takes strangers instead of her husband!
33 People give gifts to all prostitutes.
But you give your gifts to all your lovers.
You bribe them
to come to you from every side for your prostitution.
34 So in your prostitution you are different from other women.
No one runs after you to sleep with you.
You pay, and no one pays you.
That is why you are different."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it is about politics: Jerusalem made alliances with Egypt, Assyria, and Babylon (Chaldea). Instead of trusting God, it looked for protection from the great powers, and in doing so it also took over their gods.

Verse 26: "With the big bodies": The WEB, our English source text, says literally "great of flesh." It is a crude picture for how attractive the great power Egypt was.

Verse 27: Even the Philistines, Israel's old enemies, are ashamed of how Jerusalem behaves.

Verses 31–34: A bitter paradox: Jerusalem does not even get anything for its unfaithfulness. Instead it pays for it itself. This means the heavy tribute payments to foreign kings (compare 2 Kings 16:8). Jerusalem gives away its riches to those who will exploit it in the end.

The judgment VERSES 35–43

35 "So, you prostitute, listen to the LORD's word!
36 'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Your filth was poured out,
and your nakedness was uncovered
through your prostitution with your lovers.
You worshiped all your disgusting idols,
and you gave them the blood of your children.
37 That is why I will gather all your lovers,
the ones you enjoyed,
all the ones you loved
and all the ones you hated.
I will gather them against you from every side.
I will uncover your nakedness in front of them,
so that they see all your nakedness.
38 I will judge you
the way women who break their marriage and spill blood are judged.
I will bring on you the bloodshed of anger and jealousy.
39 I will also hand you over to them.
They will tear down your vaulted shrine
and break down your raised places.
They will take off your clothes
and take your beautiful jewelry.
They will leave you naked and bare.
40 They will also bring a crowd against you.
They will throw stones at you
and stab you with their swords.
41 They will burn your houses with fire.
They will carry out judgments on you while many women watch.
I will put an end to your prostitution,
and you will no longer pay anyone.
42 Then my anger against you will come to rest,
and my jealousy will leave you.
I will be calm
and will not be angry anymore.

43 “‘“You did not remember the days when you were
young.
Instead, you raged against me with all these things.
So I will bring on your own head what you have done,”
says the Lord GOD.
“Then you will no longer do this shameful thing
on top of all your other disgusting deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are especially hard. In pictures, they describe what really happened to Jerusalem in 586 BC: The former “lovers,” that is, the great powers, turn against the city. The Babylonians loot it, tear down the walls, burn the houses, and kill many people (2 Kings 25:8–10).

For this, Ezekiel uses the language of the punishments that were given for adultery and murder in those days. It is a picture from a world ruled by men, and the violence in it is shocking.

Very important: This text is not an instruction and not a permission. It never justifies one person hitting, exposing, humiliating, or killing another person, not in marriage, and not because of unfaithfulness. Violence is wrong. Jesus clearly stood up for a woman who was about to be stoned (John 8:1–11).

If you are experiencing violence in your relationship or family, it is not your fault, and you are not alone. Help is available for free, without giving your name, day and night: Domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US: RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Like mother, like daughter VERSES 44–52

44 “‘“Everyone who uses sayings
will use this saying about you:
‘Like mother, like daughter.’
45 You are your mother’s daughter.
She hated her husband and her children.
And you are the sister of your sisters,
who hated their husbands and their children.
Your mother was a Hittite,
and your father was an Amorite.
46 Your older sister is Samaria,
who lives on your left with her daughters.
And your younger sister, who lives on your right,
is Sodom with her daughters.
47 You did not only follow their ways
and do the disgusting things they did.
Very soon you became even more corrupt than they
were
in all your ways.
48 As surely as I live,” says the Lord GOD,
“your sister Sodom and her daughters never did
what you and your daughters have done.
49 “‘“This was the sin of your sister Sodom:
She and her daughters were proud.
They had more than enough food,
and they lived in comfort without a care.
But she did not help the poor and needy.
50 They were arrogant
and did disgusting things in front of me.
So I removed them when I saw it.
51 Samaria did not commit even half of your sins.
You have done many more disgusting things than they
did.
All the disgusting things you have done
make your sisters look righteous.
52 You must also carry your own shame,
because you have judged your sisters.
Your sins are more disgusting than theirs,
so they are more righteous than you.
Yes, be ashamed too, and carry your shame,
because you have made your sisters look righteous.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem thought it was better than Samaria (the northern kingdom that had been destroyed) and Sodom (the city God had destroyed, Genesis 19). But God says: You are worse than both of them!

Verse 49: An important verse! Here the Bible itself says what the sin of Sodom was: pride, too much of everything, a life without a care, and not helping the poor and needy. Whoever is rich and full and forgets the poor is in danger of becoming like Sodom.

Verse 52: God says to Jerusalem: “You must also carry your own shame, because you have judged your sisters.” Whoever is quick to judge others should first look at himself (compare Matthew 7:3–5).

All will be restored VERSES 53–58

53 “‘“I will turn their fate around,
the fate of Sodom and her daughters,
and the fate of Samaria and her daughters.
And I will turn around the fate of your own captives
among them.
54 Then you will carry your own shame
and be ashamed of everything you have done,
because you are a comfort to them.
55 Your sisters, Sodom and her daughters,
will go back to what they were before.
Samaria and her daughters
will go back to what they were before.
And you and your daughters
will go back to what you were before.
56 In the days of your pride,
you would not even speak the name of your sister
Sodom.
57 That was before your wickedness was uncovered.
Now you are mocked like the daughters of Syria
and all who are around her,
and like the daughters of the Philistines.
All around you, people look down on you.
58 You have carried the punishment for your shameful
acts and your disgusting deeds,”
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An amazing promise: God will restore not only Jerusalem, but also Samaria and even Sodom! God’s mercy is greater than Jerusalem could imagine.

Verse 54: Jerusalem will be “a comfort” to the others. That means: If even Jerusalem finds grace after all this, then there is hope for the others too.

Verse 56: In its pride, Jerusalem did not even want to speak the name Sodom. It looked down on the others.

Verse 57: Here the WEB has "Syria" (Syria, which was called Aram in those days). Some Hebrew manuscripts have "Edom." The two words look very much alike in Hebrew.

An everlasting covenant VERSES 59–63

59 "'For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will deal with you as you have deserved.
You have despised your promise
by breaking the covenant.
60 But I will still remember my covenant
that I made with you in the days when you were young.
And I will set up an everlasting covenant with you.
61 Then you will remember your ways and be ashamed
when you welcome your sisters,
both your older and your younger sisters.
I will give them to you as daughters,
but not because of your covenant.
62 I will set up my covenant with you.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
63 Then you will remember and be ashamed.
You will never open your mouth again because of your shame,
when I have forgiven you for all that you have done,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is God's great "And yet"! Jerusalem has broken the covenant. But God does not forget his covenant. He even makes an "everlasting covenant" that will never break.

Verse 60: Jerusalem forgot "the days when you were young" (verses 22 and 43). But God remembers them. God's faithfulness is stronger than people's unfaithfulness (compare 2 Timothy 2:13).

Verse 63: In the end there is forgiveness. The shame spoken of here is not a destructive shame. It is amazement at receiving so much grace, even though it is not deserved. You become silent out of thankfulness.

Christians see a line from here to the "new covenant" (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Luke 22:20). For Jews, it is God's lasting faithfulness to Israel.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 17

Two eagles and a vine

The riddle VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
2 "Son of man, give the people of Israel a riddle.
Tell them a parable.
3 Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"A great eagle with great wings and long feathers,
full of feathers of many colors,
came to Lebanon
and took the top of the cedar tree.
4 He broke off the highest of its young twigs
and carried it to a land of trade.
He planted it in a city of merchants.
5 "'"He also took some of the seed of the land
and planted it in rich soil.
He put it beside plenty of water.
He planted it like a willow tree.
6 It grew and became a vine that spread out
but stayed low.
Its branches turned toward the eagle,
and its roots stayed under the eagle.
So it became a vine.
It grew branches and sent out shoots.
7 "'"There was also another great eagle
with great wings and many feathers.
And this vine bent its roots toward him.
It sent out its branches toward him,
away from the bed where it was planted,
so that he would water it.
8 But it had been planted in good soil beside plenty of water,
so that it could grow branches and bear fruit
and be a fine vine."'
9 "Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Will it do well?
Will he not pull up its roots
and cut off its fruit, so that it dries up,
so that all its fresh new leaves dry up?
No strong arm and no crowd of people
will be able to lift it up again by its roots.
10 Yes, it is planted, but will it do well?
Will it not dry up completely
when the east wind touches it?
It will dry up in the bed where it grew."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel tells a riddle in pictures. The answer comes from verse 11 on. In short:

The first great eagle is Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon.

The top of the cedar is King Jehoiachin. In 597 BC, Nebuchadnezzar took him to Babylon (the "land of trade").

The seed he plants is Zedekiah, whom Nebuchadnezzar made king in Jerusalem. He is a "low" vine, that is, a king who depends on someone else. But he could have lived well.

The second eagle is the Pharaoh of Egypt. Zedekiah stretches out his "roots" toward Egypt and hopes for help against Babylon.

Verse 10: The "east wind" is a hot desert wind that makes plants dry up. It stands for Babylon, which comes from the east.

The meaning: Zedekiah breaks his oath VERSES 11–21

11 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,

12 "Say to these rebellious people,
'Don't you know what these things mean?'
Tell them,
'The king of Babylon came to Jerusalem.
He took its king and its leaders
and brought them to himself in Babylon.
13 He took a man from the royal family
and made a covenant with him.
He made him swear an oath.
And he took away the powerful men of the land.
14 He did this so that the kingdom would stay weak
and would not rise up again,
but would last by keeping his covenant.
15 But the king rebelled against him.
He sent his messengers to Egypt
to get horses and many soldiers.
Will he succeed?
Will someone who does such things escape?
Can he break the covenant and still escape?
16 "'As surely as I live,' says the Lord GOD,
'he will die in Babylon,
in the land of the king who made him king,
the king whose oath he despised and whose covenant
he broke.
17 Pharaoh with his mighty army and his great crowd of
soldiers
will not help him in the war,
when ramps of earth are built and towers are put up
to kill many people.
18 For he despised the oath by breaking the covenant.
He had given his hand on it,
and yet he did all these things.
He will not escape.'
19 "That is why the Lord GOD says:
'As surely as I live,
I will bring on his own head
my oath that he despised
and my covenant that he broke.
20 I will spread my net over him,
and he will be caught in my trap.
I will bring him to Babylon.
There I will judge him
for being unfaithful to me.
21 All the soldiers in his army who run away will be killed
by the sword.
Those who are left will be scattered to every wind.
Then you will know that I, the LORD, have spoken.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zedekiah had sworn an oath of loyalty to Nebuchadnezzar, and he had sworn it in God's name (compare 2 Chronicles 36:13). Then he broke this oath and made an alliance with Egypt.

Verse 19: God calls the oath "my oath" and the covenant "my covenant." Whoever promises something in God's name and breaks it insults God himself. A promise matters even when you have made it to an enemy.

Everything happened this way: Egypt did not really help (compare Jeremiah 37:5–8), Jerusalem was captured, and Zedekiah died as a prisoner in Babylon (compare Ezekiel 12:13).

For today: Honesty and being reliable are important. Jesus says: "Let your 'Yes' be 'Yes' and your 'No' be 'No'" (Matthew 5:37).

God plants a new shoot VERSES 22–24

22 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'I myself will take a shoot from the high top of the
cedar
and plant it.
From the highest of its young twigs
I will break off a tender one.
I will plant it on a high and lofty mountain.
23 I will plant it on the high mountain of Israel.
It will grow branches and bear fruit
and become a fine cedar.
Birds of every kind will live in the shade of its
branches.
24 All the trees of the field will know
that I, the LORD, have brought down the high tree
and made the low tree high.
I have made the green tree dry up
and made the dry tree bloom.
I, the LORD, have spoken, and I have done it.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the judgment comes hope. Now it is no longer an eagle that acts, but God himself. He takes a tender shoot from the royal family of David and plants it again on Mount Zion. It becomes a great cedar in which all the birds find shelter.

Jews and Christians read this as a promise of a coming king from the family of David, the Messiah (compare Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5).

Jesus used a similar picture: The Kingdom of God is like a tiny mustard seed that becomes a great tree, so that the birds live in its branches (Mark 4:30–32).

Verse 24: God brings down the high and lifts up the low. That is a basic theme of the Bible (compare 1 Samuel 2:7–8; Luke 1:52).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 18

Turn back, and you will live!

Sour grapes VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD's word came to me again.
He said,
2 "What do you mean by using this saying about the land
of Israel:
'The fathers have eaten sour grapes,
and the children's teeth are set on edge'?
3 As surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"you will not use this saying in Israel anymore.
4 Every soul belongs to me.
The soul of the father belongs to me,

and the soul of the son belongs to me too.
The soul who sins is the one who will die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people in exile had a bitter saying: "The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge." That means: Our parents sinned, and we have to pay for it. We are innocent victims. We cannot change anything.

God disagrees: Every person belongs to him directly. Each person is responsible before God himself. No one is simply a victim of his family's history.

Jeremiah quotes the same saying (Jeremiah 31:29–30).

This is also a message that sets people free: You are not stuck because of what your parents did. You can go your own way.

The righteous man VERSES 5–9

5 "Suppose a man is righteous
and does what is lawful and right.
6 He does not eat at the shrines on the mountains.
He does not look to the idols of the people of Israel.
He does not dishonor his neighbor's wife.
He does not come near a woman during her monthly period.
7 He does not wrong anyone.
He gives back to the one who owes him what he took as a pledge.
He does not rob anyone.
He gives his bread to the hungry
and gives clothes to those who have none.
8 He does not lend money to them for interest
or take profit from them.
He has held back his hand from wrongdoing.
He judges fairly between one person and another.
9 He lives by my rules
and keeps my laws, and he is faithful.
He is righteous. He will certainly live,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is a kind of checklist of what a righteous person does. Interesting: Most of the points are not about worship, but about how we treat other people:

– no idols,

– faithfulness in marriage, respect for women,

– not oppressing or robbing anyone,

– giving back to debtors what they gave as a pledge (for example the coat they need at night, Exodus 22:26–27, in some Bibles 22:25–26),

– giving bread to the hungry, clothing the naked,

– not taking high interest from the poor,

– judging fairly and justly.

"Eating at the shrines on the mountains" means sacrificial meals at places where idols were worshiped.

Jesus names similar deeds in Matthew 25:35–36: "For I was hungry, and you gave me food to eat… I was naked, and you gave me clothes."

The violent son VERSES 10–13

10 "But suppose he has a son who is a robber,
who spills blood,
and who does any of these things.
11 He does none of the good things his father did.
Instead, he eats at the shrines on the mountains
and dishonors his neighbor's wife.
12 He wrongs the poor and needy.
He robs people.
He does not give back what he took as a pledge.
He looks to the idols.
He does disgusting things.
13 He lends money for interest
and takes profit from the poor.
Will he live?
No, he will not live.
He has done all these disgusting things.
He will certainly die.
His blood will be on his own head.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The son of a righteous father can still become evil. His father's righteousness does not save him. You cannot hide behind your family's good name.

"His blood will be on his own head" means: He himself is responsible for what happens to him.

The grandson chooses a different way VERSES 14–20

14 "Now suppose this man has a son
who sees all the sins his father has done.
He is afraid, and he does not do the same.
15 He does not eat at the shrines on the mountains.
He does not look to the idols of the people of Israel.
He does not dishonor his neighbor's wife.
16 He does not wrong anyone.
He does not take anything as a pledge.
He does not rob anyone.
Instead, he gives his bread to the hungry
and gives clothes to those who have none.
17 He has held back his hand from the poor.
He does not take interest or profit.
He obeys my laws
and lives by my rules.
He will not die because of his father's sin.
He will certainly live.
18 But his father was cruel and oppressed people.
He robbed his brother
and did what was not good among his people.
So he will die because of his own sin.
19 "Yet you ask,
'Why doesn't the son carry the punishment for his father's sin?'
If the son has done what is lawful and right,
and has kept all my rules and obeyed them,
he will certainly live.
20 The soul who sins is the one who will die.
The son will not carry the punishment for his father's sin,
and the father will not carry the punishment for his son's sin.
A righteous person will receive the reward of his own righteousness,
and a wicked person will receive the punishment of his own wickedness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The grandson sees the evil his father does, and he does things differently. He breaks the cycle! God says: He will live. He does not have to pay for his father's guilt.

Verse 17: This is a person who "has held back his hand from the poor." Here that means: He does not harm the poor or oppress them (compare verse 8: "He has held back his hand from wrongdoing").

This is a great hope for everyone who grew up in a difficult family: You do not have to repeat what was done to you or what you saw. With God's help you can live differently.

If you have experienced violence or addiction in your family and want to talk about it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453. For addiction, US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357.

God does not want death VERSES 21–24

21 "But suppose a wicked person turns away from all the sins he has done.
He keeps all my rules
and does what is lawful and right.
Then he will certainly live.
He will not die.
22 None of the sins he has done
will be held against him anymore.
He will live because of the right things he has done.
23 Do I take any pleasure in the death of the wicked?"
says the Lord GOD.
"Don't I want him to turn from his way and live?
24 "But suppose a righteous person turns away from his righteousness
and does wrong.
He does all the disgusting things that the wicked person does.
Will he live?
None of the right things he has done will be remembered.
He will die because of his unfaithfulness
and because of the sins he has committed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is not only about families, but also about our own lives: No one is fixed forever, not by his past and not by good deeds done earlier.

Verses 21–22: Whoever turns back is forgiven. God no longer holds the old sins against him. A real new beginning is possible!

Verse 23: This is one of the most important sentences in the Bible: God takes no pleasure when anyone dies, not even an evil person. He wants people to turn back and live. (Compare 1 Timothy 2:4; 2 Peter 3:9.)

Verse 24: On the other hand, you cannot rest on good deeds you did earlier. What counts is how you live now.

Is God's way unfair? VERSES 25–29

25 "Yet you say,
'The way of the Lord is not fair.'
Listen now, people of Israel:
Is my way not fair?
Isn't it your ways that are unfair?
26 When a righteous person turns away from his righteousness
and does wrong and dies because of it,
he dies because of the wrong he has done.
27 And when a wicked person turns away from the wickedness
he has done,
and does what is lawful and right,
he will save his life.
28 Because he thinks it over
and turns away from all the sins he has committed,
he will certainly live.
He will not die.
29 Yet the people of Israel say,
'The way of the Lord is not fair.'
People of Israel, are my ways not fair?
Isn't it your ways that are unfair?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people complain: "That's not fair! If someone was evil all his life and then turns back, he gets to live?"

God answers: It is not my way that is unfair, but your thinking. God gives everyone a chance. That is grace.

Jesus tells a similar parable: The workers who come only late get the same pay as the others (Matthew 20:1–16). And the lost son is welcomed with a party, while the older brother complains (Luke 15:11–32).

Make yourselves a new heart! VERSES 30–32

30 "That is why I will judge you, people of Israel,
each one by his own ways,"
says the Lord GOD.
"Turn back! Turn away from all your sins,
so that your guilt will not destroy you.
31 Throw away all the sins
you have committed.
Make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit.
Why should you die, people of Israel?
32 For I take no pleasure in the death of anyone who dies,"
says the Lord GOD.
"So turn back, and live!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chapter ends with a passionate invitation. God asks: "Why should you die?" You can hear how much God wants his people to live.

Verse 31: "Make yourselves a new heart." In Ezekiel 11:19 and 36:26, God promises that he himself will give them a new heart. Both belong together: God gives the new beginning, and people should accept it and open themselves to it.

Verse 32: "So turn back, and live!" That is the main message of this chapter and maybe of the whole book of Ezekiel. It is never too late to turn back.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 19

A lament over the princes

The lioness and her cubs VERSES 1–9

1 "Now sing a song of mourning for the princes of Israel.
2 Say,
'What was your mother?
A lioness.
She lay down among lions.
Among the young lions she raised her cubs.
3 She raised one of her cubs.
He became a young lion.
He learned to catch his prey.
He ate people.
4 The nations heard about him.
He was caught in their pit.
They brought him with hooks to the land of Egypt.
5 "'When she saw that she had waited in vain
and her hope was lost,
she took another of her cubs
and made him a young lion.
6 He walked around among the lions.
He became a young lion.
He learned to catch his prey.
He ate people.
7 He knew their palaces
and destroyed their cities.
The land and everything in it became empty
because of the sound of his roaring.
8 Then the nations from the provinces
attacked him from every side.
They spread their net over him.
He was caught in their pit.
9 They put him in a cage with hooks
and brought him to the king of Babylon.
They put him in prison,
so that his voice would never again be heard
on the mountains of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A song of mourning is really a song for people who have died. Ezekiel sings it about the last kings of Judah, even though some of them are still alive. In this way he says: The kingdom is as good as dead.

The lioness stands for Judah or for the king's mother. The lion was the symbol of the tribe of Judah (Genesis 49:9).

The first cub (verses 3–4) is King Jehoahaz. He ruled for only three months, and Pharaoh took him to Egypt (2 Kings 23:31–34).

The second cub (verses 5–9) is probably King Jehoiachin, who was taken away to Babylon (2 Kings 24:8–15). Some people also think of Zedekiah.

"He ate people" describes how these kings oppressed and exploited their own people. Instead of being shepherds, they were beasts of prey.

The dried-up vine VERSES 10–14

10 "'"Your mother was like a vine in your blood,
planted by the water.
It was full of fruit and branches
because there was plenty of water.
11 It had strong branches,
good for the scepters of rulers.
It grew tall among the thick branches.
People could see how tall it was
and how many branches it had.
12 But it was pulled up in anger.
It was thrown down to the ground.
The east wind dried up its fruit.
Its strong branches were broken off and dried up.
The fire burned them up.
13 Now it is planted in the wilderness,
in a dry and thirsty land.
14 Fire has come out of its branches.
It has burned up its fruit.
No strong branch is left on it
that could be a scepter for a ruler.'
This is a song of mourning,
and it will be used as a song of mourning."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the picture changes: The mother is a splendid vine. It had strong branches, that is, kings with scepters. A scepter is a staff that a king holds.

Verse 10: "In your blood" is a difficult phrase. Some translate it "in your vineyard" or "like you."

Verses 12–13: The vine is pulled up and planted again in the wilderness. That means: The royal family is taken into exile in Babylon.

Verse 14: "Fire has come out of its branches." The disaster came from the royal family itself. The last king (Zedekiah) caused the destruction by his rebellion.

"No strong branch is left": The kingdom of David seems to be over. But Ezekiel 17:22–24 and 34:23–24 promise that God will give a new shoot.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 20

God acts for the sake of his name

The elders come to ask God VERSES 1–4

1 It was in the seventh year, in the fifth month, on the tenth day of the month.
Some of the elders of Israel came to ask the LORD for advice.
They sat down in front of me.
2 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
3 "Son of man, speak to the elders of Israel and tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Have you come to ask me for advice?
As surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"I will not let you ask me anything."'
4 "Will you judge them, son of man?
Will you judge them?
Make them see the disgusting things their ancestors did.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is in the year 591 BC, about five years before the destruction of Jerusalem.

The elders want an answer from God. But God says: No. He will not let himself be asked by people who only want to use him but do not want to turn back.

Instead, they get a long look back at their history. It shows: From the beginning, the people turned away from God again and again, and yet God stayed faithful again and again.

In Egypt VERSES 5–10

5 "Tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"On the day I chose Israel,
I made a promise to the descendants of the family of Jacob.
I made myself known to them in the land of Egypt.
I promised them and said,
'I am the LORD your God.'
6 On that day I promised them
that I would bring them out of the land of Egypt
into a land I had chosen for them.
It is a land flowing with milk and honey,
the most beautiful of all lands.
7 I said to them,
'Each of you, throw away the disgusting idols you look at.
Do not make yourselves unclean with the idols of Egypt.
I am the LORD your God.'
8 "'"But they rebelled against me
and would not listen to me.
Not all of them threw away the disgusting idols they looked at.
They did not leave the idols of Egypt.
Then I said I would pour out my anger on them
and finish my anger against them
right there in the land of Egypt.
9 But I acted for the sake of my name,
so that it would not be dishonored
in front of the nations they were living among.
Those nations had seen me make myself known to my people
by bringing them out of the land of Egypt.
10 So I led them out of the land of Egypt
and brought them into the wilderness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God tells the history of Israel again, and he tells it very honestly. Already in Egypt, many clung to the Egyptian idols.

Verse 9: The key sentence of the chapter: "But I acted for the sake of my name." God did not save Israel because it was so good, but because God is faithful to what he has promised. His "name" stands for his reputation and who he is. The nations were to see who God really is.

In the wilderness: the first generation VERSES 11–17

11 I gave them my rules
and taught them my laws.
Whoever obeys them will live by them.
12 I also gave them my Sabbaths
as a sign between me and them,
so that they would know that I am the LORD,
who makes them holy.
13 "'"But the people of Israel rebelled against me in the wilderness.
They did not live by my rules,
and they rejected my laws.
Whoever keeps them will live by them.
They completely dishonored my Sabbaths.
Then I said I would pour out my anger on them in the wilderness
and destroy them.
14 But I acted for the sake of my name,
so that it would not be dishonored in front of the nations
who had seen me bring my people out.
15 I also promised them in the wilderness
that I would not bring them into the land I had given them,
the land flowing with milk and honey,
the most beautiful of all lands.
16 I did this because they rejected my laws,
did not live by my rules,
and dishonored my Sabbaths.
For their hearts followed their idols.
17 But my eye had pity on them,
and I did not destroy them.
I did not put an end to them in the wilderness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: God's commandments are good. They are there so that people can "live" (compare Leviticus 18:5). They are not a burden but a gift for a good life.

Verse 12: The Sabbath is a sign of the special relationship between God and his people (Exodus 31:13). Especially in exile, without a temple, the Sabbath became very important for the Jews.

Verses 15–17: The first generation was not allowed to enter the promised land (Numbers 14). But God did not destroy them. He spared them.

In the wilderness: the second generation VERSES 18–26

18 "'"I said to their children in the wilderness,
'Do not live by the rules of your ancestors.
Do not follow their laws,
and do not make yourselves unclean with their idols.
19 I am the LORD your God.
Live by my rules.
Keep my laws and obey them.
20 Keep my Sabbaths holy.
They will be a sign between me and you,
so that you will know that I am the LORD your God.'
21 "'"But the children rebelled against me too.
They did not live by my rules.
They did not keep my laws and obey them.
Whoever obeys them will live by them.
They dishonored my Sabbaths.
Then I said I would pour out my anger on them
and finish my anger against them in the wilderness.
22 But I held back my hand
and acted for the sake of my name,
so that it would not be dishonored in front of the

nations
who had seen me bring my people out.
23 I also promised them in the wilderness
that I would scatter them among the nations
and spread them through the countries.
24 I did this because they had not obeyed my laws.
They had rejected my rules
and dishonored my Sabbaths,
and their eyes longed for their ancestors' idols.
25 I also gave them rules that were not good,
and laws by which they could not live.
26 I let them make themselves unclean through their own gifts.
They made every firstborn child pass through the fire.
I did this to fill them with horror,
so that they would know that I am the LORD."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The second generation makes the same mistakes. And again God acts "for the sake of his name" and spares them.

Verses 25–26: These are very difficult verses. "Rules that were not good" cannot mean that God gave bad commandments. In other places, God clearly forbids child sacrifice (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 18:10; Jeremiah 7:31, where God says that he never commanded it and that it never even came into his mind).

A common explanation: God let them go their own wrong way. Because they did not want his good commandments, he left them to the bad customs they chose for themselves, even to the cruel child sacrifices of the foreign religions. (Compare Romans 1:24: "So God gave them up to the lusts of their hearts ...")

Another explanation: The commandment to "give" the firstborn to God (Exodus 13:2, 12) was completely misunderstood by some people and misused as child sacrifice. But God always wanted the firstborn to be bought back (Exodus 13:13).

In the promised land VERSES 27–29

27 "So, son of man, speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Your ancestors insulted me in this way too:
they were unfaithful to me.
28 I brought them into the land
that I had promised to give them.
But whenever they saw a high hill or a thick tree,
they offered their sacrifices there.
There they brought the offerings that made me angry.
There they also burned their sweet-smelling incense,
and there they poured out their drink offerings.
29 Then I said to them,
'What is this high place you go to?'
That is why it is called Bamah to this day."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the promised land it went on: On every hill and under every tree, they made sacrifices to foreign gods.

Verse 29: "Bamah" is the Hebrew word for "high place" or "hilltop shrine." There is probably a play on words here: The word sounds a bit like "ba" (to come, to go there) and "mah" (what). So it means something like: "What is this place you go to?" God is mocking these places of worship.

You want to be like the other nations VERSES 30–32

30 "So tell the people of Israel,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Will you make yourselves unclean the way your ancestors did?
Will you be unfaithful to me and chase after their disgusting idols?
31 When you bring your gifts,
when you make your sons pass through the fire,
you make yourselves unclean with all your idols to this very day.
And should I let you ask me for advice, people of Israel?
As surely as I live, says the Lord GOD,
I will not let you ask me anything!
32 "'"What you have in mind will never happen.
You say,
'We want to be like the nations,
like the peoples of other countries,
and serve wood and stone.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God comes to the present: The elders are doing the same as their ancestors.

Verse 32: Here it comes out what they really think: "We want to be like the nations, like the peoples of other countries, and serve wood and stone." In exile, the temptation was great simply to fit in, to worship the gods of the Babylonians, and to give up their own identity.

But God says: That will not happen. God does not let go of his people.

A new exodus VERSES 33–38

33 As surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"with a mighty hand,
with an outstretched arm,
and with anger poured out,
I will be king over you.
34 I will bring you out from the peoples.
I will gather you out of the countries where you are scattered,
with a mighty hand, with an outstretched arm,
and with anger poured out.
35 I will bring you into the wilderness of the peoples.
There I will judge you
face to face.
36 I judged your ancestors in the wilderness of the land of Egypt.
In the same way I will judge you,"
says the Lord GOD.
37 "I will make you pass under the shepherd's staff,
and I will bring you into the bond of the covenant.
38 I will remove from among you the rebels
and those who disobey me.
I will bring them out of the land where they are living as foreigners,
but they will not come into the land of Israel.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God announces a new exodus, like the one from Egypt long ago, "by a mighty hand and by an outstretched arm"

(compare Deuteronomy 5:15). This time it is out of Babylon and out of all the countries.

Verses 35–36: As in the wilderness long ago, there will be a time of testing.

Verse 37: God says: "I will make you pass under the shepherd's staff." That is how a shepherd counted his sheep. Each sheep walked under his staff, and he looked at it closely. God knows each person.

On my holy mountain VERSES 39–44

39 "'As for you, people of Israel, this is what the Lord GOD says:
"Go ahead, each of you, serve your idols,
now and later too, if you will not listen to me.
But you will no longer dishonor my holy name
with your gifts and your idols.
40 For on my holy mountain,
on the high mountain of Israel,"
says the Lord GOD,
"there all the people of Israel, all of them,
will serve me in the land.
There I will accept them.
There I will ask for your offerings
and the first fruits of your offerings,
with all your holy things.
41 I will accept you like a sweet-smelling offering
when I bring you out from the peoples
and gather you out of the countries where you have been scattered.
I will show through you that I am holy
while the nations watch.
42 You will know that I am the LORD
when I bring you into the land of Israel,
into the country I promised to give to your ancestors.
43 There you will remember your ways
and all the things you did to make yourselves unclean.
Then you will be disgusted with yourselves
because of all the evil things you have done.
44 You will know that I am the LORD
when I deal with you for the sake of my name,
not as your evil ways deserve
and not as your corrupt deeds deserve,
people of Israel,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 39: God speaks with bitter irony: "Go ahead, each of you, serve your idols, now and later too, if you will not listen to me. But you will no longer dishonor my holy name ..." That means: Do not pretend that you are serving me. God does not want divided loyalty.

Verses 40–42: Then comes the promise: All Israel will come together again on God's holy mountain (Zion in Jerusalem) and serve God. God will accept them "like a sweet-smelling offering."

Verse 43: When they experience God's goodness, only then will they really see how wrongly they have acted. True sorrow over sin often does not come through punishment but through experiencing love.

Verse 44: At the end, the key sentence again: God deals with them "for the sake of my name" and "not as your evil ways deserve." That is grace: God does not treat us as we deserve (compare Psalm 103:10).

Fire in the forest of the south VERSES 45–49

45 The LORD's word came to me.
He said,
46 "Son of man, turn your face toward the south.
Preach against the south,
and prophesy against the forest of the field in the south.
47 Say to the forest of the south,
'Listen to the LORD's word!
This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will light a fire in you.
It will burn up every green tree in you
and every dry tree.
The blazing flame will not be put out.
Every face from the south to the north will be burned by it.
48 All people will see that I, the LORD, have lit it.
It will not be put out."'"
49 Then I said,
"Oh, Lord GOD!
They are saying about me,
'Isn't he just telling stories in pictures?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Note: In some Bibles these verses are Ezekiel 21:1–5. Here we follow the numbering of the WEB.

Seen from Babylon, the "south" is Judah and Jerusalem (people came into the land from the north). A forest fire will burn up everything, green and dry trees, that is, righteous and unrighteous people. In Chapter 21 the picture is explained.

Verse 49: Ezekiel complains: The people do not take him seriously. They say: "Isn't he just telling stories in pictures?" You can brush off God's word as mere entertainment, but then you miss its serious message.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 21

The sword of the LORD

The sword is drawn VERSES 1–7

1 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, turn your face toward Jerusalem.
Preach against the holy places,
and prophesy against the land of Israel.
3 Tell the land of Israel,
'This is what the LORD says:
"I am against you.
I will pull my sword out of its sheath.
I will cut off from you both the righteous and the wicked.

4 Because I will cut off from you the righteous and the wicked,
my sword will go out of its sheath
against all people, from the south to the north.
5 All people will know
that I, the LORD, have pulled my sword out of its sheath.
It will not go back again."'
6 "So sigh, son of man!
Sigh in front of them with a broken heart and with bitterness.
7 When they ask you,
'Why are you sighing?'
then you must say,
'Because of the news, for it is coming!
Every heart will melt with fear.
All hands will be weak.
Every spirit will grow faint.
All knees will be as weak as water.
Look, it is coming, and it will happen,
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, Chapter 21 begins five verses earlier (with 20:45–49 of the WEB). So the verse numbers here are always five lower than in many other Bibles. We follow the numbering of the WEB.

Now the picture of the forest fire (20:45–49) is explained: The "forest of the south" is Jerusalem. And the fire is a sword, that is, the army of the Babylonians.

Verses 3–4: "The righteous and the wicked" – in war everyone suffers, even innocent people. Ezekiel does not make this sound nicer than it is. This is an honest, painful description of what war is like.

Verses 6–7: Ezekiel is to sigh in public, with a broken heart. He does not announce the judgment coldly. He suffers with his people.

The song of the sword VERSES 8–17

8 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
9 "Son of man, prophesy and say,
'This is what the LORD says:
"A sword! A sword!
It is sharpened, and it is polished too.
10 It is sharpened so that it can kill many people.
It is polished so that it flashes like lightning.
Should we be happy then?
The rod of my son looks down on every tree.
11 It is given to be polished,
so that someone can hold it in his hand.
The sword is sharpened.
Yes, it is polished
to be given into the hand of the killer."'
12 Cry and wail, son of man,
for it is coming against my people.
It is coming against all the princes of Israel.
They are handed over to the sword together with my people.
So beat your thigh.
13 "For there is a test.
And what if even the rod that looks down on others is no more?"
says the Lord GOD.
14 "So you, son of man, prophesy,
and clap your hands together.
Let the sword strike twice, even three times,
the sword for those who are wounded to death.
It is the sword of the great one who is wounded to death.
It goes into their rooms.
15 I have set the threatening sword against all their gates,
so that their hearts melt with fear,
and so that many of them stumble and fall.
Oh! It is made like lightning.
It is sharpened to kill.
16 Pull yourself together. Go to the right.
Get ready. Go to the left,
wherever your face is turned.
17 I will also clap my hands together,
and I will let my anger come to rest.
I, the LORD, have spoken."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a wild, terrifying song. The sword is sharpened and polished until it flashes. You can feel the fear and the horror of the war that is coming.

Verses 10 and 13 are among the hardest verses in the whole book. The Hebrew text is hard to understand here, and the translations are very different from each other. Maybe it means: The scepter (the rod) of the king of Judah, "my son," can do nothing against this sword.

Verse 12: "So beat your thigh." This was a sign of great sorrow and despair.

War songs like this one do not praise violence. They show how terrible war is. If you have lived through war, or if you cannot get pictures of war out of your head, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The king of Babylon at the fork in the road VERSES 18–24

18 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
19 "And you, son of man,
mark out two roads
for the sword of the king of Babylon to come by.
Both of them will start from the same land.
And make a signpost.
Put it where the road to the city begins.
20 Mark out one road
for the sword to come to Rabbah of the people of Ammon,
and one to Judah, to Jerusalem, the city with strong walls.
21 For the king of Babylon stood at the fork in the road,
where the two roads begin,
to ask for a sign about the future.
He shook the arrows back and forth.
He asked the teraphim.
He looked at the liver.
22 In his right hand was the lot for Jerusalem.
It told him to set up battering rams,
to give the order to kill,
to raise the battle cry,
to set up battering rams against the gates,
to pile up ramps of earth,
and to build siege towers.

23 To the people of Jerusalem, it will look like a false sign.
They have sworn oaths of loyalty.
But he will remind them of their guilt,
so that they will be captured.
24 "So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'You have made people remember your guilt.
Your wrongdoing has come out into the open,
so that your sins can be seen in everything you do.
Because you have been remembered,
you will be captured by force.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel is to draw a map: One road leads to Rabbah (the capital city of the Ammonites, today Amman in Jordan). The other road leads to Jerusalem. Both had rebelled against Babylon.

Verse 21: Nebuchadnezzar stands at the crossroads and asks his gods. He uses three methods: He draws arrows like lots, he asks the teraphim (small household idols), and he looks at the liver of an animal that was sacrificed (a well-known way of telling the future in Babylon).

Verse 22: The lot falls on Jerusalem. The Bible does not say that telling the future works. But God is Lord even over the decisions of foreign kings.

Verse 23: The people in Jerusalem think this is wrong, because they had made an agreement with Babylon. But it was exactly this agreement that Zedekiah had broken (see Chapter 17).

Take off the crown! VERSES 25–27

25 "'And you, wicked man, wounded to death,
prince of Israel,
your day has come,
the time when guilt comes to its end.
26 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Take off the turban,
and take off the crown.
Things will not stay the way they were.
Lift up what is low,
and bring down what is high.
27 I will turn it upside down, upside down, upside down.
This too will be no more,
until the one comes who has the right to it.
And I will give it to him."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "prince of Israel" is King Zedekiah. He will lose his crown and his turban. The kingdom of Judah comes to an end.

Verse 26: "Lift up what is low, and bring down what is high." This is a basic theme of the Bible (see 17:24 and Luke 1:52).

Verse 27: An important verse: The throne stays empty "until the one comes who has the right to it." This is like Genesis 49:10. Jews and Christians have seen in this a promise of the Messiah, the rightful king from the family of David. Christians apply this to Jesus.

The sword against the Ammonites VERSES 28–32

28 "You, son of man, prophesy and say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says
about the people of Ammon and about their insults:
"A sword! A sword is drawn!
It is polished to kill,
to devour,
so that it flashes like lightning.
29 People see false visions for you.
They tell you lies about the future.
This happens to lay you on the necks of the wicked who are wounded to death.
Their day has come,
the time when guilt comes to its end.
30 Put it back into its sheath!
In the place where you were created,
in the land where you were born,
I will judge you.
31 I will pour out my anger on you.
I will blow on you with the fire of my anger.
I will hand you over to cruel men,
who are skilled at destroying.
32 You will be wood for the fire.
Your blood will be spilled in the middle of the land.
No one will remember you anymore,
for I, the LORD, have spoken."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ammonites were maybe happy that the king of Babylon went to Jerusalem and not to them. And they mocked Jerusalem. But they will be judged too.

Verse 30: "Put it back into its sheath!" This is probably spoken to the sword of Babylon: When Babylon has finished its task, it will be judged itself, in its own land.

These words of judgment about nations do not give permission to hate other nations. They show that God is the Lord of all history, and that injustice and pride have consequences everywhere.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 22

The city of blood

The city that sheds blood VERSES 1–5

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "You, son of man, will you judge?
Will you judge the city of blood?
Then show her all the disgusting things she does.
3 You must say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"You are a city that sheds blood inside her walls,
so that her time of judgment comes.
You make idols for yourself, and they make you unclean.
4 You have become guilty because of the blood you have shed.
You have become unclean because of the idols you have made.

You have brought your days near.
You have come to the end of your years.
So I have made you something the nations scorn,
and something all the countries mock.
5 Those who are near you and those who are far from you
will mock you.
You have a bad name, and you are full of turmoil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem, the "holy city," is called the "city of blood" here. That is a shocking name. It shows: In this city a lot of injustice and violence was done.

Two main charges run through the chapter: violence ("shedding blood") and the worship of idols. The two belong together: Whoever no longer honors God also loses respect for the lives of other people.

The list of sins VERSES 6–16

6 "'"Look, the princes of Israel have been in you.
Each of them used all his power
to shed blood.
7 In you they have treated father and mother with
contempt.
Among you they have oppressed the foreigner.
In you they have wronged the orphan and the widow.
8 You have despised the things that are holy to me,
and you have treated my Sabbaths as if they were not
holy.
9 In you there have been men who tell lies about others,
so that blood is shed.
In you they have eaten on the mountains.
Among you they have done shameful things.
10 In you men have slept with their fathers' wives.
In you men have forced themselves on women
during their monthly time when they were unclean.
11 One man has done a disgusting thing with his
neighbor's wife.
Another has shamefully abused his daughter-in-law.
Another in you has forced himself on his sister,
his father's daughter.
12 In you they have taken bribes to shed blood.
You have charged interest and profit on loans.
You have greedily made money from your neighbors
by oppressing them.
And you have forgotten me,"
says the Lord GOD.
13 "So look, I strike my hands together
against the dishonest profit you have made,
and against the blood that has been shed in you.
14 Will your heart stay strong?
Will your hands stay strong
in the days when I deal with you?
I, the LORD, have spoken, and I will do it.
15 I will scatter you among the nations.
I will spread you out through the countries.
I will remove your filth from you.
16 You will be dishonored in yourself in front of the
nations.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here there is a long list of wrongs. Almost all of them are about how people treat other people:

– The powerful use their power to kill.

– Parents are treated with contempt.

– Foreigners, orphans and widows, that is, the weakest people, are oppressed. All through the Bible, God takes the side of these people again and again (see Exodus 22:21–24; Deuteronomy 10:18).

– Lies about others that lead to death.

– Sexual violence and abuse in families.

– Bribes, unfair interest, taking advantage of others out of greed.

Verse 9: "Eaten on the mountains" means: at the places where idols were worshiped.

Verses 10–11: "Forced himself on" means sexual violence here: Women were abused against their will, even inside the family. The Bible clearly calls this wrong. The guilt is always with the one who does it, never with the victim.

If you have experienced sexual violence or abuse: It is not your fault, and you are not alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 12: At the end of the list it says: "And you have forgotten me." That is the root of everything.

In the furnace VERSES 17–22

17 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
18 "Son of man, the people of Israel have become slag to
me.
All of them are bronze, tin, iron, and lead in the
middle of the furnace.
They are the slag left over from silver.
19 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'All of you have become slag.
So look, I will gather you into the middle of
Jerusalem.
20 People gather silver, bronze, iron, lead, and tin
into the middle of the furnace.
They blow on the fire to melt the metal.
In the same way I will gather you in my anger and in
my fury.
I will put you there and melt you.
21 Yes, I will gather you
and blow on you with the fire of my fury.
And you will be melted inside the city.
22 As silver is melted in the middle of the furnace,
so you will be melted inside the city.
And you will know that I, the LORD,
have poured out my fury on you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture from working with metal: To make silver pure, it is melted in a furnace. The less valuable metals separate from it as "slag." Slag is the worthless waste that is left when metal is melted.

Israel was supposed to be valuable silver. But it is only slag now. Jerusalem becomes a furnace: During the siege,

everyone is crowded together in the city, and the "fire" of judgment comes over them.

In other texts, the furnace is also a picture of making pure. That means God cleans his people so that the good is left over (Isaiah 1:25; Malachi 3:2–3).

No one stands in the gap VERSES 23–31

23 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
24 "Son of man, say to her,
'You are a land that has not been made clean.
No rain falls on you on the day of anger.'
25 Her prophets inside her have made a secret plan together.
They are like a roaring lion tearing its prey.
They have devoured people.
They take treasure and valuable things.
They have made many women into widows inside her.
26 Her priests have done violence to my law.
They have treated my holy things as if they were not holy.
They have made no difference between what is holy and what is ordinary.
They have not taught people
to tell the difference between what is unclean and what is clean.
They have closed their eyes to my Sabbaths.
So people treat me as if I were not holy.
27 Her princes inside her are like wolves tearing their prey.
They shed blood and destroy people
to get dishonest profit.
28 Her prophets have covered over these things for them, like whitewash on a wall.
They see false visions
and tell them lies about the future.
They say, 'This is what the Lord GOD says,'
when the LORD has not spoken.
29 The people of the land have oppressed others and robbed them.
Yes, they have troubled the poor and the needy.
They have oppressed the foreigner unjustly.
30 "I looked for a man among them
who would build up the wall
and stand in the gap in front of me for the land,
so that I would not destroy it.
But I found no one.
31 So I have poured out my anger on them.
I have destroyed them with the fire of my fury.
I have brought on their own heads what they have done,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here all the groups in society are named, and all of them have failed:

– the prophets (verses 25 and 28): They lie and make themselves rich.

– the priests (verse 26): They no longer teach God's commandments.

– the princes (verse 27): They are like wolves, greedy and violent.

– the people of the land (verse 29): Even ordinary people oppress the poor and foreigners.

Verse 30: A moving verse: God looks for one single person who will "stand in the gap." That means someone who stands in the hole of the broken wall, stands up for his people, and prays. Moses did this once (Psalm 106:23). But God finds no one.

This verse is a question for us today: Where are people needed who stand up for others, who pray, help, and work for justice? God is looking for people like this.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 23

Oholah and Oholibah

First: How do we read this chapter?

Ezekiel 23, like Chapter 16, is a very harsh chapter full of pictures. Two sisters stand for two cities: Oholah for Samaria (the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel) and Oholibah for Jerusalem (the capital city of the southern kingdom of Judah).

Their "unfaithfulness" is a picture for the politics and the faith of these cities: Instead of trusting God, they held on to foreign world powers, Egypt, Assyria and Babylon, and took over their gods.

In some places the language is very direct about sex, and it is also violent. It was meant to shock even back then. Today many people feel it is hurtful and hostile toward women, and it is all right to say that.

Very important: This chapter is a picture for the guilt of two cities and their leaders, and those were mostly men. It says nothing about what women are like. And it never justifies violence against women or any other person, or shaming them or punishing them.

Two sisters VERSES 1–4

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "Son of man, there were two women.
They were daughters of the same mother.
3 They acted like prostitutes in Egypt.
They acted like prostitutes when they were young.
There men touched their breasts.
There men stroked their young nipples.
4 Their names were Oholah, the older one,
and Oholibah, her sister.
They became mine,
and they had sons and daughters.
As for their names:
Samaria is Oholah,
and Jerusalem is Oholibah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The names are plays on words: "Oholah" means something like "her tent." "Oholibah" means "my tent is in her." The "tent" makes us think of the holy place of worship. Maybe it

means: Samaria had its own sanctuary that it made for itself, but in Jerusalem stood God's own temple.

Verse 3: Already in Egypt, at the very beginning of their history, the people of Israel held on to foreign gods (see 20:7–8). The picture describes young girls who were used for sex in Egypt. From today's point of view, we must say clearly: When girls are treated like this, it is abuse, and the guilt is never with the girls.

Oholah: Samaria and Assyria VERSES 5–10

5 "Oholah acted like a prostitute while she was mine.
She was madly in love with her lovers,
with the Assyrians, her neighbors.
6 They were dressed in blue.
They were governors and rulers,
all of them attractive young men,
horsemen riding on horses.
7 She gave herself to them like a prostitute,
to all of them, the finest men of Assyria.
She made herself unclean
with the idols of every man she desired.
8 She has not stopped acting like a prostitute since she left Egypt.
For when she was young, men slept with her.
They stroked her young nipples,
and they poured out their lust on her.
9 "So I handed her over to her lovers,
to the Assyrians she was madly in love with.
10 They stripped her naked.
They took her sons and her daughters,
and they killed her with the sword.
Women everywhere talked about her as a warning,
because judgment was carried out on her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samaria, the northern kingdom, was impressed by the shining world power Assyria: the splendid uniforms, the horsemen, the power. It tried to make alliances with Assyria and took over its gods (see 2 Kings 17).

Verses 9–10: In the end, exactly these "lovers" became the destroyers. In the year 722 BC, Assyria conquered Samaria and took the people away (2 Kings 17:5–6). The sons and daughters, that is, the people who lived there, were killed or taken away.

The message: Whoever trusts in power and glamour instead of in God will in the end be destroyed by exactly this power.

Oholibah: Jerusalem is even worse VERSES 11–21

11 "Her sister Oholibah saw this.
And yet she was even more corrupt than her sister in her lust.
Her prostitution was even worse
than the prostitution of her sister.
12 She lusted after the Assyrians,
governors and rulers, her neighbors.
They were dressed in splendid clothes.
They were horsemen riding on horses,
all of them attractive young men.
13 I saw that she had made herself unclean.
Both sisters went the same way.
14 "She did even more as a prostitute.
For she saw men drawn on the wall,
pictures of Chaldeans painted in red.
15 They wore belts around their waists
and flowing turbans on their heads.
All of them looked like princes.
They looked like the Babylonians in Chaldea,
the land where they were born.
16 As soon as she saw them, she lusted after them.
She sent messengers to them in Chaldea.
17 The Babylonians came to her, into her bed of love.
They made her unclean with their lust.
She became unclean through them,
and then she turned away from them in disgust.
18 So she showed her prostitution openly
and showed her naked body.
Then I turned away from her in disgust,
just as I had turned away from her sister.
19 But she did even more as a prostitute.
She remembered the days when she was young,
when she had acted like a prostitute in the land of Egypt.
20 She lusted after her lovers there.
Their bodies were like the bodies of donkeys,
and their semen was like the semen of horses.
21 So you remembered again the shameless acts of your youth,
when the Egyptians stroked your nipples
because your breasts were young.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jerusalem has learned nothing from what happened to Samaria. It makes the same mistakes, only worse:

– First Judah looked for protection from Assyria (see 2 Kings 16:7–8).

– Then it was fascinated by Babylon. Even pictures of Babylonian officers were enough (verses 14–16). Judah sent messengers to Babylon.

– Then it turned away from Babylon again and looked for help from Egypt (verses 19–21).

Verse 20: This language is crude and shocking on purpose. It is meant to show how undignified and disgusting this back and forth between the world powers is. Egypt was famous for its horses (see 1 Kings 10:28).

Verses 17–18: An important detail: Jerusalem turns away from Babylon, and God turns away from Jerusalem. Unfaithfulness destroys relationships.

The judgment on Oholibah VERSES 22–35

22 "So, Oholibah, this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will stir up your lovers against you,
the ones you turned away from in disgust.
I will bring them against you from every side:
23 the Babylonians and all the Chaldeans,
Pekod, Shoa, and Koa,
and all the Assyrians with them.
All of them are attractive young men,
governors and rulers,
princes and famous men.
All of them ride on horses.
24 They will come against you with weapons, chariots, and wagons,
and with a crowd of peoples.
They will take their places against you all around,
with large shields, small shields, and helmets.

I will give them the right to judge you,
and they will judge you by their own laws.
25 I will turn my jealous anger against you,
and they will treat you with fury.
They will cut off your nose and your ears.
Those of you who are left will die by the sword.
They will take your sons and your daughters.
And the rest of you will be burned up by fire.
26 They will also strip off your clothes
and take away your beautiful jewelry.
27 So I will put an end to your shameless acts
and to the prostitution you began in the land of Egypt.
You will not look at them with longing anymore,
and you will not think of Egypt anymore.'
28 "For this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will hand you over to the people you hate,
to the people you turned away from in disgust.
29 They will treat you with hatred.
They will take away everything you worked for.
They will leave you naked and bare.
Your naked prostitution will be shown openly,
your shameless acts and your prostitution.
30 These things will be done to you
because you acted like a prostitute with the nations,
and because you made yourself unclean with their
idols.
31 You have walked in the way of your sister.
So I will put her cup into your hand.'
32 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'You will drink from your sister's cup.
It is deep and wide.
People will laugh at you and mock you.
The cup holds a lot.
33 You will be filled with drunkenness and sorrow.
It is the cup of horror and destruction,
the cup of your sister Samaria.
34 You will drink it and empty it.
You will chew on its broken pieces,
and you will tear at your breasts.
For I have spoken,'
says the Lord GOD.
35 "So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'You have forgotten me
and thrown me behind your back.
So you too must bear the results of your shameless acts
and your prostitution.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–24: The world powers that Jerusalem "loved" now come as enemies. Pekod, Shoa, and Koa were peoples in the area of Babylon.

Verse 25: Cutting off the nose and ears was a cruel punishment in war used by the great powers back then. Ezekiel describes what the conquerors will do. This is a description of the horrors of war, not approval of them.

Verses 31–34: The "cup" is a well-known picture in the Bible for the fate that a person must "drink" (see Jeremiah 25:15–29). Jerusalem must drink the same bitter cup as Samaria.

Verse 35: God names the real reason: "You have forgotten me and thrown me behind your back." Being unfaithful to God is the heart of the problem.

Once again, very clearly: Pictures like these never justify violence against women. If you experience violence, it is not your fault. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Both sisters on trial VERSES 36–49

36 The LORD also said to me,
"Son of man, will you judge Oholah and Oholibah?
Then tell them the disgusting things they have done.
37 For they have broken their marriage vows,
and there is blood on their hands.
They have been unfaithful with their idols.
They have even made their sons, whom they had borne
to me,
pass through the fire to the idols, to be burned up as
food for them.
38 They have also done this to me:
On that same day they made my sanctuary unclean,
and they treated my Sabbaths as if they were not holy.
39 For when they had killed their children for their idols,
they came into my sanctuary that same day and made
it unholy.
Look, they did this inside my house.
40 "And you sisters even sent for men
who came from far away.
A messenger was sent to them,
and look, they came.
For them you washed yourself,
put on eye makeup,
and decorated yourself with jewelry.
41 You sat on a splendid couch,
with a table set in front of it.
On it you put my incense and my oil.
42 "The noise of a carefree crowd was around her.
Along with the ordinary men,
drunkards were brought in from the wilderness.
They put bracelets on the women's arms
and beautiful crowns on their heads.
43 Then I said about the woman who had grown old in
adultery,
'Now they will use her as a prostitute, and she will act
like one with them.'
44 They went in to her,
as men go in to a prostitute.
That is how they went in to Oholah and to Oholibah,
the shameless women.
45 Righteous men will judge them
with the punishment for women who break their
marriage vows
and with the punishment for women who shed blood.
For they have broken their marriage vows,
and there is blood on their hands.
46 "For this is what the Lord GOD says:
'I will bring up a mob against them.
I will hand them over to be pushed around and robbed.
47 The crowd will throw stones at them
and cut them down with their swords.
They will kill their sons and their daughters
and burn down their houses.

48 "'So I will put an end to shameless acts in the land,
so that all women may be warned
and not act shamelessly as you did.
49 People will pay you back for your shameless acts.
You will bear the results of your sins with your idols.
Then you will know that I am the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 37–39: Here it becomes clear what this is really about: the worship of idols and the sacrifice of children. On the same day that they had killed children for idols, they went into God's temple as if nothing had happened. God cannot bear this hypocrisy.

Verses 40–42: Jerusalem makes itself beautiful for foreign messengers. This probably means official receptions and talks about alliances, where God's gifts (incense and oil) were wasted on foreigners.

Verses 45–47: Again the language of the punishments of that time is used. The "mob" is the army that will destroy the cities.

Verse 48: "So that all women may be warned" – in the picture, the "women" are probably the other cities and nations. This verse must never be understood to mean that real women should be frightened or controlled with violence. Violence against women is wrong, always.

In another place, the Bible itself shows a completely different way: Jesus does not condemn the woman who was going to be stoned. Instead he says to the men: "Whoever among you has never sinned may throw the first stone at her" (John 8:7).

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EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 24

The cooking pot and the death of Ezekiel's wife

The day the siege begins VERSES 1–2

1 In the ninth year, in the tenth month, on the tenth day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "Son of man, write down the date of this day,
of this very day.
On this very day the king of Babylon
has come close to Jerusalem to attack it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a historical date: In the winter of 588/587 BC (scholars disagree about the exact year), Nebuchadnezzar began the siege of Jerusalem (see 2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 52:4). Ezekiel is about 560 miles away in Babylon, and through God he knows it on the same day.

In Judaism, the 10th of Tevet is still a day of fasting today. It reminds people of the beginning of this siege.

The parable of the cooking pot VERSES 3–14

3 Tell a parable to the rebellious people of Israel.
Tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Put the cooking pot on the fire.
Put it on, and pour water into it too.
4 Put the pieces of meat into it,
all the good pieces, the thigh and the shoulder.
Fill it with the best bones.
5 Take the best animals of the flock.
Pile up wood under the pot for the bones.
Make it boil well.
Yes, let its bones cook inside it."
6 "'So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"How terrible it will be for the city of blood,
for the pot that is full of rust,
whose rust has not come off!
Take the pieces out of it one after another,
without throwing lots for them.
7 "'"For the blood she shed is still inside her.
She poured it on the bare rock.
She did not pour it on the ground,
where dust could cover it.
8 I have put her blood on the bare rock,
so that it is not covered,
so that my anger rises up to pay her back."
9 "'So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"How terrible it will be for the city of blood!
I too will make the pile of wood big.
10 Pile on the wood.
Make the fire hot.
Cook the meat well.
Make the broth thick,
and let the bones burn.
11 Then set the pot empty on its coals,
so that it gets hot
and its bronze glows,
so that its filth melts inside it
and its rust is burned away.
12 She has worn herself out with hard work.
But her thick rust does not come off her,
not even in the fire.
13 "'"Your filth is your shameless sin.
I tried to make you clean, but you did not become clean.
So you will not become clean from your filth again
until my anger against you has come to rest.
14 "'"I, the LORD, have spoken.
It will happen, and I will do it.
I will not hold back.
I will not spare you.
I will not change my mind.
They will judge you
by your ways and by what you have done,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: A parable is a story with a picture that teaches something.

Do you remember Ezekiel 11:3? There the powerful people in Jerusalem said proudly that the city is the pot and they are the meat, so they are well protected. Ezekiel takes up this picture and turns it around: Yes, Jerusalem is a pot. But it stands on the fire, and the meat is cooked to nothing.

Verse 6: The pot is rusty. The rust is the guilt of the city, which cannot be washed off.

Verses 7–8: By the law, blood had to be covered with earth (Leviticus 17:13). But Jerusalem has poured out the blood of innocent people openly on the rock. It cries out to heaven like the blood of Abel (Genesis 4:10).

Verse 13: God tried again and again to make his people clean, through prophets and warnings. But they did not want it.

Ezekiel's wife dies VERSES 15–18

15 The word of the LORD also came to me. He said,
16 "Son of man, look, with one blow I will take away from you
the delight of your eyes.
But you must not mourn or cry,
and you must not let your tears flow.
17 Sigh, but not out loud.
Do not hold any mourning for the dead.
Tie on your turban,
and put your sandals on your feet.
Do not cover your lips,
and do not eat the bread that people bring to mourners."
18 So I spoke to the people in the morning,
and in the evening my wife died.
The next morning I did as I was commanded.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the saddest passages in the whole book. Ezekiel's wife, "the delight of your eyes," dies suddenly. Here we hear something about her for the first and only time, and you can feel how much he loved her.

God asks Ezekiel to do something very hard: He must not mourn in public, not wear mourning clothes, and not keep the usual customs of mourning. These customs included, for example, taking off the turban, going barefoot, covering the lower part of the face ("the lips"), and eating mourners' bread that neighbors brought. He may only sigh quietly. This is a sign-act for the people (see verses 19–24).

We must not understand this text to mean that God lets people die in order to give a sign. And it is not a rule that people who believe are not allowed to grieve. Quite the opposite: The Bible is full of laments and tears, and Jesus himself cried at the grave of his friend (John 11:35). Grief is allowed and important.

If you are grieving someone right now and need someone to talk to: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

A sign for the people VERSES 19–24

19 The people asked me,
"Won't you tell us what these things mean for us?
Why are you acting like this?"
20 Then I said to them,
"The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
21 'Speak to the people of Israel.
"This is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will make my sanctuary unholy.
It is the pride of your power,
the delight of your eyes,
and what your heart longs for.
And your sons and your daughters whom you left behind
will die by the sword.
22 You will do what I have done.
You will not cover your lips
or eat the bread that people bring to mourners.
23 Your turbans will stay on your heads
and your sandals on your feet.
You will not mourn or cry.
Instead you will waste away because of your sins,
and you will groan to one another.
24 So Ezekiel will be a sign for you.
You will do everything that he has done.
When this happens,
then you will know that I am the Lord GOD.'"'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people ask: Why aren't you mourning? Ezekiel explains: This is what will happen to you. You will lose something that is just as dear to you: the temple, "the delight of your eyes," and your children in Jerusalem.

The pain will be so great that you will not even be able to mourn properly. You will be frozen with shock.

Here Ezekiel's personal suffering and the suffering of the people become one. The prophet carries the pain of his people in his own body.

The messenger will come VERSES 25–27

25 "And you, son of man,
on the day when I take from them their strength,
the glory that gave them joy,
the delight of their eyes,
and what their hearts long for,
their sons and their daughters,
26 won't it be on that day that someone who escaped will come to you
to tell you the news, so that you hear it with your own ears?
27 On that day your mouth will be opened
to the one who escaped.
You will speak, and you will not be silent anymore.
So you will be a sign for them.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Since his call, Ezekiel had been mostly silent (3:26). He was only allowed to speak when God gave him something to say. Now God announces: When someone who fled brings the news that Jerusalem has been destroyed, Ezekiel's mouth will be opened. This happens in Ezekiel 33:21–22.

Here the first great part of the book ends (Chapters 1–24), the words of judgment about Jerusalem. Now come words about the neighboring nations (Chapters 25–32). And after that, starting with Chapter 33, the message of hope begins.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 25

Words against the neighboring nations

Against Ammon VERSES 1–7

1 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, turn your face toward the people of Ammon,
and prophesy against them.
3 Tell the Ammonites,
'Hear the word of the Lord GOD!
This is what the Lord GOD says:
"You said, 'Aha!' about my sanctuary when it was made unholy,
and about the land of Israel when it was ruined,
and about the people of Judah when they were taken away as prisoners.
4 So look, I will hand you over to the peoples of the east.
They will own you.
They will set up their camps in you
and make their homes in you.
They will eat your fruit,
and they will drink your milk.
5 I will make Rabbah a pasture for camels,
and the land of the people of Ammon a resting place for flocks.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."
6 For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"You have clapped your hands
and stamped your feet.
You have been glad about the land of Israel
with all the contempt in your heart.
7 So look, I have stretched out my hand against you.
I will hand you over to the nations, and they will rob you.
I will cut you off from the peoples.
I will make you disappear from the countries.
I will destroy you.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the second part of the book begins: words about the neighboring nations (Chapters 25–32).

The Ammonites lived east of the Jordan River (today in Jordan; their capital city Rabbah is today's Amman). When Jerusalem was destroyed, they were glad and called out "Aha!" They clapped their hands.

The message: Being glad about the suffering of others is wrong. God sees it. (See Proverbs 24:17: Don't be glad when your enemy falls.)

The "peoples of the east" are tribes of nomads from the desert. Nomads are people who move from place to place with their animals.

Against Moab VERSES 8–11

8 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Moab and Seir say,
'Look, the people of Judah are just like all the other nations.'
9 So look, I will open up the side of Moab.
I will start with the cities,
with its cities on its borders,
the pride of the country:
Beth Jeshimoth, Baal Meon, and Kiriathaim.
10 I will open it to the peoples of the east,
who will go against the people of Ammon.
I will give these lands to them to own,
so that no one among the nations will remember the people of Ammon anymore.
11 I will carry out judgment on Moab.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab was east of the Dead Sea. Seir is another name for the mountains of Edom.

Verse 8: Moab says: "The people of Judah are just like all the other nations." This means: Judah is nothing special, and neither is its God. With this they mock not only the people, but also God and his promises.

Against Edom VERSES 12–14

12 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Edom took revenge on the people of Judah.
It did great wrong
when it took revenge on them."
13 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will stretch out my hand against Edom.
I will cut off people and animals from it.
I will make it a wasteland, starting from Teman.
All the way to Dedan, they will die by the sword.
14 I will take my revenge on Edom
through my people Israel.
They will deal with Edom as my anger and my fury demand.
Then they will know my revenge,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom was south of the Dead Sea. The Edomites were descendants of Esau, Jacob's brother. So they were really relatives of Israel. That made it even worse that they took revenge on Judah and helped when Jerusalem was destroyed (see Obadiah 10–14; Psalm 137:7).

Verse 14: Here God says: "I will take my revenge on Edom through my people Israel." This is a difficult verse. But it gives no one today the right to take revenge in God's name or to justify violence against a nation. The Bible says clearly: "Revenge belongs to me, and paying back" (Deuteronomy 32:35; see Romans 12:19). Revenge is God's business, not ours.

Against the Philistines VERSES 15–17

15 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"The Philistines took revenge.
They took revenge with contempt in their hearts.

They wanted to destroy, because their hatred never ends."

16 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will stretch out my hand against the Philistines.
I will cut off the Cherethites,
and I will destroy the people who are left on the seacoast.

17 I will take great revenge on them
with angry punishments.
Then they will know that I am the LORD,
when I take my revenge on them."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines lived on the coast in the west. They had been enemies of Israel for hundreds of years ("their hatred never ends").

Verse 16: The Cherethites were a group of the Philistines. They probably came from the island of Crete in the beginning.

All four nations in this chapter have something in common: They were glad about Judah's misfortune, or they took advantage of it. The message: Whoever mocks and kicks the weak when they are down is guilty.

These old nations do not exist as living peoples today. These texts must not be used to support hatred against people living in this region today.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 26

Against Tyre

Tyre is glad that Jerusalem has fallen VERSES 1–6

1 In the eleventh year, on the first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,

2 "Son of man, Tyre has said about Jerusalem,
'Aha! She is broken!
She was the gateway of the peoples,
but now she has been handed over to me.
I will grow rich, now that she lies in ruins.'

3 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I am against you, Tyre.
I will make many nations come up against you,
as the sea makes its waves come up.

4 They will destroy the walls of Tyre
and tear down her towers.
I will even scrape her dust off her
and make her a bare rock.

5 She will be a place where fishermen spread out their nets
in the middle of the sea.
For I have spoken,'
says the Lord GOD.
'She will become plunder for the nations.

6 Her daughters on the mainland
will be killed with the sword.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tyre (today Sur in Lebanon) was a rich trading city of the Phoenicians. The most important part of the city was on an island off the coast, so it was very hard to conquer. The Phoenicians were the great sailors and traders of their time.

Verse 2: Tyre is glad that Jerusalem has fallen, but for business reasons: Jerusalem was a competitor in trade, the "gateway of the peoples." Now Tyre hopes for more profit. This is about greed: The misfortune of others is my advantage.

Verse 6: The "daughters on the mainland" are the smaller towns that belonged to Tyre.

Nebuchadnezzar is coming VERSES 7–14

7 "For this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will bring Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
the king of kings, against Tyre from the north.
He will come with horses, with chariots, with horsemen,
and with an army of many people.

8 He will kill your daughters on the mainland with the sword.
He will build siege towers against you.
He will pile up a ramp of earth against you
and raise up shields against you.

9 He will set his battering rams against your walls.
With his axes he will tear down your towers.

10 He has so many horses
that their dust will cover you.
Your walls will shake at the noise of the horsemen,
of the wagons, and of the chariots,
when he comes in through your gates,
as men come into a city whose walls have been broken open.

11 The hoofs of his horses will trample all your streets.
He will kill your people with the sword.
Your strong pillars will fall to the ground.

12 They will rob you of your riches
and steal your goods.
They will tear down your walls
and destroy your beautiful houses.
They will throw your stones, your wood, and your rubble
into the middle of the water.

13 I will put an end to the noise of your songs.
The sound of your harps will not be heard anymore.

14 I will make you a bare rock.
You will be a place where fishermen spread out their nets.
You will never be built again.
For I, the LORD, have spoken,'
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nebuchadnezzar really did lay siege to Tyre, for about 13 years (around 586–573 BC). The towns on the mainland were conquered. But he could not completely destroy the island city. In the end, Tyre surrendered to him. Ezekiel himself later says openly that Nebuchadnezzar got no reward for this siege (Ezekiel 29:17–20).

About 250 years later, in 332 BC, Alexander the Great conquered Tyre. To do this, he built a causeway of rubble and stones from the mainland into the sea to the island. Many Bible teachers see in this a further fulfillment of verse 12: "They will throw your stones, your wood, and your rubble into the middle of the water."

Verse 3: "Many nations ... as the sea makes its waves come up" – the judgment comes in several waves, not only through one single king.

Verse 13: The happy, rich city with its songs and harps will become silent.

The princes of the sea mourn VERSES 15–21

15 "This is what the Lord GOD says to Tyre:
'The islands will shake at the sound of your fall,
when the wounded groan,
when people are killed inside you.
Won't they?
16 Then all the princes of the sea will come down from their thrones.
They will take off their robes
and their embroidered clothes.
They will wrap themselves in trembling as if it were clothing.
They will sit on the ground.
They will tremble every moment,
and they will be shocked at what happened to you.
17 They will sing a song of mourning about you and say to you,
"How you are destroyed,
you city where seafaring men lived,
you famous city!
You were strong on the sea,
you and the people who lived in you.
You made everyone who lived there afraid of you!"
18 Now the islands will tremble on the day of your fall.
Yes, the islands in the sea will be terrified that you are gone.'
19 "For this is what the Lord GOD says:
'I will make you a ruined city,
like the cities where no one lives.
I will bring up the deep ocean over you,
and the great waters will cover you.
20 Then I will bring you down to those who go down into the pit,
to the people of long ago.
I will make you live in the lowest parts of the earth,
in places that have been in ruins since ancient times,
with those who go down to the pit,
so that no one lives in you anymore.
And I will give glory to the land of the living.
21 I will make you a horror,
and you will be no more.
People will look for you,
but you will never be found again,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–18: Tyre traded with many coasts and islands in the Mediterranean Sea. When Tyre falls, all its trading partners are terrified. Their wealth depended on Tyre.

Verse 20: The "pit" is a picture for the world of the dead. Tyre will fall as deep as a dead person into the grave.

"Glory to the land of the living" – while Tyre goes down, God will give honor and life to his people again.

The message for today: Wealth and power in trade do not give real security. Whoever thinks only of profit and is glad about the misfortune of others is building on sand.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 27

The song of mourning for the ship Tyre

Tyre, the splendid ship VERSES 1–11

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "You, son of man, sing a song of mourning about Tyre.
3 Say to Tyre,
'You live where the sea begins.
You trade with the peoples of many islands.
This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Tyre, you have said,
'I am perfect in beauty.'
4 Your borders are in the heart of the seas.
Your builders have made your beauty perfect.
5 They made all your boards
from cypress trees from Senir.
They took a cedar from Lebanon
to make a mast for you.
6 They made your oars
from the oaks of Bashan.
They made your benches from ivory
set into cypress wood from the islands of Kittim.
7 Your sail was made of fine linen with embroidery from Egypt,
so that it would be your flag.
Your sunshade was made of blue and purple cloth
from the islands of Elishah.
8 The people of Sidon and Arvad were your rowers.
Your wise men, Tyre, were on board.
They were your pilots who steered you.
9 The old men of Gebal and its wise men were on board.
They fixed the leaks in your seams.
All the ships of the sea and their sailors were with you
to trade your goods.
10 "'"Persia, Lud, and Put were in your army.
They were your soldiers.
They hung up their shields and helmets in you.
They made you look splendid.

11 The men of Arvad and your army
were on your walls all around.
Brave men were in your towers.
They hung their shields on your walls all around.
They made your beauty perfect.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel describes Tyre like a beautiful, proud trading ship. Everything about it is of the finest quality, brought together from all over the world:

– wood from Senir (the Hermon mountains) and from Lebanon,

– oaks from Bashan (east of the Sea of Galilee),

– ivory and cypress wood from Kittim (Cyprus),

– linen from Egypt,

– expensive blue and purple cloth from Elishah (maybe Cyprus or Greece).

By the way, purple was the most famous product of the Phoenicians. It was made from sea snails, and it was very expensive.

Verses 8–11: The crew also comes from many cities: Sidon, Arvad, Gebal (Byblos). The soldiers even come from Persia, Lud (in Asia Minor or Africa) and Put (Libya).

Verse 3: The problem is pride: "I am perfect in beauty."

The trading partners of Tyre VERSES 12–25

12 "'"Tarshish traded with you
because you had so many kinds of riches.
They paid for your goods with silver, iron, tin, and lead.
13 "'"Javan, Tubal, and Meshech traded with you.
They traded people
and bronze pots for your goods.
14 "'"The people of the house of Togarmah traded for your goods
with horses, war horses, and mules.
15 "'"The men of Dedan traded with you.
Many islands were your markets.
They brought you ivory tusks and ebony wood in exchange.
16 "'"Syria traded with you
because you made so many things.
They paid for your goods with emeralds, purple cloth, embroidery, fine linen,
coral, and rubies.
17 "'"Judah and the land of Israel traded with you.
They paid for your goods with wheat from Minnith, sweets,
honey, oil, and balm.
18 "'"Damascus traded with you
because you made so many things
and had so many kinds of riches.
They brought wine from Helbon and white wool.
19 "'"Vedan and Javan traded yarn for your goods.
Worked iron, cassia, and calamus
were among your goods.
20 "'"Dedan traded with you
in expensive saddle blankets for riding.
21 "'"Arabia and all the princes of Kedar
were your favorite traders.
They traded lambs, rams, and goats.
With these they did business with you.
22 "'"The traders of Sheba and Raamah traded with you.
They paid for your goods with the best of all kinds of spices,
with all kinds of precious stones, and with gold.
23 "'"Haran, Canneh, and Eden,
the traders of Sheba, Asshur, and Chilmad
traded with you.
24 They traded with you in fine goods,
in cloaks of blue cloth and embroidery,
and in chests of cedar wood full of rich clothing,
tied with cords.
These were among your goods.
25 "'"The ships of Tarshish carried your goods for you.
You were filled with riches
and became very glorious in the heart of the seas.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here there is a long list of the trading partners of Tyre, almost like a map of the world at that time. It reaches from Tarshish (probably in Spain) in the west to Arabia and Mesopotamia in the east.

Javan is Greece (Ionia). Tubal and Meshech were in Asia Minor (today Turkey). Togarmah was probably in Armenia. Sheba was in the south of Arabia (today Yemen).

Verse 13: "They traded people and bronze pots" – the slave trade was also part of the wealth of Tyre (see Joel 3:6; Amos 1:9). Here the Bible states it plainly. In other places it clearly condemns kidnapping and human trafficking (Exodus 21:16; 1 Timothy 1:10). Human trafficking is a serious wrong, then as now.

Verse 17: Judah and Israel also sold goods to Tyre, mostly farm products: wheat, honey, oil, and balm. Balm is a healing oil from plants.

Verse 19: Cassia and calamus are spices with a sweet smell.

The ship sinks VERSES 26–36

26 "'"Your rowers have taken you out into the great waters.
The east wind has broken you to pieces in the heart of the seas.
27 Your riches, your goods, your merchandise,
your sailors, your pilots,
the men who fixed the leaks in your seams,
the traders of your goods,
and all your soldiers on board,
with all the people on board,
will sink into the heart of the seas
on the day of your ruin.
28 At the sound of your pilots crying out,
the land along the coast will shake.
29 All who row with oars,
the sailors and all the pilots of the sea,
will come down from their ships.
They will stand on the land.
30 They will raise their voices over you
and cry bitterly.
They will throw dust on their heads.
They will roll in the ashes.
31 They will shave their heads bald because of you
and put on sackcloth.
They will weep for you with bitter hearts,
with bitter mourning.

32 As they wail, they will sing a song of mourning for you.
They will mourn over you and say,
'Who was ever like Tyre,
like her who has been made silent in the middle of the sea?'
33 When your goods came over the seas,
you met the needs of many peoples.
With your great riches and your goods
you made the kings of the earth rich.
34 Now you are broken by the seas,
in the depths of the waters.
Your goods and all the people on board
have sunk with you.
35 All the people who live on the islands are shocked at you.
Their kings shake with terror.
Their faces are full of fear.
36 The traders among the peoples hiss at you in scorn.
You have come to a terrible end,
and you will be no more."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The splendid ship sails out onto the open sea, and then a storm comes from the east and breaks it to pieces. Everything sinks: riches, goods, crew. The east wind stands for Babylon.

Verses 29–32: All the sailors stand on the shore and mourn. They throw dust on their heads and put on sackcloth, as at a funeral. Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they mourned.

The message: Even the most beautiful, richest, and most powerful "ship" can sink. Wealth and trade are not bad. But whoever puts all their trust in them and becomes proud is building on a ship that can sink.

In Revelation 18 there is a very similar song of mourning about the fall of "Babylon": Merchants and sailors stand far away and weep over the rich city (Revelation 18:9–19). That text clearly takes up Ezekiel 27.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 28

The king of Tyre

"I am a god" VERSES 1–10

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "Son of man, tell the prince of Tyre,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Your heart has become proud.
You have said,
'I am a god.
I sit on the throne of God, in the middle of the seas.'
But you are a man and not a god,
even though you think in your heart that you are like a god.
3 Look, you are wiser than Daniel.
No secret is hidden from you.
4 With your wisdom and your understanding
you have gotten riches for yourself.
You have filled your treasure rooms with gold and silver.
5 With your great wisdom and your trading
you have made your riches grow.
And your heart has become proud because of your riches."
6 "'So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"You think in your heart that you are like God.
7 So look, I will bring foreigners against you,
the most terrifying of the nations.
They will pull out their swords against your beautiful wisdom.
They will make your splendor unholy.
8 They will throw you down into the pit.
You will die a violent death in the heart of the seas.
9 Will you still say, 'I am God,'
in front of the one who kills you?
You are a man and not God
in the hands of the one who wounds you.
10 You will die the death of the uncircumcised
at the hands of foreigners.
For I have spoken,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The prince of Tyre is so rich and powerful that he thinks he is a god. That is the heart of all pride: A human being puts himself in God's place.

Verse 3: "Wiser than Daniel" is meant with irony. About "Daniel," see Ezekiel 14:14.

Verse 9: A sharp question: Will you still say "I am God" when someone kills you? At the latest in death it becomes clear: Every human being must die.

Verse 10: To die "the death of the uncircumcised" means to die a shameful death, without honor.

This warning is still true today: Whoever thinks that wealth, success, or power puts him above everything will one day notice that he is only a human being.

Song of mourning: In the garden of Eden VERSES 11–19

11 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
12 "Son of man, sing a song of mourning about the king of Tyre.
Tell him,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"You were the seal of perfection,
full of wisdom
and perfect in beauty.
13 You were in Eden, the garden of God.
Every precious stone decorated you:
ruby, topaz, emerald, chrysolite,
onyx, jasper, sapphire, turquoise, and beryl.
Gold work of tambourines and of flutes was in you.
They were prepared on the day you were created.
14 You were the anointed cherub who covers and protects.

I set you on the holy mountain of God.
You walked back and forth among the stones of fire.
15 You were perfect in your ways
from the day you were created,
until wrongdoing was found in you.
16 Because you traded so much,
you were filled with violence inside,
and you sinned.
So I threw you out of God's mountain as something unholy.
I destroyed you, you cherub who covers,
and drove you away from the stones of fire.
17 Your heart became proud because of your beauty.
You ruined your wisdom because of your splendor.
I threw you to the ground.
I laid you down in front of kings,
so that they could look at you.
18 You sinned so much,
and you were so dishonest in your trading,
that you made your holy places unholy.
So I made a fire come out from inside you.
It burned you up.
I turned you to ashes on the ground
in front of everyone who sees you.
19 All who know you among the peoples
are shocked at you.
You have become a horror,
and you will be no more."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This song of mourning is one of the most mysterious passages in the Bible. The king of Tyre is described like a beautiful being in the garden of Eden, decorated with precious stones, a "cherub" on God's holy mountain. Then he becomes proud, wrongdoing is found in him, and he is thrown out.

This is like the story of Adam in paradise (Genesis 2–3): created perfect, then fallen, then thrown out.

Verse 14: A cherub is a powerful heavenly being.

Verse 13: The precious stones are like the stones on the breastpiece of the high priest (Exodus 28:17–20).

How do we read this text?

– Many Jewish and Christian Bible teachers say: Ezekiel uses pictures from old stories about paradise to describe the deep fall of the proud king. What is meant is the human king of Tyre.

– Later, many Christians also saw in this text (together with Isaiah 14:12–15) a picture of the fall of Satan, an angel who turned away from God out of pride. The text itself does not say this directly, but this understanding is widespread in Christian tradition.

Verse 16: Again trade and violence are named together. Greed often leads to violence and injustice.

Against Sidon VERSES 20–23

20 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
21 "Son of man, turn your face toward Sidon,
and prophesy against it.
22 Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against you, Sidon.
I will show my glory in you.
Then they will know that I am the LORD,
when I carry out judgment on her
and show that I am holy in her.
23 For I will send a deadly disease into her
and blood into her streets.
The wounded will fall inside her,
with the sword against her on every side.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sidon was the neighbor and sister city of Tyre. It was also a rich Phoenician port city (today Saida in Lebanon). Queen Jezebel came from Sidon. She had spread the worship of Baal in Israel (1 Kings 16:31).

Israel will live in safety VERSES 24–26

24 "'"The people of Israel will no longer have a briar that pricks them
or a thorn that hurts them
from any of the nations around them that treated them with scorn.
Then they will know that I am the Lord GOD."
25 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will gather the people of Israel from the peoples among whom they are scattered.
I will show that I am holy among them in front of the nations.
Then they will live in their own land,
which I gave to my servant Jacob.
26 They will live there in safety.
Yes, they will build houses and plant vineyards.
They will live in safety
when I have carried out judgment on all those around them
who have treated them with contempt.
Then they will know that I am the LORD their God."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the words of judgment about the nations comes a ray of hope for Israel: God will gather his people, and they will live in the land in safety. Building houses and planting vineyards are signs of peace and of a normal, good life (see Jeremiah 29:5; Amos 9:14).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 29

Against Pharaoh of Egypt

The great monster in the Nile VERSES 1–7

1 In the tenth year, in the tenth month, on the twelfth day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,

2 "Son of man, turn your face against Pharaoh, the king
of Egypt.
Prophesy against him and against all of Egypt.
3 Speak and say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against you, Pharaoh, king of Egypt,
you great monster lying in the middle of your rivers.
You have said,
'My river is my own.
I made it for myself.'
4 I will put hooks in your jaws.
I will make the fish of your rivers stick to your scales.
I will pull you up out of the middle of your rivers,
with all the fish of your rivers
that stick to your scales.
5 I will throw you out into the wilderness,
you and all the fish of your rivers.
You will fall on the open field.
No one will pick you up or gather you.
I have given you as food to the wild animals
and to the birds of the sky.
6 "'"Then all the people who live in Egypt will know that
I am the LORD.
For they have been a walking stick made of reed for the
people of Israel.
7 When they took hold of you with their hand,
you broke and tore open their shoulders.
When they leaned on you,
you broke and made their legs give way."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From here on come four chapters against Egypt (29–32). The date is about January 587 BC, during the siege of Jerusalem. Jerusalem was hoping for help from Egypt.

Verse 3: Pharaoh is described as a "great monster" in the Nile, probably a crocodile. He says proudly: The Nile belongs to me, I made it. Again the sin of pride: A human being thinks he is the creator.

Verses 4–5: God will pull the crocodile out of the water with hooks and throw it into the wilderness, where it dies.

Verses 6–7: For Israel, Egypt was like a walking stick made of reed: If you lean on it, it breaks and even hurts you (see Isaiah 36:6). The message: Whoever trusts in people and world powers instead of in God will be disappointed.

Egypt will be ruined VERSES 8–12

8 "'So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will bring a sword against you.
I will cut off people and animals from you.
9 The land of Egypt will become a ruin and a wasteland.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.
"'"He has said,
'The river is mine. I made it.'
10 So look, I am against you and against your rivers.
I will make the land of Egypt a complete wasteland and
ruin,
from the tower of Seveneh all the way to the border of
Ethiopia.
11 No human foot will walk through it,
and no animal's foot will walk through it.
No one will live in it for 40 years.
12 I will make the land of Egypt a ruin
among the countries that are ruined.
Her cities will lie in ruins for 40 years
among the cities that are destroyed.
I will scatter the Egyptians among the nations
and spread them out through the countries."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Egypt will be ruined "from the tower of Seveneh all the way to the border of Ethiopia." Seveneh is today's Aswan in the south of Egypt. Ethiopia here means the land south of Egypt, in today's Sudan (in Hebrew: Cush).

Verses 11–12: In the Bible, "40 years" is often a round number for a long time, about one generation (see the 40 years in the wilderness). We do not know from other sources that Egypt was completely ruined for exactly 40 years. But Nebuchadnezzar really did attack Egypt later (around 568 BC), and Egypt lost its earlier position as a world power.

A lowly kingdom VERSES 13–16

13 "'For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"At the end of 40 years
I will gather the Egyptians from the peoples
where they were scattered.
14 I will bring Egypt back from captivity.
I will bring them back to the land of Pathros,
the land where they came from.
There they will be a lowly kingdom.
15 It will be the lowest of the kingdoms.
It will never again raise itself above the nations.
I will make them small,
so that they will not rule over the nations anymore.
16 The people of Israel will never again trust in Egypt.
That trust would only remind them of their guilt,
when they turned to Egypt for help.
Then they will know that I am the Lord GOD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Interesting: There is a restoration after the judgment for Egypt too. God gathers the Egyptians again. God cares about other nations too (see Isaiah 19:19–25, where Egypt is even called "my people").

Pathros is Upper Egypt, the south of the country, where the Egyptian kingdom first came from.

Verse 16: Egypt will no longer be a powerful kingdom. So Israel can no longer be tempted to trust in Egypt instead of in God.

Egypt as payment for Nebuchadnezzar VERSES 17–21

17 In the twenty-seventh year, in the first month, on the
first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,
18 "Son of man, Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon,
made his army work very hard against Tyre.
Every head was rubbed bald,
and every shoulder was rubbed raw.
But he and his army got no pay from Tyre
for the hard work he did against it.
19 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will give the land of Egypt to Nebuchadnezzar,
king of Babylon.
He will carry off its people,
take its riches as plunder,

and rob it.
That will be the pay for his army.
20 I have given him the land of Egypt as his payment
for the work he did,
because they worked for me,'
says the Lord GOD.
21 "On that day I will make a horn grow for the people of Israel.
And I will open your mouth among them.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: This is the latest date in the whole book of Ezekiel: about 571 BC, 16 years after Jerusalem was destroyed. So this word was added here later, because it fits the theme of Egypt.

Verse 18: A remarkably honest text! In Chapter 26, Ezekiel had announced that Nebuchadnezzar would completely destroy Tyre. Here he says openly: Nebuchadnezzar besieged Tyre for 13 years. His soldiers carried so much that their heads were bald and their shoulders were raw. But he got no plunder. The island city held out.

The Bible does not hide this. Prophecy is not simply telling the future in every detail. God remains free in the way he fulfills his words.

Verse 21: To "make a horn grow" is a picture for new power and strength (see Psalm 132:17).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 30

The day of the LORD over Egypt

How terrible that day will be! VERSES 1–9

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "Son of man, prophesy and say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Wail and cry, 'How terrible that day will be!'
3 For the day is near.
Yes, the day of the LORD is near.
It will be a day of clouds,
a time of judgment for the nations.
4 A sword will come against Egypt.
There will be great fear in Ethiopia
when the dead fall in Egypt.
Her people will be taken away,
and her foundations will be torn down.
5 "'"Ethiopia, Put, Lud, all the mixed peoples, Cub,
and the people of the land that is allied with them
will die by the sword together with Egypt."
6 "'This is what the LORD says:
"Those who support Egypt will also fall.
The pride of her power will come down.
From the tower of Seveneh on,
they will die there by the sword,"
says the Lord GOD.
7 "They will be ruined among the countries that are ruined.
Her cities will be among the cities that are destroyed.
8 They will know that I am the LORD
when I set fire to Egypt,
and all her helpers are crushed.
9 "'"On that day messengers will go out from me in ships
to frighten the Ethiopians, who feel so safe.
Great fear will come over them, as on the day of Egypt.
For look, it is coming."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The day of the LORD" is a big theme in the prophets: a day when God steps in and judges (see Joel 2:1–2; Zephaniah 1:14–16). This time it strikes Egypt.

Verses 4–5: "Ethiopia" here is the land south of Egypt (today Sudan; in Hebrew: Cush). Put is probably Libya. Lud is a people in Africa or in Asia Minor. These peoples were allies of Egypt or soldiers who fought for pay. We do not know for sure what "Cub" was. Some old manuscripts read "Libya" here.

Important: These texts speak about the states and armies of that time, not about people with a certain skin color or background. They must not be used for prejudice against people from Africa.

Through Nebuchadnezzar VERSES 10–12

10 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will also put an end to the crowds of Egypt
through Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon.
11 He and his people with him,
the most terrifying of the nations,
will be brought in to destroy the land.
They will pull out their swords against Egypt
and fill the land with the dead.
12 I will make the rivers dry.
I will hand the land over to evil men.
Through foreigners I will ruin the land
and everything in it.
I, the LORD, have spoken."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Egypt lived from the Nile. If the Nile dries up, the land is lost. The picture shows: God is also Lord over the Nile, which the Egyptians worshiped.

The cities of Egypt VERSES 13–19

13 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will also destroy the idols.
I will put an end to the images in Memphis.
There will no longer be a prince from the land of Egypt.
I will fill the land of Egypt with fear.
14 I will ruin Pathros.
I will set fire to Zoan.
I will carry out judgment on No.
15 I will pour out my anger on Sin,
the fortress of Egypt.
I will cut off the crowds of No.

16 I will set fire to Egypt.
Sin will twist in great pain.
No will be broken open.
Memphis will have enemies in broad daylight.
17 The young men of Aven and of Pibeseth
will die by the sword.
The people will be taken away as prisoners.
18 At Tehaphnehes the day will turn dark
when I break the yokes of Egypt there.
The pride of her power will come to an end in her.
A cloud will cover her,
and her daughters will be taken away as prisoners.
19 This is how I will carry out judgment on Egypt.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'"'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the most important cities of Egypt are listed:
– Memphis: the old capital, near today's Cairo.
– Pathros: Upper Egypt (the south).
– Zoan: Tanis, in the Nile Delta.
– No: Thebes, the great temple city in the south (today Luxor).
– Sin: Pelusium, a border fortress in the northeast.
– Aven: On, also called Heliopolis, the city of the sun god.
– Pibeseth: Bubastis, in the Delta.
– Tehaphnehes (also called Tahpanhes): a border town in the east. Jeremiah fled there with other people from Judah (Jeremiah 43:7–9).

Verse 13: The idols of Egypt will be destroyed. The many gods of Egypt cannot save the land.

Pharaoh's broken arm VERSES 20–26

20 In the eleventh year, in the first month, on the seventh day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,
21 "Son of man, I have broken the arm of Pharaoh,
king of Egypt.
Look, no one has tied it up.
No one has put medicine on it
or wrapped a bandage around it,
so that it could become strong enough to hold a sword.
22 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I am against Pharaoh, king of Egypt.
I will break his arms,
both the strong arm and the one that is already broken.
I will make the sword fall out of his hand.
23 I will scatter the Egyptians among the nations
and spread them out through the countries.
24 I will make the arms of the king of Babylon strong
and put my sword in his hand.
But I will break the arms of Pharaoh.
He will groan in front of the king of Babylon,
like a man who is wounded to death.
25 I will hold up the arms of the king of Babylon,
but the arms of Pharaoh will drop down.
Then they will know that I am the LORD,
when I put my sword into the hand of the king of Babylon,
and he stretches it out against the land of Egypt.
26 I will scatter the Egyptians among the nations
and spread them out through the countries.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: This is about April 587 BC. A short time before this, an Egyptian army had tried to help Jerusalem, but the Babylonians drove it back (see Jeremiah 37:5–11). That is Pharaoh's "broken arm."

In the Bible, the "arm" stands for strength and power. Egypt is made weak, Babylon is made strong.

Here it says that God puts his sword into the hand of the king of Babylon. That does not mean that Babylon was good or just. Later Babylon itself is judged (Isaiah 47; Jeremiah 50–51). God can even use foreign rulers in his history, but they are still responsible for the wrong they do.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 31

The cedar that was cut down

The splendid cedar VERSES 1–9

1 In the eleventh year, in the third month, on the first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, say to Pharaoh, king of Egypt,
and to all his people,
'Who are you like in your greatness?
3 Look, the Assyrian was a cedar in Lebanon.
It had beautiful branches
and gave shade like a forest.
It was very tall,
and its top reached up among the thick branches.
4 The waters made it grow.
The deep waters under the earth made it grow tall.
Its rivers flowed all around the place where it was planted.
It sent out its streams to all the trees of the field.
5 So it grew taller than all the trees of the field.
It had very many branches.
Its branches grew long because of all the water,
when it spread them out.
6 All the birds of the sky built their nests in its branches.
Under its branches all the animals of the field had their young.
All the great nations lived in its shade.
7 So it was beautiful in its greatness
and in the length of its branches,
for its roots reached down to plenty of water.
8 The cedars in the garden of God could not hide it.
The cypress trees did not have branches like it.
The pine trees did not have branches like it.
No tree in the garden of God was as beautiful as it was.

9 I made it beautiful with its many branches,
so that all the trees of Eden in the garden of God
were jealous of it.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ezekiel asks Pharaoh a question: "Who are you like?" Then he tells about a huge tree, a cedar that is taller than all the others. All the animals and nations find protection in its shade.

Verse 3: The WEB says: "The Assyrian was a cedar." This means the Assyrian Empire, which was once the greatest power in the world and then fell (its capital city Nineveh fell in 612 BC). Some Bible teachers read the Hebrew word differently, as the name of a tree ("a cypress"). Then the text is directly about Egypt as a tree.

Verses 8–9: The tree is even more beautiful than the trees in the garden of Eden. A picture for the splendor of a world empire.

The picture of the great tree where birds build their nests also appears in Daniel 4 and in Jesus' parable of the mustard seed (Mark 4:32).

The fall of the cedar VERSES 10–14

10 "So this is what the Lord GOD said:
'He grew very tall.
He stretched his top up among the thick branches,
and his heart became proud because he was so tall.
11 So I will hand him over to the mightiest ruler of the nations.
He will surely deal with him.
I have driven him out because of his wickedness.
12 Foreigners, the cruelest of the nations,
have cut him down and left him lying there.
His branches have fallen on the mountains and into all the valleys.
His boughs lie broken by all the streams of the land.
All the peoples of the earth have come out from his shade
and left him.
13 All the birds of the sky will live on his fallen trunk.
All the animals of the field will be on his branches.
14 This happened so that none of the trees by the waters
will become proud because they are tall.
None of them will stretch its top up among the thick branches.
None of their mighty ones will stand proudly in their height,
none of all the trees that drink water.
For all of them are handed over to death,
to the lowest parts of the earth,
together with human beings,
with those who go down to the pit.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The mistake of the tree is that "his heart became proud because he was so tall." That means: He became proud. Again pride is the problem.

Verse 11: The "mightiest ruler of the nations" means Babylon.

Verse 14: A lesson for all powerful people: No one should lift himself up too high. All human beings must die, even the greatest kings and empires.

Down into the world of the dead VERSES 15–18

15 "This is what the Lord GOD says:
'On the day he went down to Sheol (the world of the dead),
I made everyone mourn.
I covered the deep waters because of him.
I held back their rivers.
The great waters were stopped.
I made Lebanon mourn for him,
and all the trees of the field became faint because of him.
16 I made the nations shake at the sound of his fall,
when I threw him down to Sheol
with those who go down into the pit.
All the trees of Eden,
the finest and best trees of Lebanon,
all the trees that drink water,
were comforted in the lowest parts of the earth.
17 They also went down into Sheol with him,
to those who were killed by the sword.
These were the ones who had been his strong arm,
who lived in his shade among the nations.
18 "'Which of the trees of Eden
is like you in glory and greatness?
Yet you will be brought down with the trees of Eden
to the lowest parts of the earth.
You will lie among the uncircumcised,
with those who were killed by the sword.
"'This is Pharaoh and all his people,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Sheol" in the Old Testament is the place of the dead, a dark world under the earth.

Verse 16: The other "trees," that is, kings and empires that have already died, are "comforted" when the great tree comes down to them. They see: Even the greatest one ends like us.

Verse 18: At the end comes the point: "This is Pharaoh!" It is the answer to the question from verse 2. As Assyria fell, so Egypt will fall too.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 32

Lament over Pharaoh

The monster in the net VERSES 1–10

1 In the twelfth year, in the twelfth month, on the first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, sing a song of mourning about Pharaoh, king of Egypt.
Tell him,
'You were compared to a young lion among the nations.

But you are like a monster in the seas.
You burst out in your rivers.
You stirred up the waters with your feet
and made their rivers dirty.'"

3 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I will spread out my net over you
with a crowd of many peoples.
They will pull you up in my net.

4 I will leave you lying on the land.
I will throw you out onto the open field.
I will make all the birds of the sky settle on you.
I will feed the animals of the whole earth with you
until they are full.

5 I will lay your flesh on the mountains
and fill the valleys with your huge body.

6 I will also soak the land where you swim
with your blood, all the way to the mountains.
The streams will be full of you.

7 When I put out your light,
I will cover the sky
and make its stars dark.
I will cover the sun with a cloud,
and the moon will not give its light.

8 I will make all the bright lights in the sky dark over
you.
I will bring darkness over your land,"
says the Lord GOD.

9 "I will also trouble the hearts of many peoples
when I spread the news of your destruction among the
nations,
into countries you have not known.

10 Yes, I will make many peoples shocked at you.
Their kings will shake with terror because of you
when I swing my sword in front of them.
They will tremble every moment,
every man for his own life,
on the day of your fall."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pharaoh thinks he is a lion, a king of the nations. But God says: You are more like a crocodile that churns around in the water and makes everything dirty.

Verses 3–6: As in Chapter 29, the monster is caught with a net and thrown onto the land. The pictures are harsh: They show the complete end of Pharaoh's power.

Verses 7–8: The sun, the moon and the stars become dark. In Egypt the sun was worshiped as a god (the sun god Ra). When God makes the sun dark, he shows: He is more powerful than the gods of Egypt. Jesus uses similar pictures (Mark 13:24).

The sword of the king of Babylon VERSES 11–16

11 For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"The sword of the king of Babylon will come against
you.

12 I will make your crowds of people fall
by the swords of mighty warriors.
All of them are the most ruthless of the nations.
They will bring the pride of Egypt to nothing,
and all its crowds will be destroyed.

13 I will also destroy all its animals
from beside the many waters.
No human foot will stir up the waters anymore,
and no animal's hoofs will stir them up.

14 Then I will make their waters clear
and make their rivers flow smoothly like oil,"
says the Lord GOD.

15 "I will make the land of Egypt a ruin and a wasteland.
It will be a land empty of everything that once filled it.
I will strike down all who live there.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.

16 "'"This is the song of mourning that people will sing.
The daughters of the nations will sing it.
They will sing it over Egypt
and over all her crowds of people,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: A strangely quiet picture: When there are no more people and animals, the water becomes very clear and calm, "like oil." It is the silence after the disaster.

Verse 16: Here "the daughters of the nations" are to mourn over Egypt. Songs of mourning were often sung by women whose job was to mourn (see Jeremiah 9:17–20; in some Bibles 9:16–19).

Down into the world of the dead VERSES 17–32

17 In the twelfth year, on the fifteenth day of the month,
the word of the LORD came to me again. He said,

18 "Son of man, wail for the crowds of Egypt.
Send them down,
her and the daughters of the famous nations,
to the lowest parts of the earth,
with those who go down into the pit.

19 Who are you more beautiful than?
Go down,
and lie down with the uncircumcised.

20 They will fall among those
who are killed by the sword.
She is handed over to the sword.
Drag her away with all her crowds.

21 The strongest of the mighty warriors will speak to him
from the middle of Sheol (the world of the dead),
together with those who helped him.
They will say,
'They have gone down.
The uncircumcised lie still,
killed by the sword.'

22 "Asshur is there with all her army.
Her graves are all around her.
All of them were killed. They fell by the sword.

23 Their graves are in the deepest corners of the pit.
Her army lies around her grave.
All of them were killed. They fell by the sword.
They were the ones who spread terror in the land of
the living.

24 "Elam is there with all her crowds around her grave.
All of them were killed. They fell by the sword.
They went down uncircumcised into the lowest parts
of the earth.
They were the ones who spread terror in the land of
the living.
Now they bear their shame with those who go down to
the pit.

25 They have made a bed for Elam among the dead
with all her crowds.
Her graves are around her.
All of them are uncircumcised, killed by the sword.
For they spread terror in the land of the living.
Now they bear their shame with those who go down to
the pit.
He is laid among the dead.
26 "Meshech, Tubal, and all their crowds are there.
Their graves are around them.
All of them are uncircumcised, killed by the sword.
For they spread terror in the land of the living.
27 They will not lie with the fallen mighty warriors of the
uncircumcised,
who went down to Sheol with their weapons of war.
Those warriors had their swords laid under their
heads.
But the guilt of these is on their bones,
for they spread terror among the mighty in the land of
the living.
28 "But you will be broken among the uncircumcised.
You will lie with those who are killed by the sword.
29 "Edom is there, her kings and all her princes.
In spite of their power, they are laid with those who
are killed by the sword.
They will lie with the uncircumcised
and with those who go down to the pit.
30 "All the princes of the north are there,
and all the Sidonians.
They have gone down with the dead.
They are put to shame,
in spite of the terror that they spread with their
power.
They lie uncircumcised with those who are killed by
the sword.
They bear their shame with those who go down to the
pit.
31 "Pharaoh will see them.
He will be comforted about all his crowds,
Pharaoh and all his army, killed by the sword,"
says the Lord GOD.
32 "For I let him spread terror in the land of the living.
He will be laid among the uncircumcised,
with those who are killed by the sword,
Pharaoh and all his crowds,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an eerie picture: Ezekiel describes a kind of tour through the world of the dead. There lie the great empires that once "spread terror in the land of the living": Asshur (Assyria), Elam (in today's Iran), Meshech and Tubal (in Asia Minor), Edom, the princes of the north, and Sidon. Now they all lie dead and still, each one in his grave.

And now Pharaoh joins them. He will be "comforted" (verse 31), because he sees: The other great ones are here too.

The repeated sentence "they spread terror in the land of the living" shows the reason: These empires ruled with violence and terror. In the end it did them no good.

Verse 27: Fallen heroes were sometimes buried with their weapons, as an honor. These here are refused that honor.

The message: All tyrants and world empires end the same way, in the grave. Only God remains (see Psalm 146:3–4: Don't put your trust in princes ...).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 33

The city has fallen

The watchman VERSES 1–9

1 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, speak to the people of your nation and tell
them,
'Suppose I bring the sword against a land.
The people of the land choose a man from among them
and make him their watchman.
3 He sees the sword coming against the land.
He blows the trumpet
and warns the people.
4 Then whoever hears the sound of the trumpet
and does not pay attention to the warning,
if the sword comes and takes him away,
his blood will be on his own head.
5 He heard the sound of the trumpet,
but he did not let himself be warned.
His blood will be on him.
If he had paid attention to the warning,
he would have saved his life.
6 But suppose the watchman sees the sword coming
and does not blow the trumpet.
The people are not warned.
The sword comes and takes someone from among
them.
That person is taken away because of his own guilt.
But I will hold the watchman responsible for his
blood.'
7 "So you, son of man,
I have made you a watchman for the people of Israel.
So hear the word that I speak,
and warn them for me.
8 Suppose I say to a wicked person,
'You wicked man, you will surely die,'
and you do not speak up to warn the wicked person to
leave his way.
Then that wicked person will die because of his guilt,
but I will hold you responsible for his blood.
9 But suppose you warn the wicked person to turn away
from his way,
and he does not turn away from his way.
Then he will die because of his guilt,
but you have saved your life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the third part of the book begins. God calls Ezekiel once more to be a "watchman," as he already did in Ezekiel

3:16–21.

The picture is simple: A watchman on the city wall is to sound the alarm when enemies come. If he warns and the people do not listen, it is their own fault. If he stays silent, he shares the guilt.

The repetition shows: Even after the disaster, Ezekiel's task stays the same. He is to warn the people and call them to turn back. But now the goal is that they live.

Why do you want to die? VERSES 10–20

10 "You, son of man, say to the people of Israel,
'This is what you are saying:
"Our wrongdoings and our sins weigh on us,
and we are wasting away because of them.
How can we live?"'
11 Tell them,
'"As surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked.
I want the wicked to turn from his way and live.
Turn back, turn back from your evil ways!
Why should you die, people of Israel?"'
12 "You, son of man, say to the people of your nation,
'The righteousness of a righteous person will not save him
on the day he disobeys.
And as for the wickedness of a wicked person,
it will not make him fall
on the day he turns away from his wickedness.
And a righteous person will not be able to live because of his righteousness
on the day he sins.
13 Suppose I tell a righteous person that he will surely live.
But then he trusts in his righteousness and does wrong.
Then none of his righteous deeds will be remembered.
He will die because of the wrong he has done.
14 And suppose I say to a wicked person,
"You will surely die."
But then he turns away from his sin
and does what is just and right.
15 The wicked person gives back what he took as a pledge for a loan.
He pays back what he stole.
He follows the rules that lead to life
and does nothing wrong.
Then he will surely live.
He will not die.
16 None of the sins he has done will be held against him.
He has done what is just and right.
He will surely live.
17 "'But the people of your nation say,
"The way of the Lord is not fair."
But it is their own way that is not fair.
18 When a righteous person turns away from his righteousness
and does wrong,
he will die because of it.
19 When a wicked person turns away from his wickedness
and does what is just and right,
he will live because of it.
20 But you say,
"The way of the Lord is not fair."
People of Israel, I will judge each one of you by his ways.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: After the disaster, the people are in despair: "Our wrongdoings and our sins weigh on us, and we are wasting away because of them. How can we live?" They have lost all hope.

Verse 11: God's answer is one of the most beautiful sentences in the Bible: "I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked. I want the wicked to turn from his way and live. Turn back, turn back from your evil ways! Why should you die" (verse 11). The same thought is in Ezekiel 18:23 and 18:32. God wants life, not death.

Verses 12–20: This repeats the message from Chapter 18: Every person can turn back. The past does not have to decide the future.

Verse 15: Turning back is very practical: giving back what was stolen, making up for wrong (see Zacchaeus in Luke 19:8).

If you feel that your guilt or your situation is crushing you, and you see no way out: Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The news arrives VERSES 21–22

21 In the twelfth year of our captivity,
in the tenth month, on the fifth day of the month,
a man who had escaped from Jerusalem came to me.
He said,
"The city has been conquered!"
22 The hand of the LORD had been on me in the evening,
before the man who escaped arrived.
The LORD had opened my mouth
by the time the man came to me in the morning.
So my mouth was opened,
and I was no longer silent.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the turning point in the whole book! A refugee brings the terrible news: Jerusalem has fallen. (The city had been destroyed in the summer of 586 BC. The messenger needed several months for the long journey.)

Just as God had announced in 24:25–27, Ezekiel's mouth is now opened. His silence is over. From now on he speaks mostly words of hope.

The survivors in the land VERSES 23–29

23 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
24 "Son of man, the people who live in the ruins in the land of Israel are saying,
'Abraham was only one man,
and he received the land as his own.
But we are many.
The land has been given to us as our own.'
25 So tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"You eat meat with the blood still in it.
You look to your idols for help.
You shed blood.
And should you own the land?

26 You rely on your sword.
You do disgusting things.
Each of you sleeps with his neighbor's wife.
And should you own the land?"'
27 "Tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"As surely as I live,
those who are in the ruins will die by the sword.
Whoever is in the open field I will give to the wild animals to be eaten.
And those who are in the fortresses and in the caves will die of a deadly disease.
28 I will make the land a ruin and a horror.
The pride of her power will come to an end.
The mountains of Israel will be ruined,
so that no one will travel through them.
29 Then they will know that I am the LORD,
when I have made the land a ruin and a horror
because of all the disgusting things they have done."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some people have stayed behind in the ruins of Jerusalem. They say: Abraham was alone and got the whole land. We are many, so the land belongs to us all the more.

God answers: You appeal to Abraham, but you do not live like Abraham. You do not keep God's commandments. You trust in violence ("you rely on your sword"). You cannot appeal to God's promises and do wrong at the same time.

Verse 25: God says: "You eat meat with the blood still in it." That was forbidden (Genesis 9:4; Leviticus 17:10–14).

A beautiful song, but no one acts VERSES 30–33

30 "As for you, son of man,
the people of your nation are talking about you
by the walls and in the doorways of the houses.
They say to one another, each to his brother,
'Come and hear
what the word is that comes from the LORD.'
31 They come to you the way people come,
and they sit in front of you as my people.
They hear your words,
but they do not do them.
With their mouths they show a lot of love,
but their hearts chase after their own profit.
32 Look, to them you are like a very lovely song
sung by someone with a pleasant voice
who can play an instrument well.
For they hear your words,
but they do not do them.
33 "But when this happens
– and look, it is coming –
then they will know
that a prophet has been among them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now that Ezekiel's predictions have come true, he is suddenly popular. People talk about him and come to hear him.

But God says: They listen to you like a good singer with a beautiful voice. They find it entertaining. But they change nothing in their lives.

This is an important warning, for today too: You can find a sermon beautiful, enjoy a worship service, or find a Bible chapter interesting, and still not put any of it into practice in your life. Jesus says: "So everyone who hears these words of mine and does them is like a wise man who built his house on the rock" (Matthew 7:24). See also James 1:22: "But be doers of the word, not only hearers."

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 34

The good shepherd

How terrible for the shepherds who feed only themselves VERSES 1–10

1 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, prophesy against the shepherds of Israel.
Prophesy and say to them, to the shepherds,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"How terrible it will be for the shepherds of Israel who feed only themselves!
Shouldn't the shepherds feed the sheep?
3 You eat the fat.
You dress yourselves with the wool.
You kill the fattened animals,
but you do not feed the sheep.
4 You have not made the weak ones strong.
You have not healed the sick ones.
You have not bandaged the injured ones.
You have not brought back the ones that were driven away.
You have not searched for the lost ones.
Instead you have ruled over them with force and harshness.
5 They were scattered because there was no shepherd.
They became food for all the wild animals,
and they were scattered.
6 My sheep wandered over all the mountains
and on every high hill.
Yes, my sheep were scattered over the whole earth.
No one looked for them or searched for them."
7 "'So, you shepherds, hear the word of the LORD:
8 "As surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"my sheep have become prey.
My sheep have become food for all the wild animals, because there was no shepherd.
My shepherds did not look for my sheep.
The shepherds fed themselves
and did not feed my sheep.
9 So, you shepherds, hear the word of the LORD!"
10 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against the shepherds.
I will hold them responsible for my sheep.
I will stop them from taking care of the sheep.
The shepherds will not feed themselves anymore.

I will rescue my sheep from their mouths,
so that the sheep will not be food for them anymore."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "shepherds" are the kings and leaders of Israel. In the ancient Near East, kings were often called "shepherds of their people."

The charge: These shepherds thought only of themselves. They ate the fat and dressed themselves with the wool, that is, they used the people for their own gain. But they did nothing for the weak, the sick and the lost. Instead they ruled with harshness and force.

Verse 4 is a kind of job description for good leadership: making the weak strong, healing the sick, bandaging the injured, bringing back those who have wandered off, searching for the lost.

This is still true today for everyone who has responsibility: in politics, church, school, business or family. Good leadership serves people, especially the weakest. Whoever uses power only for himself fails before God.

I myself will search for my sheep VERSES 11–16

11 "'For this is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I myself, yes I,
will search for my sheep
and seek them out.
12 A shepherd looks for his flock
on the day he is among his scattered sheep.
In the same way I will look for my sheep.
I will rescue them from all the places
where they were scattered
on the day of clouds and darkness.
13 I will bring them out from the peoples.
I will gather them from the countries.
I will bring them into their own land.
I will feed them on the mountains of Israel,
by the streams,
and in all the places in the land where people live.
14 I will feed them on good pasture.
Their resting place will be on the high mountains of Israel.
There they will lie down in a good resting place.
They will eat rich grass on the mountains of Israel.
15 I myself will be the shepherd of my sheep,
and I will let them lie down and rest,"
says the Lord GOD.
16 "I will search for the lost ones.
I will bring back the ones that were driven away.
I will bandage the injured ones.
I will make the sick ones strong.
But I will destroy the fat and the strong ones.
I will take care of them with justice."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Because the human shepherds have failed, God says: "I myself will be the shepherd!" And he does exactly what the bad shepherds did not do (verse 16 is the answer to verse 4).

This is like Psalm 23: "The LORD is my shepherd. I will not lack anything."

Jesus takes up this chapter: "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd gives his life for the sheep" (John 10:11). And he tells the parable of the lost sheep, which the shepherd searches for until he finds it (Luke 15:4–7). "The Son of Man came to look for the lost and to save them" (Luke 19:10).

Verse 16: "I will destroy the fat and the strong ones." This means those who became fat and strong at the cost of others (see verses 17–21).

For you this means: If you feel lost, hurt or weak, you are exactly the one God is looking for.

God judges between sheep and sheep VERSES 17–22

17 "As for you, my flock,
this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Look, I will judge between one sheep and another,
between the rams and the male goats.
18 Is it not enough for you to eat the good grass?
Must you also trample the rest of your pasture with your feet?
Is it not enough for you to drink the clear water?
Must you also make the rest muddy with your feet?
19 And my sheep must eat what you have trampled with your feet.
They must drink what you have made muddy with your feet.'
20 "So this is what the Lord GOD says to them:
'Look, I myself, yes I, will judge
between the fat sheep and the thin sheep.
21 You push with your side and your shoulder.
You butt all the weak ones with your horns,
until you have driven them away.
22 So I will save my flock,
and they will not be prey anymore.
I will judge between one sheep and another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God speaks not only to the leaders, but to the whole people. Among the "sheep" there is injustice too: The strong ones eat the best grass and drink the clear water. Then they trample the rest, so that the weak ones only get what is dirty. And they push the weak away with their horns.

This is a picture for social injustice: The rich and powerful take the best for themselves and leave only the leftovers for the poor, often leftovers that are ruined.

God takes the side of the "thin sheep," the weak and the disadvantaged.

Jesus also speaks about this in Matthew 25:31–46: The Son of Man will separate people from one another "as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats." What counts there is how people treated the weakest.

My servant David VERSES 23–24

23 I will put one shepherd over them,
and he will take care of them.
He is my servant David.
He will feed them,
and he will be their shepherd.
24 I, the LORD, will be their God,
and my servant David will be prince among them.
I, the LORD, have spoken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At this time King David had been dead for more than 400 years. What is meant is a new king from the family of David, a king who is like David, only better: a shepherd after God's own heart.

Jews are waiting for this Messiah from the house of David. Christians see the promise fulfilled in Jesus, who came

from the family of David (Matthew 1:1) and calls himself the good shepherd.

Remarkable: God is the shepherd (verse 15), and David is the shepherd (verse 23). Both belong together: Through the new David, God himself takes care of his people.

A covenant of peace VERSES 25–31

25 "'I will make a covenant of peace with them.
I will make the dangerous wild animals disappear from the land.
They will live safely in the wilderness
and sleep in the woods.
26 I will make them and the places around my hill a blessing.
I will send down the rain at the right time.
There will be showers of blessing.
27 The trees of the field will give their fruit.
The earth will give its harvest.
They will be safe in their land.
Then they will know that I am the LORD,
when I have broken the bars of their yoke
and rescued them from the hands of those who made them slaves.
28 They will not be prey for the nations anymore.
The wild animals will not eat them anymore.
They will live in safety,
and no one will make them afraid.
29 I will give them a land where plants grow well, and it will be famous.
They will not be destroyed by famine in the land anymore.
They will not have to bear the scorn of the nations anymore.
30 They will know that I, the LORD their God, am with them,
and that they, the people of Israel, are my people,
says the Lord GOD.
31 You are my sheep, the sheep of my pasture.
You are human beings,
and I am your God,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wonderful picture of peace: no more wild animals, you can even sleep safely in the woods. Rain at the right time, trees full of fruit, no fear, no hunger, no more slavery.

Verse 27: God breaks the yoke of oppression. He is a God who sets people free (see Exodus 6:6).

Verse 26: "Showers of blessing" has become a well-known phrase, also in songs.

Verse 31: A touching ending: "You are my sheep, the sheep of my pasture. You are human beings, and I am your God." The picture of the sheep is explained: God really means people, and he wants to be their God.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 35

Against Mount Seir

Hatred that never ends VERSES 1–9

1 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
2 "Son of man, turn your face against Mount Seir,
and prophesy against it.
3 Tell it,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against you, Mount Seir.
I will stretch out my hand against you.
I will make you a ruin and a horror.
4 I will destroy your cities,
and you will be a ruin.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
5 "'"Your hatred never ended.
You handed over the people of Israel to the power of the sword
at the time of their disaster,
at the time when their guilt came to its end.
6 So as surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"I will hand you over to bloodshed,
and bloodshed will chase you.
Because you did not hate bloodshed,
bloodshed will chase you.
7 So I will make Mount Seir a horror and a ruin.
I will cut off from it everyone who comes and goes.
8 I will fill its mountains with its dead.
Those killed by the sword will fall on your hills,
in your valleys, and in all your streams.
9 I will make you a ruin forever.
No one will live in your cities.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seir is the mountain country of Edom, south of the Dead Sea. The Edomites were descendants of Esau, the twin brother of Jacob (Israel). The hatred between the two peoples ran through their whole history, just as it did between the two brothers (Genesis 27).

Verse 5: When Jerusalem fell, Edom did not protect the refugees. Instead it handed them over to the enemy (see Obadiah 14).

Verse 6: "Because you did not hate bloodshed" – whoever does not reject violence will be caught up by violence himself. Violence creates new violence.

Why is this chapter here, in the middle of the words of hope? Because Chapter 36 speaks to the mountains of Israel. Here the mountains of Edom, which wanted to take over Israel's land, and there the mountains of Israel, which will become green again. The two belong together.

You wanted to take the land VERSES 10–15

10 "'"You have said,
'These two nations and these two countries will be mine,
and we will take them over.'
But the LORD was there.
11 So as surely as I live," says the Lord GOD,
"I will treat you with the same anger

and the same jealousy that you showed in your hatred
against them.
And I will make myself known among them
when I judge you.
12 You will know that I, the LORD, have heard all your
insults
that you spoke against the mountains of Israel.
You said,
'They lie in ruins.
They have been given to us to devour.'
13 You have boasted against me with your mouth.
You have spoken many words against me.
I have heard it."
14 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"While the whole earth is glad,
I will make you a ruin.
15 You were glad over the land that belonged to the people
of Israel,
because it lay in ruins.
I will do the same to you.
You will be a ruin, Mount Seir,
and all of Edom, all of it.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Edom wanted to grab the empty land of Israel and Judah ("these two nations"). But Edom had forgotten: "The LORD was there." The land belongs to God, not to whoever takes it the fastest.

Verse 13: "I have heard it." God also hears mocking and hateful words.

Verse 15: Again it is about being glad when others suffer. As you have done to others, so it will be done to you.

Important: Edom no longer exists as a people today. This chapter is no reason for hatred against people or nations in this region today.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 36

A new heart and a new spirit

You mountains of Israel, listen! VERSES 1–7

1 "You, son of man, prophesy to the mountains of Israel
and say,
'You mountains of Israel, hear the word of the LORD.
2 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"The enemy has said about you, 'Aha!'
and, 'The ancient heights are ours now!'"'
3 So prophesy and say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Yes, they have ruined you
and swallowed you up from every side,
so that you became the property of the rest of the
nations.
People gossip about you,
and they say bad things about you."
4 So, you mountains of Israel, hear the word of the Lord
GOD!
This is what the Lord GOD says
to the mountains and to the hills,
to the streams and to the valleys,
to the ruins that lie empty and to the cities that are
abandoned.
They have been robbed and mocked
by the rest of the nations all around.
5 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"In the fire of my jealous love I have spoken
against the rest of the nations and against all of Edom.
They took my land for themselves as their property,
with joy in all their hearts
and with contempt,
so that they could take it as plunder."'
6 So prophesy about the land of Israel.
Say to the mountains, the hills, the streams, and the
valleys,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I have spoken in my jealous love and in my fury,
because you have had to bear the scorn of the nations."
7 So this is what the Lord GOD says:
"I have sworn an oath:
The nations around you will surely
bear their own shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 6, Ezekiel had prophesied against the mountains of Israel, because idols were worshiped there. Now he speaks to the mountains again, but this time with a message of hope!

The enemies have mocked and grabbed the abandoned land. God says: I am on the side of my land. The mockers will be put to shame themselves.

The mountains will become green again VERSES 8–15

8 "'"But you, mountains of Israel,
you will grow your branches
and give your fruit to my people Israel,
for they will soon come home.
9 For look, I am for you.
I will turn to you,
and you will be plowed and planted.
10 I will make many people live on you,
all the people of Israel, all of them.
People will live in the cities,
and the ruins will be rebuilt.
11 I will make many people and animals live on you.
They will grow in number and have many young.
I will let people live on you as they did before.
I will do more good to you than at the beginning.
Then you will know that I am the LORD.
12 Yes, I will let people walk on you,
my people Israel.
They will own you,
and you will be their land.

You will never again take their children away from them."

13 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"People say to you,
'You are a land that eats people.
You have taken away the children of your nation.'
14 So you will not eat people anymore,
and you will not take away the children of your nation anymore,"
says the Lord GOD.
15 "I will not let you hear the scorn of the nations anymore.
You will not have to bear the insults of the peoples anymore.
You will not make your nation stumble anymore,"
says the Lord GOD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: "Look, I am for you." What a sentence after all the judgment! (See Romans 8:31: "If God is for us, who can be against us?")

The ruined land will become fruitful again. Fields will be plowed, cities will be rebuilt, people and animals will become many. God even promises: "I will do more good to you than at the beginning."

Verses 13–14: People said to the land: "You are a land that eats people." There had been so much war, hunger, and death there. God promises: This will stop.

For the sake of my holy name VERSES 16–23

16 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
17 "Son of man, when the people of Israel lived in their own land,
they made it unclean by the way they lived and by what they did.
To me, their way of life was like the uncleanness of a woman
during her monthly period.
18 So I poured out my fury on them
because of the blood they had poured out on the land,
and because they had made it unclean with their idols.
19 I scattered them among the nations,
and they were spread out through the countries.
I judged them by the way they lived and by what they did.
20 When they came to the nations where they went,
they caused my holy name to be dishonored.
For people said about them,
'These are the LORD's people,
and yet they had to leave his land.'
21 But I cared about my holy name,
which the people of Israel had caused to be dishonored among the nations where they went.
22 "So say to the people of Israel,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"I am not doing this for your sake, people of Israel.
I am doing it for the sake of my holy name,
which you have caused to be dishonored among the nations where you went.
23 I will show that my great name is holy,
the name that has been dishonored among the nations,
the name that you dishonored among them.
Then the nations will know that I am the LORD,"
says the Lord GOD,
"when I show through you that I am holy, in front of their eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Here the guilt of Israel is compared to the "uncleanness of a woman" during her period. This refers to the old rules about being clean (Leviticus 15:19–24). Important: A period is something completely natural. It is not a sin and nothing dirty. The comparison only means being unclean for worship by the rules of that time. Today people would not use a picture like this anymore.

Verse 20: The other nations saw the people in exile and mocked: "These are the LORD's people, and yet they had to leave his land." That means: Their God could not even keep them in their land. So God's name was made to look ridiculous.

Verse 22: "I am not doing this for your sake." God does not save Israel because Israel deserved it, but because God is faithful and wants to show his name, that is, who he is and his reputation, to the world. This is pure grace.

Verse 23: "I will show that my great name is holy." Jesus teaches us to pray: "May your name be kept holy" (Matthew 6:9).

A new heart VERSES 24–32

24 "'"For I will take you out from among the nations.
I will gather you from all the countries
and bring you into your own land.
25 I will sprinkle clean water on you,
and you will be clean.
I will make you clean from all your filth
and from all your idols.
26 I will also give you a new heart,
and I will put a new spirit inside you.
I will take the heart of stone out of your body
and give you a heart of flesh.
27 I will put my Spirit inside you.
I will make you follow my rules,
and you will keep my laws and do them.
28 You will live in the land that I gave to your ancestors.
You will be my people,
and I will be your God.
29 I will save you from all your uncleanness.
I will call for the grain and make it grow in plenty.
I will not bring famine on you.
30 I will make the fruit of the trees and the harvest of the fields grow in plenty,
so that you will never again have to bear the shame of famine among the nations.
31 "'"Then you will remember your evil ways
and your deeds that were not good.
You will be disgusted with yourselves
because of your sins and because of the disgusting things you did.
32 I am not doing this for your sake,"
says the Lord GOD.
"You should know that.
Be ashamed and embarrassed about your ways, people of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the whole Old Testament!

Verse 25: God makes his people clean with clean water. He washes away everything old. (Christians think of baptism here.)

Verse 26: God gives a new heart. A heart of stone is hard, cold, and does not move. A heart of flesh is alive, warm, and can feel. God changes people from the inside. What people cannot do themselves, God gives as a gift.

Verse 27: God puts his own Spirit into people. Then they keep God's commandments not because they are forced to, but because they want to from the inside.

This promise is like the "new covenant" in Jeremiah 31:31–34. Jesus says: "No one can enter God's Kingdom unless he is born of water and Spirit" (John 3:5). Christians see the fulfillment in the gift of the Holy Spirit (Acts 2). In Judaism this text is read as a promise for the renewal of Israel.

Verse 31: When people experience God's goodness, they see their own past more honestly. This means being sorry, not hating yourself.

Like the garden of Eden VERSES 33–38

33 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"On the day I make you clean from all your sins,
I will let people live in the cities again,
and the ruins will be rebuilt.
34 The land that lay in ruins will be plowed again.
It will no longer be a wasteland in the eyes of everyone
who passes by.
35 They will say,
'This land that lay in ruins
has become like the garden of Eden.
The cities that were empty, ruined, and torn down
now have strong walls, and people live in them.'
36 Then the nations that are left around you will know
that I, the LORD, have rebuilt what was torn down
and planted what was ruined.
I, the LORD, have spoken, and I will do it."
37 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Once more I will let the people of Israel ask me
to do this for them:
I will make their people as many as a flock of sheep.
38 They will be like the flocks for sacrifice,
like the flocks in Jerusalem at her festivals.
In the same way, the ruined cities will be filled with
flocks of people.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 35: The ruined land becomes "like the garden of Eden." After the judgment comes a new beginning, more beautiful than before. It is as if God creates paradise again.

Verse 37: Before, God had said that he would not let them ask him for anything (20:3). Now he says: "Once more I will let the people of Israel ask me." The relationship has been restored. Prayer is possible again.

Verse 38: At the great festivals, Jerusalem was full of people and animals for sacrifice. The empty cities will be that full again, full of life.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 37

The dry bones come to life

The valley full of bones VERSES 1–10

1 The hand of the LORD was on me.
He brought me out by the Spirit of the LORD
and set me down in the middle of the valley.
It was full of bones.
2 He led me all around among them.
Look, there were very many of them on the floor of
the valley,
and look, they were very dry.
3 He said to me,
"Son of man, can these bones live?"
I answered,
"Lord GOD, you know."
4 Again he said to me,
"Prophesy over these bones and tell them,
'You dry bones, hear the word of the LORD!
5 This is what the Lord GOD says to these bones:
"Look, I will make breath come into you,
and you will live.
6 I will put tendons on you.
I will make flesh grow on you.
I will cover you with skin.
I will put breath in you,
and you will live.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."'"
7 So I prophesied as I was commanded.
While I was prophesying, there was a noise,
and look, there was an earthquake.
Then the bones came together,
each bone to its own bone.
8 I looked, and there were tendons on them.
Flesh grew on them,
and skin covered them.
But there was no breath in them.
9 Then he said to me,
"Prophesy to the wind.
Prophesy, son of man, and tell the wind,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Come from the four winds, breath,
and breathe on these people who were killed,
so that they may live."'"
10 So I prophesied as he commanded me.
And the breath came into them,
and they came to life.
They stood up on their feet,
a very, very large army.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most famous visions in the Bible. Ezekiel stands in a valley full of bones, completely dry, so they have been dead for a long time. A picture of complete hopelessness.

Verse 3: God asks: "Can these bones live?" From a human point of view: impossible. Ezekiel answers wisely and humbly: "You know."

Verses 7–10: It happens in two steps. First the bones come together, and tendons, flesh and skin grow. But they are still dead. Then the breath comes, and they live.

An important play on words: The Hebrew word "ruach" means "breath," "wind," and "spirit" at the same time. It appears again and again in this chapter. The breath that makes the dead come alive is God's own Spirit. This is like the creation: God breathed the breath of life into the first human being (Genesis 2:7).

I will open your graves VERSES 11–14

11 Then he said to me,
"Son of man, these bones are all the people of Israel.
Look, they say,
'Our bones are dried up,
and our hope is lost.
We are completely cut off.'
12 So prophesy and tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will open your graves.
I will make you come up out of your graves, my people.
And I will bring you into the land of Israel.
13 You will know that I am the LORD
when I have opened your graves
and made you come up out of your graves, my people.
14 I will put my Spirit in you,
and you will live.
Then I will settle you in your own land.
And you will know that I, the LORD, have spoken and have done it,"
says the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here God explains the vision: The bones are the people of Israel in exile. The people say: "Our hope is lost." They feel as if they were dead. After the destruction of Jerusalem they felt as if they were in a mass grave.

God answers: "Look, I will open your graves." God can make a dead people come alive again. He brings them back into their land. Nothing is hopeless for God.

In Judaism, this text is read on the Sabbath during the Passover festival. Jews read it as a promise that Israel will be restored, and also as a sign pointing to the resurrection of the dead. After the Holocaust, many people found comfort in this text.

Christians also read it as a picture for the resurrection and for the work of the Holy Spirit, who gives life.

If you yourself feel "dried up" inside and without hope: This text says that God can give new life even there. And it is good to get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Two sticks become one VERSES 15–28

15 The word of the LORD came to me again. He said,
16 "You, son of man, take a stick
and write on it,
'For Judah, and for the people of Israel who belong with him.'
Then take another stick
and write on it,
'For Joseph, the stick of Ephraim,
and for all the people of Israel who belong with him.'
17 Then join them together into one stick,
so that they become one in your hand.
18 "The people of your nation will say to you,
'Won't you show us what you mean by this?'
19 Then tell them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will take the stick of Joseph,
which is in the hand of Ephraim,
and the tribes of Israel who belong with him.
I will put them together with the stick of Judah.
I will make them one stick,
and they will be one in my hand."'
20 The sticks you write on
must be in your hand where they can see them.
21 Say to them,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I will take the people of Israel from among the nations
where they have gone.
I will gather them from every side
and bring them into their own land.
22 I will make them one nation in the land,
on the mountains of Israel.
One king will be king over all of them.
They will no longer be two nations.
They will never again be divided into two kingdoms.
23 They will not make themselves unclean anymore
with their idols, with their disgusting images,
or with any of their sins.
I will save them from all the places where they lived
and where they sinned.
I will make them clean.
So they will be my people,
and I will be their God.
24 "'"My servant David will be king over them.
All of them will have one shepherd.
They will follow my laws
and keep my rules and do them.
25 They will live in the land
that I gave to my servant Jacob,
where your ancestors lived.
They will live there,
they and their children and their grandchildren,
forever.
And David my servant will be their prince forever.
26 I will make a covenant of peace with them.
It will be a covenant that lasts forever.
I will settle them and make them many.
I will put my sanctuary among them forever.
27 My tent will also be with them.
I will be their God,
and they will be my people.
28 Then the nations will know that I am the LORD,
who makes Israel holy,
when my sanctuary is among them forever."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the death of King Solomon, the people were divided into two kingdoms: the northern kingdom of Israel (often

called "Ephraim" or "Joseph") and the southern kingdom of Judah (1 Kings 12). This split lasted for hundreds of years, with much fighting and even wars.

Ezekiel takes two sticks and holds them in his hand so that they look like one. God promises: I will make the separated parts into one people again.

Verses 24–25: Again it speaks of "my servant David," the coming king from the family of David (see 34:23–24).

Verses 26–27: A covenant of peace that lasts forever, and God lives in the middle of his people. "My tent will also be with them" means: God will live among them. The Hebrew word here means a "tent," like God's tent in the wilderness. In the New Testament it says: "The Word became flesh and lived among us" (John 1:14). In Greek it says there, word for word: He "pitched his tent" among us. And at the end of the Bible: "Look! God's home is with people. He will live with them. They will be his people" (Revelation 21:3).

We know the longing for unity today too: between nations, churches, families. God can join together what is broken.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 38

Gog of the land of Magog

Gog and his armies VERSES 1–9

1 The word of the LORD came to me. He said,
2 "Son of man, turn your face toward Gog of the land of Magog,
the prince of Rosh, Meshech, and Tubal.
Prophesy against him.
3 Say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against you, Gog,
prince of Rosh, Meshech, and Tubal.
4 I will turn you around
and put hooks into your jaws.
I will lead you out with your whole army,
horses and horsemen,
all of them in full armor,
a great crowd with large and small shields,
all of them holding swords.
5 Persia, Cush, and Put are with them,
all of them with shields and helmets.
6 Gomer and all his troops are there,
the house of Togarmah from the far north
and all his troops,
many peoples with you.
7 "'"Be ready, yes, get yourself ready,
you and all the troops gathered around you,
and be their commander.
8 After many days you will be called up.
In the years to come you will come into a land
that has recovered from the sword.
Its people were gathered from many peoples
to the mountains of Israel,
which had lain in ruins for a long time.
They were brought out from the peoples,
and all of them live in safety.
9 You will go up.
You will come like a storm.
You will be like a cloud that covers the land,
you and all your troops,
and many peoples with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 38–39 are very different from the rest of the book. In huge, almost unreal pictures they describe one last great attack on Israel, after the people have come back and are living in peace.

Who is "Gog of the land of Magog"? We do not know for sure. Maybe the name is like that of a king Gyges of Lydia (in today's Turkey). It is more likely that Gog is a symbolic figure: the essence of all enemies of God and his people, who come from the far-off, frightening north.

"Rosh" (verse 2): The WEB says "prince of Rosh." The Hebrew word "rosh" simply means "head" or "chief." So many translations write "chief prince of Meshech and Tubal." Some people have said that "Rosh" means "Russia." But there is no basis in language or history for this.

The peoples who are named come from all directions: Meshech, Tubal, Gomer and Togarmah from the north (Asia Minor), Persia from the east, Cush (the area south of Egypt) and Put (Libya) from the south. This shows: The whole world seems to stand against God's people.

Verse 4: "Hooks into your jaws" – Gog thinks he is acting by his own will. But really God leads him like an animal on a hook.

Gog's evil plan VERSES 10–16

10 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"On that day thoughts will come into your mind,
and you will make an evil plan.
11 You will say,
'I will go up against the land of villages without walls.
I will attack the people who are at peace,
who live in safety,
all of them living without walls,
without bars or gates.
12 I will take plunder and rob them.
I will turn my hand against the ruins where people live again,
and against the people who were gathered from the nations.
They have gotten livestock and goods,
and they live in the center of the earth.'
13 Sheba, Dedan, and the traders of Tarshish
with all its young lions will ask you,
'Have you come to take plunder?
Have you gathered your troops to rob,
to carry away silver and gold,
to take away livestock and goods,
to take a great amount of plunder?'"'
14 "So, son of man, prophesy and tell Gog,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"On that day, when my people Israel live in safety,
won't you notice it?

15 You will come from your place
in the far north,
you and many peoples with you,
all of them riding on horses,
a great crowd and a mighty army.
16 You will come up against my people Israel
like a cloud that covers the land.
In the last days
I will bring you against my land,
so that the nations may know me,
when I show through you, Gog, that I am holy, in
front of their eyes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gog plans to attack a peaceful people who live without walls, only to rob them. This is pure greed and violence against people who cannot defend themselves.

Verse 12: The people live "in the center of the earth" (word for word: at the "navel of the earth"). Jerusalem was seen as the center of the world.

Verse 13: The trading nations ask, mocking or curious: "Have you come to take plunder?" Maybe they want to make money from it themselves.

Verse 16: "In the last days" – that is why many people have applied these chapters to the end of time.

God steps in VERSES 17–23

17 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Are you the one I spoke about long ago
through my servants, the prophets of Israel?
In those days they prophesied for years
that I would bring you against them.
18 On that day, when Gog comes against the land of
Israel,"
says the Lord GOD,
"my anger will rise up in my nostrils.
19 For I have spoken in my jealous love and in the fire of
my anger.
On that day there will surely be a great earthquake in
the land of Israel.
20 The fish of the sea, the birds of the sky,
the animals of the field,
every creature that crawls on the ground,
and all the people on the face of the earth
will shake because I am there.
The mountains will be thrown down.
The steep cliffs will fall.
Every wall will fall to the ground.
21 I will call for a sword against him on all my
mountains,"
says the Lord GOD.
"Every man's sword will be against his brother.
22 I will judge him
with deadly disease and with bloodshed.
I will rain down on him,
on his troops, and on the many peoples who are with
him,
pouring rain and huge hailstones,
fire and sulfur.
23 I will show how great and how holy I am.
I will make myself known in the eyes of many nations.
Then they will know that I am the LORD."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When Gog attacks, it is not Israel that fights, but God himself. He sends an earthquake, rain, hail, fire and sulfur. And the enemies kill one another (verse 21).

The pictures are like the great flood, like Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24), and like the plagues in Egypt. God is more powerful than all the armies of the world.

How do we read these chapters?

– In Judaism, the "war of Gog and Magog" is often connected with the time before the coming of the Messiah.

– In Revelation, "Gog and Magog" appear as a picture for the last enemies of God (Revelation 20:8).

– Again and again, people have tried to say that Gog is a certain country or ruler of their own time. These guesses have always turned out to be wrong, and sometimes they have stirred up fear and hatred. The Bible itself gives no date and names no country of today.

– The real message is a comfort: No matter how powerful the enemies are, God protects his people, and in the end God wins.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 39

Gog's end and God's Spirit

Gog falls on the mountains of Israel VERSES 1–8

1 "You, son of man, prophesy against Gog and say,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Look, I am against you, Gog,
prince of Rosh, Meshech, and Tubal.
2 I will turn you around.
I will lead you on.
I will make you come up from the far north.
And I will bring you onto the mountains of Israel.
3 I will knock your bow out of your left hand.
I will make your arrows fall out of your right hand.
4 You will fall on the mountains of Israel,
you and all your troops and the peoples who are with
you.
I will give you as food to all kinds of birds of prey
and to the wild animals.
5 You will fall on the open field,
for I have spoken,"
says the Lord GOD.
6 "I will send fire on Magog
and on those who live in safety on the islands.
Then they will know that I am the LORD.
7 "'"I will make my holy name known
among my people Israel.
I will not let my holy name be dishonored anymore.
Then the nations will know that I am the LORD,
the Holy One in Israel.

8 Look, it is coming, and it will happen,"
says the Lord GOD.
"This is the day I have spoken about.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gog is defeated without Israel having to fight. God himself knocks the weapons out of his hands.

Verse 7: The goal of everything: God's holy name is to be made known. All nations are to know who God is.

The weapons burn for seven years VERSES 9–10

9 "'"The people who live in the cities of Israel will go out.
They will make fires with the weapons and burn them,
the small and large shields,
the bows and the arrows,
the war clubs and the spears.
They will make fires with them for seven years.
10 They will not need to take any wood from the field
or cut down any in the forests,
because they will make fires with the weapons.
They will rob those who robbed them,
and take plunder from those who plundered them,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A powerful picture: There are so many weapons that people can use them to heat their homes for seven years. The weapons are no longer needed. They are burned.

This is like Isaiah 2:4: "They will beat their swords into plowshares." And like Psalm 46:9 (in some Bibles 46:10): "He breaks the bow and smashes the spear. He burns the chariots in the fire."

The hope of the Bible is a world without weapons and without war.

The burial in the valley of Hamon Gog VERSES 11–16

11 "On that day I will give Gog a burial place in Israel,
the valley of the travelers, east of the sea.
It will block the way of the travelers.
There they will bury Gog and all his crowd of people.
They will call it 'The valley of Hamon Gog.'
12 "'"The people of Israel will spend seven months
burying them,
to make the land clean.
13 Yes, all the people of the land will bury them.
And they will become famous for it
on the day I show my glory,"
says the Lord GOD.
14 "They will choose men whose full-time job
is to go through the land.
These men will go with those who bury the bodies
that are still lying on the ground,
to make the land clean.
After the seven months are over, they will search.
15 The searchers will go through the land.
When one of them sees a human bone,
he will put up a sign next to it,
until the gravediggers have buried it in the valley of
Hamon Gog.
16 A city will also be called Hamonah.
This is how they will make the land clean."'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Hamon Gog" means "crowd of Gog." There are so many dead that it takes seven months to bury them all.

By the rules about being clean, a dead body made the land unclean (Numbers 19:11–16). So all the bones must be found and buried.

Remarkable: The enemies are buried too. They get a grave. The dignity of the dead is respected, even that of enemies.

In the Bible, the number seven (seven years, seven months) often stands for completeness.

The great sacrifice meal VERSES 17–20

17 "You, son of man,
this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Speak to all kinds of birds
and to all the wild animals.
Say, "Gather together and come!
Gather from every side
to my sacrifice that I am killing for you,
a great sacrifice on the mountains of Israel.
There you may eat meat and drink blood.
18 You will eat the flesh of mighty warriors
and drink the blood of the princes of the earth,
as if they were rams, lambs, and goats,
and bulls, all of them fattened animals from Bashan.
19 You will eat fat until you are full
and drink blood until you are drunk,
at my sacrifice that I have killed for you.
20 At my table you will be filled
with horses and chariot drivers,
with mighty warriors and with all soldiers,"
says the Lord GOD.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A horrifying picture: The birds and wild animals are invited to a "sacrifice meal," and the "sacrifice" is the fallen warriors. The rams, lambs, goats, and bulls in verse 18 are a picture for the leaders and the soldiers.

The picture is cruel on purpose. It shows the complete end of the enemy's power. Revelation takes up this picture (Revelation 19:17–18).

Pictures like this describe God's judgment on tyrants. They are not joy over people's death, and they do not give permission for violence.

God will not hide his face anymore VERSES 21–29

21 "I will show my glory among the nations.
Then all the nations will see the judgment I have
carried out,
and my hand that I have laid on them.
22 So the people of Israel will know that I am the LORD
their God,
from that day on.
23 The nations will know
that the people of Israel went into captivity because of
their guilt.
They were unfaithful to me,
so I hid my face from them.
I handed them over to their enemies,
and all of them died by the sword.
24 I treated them as their uncleanness and their sins
deserved.

I hid my face from them.
25 "So this is what the Lord GOD says:
'Now I will bring Jacob's people back from captivity
and have mercy on all the people of Israel.
I will be jealous for my holy name.
26 They will forget their shame
and all the ways they were unfaithful to me,
when they live in safety in their land,
and no one makes them afraid.
27 That will be when I have brought them back from the peoples,
gathered them out of the lands of their enemies,
and shown through them that I am holy
in the eyes of many nations.
28 They will know that I am the LORD their God,
because I sent them into captivity among the nations,
and I have gathered them back into their own land.
I will not leave any of them behind as captives
anymore.
29 I will not hide my face from them anymore,
for I have poured out my Spirit on the people of Israel,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of this dark section there is a wonderful promise.

Verses 23–24: The nations are to understand: Israel did not go into exile because its God was weak, but because God had hidden his face, because the people were unfaithful.

Verse 25: "Now I will bring Jacob's people back from captivity and have mercy on all the people of Israel." God turns their fate around.

Verse 29: "I will not hide my face from them anymore, for I have poured out my Spirit on the people of Israel." God will stay close. This is like Joel, where God promises to pour out his Spirit on all people (Joel 2:28; in some Bibles 3:1). Christians see this fulfilled at Pentecost (Acts 2:17).

"God's face" is a picture for his attention and his closeness. The blessing of Aaron says: "The LORD make his face shine on you" (Numbers 6:25).

EZEKIEL

Chapter 40

The vision of the new temple

The man with the measuring rod VERSES 1–4

1 It was in the twenty-fifth year of our captivity,
at the beginning of the year, on the tenth day of the month,
in the fourteenth year after the city was conquered.
On that very day
the hand of the LORD was on me,
and he brought me there.
2 In visions from God he brought me into the land of Israel.
He set me down on a very high mountain.
On it, to the south, was something like the buildings of a city.
3 He brought me there.
Look, there was a man
who looked like bronze.
He had a cord made of flax in his hand
and a measuring rod.
He was standing in the gateway.
4 The man said to me,
"Son of man, look with your eyes,
listen with your ears,
and pay close attention to everything I will show you.
For you have been brought here
so that I can show it to you.
Tell the people of Israel everything you see."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the last great part of the book begins (Chapters 40–48): the vision of a new temple and a new land.

Verse 1: This is in the year 573 BC, 25 years after Ezekiel was taken away, and 14 years after Jerusalem was destroyed. The old temple lies in ruins.

Verses 2–3: Again in a vision, Ezekiel is brought to Israel. A heavenly man "who looked like bronze" has a measuring cord and a measuring rod. He will measure the whole new temple exactly.

Why so many measurements? For the people in exile this was a message: The temple will not only be a dream. God has an exact plan. There is a future.

A note: The following chapters contain very many measurements and descriptions of buildings. They are not easy to read, and some details are hard to understand even for experts. You do not have to understand every detail to grasp the message: God wants to live among his people again.

The east gate VERSES 5–16

5 Look, there was a wall all around the outside of the temple area.
In the man's hand was a measuring rod six cubits long.
Each of these cubits was a normal cubit plus a hand width.
So the rod was about 10½ feet long.
He measured the wall.
It was one rod thick and one rod high.
6 Then he came to the gate that faces east
and went up its steps.
He measured the threshold of the gate. It was one rod deep.
The other threshold was one rod deep too.
7 Each guard room was one rod long and one rod wide.
Between the guard rooms the wall was about 9 feet thick.
The threshold of the gate next to the porch of the gate, on the side toward the temple, was one rod.
8 He also measured the porch of the gate toward the temple. It was one rod.
9 Then he measured the porch of the gate. It was about 14 feet.
Its posts were about 3½ feet thick.

The porch of the gate was on the side toward the temple.
10 There were three side rooms on each side of the east gate.
All three had the same size.
The posts on each side also had the same size.
11 He measured the width of the opening of the gate. It was about 17½ feet.
The length of the gateway was about 23 feet.
12 In front of the guard rooms was a border,
about 21 inches on each side.
The side rooms were about 10½ feet on each side.
13 He measured the gateway from the roof of one side room
to the roof of the other.
It was about 44 feet wide, from one door to the door across from it.
14 He also measured the posts. They were about 105 feet.
The courtyard reached to the posts all around the gate.
15 From the front of the gate at the entrance
to the front of the inner porch of the gate
was about 88 feet.
16 There were narrow windows with frames that could not be opened
in the side rooms and in their posts inside the gateway, all around,
and also in the arches.
There were windows all around facing inward.
Palm trees were carved on each post.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A cubit is the length from the elbow to the tip of the finger, about 18 inches. The "long cubit" used here (a cubit and a hand width) is about 21 inches long. The measuring rod is six of these cubits long, so about 10½ feet. In the text we have changed the measurements into feet.

The east gate is a large gate building with three guard rooms on each side, like old city gates in Israel (for example at Megiddo, Hazor and Gezer). It is about 88 feet long and 44 feet wide.

The palm trees (verse 16) were a sign of life, fruitfulness and victory. Solomon's temple already had decorations of palm trees (1 Kings 6:29).

The east gate is especially important: God's glory had left the temple through this gate (Chapters 10–11). And it will come back through this gate (Chapter 43).

The outer courtyard and the other gates VERSES 17–27

17 Then he brought me into the outer courtyard.
Look, there were rooms there,
and a stone pavement had been made all around the courtyard.
30 rooms faced the pavement.
18 The pavement ran along the side of the gates.
It was as long as the gates were deep.
This was the lower pavement.
19 Then he measured the distance
from the front of the lower gate
to the front of the inner courtyard on the outside.
It was about 175 feet, both on the east side and on the north side.
20 He measured the length and the width of the gate of the outer courtyard
that faces north.
21 It had three guard rooms on each side.
Its posts and its arches had the same measurements as the first gate.
It was about 88 feet long
and about 44 feet wide.
22 Its windows, its arches, and its palm trees
had the same measurements as the gate that faces east.
People went up to it by seven steps.
Its arches were in front of them.
23 There was a gate to the inner courtyard
across from the north gate, just as on the east side.
He measured from gate to gate. It was about 175 feet.
24 He led me toward the south.
Look, there was a gate facing south.
He measured its posts and its arches.
They had the same measurements as the others.
25 There were windows all around in it and in its arches,
like the other windows.
It was about 88 feet long
and about 44 feet wide.
26 Seven steps led up to it,
and its arches were in front of them.
It had palm trees on its posts,
one on each side.
27 There was a gate to the inner courtyard facing south.
He measured from gate to gate toward the south. It was about 175 feet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The outer courtyard has three gates that are the same: in the east, in the north, and in the south. There is no gate in the west. That is where the temple building itself stands.

Seven steps lead up to the outer gates. So the temple is on higher ground. Whoever comes to God goes up.

The 30 rooms along the edge were probably for the people's sacrifice meals.

The many measurements that are the same show order, harmony and perfection.

The gates of the inner courtyard VERSES 28–37

28 Then he brought me into the inner courtyard through the south gate.
He measured the south gate.
It had the same measurements as the others,
29 with its guard rooms, its posts, and its arches.
There were windows all around in it and in its arches.
It was about 88 feet long and about 44 feet wide.
30 There were arches all around,
about 44 feet long and about 9 feet wide.
31 Its arches faced the outer courtyard.
Palm trees were carved on its posts.
The stairway up to it had eight steps.
32 He brought me into the inner courtyard on the east side.
He measured the gate.
It had the same measurements as the others,
33 with its guard rooms, its posts, and its arches.
There were windows all around in it and in its arches.
It was about 88 feet long and about 44 feet wide.

34 Its arches faced the outer courtyard.
Palm trees were carved on its posts on each side.
The stairway up to it had eight steps.
35 He brought me to the north gate.
He measured it, and it had the same measurements:
36 its guard rooms, its posts, and its arches.
There were windows all around in it.
It was about 88 feet long and about 44 feet wide.
37 Its posts faced the outer courtyard.
Palm trees were carved on its posts on each side.
The stairway up to it had eight steps.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The inner courtyard also has three gates, exactly across from the outer gates and just as big.

Eight steps lead up to the inner gates, so they are even higher than the outer gates (seven steps). The closer you come to the holy place, the higher you go. Up to the temple building there are even more steps (40:49).

The tables for the sacrifices and the rooms for the priests VERSES 38–47

38 There was a room with a door by the posts of the gates.
There they washed the burnt offering.
A burnt offering is an animal that was completely burned on the altar for God.
39 In the porch of the gate there were two tables on each side.
On them they killed the animals for the burnt offering,
the sin offering, and the guilt offering.
40 Outside, on one side,
as you go up to the entrance of the north gate,
there were two tables.
On the other side, by the porch of the gate,
there were two tables.
41 So there were four tables on one side
and four tables on the other side
by the side of the gate:
eight tables on which they killed the animals for the sacrifices.
42 For the burnt offering there were four tables of cut stone.
They were about 2½ feet long,
about 2½ feet wide,
and about 21 inches high.
On them they laid the tools
they used to kill the animals for the burnt offering and the other sacrifices.
43 Hooks about 3 inches long were fastened all around on the inside.
The meat of the offerings was put on the tables.
44 Outside the inner gate, in the inner courtyard, there were rooms for the singers.
One was at the side of the north gate.
It faced south.
Another was at the side of the east gate and faced north.
45 He said to me,
"This room that faces south
is for the priests who take care of the temple.
46 The room that faces north
is for the priests who take care of the altar.
They are the sons of Zadok.
Of all the descendants of Levi, only they may come near to the LORD
to serve him."
47 He measured the courtyard.
It was about 175 feet long and about 175 feet wide. It was a square.
The altar stood in front of the temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here it describes where the sacrifices were prepared: rooms for washing, tables for killing the animals, hooks for hanging them up.

Verse 44: There are also rooms for the singers. Music and singing were part of the worship in the temple (see 1 Chronicles 25).

Verse 46: Zadok was the high priest at the time of David and Solomon (1 Kings 1:32–39). Only his descendants are to serve at the altar. Ezekiel explains this in more detail in Chapter 44.

Verse 47: The inner courtyard is a perfect square. In its middle stands the altar. The altar is the center of the whole area.

The porch of the temple building VERSES 48–49

48 Then he brought me to the porch of the temple.
He measured each post of the porch.
They were about 9 feet thick on each side.
The width of the gateway was about 5 feet on each side.
49 The porch was about 35 feet long
and about 19 feet wide.
People went up to it by steps.
There were pillars by the posts,
one on each side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Ezekiel comes to the temple building itself. First the porch with two pillars. This is like the two famous pillars "Jachin" and "Boaz" in front of Solomon's temple (1 Kings 7:15–22).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 41

The temple building

The holy place and the most holy place VERSES 1–4

1 He brought me into the main hall
and measured the posts.
They were about 10½ feet wide on one side
and about 10½ feet wide on the other side.
That was the width of the tent.
2 The entrance was about 17½ feet wide.
The walls on the sides of the entrance were about 9 feet on one side

and about 9 feet on the other side.
He measured the length of the hall. It was about 70 feet.
It was about 35 feet wide.
3 Then he went further in.
He measured each post of the entrance. It was about 3½ feet.
The entrance was about 10½ feet,
and the width of the entrance was about 12 feet.
4 He measured the room beyond the main hall.
It was about 35 feet long
and about 35 feet wide.
He said to me,
"This is the most holy place."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple building has three parts, like Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6): the porch, the main hall ("the holy place"), and at the very back the most holy place.

The main hall is 40 cubits long and 20 cubits wide (about 70 by 35 feet).

Verses 3–4: Only the heavenly man goes into the most holy place. Ezekiel stays outside, even though he is a priest. The most holy place is a perfect square of 20 by 20 cubits. It is the holiest place, where God himself is present.

Verse 1: "The width of the tent" is a reminder of the holy tent in the wilderness, the model for all the later temples.

The side rooms and the building in the west VERSES 5–15

5 Then he measured the wall of the temple. It was about 10½ feet thick.
Each side room was about 7 feet wide.
The side rooms went all around the temple on every side.
6 The side rooms were on three floors, one above the other,
30 on each floor.
They rested on ledges in the wall that belonged to the temple
for the side rooms all around.
So they were supported
and did not have to go into the wall of the temple.
7 The side rooms were wider on the higher floors,
because the walls were thinner on the higher floors.
So the building became wider toward the top.
People went up from the lowest floor
through the middle floor to the highest floor.
8 I also saw that the temple had a raised platform all around.
The foundations of the side rooms were one full rod high,
six long cubits, about 10½ feet.
9 The outer wall of the side rooms was about 9 feet thick.
The space that was left was the place of the side rooms that belonged to the temple.
10 Between the rooms there was an open space
about 35 feet wide all around the temple on every side.
11 The doors of the side rooms opened toward an open area that was left free.
One door faced north,
and another door faced south.
The open area was about 9 feet wide all around.
12 On the west side, facing the separate yard,
there was a building.
It was about 123 feet wide.
Its wall was about 9 feet thick all around,
and it was about 158 feet long.
13 Then he measured the temple. It was about 175 feet long.
The separate yard and the building with its walls were also about 175 feet long.
14 The width of the front of the temple
and of the separate yard on the east side
was also about 175 feet.
15 He measured the length of the building facing the separate yard
at the back of the temple,
with its galleries on each side.
It was about 175 feet.
He also measured the inner temple
and the porches of the courtyard,

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Around the temple building, on three floors, there are 30 side rooms on each floor, so 90 rooms. They were probably storerooms for temple objects and gifts. Solomon's temple also had buildings like this along its sides (1 Kings 6:5–10).

Verse 6: The beams of the rooms were not to go into the holy temple wall. The wall became thinner step by step toward the top, and the beams rested on the steps. So the temple wall stayed undamaged.

Verse 12: Behind the temple, in the west, stands a large building. It does not say what it was used for.

Verses 13–15: Everything is exactly 100 cubits long and wide (about 175 feet). The numbers show: The temple is perfectly balanced and harmonious.

The decoration of the temple VERSES 16–26

16 the thresholds, the narrow windows,
and the galleries around them on their three floors.
Across from the threshold
the walls were covered with wood all around,
from the floor up to the windows.
The windows were covered.
17 This went up to the space above the door,
to the inner room and outside,
and on the whole wall all around, inside and outside.
Everything was measured.
18 The walls were decorated with cherubim and palm trees.
Cherubim are powerful heavenly beings.
A palm tree was between each cherub and the next.
Each cherub had two faces.
19 The face of a man looked toward the palm tree on one side,
and the face of a young lion looked toward the palm tree on the other side.
It was made like this all around the whole temple.
20 From the floor to above the door
there were cherubim and palm trees.
That is how the wall of the main hall looked.
21 The doorposts of the main hall were square.
The front of the holy place
looked the same as the main hall.

22 There was an altar made of wood.
It was about 5 feet high and about 3½ feet long.
Its corners, its base, and its sides were made of wood.
He said to me,
"This is the table that stands before the LORD."
23 The main hall and the holy place each had a double door.
24 Each door had two parts,
two parts that could swing open:
two for one door
and two parts for the other.
25 On the doors of the main hall
there were cherubim and palm trees,
like the ones on the walls.
There was a wooden threshold in front of the porch outside.
26 There were narrow windows and palm trees
on each side,
on the side walls of the porch.

This is how the side rooms of the temple and the thresholds were arranged.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: These verses are very hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: The walls inside were covered with wood all around, from the floor to above the windows.

Verses 18–20: The walls are decorated with cherubim and palm trees. Here the cherubim have two faces (a man and a lion). Palm trees and cherubim are a reminder of the garden of Eden, where cherubim guarded the way to the tree of life (Genesis 3:24). The temple is like a new paradise, a place where God and people meet.

Verse 22: In the main hall stands a table made of wood, "the table that stands before the LORD." This is probably the table for the bread of the presence (see Exodus 25:23–30). This was bread that lay before God as a sign of fellowship with him.

Interesting: Many objects from the old temple, like the great lampstand or the ark of the covenant, are not mentioned here.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 42

The holy rooms and the wall

The rooms in the north VERSES 1–9

1 Then he led me out into the outer courtyard,
on the way toward the north.
He brought me to the building with rooms
that was across from the separate yard
and across from the building on the north side.
2 The building was about 175 feet long,
with its door facing north.
It was about 88 feet wide.
3 It stood across from the open space of about 35 feet
that belonged to the inner courtyard,
and across from the pavement of the outer courtyard.
Gallery faced gallery on all three floors.
4 In front of the rooms was a walkway on the inside.
It was about 17½ feet wide,
with a path about 21 inches wide.
Their doors faced north.
5 The upper rooms were narrower,
because the galleries took more space away from them
than from the lower and middle rooms of the building.
6 For the rooms were on three floors,
and they did not have pillars like the pillars of the courtyards.
So the top floor was set back more
than the lowest and the middle floor.
7 There was an outer wall alongside the rooms,
toward the outer courtyard, in front of the rooms.
It was about 88 feet long.
8 For the rooms on the side of the outer courtyard
were about 88 feet long.
Look, the rooms facing the temple
were about 175 feet long.
9 Below these rooms was the entrance on the east side,
where people go into them from the outer courtyard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Next to the temple there are large buildings with rooms on three floors. The floors are set back step by step toward the top (like terraces).

The exact measurements and the layout are hard to follow even for experts. What is important is what the rooms are used for. That is explained in verses 13–14.

The rooms in the south VERSES 10–12

10 In the thickness of the wall of the courtyard toward the east,
in front of the separate yard and in front of the building,
there were rooms.
11 The walkway in front of them looked like the one
in front of the rooms on the north side.
They had the same length and the same width.
All their exits had the same layout and the same doors.
12 Like the doors of the rooms on the south side,
there was a door at the beginning of the walkway,
the walkway right in front of the wall toward the east,
where people go into them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the south side there are the same rooms as on the north side. Again it is clear: The whole temple is built in a balanced and even way.

What the holy rooms are for VERSES 13–14

13 Then he said to me,
"The north rooms and the south rooms,
which are across from the separate yard,
are the holy rooms.
There the priests who come near to the LORD

are to eat the most holy offerings.
There they are to put the most holy offerings:
the grain offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering.
For the place is holy.
14 When the priests go in,
they must not go out of the holy place into the outer courtyard
until they have taken off the clothes
they wear when they serve there.
For these clothes are holy.
They must put on other clothes
before they go near the places that are for the people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In these rooms the priests eat their share of the sacrifices (see Leviticus 6:16, 26; in some Bibles 6:9, 19). They also keep the holy gifts there.

Verse 14: The priests wear special clothes in the sanctuary. Before they go out to the people, they must change their clothes. This makes a clear difference between what is holy and what is ordinary.

The wall around the temple VERSES 15–20

15 When he had finished measuring the inner temple area,
he led me out through the gate that faces east.
He measured the area all around.
16 He measured the east side with the measuring rod.
It was 500 rods (about 5,250 feet) by the measuring rod.
17 He measured the north side.
It was 500 rods by the measuring rod.
18 He measured the south side.
It was 500 rods by the measuring rod.
19 He turned to the west side
and measured 500 rods by the measuring rod.
20 So he measured the area on all four sides.
It had a wall all around it.
It was 500 cubits (about 875 feet) long
and 500 cubits wide.
The wall separated what is holy from what is ordinary.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, the whole temple area is measured: a large square with a wall all around.

Verses 16–20: In verses 16–19 the WEB says "five hundred reeds," but in verse 20 "five hundred cubits." That is a big difference (500 rods would be about a mile, 500 cubits about 875 feet). The Greek translation (the Septuagint) has "cubits" everywhere, and that also fits the other measurements of the temple. So many Bible teachers think that 500 cubits is right.

Verse 20: The purpose of the wall: to separate what is holy from what is ordinary. God's holiness is to be protected and respected. This was very important to Ezekiel, because the old temple had been made unholy by the worship of idols (Chapter 8).

Jews and Christians read this vision of the temple in different ways: Some Jews expect that such a temple will be built one day. Many Christians understand it more as a picture: God lives among people in Christ and in his church (see John 2:19–21; 1 Corinthians 3:16; Revelation 21–22).

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 43

The glory comes back

God's glory fills the temple VERSES 1–5

1 After that he brought me to the gate,
the gate that faces east.
2 Look, the glory of the God of Israel was coming from the east.
His voice was like the roar of many waters,
and the earth shone with his glory.
3 What I saw looked like the vision I had seen before,
like the vision I saw when I came to destroy the city.
And the visions were like the vision
I had seen by the river Chebar.
I fell on my face.
4 The glory of the LORD came into the temple
through the gate that faces east.
5 The Spirit lifted me up
and brought me into the inner courtyard.
Look, the glory of the LORD filled the temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point of the whole book!

In Chapters 10–11, Ezekiel had seen God's glory leave the temple through the east gate and go to the Mount of Olives in the east. Now it comes back the same way: from the east, through the east gate, into the temple.

Verse 2: "Like the roar of many waters" – the same picture as in Ezekiel 1:24. Revelation describes the risen Christ with these words (Revelation 1:15).

Verse 3: "When I came to destroy the city" means: when I announced that the city would be destroyed (Chapters 8–11).

Verse 5: God's glory fills the temple, as it did long ago when the tent of meeting was dedicated (Exodus 40:34) and when Solomon's temple was dedicated (1 Kings 8:10–11). God is back. He lives with his people again.

The place of my throne VERSES 6–12

6 I heard someone speaking to me from inside the temple,
while a man stood beside me.
7 He said to me,
"Son of man, this is the place of my throne
and the place for the soles of my feet.
Here I will live forever among the people of Israel.
The people of Israel will never again make my holy name unclean,
neither they nor their kings,
by their unfaithfulness
and by the dead bodies of their kings at their shrines.
8 They put their threshold next to my threshold
and their doorpost next to my doorpost.

Only a wall was between me and them.
They made my holy name unclean
by the disgusting things they did.
So I destroyed them in my anger.
9 Now let them put away their unfaithfulness
and the dead bodies of their kings far from me.
Then I will live among them forever.
10 "You, son of man, show the temple to the people of Israel,
so that they will be ashamed of their sins.
Let them measure the plan.
11 If they are ashamed of everything they have done,
then show them the design of the temple,
its layout, its exits, its entrances,
its whole structure, all its rules,
all its designs, and all its laws.
Write it down where they can see it,
so that they keep its whole design
and all its rules and do them.
12 "This is the law of the temple:
All the area around it
on the top of the mountain will be most holy.
Look, this is the law of the temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: God wants to live here, "forever among the people of Israel." The temple is God's throne and the footstool for his feet on earth.

Verses 7–8: In old Jerusalem, the king's palace was right next to the temple. Only a wall separated them. The kings made the temple unholy with their idols, and maybe also with graves or monuments for dead kings. In the new temple this will not happen anymore.

Verses 10–11: When the people see the beautiful plan of the new temple, they are to realize how far they had moved away from God. God's kindness leads people to turn back (see Romans 2:4).

Verse 12: The "law of the temple" is very simple: Everything is holy.

The altar VERSES 13–17

13 "These are the measurements of the altar in long cubits.
Each of these cubits is a normal cubit plus a hand width.
The gutter at the bottom is to be about 21 inches deep and about 21 inches wide.
The rim around its edge is to be about 10 inches.
This is to be the base of the altar.
14 From the gutter on the ground up to the lower ledge, it is to be about 3½ feet high,
and the ledge about 21 inches wide.
From the smaller ledge up to the larger ledge, it is to be about 7 feet high,
and the ledge about 21 inches wide.
15 The top part of the altar is to be about 7 feet high.
From the hearth of the altar four horns are to stick up.
16 The hearth of the altar is to be about 21 feet long and about 21 feet wide.
It is to be a square with four equal sides.
17 The ledge is to be about 24½ feet long and about 24½ feet wide,
square on its four sides.
The rim around it is to be about 10½ inches,
and the gutter around it about 21 inches.
Its steps are to face east."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The altar is built like a tower with steps, with several ledges one above the other. At the very top is the hearth, the place where the fire burns, 12 by 12 cubits (about 21 by 21 feet), with four "horns" at the corners. A long cubit is about 21 inches.

The horns of the altar were especially holy. Whoever needed protection could hold on to them (1 Kings 1:50).

All together the altar is about 11 cubits high, more than 19 feet.

The dedication of the altar VERSES 18–27

18 He said to me,
"Son of man, this is what the Lord GOD says:
'These are the rules for the altar
on the day it is built,
so that burnt offerings can be offered on it
and blood can be sprinkled on it.
19 You must give a young bull as a sin offering
to the priests from the tribe of Levi
who are descendants of Zadok
and who come near to me to serve me,'
says the Lord GOD.
20 'You must take some of its blood
and put it on the four horns of the altar,
on the four corners of the ledge,
and on the rim all around.
That is how you will make it clean and make atonement for it.
21 You must also take the bull for the sin offering.
It must be burned at the place chosen for it in the temple area,
outside the sanctuary.
22 "'On the second day you must offer a male goat without any defect
as a sin offering.
The priests must make the altar clean,
as they made it clean with the bull.
23 When you have finished making it clean,
you must offer a young bull without any defect
and a ram from the flock without any defect.
24 You must bring them before the LORD.
The priests must throw salt on them
and offer them up to the LORD as a burnt offering.
25 "'For seven days you must prepare a goat every day as a sin offering.
They must also prepare a young bull and a ram from the flock,
without any defect.
26 For seven days they must make atonement for the altar
and make it clean.
That is how they will set it apart for God.
27 When these days are over,
from the eighth day on,
the priests will offer your burnt offerings
and your peace offerings on the altar.
Then I will accept you,'
says the Lord GOD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the altar may be used, it is made clean and set apart for God for seven days. This is like the dedication of the first altar by Moses (Exodus 29:36–37).

Verse 20: To make atonement means to take away guilt so that things are right with God again.

Verse 24: The salt was a sign of the lasting covenant between God and his people (see Leviticus 2:13: "the salt of the covenant").

Verse 27: At the end comes the goal: "Then I will accept you." It is not about the ritual for its own sake, but about the restored relationship with God.

Christians believe that the sacrifices of the temple found their fulfillment in Jesus Christ (Hebrews 10:10–14). In Judaism today, without a temple, prayer, the study of the Torah, and good deeds take the place of the sacrifices.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 44

The closed gate and the priests

The east gate stays closed VERSES 1–3

1 Then he brought me back to the outer gate of the sanctuary,
the one that faces east.
It was closed.
2 The LORD said to me,
"This gate must stay closed.
It must not be opened.
No one may go in through it,
because the LORD, the God of Israel, has gone in through it.
So it must stay closed.
3 As for the prince, he may sit in it as prince
to eat bread before the LORD.
He must come in through the porch of the gate
and go out the same way."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Because God himself has come back through the east gate, it is closed forever. No one else may use this way. This also shows: God will never leave the temple again.

Today in Jerusalem there is a gate in the eastern city wall that has been bricked up, the "Golden Gate" (in Hebrew "Shaar haRachamim," the Gate of Mercy). It was bricked up hundreds of years ago. Many Jews, Christians, and Muslims connect hopes for the end of time with it.

In Christian tradition, the closed gate was later also understood as a picture for Mary, through whom God came into the world.

Foreigners in the sanctuary VERSES 4–9

4 Then he brought me through the north gate to the front of the temple.
I looked, and the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD.
I fell on my face.
5 The LORD said to me,
"Son of man, pay close attention.
Look with your eyes,
and listen with your ears to everything I tell you about all the rules of the house of the LORD and all its laws.
Pay close attention to the entrance of the temple
and to all the exits of the sanctuary.
6 Say to the rebels, to the people of Israel,
'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"People of Israel, enough of all the disgusting things you have done!
7 You brought in foreigners,
uncircumcised in heart and uncircumcised in body,
to be in my sanctuary and make it unholy, my house,
while you offered me my food, the fat and the blood.
They broke my covenant,
in addition to all the disgusting things you did.
8 You did not take care of my holy things yourselves.
Instead you put others in my sanctuary
to do the work for you."
9 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"No foreigner who is uncircumcised in heart and uncircumcised in body
may enter my sanctuary,
none of the foreigners who live among the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the old temple they had apparently used foreign workers or guards who did not know or worship God ("uncircumcised in heart"). They did holy work that the priests and Levites should have done. The people of Israel had simply handed over their responsibility.

Important: This is about the service in the innermost sanctuary, not about foreigners in general. In many places the Bible commands people to love and protect foreigners (Leviticus 19:33–34). Isaiah 56:6–7 even says that foreigners who join the LORD are welcome in his house: "For my house will be called a house of prayer for all peoples." And Ezekiel himself says in 47:22–23 that foreigners are to receive land as their share, just like those born in the land.

So this text must not be used to exclude foreigners or people of a different background.

The Levites VERSES 10–14

10 "'"But the Levites
who went far away from me when Israel went astray,
who wandered away from me to follow their idols,
must bear the results of their guilt.
11 Still, they are to serve in my sanctuary.
They are to watch over the gates of the temple
and serve in the temple.
They are to kill the animals for the burnt offering and the sacrifices for the people.
They are to stand before the people to serve them.
12 They served the people in front of their idols
and made the people of Israel fall into sin.
So I have raised my hand and sworn an oath against

them,"
says the Lord GOD,
"that they will bear the results of their guilt.
13 They must not come near me
to serve me as priests.
They must not come near any of my holy things,
the things that are most holy.
They must bear their shame
and the results of the disgusting things they have done.
14 Still, I will put them in charge of the work of the temple,
of all its work
and of everything that is done in it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites were the tribe that was responsible for worship. Many of them had served at shrines for idols. So they may no longer be priests, but they keep a task: They guard the gates, kill the animals for the sacrifices, and help the people.

This shows: Guilt has consequences. But God does not reject the Levites completely. They still get a place in the service.

The priests, the sons of Zadok VERSES 15–16

15 "'"But the priests from the tribe of Levi, the sons of Zadok,
took care of my sanctuary
when the people of Israel went astray from me.
They will come near me to serve me.
They will stand before me
to offer me the fat and the blood,"
says the Lord GOD.
16 "They will enter my sanctuary.
They will come near my table to serve me,
and they will keep my instructions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests from the family of Zadok had stayed faithful when others turned away. So they may do the work of priests. Ezekiel himself probably came from a priestly family in Jerusalem, maybe from this line.

Rules for the priests VERSES 17–27

17 "'"When they go in through the gates of the inner courtyard,
they must wear linen clothes.
They must not wear any wool
while they serve at the gates of the inner courtyard and inside it.
18 They must wear linen turbans on their heads
and linen pants around their waists.
They must not wear anything that makes them sweat.
19 When they go out into the outer courtyard,
into the outer courtyard where the people are,
they must take off the clothes they serve in
and leave them in the holy rooms.
They must put on other clothes,
so that they do not make the people holy with their clothes.
20 "'"They must not shave their heads,
and they must not let their hair grow long.
They must only trim the hair on their heads.
21 No priest may drink wine
when he goes into the inner courtyard.
22 They must not marry a widow or a divorced woman.
They must marry young women who have never been with a man,
from the descendants of the people of Israel,
or a widow whose husband was a priest.
23 They must teach my people the difference
between what is holy and what is ordinary.
They must help them tell the difference between what is unclean and what is clean.
24 "'"When there is a dispute, they must stand up and judge.
They must judge by my rulings.
They must keep my laws and my rules
at all my festivals.
They must keep my Sabbaths holy.
25 "'"A priest must not make himself unclean
by going near a dead person.
But he may make himself unclean
for his father or mother,
for his son or daughter,
for his brother, or for his sister who has never had a husband.
26 After he has been made clean,
he must wait seven more days.
27 On the day he goes into the sanctuary,
into the inner courtyard, to serve in the sanctuary,
he must offer his sin offering,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These rules are like the laws for the priests in the book of Leviticus (Chapters 10 and 21).

Verses 17–18: Linen is cool and light. The priests are not to sweat in the sanctuary. Sweat was considered unclean.

Verse 21: No alcohol while serving (see Leviticus 10:9). Whoever serves before God is to have a clear head.

Verse 22: These marriage rules for priests match the old rules about being clean (Leviticus 21:7, 14). They do not look down on widows or divorced women. In many places the Bible gives special protection to widows (for example Deuteronomy 24:17; James 1:27).

Verses 23–24: The priests are responsible not only for sacrifices. They are also teachers and judges. They are to help the people understand God's will.

Verse 25: An exception when a close family member dies: Priests may mourn too.

God is their share VERSES 28–31

28 "They will have something to inherit:
I am what they inherit.
You must not give them any land of their own in Israel.
I am their property.
29 They will eat the grain offering, the sin offering, and the guilt offering.
Everything in Israel that is given completely to God will belong to them.
30 The best of all the first fruits of every kind
and every gift of every kind,
of all your gifts,
will belong to the priests.

You must also give the priests the first part of your dough,
so that a blessing may rest on your house.
31 The priests must not eat anything that died by itself
or was torn apart by wild animals,
whether bird or animal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: "I am what they inherit." The priests get no land. Their wealth is God himself (see Numbers 18:20: "I am your share and your inheritance"; Psalm 16:5).

They live from the gifts of the people. The people take care of the priests, and the priests serve the people.

Verse 30: Whoever gives will be blessed: "so that a blessing may rest on your house."

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 45

The holy area and honest measures

The holy share of the land VERSES 1–8

1 "'"When you divide the land by lot as an inheritance,
you must give a gift to the LORD,
a holy part of the land.
It is to be 25,000 rods (about 50 miles) long
and 10,000 rods (about 20 miles) wide.
The whole area within its borders will be holy.
2 Out of this, a square of 500 by 500
will be for the sanctuary.
Around it there will be an open space about 88 feet wide.
3 In this holy area you must measure off a part
25,000 long and 10,000 wide.
In it will be the sanctuary, the most holy place.
4 It is a holy part of the land.
It will belong to the priests,
who serve in the sanctuary
and who come near to serve the LORD.
It will be a place for their houses
and a holy place for the sanctuary.
5 An area 25,000 cubits (about 8 miles) long
and 10,000 cubits (about 3⅓ miles) wide
will belong to the Levites, who serve in the temple.
It will be their own property, for 20 rooms.
6 "'"As the property of the city you must set aside an area
5,000 cubits (about 1⅔ miles) wide and 25,000 cubits long,
next to the holy area.
It will belong to all the people of Israel.
7 "'"The land for the prince
will be on both sides of the holy area
and of the property of the city.
It will lie next to the holy area and next to the property of the city,
on the west side toward the west
and on the east side toward the east.
Its length will be the same as one of the tribes' shares,
from the western border to the eastern border.
8 This land will be his property in Israel.
My princes will no longer oppress my people.
Instead they will give the rest of the land to the people of Israel
by their tribes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the land a holy area is measured off. In it are the temple, the land of the priests, the land of the Levites, and the city. To the left and right of it is the land of the prince.

Verse 1: The WEB says "reeds" (rods) here, but in verses 5 and 6 "cubits." Here too many Bible teachers think that cubits are meant everywhere (see 42:16–20). With cubits the area would be about 8 by 3 miles.

Verse 8: An important sentence: "My princes will no longer oppress my people." The prince gets enough land of his own, so that he is not tempted to take land away from the people. Kings had done this in the past (see Naboth's vineyard, 1 Kings 21).

Justice and what is right VERSES 9–12

9 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Enough, you princes of Israel!
Put away violence and robbery,
and do what is just and right!
Stop driving my people off their land!"
says the Lord GOD.
10 "You must use honest scales,
an honest ephah and an honest bath.
11 The ephah and the bath must be the same size.
The bath must hold one tenth of a homer,
and the ephah one tenth of a homer.
The homer is the standard for both.
12 The shekel must be 20 gerahs.
20 shekels plus 25 shekels plus 15 shekels
make one mina.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: "Enough!" God calls on the powerful to stop violence and oppression. Justice and doing what is right are the foundation of a good life together.

Verses 10–12: Honest measures and weights. In trade people often cheated, for example with false weights (see Amos 8:5; Micah 6:11). God wants people to be honest in business too.

The measures: An ephah (for grain) and a bath (for liquids) are the same size, about 6 gallons. A homer is 10 times as much, about 60 gallons. A shekel is a weight of about 0.4 ounces. A gerah is one twentieth of a shekel. 20 + 25 + 15 = 60 shekels make one mina.

For today: Being honest at work, fair prices, fair wages – all this is part of living by God's will.

Gifts for the prince VERSES 13–17

13 "'"This is the gift you must give:
one sixth of an ephah from every homer of wheat,

and one sixth of an ephah from every homer of barley.
14 The set share of oil, measured by the bath, is this:
one tenth of a bath from every cor.
A cor is 10 baths, the same as a homer.
(For 10 baths are a homer.)
15 And give one lamb out of every 200 in the flock
from the well-watered pastures of Israel.
These are for grain offerings, burnt offerings, and peace offerings,
to make atonement for the people,"
says the Lord GOD.
16 "All the people of the land must give this gift
to the prince in Israel.
17 It will be the prince's duty to provide the burnt offerings,
the grain offerings, and the drink offerings
at the festivals, at the new moons, and on the Sabbaths,
at all the appointed festivals of the people of Israel.
He must provide the sin offering, the grain offering,
the burnt offering,
and the peace offerings,
to make atonement for the people of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people give a gift: about 1/60 of their grain, 1/100 of their oil, 1/200 of their sheep. That is modest.

These gifts go to the prince. He is responsible for providing the sacrifices for the whole people at the festivals.

Here the prince is above all a servant in worship, not a powerful ruler who collects things for himself.

Verse 15: To make atonement means to take away guilt so that things are right with God again.

Festivals and making clean VERSES 18–25

18 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"In the first month, on the first day of the month,
you must take a young bull without any defect
and make the sanctuary clean.
19 The priest must take some of the blood of the sin offering
and put it on the doorposts of the temple,
on the four corners of the ledge of the altar,
and on the posts of the gate of the inner courtyard.
20 You must do the same on the seventh day of the month
for anyone who sins by mistake
or because he does not know better.
That is how you will make atonement for the temple.
21 "'"In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the month,
you must celebrate the Passover,
a festival of seven days.
You must eat bread made without yeast.
22 On that day the prince must provide a bull as a sin offering
for himself and for all the people of the land.
23 On each of the seven days of the festival
he must provide a burnt offering for the LORD:
seven bulls and seven rams without any defect,
every day for the seven days,
and a male goat every day as a sin offering.
24 He must provide a grain offering:
an ephah for each bull,
an ephah for each ram,
and a hin of oil (about 1 gallon) for each ephah.
25 "'"In the seventh month, on the fifteenth day of the month,
during the festival, he must do the same for seven days.
He must provide the same things
for the sin offering, the burnt offering, the grain offering, and the oil."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–20: Twice a year the sanctuary is made clean, especially for the people who sinned "by mistake" or "because they did not know better." God understands human weakness.

Verse 21: The Passover (Pesach) reminds people of the freedom from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 12). It is still celebrated in Judaism today. Before his death, Jesus celebrated the Passover meal with his disciples (Luke 22:15).

Verse 25: The festival in the seventh month on the 15th day is the Feast of Booths (Sukkot), a joyful harvest festival (Leviticus 23:33–43).

Interesting: Some festivals from the book of Leviticus, like the Feast of Weeks (Shavuot) or the Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur), are not mentioned here. Ezekiel's order is different from the laws of Moses in some places. Jewish scholars discussed this very early.

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 46

Rules for the prince and the people

Sabbath and new moon VERSES 1–8

1 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"The gate of the inner courtyard that faces east
must stay closed on the six working days.
But on the Sabbath day it must be opened,
and on the day of the new moon it must be opened.
2 The prince must come in from outside through the porch of the gate
and stand by the post of the gate.
The priests must prepare his burnt offering and his peace offerings.
He must worship at the threshold of the gate.
Then he must go out.
But the gate must not be closed until evening.
3 The people of the land must worship before the LORD
at the entrance of that gate
on the Sabbaths and on the new moons.

4 The burnt offering that the prince offers to the LORD
on the Sabbath day must be
six lambs without any defect and one ram without any defect.
5 The grain offering must be an ephah for the ram.
The grain offering for the lambs is as much as he is able to give.
He must also give a hin of oil for each ephah.
6 On the day of the new moon he must offer a young bull without any defect,
six lambs, and a ram.
They must be without any defect.
7 He must provide a grain offering:
an ephah for the bull,
an ephah for the ram,
and for the lambs as much as he is able to give,
and a hin of oil for each ephah.
8 When the prince comes in,
he must come in through the porch of the gate.
And he must go out the same way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On normal days the inner east gate is closed. It is opened only on the Sabbath and at the new moon (the beginning of the month). Then the prince prays at the threshold, and the people pray outside at the entrance. Through the open gate everyone can see the altar and the temple.

The prince may not go into the inner courtyard. He is the leader of the people, but he is not a priest. God is above all rulers.

Verses 5 and 7: "As much as he is able to give" – the gift depends on what a person can do. God does not ask for anything impossible.

An ephah is about 6 gallons. A hin is about 1 gallon.

How people walk through the temple VERSES 9–15

9 "'"But when the people of the land come before the LORD at the appointed festivals,
whoever comes in through the north gate to worship must go out through the south gate.
And whoever comes in through the south gate must go out through the north gate.
No one may go back through the gate he came in by.
Everyone must go straight ahead and out.
10 The prince must go in with them when they go in.
When they go out, he must go out.
11 "'"At the festivals and on the appointed holy days,
the grain offering must be an ephah for a bull
and an ephah for a ram,
and for the lambs as much as he is able to give,
and a hin of oil for each ephah.
12 When the prince provides a freewill offering,
a burnt offering or peace offerings as a freewill gift to the LORD,
the gate that faces east must be opened for him.
He must provide his burnt offering and his peace offerings,
as he does on the Sabbath day.
Then he must go out,
and after he has gone out, the gate must be closed.
13 "'"Every day you must provide a lamb one year old without any defect
as a burnt offering to the LORD.
You must provide it every morning.
14 Every morning you must also provide a grain offering with it:
one sixth of an ephah of flour,
and one third of a hin of oil to moisten the fine flour.
This is a grain offering to the LORD.
It must be given always, as a rule that lasts forever.
15 So they must provide the lamb, the grain offering, and the oil
every morning,
as a burnt offering that is given always."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: At the great festivals the temple is full of people. So that there is no crowding, there is a one-way rule: Whoever comes in from the north goes out to the south, and the other way around. A practical rule! Some Bible teachers also see a picture in it: Whoever has met God does not go back the same way, but goes on changed.

Verse 10: The prince walks in the middle of the people, not ahead of them and not apart from them. He is one of them.

Verses 13–15: Every morning a lamb is sacrificed, the "continual offering." It shows: Every day belongs to God.

The prince's property VERSES 16–18

16 "'This is what the Lord GOD says:
"Suppose the prince gives a gift of land to one of his sons.
Then it is his son's inheritance.
It will belong to his sons.
It is their property to inherit.
17 But suppose he gives a gift from his land to one of his servants.
Then it will belong to the servant only until the year of freedom.
After that it will go back to the prince.
His land will belong only to his sons.
18 The prince must not take any of the people's land
and drive them off their property.
He must give his sons land from his own property,
so that none of my people are driven away from their property."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: The "year of freedom" is the year of release (the Year of Jubilee), every 50 years. Then land went back to its original owners (Leviticus 25:10–13).

Verse 18: Again the ordinary people are protected: The prince may not take land away from the people. He may provide for his sons only from his own property. The powerful must not grow rich at the cost of the weak.

The kitchens of the temple VERSES 19–24

19 Then he brought me through the entrance
at the side of the gate
into the holy rooms for the priests,
which faced north.
Look, there was a place at the back, on the west side.
20 He said to me,
"This is the place where the priests must boil the guilt offering and the sin offering,
and where they must bake the grain offering.

Then they do not have to carry them out into the outer courtyard
and make the people holy."
21 Then he brought me out into the outer courtyard
and led me past the four corners of the courtyard.
Look, in each corner of the courtyard there was a smaller courtyard.
22 In the four corners of the courtyard there were enclosed courtyards,
about 70 feet long and about 52½ feet wide.
All four in the corners were the same size.
23 Around each of the four there was a wall,
and fireplaces for cooking were built along the bottom of the walls all around.
24 Then he said to me,
"These are the kitchens
where those who serve in the temple must boil the sacrifices of the people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: The WEB says 40 cubits long and 30 cubits wide. In Ezekiel's temple a cubit is about 21 inches.

The temple even has kitchens! There are two kinds: the kitchens of the priests for the holy shares of the sacrifices, and four large kitchens in the corners of the outer courtyard, where the Levites cook the sacrifice meals for the people.

Many sacrifices ended with a shared festive meal. Worship and eating together belonged together. This is like the Lord's Supper (Communion) for Christians and the festive meals in Judaism, for example on the Sabbath and at Passover.

EZEKIEL

Chapter 47

The river from the temple

The water gets deeper and deeper VERSES 1–6

1 He brought me back to the entrance of the temple.
Look, water was flowing out from under the threshold of the temple toward the east,
for the front of the temple faced east.
The water was flowing down from under
the right side of the temple,
south of the altar.
2 Then he brought me out through the north gate.
He led me around on the outside to the outer gate,
the gate that faces east.
Look, water was trickling out on the right side.
3 The man went out toward the east with a measuring cord in his hand.
He measured about 1,750 feet
and led me through the water.
The water came up to my ankles.
4 Again he measured about 1,750 feet
and led me through the water.
The water came up to my knees.
Again he measured about 1,750 feet
and led me through water that came up to my waist.
5 Then he measured about 1,750 feet more.
Now it was a river that I could not walk through.
The water had risen.
It was deep enough to swim in,
a river that no one could walk through.
6 He said to me,
"Son of man, have you seen this?"
Then he led me back to the bank of the river.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful vision: Water comes out from under the threshold of the temple. At first it is only a little stream. But it gets deeper and deeper: up to the ankles, up to the knees, up to the waist, and finally it is a river you have to swim in.

The measurement is 1,000 cubits each time, about 1,750 feet.

The amazing thing: Normally a river only gets bigger when other streams flow into it. This river grows all by itself. It comes directly from God.

The picture shows: Where God lives, life flows. And this life grows and becomes more and more.

Jesus says: "The Scriptures say this about whoever believes in me: Rivers of living water will flow from inside him" (John 7:38). See also Psalm 46:4 (in some Bibles 46:5): "There is a river. Its streams make the city of God glad."

The water makes everything healthy VERSES 7–12

7 When I came back,
look, there were very many trees on the bank of the river,
on both sides.
8 Then he said to me,
"This water flows out toward the eastern region.
It will go down into the Arabah.
Then it will flow toward the sea
and into the sea, which will be made to flow out.
And the water there will become healthy and fresh.
9 Every living creature that swarms
will live wherever the river goes.
There will be very many fish,
because this water goes there.
The water of the sea will become healthy,
and everything will live wherever the river goes.
10 Fishermen will stand along its shore.
From En Gedi all the way to En Eglaim there will be places to spread out nets.
There will be many kinds of fish,
like the fish of the great sea,
very many.
11 But its swamps and marshes will not become fresh.
They will be left for salt.
12 On both banks of the river
all kinds of fruit trees will grow.
Their leaves will not dry up,
and their fruit will not fail.
They will bear new fruit every month,
because their water flows out from the sanctuary.

Their fruit will be for food,
and their leaves for healing."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The river flows through the desert (the Arabah is the valley of the Jordan down to the Dead Sea) and then into the Dead Sea. The Dead Sea is so salty that no fish can live in it. But this water makes even the Dead Sea come alive! Fishermen will throw out their nets there.

En Gedi is an oasis on the west shore of the Dead Sea that still exists today.

Verse 11: The swamps stay salty. Salt was important for life back then (for seasoning food and for keeping it from spoiling). God provides for everything.

Verse 12: Trees that bear fruit every month and whose leaves heal. That is a picture of paradise. At the end of the Bible this picture is taken up: "The angel showed me a river of the water of life ... On both sides of the river was the tree of life. It bears 12 kinds of fruit. It gives its fruit every month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations" (Revelation 22:1–2).

The message: God's presence changes even what is dead into what is alive, the desert into a garden.

The borders of the land VERSES 13–21

13 This is what the Lord GOD says:
"These are the borders
by which you must divide the land to own
among the 12 tribes of Israel.
Joseph will have two shares.
14 You must divide it equally, each tribe as much as another.
For I swore to give it to your ancestors.
This land will be yours to own.
15 "This will be the border of the land:
On the north side it goes from the great sea,
by the road to Hethlon,
to the entrance of Zedad,
16 to Hamath, Berothah, and Sibraim
(which is between the border of Damascus and the border of Hamath),
as far as Hazer Hatticon, which is on the border of Hauran.
17 So the border will run from the sea to Hazar Enon,
on the border of Damascus.
To the north is the border of Hamath.
This is the north side.
18 "On the east side
the border runs between Hauran and Damascus,
and between Gilead and the land of Israel.
It is the Jordan.
You must measure from the north border to the eastern sea.
This is the east side.
19 "On the south side
the border goes from Tamar
to the waters of Meriboth Kadesh,
along the brook
to the great sea.
This is the south side.
20 "On the west side the border is the great sea,
from the south border to a point across from the entrance of Hamath.
This is the west side.
21 "So you must divide this land among yourselves
by the tribes of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the borders of the new land are described. They are like the borders in Numbers 34:1–12.

The "great sea" is the Mediterranean Sea. The "eastern sea" is the Dead Sea. The "brook" is the Brook of Egypt (Wadi el-Arish).

Verse 13: Joseph gets two shares, for his sons Ephraim and Manasseh (see Genesis 48:5). So there are still 12 shares, even though the tribe of Levi does not get any land of its own.

Verse 14: "Each tribe as much as another" – all the tribes get shares of the same size. Justice for everyone.

These borders describe a vision and a promise. They are not a plan for political borders today.

The foreigners get a share too VERSES 22–23

22 You must divide it by lot
as land to own for yourselves
and for the foreigners who live among you
and who have children among you.
They will be to you like those born among the people of Israel.
They will get land to own with you
among the tribes of Israel.
23 In whatever tribe the foreigner lives,
there you must give him his share of land,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A revolutionary sentence for that time! The foreigners who live among Israel for good and have their families there are to get land just like those born in the land. They are to be "like those born among the people of Israel."

In the old law, the land to inherit was tied to the tribes of Israel. Foreigners usually did not have their own land to inherit. Here Ezekiel takes a big step further: In God's new land, the foreigners fully belong.

This is a strong message for today: People who have come to us from other countries and live here are to receive equal rights and a real home. God shuts no one out (see Leviticus 19:34: "The foreigner who lives with you shall be to you like someone born among you. And you shall love him as yourself").

EZEKIEL

CHAPTER 48

The LORD is there

The tribes in the north VERSES 1–7

1 "These are the names of the tribes and their shares:
At the northern end,
along the road to Hethlon, to the entrance of Hamath,
as far as Hazar Enan on the border of Damascus,
north next to Hamath
(each share will run from the east side to the west side):
Dan will have one share.
2 "Next to the border of Dan, from the east side to the
west side,
Asher will have one share.
3 "Next to the border of Asher, from the east side to the
west side,
Naphtali will have one share.
4 "Next to the border of Naphtali, from the east side to
the west side,
Manasseh will have one share.
5 "Next to the border of Manasseh, from the east side to
the west side,
Ephraim will have one share.
6 "Next to the border of Ephraim, from the east side to
the west side,
Reuben will have one share.
7 "Next to the border of Reuben, from the east side to the
west side,
Judah will have one share.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The land is divided up in a completely new way, into strips of the same width from east to west, like ribbons. Seven tribes live north of the holy area.

This division is different from the one in Joshua (Joshua 13–19). It is very regular and fair: Every tribe gets a strip of the same width with access to the Jordan and to the sea.

The tribes that came from the servant women of Jacob (Dan, Asher, Naphtali, Gad) are more toward the edges. The tribes of Leah and Rachel are closer to the sanctuary.

The holy area VERSES 8–22

8 "Next to the border of Judah, from the east side to the
west side,
will be the special gift of land that you must set apart.
It will be 25,000 rods (about 50 miles) wide,
and as long as one of the tribes' shares,
from the east side to the west side.
The sanctuary will be in the middle of it.
9 "The gift of land that you must set apart for the LORD
will be 25,000 rods long
and 10,000 rods (about 20 miles) wide.
10 This holy gift of land will be for the priests.
On the north side it will be 25,000 long,
on the west side 10,000 wide,
on the east side 10,000 wide,
and on the south side 25,000 long.
The sanctuary of the LORD will be in the middle of it.
11 It will be for the priests who have been set apart as holy,
the sons of Zadok.
They kept my instructions.
They did not go astray when the people of Israel went
astray,
as the Levites went astray.
12 It will be their special share out of the gift of the land,
a most holy area,
next to the border of the Levites.
13 "Next to the border of the priests, the Levites will have
an area
25,000 cubits (about 8 miles) long
and 10,000 cubits (about 3⅓ miles) wide.
The whole length will be 25,000,
and the width 10,000.
14 They must not sell any of it
or trade any of it.
This best part of the land must not pass into other
hands,
for it is holy to the LORD.
15 "The remaining area, 5,000 cubits (about 1⅔ miles) wide
and 25,000 long,
will be for ordinary use:
for the city,
for houses, and for pastures.
The city will be in the middle of it.
16 These will be the city's measurements:
the north side 4,500,
the south side 4,500,
the east side 4,500,
and the west side 4,500.
17 The city will have pastures:
250 to the north,
250 to the south,
250 to the east,
and 250 to the west.
18 What is left of the length, next to the holy gift of land,
will be 10,000 to the east
and 10,000 to the west.
It will lie next to the holy gift of land.
Its harvest will be food for the people who work in the
city.
19 The people who work in the city,
from all the tribes of Israel,
will farm it.
20 The whole gift of land will be a square,
25,000 by 25,000.
You must set it apart as a holy gift,
together with the property of the city.
21 "What is left will belong to the prince.
It will lie on both sides of the holy gift of land
and of the property of the city.
It will reach from the 25,000 of the holy area east to
the eastern border,
and west from the 25,000 to the western border,
alongside the tribes' shares.
It will belong to the prince.
The holy gift of land and the sanctuary of the temple
will be in the middle of it.
22 The property of the Levites
and the property of the city
will lie in the middle of the prince's land.
The prince's land will lie between the border of Judah
and the border of Benjamin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the land, between Judah and Benjamin, lies the holy area, a large square. In it are:

– the land of the priests with the temple in the middle,
– the land of the Levites,
– the city with the land around it.

To the left and right of it is the land of the prince.

Again the WEB says "reeds" (rods) in verses 8–9, but "cubits" in other places (see 42:16–20 and 45:1). Probably cubits are meant everywhere. Then the holy area would be about 8 miles on each side.

Verse 14: The holy land must not be sold. It belongs to God.

Verse 19: The city does not belong to one tribe, but to all. People from all the tribes work there together. The city is a place of unity.

Remarkable: The temple does not stand in the city, but next to it, in the land of the priests.

The tribes in the south VERSES 23–29

23 "As for the rest of the tribes:
From the east side to the west side,
Benjamin will have one share.
24 "Next to the border of Benjamin, from the east side to the west side,
Simeon will have one share.
25 "Next to the border of Simeon, from the east side to the west side,
Issachar will have one share.
26 "Next to the border of Issachar, from the east side to the west side,
Zebulun will have one share.
27 "Next to the border of Zebulun, from the east side to the west side,
Gad will have one share.
28 "Next to the border of Gad, on the south side,
the border will run from Tamar
to the waters of Meribath Kadesh,
along the brook,
to the great sea.
29 "This is the land that you must divide by lot
among the tribes of Israel to own,
and these are their shares,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Five tribes live south of the holy area. Together with the seven in the north, there are 12 tribes. The whole people of Israel is united again. No tribe is forgotten, not even the tribes of the northern kingdom, which had been taken away more than 100 years before.

The city with 12 gates VERSES 30–35

30 "These are the exits of the city:
The north side is 4,500 rods (about 9 miles) long.
31 The gates of the city will be named after the tribes of Israel.
There will be three gates on the north side:
one gate for Reuben,
one gate for Judah,
and one gate for Levi.
32 "The east side is 4,500 rods long.
It has three gates:
one gate for Joseph,
one gate for Benjamin,
and one gate for Dan.
33 "The south side is 4,500 rods long.
It has three gates:
one gate for Simeon,
one gate for Issachar,
and one gate for Zebulun.
34 "The west side is 4,500 rods long.
It has three gates:
one gate for Gad,
one gate for Asher,
and one gate for Naphtali.
35 "The distance all around the city will be 18,000 rods (about 36 miles).
And from that day on, the name of the city will be,
'The LORD is there.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The city is a square with three gates on each side, 12 gates in all, each named after a tribe of Israel. Here Levi also has a gate, and Joseph stands for Ephraim and Manasseh together. All the tribes have access to the city.

Revelation takes up this picture: The new Jerusalem has 12 gates with the names of the 12 tribes of Israel (Revelation 21:12–13).

Verse 35: This is the last sentence of the book, and it is beautiful. The city is no longer called Jerusalem, but "The LORD is there" (in Hebrew "Yahweh Shammah").

The book began with a man in exile, far from home, who saw God's glory in a foreign land. It ends with the certainty: God lives among his people. He is there. Forever.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Ezekiel?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet in exile: Ezekiel was a priest who was taken away to Babylon in 597 BC. There, far from the temple, heaven opened, and he saw God's glory (Chapter 1). God is not tied to one place.

Judgment on Jerusalem (Chapters 1–24): With words and many sign-acts, Ezekiel announced that Jerusalem would be destroyed. In a vision he saw God's glory leave the temple that had been made unholy (Chapters 8–11).

The watchman: Ezekiel was to warn the people like a watchman on the wall (Chapters 3 and 33). He suffered with his people, even through the death of his own wife (Chapter 24).

Everyone is responsible: "The fathers have eaten sour grapes ..." is no longer true. Every person can turn back. "I take no pleasure in the death ... So turn back, and live!" (18:32; 33:11).

The nations (Chapters 25–32): God is Lord over all nations. Pride, being glad when others suffer, and violence have consequences everywhere: for Tyre, for Egypt, and for all the others.

The good shepherd: "Look, I myself, yes I, will search for my sheep" (Chapter 34). God looks for the lost and bandages the injured.

A new heart: "I will also give you a new heart, and I will put a new spirit inside you" (36:26). God changes people from the inside.

Dry bones: God can make what is dead come alive. "Look, I will open your graves" (Chapter 37). No situation is hopeless for God.

The new temple (Chapters 40–48): God's glory comes back (Chapter 43). A river flows out of the temple that makes

even the Dead Sea come alive (Chapter 47). The foreigners also get a share of the land.

Hard texts: Some pictures in Ezekiel are harsh and violent, especially the pictures of women in Chapters 16 and 23. They describe the disaster of their time. They never justify violence against women or other people.

The last sentence: "The LORD is there" (48:35). The whole book leads up to this.

For today: If you feel as if you are in exile, far from home, without hope, "dried up": Ezekiel says that God can be found exactly there and can give new life. If you need help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

What comes next? Next comes the book of Daniel. Daniel lived at the same time as Ezekiel, at the court of the king of Babylon. The book tells about Daniel and his friends, who stay faithful to God even in a foreign land, about the fiery furnace and the lions' den. And it contains great visions about the kingdoms of the world and about the Kingdom of God.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 27 OF 66

DANIEL

12 CHAPTERS

DANIEL

CHAPTER 1

Faithful in a foreign land

Before we begin: Who was Daniel?

The book of Daniel tells about a young man from Judah. He was taken away to Babylon and lived there at the king's court. So he lived at the same time as Ezekiel and Jeremiah.

His name means "God is my judge."

The book has 12 chapters and two parts:

– Chapters 1–6: Stories about Daniel and his three friends. They stay faithful to God, even when that is dangerous: in the fiery furnace, in the lions' den.

– Chapters 7–12: Visions about the kingdoms of the world and the coming kingdom of God.

A special feature: Part of the book (Daniel 2:4 to 7:28) is not written in Hebrew but in Aramaic. Aramaic was the international language of that time.

When was the book written? According to tradition, Daniel himself wrote it, in the 6th century BC. Many scholars think that it got its present form only in the 2nd century BC. At that time, King Antiochus IV persecuted the Jews and wanted to forbid their faith. Then the stories of Daniel gave courage to the people who were persecuted. Believers hold both views.

In the Jewish Bible, Daniel is not among the Prophets but among the "Writings." In Christian Bibles, it is among the Prophets. Jesus calls Daniel a prophet (Matthew 24:15). And he calls himself the "Son of Man," after Daniel 7:13.

The basic message: The powerful people of the world may seem great and threatening. But God is the true Lord of history. His kingdom will last.

Taken away to Babylon VERSES 1–7

1 In the third year that Jehoiakim was king of Judah,
Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, came to Jerusalem.
He put the city under siege.
That means: His army surrounded the city.
2 The Lord handed Jehoiakim, the king of Judah, over to him.
He also handed over some of the objects from the house of God.
Nebuchadnezzar carried them away to the land of Shinar,
to the house of his god.
He put the objects into the treasure house of his god.
3 The king spoke to Ashpenaz, the chief of his eunuchs.
He told him to bring some of the people of Israel,
from the royal family and from the noble families.
4 They were to be young men without any defect,
good-looking,
skillful in all kinds of wisdom,
gifted with knowledge,
with understanding for learning,
young men who were able to serve in the king's palace.
Ashpenaz was to teach them the writing and the language of the Chaldeans.
5 The king gave them a daily share
of the king's fine food
and of the wine that he drank.
They were to be trained for three years.
After that, they were to serve the king.
6 Among them were these men from Judah:
Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.
7 The chief of the eunuchs gave them new names:
He called Daniel Belteshazzar,
Hananiah he called Shadrach,
Mishael he called Meshach,
and Azariah he called Abednego.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Nebuchadnezzar conquers Jerusalem and takes objects from the temple with him. He puts them in the temple of his own god. That was meant to show: The god of Babylon is stronger. But the text says: "The Lord handed Jehoiakim, the king of Judah, over to him." God is in control, even in defeat.

The "third year of Jehoiakim" would be about 606/605 BC. Scholars disagree about the exact date of this first deportation.

"Shinar" is an old name for Babylonia (compare Genesis 11:2, the tower of Babel).

Verses 3–5: The young men from noble families are to be retrained as Babylonian officials: a new language, a new education, new food. The WEB calls Ashpenaz the "master of his eunuchs." Eunuchs were court officials. Often they had been castrated. The text does not say whether Daniel and his friends were also made eunuchs.

Verse 7: Even their names are changed. Their Hebrew names reminded people of God (for example, "Daniel" = "God is my judge," "Hananiah" = "The LORD is gracious"). The new names remind people of Babylonian gods. Someone wanted to wipe out who they were.

Daniel does not want to make himself unclean VERSES 8–16

8 But Daniel decided in his heart
that he would not make himself unclean
with the king's fine food
or with the wine that he drank.
Unclean means: not fit to come before God.
So Daniel asked the chief of the eunuchs
to let him not make himself unclean.
9 God made the chief of the eunuchs
kind to Daniel and full of compassion for him.
10 The chief of the eunuchs said to Daniel,
"I am afraid of my lord the king.
He has decided what you eat and what you drink.
What if he sees that your faces look worse
than the faces of the young men of your own age?
Then you would put my head in danger with the king."
11 Then Daniel spoke to the guard
whom the chief of the eunuchs had put in charge of
Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.
12 Daniel said,
"Please test your servants for 10 days.
Let them give us vegetables to eat and water to drink.
13 Then look at our faces
and at the faces of the young men
who eat the king's fine food.
Then do with your servants what you think is right."
14 So the guard listened to them in this matter.
He tested them for 10 days.

15 At the end of the 10 days,
their faces looked better and healthier.
They were better fed
than all the young men who ate the king's fine food.
16 So the guard took away their fine food
and the wine they were supposed to drink.
And he gave them vegetables.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Daniel does not want to eat the king's food. Why? Probably because the meat was not prepared according to the Jewish food laws, or because it had first been offered to idols. Daniel wanted to stay faithful to God, even in a foreign land.

It is remarkable how Daniel does this: He does not rebel loudly. He asks politely and suggests a fair test. He looks for a solution that is also good for the guard.

Verse 9: "God made the chief of the eunuchs kind to Daniel." God works in the background.

Verse 15: After 10 days of vegetables and water, the four look healthier than the others. This is not a general rule for healthy eating. It shows: God blesses faithfulness.

For today: We too can live in a place where people have other values. Daniel shows how to stay true to what you believe without looking down on others.

10 times wiser VERSES 17–21

17 God gave these four young men knowledge and skill
in all kinds of learning and wisdom.
And Daniel could understand all visions and dreams.
18 The king had set a time for bringing them in.
At the end of that time,
the chief of the eunuchs brought them before
Nebuchadnezzar.
19 The king talked with them.
Among them all, there was no one like Daniel,
Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah.
So they began to serve the king.
20 The king asked them about many things
that needed wisdom and understanding.
In every matter, he found them 10 times better
than all the magicians and enchanters in his whole
kingdom.
Enchanters are people who try to use magic words.
21 Daniel stayed there until the first year of King Cyrus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The four learn all the knowledge of Babylon, and they are excellent at it. They do not refuse the foreign culture. They learn and work along with others, but they do not give up their faith.

Verse 20: "10 times better" – God gives them wisdom that is greater than the wisdom of the Babylonian magicians.

Verse 21: Daniel lives longer than the whole Babylonian Empire. He is still there when the Persian king Cyrus conquers Babylon (539 BC) and allows the Jews to return home. Kings come and go, but God's faithful servant remains.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 2

The dream of the great statue

The king demands the impossible VERSES 1–13

1 In the second year that Nebuchadnezzar was king,
Nebuchadnezzar had dreams.
His spirit was troubled,
and he could not sleep anymore.
2 Then the king gave an order
to call the magicians, the enchanters, the sorcerers,
and the Chaldeans.
They were to tell the king his dreams.
So they came and stood in front of the king.
3 The king said to them,
"I have had a dream.
My spirit is troubled,
and I want to know the dream."
4 Then the Chaldeans spoke to the king in the Syrian
language,
"O king, live forever!
Tell your servants the dream,
and we will explain what it means."
5 The king answered the Chaldeans,
"The matter has gone from me.
If you do not tell me the dream and what it means,
you will be cut to pieces.
And your houses will be turned into piles of garbage.
6 But if you tell me the dream and what it means,
you will receive gifts, rewards, and great honor from
me.
So tell me the dream and what it means."
7 They answered a second time,
"Let the king tell his servants the dream.
Then we will explain what it means."
8 The king answered,
"I know for sure that you are trying to gain time.
For you see that the matter has gone from me.
9 If you do not tell me the dream,
there is only one law for you.
For you have agreed to speak lying and evil words to
me
until the situation changes.
So tell me the dream.
Then I will know that you can also tell me what it
means."
10 The Chaldeans answered the king,
"There is no one on earth
who can do what the king asks.
For no king, lord, or ruler
has ever asked such a thing of any magician,
enchanter, or Chaldean.
11 What the king asks is very hard.
No one can tell it to the king
except the gods.
And the gods do not live among human beings."

12 Because of this, the king became angry and very
furious.
He ordered that all the wise men of Babylon be killed.
13 So the order went out,
and the wise men were to be killed.
They also looked for Daniel and his friends to kill
them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king has a troubling dream. He puts his dream interpreters to the test: They are to tell him not only what it means, but first the dream itself. That way he can check whether they really have knowledge from beyond this world, or whether they are just making something up.

Verse 4: From here to Daniel 7:28, the book is written in Aramaic. The WEB calls the language "Syrian." It means Aramaic.

Verse 11: The wise men admit it themselves: Only the gods could know this, and they do not live among human beings. Without knowing it, they prepare Daniel's answer: There is a God who reveals secrets (verse 28).

Verse 12: A cruel order out of anger. The text shows how unfair and dangerous the power of a tyrant is.

Daniel prays with his friends VERSES 14–23

14 Then Daniel spoke with wisdom and good sense
to Arioch, the captain of the king's guard.
Arioch had gone out to kill the wise men of Babylon.
15 Daniel said to Arioch, the king's captain,
"Why is the king's order so urgent?"
Then Arioch explained the matter to Daniel.
16 Daniel went in and asked the king
to give him some time.
Then he would tell the king what the dream means.
17 Then Daniel went to his house.
He told the matter to his friends Hananiah, Mishael,
and Azariah.
18 He asked them to pray to the God of heaven for mercy
about this secret,
so that Daniel and his friends would not die
with the rest of the wise men of Babylon.
19 Then the secret was shown to Daniel in a vision in the
night.
And Daniel praised the God of heaven.
20 Daniel said,
"May the name of God be praised forever and ever,
for wisdom and power belong to him.
21 He changes the times and the seasons.
He removes kings and sets up kings.
He gives wisdom to the wise
and knowledge to those who have understanding.
22 He reveals what is deep and secret.
He knows what is in the darkness,
and the light lives with him.
23 I thank you and praise you, O God of my ancestors.
You have given me wisdom and power.
And now you have shown me what we asked you for.
For you have shown us what the king wants to know."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Daniel stays calm. He speaks wisely with the officer of the guard, asks the king for time, and then prays with his friends. Together they ask God for help.

Verses 19–23: When God shows him the secret, Daniel first gives thanks. He praises God before he goes to the king. His prayer is a beautiful song of praise:
"He removes kings and sets up kings." That is the theme of the whole book: Not the rulers decide history, but God.
"The light lives with him." God also sees into the darkness.

There is a God in heaven VERSES 24–30

24 So Daniel went to Arioch.
The king had given Arioch the job of killing the wise
men of Babylon.
Daniel went and said to him,
"Do not kill the wise men of Babylon.
Bring me to the king,
and I will tell the king what the dream means."
25 Then Arioch quickly brought Daniel to the king.
He said to him,
"I have found a man among the captives from Judah
who will tell the king what the dream means."
26 The king said to Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar,
"Can you tell me the dream that I saw
and what it means?"
27 Daniel answered the king,
"Wise men, enchanters, magicians, and fortune-
tellers
cannot tell the king the secret
that the king has asked about.
28 But there is a God in heaven who reveals secrets.
He has shown King Nebuchadnezzar
what will happen in the last days.
Your dream and the visions in your head as you lay on
your bed were these:
29 "O king, as you lay on your bed,
you had thoughts about what would happen in the
future.
And he who reveals secrets has shown you what will
happen.
30 But this secret was not shown to me
because I am wiser than anyone else alive.
It was shown to me so that the king would learn what
the dream means,
and so that you would know the thoughts of your
heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: Daniel does not think only of himself. First he asks that the other wise men are not killed either, even though they are not believers in his God.

Verses 27–28: Daniel does not take the honor for himself. He says: No human being can do this. "But there is a God in heaven who reveals secrets."

Verse 30: Daniel is humble: "This secret was not shown to me because I am wiser than anyone else alive." That means: I am not smarter than others. Everything is God's gift.

The dream VERSES 31–35

31 "O king, you looked,
and you saw a great statue.
This statue was huge,
and it shone brightly.
It stood in front of you,
and it looked terrifying.

32 The head of this statue was made of fine gold.
Its chest and its arms were made of silver.
Its belly and its thighs were made of bronze.
33 Its legs were made of iron.
Its feet were partly iron and partly clay.
34 As you watched,
a stone was cut out, but not by human hands.
It struck the statue on its feet of iron and clay
and broke them to pieces.
35 Then the iron, the clay, the bronze, the silver, and the gold
were all broken to pieces together.
They became like chaff on the threshing floors in summer.
The wind carried them away,
so that no trace of them was found.
But the stone that struck the statue
became a great mountain and filled the whole earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king saw a huge statue made of different metals. From top to bottom, they are less and less valuable (gold, silver, bronze, iron). And at the end it stands on feet of iron and clay, so it is not stable.

Then a stone comes, "but not by human hands." So it is not made by human beings. It smashes the whole statue. And the stone becomes a mountain that fills the whole world.

Verse 35: Chaff is the dry husk of grain that the wind blows away.

The meaning: four kingdoms and the kingdom of God
VERSES 36–45

36 "That was the dream.
Now we will tell the king what it means.
37 O king, you are the king of kings.
The God of heaven has given you the kingdom,
the power, the strength, and the glory.
38 Wherever people live,
he has handed over to you the animals of the field and the birds of the sky.
He has made you ruler over them all.
You are the head of gold.
39 "After you, another kingdom will rise.
It will be weaker than you.
Then a third kingdom, of bronze, will come.
It will rule over the whole earth.
40 The fourth kingdom will be as strong as iron.
For iron breaks everything to pieces and defeats everything.
Like iron that crushes all these things,
it will break and crush them all.
41 You saw the feet and toes,
partly of potter's clay and partly of iron.
It will be a divided kingdom.
But some of the strength of iron will be in it,
because you saw the iron mixed with soft, muddy clay.
42 The toes of the feet were partly iron and partly clay.
In the same way, the kingdom will be partly strong and partly brittle.
43 You saw the iron mixed with soft, muddy clay.
They will mix with other people through marriage.
But they will not hold together,
just as iron does not mix with clay.
44 "In the days of those kings,
the God of heaven will set up a kingdom
that will never be destroyed.
Its rule will never be handed over to another people.
It will break all these kingdoms to pieces and put an end to them.
But it will last forever.
45 For you saw a stone cut out of the mountain, but not by human hands.
And it broke to pieces the iron, the bronze, the clay, the silver, and the gold.
The great God has shown the king
what will happen in the future.
The dream is certain,
and its meaning can be trusted."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The statue stands for four world empires that come one after the other. The head of gold is Babylon under Nebuchadnezzar.

Verse 42: Brittle means: It breaks easily.

Which empires are the others? There are two main explanations:

– Many interpreters: Babylon, Media, Persia, Greece (the empire of Alexander the Great and of the kings after him. They joined their families through marriage, but they stayed divided, verse 43).

– An old explanation that many people hold (already among Jewish and Christian interpreters in ancient times): Babylon, Media-Persia, Greece, Rome.

Verse 44: The central message: All world empires, as powerful as they are, will pass away. At the end there is a kingdom that God himself sets up and that lasts forever.

Jews expect this kingdom with the coming of the Messiah. Christians see in it the kingdom of God that Jesus announced. Jesus said that the kingdom of God is near (Mark 1:15). It begins small like a stone and grows until it fills the whole world.

For today: No power in the world lasts forever. Dictators, world empires, and superpowers come and go. God's kingdom remains.

The king honors Daniel's God VERSES 46–49

46 Then King Nebuchadnezzar fell on his face
and bowed down to Daniel in worship.
He ordered that an offering and sweet-smelling incense be offered to him.
47 The king said to Daniel,
"Truly, your God is the God of gods
and the Lord of kings.
He reveals secrets,
for you were able to reveal this secret."
48 Then the king made Daniel great.
He gave him many great gifts.
He made him ruler over the whole province of Babylon
and the chief governor over all the wise men of Babylon.
49 Daniel made a request to the king.
So the king put Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego
in charge of the business of the province of Babylon.

But Daniel stayed at the king's gate.
That means: He served at the king's court.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The most powerful king in the world falls down before a young captive. And he confesses: "Your God is the God of gods and the Lord of kings."

The text does not say whether Daniel accepted the worship. But the king understands: The honor really belongs to Daniel's God.

Verse 49: Daniel does not forget his friends. He makes sure that they also get important positions.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 3

The three men in the fiery furnace

The golden statue VERSES 1–7

1 King Nebuchadnezzar made a statue of gold.
It was 60 cubits high, that is about 90 feet.
It was six cubits wide, that is about 9 feet.
He set it up on the plain of Dura in the province of Babylon.

2 Then King Nebuchadnezzar sent messengers
to gather the local governors, the deputies, and the governors,
the judges, the treasurers, the advisers, the sheriffs,
and all the rulers of the provinces.
They were to come to the dedication of the statue
that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.
A dedication is a celebration where something is given its special purpose.

3 So the local governors, the deputies, and the governors,
the judges, the treasurers, the advisers, the sheriffs,
and all the rulers of the provinces gathered
for the dedication of the statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.
And they stood in front of the statue
that Nebuchadnezzar had set up.

4 Then the herald called out loudly.
A herald is a man who announces the king's orders.
He said, "Peoples, nations, and people of every language,
this is your order:

5 As soon as you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre,
harp, pipe, and all kinds of music,
you must fall down and worship the golden statue
that King Nebuchadnezzar has set up.

6 Whoever does not fall down and worship
will be thrown that same hour
into the middle of a burning, fiery furnace."
A furnace is a very large oven.

7 So at that time,
as soon as all the peoples heard the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre,
harp, pipe, and all kinds of music,
all the peoples, nations, and people of every language fell down.
They worshiped the golden statue
that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nebuchadnezzar has a huge golden statue built: 60 cubits high (about 90 feet) and only 6 cubits wide. So it was more like a pillar or an obelisk, maybe only covered with gold. A cubit is about 18 inches.

Maybe the king misunderstood his dream from Chapter 2: There, only the head was made of gold. Now he makes the whole statue of gold, as if he wanted to say: My kingdom will last forever.

The many repetitions (again and again the list of officials and the list of instruments) seem almost funny. They show how boastful and bureaucratic this power is.

Verse 6: Anyone who does not go along is killed. A dictatorship that demands the same worship from everyone.

In the 20th century, Christians and Jews under dictatorships (for example, under the Nazis) read this chapter as encouragement not to bow down.

The accusation VERSES 8–12

8 So at that time, some Chaldeans came forward
and accused the Jews.

9 They said to King Nebuchadnezzar,
"O king, live forever!

10 O king, you have given an order:
Everyone who hears the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre,
harp, pipe, and all kinds of music
must fall down and worship the golden statue.

11 And whoever does not fall down and worship
will be thrown into the middle of a burning, fiery furnace.

12 There are some Jews whom you put in charge of the business of the province of Babylon:
Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.
These men, O king, have not respected you.
They do not serve your gods.
And they do not worship the golden statue
that you have set up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jealous officials use the chance to get rid of their successful Jewish colleagues. They stress: "There are some Jews whom you put in charge …"

Here we see how hatred against a minority often grows out of jealousy and the hunger for power. Sadly, hatred of Jews has a long and terrible history, up to today. This text clearly takes the side of those who are persecuted.

"But if not …" VERSES 13–18

13 Then Nebuchadnezzar became angry and furious.
He ordered that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego be

brought.
So these men were brought to the king.
14 Nebuchadnezzar said to them,
"Is it true, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,
that you do not serve my gods
and do not worship the golden statue that I have set up?
15 Now, when you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre,
harp, pipe, and all kinds of music,
if you are ready to fall down and worship the statue that I have made, good.
But if you do not worship,
you will be thrown that same hour
into the middle of a burning, fiery furnace.
And who is the god who can rescue you from my hands?"
16 Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego answered the king,
"Nebuchadnezzar, we do not need
to answer you in this matter.
17 If it happens,
our God whom we serve is able to rescue us from the burning, fiery furnace.
And he will rescue us from your hand, O king.
18 But if not,
you should know, O king,
that we will not serve your gods
or worship the golden statue that you have set up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The king gives them a second chance, and he challenges God: "Who is the god who can rescue you from my hands?"

Verses 17–18: One of the bravest answers in the Bible: "Our God whom we serve is able to rescue us from the burning, fiery furnace … But if not, you should know, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden statue that you have set up."

That is real faith: It does not depend on whether God solves the problem. The three trust God, even though they do not know how it will end. They are ready to die for what they believe.

Many people have drawn strength from this "But if not…", for example when they stood up against injustice.

In the fiery furnace VERSES 19–23

19 Then Nebuchadnezzar was full of fury.
The look on his face changed toward Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.
He gave an order
to heat the furnace seven times hotter than usual.
20 He ordered some strong men in his army
to tie up Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego
and to throw them into the burning, fiery furnace.
21 So these men were tied up
in their pants, their tunics, their cloaks, and their other clothes.
And they were thrown into the middle of the burning, fiery furnace.
22 The king's order was urgent,
and the furnace was extremely hot.
So the flames of the fire killed the men
who carried Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego up.
23 These three men, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,
fell, tied up, into the middle of the burning, fiery furnace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In his rage, the king loses all good sense. He has the furnace heated so much that even his own soldiers die. Blind rage also destroys your own people.

Note: In Catholic and Orthodox Bibles, there is a longer section after verse 23: the prayer of Azariah and the song of praise of the three men in the furnace. It has come down to us only in Greek and is not in the Hebrew-Aramaic Bible. The WEB does not include it here.

The fourth man in the fire VERSES 24–27

24 Then King Nebuchadnezzar was amazed.
He quickly stood up.
He said to his advisers,
"Didn't we throw three men, tied up, into the middle of the fire?"
They answered the king,
"That is true, O king."
25 He answered,
"Look! I see four men walking around free in the middle of the fire.
And they are not hurt.
And the fourth one looks like a son of the gods."
26 Then Nebuchadnezzar came near to the opening of the burning, fiery furnace.
He said,
"Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego,
servants of the Most High God,
come out! Come here!"
Then Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego came out of the middle of the fire.
27 The local governors, the deputies, the governors, and the king's advisers
gathered and looked at these men.
The fire had had no power over their bodies.
The hair on their heads was not burned.
Their pants had not changed.
There was not even the smell of fire on them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Suddenly the king sees four men in the fire, free and unhurt. The ropes are burned, but not the men.

Verse 25: Who is the fourth? The king says: "The fourth one looks like a son of the gods." Later he calls him an "angel" (verse 28). Many Christians have seen in the fourth man an appearance of Christ. In Judaism, he is usually understood as an angel of God.

The most important message: God was with them in the fire. He did not keep them from the fire, but he kept them safe in the fire. Compare Isaiah 43:2. There God promises: When you walk through the fire, you will not be burned.

Verse 27: Not even the smell of smoke! The rescue is complete.

The king praises the God of the three men VERSES 28–30

28 Nebuchadnezzar said,
"Praise be to the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego!
He has sent his angel
and rescued his servants

who trusted in him.
They went against the king's word.
They were ready to give up their bodies
so that they would not serve or worship any god except their own God.
29 So I give this order:
Any people, nation, or people of any language
that says anything evil against the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego
will be cut to pieces.
And their houses will be turned into piles of garbage.
For there is no other god who can rescue like this."
30 Then the king gave Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego higher positions
in the province of Babylon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king praises God. He admits: These men risked their lives to stay faithful to their God.

Verse 29: But the king has not really understood yet. Now he threatens the same violence, only in the other direction. Faith cannot be forced by threats. God does not need violence to protect him.

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, the first three verses of the next chapter (in the WEB 4:1–3) still belong to Chapter 3 (as 3:31–33).

For today: All over the world, people are persecuted because of their faith. This chapter encourages us to stay faithful. And it reminds us to stand up for freedom of religion for all people.

DANIEL

Chapter 4

The pride of Nebuchadnezzar

A letter from the king VERSES 1–3

1 From King Nebuchadnezzar
to all the peoples, nations, and people of every language
who live in the whole earth:
May you have more and more peace!
2 I am glad to tell you
about the signs and wonders
that the Most High God has done for me.
3 How great are his signs!
How mighty are his wonders!
His kingdom is a kingdom that lasts forever.
His rule goes on from generation to generation.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, these three verses are at the end of Chapter 3 (3:31–33). That is why the verse numbers in this chapter of the WEB are three higher than in many other Bibles. We follow the numbering of the WEB.

An unusual chapter: It is a letter that the pagan King Nebuchadnezzar himself writes to the whole world. Pagan means: He believed in other gods. He tells how God humbled him and then raised him up again. At the beginning and at the end, he praises God.

The dream of the great tree VERSES 4–18

4 I, Nebuchadnezzar, was living in peace in my house.
Things were going well for me in my palace.
5 Then I had a dream that made me afraid.
The thoughts I had on my bed
and the visions in my head frightened me.
6 So I gave an order
to bring all the wise men of Babylon to me,
so that they would tell me what the dream means.
7 Then the magicians, the enchanters, the Chaldeans, and the fortune-tellers came in.
I told them the dream,
but they could not tell me what it means.
8 But at last Daniel came to me.
His name is Belteshazzar, after the name of my god.
The spirit of the holy gods is in him.
I told him the dream.
I said,
9 "Belteshazzar, chief of the magicians,
I know that the spirit of the holy gods is in you,
and that no secret is too hard for you.
Tell me the visions of the dream I have seen,
and tell me what it means.
10 These were the visions in my head as I lay on my bed:
I looked, and I saw a tree in the middle of the earth.
It was very tall.
11 The tree grew and became strong.
It was so tall that it reached up to the sky.
It could be seen to the ends of the whole earth.
12 Its leaves were beautiful,
and it had a lot of fruit.
There was food on it for everyone.
The animals of the field found shade under it.
The birds of the sky lived in its branches.
And every living creature was fed from it.
13 "As I lay on my bed, I saw in the visions in my head
a holy watcher coming down from the sky.
14 He called out loudly,
'Cut down the tree!
Cut off its branches!
Shake off its leaves,
and scatter its fruit!
Let the animals run away from under it
and the birds from its branches.
15 But leave the stump with its roots in the earth,
with a band of iron and bronze around it,
in the soft grass of the field.
Let it get wet with the dew of the sky.
Let him have his share with the animals in the grass of the earth.
16 Let his heart be changed
so that it is no longer a human heart.
Let him be given the heart of an animal.
Then let seven times pass over him.

17 "'This sentence was decided by the watchers.
The decision comes from the word of the holy ones.
It is so that the living may know
that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of human beings.
He gives them to whomever he wants.
He even puts the lowest of people over them.'
18 "This is the dream that I, King Nebuchadnezzar, have seen.
Now you, Belteshazzar, tell me what it means.
For all the wise men of my kingdom cannot tell me what it means.
But you can,
for the spirit of the holy gods is in you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In his dream, the king sees a huge tree that reaches up to the sky and gives shade and food to all living creatures. Then a "holy watcher," an angel, calls out that it should be cut down. Only the stump stays, with a band of metal.

Verse 13: A watcher is an angel who keeps watch.

Verse 16: Suddenly the tree becomes a "him": The tree is a human being, and he is to be given the heart of an animal.

"Seven times" are probably seven years, or simply a complete, long time.

Verse 17: That is the theme: Everyone should know "that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of human beings." God can even make the lowest person a ruler.

Verses 8–9: Nebuchadnezzar believes in other gods. So he speaks of "the spirit of the holy gods." He still understands God within his own view of the world.

Daniel explains the dream VERSES 19–27

19 Then Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar, could not speak for a while.
His thoughts frightened him.
The king said,
"Belteshazzar, do not let the dream or its meaning frighten you."
Belteshazzar answered,
"My lord, I wish the dream were for those who hate you,
and its meaning for your enemies.
20 You saw the tree
that grew and became strong.
It was so tall that it reached up to the sky.
It could be seen over the whole earth.
21 Its leaves were beautiful, and it had a lot of fruit.
There was food on it for everyone.
The animals of the field lived under it.
The birds of the sky had their homes in its branches.
22 O king, that tree is you.
You have grown and become strong.
Your greatness has grown and reaches up to the sky.
Your rule reaches to the end of the earth.
23 "The king saw a holy watcher coming down from the sky.
He said,
'Cut down the tree and destroy it.
But leave the stump with its roots in the earth,
with a band of iron and bronze around it, in the soft grass of the field.
Let it get wet with the dew of the sky.
Let him have his share with the animals of the field,
until seven times pass over him.'
24 "O king, this is what it means.
It is a decision of the Most High
that has come upon my lord the king:
25 You will be driven away from people.
You will live with the animals of the field.
You will be made to eat grass like cattle.
You will get wet with the dew of the sky.
Seven times will pass over you,
until you know that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of human beings
and gives them to whomever he wants.
26 It was ordered that the stump of the tree with its roots be left.
So your kingdom will be given back to you
after you learn that Heaven rules.
27 So, O king, please accept my advice:
Stop sinning, and do what is right.
Stop your evil deeds, and show mercy to the poor.
Then maybe your peace will last longer."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Daniel is frightened. He likes the king and does not wish him any harm. He says honestly: "My lord, I wish the dream were for those who hate you, and its meaning for your enemies." Daniel is not a cold prophet of doom.

Verse 26: The stump stays. That is the hope: After he has been humbled, the king will get his kingdom back.

Verse 27: Daniel gives the king brave advice: "Stop sinning, and do what is right. Stop your evil deeds, and show mercy to the poor." Doing what is right and helping the poor are the way to turn back to God, for every person, also for the powerful.

"Heaven rules" (verse 26) – here "Heaven" stands for God. Later, in Judaism, people often said "Heaven" instead of "God" out of deep respect (compare "the kingdom of heaven" in Matthew).

It comes true VERSES 28–33

28 All this happened to King Nebuchadnezzar.
29 After 12 months, he was walking around in the royal palace of Babylon.
30 The king said,
"Isn't this great Babylon?
I have built it as a royal home
by my own great power
and for the glory of my majesty."
31 The words were still in the king's mouth
when a voice came from the sky,
"King Nebuchadnezzar, this is said to you:
'The kingdom has been taken away from you.
32 You will be driven away from people.
You will live with the animals of the field.
You will be made to eat grass like cattle.
Seven times will pass over you,
until you know that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of human beings
and gives them to whomever he wants.'"
33 That same hour, it happened to Nebuchadnezzar.
He was driven away from people.
He ate grass like cattle.
His body got wet with the dew of the sky,

until his hair had grown long like eagles' feathers,
and his nails like birds' claws.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God gives the king a whole year to turn back. But the king changes nothing.

Verse 30: The king is on the roof of his palace. He looks out over his splendid city and says: "Isn't this great Babylon? I have built it as a royal home by my own great power and for the glory of my majesty." He talks only about himself: I, my power, my majesty. Babylon really was splendid, with the famous Ishtar Gate and many palaces.

Verses 31–33: At exactly this moment of pride, he falls deeply. He loses his mind and lives like an animal.

Some interpreters think of a rare mental illness in which people believe they are animals. Others connect the story with the last Babylonian king, Nabonidus, who lived for many years in the desert, far away from Babylon. Either way: The text shows how fragile human power is, and also the human mind.

Important: Mental illnesses are not a punishment from God. People who are mentally ill need help and understanding, not blame.

The king praises the Most High VERSES 34–37

34 At the end of that time, I, Nebuchadnezzar, looked up
to heaven,
and my mind came back to me.
I praised the Most High.
I praised and honored him who lives forever.
For his rule lasts forever,
and his kingdom goes on from generation to
generation.

35 All the people who live on the earth are counted as
nothing.
He does what he wants with the army of heaven
and with the people who live on the earth.
No one can stop his hand
or say to him, "What are you doing?"

36 At that same time, my mind came back to me.
For the glory of my kingdom,
my majesty and my splendor came back to me.
My advisers and my nobles came looking for me.
I was set up again over my kingdom,
and I was given even greater power.

37 Now I, Nebuchadnezzar, praise, lift up, and honor
the King of heaven.
For everything he does is true,
and his ways are just.
And he is able to bring down
those who walk in pride.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 34: That is the turning point. The king tells: "I, Nebuchadnezzar, looked up to heaven, and my mind came back to me." That means: At the moment he looks up and accepts God, he becomes healthy again.

Verse 37: At the end, the most powerful king in the world praises the "King of heaven." And he has learned: "He is able to bring down those who walk in pride."

The message: God can humble even the most powerful. But he does it so that they come to understand, not to destroy them. God gives even the proud king a second chance.

Compare Proverbs 16:18. There it says that pride comes before destruction, and a proud spirit comes before a fall. And Luke 1:52 says that God brings down rulers from their thrones and lifts up the lowly.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 5

The writing on the wall

Belshazzar's feast VERSES 1–4

1 King Belshazzar gave a great feast for 1,000 of his
nobles.
He drank wine in front of the 1,000.

2 While Belshazzar was tasting the wine,
he gave an order to bring the gold and silver cups and
bowls
that his father Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the
temple in Jerusalem.
He wanted the king and his nobles,
his wives and his concubines to drink from them.
Concubines are women who live with a man like
wives, but with fewer rights.

3 So they brought the gold cups and bowls
that had been taken from the temple, the house of God
in Jerusalem.
And the king and his nobles,
his wives and his concubines drank from them.

4 They drank wine
and praised the gods made of gold and silver,
of bronze, iron, wood, and stone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Belshazzar was the last king of Babylon. He holds a great feast, even though (as we know from other sources) the Persians were already outside the city.

Verse 2: The text calls Nebuchadnezzar Belshazzar's "father." According to Babylonian inscriptions, Belshazzar was the son of King Nabonidus and ruled in Babylon in his place. But in the Bible, "father" can also mean "the king before him" or "ancestor."

Verses 3–4: Belshazzar drinks from the holy cups of the temple and praises idols while he does it. He is mocking the God of Israel on purpose.

The hand writes on the wall VERSES 5–9

5 At that very hour, the fingers of a human hand
appeared.
They wrote on the plaster of the wall of the king's
palace,
near the lampstand.
And the king saw the part of the hand that was
writing.

6 Then the king's face turned pale.
His thoughts frightened him.

His legs became weak,
and his knees knocked together.
7 The king shouted
for them to bring in the enchanters, the Chaldeans,
and the fortune-tellers.
The king said to the wise men of Babylon,
"Whoever reads this writing and tells me what it
means
will be dressed in purple
and will wear a gold chain around his neck.
He will be the third ruler in the kingdom."
Purple clothes were a sign of high honor.
8 Then all the king's wise men came in.
But they could not read the writing,
and they could not tell the king what it means.
9 Then King Belshazzar was very frightened.
His face turned pale,
and his nobles did not know what to do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the feast, a hand appears and writes on the wall. Suddenly the reckless king turns pale and shakes.

To this day, people say "the writing is on the wall" when they mean a clear warning sign.

Verse 7: "The third ruler in the kingdom" – this fits history exactly: Nabonidus was the first, Belshazzar the second. The third place was the highest place that Belshazzar could give away.

The queen reminds the king of Daniel VERSES 10–16

10 The queen heard what the king and his nobles were
saying.
So she came into the banquet hall.
The queen said,
"O king, live forever!
Do not let your thoughts frighten you.
Do not let your face turn pale.
11 There is a man in your kingdom
who has the spirit of the holy gods in him.
In the days of your father,
he was found to have light, understanding, and
wisdom, like the wisdom of the gods.
King Nebuchadnezzar, your father,
yes, the king, your father,
made him chief of the magicians, enchanters,
Chaldeans, and fortune-tellers.
12 For this Daniel,
whom the king named Belteshazzar,
was found to have an excellent spirit,
knowledge, and understanding.
He could explain dreams,
make riddles clear,
and solve hard problems.
Now call Daniel,
and he will tell you what it means."
13 Then Daniel was brought to the king.
The king said to Daniel,
"Are you that Daniel, one of the captives from Judah
whom the king, my father, brought from Judah?
14 I have heard about you,
that the spirit of the gods is in you,
and that you have light, understanding, and excellent
wisdom.
15 The wise men, the enchanters, have just been brought
to me
to read this writing and tell me what it means.
But they could not tell me what the matter means.
16 But I have heard about you,
that you can explain things and solve hard problems.
If you can read the writing and tell me what it means,
you will be dressed in purple
and will wear a gold chain around your neck.
You will be the third ruler in the kingdom."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "queen" is probably the queen mother. She remembers Daniel, whom the young king had obviously forgotten. By now, Daniel is an old man, over 80 years old.

A wise woman saves the situation. She keeps a clear head while the men do not know what to do.

Verse 12: "Solve hard problems" means: answer difficult questions and riddles. The WEB says "dissolving of doubts."

Daniel preaches to the king VERSES 17–24

17 Then Daniel answered the king,
"Keep your gifts for yourself,
and give your rewards to someone else.
But I will read the writing to the king
and tell him what it means.
18 "O king, the Most High God gave Nebuchadnezzar,
your father,
the kingdom, greatness, glory, and majesty.
19 Because of the greatness that God gave him,
all the peoples, nations, and people of every language
trembled with fear before him.
He killed whomever he wanted to kill,
and he let live whomever he wanted to let live.
He raised up whomever he wanted to raise up,
and he brought down whomever he wanted to bring
down.
20 But his heart became proud,
and his spirit became hard, so that he acted with pride.
Then he was removed from his royal throne,
and his glory was taken away from him.
21 He was driven away from people.
His heart was made like the heart of an animal.
He lived with the wild donkeys.
He was fed grass like cattle.
His body got wet with the dew of the sky,
until he knew that the Most High God rules over the
kingdoms of human beings
and puts over them whomever he wants.
22 "But you, his son Belshazzar,
have not humbled your heart,
even though you knew all this.
23 Instead, you have set yourself up against the Lord of
heaven.
The cups and bowls of his house were brought to you.
You and your nobles, your wives and your concubines
drank wine from them.
You praised the gods made of silver and gold,
of bronze, iron, wood, and stone.
They cannot see or hear or know anything.
But you have not honored the God
who holds your breath in his hand
and to whom all your ways belong.

24 That is why he sent the hand,
and this writing was written.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Daniel does not want any gifts. He cannot be bought.

Verses 18–21: Daniel reminds the king of the story of Nebuchadnezzar in Chapter 4: Even the greatest king was humbled until he accepted God.

Verse 22: The heaviest accusation: "But you, his son Belshazzar, have not humbled your heart, even though you knew all this." Belshazzar knew the story, but he learned nothing from it.

Verse 23: A strong contrast: Belshazzar praises gods that "cannot see or hear or know anything." But he does not honor the God "who holds your breath in his hand." Every breath is a gift from God.

Mene, mene, tekel, upharsin VERSES 25–31

25 "This is the writing that was written:
'MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN.'
26 "This is what it means:
MENE: God has counted the days of your kingdom
and brought it to an end.
27 TEKEL: You have been weighed on the scales
and found too light.
28 PERES: Your kingdom is divided
and given to the Medes and Persians."
29 Then Belshazzar gave an order.
They dressed Daniel in purple
and put a gold chain around his neck.
And they announced
that he would be the third ruler in the kingdom.
30 That same night, Belshazzar, the Chaldean king, was killed.
31 And Darius the Mede received the kingdom.
He was about 62 years old.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The four words are Aramaic names of weights (mina, shekel, half a mina). At the same time, they sound like verbs:

– MENE = "counted": Your days as king are counted.

– TEKEL = "weighed": You have been weighed and found too light.

– PERES (the singular of "parsin"; the "u" in "upharsin" means "and") = "divided," and it sounds like "Paras" = Persia.

Verse 30: That same night, Belshazzar dies. In the year 539 BC, the Persians under Cyrus conquered Babylon. Greek historians report that the city was taken during a feast.

Verse 31: To this day, it is not clear who "Darius the Mede" was exactly. He is not known by this name in other sources. Some think of a governor under Cyrus (for example, Gubaru). Others think it is another name for Cyrus himself.

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, verse 31 is already the first verse of Chapter 6.

The message: Every person, every ruler too, will one day be "weighed." What counts in the end? Not power and wealth, but whether we have honored God and done what is right.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 6

Daniel in the lions' den

A plot against Daniel VERSES 1–9

1 Darius decided
to put 120 local governors over the kingdom.
They were to be all over the kingdom.
2 Over them he put three officials,
and Daniel was one of them.
The local governors were to report to them,
so that the king would not lose anything.
3 This Daniel stood out above the other officials and the local governors,
because there was an excellent spirit in him.
And the king thought about putting him over the whole kingdom.
4 Then the officials and the local governors looked for a reason to accuse Daniel
in the way he did his work for the kingdom.
But they could not find any reason or any fault,
because he was faithful.
No mistake and no fault was found in him.
5 Then these men said,
"We will not find any reason to accuse this Daniel,
unless we find it in the law of his God."
6 So these officials and local governors went together to the king.
They said to him,
"King Darius, live forever!
7 All the officials of the kingdom,
the deputies and the local governors,
the advisers and the governors,
have talked together.
They want you to make a royal law and a strict order:
For 30 days, whoever asks anything of any god or any human being,
except of you, O king,
will be thrown into the lions' den.
8 Now, O king, make this order
and sign the document,
so that it cannot be changed.
That is the law of the Medes and Persians,
which cannot be changed."
9 So King Darius signed the document and the order.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, the verse numbers in this chapter are one higher (6:2–29), because there 5:31 is already counted as 6:1.

By now, Daniel is an old man, and again he has a high position, this time under the new Persian Empire. He is so good and honest that his colleagues become jealous.

Verse 4: High praise: They do not find a single fault in Daniel. He does not take bribes. He is not lazy and not

dishonest.

Verse 5: So they look for his only "weak spot": his faith. They know that Daniel will stay faithful to God, no matter what happens.

Verses 7–8: They flatter the king and get him to make a law that can no longer be changed. The king does not notice that he is being used.

Daniel keeps praying VERSES 10–15

10 Daniel learned that the document had been signed.
Then he went into his house.
In his room, the windows were open toward Jerusalem.
Three times a day he knelt down on his knees.
He prayed and gave thanks to his God,
just as he had done before.
11 Then these men came together.
They found Daniel praying and asking his God for help.
12 Then they went to the king
and spoke to him about the king's order:
"Didn't you sign an order
that for 30 days, anyone who asks anything of any god or any human being,
except of you, O king,
will be thrown into the lions' den?"
The king answered,
"That is true.
It is the law of the Medes and Persians,
which cannot be changed."
13 Then they said to the king,
"That Daniel, one of the captives from Judah,
does not respect you, O king,
or the order that you have signed.
He still prays three times a day."
14 When the king heard these words,
he was very upset.
He set his heart on saving Daniel.
Until the sun went down, he worked hard to rescue him.
15 Then these men went together to the king.
They said to the king,
"You know, O king,
that it is a law of the Medes and Persians
that no order or law that the king makes
may be changed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Daniel does not change his habit. He keeps praying three times a day, with his windows open toward Jerusalem, "just as he had done before." He does not make a show of it, but he does not hide either.

Praying toward Jerusalem reminds us of Solomon's prayer (1 Kings 8:48). To this day, Jews pray toward Jerusalem. And praying three times a day is still part of Jewish life today (compare Psalm 55:17).

Verse 14: The king likes Daniel and tries all day to rescue him. But he is trapped by his own law. Even the most powerful man is powerless against an unjust law that he made himself.

In the lions' den VERSES 16–18

16 Then the king gave the order.
They brought Daniel and threw him into the lions' den.
The king said to Daniel,
"Your God, whom you serve all the time,
will rescue you."
17 A stone was brought
and put over the opening of the den.
The king sealed it with his own signet ring
and with the signet rings of his nobles.
A signet ring is a ring with a stamp, used like a signature.
That way, nothing could be changed in Daniel's case.
18 Then the king went to his palace.
He spent the night without eating.
No musical instruments were brought to him,
and he could not sleep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: The king believes in other gods, but he hopes that Daniel's God will rescue him.

Verse 17: The den is closed with a stone and sealed. For Christians, this is a reminder of the tomb of Jesus. It was also closed with a stone and sealed (Matthew 27:66).

Verse 18: The king cannot sleep. He fasts and worries. Fasting means: not eating for a time.

God shut the lions' mouths VERSES 19–24

19 Then the king got up very early in the morning.
He hurried to the lions' den.
20 When he came near the den where Daniel was,
he called out with a worried voice.
The king said to Daniel,
"Daniel, servant of the living God,
has your God, whom you serve all the time,
been able to rescue you from the lions?"
21 Then Daniel said to the king,
"O king, live forever!
22 My God has sent his angel,
and he has shut the lions' mouths.
They have not hurt me,
because God found me innocent.
And I have not done anything wrong to you either, O king."
23 Then the king was very glad.
He ordered that Daniel be lifted out of the den.
So Daniel was lifted out of the den.
No injury of any kind was found on him,
because he had trusted in his God.
24 Then the king gave an order.
They brought the men who had accused Daniel.
And they threw them into the lions' den,
them, their children, and their wives.
The lions attacked them
and crushed all their bones
even before they reached the bottom of the den.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the morning, the king calls out, full of fear. And Daniel answers calmly: "My God has sent his angel, and he has shut the lions' mouths."

Verse 23: The reason for the rescue: "because he had trusted in his God." Compare Hebrews 11:33. There it says about people who trusted God: "Through faith they … stopped the mouths of lions."

Verse 24: This verse is very shocking. The king punishes not only the accusers, but also their innocent wives and children. That was the cruel custom of some rulers at that time. The Bible reports it, but it does not approve of it. God's law says clearly that fathers must not be put to death for their children, and children must not be put to death for their fathers (Deuteronomy 24:16; compare Ezekiel 18:20). Punishing children for what their parents did is wrong.

The king praises Daniel's God VERSES 25–28

25 Then King Darius wrote
to all the peoples, nations, and people of every language
who live in the whole earth:
"May you have more and more peace!
26 "I give this order:
In every part of my kingdom,
people must tremble and fear before the God of Daniel.
"For he is the living God.
He stands firm forever.
His kingdom will never be destroyed.
His rule will last to the very end.
27 He saves and rescues.
He does signs and wonders in heaven and on earth.
He has rescued Daniel from the power of the lions."
28 So this Daniel did well
during the rule of Darius
and during the rule of Cyrus the Persian.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like Nebuchadnezzar in Chapters 3 and 4, now the Persian king also praises the God of Israel: "He is the living God." "He saves and rescues."

Here the first part of the book ends, the part with the stories. The message of all six chapters: God is faithful to those who are faithful to him, even in a foreign, hostile place. And his kingdom is greater than all the kingdoms of the world.

For today: All over the world, people are persecuted and thrown into prison because of their faith. Daniel's story encourages us to stay faithful. And it reminds us to stand up for freedom of religion for all people.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 7

Four animals and the Son of Man

Four animals come up out of the sea VERSES 1–8

1 In the first year that Belshazzar was king of Babylon,
Daniel had a dream.
He saw visions in his head as he lay on his bed.
Then he wrote down the dream
and told the main points of it.
2 Daniel said,
"I looked in my vision at night,
and I saw the four winds of the sky
stirring up the great sea.
3 Four great animals came up out of the sea.
Each one was different from the others.
4 "The first was like a lion,
and it had the wings of an eagle.
As I watched, its wings were pulled off.
It was lifted up from the ground
and made to stand on two feet like a human being.
And it was given a human heart.
5 "Then I saw another animal, a second one.
It looked like a bear.
It was raised up on one side.
It had three ribs in its mouth between its teeth.
It was told,
'Get up! Eat a lot of meat!'
6 "After this I looked,
and I saw another animal. It looked like a leopard.
On its back it had four wings like a bird.
The animal also had four heads.
And it was given power to rule.
7 "After this I looked in the visions at night,
and I saw a fourth animal.
It was terrifying, powerful, and very strong.
It had large iron teeth.
It ate and crushed its victims,
and it stamped on what was left with its feet.
It was different from all the animals before it.
It had 10 horns.
8 "I was thinking about the horns.
Then I saw another horn come up among them, a little one.
Three of the first horns were pulled out by the roots to make room for it.
This horn had eyes like the eyes of a human being
and a mouth that spoke proudly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Chapter 7, the second part of the book begins: Daniel's own visions. They are full of strange pictures, like a nightmare. Texts like this are called "apocalyptic" (from a Greek word that means "revealing"): They show in pictures what is going on behind history.

The "great sea" stands for chaos and unrest. Out of this chaos come four wild animals: a lion with wings, a bear, a leopard with four heads, and a terrible fourth animal with iron teeth and 10 horns.

The animals are like the four metals of the statue in Chapter 2: four world empires. Here, world empires are shown as beasts of prey, dangerous and greedy.

In the Bible, horns are a picture of power and of kings.

Verse 8: The little horn with human eyes and a big mouth is an especially proud ruler.

The Ancient of Days on the throne VERSES 9–12

9 "As I watched,
thrones were set in place,
and one who was the Ancient of Days sat down.
His clothes were as white as snow.
The hair on his head was like pure wool.
His throne was flames of fire,
and its wheels were burning fire.

10 A river of fire flowed out from in front of him.
Thousands and thousands served him.
10,000 times 10,000 stood in front of him.
The court sat down to judge,
and the books were opened.
11 "Then I kept watching because of the proud words
that the horn was speaking.
I watched until the animal was killed.
Its body was destroyed
and thrown into the fire to be burned.
12 The power of the other animals was taken away.
But they were allowed to live a while longer,
for a set time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Suddenly the scene changes: a courtroom in heaven. God himself sits on the throne. He is called "the Ancient of Days" (that means: the one who is very old), because he is eternal. His white hair and clothes stand for wisdom and purity.

The throne has wheels of fire, like the throne chariot in Ezekiel (Ezekiel 1).

Verse 10: Countless angels serve him. "The court sat down to judge, and the books were opened." That means: God judges what the powerful have done.

Verse 11: The fourth animal with the proud horn is destroyed. God's judgment ends the rule of violence.

One like a son of man VERSES 13–14

13 "I looked in the visions at night,
and I saw one like a son of man
coming with the clouds of the sky.
He came to the Ancient of Days,
and he was brought to him.
14 He was given power to rule, glory, and a kingdom,
so that all the peoples, nations, and people of every
language would serve him.
His rule is a rule that lasts forever.
It will never pass away.
And his kingdom will never be destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important verses in the whole Bible!

After the wild animals out of the sea, now comes "one like a son of man," that is, like a human being. And he does not come out of the sea, but with the clouds of the sky. The animal kingdoms are violent. The kingdom of this "human being" is humane, and it comes from God. It will never pass away.

Who is this "son of man"?

– Verses 18 and 27 say that "the saints of the Most High" receive the kingdom. That is why many Jewish interpreters understand the son of man as a picture of God's faithful people.

– Other Jewish interpreters, already in ancient times, saw in him the Messiah.

– In the New Testament, Jesus calls himself the "Son of Man" again and again. Before the high council, he says: "You will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of Power and coming with the clouds of the sky" (Mark 14:62). For Christians, Jesus is this Son of Man.

The meaning VERSES 15–28

15 "As for me, Daniel, my spirit was troubled inside me.
The visions in my head frightened me.
16 I went to one of those who were standing there.
I asked him what all this really meant.
"So he told me
and explained to me what these things mean:
17 'These four great animals
are four kings who will rise from the earth.
18 But the saints of the Most High will receive the
kingdom.
They will have the kingdom forever,
yes, forever and ever.'
19 "Then I wanted to know the truth about the fourth
animal.
It was different from all the others
and very terrifying.
Its teeth were made of iron, and its claws of bronze.
It ate and crushed its victims,
and it stamped on what was left with its feet.
20 I also wanted to know about the 10 horns on its head,
and about the other horn that came up.
Three horns fell to make room for it.
That horn had eyes
and a mouth that spoke proudly,
and it looked bigger than the others.
21 As I watched,
this horn made war against the saints
and defeated them,
22 until the Ancient of Days came.
Then judgment was given in favor of the saints of the
Most High.
And the time came when the saints took over the
kingdom.
23 "He said,
'The fourth animal will be a fourth kingdom on earth.
It will be different from all the other kingdoms.
It will eat up the whole earth.
It will trample it down and crush it.
24 As for the 10 horns:
10 kings will rise out of this kingdom.
After them, another king will rise.
He will be different from the kings before him.
And he will bring down three kings.
25 He will speak words against the Most High.
He will wear down the saints of the Most High.
He will plan to change the times and the law.
And the saints will be handed over to him
for a time, and times, and half a time.
26 "'But the court will sit down to judge.
His power will be taken away from him.
It will be completely wiped out and destroyed forever.
27 Then the kingdom and the power to rule
and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole
sky
will be given to the people of the saints of the Most
High.
His kingdom is a kingdom that lasts forever.
And all rulers will serve him and obey him.'
28 "This is the end of the matter.
As for me, Daniel, my thoughts frightened me very
much,
and my face turned pale.
But I kept the matter in my heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An angel explains: The four animals are four kingdoms. But in the end, "the saints of the Most High" receive the kingdom that lasts forever.

Verse 18: Saints are people who belong to God.

Verse 25: The proud ruler (the little horn) persecutes the believers. He plans "to change the times and the law." That means: He wants to get rid of God's feasts and commandments.

"A time, and times, and half a time" is probably three and a half years (1 + 2 + ½), a limited time of suffering. The persecution has an end.

Who is the little horn?

– Many interpreters think of King Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–164 BC). He forbade the Jews to keep the Sabbath and to circumcise their sons, and he made the temple in Jerusalem unclean. After about three and a half years, the temple was dedicated to God again (Jews still celebrate this today at the feast of Hanukkah).

– Others, especially in the Christian tradition, take the fourth animal as Rome and the little horn as an enemy of God at the end of time.

Important: Again and again, people have tried to apply these pictures to persons or countries of their own time, often with wrong results. The main message is clear and comforting: Even the worst tyrants have only a limited time. God's kingdom will come and will last.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 8

The ram and the male goat

The vision by the Ulai River VERSES 1–8

1 In the third year that King Belshazzar ruled,
I, Daniel, saw a vision.
It came after the vision that I had seen at first.
2 I saw the vision.
In the vision, I was in the fortress of Susa,
which is in the province of Elam.
I saw in the vision
that I was by the Ulai River.
3 Then I looked up,
and I saw a ram with two horns standing beside the river.
A ram is a male sheep.
The two horns were long,
but one was longer than the other.
The longer one grew up last.
4 I saw the ram charging toward the west, the north, and the south.
No animal could stand against him.
No one could rescue anyone from his power.
He did whatever he wanted,
and he made himself great.
5 As I was thinking about this,
I saw a male goat coming from the west.
He crossed the whole earth
without touching the ground.
The goat had one large horn between his eyes.
6 He came to the ram with the two horns,
which I had seen standing beside the river.
He ran at him with all his furious strength.
7 I saw him come close to the ram.
He was very angry with him.
He struck the ram
and broke his two horns.
The ram had no strength to stand against him.
The goat threw him to the ground
and trampled on him.
And no one could rescue the ram from his power.
8 The male goat made himself very great.
But when he was at his strongest, the great horn was broken.
In its place, four large horns grew up.
They pointed toward the four winds of the sky.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

From Chapter 8 on, the book is written in Hebrew again.

In a vision, Daniel sees himself in Susa, which later became the capital of the Persian Empire (in today's Iran).

Here, the meaning is given in the text itself (verses 20–21): The ram with two horns is the kingdom of the Medes and Persians. The longer horn that grew later is Persia, which became stronger than Media.

The male goat from the west is Greece. He is so fast that he does not touch the ground. The great horn is the first king: Alexander the Great. He conquered the huge Persian Empire in only a few years (334–331 BC).

Verse 8: At the height of his power, "the great horn was broken": Alexander died when he was only 32 years old (323 BC). His empire was divided among his generals, into four parts.

The little horn VERSES 9–14

9 Out of one of them came a little horn.
It grew very great
toward the south, toward the east,
and toward the glorious land.
10 It grew so great that it reached the army of the sky.
It threw some of the army and some of the stars down to the earth
and trampled on them.
11 Yes, it made itself great, even up to the prince of the army.
It took away from him the daily burnt offering.
A burnt offering is an animal that is burned completely on the altar for God.
And the place of his holy temple was thrown down.
12 Because of rebellion against God,
the army was handed over to it,
together with the daily burnt offering.
It threw truth down to the ground.
It did whatever it wanted,
and it was successful.
13 Then I heard a holy one speaking.
And another holy one asked the one who was speaking,

"How long will the vision last?
How long will it be about the daily burnt offering
and the rebellion that causes ruin?
How long will the holy place and the army be trampled underfoot?"
14 He said to me,
"For 2,300 evenings and mornings.
Then the holy place will be made clean again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Out of one of the four kingdoms grows a little horn that becomes very powerful. It attacks the "glorious land" (Israel), stops the daily offering in the temple, and makes the holy place unclean.

Most interpreters, Jewish and Christian, see in it King Antiochus IV Epiphanes from the kingdom of the Seleucids (one of the four kingdoms that came after Alexander). In the year 167 BC, he forbade the Jewish worship of God and set up an altar for the Greek god Zeus in the temple.

Verse 10: He even attacks "the stars," that is, he rises up against God himself. A picture of pride without limits.

Verse 14: 2,300 "evenings and mornings" – that is either 2,300 days (a little more than six years) or, if you count the evening and morning offerings separately, 1,150 days (a little more than three years). After that, the holy place is cleansed. In the year 164 BC, the Maccabees won back the temple and dedicated it again. The Jewish feast of Hanukkah remembers this.

The angel Gabriel explains the vision VERSES 15–27

15 I, Daniel, had seen the vision,
and I was trying to understand it.
Then someone stood in front of me
who looked like a man.
16 I heard a man's voice between the banks of the Ulai.
It called out,
"Gabriel, help this man understand the vision."
17 So he came near the place where I was standing.
When he came, I was frightened and fell on my face.
But he said to me,
"Understand, son of man,
that the vision is about the time of the end."
18 While he was speaking with me,
I fell into a deep sleep
with my face to the ground.
But he touched me and stood me up.
19 He said,
"Listen, I will tell you
what will happen later, in the time of God's anger.
For the vision is about the set time of the end.
20 You saw the ram with the two horns.
They are the kings of Media and Persia.
21 The hairy male goat is the king of Greece.
The great horn between his eyes is the first king.
22 The horn was broken, and four horns grew up in its place.
Four kingdoms will rise from his nation,
but they will not have his power.
23 "In the last part of their rule,
when the wrongdoers have become as bad as they can be,
a king will rise up.
He will have a fierce face,
and he will understand riddles.
24 His power will be great,
but not by his own strength.
He will cause terrible destruction.
He will be successful in what he does.
He will destroy the mighty ones and the holy people.
25 With his cleverness, he will make lies and tricks succeed.
In his heart he will think he is great.
He will destroy many people who feel safe.
He will even rise up against the Prince of princes.
But he will be broken,
and not by any human hand.
26 "The vision about the evenings and the mornings
that has been told to you is true.
But seal up the vision.
For it is about a time many days from now."
27 I, Daniel, fainted
and was sick for several days.
Then I got up
and did the king's work again.
I was shocked by the vision,
but no one understood it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Here, for the first time in the Bible, an angel is called by name: Gabriel. His name means "God is strong" or "man of God." In the New Testament, it is Gabriel who tells Mary that Jesus will be born (Luke 1:26–38).

Verse 17: Gabriel calls Daniel "son of man," just as God called Ezekiel.

Verses 23–25: The king with "a fierce face" is again the cruel ruler (Antiochus IV). He is clever, deceitful, and violent. He even attacks God ("the Prince of princes").

Verse 25: "He will be broken, and not by any human hand." Antiochus IV died of an illness in the year 164 BC, not in battle.

Verse 26: "Seal up the vision" means: Keep it secret.

Verse 27: The vision is so heavy that Daniel becomes sick. But then he gets up and goes back to his work. Faith also means to keep doing your daily work faithfully, even when you have heavy thoughts.

DANIEL

CHAPTER 9

Daniel's prayer and the 70 weeks

Daniel reads in Jeremiah VERSES 1–3

1 It was the first year of Darius, the son of Ahasuerus.
Darius was from the family line of the Medes.
He had been made king over the kingdom of the Chaldeans.

2 In the first year that he ruled,
I, Daniel, learned from the books
the number of years
that the word of the LORD had told to Jeremiah the prophet.
That was how long Jerusalem would lie in ruins:
70 years.
3 I turned my face to the Lord God.
I looked for him with prayer and requests,
with fasting, sackcloth, and ashes.
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they were very sad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the year 539/538 BC, right after the end of Babylon.

Daniel reads in the book of the prophet Jeremiah. It says there that the exile will last 70 years (Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10). The exile is the time when the people had to live far away from their land. Daniel notices: The time is almost over!

Interesting: Daniel reads the Bible, that is, the writings of the prophets before him. He takes God's word seriously and prays about it.

Instead of simply waiting, Daniel prays. He fasts and wears sackcloth and ashes, signs of sorrow and of being sorry for sins.

We have sinned VERSES 4–14

4 I prayed to the LORD my God.
I confessed our sins.
I said,
"Oh, Lord, you great and awesome God!
You keep your covenant and your loving kindness
with those who love you and keep your commandments.
5 We have sinned.
We have done wrong.
We have done evil.
We have rebelled against you.
We have turned away from your commands and your laws.
6 We have not listened to your servants the prophets.
They spoke in your name to our kings, our leaders, and our ancestors,
and to all the people of the land.
7 "Lord, you are in the right.
But we are ashamed, as we are today:
the men of Judah, the people who live in Jerusalem,
and all Israel,
those who are near and those who are far away,
in all the countries where you have driven them.
This is because they were unfaithful to you.
8 Lord, we are ashamed,
we and our kings, our leaders, and our ancestors,
because we have sinned against you.
9 But the Lord our God is merciful and forgives,
even though we have rebelled against him.
10 We have not obeyed the voice of the LORD our God.
We have not lived by his laws,
which he gave us through his servants the prophets.
11 Yes, all Israel has broken your law.
They have turned away
and have not obeyed your voice.
"That is why the curse and the oath
that are written in the law of Moses, the servant of God,
have been poured out on us.
For we have sinned against God.
12 He has done what he said he would do
against us and against our judges who ruled us.
He has brought great disaster on us.
For nowhere under the whole sky has anything been done
like what has been done to Jerusalem.
13 All this disaster has come upon us,
just as it is written in the law of Moses.
And still we have not asked the LORD our God for his kindness.
We have not turned away from our sins.
We have not paid attention to your truth.
14 So the LORD kept the disaster ready
and brought it upon us.
For the LORD our God is right in everything he does,
and we have not obeyed his voice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: A covenant is a binding agreement.

Daniel's prayer is a great confession of sin. It is remarkable: Daniel himself was faithful. In the stories, no fault of his is reported. And still he does not say "they have sinned," but "WE have sinned." He stands together with his people and shares the guilt.

Verses 7 and 9: A strong contrast: "Lord, you are in the right. But we are ashamed." But also: "The Lord our God is merciful and forgives." Daniel knows: God is just, but he is also merciful.

This prayer has become an example for prayers of repentance, in Judaism and in Christianity. Repentance means: being sorry for sins and turning back to God.

Lord, hear! Lord, forgive! VERSES 15–19

15 "Now, Lord our God,
you brought your people out of the land of Egypt with a mighty hand.
You made a name for yourself that lasts to this day.
We have sinned.
We have done evil.
16 Lord, because you always do what is right,
please turn your anger and your fury away
from your city Jerusalem, your holy mountain.
For because of our sins and the guilt of our ancestors,
Jerusalem and your people have become a joke
to all the people around us.
17 "Now, our God,
listen to the prayer of your servant and to his requests.
Let your face shine with kindness
on your holy place, which lies in ruins.
Do it for your own sake, Lord.
18 My God, turn your ear and listen.
Open your eyes and see our ruins
and the city that is called by your name.
For we do not bring our requests to you
because we are good,
but because your mercy is great.
19 Lord, hear!
Lord, forgive!

Lord, listen and act!
Do not wait!
Do it for your own sake, my God,
because your city and your people are called by your name."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: The heart of the prayer: "For we do not bring our requests to you because we are good, but because your mercy is great." We have nothing to show before God. We can only trust in his grace.

Verse 19: A short, urgent prayer: "Lord, hear! Lord, forgive! Lord, listen and act!" You can pray it today too, when you do not know what to do anymore.

Gabriel comes with the answer VERSES 20–23

20 I was still speaking and praying.
I was confessing my sin and the sin of my people Israel.
I was bringing my request to the LORD my God
for the holy mountain of my God.
21 Yes, while I was still praying,
the man Gabriel came.
I had seen him at the beginning in the vision.
He came flying quickly.
He touched me at about the time of the evening offering.
22 He taught me and talked with me.
He said,
"Daniel, I have now come
to give you wisdom and understanding.
23 When you began to pray, an order went out.
And I have come to tell it to you,
for you are greatly loved.
So think about the message
and understand the vision.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: Gabriel comes "at about the time of the evening offering." There was no temple anymore. But Daniel still prayed at the time when offerings used to be made in the temple. Prayer took the place of the offering.

Verse 23: God already heard the prayer at the beginning, even before Daniel had finished. And Gabriel says to Daniel: "You are greatly loved." What a beautiful word from God!

70 weeks VERSES 24–27

24 "70 weeks have been decided
for your people and for your holy city.
Then the rebellion will be finished.
Sins will come to an end.
Guilt will be paid for and taken away.
Righteousness that lasts forever will be brought in.
Vision and prophecy will be sealed.
And the most holy place will be anointed.
25 "So know this and understand it:
The order will go out
to restore and to build Jerusalem again.
From that time until the Anointed One, the prince, comes,
there will be 7 weeks and 62 weeks.
Jerusalem will be built again,
with streets and a moat,
even in troubled times.
26 After the 62 weeks,
the Anointed One will be killed
and will have nothing.
The people of a prince who will come
will destroy the city and the holy place.
Its end will come like a flood.
There will be war until the end.
Ruin has been decided.
27 He will make a firm covenant with many people for one week.
In the middle of the week,
he will put an end to the sacrifices and the offerings.
And on the wing of disgusting things will come one
who causes ruin.
Until the full end that has been decided,
God's anger will be poured out on what lies in ruins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Daniel had been thinking about the 70 years in Jeremiah. Gabriel answers with "70 weeks." This probably means "weeks of years," that is, 7 years each. 70 times 7 = 490 years. So the time until final salvation is much longer than Daniel thought.

Verse 24: Righteousness means: everything is right with God. To anoint means: to pour oil on something to make it holy for God.

Verse 25: A moat is a deep ditch around a city.

These verses are among the most discussed in the whole Bible. The Hebrew text is difficult, and there are different explanations:

– Many interpreters connect them with the time up to Antiochus IV: The "Anointed One" who is "killed" (verse 26) would be the rightful high priest Onias III, who was murdered in 171 BC. The "one who causes ruin" is Antiochus, who stopped the worship in the temple (verse 27). The end of verse 27 can be translated in different ways: The WEB says that the anger is poured out "on the desolate," that is, on what lies in ruins. Other translations say it comes on the one who makes desolate, that is, on the one who causes ruin.

– Many Christians connect the verses with Jesus Christ, the "Anointed One" (Messiah), who was killed, and with the destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans in AD 70.

– In Judaism, they were also connected with the destruction of the Second Temple.

In verses 25–26, the WEB translates "the Anointed One" with capital letters, like a name. The Hebrew has no word for "the." You can also translate "an anointed one."

Jesus says: "So when you see the 'abomination of desolation' standing in the holy place, which the prophet Daniel spoke about…" (Matthew 24:15). An abomination is something disgusting to God.

The important message for everyone: God has a plan for history. The suffering has an end. At the goal there is forgiveness and "righteousness that lasts forever" (verse 24).

DANIEL

CHAPTER 10

The man dressed in linen

Daniel mourns for three weeks VERSES 1–3

1 In the third year of Cyrus, the king of Persia,
a message was shown to Daniel,
who was also called Belteshazzar.
The message was true.
It was about a great war.
He understood the message,
and he understood the vision.
2 In those days, I, Daniel, was mourning
for three whole weeks.
3 I did not eat any tasty food.
No meat and no wine came into my mouth.
I did not put any oil on my body at all,
until the three whole weeks were over.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 10–12 belong together. They are Daniel's last and longest vision.

The third year of Cyrus is about 536 BC. By then, many Jews had returned to Jerusalem. But Daniel, now very old, stayed in Babylon.

Why does Daniel mourn? The text does not say exactly. Maybe because of the difficulties with rebuilding Jerusalem (compare Ezra 4). He fasts in part: no tasty food, no meat, no wine, no oil to care for his body.

The vision by the Tigris VERSES 4–9

4 On the twenty-fourth day of the first month,
I was on the bank of the great river, the Hiddekel.
5 I looked up,
and I saw a man dressed in linen.
Around his waist he wore a belt of pure gold from Uphaz.
6 His body was like beryl.
His face looked like lightning.
His eyes were like burning torches.
His arms and his feet were like polished bronze.
And the sound of his words was like the noise of a huge crowd.
7 Only I, Daniel, saw the vision.
The men who were with me did not see the vision.
But they began to shake with great fear,
and they ran away to hide.
8 So I was left alone,
and I saw this great vision.
I had no strength left.
My face turned as pale as death,
and I had no strength anymore.
9 But I heard the sound of his words.
When I heard the sound of his words,
I fell into a deep sleep on my face,
with my face to the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hiddekel is the Hebrew name for the Tigris.

Daniel sees a shining man from heaven, dressed in linen, with a belt of gold, with eyes like fire and arms like bronze.

The description is very similar to the appearance of the risen Christ in Revelation 1:13–15. The text does not say who the man in Daniel is. Many think of a high angel, maybe Gabriel.

Verse 7: The men with Daniel see nothing, but they feel something and run away. Something similar happened to the men with Paul near Damascus (Acts 9:7).

In verse 6, the WEB has "beryl," a shimmering gemstone.

Do not be afraid, you who are greatly loved VERSES 10–14

10 Then a hand touched me.
It helped me up onto my knees and the palms of my hands.
11 He said to me,
"Daniel, you man who is greatly loved,
understand the words that I am speaking to you.
Stand up,
for I have now been sent to you."
When he said this to me,
I stood up, trembling.
12 Then he said to me,
"Do not be afraid, Daniel!
From the first day
that you set your heart on understanding
and on humbling yourself before your God,
your words were heard.
And I have come because of your words.
13 But the prince of the kingdom of Persia
stood against me for 21 days.
Then Michael, one of the chief princes,
came to help me,
because I was left there with the kings of Persia.
14 Now I have come
to help you understand
what will happen to your people in the last days.
For the vision is about a time many days from now."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: A great comfort: God heard Daniel's prayer from the first day! Only the answer arrived later.

Verse 13: A mysterious look behind the scenes: The messenger was held up for 21 days, exactly the three weeks that Daniel fasted. The "prince of the kingdom of Persia" is an invisible power that stands behind the Persian Empire. Only when Michael came could the messenger go on.

Michael (the name means "Who is like God?") is an archangel, a chief angel. Here he is named as the protector of Israel. In the New Testament, he appears in the letter of Jude (verse 9) and in Revelation (12:7).

The message: Behind the events on earth there is an invisible reality. When an answer to prayer takes a long time, that does not mean that God has not heard.

Be strong! VERSES 15–21

15 When he had spoken these words to me,
I bowed my face to the ground,
and I could not speak.
16 Then one who looked like a human being
touched my lips.
Then I opened my mouth.
I spoke to the one who was standing in front of me.
I said,

"My lord, because of the vision, pain has come over me,
and I have no strength left.
17 How can I, your servant, my lord,
talk with you, my lord?
For right now I have no strength left in me,
and there is no breath left in me."
18 Then the one who looked like a man touched me again,
and he gave me strength.
19 He said,
"You man who is greatly loved, do not be afraid!
Peace be with you!
Be strong! Yes, be strong!"
When he spoke to me, I became stronger.
I said,
"Let my lord speak, for you have given me strength."
20 Then he said,
"Do you know why I have come to you?
Now I will go back
to fight against the prince of Persia.
And when I leave,
the prince of Greece will come.
21 But I will tell you
what is written in the book of truth.
No one stands with me against them
except Michael, your prince.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Daniel is completely exhausted. Three times he is touched and given strength: on his body (verse 10), on his lips (verse 16), and once more (verse 18).

Verse 19: Beautiful words: "You man who is greatly loved, do not be afraid! Peace be with you! Be strong! Yes, be strong!" God also speaks like this to us when we are weak and exhausted.

Verse 20: The world empires (Persia, Greece) have their invisible "princes." The fight goes on, but God sees everything: It is written in the "book of truth" (verse 21).

DANIEL

Chapter 11

The kings of the north and of the south

From Persia to Alexander VERSES 1–4

1 "As for me, in the first year of Darius the Mede,
I stood up to support him and to make him strong.
2 "Now I will show you the truth.
Three more kings will rise up in Persia.
The fourth will be much richer than all of them.
When he has become strong through his riches,
he will stir up everyone against the kingdom of Greece.
3 Then a mighty king will rise up.
He will rule with great power
and do whatever he wants.
4 But as soon as he has risen up,
his kingdom will be broken.
It will be divided toward the four winds of the sky.
But it will not go to his descendants.
And it will not have the power with which he ruled.
For his kingdom will be pulled up by the roots,
and it will go to others besides these.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapter 11 is the most detailed picture of the future in the Bible. It describes the history from about 530 to 165 BC in coded language, but amazingly exactly.

Verse 2: The Persian kings. The rich fourth king is probably Xerxes I, who went to war against Greece in 480 BC.

Verses 3–4: The mighty king is Alexander the Great. After his early death, his empire was divided among his generals, not given to his sons.

Some scholars date the book to the 2nd century BC. For them, Chapter 11 is history looking back, written in the style of a prophecy. For readers who date it to the 6th century, it is an exact prediction. Both views are held.

Wars between north and south VERSES 5–20

5 "The king of the south will become strong.
But one of his princes will become stronger than he is.
He will rule,
and his rule will be a great rule.
6 After some years, they will become allies.
The daughter of the king of the south
will come to the king of the north to make an agreement.
But she will not keep her power.
He will not last either, and neither will his power.
She will be handed over,
together with those who brought her,
and the one who became her father,
and the one who supported her in those times.
7 "But a branch from her family roots
will rise up in his place.
He will march against the army.
He will go into the fortress of the king of the north.
He will fight against them and win.
8 He will also carry their gods off to Egypt,
together with their metal idols
and their valuable objects of silver and gold.
For some years, he will leave the king of the north alone.
9 Then the king of the north will come into the kingdom of the king of the south,
but he will go back to his own land.
10 His sons will go to war.
They will gather a huge number of large armies.
These armies will come on like a flood and sweep through.
They will come back and make war
all the way to his fortress.
11 "The king of the south will become very angry.
He will go out and fight against him,

against the king of the north.
The king of the north will send out a huge army,
but that army will be handed over to the king of the south.
12 The army will be carried off,
and the heart of the king of the south will become proud.
He will kill tens of thousands,
but he will not stay in power.
13 The king of the north will come back.
He will send out an army that is even bigger than the first one.
After some time, after some years,
he will come with a great army and with plenty of supplies.
14 "In those times, many will rise up against the king of the south.
Also some violent men from your people
will rise up to make the vision come true.
But they will fall.
15 So the king of the north will come.
He will build up a ramp of earth
and capture a city with strong walls.
The armies of the south will not be able to stand against him,
not even their best troops.
They will have no strength to resist.
16 But the one who comes against him will do whatever he wants.
No one will be able to stand against him.
He will stand in the glorious land,
and he will have the power to destroy it.
17 He will set his mind on coming
with the strength of his whole kingdom.
He will bring fair terms of peace with him,
and he will carry them out.
He will give him a daughter in marriage
to destroy the kingdom.
But she will not succeed,
and she will not be on his side.
18 After this, he will turn to the islands
and capture many of them.
But a commander will put an end to his insults.
Yes, he will turn his insults back on him.
19 Then he will turn back toward the fortresses of his own land.
But he will stumble and fall,
and he will not be seen anymore.
20 "Then someone else will rise up in his place.
He will send a tax collector through the kingdom
to keep up its royal splendor.
But in a few days, he will be destroyed,
not in anger and not in battle.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After Alexander's death, two of the kingdoms that came after him fought against each other again and again:

– the "king of the south": the Ptolemies in Egypt,

– the "king of the north": the Seleucids in Syria.

Israel lay right between them, in the "glorious land" (verse 16), and it became the battlefield of their wars again and again.

Many details fit known events, for example:

Verse 6: Around 250 BC, the Egyptian princess Berenice married the Syrian king Antiochus II. The alliance failed, and she was murdered.

Verses 15–16: Around 200 BC, Antiochus III took the land of Israel from the Egyptians.

Verse 17: Antiochus III gave his daughter Cleopatra I to the Egyptian king as his wife, to gain influence. But she stood by her husband and by Egypt.

Verse 18: A Roman commander stopped Antiochus III.

Verse 20: Seleucus IV sent an official (Heliodorus) to take the temple treasure in Jerusalem. Seleucus was murdered later.

Verse 14: "Some violent men from your people" – people from Israel also tried to make the vision "come true" by violence, and they failed. God's plans cannot be forced by violence.

The despised king VERSES 21–35

21 "In his place, a despised man will rise up.
People had not given him the honor of being king.
But he will come at a time when people feel safe.
He will get the kingdom by flattering people.
22 Huge armies will be swept away before him like a flood.
They will be broken.
Yes, the prince of the covenant will also be broken.
23 After an agreement is made with him,
he will act with lies and tricks.
He will rise up
and become strong with only a few people.
24 At a time when people feel safe,
he will come into the richest parts of the province.
He will do what his ancestors did not do,
not even the ancestors before them.
He will hand out loot, plunder, and riches among his followers.
Yes, he will make plans against the strong cities,
but only for a time.
25 "He will stir up his power and his courage
against the king of the south
with a great army.
And the king of the south will go to war
with a very great and mighty army.
But he will not be able to stand,
because people will make plans against him.
26 Yes, those who eat his fine food
will destroy him.
His army will be swept away.
Many will fall dead.
27 Both these kings
will want in their hearts to do evil.
They will sit at one table and tell each other lies.
But it will not succeed,
for the end will still come at the set time.
28 Then he will go back to his land with great riches.
His heart will be against the holy covenant.
He will act against it
and then go back to his own land.
29 "At the set time, he will come back
and come into the south.
But this time it will not be like the first time.

30 For ships of Kittim will come against him.
So he will lose courage
and turn back.
He will rage against the holy covenant
and act against it.
He will come back
and pay attention to those who leave the holy covenant.
31 "His armies will make the holy place unclean, the fortress.
They will take away the daily burnt offering.
Then they will set up the disgusting thing that causes ruin.
32 He will lead astray with flattery
those who act wickedly against the covenant.
But the people who know their God
will be strong and take action.
33 "Those among the people who are wise will teach many.
But for many days, they will fall
by the sword and by fire,
by being taken captive and by being robbed.
34 When they fall,
they will receive a little help.
But many will join them who are not honest.
35 Some of the wise will fall,
so that they are refined, made pure, and made white,
until the time of the end.
For the end will still come at the set time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the "despised man," who comes to power by flattery. Almost all interpreters see in him Antiochus IV Epiphanes (175–164 BC), the "little horn" from Chapters 7 and 8.

Verse 22: The "prince of the covenant" is probably the high priest Onias III, who was removed from office and later murdered.

Verse 30: The "ships of Kittim" are the Romans. In the year 168 BC, a Roman messenger forced Antiochus to leave Egypt. The humbled king took out his anger on Jerusalem.

Verse 31: He made the temple unclean, stopped the daily offering, and set up the "disgusting thing that causes ruin," an altar for the god Zeus (167 BC).

Verse 32: But: "The people who know their God will be strong." Many Jews stayed faithful, even when their lives were in danger.

Verses 33–35: The "wise" teach the people, even when they suffer and die for it. Their suffering is not meaningless. The Bible says that it "refines" the community. Refining means: making pure, like metal in a fire. This does not mean that God wants suffering. But in God's eyes it has meaning.

Verse 34: "A little help" – many interpreters think of the uprising of the Maccabees.

The king who lifts himself above everything VERSES 36–45

36 "The king will do whatever he wants.
He will lift himself up and make himself greater than every god.
He will say shocking things against the God of gods.
He will be successful until the time of God's anger is over.
For what has been decided will happen.
37 He will not care about the gods of his ancestors,
or about the god that women love,
or about any god.
For he will make himself greater than all of them.
38 Instead, he will honor the god of fortresses.
He will honor a god that his ancestors did not know.
He will honor him with gold and silver,
with precious stones and costly gifts.
39 With the help of a foreign god,
he will attack the strongest fortresses.
He will give great honor to those who accept him.
He will make them rulers over many people.
And he will divide up the land as a reward.
40 "At the time of the end, the king of the south will fight against him.
And the king of the north will come at him like a storm,
with chariots, with horsemen, and with many ships.
He will invade the countries.
He will sweep through them like a flood.
41 He will also come into the glorious land.
Many countries will be defeated.
But these will be rescued from his power:
Edom, Moab, and the leaders of the people of Ammon.
42 He will also reach out his hand against the countries.
The land of Egypt will not escape.
43 He will have power over the treasures of gold and silver
and over all the precious things of Egypt.
The Libyans and the Ethiopians will follow him.
44 But news from the east and from the north
will frighten him.
He will go out in a great rage
to destroy many and wipe them out completely.
45 He will set up his royal tents
between the sea and the glorious holy mountain.
But he will come to his end,
and no one will help him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The king becomes more and more mad with power. He puts himself above all gods, even above the God of gods. Antiochus IV called himself "Epiphanes." That means "the god who has appeared."

Verse 37: "The god that women love" probably means a god that women especially worshiped (maybe Tammuz or Adonis, compare Ezekiel 8:14). In the WEB, the words are: the desire of women.

Verse 38: The "god of fortresses" – maybe Zeus, or simply: He worships only power and war.

Verse 43: "Ethiopians" – this means the people of Cush, south of Egypt.

Verses 40–45: These verses no longer fit exactly with what is known about Antiochus IV. He died of an illness in Persia in 164 BC. That is why many interpreters connect these verses with a time of the end that is still to come. Others see in them a general announcement of his downfall.

The message is clear: Even the most powerful and cruel ruler "will come to his end, and no one will help him."

Chapter 12

The time of the end

The resurrection VERSES 1–4

1 "At that time Michael will stand up,
the great prince who protects the people of your nation.
There will be a time of trouble,
worse than any time since there was a nation until that time.
But at that time your people will be rescued,
everyone whose name is found written in the book.
2 Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth will wake up.
Some will wake up to life that lasts forever.
Others will wake up to shame and to disgrace that lasts forever.
3 Those who are wise will shine like the bright sky.
And those who lead many people to do what is right will shine like the stars
forever and ever.
4 But you, Daniel, close up the words
and seal the book
until the time of the end.
Many will run here and there,
and knowledge will increase."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important texts of the Old Testament!

Verse 1: A hard time of trouble will come. But Michael, the protector of Israel, stands up. And everyone whose name is written "in the book" will be rescued. The "book of life" is a picture that God knows everyone who belongs to him (compare Revelation 20:12).

Verse 2: Here, for the first time in the Bible, it is said very clearly: The dead will rise again. Death is a "sleep in the dust" from which people wake up, to life that lasts forever or to shame that lasts forever.

That was a great hope, especially for the martyrs who had died for their faith (Daniel 11:33–35). Martyrs are people who are killed because of their faith. Their death is not the end. God will give them justice.

Belief in the resurrection of the dead is a basic belief in Judaism (the daily prayer says: "Blessed are you, who gives life to the dead") and in Christianity (Jesus speaks in a very similar way in John 5:28–29).

Verse 3: A beautiful picture: Whoever is wise and leads others to what is good will shine like the stars. That is true for everyone who helps others find God and what is good: parents, teachers, friends.

How long? VERSES 5–13

5 Then I, Daniel, looked,
and I saw two others standing there.
One was on the bank of the river on this side,
and the other was on the bank of the river on the other side.
6 One of them said to the man dressed in linen,
who was above the waters of the river,
"How long will it be until the end of these amazing things?"
7 I heard the man dressed in linen,
who was above the waters of the river.
He raised his right hand and his left hand toward heaven.
He made a promise by the one who lives forever.
He said: It will be for a time, times, and a half.
When the power of the holy people has been completely broken,
all these things will be finished.
8 I heard it, but I did not understand it.
So I said,
"My lord, how will all these things end?"
9 He said,
"Go your way, Daniel.
For the words are closed up and sealed
until the time of the end.
10 Many will make themselves pure.
They will make themselves white and be refined.
But the wicked will keep doing what is wicked.
None of the wicked will understand.
But those who are wise will understand.
11 "The daily burnt offering will be taken away,
and the disgusting thing that causes ruin will be set up.
From that time on, there will be 1,290 days.
12 Happy is the one who waits patiently
and reaches the 1,335 days.
13 "But you, go your way until the end.
You will rest.
And at the end of the days, you will stand up to receive your share."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: The question of everyone who suffers: "How long?" The answer: "A time, times, and a half," that is, about three and a half years (compare 7:25). A limited time. The suffering has an end.

Verse 8: An honest sentence: "I heard it, but I did not understand it." Even Daniel does not understand everything. We do not have to understand every number and every picture in the Bible either.

Verses 11–12: 1,290 days and 1,335 days. It is not clear what exactly these numbers mean. They are a little longer than three and a half years. Maybe it is meant to say: If it takes longer than you expect, do not give up. "Happy is the one who waits patiently."

Important: Again and again, people have tried to use these numbers to calculate the date of the end of the world. All these calculations have failed. Jesus says: "But no one knows that day or that hour" (Mark 13:32).

Verse 13: The last verse of the book is a personal promise to Daniel: "But you, go your way until the end. You will rest. And at the end of the days, you will stand up to receive your share." Many understand this as a promise of resurrection: Daniel will rise again and receive his place with God. A comforting word for everyone who has lived faithfully.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Daniel?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Faithful in a foreign land: Daniel and his friends were taken away and lived at the court of Babylon. They learned the foreign culture and worked faithfully for the kings. But they did not give up their faith (Chapter 1).

Courage in danger: The three friends would rather go into the fiery furnace than worship an idol: "But if not…" (Chapter 3). Daniel kept praying, even when it was forbidden, and was thrown into the lions' den (Chapter 6). God was with them in the fire and with the lions.

God is Lord over the kings: "He removes kings and sets up kings" (2:21). Proud Nebuchadnezzar was humbled and learned to praise the King of heaven (Chapter 4). Belshazzar was "weighed" and found "too light" (Chapter 5).

The world empires pass away: The statue made of metals (Chapter 2) and the four animals (Chapter 7) show: All world empires, as powerful as they are, pass away.

God's kingdom remains: A stone, not made by human hands, becomes a mountain (Chapter 2). "One like a son of man" comes with the clouds and receives a kingdom that lasts forever (Chapter 7). Jesus called himself the "Son of Man."

Prayer: Daniel prayed three times a day (Chapter 6). He confessed the guilt of his people and said "we" (Chapter 9). God heard his prayers from the first day (10:12).

Hope beyond death: "Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth will wake up" (12:2). The faithful teachers will shine like the stars.

Be careful with calculations: The numbers and pictures in Daniel are often hard to understand. They are meant to give courage, not fear. No one can use them to calculate the end of the world.

For today: Daniel shows how to stay faithful in a world with other values: polite, wise, hardworking, but firm in faith. And the book gives courage: No power in the world has the last word. God does.

What comes next? Now come the 12 "Minor Prophets." They are called "minor" (small) because their books are shorter, not because they are less important. The first is Hosea. His marriage to an unfaithful woman becomes a picture of God's love for his unfaithful people: a love that does not give up.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 28 OF 66

HOSEA

14 CHAPTERS

HOSEA

Chapter 1

Hosea's marriage and his children

Before we begin: The 12 Minor Prophets and Hosea

Now the 12 "Minor Prophets" begin: Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. They are called "minor" (small) because their books are shorter than those of Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel, not because they are less important. In Judaism, they form one single book together, the "Book of the Twelve."

Hosea lived in the 8th century BC in the northern kingdom of Israel, at about the same time as Amos, Isaiah, and Micah. It was a time when many people were doing well. But the people mixed the God of Israel with Baal, a god of fertility. Shortly afterward, in the year 722 BC, the northern kingdom was destroyed by the Assyrians.

His name means "The LORD saves," very similar to "Joshua" and "Jesus."

What is special about Hosea: He feels God's pain in his own life. His own marriage to an unfaithful wife becomes a picture of God's relationship with his unfaithful people.

A word first: Hosea uses the picture of an unfaithful wife for the people. This picture comes from a time when men had all the power. It is a picture of unfaithfulness toward God, not a statement about women. And it never excuses violence in a marriage.

The great message of Hosea: God's love does not give up. "How can I give you up?" (Hosea 11:8). The book has 14 chapters.

Hosea marries Gomer VERSES 1–3

1 This is the word of the LORD that came to Hosea, the son of Beeri.
It came in the days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah,
and in the days of Jeroboam the son of Joash, king of Israel.
2 When the LORD first spoke through Hosea,
the LORD said to Hosea,
"Go, marry a woman who is a prostitute,
and have children who come from unfaithfulness.
For the land is like an unfaithful wife.
It has left the LORD."
3 So he went and married Gomer, the daughter of Diblaim.
She became pregnant and gave birth to a son for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God asks Hosea to do something shocking: He is to marry a woman who will be unfaithful to him. That way, Hosea is to feel in his own life what God feels when his people leave him and run after other gods.

Interpreters disagree about whether Gomer already lived like this before the marriage or only became unfaithful later. Some also think that she belonged to a pagan cult, a religion of other gods.

Important: Here, Gomer is a picture of the whole people, especially of the men who ruled the land and served idols. The text is not a statement about what women are like.

Three children with names that are signs VERSES 4–9

4 The LORD said to him,
"Name him Jezreel.
For in just a little while,
I will punish the house of Jehu
for the blood it shed at Jezreel.
And I will put an end to the kingdom of the house of Israel.
5 On that day,
I will break the bow of Israel in the valley of Jezreel."
The bow stands for the power of the army.
6 She became pregnant again and gave birth to a daughter.
Then the LORD said to Hosea,
"Name her Lo-Ruhamah.
For I will no longer have mercy on the house of Israel.
I will not forgive them in any way.
7 But I will have mercy on the house of Judah.
I will save them by the LORD their God.
I will not save them by bow, sword, battle,
horses, or horsemen."
8 After she had weaned Lo-Ruhamah,
she became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
To wean means: The child stops drinking its mother's milk.
9 The LORD said,
"Name him Lo-Ammi.
For you are not my people,
and I will not be yours.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The three children get names that are a message, like living posters:

– Jezreel ("God sows"): In the valley of Jezreel, King Jehu had killed many people when he came to power (2 Kings 9–10). God has not forgotten this violence.

– Lo-Ruhamah ("No mercy"): God will no longer have mercy.

– Lo-Ammi ("Not my people"): The relationship between God and Israel is broken. God had told Moses his name: "I AM" (Exodus 3:14). Now God says: "I will not be yours" (Hosea 1:9). A shocking sentence.

Imagine what it means for children to carry names like these. But the story goes on: In Hosea 1:10 and 2:23, the names are turned around!

Verse 7: Judah will be saved, but not by weapons. God himself will save them.

But then: children of the living God VERSES 10–11

10 "Yet the number of the people of Israel will be like the
sand of the sea,
which cannot be measured or counted.
And this will happen:
In the place where people said to them,
'You are not my people,'
they will be called 'children of the living God.'
11 The people of Judah and the people of Israel
will be gathered together.
They will choose one leader for themselves.
And they will go up out of the land.
For the day of Jezreel will be great."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, these two verses are 2:1–2. That is why the verse numbers in Chapter 2 of the WEB are two lower than in many other Bibles.

In the middle of judgment, there is suddenly a great hope! Where it said "Not my people," it will say "children of the living God." God's last word is not separation, but love.

Verse 10: This reminds us of the promise to Abraham: descendants like the sand of the sea (Genesis 22:17).

Verse 11: The divided people (the northern kingdom and the southern kingdom) will become one again.

"The day of Jezreel": Now the name gets a good meaning, "God sows." God will sow his people again, like seed that comes up.

Paul quotes this verse in his letter to the Romans (Romans 9:25–26): Now people from the nations who were not God's people may also be called children of the living God.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 2

I will speak tenderly to her

The unfaithful wife VERSES 1–5

1 "Say to your brothers, 'My people!'
And say to your sisters, 'My loved one!'
2 Bring charges against your mother!
Bring charges, for she is not my wife,
and I am not her husband.
Let her put away the signs of her prostitution from
her face,
and her unfaithfulness from between her breasts.
3 If she does not,
I will strip her naked.
I will make her as bare as on the day she was born.
I will make her like a wilderness.
I will make her like a dry land,
and I will let her die of thirst.
4 I will have no mercy on her children,
for they are children of unfaithfulness.
5 For their mother has acted like a prostitute.
The woman who became pregnant with them has
acted shamefully.
For she said,
'I will go after my lovers.
They give me my bread and my water,
my wool and my linen,
my oil and my drinks.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, the verses of this chapter are two higher (2:3–25).

Verse 1: The names of the children are turned around: "Lo-Ammi" (not my people) becomes "Ammi" (my people), and "Lo-Ruhamah" (no mercy) becomes "Ruhamah" (loved one, who finds mercy).

Verses 2–5: The "mother" is the land of Israel as a whole. She is unfaithful to her husband (God). Her "lovers" are the Baal gods. The people believed that Baal gave them rain, bread, wine, and wool. They had forgotten that everything comes from God.

Verse 3: At that time, stripping a woman naked was a punishment for adultery. Adultery means: A married person has sex with someone else. Here it is a picture of what will happen to the land: It will become bare and empty like a desert.

Very important: This picture never justifies a man humiliating, beating, or shaming his wife. Behavior like that is violence and is wrong. If you experience violence in a relationship: For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

She did not know that it was I VERSES 6–13

6 "So I will block her road with thorns.
I will build a wall against her,
so that she cannot find her way.
7 She will run after her lovers,
but she will not catch up with them.
She will look for them,
but she will not find them.
Then she will say,
'I will go back to my first husband,
for back then it was better for me than now.'
8 For she did not know
that it was I who gave her the grain, the new wine, and
the oil.
I gave her more and more silver and gold,
and they used it for Baal.
9 "So I will take back my grain at harvest time,
and my new wine when it is ready.
I will take away my wool and my linen,
which were meant to cover her naked body.
10 Now I will show her shame
in front of her lovers.
And no one will rescue her from my hand.
11 I will also put an end to all her celebrations:
her feasts, her New Moon festivals, her Sabbaths,
and all her holy gatherings.

12 I will ruin her grapevines and her fig trees.
She said about them,
'These are my pay that my lovers have given me.'
I will turn them into a thicket,
and the animals of the field will eat them.
13 I will punish her for the days of the Baals,
when she burned incense to them.
She put on her earrings and her jewelry.
She went after her lovers,
and she forgot me,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: God "blocks the road." He lets the people notice that the false gods do not help. That sounds hard, but it has a goal: The people are to come back. "Back then it was better for me." Like the lost son who remembers his father's house (Luke 15:17).

Verse 8: The heart of the problem: "She did not know that it was I who gave her the grain, the new wine, and the oil." The people gave the credit for God's gifts to the false gods.

Verse 13: "And she forgot me." That is God's real pain: being forgotten by the one you love.

For today: We too often forget where the good things in our lives come from. And we thank the wrong one, for example only our own skill or money.

I will lead her into the wilderness VERSES 14–17

14 "So I will win her back with love.
I will bring her into the wilderness
and speak tenderly to her.
15 From there I will give her back her vineyards.
I will make the valley of Achor a door of hope.
There she will answer me as in the days when she was young,
as on the day when she came up out of the land of Egypt.
16 On that day," says the LORD,
"you will call me 'my husband.'
You will no longer call me 'my master.'
17 For I will take the names of the Baals out of her mouth.
Their names will no longer be spoken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most tender texts in the Bible! After all the threats, there is suddenly a "So" that no one expects: Not "So I will punish her," but "So I will win her back with love … and speak tenderly to her." God tries to win his people's love, like someone in love.

The wilderness is a reminder of the first love between God and Israel, when they came out of Egypt (compare Jeremiah 2:2). There, where there is nothing to distract, the relationship can begin again.

Verse 15: The valley of Achor ("valley of trouble") was a place of disaster (Joshua 7:24–26). Now it becomes a "door of hope." God can turn places of trouble into doors of hope.

Verse 16: A play on words: The WEB translates "my master." In Hebrew, the word there is "Baali," that is, "my Baal." In Hebrew, "Baal" also means "lord" or "owner," and it was used for a husband. God does not want to be called "my Baal" (my owner), but "my husband" (Hebrew "Ishi"). God wants a relationship of love, not of power.

I will make you my bride forever VERSES 18–23

18 "On that day, I will make a covenant for them
with the animals of the field,
with the birds of the sky,
and with the creatures that crawl on the ground.
I will break the bow and the sword and put an end to war in the land.
I will let them lie down in safety.
19 I will make you my bride forever.
Yes, I will make you my bride
with righteousness and justice,
with loving kindness and compassion.
20 I will make you my bride with faithfulness,
and you will know the LORD.
21 "On that day,
I will answer," says the LORD.
"I will answer the heavens,
and they will answer the earth.
22 The earth will answer the grain, the new wine, and the oil,
and they will answer Jezreel.
23 I will sow her for myself in the land, like seed.
I will have mercy on her who had not received mercy.
I will say to those who were not my people, 'You are my people.'
And they will say, 'You are my God!'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A covenant is a binding agreement. Here it is a covenant of peace with all of creation. No more war. A picture of paradise.

Verses 19–20: God makes a new engagement, and he brings the "wedding gifts" himself: righteousness, justice, loving kindness, compassion, and faithfulness. In Judaism, these words are spoken every morning when the prayer straps (tefillin) are wound around the finger.

"You will know the LORD." In Hebrew, "knowing" does not only mean knowledge, but a deep, personal relationship.

Verses 21–22: A chain of blessing: God answers the heavens, the heavens answer the earth (with rain), the earth answers the grain, and all together answer the people.

Verse 23: The names of the children are finally turned around. "No mercy" becomes "mercy." "Not my people" becomes "my people." And the people answer: "You are my God!" The relationship is restored.

1 Peter 2:10 also quotes this verse: "In the past you were not a people, but now you are God's people."

HOSEA

CHAPTER 3

Love that does not give up

Go again and love her VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD said to me,
"Go again.

Love a woman who is loved by another man
and who is unfaithful to her husband.
Love her just as the LORD loves the people of Israel,
even though they turn to other gods
and love raisin cakes."
2 So I bought her for myself
for 15 pieces of silver
and a homer and a half of barley.
That is about 9 bushels of barley.
3 I said to her,
"You must stay with me for many days.
You must not act like a prostitute.
You must not be with any other man.
And I will act the same way toward you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gomer has left Hosea and is living with another man. Maybe she has even fallen into debt or into someone else's power. God says to Hosea: "Go again. Love a woman ..."

That is unbelievable: After all the hurt, Hosea is to bring his wife back, "just as the LORD loves the people of Israel, even though they turn to other gods."

Verse 1: "Raisin cakes" were eaten at festivals for foreign gods.

Verse 2: Hosea has to buy her freedom. The price (15 pieces of silver and barley) was about the price of a female slave. Maybe Gomer had become a slave because of debt. A homer is about 6 bushels.

Verse 3: Hosea promises to be faithful to her: "And I will act the same way toward you." It is a new beginning, with a time of quiet and of thinking things over.

Christians see here a picture of God's love in Jesus Christ: God "buys free" (redeems) those who have turned away from him.

Important for today: This chapter is not advice to stay in a relationship where you are hurt, cheated on, or abused. It describes God's love. If you live in a relationship that harms you, you may get help and protect yourself.

Many days without a king VERSES 4–5

4 For the people of Israel will live for many days
without a king and without a leader,
without sacrifice and without a sacred stone,
without an ephod and without idols.
An ephod is a special garment of the priest, used to ask God for answers.
5 After that, the people of Israel will return.
They will look for the LORD their God
and for David their king.
They will come trembling to the LORD
and to his goodness
in the last days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Just as Gomer has to live apart for a while, Israel will also be without a king, without temple worship, and without idols for a long time. That happened in the exile.

But after that comes the return: They will look for God and for "David their king," that is, a king from the family of David. Jews expect the Messiah from David's family. Christians see this fulfilled in Jesus, the "Son of David."

"Come trembling to the LORD and to his goodness": not out of fear of punishment, but full of awe at a goodness that they have not deserved.

The message of the first three chapters: God's love is stronger than people's unfaithfulness. He does not give up.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 4

No faithfulness, no love, no knowledge of God

God brings charges against his people VERSES 1–3

1 Listen to the word of the LORD, you people of Israel.
For the LORD has a charge against the people who live in the land:
"There is no truth,
no goodness,
and no knowledge of God in the land.
2 There is cursing, lying, murder, stealing, and adultery.
People break through every limit.
One killing follows another.
3 That is why the land will mourn.
Everyone who lives in it will waste away,
together with all living things in it,
with the animals of the field and the birds of the sky.
Yes, even the fish in the sea are dying.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God brings "charges" against his people, as in a court of law.

Verse 1: Three things are missing in the land: truth (faithfulness, being someone others can count on), goodness (love, mercy), and knowledge of God. These are the foundations of every good community.

Verse 2: Instead, there is cursing, lying, murder, stealing, and adultery. That is almost exactly the Ten Commandments, only turned around (compare Exodus 20:7, 13–16). When people forget God, their life together also breaks apart.

Verse 3: Even nature suffers: Animals, birds, and fish die. The wrong that people do has consequences for all of creation. A thought that is very relevant today, when we see the destruction of the environment and the loss of many kinds of animals and plants.

The guilt of the priests VERSES 4–10

4 "But let no one bring charges,
and let no one blame others.
For your people are like those who bring charges against a priest.
5 You will stumble in the daytime,
and the prophet will also stumble with you at night.
And I will destroy your mother.
6 My people are destroyed because they lack knowledge.
Because you have rejected knowledge,
I will also reject you.
You will no longer be a priest for me.

Because you have forgotten the law of your God,
I will also forget your children.
7 The more of them there were,
the more they sinned against me.
I will turn their glory into shame.
8 They feed on the sin of my people.
They are eager for them to do more wrong.
9 It will be the same for the people and for the priest.
I will punish them for the way they live.
I will pay them back for what they have done.
10 They will eat, but they will not have enough.
They will act like prostitutes, but they will not have more children.
For they have stopped listening to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God speaks directly to the priests. They should have taught the people who God is and what he wants. But they did not do it.

Verse 6: A famous sentence: "My people are destroyed because they lack knowledge." The people no longer know God, because no one has taught them. The priests are to blame.

Verse 8: A heavy accusation: The priests "feed on the sin" of the people. They received a share of the sin offerings. The more the people sinned, the more the priests earned. Instead of calling the people to turn back, they profited from their guilt.

Verse 9: "The same for the people and for the priest." The spiritual leaders are no better than the others.

For today: Whoever is responsible for others (in church, at school, or in the family) should pass on knowledge and values and must not take advantage of others.

Idol worship under the trees VERSES 11–14

11 Prostitution, wine, and new wine take away people's good sense.
12 My people ask their wooden idol for advice.
They expect a stick of wood to give them answers.
For a spirit of prostitution has led them astray.
They have been unfaithful to their God.
13 They offer sacrifices on the tops of the mountains.
They burn incense on the hills,
under oaks, poplars, and terebinths,
because their shade is good.
That is why your daughters act like prostitutes,
and your brides are unfaithful to their husbands.
14 I will not punish your daughters when they act like prostitutes,
or your brides when they are unfaithful.
For the men themselves go off with prostitutes.
They offer sacrifices with the shrine prostitutes.
So a people without understanding will come to ruin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The people ask a piece of wood (an idol or a stick used to tell the future) instead of asking God.

Verse 13: Under shady trees on the hills, people celebrated fertility cults, often with sexual rituals. A terebinth is a large tree with wide branches.

Verse 14: A remarkable verse! God says: I will not punish the young women. For the men themselves go to the prostitutes and take part in the cults. God stands against the double standard where women are punished while men do the same thing. The main responsibility belongs to the men, who set the example and have the power.

The WEB speaks of "shrine prostitutes." Scholars disagree about whether there really was "holy prostitution" in Israel. What is sure is this: The women in these cults were often exploited.

Ephraim is joined to idols VERSES 15–19

15 "Israel, even if you act like a prostitute,
do not let Judah become guilty!
Do not go to Gilgal.
Do not go up to Beth Aven.
And do not swear, 'As surely as the LORD lives.'
16 For Israel has been very stubborn, like a stubborn young cow.
How then can the LORD feed them like a lamb in a meadow?
17 Ephraim has joined himself to idols.
Leave him alone!
18 Their drink has turned sour.
They act like prostitutes all the time.
Their rulers dearly love their shameful ways.
19 The wind has wrapped her up in its wings.
They will be put to shame because of their sacrifices."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Gilgal and Beth Aven ("house of evil") were places of worship in the northern kingdom. "Beth Aven" is a mocking name for Bethel ("house of God"). The house of God has become a house of evil.

Judah (the southern kingdom) should not make the same mistakes.

Verse 16: A stubborn cow that does not want to be led. God wants to feed his people like a shepherd feeds his lambs, but they do not let themselves be led.

Verse 17: "Ephraim" is another name for the northern kingdom of Israel (after its largest tribe). "Leave him alone!" – a sad sentence. Sometimes you have to let people go their own way.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 5

God draws back

A trap and a net VERSES 1–7

1 "Listen to this, you priests!
Pay attention, house of Israel!
Listen, house of the king!
For the judgment is against you.
You have been a trap at Mizpah
and a net spread out on Tabor.
2 The rebels are deep in killing,
but I will correct all of them.

3 I know Ephraim,
and Israel is not hidden from me.
For now, Ephraim, you have acted like a prostitute.
Israel has made itself unclean.
4 Their deeds do not let them turn back to their God.
For a spirit of prostitution is in them,
and they do not know the LORD.
5 The pride of Israel speaks against him to his face.
So Israel and Ephraim will stumble in their guilt.
Judah will also stumble with them.
6 They will go with their flocks and their herds
to look for the LORD,
but they will not find him.
He has drawn back from them.
7 They have been unfaithful to the LORD.
They have had children who are not his.
Now the New Moon festival will eat them up, together with their fields.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The priests, the people, and the royal family are all spoken to. The leaders are like traps and nets for the people: Instead of protecting them, they lead them into ruin. Mizpah and Tabor were places with shrines.

Verse 4: "Their deeds do not let them turn back to their God." A frightening insight: Whoever does wrong for a long time finds it harder and harder to get free of it. Bad habits can hold people captive.

Verse 6: They bring many animals for sacrifice and want to look for God, but they do not find him. God cannot be "bought" with sacrifices when the heart is not in it.

Verse 7: "Children who are not his" – children who are no longer raised in faith in God. The WEB says "illegitimate children." A whole generation has become strangers to God.

Alarm in Benjamin VERSES 8–12

8 "Blow the horn in Gibeah,
and the trumpet in Ramah!
Shout a battle cry at Beth Aven:
'Behind you, Benjamin!'
9 Ephraim will become a ruin on the day of punishment.
Among the tribes of Israel,
I have told what will surely happen.
10 The leaders of Judah are like people who move
boundary stones.
I will pour out my anger on them like water.
11 Ephraim is oppressed.
He is crushed in judgment,
because he was determined to run after idols.
12 So I am like a moth to Ephraim,
and like rot to the house of Judah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Alarm! Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth Aven are in the land of Benjamin, at the border between the northern and the southern kingdom. This probably points to a war between Israel and Judah (compare 2 Kings 16:5).

Verse 10: "Moving boundary stones" was a serious crime (Deuteronomy 19:14). In this way, people stole land from their neighbors. The leaders of Judah use the war to take land for themselves.

Verse 12: God compares himself to a moth and to rot. Not a dramatic judgment, but a slow, quiet falling apart from the inside.

False help from Assyria VERSES 13–15

13 "When Ephraim saw his sickness,
and Judah saw his wound,
Ephraim went to Assyria
and sent to King Jareb.
But he cannot heal you.
He cannot cure your wound.
14 For I will be like a lion to Ephraim,
and like a young lion to the house of Judah.
I myself will tear them to pieces and go away.
I will carry them off, and no one will rescue them.
15 I will go back to my place
until they admit their guilt
and look for my face.
In their trouble, they will look for me with all their heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Israel notices that it is "sick," that is, in great trouble. But instead of coming to God, it looks for help from the king of Assyria. "Jareb" means "the one who loves to fight," probably a mocking name for the Assyrian king. He cannot heal. On the contrary: Assyria later destroyed the northern kingdom.

Verse 14: A frightening picture: God like a lion. He is not harmless.

Verse 15: But the goal is not destruction. God draws back and waits "until they admit their guilt and look for my face." God hopes that his people will find their way back to him in their trouble.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 6

I desire mercy, not sacrifice

Come, let us return! VERSES 1–3

1 "Come! Let us return to the LORD.
For he has torn us to pieces,
and he will heal us.
He has wounded us,
and he will bandage our wounds.
2 After two days he will bring us back to life.
On the third day he will raise us up,
and we will live in his presence.
3 Let us know the LORD.
Let us try hard to know the LORD.
As surely as the sun rises,
the LORD will appear.

He will come to us like the rain,
like the spring rain that waters the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This sounds like a beautiful song about turning back to God. The people say: "Come! Let us return to the LORD. He has wounded us, and he will heal us."

Verse 2: "On the third day he will raise us up." Christians have often connected this verse with the resurrection of Jesus on the third day (compare 1 Corinthians 15:4: "He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures"). In its original setting, it means: God will quickly raise his people up again.

But be careful: The verses that follow show that God does not fully trust this song. Does this turning back sound too easy, as if it were a matter of course? As if you only had to say a few pious words, and God would make everything all right again?

Your love is like the morning dew VERSES 4–6

4 "Ephraim, what should I do with you?
Judah, what should I do with you?
For your love is like a morning cloud,
like the dew that disappears early.
5 That is why I have cut them to pieces through the prophets.
I have killed them with the words of my mouth.
Your judgments are like a flash of lightning.
6 For I desire mercy, not sacrifice.
I desire the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Here God sounds like desperate parents: "Ephraim, what should I do with you?" The people's love is like the morning dew: In the morning it is there, but as soon as the sun shines, it is gone. It does not last.

Verse 6: One of the most important sentences in the whole Bible: "For I desire mercy, not sacrifice. I desire the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."

The Hebrew word "chesed" means goodness, faithfulness, and loving mercy all at once. God does not want religious rituals without the heart. He wants real love, faithfulness, and mercy.

Jesus quotes this verse twice: when people blame him for eating with sinners (Matthew 9:13), and when people criticize his disciples because of the Sabbath (Matthew 12:7). "But go and learn what this means: 'I desire mercy, and not sacrifice'" (Matthew 9:13).

This verse is also very important in Judaism. After the temple was destroyed, Rabbi Johanan ben Zakkai taught with this verse: Acts of love now make up for sin, as the sacrifices did before.

They have broken the covenant VERSES 7–11

7 "But like Adam, they have broken the covenant.
There they were unfaithful to me.
8 Gilead is a city of people who do evil.
It is stained with blood.
9 Like gangs of robbers who lie in wait for a man,
so the priests join together and murder on the road to Shechem.
They commit shameful crimes.
10 In the house of Israel I have seen something horrible.
There Ephraim acts like a prostitute.
Israel has made itself unclean.
11 "And for you too, Judah, a harvest has been set,
when I turn things around for my people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: "Like Adam" – this can mean: like the first human being in paradise, who broke God's command. Or "Adam" here is the name of a place (a town by the Jordan, compare Joshua 3:16). The word "there" points to this. Both are possible.

Verses 8–9: Terrible conditions: violence and murder, even by priests. The people who should serve God have become robbers.

Verse 11: Judah too will get its "harvest," that is, the result of what it has done. But the verse ends with hope: "when I turn things around for my people." In the WEB, the words are: when I restore the fortunes of my people.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 7

A flat cake that was not turned over

Burning like an oven VERSES 1–7

1 "When I want to heal Israel,
then the guilt of Ephraim comes to light,
and the evil of Samaria too.
For they cheat and lie.
The thief breaks in,
and gangs of robbers rob people out on the streets.
2 They do not think in their hearts
that I remember all their evil.
Now their own deeds surround them.
They are right in front of my face.
3 They make the king glad with their evil,
and the leaders with their lies.
4 They are all unfaithful, like people who commit adultery.
They are burning like an oven.
The baker does not even need to stir the fire
from the time he kneads the dough
until it has risen.
5 On the day of our king's celebration,
the leaders made themselves sick with the heat of wine.
The king joined hands with people who mock.
6 For they have made their hearts ready like an oven,
while they lie in wait.
Their anger smolders all night.
In the morning it blazes up like a flaming fire.

7 They are all as hot as an oven.
They devour their judges.
All their kings have fallen.
Not one of them calls to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A sad sentence: God wants to heal. But the more closely he looks, the more evil comes to light.

Verses 3–7: Hosea describes the political situation in the northern kingdom. In his time, several kings were murdered one after the other (compare 2 Kings 15). The plotters flatter the king, get drunk with him at the feast, and then they strike.

The picture of the oven: Their passion and their desire to kill glow in secret like an oven overnight. And in the morning they break out like fire.

Verse 7: "Not one of them calls to me." In all the chaos, no one asks about God.

Ephraim does not notice VERSES 8–10

8 "Ephraim mixes himself with the nations.
Ephraim is a flat cake that was not turned over.
9 Strangers have eaten up his strength,
and he does not notice it.
Yes, gray hairs have appeared here and there on him,
and he does not notice it.
10 The pride of Israel speaks against him to his face.
And still, in spite of all this, they have not returned to the LORD their God.
They have not looked for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A vivid picture from the kitchen: a flat bread that someone forgot to turn over on the hot stone. It is burned on one side and raw on the other. Half this way, half that way. Israel is neither fully with God nor fully with the nations. It is useless.

Verse 9: A sad picture: Israel grows old and weak without noticing it. Gray hairs appear, but Israel thinks it is still young and strong. The foreign powers have eaten up its strength.

For today: Sometimes we do not notice how things slowly weaken us, until it is almost too late.

A silly dove VERSES 11–16

11 "Ephraim is like a dove that is easily fooled
and has no sense.
They call to Egypt.
They go to Assyria.
12 When they go,
I will spread my net over them.
I will bring them down like the birds of the sky.
I will punish them,
as their community has been told.
13 How terrible for them!
For they have wandered away from me.
Destruction will come on them!
For they have sinned against me.
I wanted to set them free,
but they have spoken lies against me.
14 They have not cried out to me from their hearts.
Instead, they howl on their beds.
They gather together for grain and new wine.
They turn away from me.
15 I trained them and made their arms strong,
and yet they plan evil against me.
16 They turn back, but not to the Most High.
They are like a bow that does not shoot straight.
Their leaders will fall by the sword
because of their angry words.
For this they will be laughed at in the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Israel is like a confused dove that flutters back and forth: now to Egypt, now to Assyria. It looks for protection from the great powers, but not from God.

Verse 13: "I wanted to set them free." God was ready to help. But they turned away.

Verse 14: They howl and complain on their beds, but only because they are hungry (grain and new wine). They do not cry out to God "from their hearts." They care about food, not about their relationship with God.

Verse 16: "They turn back, but not to the Most High." They change direction, but toward the wrong thing. Like a bow that does not shoot straight and misses.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 8

Whoever sows the wind will reap the whirlwind

An eagle over the house of the LORD VERSES 1–6

1 "Put the trumpet to your lips!
Something like an eagle is over the house of the LORD,
because they have broken my covenant
and rebelled against my law.
2 They cry out to me,
'My God, we, Israel, know you!'
3 Israel has thrown away what is good.
The enemy will chase him.
4 They have set up kings, but not by my choice.
They have made leaders, and I did not approve.
With their silver and their gold
they have made idols for themselves,
so that they will be destroyed.
5 Samaria, throw out your calf idol!
My anger burns against them!
How long will it be until they can be pure?
6 For this calf comes from Israel!
A craftsman made it,
and it is not God.
Yes, the calf of Samaria will be broken to pieces.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Alarm! Like a bird of prey, the enemy (Assyria) is already circling over the land.

Verse 2: The people say piously: "My God, we, Israel, know you!" But in verse 3, God says: "Israel has thrown away what is good." Pious words are not the same as really knowing God.

Verse 4: In the northern kingdom, kings often came to power by murder, not by God's will.

Verses 5–6: The "calf of Samaria": King Jeroboam I had set up golden bull statues in the northern kingdom (1 Kings 12:28–29). Hosea mocks: "A craftsman made it, and it is not God" (Hosea 8:6). How can something that a human being made be a god?

Sowing the wind, reaping the whirlwind VERSES 7–10

7 "For they sow the wind,
and they will reap the whirlwind.
There is no grain standing in his fields.
The stalks will produce no heads of grain.
And even if they produce some,
strangers will swallow it up.
8 Israel is swallowed up.
Now they are among the nations like something worthless.
9 For they have gone up to Assyria,
like a wild donkey wandering alone.
Ephraim has paid lovers for himself.
10 But even though they have sold themselves among the nations,
I will now gather them together.
And they will begin to waste away
under the heavy load of the king of mighty rulers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: "They sow the wind, and they will reap the whirlwind." A whirlwind is a violent storm. This became a famous saying. It is still used today. It means: Whoever does bad things will in the end get back something much worse. Small wrong decisions can have big, terrible consequences.

Verse 9: A wild donkey wanders around alone. Israel is alone and lonely because it has separated itself from God. And it even has to pay its "lovers" (its allies), with high tribute payments to Assyria (compare 2 Kings 15:19–20). Tribute is money that a weaker country must pay to a stronger one.

Verse 10: The "king of mighty rulers" is the king of Assyria. The burden of tribute will crush Israel.

Many altars, much sin VERSES 11–14

11 "Ephraim has built many altars for sinning.
So they have become altars for sinning for him.
12 I wrote down for him the many things of my law,
but they were seen as something strange.
13 As for the sacrifices they offer me,
they offer meat and eat it.
But the LORD does not accept them.
Now he will remember their guilt
and punish their sins.
They will go back to Egypt.
14 For Israel has forgotten his Maker
and has built palaces.
And Judah has built many cities with strong walls.
But I will send fire on his cities,
and it will burn up their fortresses."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: More altars do not mean more faith. On the contrary: They became places of sin.

Verse 12: God has written down his commandments, but the people treat them like something strange that has nothing to do with them.

Verse 13: The sacrifices are just barbecues now. They eat the meat, but God does not accept the sacrifices, because there is no real faith behind them.

"They will go back to Egypt" – a picture that they will fall back into the slavery from which God once set them free.

Verse 14: "Israel has forgotten his Maker and has built palaces." They trust in wealth and fortresses instead of God. But walls and palaces do not protect you if you forget God.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 9

The days of reckoning

No more joy VERSES 1–6

1 Do not rejoice, Israel.
Do not celebrate like the nations.
For you have been unfaithful to your God.
You love the pay of a prostitute on every threshing floor.
A threshing floor is a flat place where grain is separated from the straw.
2 The threshing floor and the winepress will not feed them.
The new wine will fail them.
3 They will not stay in the LORD's land.
Ephraim will go back to Egypt,
and they will eat unclean food in Assyria.
4 They will not pour out wine offerings to the LORD.
Their sacrifices will not please him.
Their sacrifices will be to them like the bread of mourners.
All who eat it will become unclean.
For their bread will only be for their own hunger.
It will not come into the house of the LORD.
5 What will you do on the day of the holy gathering,
on the day of the LORD's feast?
6 For when they run away from destruction,
Egypt will gather them up.
Memphis will bury them.
Weeds will take over their precious things of silver.
Thorns will grow in their tents.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The harvest festival is being celebrated, but Hosea calls out: "Do not rejoice!" On the threshing floors, the people thanked Baal, the god of fertility, for the harvest.

Hosea calls this "the pay of a prostitute": They believe the harvest is Baal's payment to them.

Verses 3–4: In the exile (in Assyria), they will no longer be able to celebrate feasts for God. They will have to eat unclean food. Their bread will be like "the bread of mourners": Bread in a house where someone had died was seen as unclean.

Verse 5: A sad question: "What will you do on the day of the holy gathering?" Without the temple and without the land, there are no more feasts.

Verse 6: Memphis in Egypt was known for its large burial grounds. Whoever flees to Egypt will be buried there. The abandoned land will be covered with weeds and thorns.

The prophet is a fool? VERSES 7–9

7 The days of punishment have come.
The days of reckoning have come.
Reckoning means: Everyone must answer for what they have done.
Israel will think that the prophet is a fool,
and that the man filled with the Spirit is crazy.
This is because your sins are so many,
and because your hatred is so great.

8 A prophet keeps watch over Ephraim together with my God.
But a bird catcher's trap is set on all his paths,
and there is hatred in the house of his God.

9 They have sunk deep into evil,
as in the days of Gibeah.
God will remember their guilt.
He will punish them for their sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: The people laugh at Hosea: "Israel will think that the prophet is a fool, and that the man filled with the Spirit is crazy." People who say uncomfortable truths are often made fun of.

Verse 8: The prophet is like a watchman (compare Ezekiel 3:17). But people set traps for him. Even in the temple, he meets hatred.

Verse 9: "As in the days of Gibeah" is a reminder of a terrible crime in Gibeah: There a woman suffered cruel sexual violence that led to her death (Judges 19–21). Hosea says: That is how low the people have sunk.

Like grapes in the wilderness VERSES 10–14

10 "I found Israel like grapes in the wilderness.
I saw your ancestors
like the first ripe figs on a fig tree in its first season.
But they came to Baal Peor.
They gave themselves to that shameful god.
And they became as disgusting as the thing they loved.

11 As for Ephraim, their glory will fly away like a bird.
There will be no birth,
no pregnancy,
and no conceiving of children.

12 Even if they bring up their children,
I will take them away,
so that not one is left.
Yes, how terrible for them when I turn away from them!

13 I have seen Ephraim like Tyre,
planted in a pleasant place.
But Ephraim will lead his children out to the killer."

14 Give them – LORD, what will you give them?
Give them wombs that lose their babies
and breasts that are dry.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: God remembers the beginning tenderly: When he found Israel, it was as precious as grapes in the wilderness or as the very first figs. Love at first sight!

But at Baal Peor, Israel already worshiped the god Baal in the wilderness (Numbers 25). God says: "They became as disgusting as the thing they loved" (Hosea 9:10). This means: We become like what we love and worship.

Verses 11–14: These verses are very hard. Baal, the god of fertility, was supposed to give children. Hosea says: Exactly the opposite will happen. Idol worship brings childlessness and death.

Verse 14: Hosea himself breaks off and hesitates: "Give them – LORD, what will you give them?" You can feel his pain. He does not know what to pray.

Very important: These verses describe a judgment on a whole people at a certain time. They do not mean in any way that a miscarriage, a stillbirth, or not being able to have children is God's punishment for a person. Anyone who has lost a child is not to blame. If you want to talk about it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Wanderers among the nations VERSES 15–17

15 "All their evil is in Gilgal.
That is where I began to hate them.
Because of the evil things they have done,
I will drive them out of my house.
I will not love them anymore.
All their leaders are rebels.

16 Ephraim has been struck down.
Their root has dried up.
They will bear no fruit.
Even if they give birth,
I will kill the dear children they bear."

17 My God will reject them,
because they did not listen to him.
And they will be wanderers among the nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: In Gilgal, Israel had once made Saul its first king (1 Samuel 11:15), even though God himself wanted to be their king. Later there was also idol worship there.

"I will not love them anymore." That is a terrible sentence. But you have to read the whole book: In Chapters 11 and 14, God says exactly the opposite: "How can I give you up?" and "I will love them freely" (14:4). God's anger is real, but his love has the last word.

Verse 16: A play on words: "Ephraim" sounds like "fruitful." But now Ephraim will bear no more fruit.

Verse 17: "Wanderers among the nations." That came true: After 722 BC, the Israelites of the northern kingdom were taken away by the Assyrians and scattered among the nations.

This verse is not permission for violence against children either. In the Bible, children always deserve protection (compare Mark 10:14: "Let the little children come to me!").

HOSEA

Chapter 10

Break up your unplowed ground!

A rich vine with a divided heart VERSES 1–8

1 Israel is a rich, spreading vine
that produces his fruit.
The more fruit he had,
the more altars he built.
The better things went for his land,
the more beautifully they decorated their sacred stones.
2 Their heart is divided.
Now they will be found guilty.
God will tear down their altars.
He will destroy their sacred stones.
3 Now they will surely say,
"We have no king,
because we do not fear the LORD.
And the king, what could he do for us?"
4 They make promises.
They swear falsely when they make agreements.
So judgment springs up like poisonous weeds
in the rows of a plowed field.
5 The people who live in Samaria will be terrified
about the calves of Beth Aven.
Its people will mourn over it,
together with its priests who used to celebrate over it,
over its glory,
because the glory has left it.
6 It too will be carried to Assyria
as a gift for a great king.
Ephraim will be put to shame.
Israel will be ashamed of his own plans.
7 Samaria and her king will float away
like a twig on the water.
8 The high places of Aven, the sin of Israel,
will also be destroyed.
High places were places of worship on hills.
Thorns and thistles will grow up on their altars.
They will say to the mountains, "Cover us!"
and to the hills, "Fall on us!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A sad contradiction: The richer Israel became, the more altars it built for foreign gods. Wealth did not lead to thankfulness toward God, but to more idol worship.

Verse 2: "Their heart is divided." They want both: a little bit of God and a little bit of Baal. But a divided heart does not hold together.

Verses 5–6: The golden calf in Bethel (mockingly called "Beth Aven" = house of evil) is carried away by the Assyrians as loot. The god they trusted is itself dragged away!

Verse 7: A strong picture: The king floats helplessly like a twig on the water.

Verse 8: "They will say to the mountains, 'Cover us!' and to the hills, 'Fall on us!'" That is how great their despair is. Jesus says these words on the way to the cross (Luke 23:30). They also appear in Revelation (Revelation 6:16).

Break up your unplowed ground VERSES 9–15

9 "Israel, you have sinned since the days of Gibeah.
They have stayed there.
The battle against the wicked people
does not reach them in Gibeah.
10 When I want to, I will punish them.
The nations will gather against them
when they are tied to their two sins.
11 Ephraim is a trained young cow
that loves to thresh grain.
So I will put a yoke on her beautiful neck.
I will put a rider on Ephraim.
Judah will plow.
Jacob will break up the clods of earth.
12 Sow righteousness for yourselves.
Then you will reap the fruit of kindness.
Break up your unplowed ground,
for it is time to look for the LORD,
until he comes and rains righteousness on you.
13 You have plowed evil.
You have reaped wrongdoing.
You have eaten the fruit of lies.
For you trusted in your own way
and in your many strong soldiers.
14 So the roar of battle will rise up among your people.
All your fortresses will be destroyed,
just as Shalman destroyed Beth Arbel on the day of battle.
There the mother was smashed to pieces together with her children.
15 That is what Bethel will do to you
because of your great evil.
At dawn, the king of Israel will be completely destroyed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Israel was like a young cow that likes to thresh grain. When threshing, the cow was allowed to eat (Deuteronomy 25:4). It was pleasant work. Now it has to carry the heavy yoke of the plow. A yoke is a wooden bar put on the neck of animals that pull a plow.

Verse 12: A beautiful call: "Sow righteousness for yourselves. Then you will reap the fruit of kindness. Break up your unplowed ground." Righteousness means: living right before God. Unplowed ground is a field that has not been used for a long time and has become hard. You have to break it up so that something can grow again. In the same way, the people should break up their hard hearts and start over. Compare Jeremiah 4:3.

"It is time to look for the LORD." It is never too late for a new beginning.

Verse 13: The opposite: Whoever plows evil reaps wrongdoing. Whoever trusts in their own strength and soldiers eats "the fruit of lies."

Verse 14: Beth Arbel was a city that was cruelly destroyed. No one knows for sure who "Shalman" was. The sentence "There the mother was smashed to pieces together with her

children" describes the cruelty of war. The Bible does not keep quiet about what war does to women and children. Violence like this is a terrible wrong. If you have experienced war and want to talk about it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

HOSEA

Chapter 11

How can I give you up?

When Israel was young, I loved him VERSES 1–4

1 "When Israel was a child, I loved him.
And I called my son out of Egypt.
2 They called to them,
so they went away from them.
They offered sacrifices to the Baals
and burned incense to carved idols.
3 And yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk.
I took them by their arms.
But they did not know that it was I who healed them.
4 I led them with human ropes,
with ties of love.
I was to them like someone who lifts the yoke off their necks.
I bent down to him
and fed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most tender texts in the whole Bible. God speaks like a father or a mother about a child.

Verse 1: "When Israel was a child, I loved him." God remembers the beginning, when he set Israel free from Egypt.

The Gospel writer Matthew quotes this verse about Jesus, who fled to Egypt as a child with Mary and Joseph and came back: "Out of Egypt I called my son" (Matthew 2:15).

Verse 3: "And yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk." Just as parents hold a child's hands when it takes its first steps. "I took them by their arms." But the child did not notice who had helped it.

Verse 4: "With ties of love." God did not pull with force, but with love. "I bent down to him and fed him." Like a mother who bends down to her little child to feed it.

This picture shows: God also has motherly sides.

They do not want to turn back VERSES 5–7

5 "They will not go back to the land of Egypt.
But the Assyrian will be their king,
because they refused to turn back to me.
6 The sword will fall on their cities.
It will destroy the bars of their gates
and put an end to their plans.
7 My people are determined to turn away from me.
Even if they call to the Most High,
he will certainly not lift them up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The beloved child has turned away. And that has consequences: Assyria will rule over them. The sword will come.

Here you can feel God's pain: like parents whose child is going down a dangerous road and no longer listens to them.

My heart is turned within me VERSES 8–11

8 "How can I give you up, Ephraim?
How can I hand you over, Israel?
How can I make you like Admah?
How can I make you like Zeboiim?
My heart is turned within me.
My compassion is stirred up.
9 I will not act in my fierce anger.
I will not come back to destroy Ephraim.
For I am God, and not a human being.
I am the Holy One among you.
I will not come in anger.
10 They will follow the LORD.
He will roar like a lion.
When he roars,
the children will come trembling from the west.
11 They will come trembling like a bird out of Egypt,
and like a dove out of the land of Assyria.
And I will let them live in their homes,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point of the whole book!

Verse 8: God struggles with himself: "How can I give you up, Ephraim?" Admah and Zeboiim were cities that were destroyed together with Sodom and Gomorrah (Deuteronomy 29:23). God says: I cannot do that to my beloved child!

"My heart is turned within me." God's love is stronger than his anger. Compassion wins.

Verse 9: The most important reason: "For I am God, and not a human being." A human being might say: "That is enough now. You have only got what you deserve." But God is different. Precisely because he is holy, precisely because he is God, he can forgive where people would give up.

Verses 10–11: God roars like a lion, but not to attack. He roars to call his children. And they come trembling, like birds, from everywhere, back home.

These verses show God's heart. Jesus tells the same message in the parable of the lost son: The father sees his son from far away, is moved with compassion, runs to meet him, and hugs him (Luke 15:20).

Lies and deceit VERSE 12

12 Ephraim surrounds me with lies,
and the house of Israel with deceit.
Judah still wanders away from God
and is unfaithful to the Holy One.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, this verse is the first verse of Chapter 12 (12:1). That is why the verse numbers in Chapter 12 of the WEB are one lower than in many other Bibles.

After God's wonderful confession of love comes reality: The people go on lying and deceiving. God's love is there, but people also have to accept it.

The meaning of the second part is not quite clear in Hebrew. Some translations understand it in a positive way (Judah still holds on to God). The WEB understands it in a negative way.

HOSEA

CHAPTER 12

Jacob, who struggled with God

Ephraim chases the wind VERSES 1–2

1 Ephraim feeds on wind.
He chases the east wind.
He keeps making more and more lies and ruin.
They make a covenant with Assyria,
and oil is carried to Egypt.
2 The LORD also has a charge against Judah.
He will punish Jacob for the way he lives.
He will pay him back for what he has done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, the verse numbers in this chapter are one higher (12:2–15).

Verse 1: "Feeding on wind" and "chasing the east wind" – that is pointless. That is how pointless it is to rely on Assyria and Egypt. Israel made agreements with both great powers at the same time and sent oil to Egypt as a gift. A dangerous double game.

Jacob, the fighter VERSES 3–6

3 In the womb, he took hold of his brother's heel.
And as a grown man, he struggled with God.
4 Yes, he struggled with the angel and won.
He wept and pleaded with him.
He found God at Bethel,
and there God spoke with us –
5 the LORD, the God of Armies.
The LORD is his famous name!
6 So turn back to your God!
Hold on to kindness and justice,
and always wait for your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hosea reminds the people of Jacob, the father of the people of Israel (Israel is Jacob's second name):

– Even in the womb, he held on to the heel of his twin brother Esau (Genesis 25:26). The name "Jacob" sounds like "heel-holder," and also like "cheater."

– Later, he struggled with God a whole night by the river Jabbok and received the name "Israel" ("he struggles with God," Genesis 32:22–30).

– At Bethel, God met him in the dream of the stairway to heaven (Genesis 28:10–22).

Verse 4: "He wept and pleaded with him" – this is a detail that is not written like this in Genesis. Jacob did not only fight. He also wept and pleaded with God.

The message: Jacob was not a perfect person either. He was a cheater. But he struggled with God and met him. In the same way, the people should turn back to God.

Verse 6: The way back is simple to say: "Hold on to kindness and justice, and always wait for your God." That is a good summary of faith, for today too.

Dishonest scales and false pride VERSES 7–11

7 A merchant has dishonest scales in his hand.
He loves to cheat people.
8 Ephraim said,
"Surely I have become rich.
I have gained wealth for myself.
In all my wealth, they will not find any guilt in me
that would be sin."
9 "But I am the LORD your God
ever since the land of Egypt.
I will again make you live in tents,
as in the days of the holy feast.
10 I have also spoken to the prophets.
I have given them many visions.
And through the prophets, I have spoken in parables.
11 If Gilead is evil,
then they are surely worthless.
In Gilgal they sacrifice bulls.
Yes, their altars are like piles of stones
in the rows of a plowed field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: Israel is like a dishonest merchant with false scales. And then he says proudly: "Surely I have become rich ... In all my wealth, they will not find any guilt in me." He means: No one can blame me for anything! Wealth through cheating, and then self-righteous on top of it.

Verse 9: God reminds them: "I am the LORD your God ever since the land of Egypt." He will make them live in tents again, as at the Feast of Tabernacles (also called the Feast of Booths), when people remembered the time in the wilderness. This can mean punishment (losing their houses) or also a new beginning like back then in the wilderness (compare Hosea 2:14).

Verse 10: God spoke through prophets again and again, in pictures and parables. Parables are stories or pictures that teach something. He was not silent.

Through a prophet VERSES 12–14

12 Jacob fled to the country of Aram.
Israel worked to get a wife.
To get a wife, he took care of flocks and herds.
13 Through a prophet, the LORD brought Israel up out of Egypt.
And through a prophet, Israel was kept safe.
14 Ephraim has made God bitterly angry.
So the guilt of his bloodshed will stay on him.
And his Lord will pay him back for his insults.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Jacob had to flee from Esau. For many years he worked as a shepherd for Laban, so that he could marry

Rachel (Genesis 29). A picture of how hard the way of the father of Israel was.

Verse 13: The "prophet" through whom God led Israel out of Egypt is Moses. God has always led and protected his people through prophets. Hosea places himself in this line.

Verse 14: Ephraim has bitterly disappointed God. It must bear the consequences of what it has done.

HOSEA

Chapter 13

Death, where is your sting?

Like the morning mist VERSES 1–3

1 When Ephraim spoke, people trembled.
He was lifted up high in Israel.
But when he became guilty by worshiping Baal,
he died.
2 Now they sin more and more.
They make metal idols for themselves out of their silver,
idols that they thought up themselves,
all of them made by craftsmen.
They say about them,
"They offer human sacrifices and kiss the calves."
3 So they will be like the morning mist,
like the dew that disappears early,
like the chaff that a whirlwind blows off the threshing floor,
and like the smoke out of a chimney.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Ephraim (the northern kingdom) was once powerful and respected. But through the worship of Baal, it has "died" inside.

Verse 2: A ridiculous picture: People kiss calves made of metal that craftsmen have made. The phrase "They offer human sacrifices" is not clear in Hebrew. It can also mean: "The people who offer sacrifices kiss the calves."

Verse 3: Four pictures of things that do not last: mist, dew, chaff, smoke. Everything disappears quickly. That is how short-lived a life without God is.

I have been your God since Egypt VERSES 4–8

4 "Yet I am the LORD your God
ever since the land of Egypt.
You must know no god but me.
There is no savior except me.
5 I knew you in the wilderness,
in the land of great drought.
6 When they had pasture, they ate their fill.
They were full,
and their hearts became proud.
That is why they have forgotten me.
7 So I am like a lion to them.
Like a leopard, I will lie in wait by the road.
8 I will attack them like a mother bear
whose cubs have been taken from her.
I will tear open their chests.
There I will eat them up like a lioness.
The wild animals will tear them apart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "There is no savior except me." The Hebrew word for "savior" is related to the name Hosea (and Jesus).

Verses 5–6: A pattern that the Bible describes again and again: In times of need, in the wilderness, the people were close to God. When they became full and rich, they forgot God (compare Deuteronomy 8:11–14). Wealth can be dangerous if you forget the one who gives it.

Verses 7–8: God compares himself with dangerous animals: a lion, a leopard, a mother bear. Especially powerful is the "mother bear whose cubs have been taken from her," a picture of hurt, angry love. God's anger comes from his hurt love.

Where is your king now? VERSES 9–13

9 "Israel, you are destroyed,
because you are against me, against your helper.
10 Where is your king now,
who could save you in all your cities?
And where are your judges?
You said about them,
'Give me a king and leaders.'
11 I gave you a king in my anger,
and I took him away in my anger.
12 The guilt of Ephraim is stored up.
His sin is kept on record.
13 Pains like those of a woman giving birth will come on him.
He is a foolish son.
When it is time,
he does not come out of the womb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Israel wanted a king like all the other nations (1 Samuel 8:5). But the kings could not save the people. In the northern kingdom, one king after another was murdered.

Verse 13: An unusual picture: a baby that does not want to come out at birth, even though it is time. Israel has the chance to turn back, to a new life, but it simply gets stuck. A picture of missed chances.

Death, where are your plagues? VERSES 14–16

14 "I will pay the price to free them from the power of Sheol (the world of the dead).
I will set them free from death!
Death, where are your plagues?
Sheol, where is your destruction?
"Compassion will be hidden from my eyes.
15 Even though he grows well among his brothers,
an east wind will come,
the breath of the LORD rising up from the wilderness.
His spring will run dry,
and his well will dry up.
The enemy will rob his storehouse of all its treasures.

16 Samaria will bear her guilt,
for she has rebelled against her God.
They will fall by the sword.
Their little children will be smashed to pieces,
and their pregnant women will be ripped open."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: A mysterious and famous verse. It can be understood in two ways:

– As a threatening question: Should I really pay the price to free them from death? No! Death, come with your plagues! The last sentence points to this: "Compassion will be hidden."

– As a promise, the way the WEB translates it: "I will set them free from death! Death, where are your plagues?"

The apostle Paul takes up this verse and rejoices over the resurrection of Jesus: "Death, where is your sting? Hades, where is your victory?" (1 Corinthians 15:55). For Christians, this is a promise: Death does not have the last word.

Verse 15: The "east wind" is a hot desert wind and is a picture of Assyria here.

Verse 16: This verse describes the horrible cruelty of the Assyrian war that came over Samaria in 722 BC. Acts of cruelty like these against children and pregnant women are terrible war crimes. The Bible does not keep quiet about them, but it does not approve of them. Violence against children and pregnant women is always wrong.

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, verse 16 is the first verse of Chapter 14 (14:1). That is why the verse numbers in Chapter 14 of the WEB are one lower.

If you carry painful experiences of war or violence: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

HOSEA

Chapter 14

I will love them freely

Return, Israel! VERSES 1–3

1 Israel, return to the LORD your God.
For you have fallen because of your sin.
2 Take words with you
and return to the LORD.
Say to him,
"Forgive all our sins,
and accept what is good.
Then we will offer you bulls,
as we promised with our lips.
3 Assyria cannot save us.
We will not ride on horses anymore.
And we will never again say to the work of our hands,
'Our gods!'
For with you, the orphan finds mercy."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, the verse numbers in this chapter are one higher (14:2–10).

After all the words of judgment, the book ends with a great call to turn back.

Verse 2: "Take words with you." God does not ask for expensive sacrifices. He wants honest words, a prayer from the heart. Hosea even gives the people the prayer they should say.

Verse 3: The people are to give up three things: trusting in Assyria (political alliances), in horses (military power), and in gods they made themselves.

"With you, the orphan finds mercy." A beautiful sentence: Israel is like an orphan who has no one anymore. But with God, it finds mercy.

In Judaism, this passage is read on "Shabbat Shuvah," the Sabbath of Return between the Jewish New Year and the Day of Atonement.

I will be like the dew VERSES 4–8

4 "I will heal their unfaithfulness.
I will love them freely,
for my anger has turned away from them.
5 I will be like the dew to Israel.
He will bloom like the lily.
He will send down his roots like Lebanon.
6 His branches will spread out.
His beauty will be like the olive tree,
and his fragrance like Lebanon.
7 People will live in his shade.
They will come back to life like the grain
and bloom like the grapevine.
Their fragrance will be like the wine of Lebanon.
8 Ephraim, what more do I have to do with idols?
I answer him, and I will take care of him.
I am like a green cypress tree.
Your fruit comes from me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's answer is beautiful:

Verse 4: "I will heal their unfaithfulness. I will love them freely." Unfaithfulness means: The people turned away from God. They were not faithful to him. God does not love because the people deserved it, but freely, out of pure grace. And he heals their unfaithfulness the way an illness is healed.

Verse 5: "I will be like the dew to Israel." In Hosea 6:4, the people's love was "like the dew that disappears early." Now God himself is the dew that comes new every morning and refreshes the land. In Israel's dry summer, the dew is vital.

Verses 5–7: Many pictures of life and beauty: blooming lilies, deep roots, spreading branches, the olive tree, fragrance, grain, the grapevine.

Verse 8: God compares himself with an evergreen tree that bears fruit. This is a very rare picture in the Bible. The fruitfulness that Israel looked for in Baal really comes from God: "Your fruit comes from me."

Lebanon was famous for its great cedar trees with deep roots.

Whoever is wise, let him understand VERSE 9

9 Who is wise enough to understand these things?
Who has enough good sense to know them?

For the ways of the LORD are right.
Those who do right walk in them.
But the rebels stumble in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last verse is like an afterword for the readers: Whoever is wise should think about this book. God's ways are good and straight. Some walk on them and find life. Others stumble over them.

The book is an offer. Every reader must decide for themselves how to answer it.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Hosea?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet who feels God's pain: Hosea married Gomer, who became unfaithful to him. So he felt in his own life what God feels when his people leave him (Chapters 1–3).

Children with message names: "No mercy" and "Not my people." But in the end the names are turned around: "mercy" and "my people" (1:10; 2:23).

God tries to win his people back: "So I will win her back with love. I will bring her into the wilderness and speak tenderly to her" (2:14). God wants a relationship of love, not of power.

The charge: "There is no truth, no goodness, and no knowledge of God in the land" (4:1). Lies, violence, idol worship, and false trust in great powers.

Mercy instead of sacrifice: "For I desire mercy, not sacrifice" (6:6). Jesus quoted this sentence twice.

Wind and whirlwind: "For they sow the wind, and they will reap the whirlwind" (8:7).

God's mother's heart: "It was I who taught Ephraim to walk … with ties of love … I bent down to him" (Chapter 11).

Love that does not give up: "How can I give you up, Ephraim? … For I am God, and not a human being" (11:8–9).

Healing: "I will heal their unfaithfulness. I will love them freely … I will be like the dew to Israel" (14:4–5).

Hard pictures: The pictures of the unfaithful wife come from a time when men had all the power. They never justify violence in relationships. And the cruelties of war that the book describes are wrong.

For today: Hosea shows that God is not cold and does not stop caring. He loves, he suffers, he struggles with himself, and in the end his love wins. It is never too late to turn back: "Take words with you and return to the LORD."

What comes next? Next comes the prophet Joel. A terrible plague of locusts becomes his reason to call the people to turn back. And he promises: "I will pour out my Spirit on all people."

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 29 OF 66

JOEL

3 CHAPTERS

JOEL

Chapter 1

The plague of locusts

Before we begin: Who was Joel?

We know very little about the prophet Joel. His name means "The LORD is God." He was a son of Pethuel and worked in Judah, probably in Jerusalem, because he often speaks about the temple and the priests.

The book does not say when he lived. Some scholars think of the time before the exile. Many think of the time after the exile (5th or 4th century BC), when the second temple was already standing.

The reason for the book was a terrible plague of locusts together with a drought. Locusts are large grasshoppers that fly in huge swarms. Joel sees in this a sign of the coming "day of the LORD," and he calls the people to turn back to God.

Then everything turns out well: God has mercy, gives new rain, and promises: "I will pour out my Spirit on all people" (in the WEB 2:28). On the day of Pentecost, Peter quotes exactly these words (Acts 2:16–21).

A note on the numbering: The WEB divides Joel into 3 chapters, like most English Bibles. Some other Bibles (for example, Hebrew Bibles) have 4 chapters. There, WEB 2:28–32 is Chapter 3, and WEB Chapter 3 is Chapter 4.

Nothing like this has ever happened VERSES 1–4

1 This is the word of the LORD that came to Joel, the son
of Pethuel.
2 Listen to this, you elders!
Listen, all you people who live in the land!
Has anything like this ever happened in your days,
or in the days of your ancestors?
3 Tell your children about it.
Let your children tell their children,
and let their children tell the next generation.
4 What the swarming locust left,
the great locust has eaten.
What the great locust left,
the grasshopper has eaten.
What the grasshopper left,
the caterpillar has eaten.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joel describes a disaster like none before: a plague of locusts, wave after wave. Four names for locusts are given. Maybe they are different kinds, or different stages in the life of these animals. What the first wave leaves, the next one eats.

Swarms of locusts can be huge, millions of animals. In a short time, they eat up everything green. Plagues like this still happen today, for example in East Africa, and they mean hunger for many people.

Verse 3: Pass it on, generation after generation! The memory of this disaster should not be forgotten.

Everyone, mourn! VERSES 5–12

5 Wake up, you drunkards, and weep!
Cry out loud, all you who drink wine,
because of the sweet wine,
for it has been taken away from your mouths.
6 For a nation has come up against my land.
It is strong, and there are too many to count.
Its teeth are the teeth of a lion.
It has the fangs of a lioness.
7 It has ruined my grapevine
and stripped my fig tree bare.
It has peeled off its bark
and thrown it away.
Its branches have turned white.
8 Mourn like a young woman dressed in sackcloth
who mourns for the man she was going to marry!
Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they were very sad.
9 The grain offerings and the drink offerings are cut off
from the house of the LORD.
The priests, who serve the LORD, are mourning.
10 The field is ruined.
The land mourns,
for the grain is destroyed.
The new wine has dried up,
and the olive oil is running out.
11 Be ashamed, you farmers!
Cry out loud, you who grow grapes,
for the wheat and for the barley.
For the harvest of the field is lost.
12 The grapevine has dried up,
and the fig tree has withered.
The pomegranate tree, the palm tree, and the apple tree,
all the trees of the field have withered.
Yes, joy has dried up among the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joel calls everyone to mourn: the wine drinkers, the farmers, the people who grow grapes, the priests.

Verse 6: The locusts are described like an enemy army, with teeth like lions. Some interpreters think that the locusts also stand for a real enemy army.

Verse 7: The locusts even eat the bark off the trees, so that the branches stand there white and bare.

Verse 8: The mourning should be as deep as that of a young woman whose future husband has died. In the WEB, he is called the husband of her youth.

Verse 9: Without a harvest, there are no more offerings in the temple. The worship of God comes to a stop.

Verse 12: "Joy has dried up among the people." The disaster affects not only the food, but all of life.

Call for a fast! VERSES 13–20

13 Put on sackcloth and mourn, you priests!
Cry out loud, you who serve at the altar!

Come, spend the night in sackcloth,
you who serve my God.
For the grain offerings and the drink offerings
are kept away from the house of your God.
14 Set apart a holy time of fasting!
Fasting means: not eating for a time, to pray to God.
Call a holy gathering!
Gather the elders
and all the people who live in the land
to the house of the LORD your God,
and cry out to the LORD.
15 Oh, what a terrible day!
For the day of the LORD is near.
It will come like destruction from the Almighty.
16 Hasn't our food been taken away before our eyes?
Haven't joy and gladness been taken from the house of our God?
17 The seeds are rotting under the clods of earth.
The storehouses are empty.
The barns have fallen down,
for the grain has dried up.
18 How the animals groan!
The herds of cattle wander around confused,
because they have no pasture.
Yes, the flocks of sheep are suffering too.
19 LORD, I cry out to you!
For fire has burned up the pastures of the wilderness.
The flames have burned all the trees of the field.
20 Yes, the animals of the field long for you,
for the streams of water have dried up,
and fire has burned up the pastures of the wilderness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: In the time of trouble, everyone should come together, fast, and cry out to God. The trouble should lead to prayer.

Verse 15: "The day of the LORD is near." Joel sees in the disaster a warning sign of the great day when God steps in.

Verses 17–20: Along with the plague of locusts comes a terrible drought with fires. Even the animals "long for" God and suffer too. That is a reminder of Psalm 42, where a deer longs for streams of water.

Verse 19: Joel himself prays: "LORD, I cry out to you!" He does not wait until the others pray. He starts himself.

For today: There are droughts, forest fires, and failed harvests today too, often made worse by climate change. Joel shows: In crises like these, we should mourn, pray, and act together. And he shows that God also sees the suffering of the animals.

Important: Natural disasters are not simply God's punishment for the people who suffer from them (compare Luke 13:1–5). Joel uses the disaster as a reason to think about our own lives.

JOEL

CHAPTER 2

Tear your hearts

The day of the LORD is coming VERSES 1–11

1 Blow the trumpet in Zion!
Sound the alarm on my holy mountain!
Let all the people who live in the land tremble,
for the day of the LORD is coming.
It is very near.
2 It is a day of darkness and gloom,
a day of clouds and thick darkness.
Like the dawn spreading over the mountains,
a great and strong people comes.
There has never been anything like it,
and there will never be anything like it again,
not for many generations.
3 A fire burns up everything in front of them.
Behind them, a flame burns.
In front of them, the land is like the garden of Eden.
Behind them, it is an empty wilderness.
Yes, no one has escaped them.
4 They look like horses,
and they run like horsemen.
5 They leap on the tops of the mountains
with a noise like chariots,
with a noise like flames of fire burning up dry straw,
like a strong army lined up for battle.
6 When the peoples see them, they are in agony.
Every face turns pale.
7 They run like mighty soldiers.
They climb the wall like warriors.
Each one marches in his line.
They do not leave their path.
8 They do not push each other.
Each one marches in his own track.
They break through the defenses
and do not break their ranks.
9 They rush into the city.
They run on the wall.
They climb up into the houses.
They come in through the windows like thieves.
10 The earth shakes in front of them.
The heavens tremble.
The sun and the moon grow dark,
and the stars stop shining.
11 The LORD thunders with his voice in front of his army.
For his army is very great.
The one who carries out his command is strong.
For the day of the LORD is great and very terrible.
Who can live through it?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joel describes the locusts like a huge, perfectly organized army. Anyone who has ever seen a swarm of locusts knows this: The animals darken the sky, they eat everything, and they even get into the houses through the windows.

Verse 3: Before, the land is like paradise. Afterward, it is a desert.

Verse 4: The head of a locust really does look a little like a horse's head. In Italian, the locust is even called "cavalletta," "little horse."

Verse 11: And the frightening part: This army is God's army. The "day of the LORD" is a day of judgment. "Who can live through it?"

Turn back with all your heart VERSES 12–14

12 "But even now," says the LORD,
"turn back to me with all your heart,
with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning."
13 Tear your hearts, not your clothes,
and turn back to the LORD your God.
For he is gracious and merciful.
He is slow to become angry, and he is full of loving kindness.
He is ready to change his mind about sending disaster.
14 Who knows?
Maybe he will turn and change his mind.
Maybe he will leave a blessing behind him,
a grain offering and a drink offering
for the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "But even now!" In the middle of the disaster, it is not too late. God invites the people to turn back.

Verse 13: A famous sentence: "Tear your hearts, not your clothes." At that time, people tore their clothes as a sign of grief. But God does not want outward signs. He wants a real change in the heart.

"He is gracious and merciful. He is slow to become angry, and he is full of loving kindness" – that is how God described himself to Moses (Exodus 34:6). It is one of the most important statements about God in the Old Testament.

Verse 14: "Who knows?" Joel does not promise anything. God is free. But we may hope.

This passage is read in many churches on Ash Wednesday, at the beginning of Lent, the time of fasting before Easter.

Gather everyone! VERSES 15–17

15 Blow the trumpet in Zion!
Set apart a holy time of fasting!
Call a holy gathering!
16 Gather the people!
Make the gathering holy!
Bring the elders together!
Gather the children
and the babies who are still nursing!
Let the bridegroom come out of his room
and the bride out of her room.
17 Let the priests, who serve the LORD,
weep between the porch of the temple and the altar.
Let them say,
"Spare your people, LORD!
Do not let your own people be put to shame,
with the nations ruling over them.
Why should they say among the peoples,
'Where is their God?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everyone should come: old people and children, even the babies, even the bride and groom who are just getting married. No one is left out. In times of trouble, the whole community stands together before God.

Verse 17: The priests pray: "Spare your people, LORD!" And they have a strong argument: What will the other nations think? "Where is their God?" God's honor is at stake.

God answers VERSES 18–20

18 Then the LORD became zealous for his land.
He had pity on his people.
19 The LORD answered his people,
"I will send you grain, new wine, and oil.
You will have enough of them and be satisfied.
I will never again make you a joke among the nations.
20 I will drive the army from the north far away from you.
I will push it into a dry and empty land,
its front into the eastern sea,
and its back into the western sea.
Its stink will rise up,
and its bad smell will go up."
Surely he has done great things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the turning point of the book: God has pity. He answers the prayer of the people.

Verse 20: The "army from the north" is probably the locusts (or an enemy that they stand for). God drives them into the sea. Swarms of locusts really are sometimes blown into the sea by the wind and die there. Then the dead animals stink terribly on the coast.

The "eastern sea" is the Dead Sea. The "western sea" is the Mediterranean Sea.

Rejoice! VERSES 21–27

21 Land, do not be afraid!
Be glad and rejoice,
for the LORD has done great things.
22 Do not be afraid, you animals of the field!
For the pastures of the wilderness are turning green.
The trees are bearing their fruit.
The fig tree and the grapevine give their full harvest.
23 "So be glad, you people of Zion!
Rejoice in the LORD your God!
For he gives you the early rain in the right amount.
He makes the rain come down for you,
the early rain and the late rain, as before.
24 The threshing floors will be full of wheat.
The vats will overflow with new wine and oil.
25 I will give you back what you lost in the years
that the swarming locust has eaten,
the great locust, the grasshopper, and the caterpillar,
my great army that I sent among you.
26 You will have plenty to eat and be satisfied.
You will praise the name of the LORD your God,
who has done wonderful things for you.
And my people will never again be put to shame.
27 You will know that I am in the middle of Israel,
and that I am the LORD your God, and there is no other.
And my people will never again be put to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the great joy. The land, the animals, and the people should not be afraid anymore. God sends rain at the

right time: the early rain in the fall (for sowing) and the late rain in the spring (for ripening).

Verse 25: A wonderful promise: "I will give you back what you lost in the years that the swarming locust has eaten." The swarming locust is a kind of locust. God can make up for lost time. Many people have found comfort in this verse when they felt they had lost years of their lives through illness, war, addiction, or guilt.

Verse 27: "You will know that I am in the middle of Israel." That is the greatest gift: not only grain and wine, but God's nearness.

I will pour out my Spirit VERSES 28–32

28 "And afterward, this will happen:
I will pour out my Spirit on all people.
Your sons and your daughters will prophesy.
Your old men will dream dreams.
Your young men will see visions.
29 In those days, I will pour out my Spirit
even on the male and female servants.
30 I will show wonders in the sky and on the earth:
blood, fire, and columns of smoke.
31 The sun will turn dark,
and the moon will turn to blood,
before the great and terrible day of the LORD comes.
32 And this will happen:
Whoever calls on the name of the LORD will be saved.
For on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem
there will be people who escape,
as the LORD has said.
Among those who are left, there will be those whom
the LORD calls."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, these verses form their own Chapter 3 (Joel 3:1–5).

This is one of the greatest promises in the Bible. Before, God's Spirit came only on individual people: prophets, kings, judges. Now God says: I will pour out my Spirit "on all people"! The WEB says: "on all flesh." To prophesy means: to speak a message from God.

And on all of them, without any difference:

– sons and daughters (men and women),

– old and young,

– even male and female servants (slaves, who were at the very bottom of society).

God's Spirit makes no difference between people because of whether they are men or women, old or young, or rich or poor. Moses already had this wish: "I wish that all the LORD's people were prophets" (Numbers 11:29).

On the day of Pentecost, when the Holy Spirit came on the disciples of Jesus, Peter quotes exactly these verses: "No, this is what God spoke through the prophet Joel" (Acts 2:16–21).

Verse 32: "Whoever calls on the name of the LORD will be saved." Paul also quotes this sentence (Romans 10:13). Salvation is open to everyone who turns to God.

JOEL

CHAPTER 3

The valley of decision

Judgment on the nations VERSES 1–8

1 "For in those days and at that time,
when I turn things around for Judah and Jerusalem,
2 I will gather all the nations.
I will bring them down into the valley of Jehoshaphat.
There I will judge them
because of my people, my own people Israel.
They scattered them among the nations,
and they divided up my land.
3 They threw lots for my people.
They traded a boy for a prostitute.
They sold a girl for wine
so that they could drink.
4 "Yes, and what are you to me,
Tyre and Sidon, and all the regions of Philistia?
Do you want to pay me back for something?
If you pay me back,
I will quickly and suddenly turn what you do back on
your own heads.
5 For you have taken my silver and my gold.
You have carried my finest treasures into your
temples.
6 You have sold the people of Judah and the people of
Jerusalem
to the Greeks,
to take them far away from their own land.
7 I will stir them up and bring them out of the place
where you have sold them.
And I will turn what you have done back on your own
heads.
8 I will sell your sons and your daughters
into the hands of the people of Judah.
They will sell them to the people of Sheba,
a nation far away.
For the LORD has spoken."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A note on the numbering: In some Bibles, this is Chapter 4.

Verse 2: The "valley of Jehoshaphat" means "The LORD judges." It is more a symbolic place than one particular valley: the place where God judges the nations. An old tradition connects it with the Kidron Valley near Jerusalem.

Verse 3: Throwing lots was a kind of game of chance, a way to decide things. A terrible crime: The enemies sold children from Judah as slaves, a boy for a prostitute, a girl for a jug of wine. People, especially children, were treated like cheap goods. God sees this wrong and will judge it.

Verse 6: Tyre and Sidon (Phoenician trading cities) sold people from Judah as slaves to Greece.

Verse 8: The punishment fits the crime: Whoever sold others as slaves will be sold themselves. This verse describes paying back in the way people thought at that time. It is not permission to make people slaves. Slavery and human trafficking are a serious wrong, then as now. The Bible itself forbids kidnapping people (Exodus 21:16).

Hammer your plows into swords! VERSES 9–17

9 Announce this among the nations:
"Get ready for war!
Wake up the mighty soldiers!
Let all the warriors come near.
Let them come up.
10 Hammer your plows into swords,
and your pruning knives into spears.
Let the weak one say, 'I am strong.'
11 Hurry and come, all you nations around,
and gather together."
LORD, send your mighty warriors down there!
12 "Let the nations get up
and come up to the valley of Jehoshaphat.
For there I will sit
to judge all the nations around.
13 Swing the sickle,
for the harvest is ripe.
Come, trample the grapes,
for the winepress is full.
The vats overflow,
for their evil is great."
14 Crowds, crowds in the valley of decision!
For the day of the LORD is near in the valley of decision.
15 The sun and the moon grow dark,
and the stars stop shining.
16 The LORD will roar from Zion.
He will thunder from Jerusalem.
The heavens and the earth will shake.
But the LORD will be a safe place for his people,
a strong fortress for the people of Israel.
17 "Then you will know that I am the LORD your God.
I live in Zion, my holy mountain.
Then Jerusalem will be holy.
Strangers will never again march through her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A remarkable sentence: "Hammer your plows into swords!" That is exactly the opposite of Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3: "They will hammer their swords into plows." Joel uses the picture with irony: Let the nations come with all their weapons. It will not help them against God. The hope of the Bible remains peace without weapons.

Verse 13: A sickle is a curved knife for cutting grain. The pictures of the harvest and the winepress stand for judgment. Revelation takes them up (Revelation 14:14–20).

Verse 14: "Crowds, crowds in the valley of decision!" Here the fate of the nations is decided.

Verse 16: In the middle of the shaking, God is a safe place for his people.

Verse 17: "Strangers will never again march through her" means enemy conquerors who had robbed Jerusalem again and again. It does not mean strangers who come in peace. Many prophets say that one day all nations will come to Jerusalem in peace (Isaiah 2:2–3).

The mountains drip with sweet wine VERSES 18–21

18 "On that day,
the mountains will drip with sweet wine.
The hills will flow with milk.
All the streams of Judah will be full of water.
A spring will flow out from the house of the LORD
and water the valley of Shittim.
19 Egypt will become a ruin,
and Edom an empty wilderness,
because of the violence done to the people of Judah.
For they shed innocent blood in their land.
20 But people will live in Judah forever,
and in Jerusalem from generation to generation.
21 I will make clean their blood that I have not yet made clean,
for the LORD lives in Zion."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends with a picture of paradise: mountains dripping with wine, hills full of milk, streams full of water. After the drought and the plague of locusts in Chapter 1, this is the complete turnaround.

Verse 18: A spring flows out of the temple, as in Ezekiel (Ezekiel 47). The valley of Shittim (valley of acacia trees) was a dry area. Now it too is watered.

Verse 19: Egypt and Edom stand for the enemies who shed innocent blood.

Verse 21: The last sentence of the book: "For the LORD lives in Zion." As in Ezekiel (48:35), the goal of everything is God's presence with his people.

In verse 21, the WEB uses the word "cleanse" (make clean). Other translations understand it as: I will not let their blood go unpunished. The Hebrew text is not clear here.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Joel?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A disaster: A terrible plague of locusts and a drought destroy everything (Chapter 1). Even the animals suffer.

Mourning together: Joel calls everyone together, old people and children, priests and farmers, to fast and to pray.

The day of the LORD: The plague becomes a sign of the great day when God steps in.

Turning back from the heart: "Tear your hearts, not your clothes" (2:13). God is "gracious and merciful," "slow to become angry," and "full of loving kindness."

Lost years given back: "I will give you back what you lost in the years that the swarming locust has eaten" (2:25). The swarming locust is a kind of locust.

God's Spirit for everyone: "I will pour out my Spirit on all people": on sons and daughters, old and young, male and female servants (2:28–29). In the Christian understanding, this promise came true at Pentecost.

Salvation for everyone: "Whoever calls on the name of the LORD will be saved" (2:32).

Judgment and salvation: God judges the nations that have done wrong, especially those who traded in human beings. And in the end, he lives with his people.

For today: Joel helps us not to give up hope in times of crisis (natural disasters, hunger, loss), but to mourn together, to pray, and to hope for God's mercy.

What comes next? Next comes the prophet Amos. He was a herdsman and a grower of sycamore figs whom God sent to the rich northern kingdom of Israel. He fought passionately against social injustice: "But let justice roll on like rivers, and righteousness like a mighty stream" (Amos 5:24).

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 30 OF 66

AMOS

9 CHAPTERS

AMOS

CHAPTER 1

The LORD roars from Zion

Before we begin: Who was Amos?

Amos was not a professional prophet. He was a herdsman from Tekoa, a small town south of Bethlehem in Judah. He also grew sycamore figs (Amos 7:14). God called him away from his herds and sent him to the northern kingdom of Israel.

He worked around 760 BC, in the time of King Jeroboam II. It was a time of wealth: The rich built summer houses and winter houses with ivory. They held great feasts and brought many sacrifices. At the same time, the poor were used, cheated, and treated unfairly in court.

Amos is the great prophet of social justice. His most famous sentence is: "But let justice roll on like rivers, and righteousness like a mighty stream" (Amos 5:24). Martin Luther King Jr. quoted this sentence in 1963 in his famous speech. In it, he spoke about his dream: Black people and white people should have the same rights.

The book has 9 chapters:

– Chapters 1–2: Words of judgment against the neighboring peoples and against Israel.

– Chapters 3–6: Speeches against injustice in Israel.

– Chapters 7–9: Five visions and a look ahead to a new beginning.

His name probably means "carried" or "burden."

Amos from Tekoa VERSES 1–2

1 These are the words of Amos.
He was one of the herdsmen of Tekoa.
He saw these words about Israel
in the days of Uzziah, the king of Judah,
and in the days of Jeroboam, the son of Joash, the king of Israel.
It was two years before the earthquake.
2 He said:
"The LORD will roar from Zion.
He will let his voice be heard from Jerusalem.
The pastures of the shepherds will mourn,
and the top of Carmel will dry up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "It was two years before the earthquake." At that time there was an earthquake so great that people still remembered it centuries later (compare Zechariah 14:5). Archaeologists have found signs of a strong earthquake around 760 BC in several places.

Verse 2: God "roars" like a lion. Amos was a shepherd. He knew the roar of lions that threatened his herds. When a lion roars, everyone is afraid. That is how shaking God's voice is.

Carmel was a very green, fertile mountain range. If even Carmel dries up, it is a disaster.

Against Damascus VERSES 3–5

3 The LORD says:
"Damascus has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they have threshed Gilead with threshing tools made of iron.
4 So I will send a fire into the house of Hazael.
It will burn up the palaces of Ben Hadad.
5 I will break the bar on the gate of Damascus.
I will cut off the people who live in the valley of Aven,
and the one who holds the scepter in the house of Eden.
And the people of Syria will be taken away as prisoners to Kir,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a series of words of judgment begins against seven neighboring peoples, and then against Israel itself.

"Three times, yes, four times" is a typical way of speaking. It means: The measure is more than full.

Damascus was the capital of Aram (Syria). Hazael and Ben Hadad were kings of Aram.

The crime: They "threshed Gilead with threshing tools made of iron." Gilead is an area east of the Jordan. A threshing tool was a heavy board with iron spikes. People used it to thresh grain. This is a picture for unbelievable cruelty in war against people.

Verse 5: A scepter is a staff that a king holds.

Against Gaza and Tyre VERSES 6–10

6 The LORD says:
"Gaza has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they took away a whole community as prisoners to hand them over to Edom.
7 So I will send a fire on the wall of Gaza.
It will burn up its palaces.
8 I will cut off the people who live in Ashdod,
and the one who holds the scepter in Ashkelon.
I will turn my hand against Ekron.
And the rest of the Philistines will die,"
says the Lord GOD.
9 The LORD says:
"Tyre has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they handed over a whole community to Edom.
And they did not remember the agreement between brothers.
10 So I will send a fire on the wall of Tyre.
It will burn up its palaces."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gaza, the other cities of the Philistines, and Tyre carried off whole villages. They sold the people as slaves to Edom. That was human trafficking on a large scale.

Verse 9: In doing this, Tyre broke an "agreement between brothers," a treaty with Israel (compare 1 Kings 5:12, where King Hiram of Tyre and Solomon made a covenant).

It is remarkable: Here God also judges foreign peoples who do not believe in him. All people are responsible for cruelty, human trafficking, and breaking treaties. There is a conscience that all people have.

Against Edom and Ammon VERSES 11–15

11 The LORD says:
"Edom has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For he chased his brother with the sword
and threw away all pity.

His anger raged all the time,
and he held on to his rage forever.
12 So I will send a fire on Teman.
It will burn up the palaces of Bozrah."
13 The LORD says:
"The people of Ammon have sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they ripped open the pregnant women of Gilead
to make their own land bigger.
14 So I will light a fire in the wall of Rabbah.
It will burn up its palaces.
There will be shouting on the day of battle
and a storm on the day of the whirlwind.
15 Their king will be taken away as a prisoner,
he and his princes together,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Edom (the descendants of Esau) chased his "brother" Israel, without pity and with endless hate. Hate that never stops destroys.

Verse 13: The people of Ammon killed pregnant women in a cruel way, only to make their land bigger. That is one of the worst war crimes. God sees this injustice, and he will judge it.

Here the Bible clearly says: Violence against people who cannot defend themselves, especially against women and children, is a serious wrong, no matter who does it. If you carry painful experiences of violence or war, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

AMOS

CHAPTER 2

Judgment on Judah and Israel too

Against Moab VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD says:
"Moab has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For he burned the bones of the king of Edom into lime.
2 So I will send a fire on Moab.
It will burn up the palaces of Kerioth.
Moab will die in a great noise,
with shouting and with the sound of the trumpet.
3 I will cut off the judge from among them.
And I will kill all its princes with him,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moab burned the bones of a dead king of Edom. Lime is a white powder. That was a terrible insult to the dead. It is remarkable: Edom was no friend of Israel. And yet God takes this deed seriously. The dignity of a dead person must be respected, even the dignity of an enemy.

Against Judah VERSES 4–5

4 The LORD says:
"Judah has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they have rejected the law of the LORD.
They have not kept his rules.
Their lies have led them the wrong way,
the same lies their ancestors followed.
5 So I will send a fire on Judah.
It will burn up the palaces of Jerusalem."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You can imagine how the listeners in Israel nodded in agreement at the words so far: "Yes, those evil neighboring peoples!" Now it is Judah's turn, the brother kingdom in the south. Here, too, they may still be nodding.

For Judah the charge is different: They rejected God's law. Whoever knows God's commandments has a greater responsibility.

Against Israel VERSES 6–8

6 The LORD says:
"Israel has sinned three times, yes, four times.
So I will not take back its punishment.
For they sell the righteous for silver,
and the needy for a pair of sandals.
7 They trample the heads of the poor into the dust of the earth.
They deny justice to people who are treated badly.
A man and his father use the same young woman.
In this way they make my holy name unclean.
8 They lie down beside every altar
on clothes they took from the poor as a pledge.
In the house of their God they drink wine
that they took from people who had to pay a fine.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

And now, as the eighth people, it is Israel's turn, the listeners themselves! The trap snaps shut. And the list is the longest.

Israel's crimes are not war crimes against strangers. They are wrongs within their own people, against their own poor:

– Verse 6: Righteous means: living right before God. Whoever cannot pay his debts is sold into slavery. Sometimes this happens because of a small amount, the price of a pair of sandals.

– Verse 7: The poor are trampled into the dust. In court they do not get justice.

– Verse 7: "A man and his father use the same young woman." This is probably a young maid or servant in the house. Father and son use her sexually. She cannot defend herself, and she depends on them. Amos calls this making God's name unclean. This is sexual abuse, and the guilt lies with the men who do it.

– Verse 8: A pledge is something you give as a promise that you will pay back a debt. Poor people had to give their outer cloak as a pledge. The law said: The cloak must be given back before night, because it is the only blanket (Exodus 22:26–27). But the rich keep it and lie down on it during worship! And they drink wine that was paid for with unjust fines.

For Amos it is clear: Worship and injustice do not go together.

If you have experienced sexual violence or exploitation, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

What I did for you VERSES 9–12

9 "And yet I destroyed the Amorite before them.
He was as tall as the cedars,
and he was as strong as the oaks.
But I destroyed his fruit above
and his roots below.
10 I also brought you up out of the land of Egypt.
I led you 40 years in the wilderness,
so that you could take the land of the Amorite.
11 I chose some of your sons to be prophets,
and some of your young men to be Nazirites.
Isn't this true, you people of Israel?"
says the LORD.
12 "But you gave the Nazirites wine to drink.
And you commanded the prophets,
'Don't prophesy!'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God reminds them of everything he has done for Israel: the rescue from Egypt, the guidance through the wilderness, the land.

Verses 11–12: God also gave them people who were to be an example: prophets and Nazirites. Nazirites were people who had given themselves to God in a special way and did not drink wine (Numbers 6). But the people tempted the Nazirites to drink, and they told the prophets to be quiet. To prophesy means: to speak a message from God. They did not want to hear uncomfortable voices.

No one will escape VERSES 13–16

13 "Look, I will crush you where you are,
the way a cart full of grain crushes the ground.
14 The fast runner will not be able to flee.
The strong man will not keep his strength.
The mighty warrior will not save his life.
15 The one who uses the bow will not stand firm.
The one who is fast on his feet will not escape.
The one who rides the horse will not save his life.
16 And the bravest of the mighty warriors
will run away naked on that day,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When the judgment comes, no strength, no speed, and no weapon will help. Even the bravest warrior will drop everything and run away naked.

This came true when the Assyrians conquered the northern kingdom of Israel in the year 722 BC.

AMOS

CHAPTER 3

The lion has roared

Precisely because you are chosen VERSES 1–2

1 Listen to this word that the LORD has spoken against you,
you people of Israel,
against the whole family that I brought up out of the land of Egypt.
He says:
2 "I have chosen only you
of all the families of the earth.
That is why I will punish you for all your sins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A surprising sentence! The Israelites probably thought: "We are God's chosen people. So we are safe." Amos turns this around: Precisely because you are chosen, precisely because you know God so well, you have a greater responsibility.

Being chosen is not a privilege. It is a task. Jesus says something similar: "If someone has been given much, much will be expected from him" (Luke 12:48).

The Hebrew word for "chosen" actually means "known." It describes a close, personal relationship.

Nothing happens without a reason VERSES 3–8

3 Do two people walk together
if they have not agreed to meet?
4 Will a lion roar in the bushes
when he has no prey?
Does a young lion cry out from his den
if he has caught nothing?
5 Can a bird fall into a trap on the ground
if no trap has been set for it?
Does a trap spring up from the ground
when there is nothing to catch?
6 When the trumpet sounds the alarm in a city,
are the people not afraid?
When disaster comes to a city,
has the LORD not done it?
7 Surely the Lord GOD does nothing
without first showing his secret plan to his servants,
the prophets.
8 The lion has roared.
Who will not be afraid?
The Lord GOD has spoken.
Who can do anything but prophesy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amos asks a series of questions from the everyday life of a shepherd and farmer. The answer is always: No! Everything has a cause.

– Two people walk together because they have agreed to meet.

– A lion roars because he has prey.

– A trap snaps shut because something has stepped into it.

And then comes the point (verse 8): I, Amos, speak because God has spoken. I cannot do anything else. Just as people are

afraid when a lion roars, I must prophesy when God speaks. In this way Amos defends his task.

Verse 6: "When disaster comes to a city, has the LORD not done it?" This is a difficult sentence. Here Amos means the disaster that God sends as judgment on Israel. He wants to say: It is no accident. It has a meaning. This verse must not be understood to mean that every disaster that happens to a person is a punishment from God (compare Luke 13:1–5; John 9:2–3).

Verse 7: God does not act in secret. He warns beforehand through his prophets. He always gives a chance to turn back.

Injustice in the palaces VERSES 9–12

9 Announce it in the palaces of Ashdod
and in the palaces in the land of Egypt. Say:
"Gather on the mountains of Samaria.
See how much unrest there is in the city
and how people are treated badly there."
10 "Yes, they do not know how to do what is right,"
says the LORD.
"They pile up stolen goods and loot in their palaces."
11 That is why the Lord GOD says:
"An enemy will overrun the land.
He will tear down your strong places,
and your fortresses will be robbed."
12 The LORD says:
"A shepherd may save two legs or a piece of an ear
out of the mouth of the lion.
In the same way the people of Israel will be saved,
those who sit in Samaria in the corner of a couch
and on the silk cushions of a bed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: An unusual call: The foreign peoples (Philistines from Ashdod, Egyptians) are to come and watch how much injustice happens in Samaria. Even the foreign peoples would be amazed at it.

Verse 10: "Yes, they do not know how to do what is right." The rich in their palaces pile up wealth that they gained through robbery and violence.

Verse 12: A bitter picture from the life of a shepherd: When a lion had killed a sheep, the shepherd had to show what was left as proof that he had not stolen it (compare Exodus 22:13). In the same way, only a pitiful remnant will be left of the rich Israelites who lie comfortably on their couches and silk cushions.

Houses of ivory VERSES 13–15

13 "Listen, and speak as witnesses against the house of Jacob,"
says the Lord GOD, the God of Armies.
14 "For on the day when I punish Israel for its sins,
I will also punish the altars of Bethel.
The horns of the altar will be cut off
and fall to the ground.
15 I will strike the winter house together with the summer house.
The houses of ivory will be destroyed,
and the great houses will come to an end,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Bethel was the most important holy place in the northern kingdom. The "horns of the altar" were a place of safety (1 Kings 1:50). When they are cut off, there is no more safety.

Verse 15: The rich had a winter house (in the warm Jordan valley) and a summer house (in the cool mountains). Their houses were decorated with ivory. Archaeologists have really found many beautiful ivory carvings from this time in Samaria.

The message: Luxury that was gained at the cost of the poor does not last.

For today: Amos asks us how our wealth is connected with the need of others, also around the world.

AMOS

CHAPTER 4

And yet you did not come back to me

You cows of Bashan VERSES 1–3

1 Listen to this word, you cows of Bashan,
you who live on the mountain of Samaria,
you who treat the poor badly,
you who crush the needy,
you who say to your husbands,
"Bring us drinks!"
2 The Lord GOD has made a promise by his holiness:
"The days will come on you
when they will take you away with hooks,
and the last of you with fish hooks.
3 You will go out through the holes in the wall,
each woman straight ahead.
And you will throw yourselves into Harmon,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bashan (east of the Sea of Galilee) was famous for its well-fed, strong cattle. Amos calls the rich women of Samaria "cows of Bashan": well-fed and full, while others go hungry. They keep asking their husbands for drinks for their parties. And the money for it comes from using the poor.

Important: Amos does not criticize women in general here. He criticizes rich people who live at the cost of the poor. The men are criticized just as harshly in other chapters (for example 6:1–6). And the picture is not an insult about how someone looks. It is about greed and injustice.

Verses 2–3: Like cattle on hooks, they will be led away through holes in the destroyed city wall. Pictures from Assyria really show how prisoners were led away on hooks or ropes. No one knows where "Harmon" was.

Religious, but unjust VERSES 4–5

4 "Go to Bethel, and sin!
Go to Gilgal, and sin even more!

Bring your sacrifices every morning,
and your tithes every three days.
5 Offer a thank offering of bread made with yeast.
Announce your free gifts and brag about them.
For this is what you like to do, you people of Israel,"
says the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bitter irony: Amos sounds like a priest who invites people to worship. But he says, "Go to Bethel, and sin!" The eager worship in Bethel and Gilgal is sin, because it goes together with injustice in everyday life.

Verse 4: A tithe is a tenth of what you earn. It was given to God.

Verse 5: They give gifts, but only to brag about them. "For this is what YOU like to do." They care about their own reputation, not about God. Later Jesus warns: "So when you do merciful deeds, don't sound a trumpet in front of you" (Matthew 6:2).

Five times: And yet you did not come back to me
VERSES 6–11

6 "I gave you clean teeth in all your cities.
There was no bread in all your towns.
And yet you did not come back to me,"
says the LORD.
7 "I also held back the rain from you
when it was still three months until the harvest.
I let it rain on one city,
and I did not let it rain on another city.
One field got rain,
and the field where it did not rain dried up.
8 So two or three cities stumbled to one city
to drink water.
But they did not get enough.
And yet you did not come back to me,"
says the LORD.
9 "Many times I struck your gardens and your vineyards
with plant diseases that made them dry up and rot.
And swarms of locusts ate your fig trees and your olive trees.
And yet you did not come back to me,"
says the LORD.
10 "I sent plagues among you, as I did in Egypt.
I killed your young men with the sword,
and I took away your horses.
I filled your noses with the stink of your camp.
And yet you did not come back to me,"
says the LORD.
11 "I destroyed some of you,
as God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah.
You were like a burning stick pulled out of the fire.
And yet you did not come back to me,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The same sad sentence comes five times: "And yet you did not come back to me." You can feel God's disappointment.

Verse 6: "I gave you clean teeth" is a bitter expression: There was nothing to eat, so the teeth stayed clean. It means famine.

Verses 7–8: The rain did not fall evenly. People had to stumble from city to city to find water.

Verse 11: "You were like a burning stick pulled out of the fire." They barely escaped. But even that did not make them think.

This list explains disasters as wake-up calls from God. Important: This is the prophet's explanation of one particular time. It does not mean that every drought, every plague, or every war today is a punishment from God for the people it hits. Jesus clearly speaks against this way of thinking (Luke 13:1–5). But a crisis can be a reason to think about your own life.

Get ready to meet your God VERSES 12–13

12 "That is why I will do this to you, Israel.
Because I will do this to you,
get ready to meet your God, Israel!
13 For look, he is the one who forms the mountains
and creates the wind.
He tells people what they are thinking.
He turns the morning into darkness
and walks on the high places of the earth.
The LORD, the God of Armies, is his name."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "Get ready to meet your God, Israel!" That sounds like a threat, and it is one. But it is also a last invitation: You will meet God, whether you want to or not. Get ready!

Verse 13: A song of praise to God's greatness: He made the mountains and the wind. He even knows what people are thinking. Short songs of praise like this come several times in Amos (compare 5:8–9; 9:5–6).

AMOS

CHAPTER 5

Let justice roll on like rivers

A song of mourning for Israel VERSES 1–3

1 Listen to this word, house of Israel.
I sing it as a song of mourning over you:
2 "The virgin Israel has fallen.
She will not get up again.
She lies thrown down on her land.
There is no one to lift her up."
3 For the Lord GOD says:
"The city that sent out 1,000 soldiers
will have 100 left.
The city that sent out 100
will have 10 left
for the house of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amos sings a funeral song, as if Israel had already died. The people are still in the middle of their wealth. But Amos already sees the end coming.

The "virgin Israel" is a picture for the people as a young woman who dies before her life has really begun.

Verse 3: Only one tenth will survive. That is how terrible the war will be.

Seek me, and you will live VERSES 4–9

4 For the LORD says to the house of Israel:
"Seek me, and you will live!
5 But do not seek Bethel.
Do not go to Gilgal.
And do not cross over to Beersheba.
For Gilgal will surely be taken away as prisoners,
and Bethel will come to nothing.
6 Seek the LORD, and you will live.
Otherwise he will break out like a fire in the house of Joseph.
It will burn it up,
and there will be no one in Bethel to put it out.
7 You turn justice into wormwood.
You throw righteousness down to the ground!
8 Seek him who made the Pleiades and Orion.
He turns the shadow of death into morning.
He makes the day dark as night.
He calls for the waters of the sea
and pours them out over the land.
The LORD is his name.
9 He brings sudden destruction on the strong,
so that destruction comes on the fortress.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Seek me, and you will live!" In the middle of all the words of judgment, here is a simple, clear way: Turn to God!

Verse 5: But not in the holy places of Bethel, Gilgal, and Beersheba. People pray and sacrifice a lot there. But God cannot be found there, because the worship goes together with injustice. You do not seek God in certain places. You seek him by living a just life.

Verse 7: Wormwood is a very bitter plant. Justice should be sweet and good, but they have made it bitter.

Verse 8: The Pleiades and Orion are groups of stars. God made the stars. He decides day and night. And this great God wants you to seek him.

Injustice in the gate VERSES 10–13

10 They hate the one who speaks up against wrong in the city gate.
They hate the one who speaks honestly.
11 You trample on the poor.
You take a tax of wheat from them.
That is why this will happen:
You have built houses of cut stone,
but you will not live in them.
You have planted beautiful vineyards,
but you will not drink their wine.
12 For I know how many wrongs you have done
and how great your sins are.
You make life hard for people who do right.
You take bribes.
You turn the needy away in the courts.
13 That is why a wise person keeps quiet in such a time,
for it is an evil time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "gate" was the place in a city where court was held. The elders sat there and judged.

Verse 10: Whoever tells the truth there and speaks up against injustice is hated.

Verse 11: The rich take grain from the poor farmers as a tax. With it they build splendid stone houses for themselves. But they will not live in them for long.

Verse 12: Bribes and unjust judgments. The poor do not get justice in court.

Verse 13: "A wise person keeps quiet." In such an evil time it is dangerous to tell the truth. Some also understand the sentence as bitter irony: Many people would rather stay quiet, even though they should speak. Amos himself does not stay quiet.

Hate evil, love good VERSES 14–17

14 Seek what is good, and not what is evil,
so that you may live.
Then the LORD, the God of Armies, will be with you,
as you say he is.
15 Hate what is evil.
Love what is good.
Make sure there is justice in the courts.
Maybe the LORD, the God of Armies,
will be kind to the rest of Joseph."
16 That is why the LORD, the God of Armies, the Lord, says:
"There will be crying in all the wide streets.
In all the streets they will say, 'Oh no! Oh no!'
They will call the farmer to mourn,
and those who are skilled in songs of mourning to cry aloud.
17 There will be crying in all the vineyards,
for I will pass through the middle of you,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Seek what is good, and not what is evil, so that you may live." The people said: "God is with us." Amos says: God is only with you if you seek what is good.

Verse 15: A clear plan in three steps: Hate what is evil. Love what is good. Make sure there is justice in court. And then: "Maybe God will be kind." Amos promises nothing, but he leaves room for hope.

Verse 17: "I will pass through the middle of you." This reminds us of the night in Egypt when God went through the land (Exodus 12:12). But this time it hits Israel itself.

The day of the LORD is darkness VERSES 18–20

18 "How terrible it will be for you who wish for the day of the LORD!
Why do you long for the day of the LORD?
It is darkness, and not light.
19 It is as if a man ran away from a lion,
and a bear met him.
Or he went into the house
and leaned his hand on the wall,
and a snake bit him.
20 Won't the day of the LORD be darkness, and not light?
Very dark, with no brightness in it?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Israelites were looking forward to the "day of the LORD." They thought: On that day God will defeat our enemies and make us great.

Amos says: Careful! For you this day will be dark, because you yourselves are unjust.

Verse 19: A picture with dark humor: Someone barely escapes a lion. He runs right into a bear. He escapes that too and saves himself by going home. Tired, he leans against the wall, and then a snake bites him. There is no escape.

I hate your feasts VERSES 21–27

21 "I hate your feasts. I despise them.
I cannot stand your holy gatherings.
22 Yes, even if you offer me your burnt offerings and grain offerings,
I will not accept them.
And I will not look at the peace offerings of your fattened animals.
23 Take the noise of your songs away from me!
I will not listen to the music of your harps.
24 But let justice roll on like rivers,
and righteousness like a mighty stream.
25 "House of Israel, did you bring me sacrifices and offerings
during the 40 years in the wilderness?
26 You also carried the tent of your king
and the stand for your idols,
the star of your god,
which you made for yourselves.
27 That is why I will make you go away as prisoners
to a land beyond Damascus,"
says the LORD, whose name is the God of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most famous texts in the Bible!

Verses 21–23: God says with hard words: I hate your worship! Your feasts, your sacrifices, your songs and harps: I want none of it. Why? Because they are celebrated by people who at the same time treat the poor badly. Beautiful worship cannot make up for injustice.

Verse 24: What God wants instead: "But let justice roll on like rivers, and righteousness like a mighty stream." Not just a drop now and then, but a stream that never dries up. Justice should flow through all of life.

Martin Luther King Jr. quoted this sentence in 1963 in his famous speech "I Have a Dream," in the struggle against racial segregation in the US. It is also written on the Civil Rights Memorial in Montgomery.

Verse 25: A question: In the wilderness, in the time of your first love for God, was it about sacrifices? No, it was about faithfulness.

Verse 26: A difficult verse. The Hebrew probably has the names of star gods there (Sakkuth and Kaiwan, gods of Assyria). The WEB translates them as "the tent of your king" and "the star of your god." Stephen quotes this verse in Acts 7:42–43.

AMOS

CHAPTER 6

How terrible for those who feel safe

How terrible for those who are sure of themselves VERSES 1–7

1 How terrible it will be for those who live at ease in Zion,
and for those who feel safe on the mountain of Samaria!
They are the important men of the first of the nations.
The house of Israel comes to them.
2 Go over to Calneh, and look.
From there go to Hamath the great.
Then go down to Gath of the Philistines.
Are they better than these kingdoms?
Is their land bigger than your land?
3 How terrible for you who push the evil day far away,
and yet bring the rule of violence near!
4 You lie on beds of ivory
and stretch out on your couches.
You eat lambs from the flock
and calves from the middle of the stall.
5 You play on the strings of the harp.
You make up musical instruments for yourselves, like David.
6 You drink wine from bowls.
You rub yourselves with the best oils.
But they do not grieve over the ruin of Joseph.
7 That is why they will now be the first to be taken away as prisoners.
The feasting and lazing around will come to an end.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it is the rich men's turn, the upper class in Jerusalem (Zion) and in Samaria.

Verse 1: They feel safe and carefree. They think they are "the important men of the first of the nations."

Verse 2: Amos says: Look at other cities (Calneh, Hamath, Gath) that have already fallen. You are not better than they are.

Verses 4–6: A lively picture of luxury: beds of ivory, lying lazily on couches, eating only the most tender lambs and calves, making music, drinking wine from large bowls, taking care of themselves with expensive oils.

Verse 6: The worst thing is not the luxury itself. It is the end of the verse: "... But they do not grieve over the ruin of Joseph." To grieve means: to be very sad. The people are going to ruin, the poor are suffering, and they do not care.

Verse 7: Whoever sits at the front of the table now will soon be the first to be taken away as a prisoner.

For today: Amos asks whether we see the suffering of other people, or whether we make ourselves comfortable and look away.

God hates pride VERSES 8–11

8 "The Lord GOD has made a promise by himself,"
says the LORD, the God of Armies:
"I hate the pride of Jacob.

I hate his strong places.
That is why I will hand over the city
with everything that is in it.
9 And this will happen:
If 10 men are left in one house,
they will die.
10 Then a relative will come to carry out the bodies.
He is the one who will burn them.
He will bring the bodies out of the house.
He will ask the one who is in the farthest room of the house,
'Is there anyone else with you?'
And he will say, 'No.'
Then the relative will say, 'Hush!
We must not say the name of the LORD.'
11 For look, the LORD gives the command,
and the great house will be smashed to pieces,
and the little house into bits.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: A frightening scene after the disaster (maybe war or plague): In one house everyone has died. A relative comes to bring out the dead. He finds one last survivor who is hiding. And he whispers: "Hush! Don't say God's name!" They are afraid that God could send even more disaster.

Verse 11: Great houses and little houses, rich and poor: Everyone is hit.

Justice turned into poison VERSES 12–14

12 Do horses run on rocky cliffs?
Does anyone plow there with oxen?
But you have turned justice into poison,
and the fruit of righteousness into bitterness.
13 You are happy about a thing of nothing.
You say,
'Haven't we taken horns for ourselves by our own strength?'
14 "For look, I will make a nation rise up against you,
house of Israel,"
says the LORD, the God of Armies.
"They will treat you harshly
from the entrance of Hamath to the brook of the Arabah."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Two silly questions: Do horses run over rocks? Does anyone plow rocks? No, that is crazy. Just as crazy is turning justice into poison. And that is exactly what you are doing!

Verse 13: Horns are a picture of power. There is probably a play on words here: Israel is happy about military victories. Many scholars think of the capture of the towns of Lo Debar (that sounds like "nothing") and Karnaim (that means "horns"). They say: "We did this by our own strength!" Amos mocks them: You are happy about a "nothing."

Verse 14: God will send a nation (Assyria) that will oppress the whole land, from the north (Hamath) to the south (Arabah). That is exactly the area that King Jeroboam II had conquered (2 Kings 14:25).

AMOS

CHAPTER 7

Visions and a quarrel in Bethel

Two visions: locusts and fire VERSES 1–6

1 This is what the Lord GOD showed me:
He was forming locusts
when the late crop was just starting to grow.
It was the late crop after the king's harvest.
2 When the locusts had finished eating the grass of the land,
I said,
"Lord GOD, forgive, please!
How could Jacob stand?
For he is small."
3 Then the LORD changed his mind about this.
"It will not happen," said the LORD.
4 This is what the Lord GOD showed me:
The Lord GOD called for judgment by fire.
It dried up the great deep sea,
and it would have burned up the land.
5 Then I said,
"Lord GOD, stop, please!
How could Jacob stand?
For he is small."
6 Then the LORD changed his mind about this.
"This will not happen either," said the Lord GOD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapters 7–9, Amos has five visions.

Vision 1: Locusts eat the late crop. That was especially bad: The first harvest went to the king as a tax ("the king's harvest"). The second harvest was what ordinary people had to live on.

Vision 2: A huge fire dries up even the sea.

Both times Amos speaks up for his people: "Lord GOD, forgive, please!" and "Lord GOD, stop, please! How could Jacob stand? For he is small." And God listens to him: "It will not happen."

That is remarkable: Amos, the hard prophet of judgment, also prays for others. He loves his people. And God lets himself be moved by prayer. Prayer changes things.

The third vision: the plumb line VERSES 7–9

7 This is what he showed me:
The Lord was standing beside a wall
that had been built with a plumb line.
He had a plumb line in his hand.
8 The LORD said to me,
"Amos, what do you see?"
I said, "A plumb line."
Then the Lord said,
"Look, I will put a plumb line in the middle of my

people Israel.
I will not pass them by any more.
9 The high places of Isaac will be left empty.
The holy places of Israel will be destroyed.
And I will rise up against the house of Jeroboam with the sword."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A plumb line is a weight on a string. Builders use it to check whether a wall stands straight. God measures his people with the plumb line. And it shows: The wall is crooked. Israel does not stand straight before God.

This time Amos no longer prays for the people. God says, "I will not pass them by any more." That means: He will not spare them any more.

"Isaac" is another name for the people of Israel here.

Amaziah against Amos VERSES 10–17

10 Then Amaziah, the priest of Bethel,
sent a message to Jeroboam, the king of Israel:
"Amos has made a secret plan against you
in the middle of the house of Israel.
The land cannot bear all his words.
11 For Amos says,
'Jeroboam will die by the sword,
and Israel will surely be taken away from its land as prisoners.'"
12 Amaziah also said to Amos,
"You seer, go, flee to the land of Judah.
Earn your bread there,
and prophesy there.
13 But don't prophesy at Bethel any more.
For it is the king's holy place,
and it is a royal house!"
14 Then Amos answered Amaziah,
"I was not a prophet,
and I was not a prophet's son.
I was a herdsman,
and I grew sycamore figs.
15 The LORD took me away from following the flock.
The LORD said to me,
'Go, prophesy to my people Israel.'
16 So now listen to the word of the LORD.
You say,
'Don't prophesy against Israel,
and don't preach against the house of Isaac.'
17 That is why the LORD says:
'Your wife will become a prostitute in the city.
Your sons and your daughters will be killed by the sword.
Your land will be measured with a line and divided up.
You yourself will die in an unclean land.
And Israel will surely be taken away from its land as prisoners.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amaziah was the highest priest at the king's holy place in Bethel. He reports Amos to the king: "Amos has made a secret plan against you … The land cannot bear all his words."

Verses 12–13: A seer is a prophet who sees things from God. Then Amaziah says to Amos: "You seer, go, flee to the land of Judah. Earn your bread there, and prophesy there." That means: Make your money there by prophesying! And: "But don't prophesy at Bethel any more. For it is the king's holy place." It is telling: He does not call it "God's holy place," but "the king's holy place." Religion serves politics.

Verses 14–15: Amos's famous answer: "I was not a prophet, and I was not a prophet's son. I was a herdsman, and I grew sycamore figs." That means: He is not a professional prophet. He does not earn money with it. And then: "The LORD took me away from following the flock." Amos does not speak because he is paid for it. He speaks because God sent him.

Verse 17: A hard word to Amaziah. It describes what happens to a priest's family when enemies conquer the land: The men are killed. The women become victims of sexual violence and exploitation. The land is divided up. And he himself dies in exile. That is a terrible injustice of war. The wife here is a victim, not guilty.

AMOS

CHAPTER 8

A hunger for God's word

The fourth vision: a basket of summer fruit VERSES 1–3

1 This is what the Lord GOD showed me:
a basket of summer fruit.
2 He said,
"Amos, what do you see?"
I said, "A basket of summer fruit."
Then the LORD said to me,
"The end has come for my people Israel.
I will not pass them by any more.
3 On that day the songs of the temple will turn into crying,"
says the Lord GOD.
"There will be many dead bodies.
In every place they will throw them out in silence."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A play on words in Hebrew: "Summer fruit" is "qayits," and "end" is "qets." The two words sound almost the same. The ripe fruit at the end of summer becomes a sign: Israel is ripe for the end.

Verse 3: The happy songs in the temple turn into songs of mourning. And at the end there is only silence. A shaking silence after the disaster.

The cheaters at the market VERSES 4–8

4 Listen to this, you who want to swallow up the needy
and destroy the poor of the land.
5 You say,
"When will the new moon feast be over,
so that we can sell grain?
And when will the Sabbath be over,

so that we can sell wheat at the market?
We will make the ephah small
and the shekel large.
We will cheat with false scales.
6 We will buy the poor for silver,
and the needy for a pair of sandals.
And we will sell the trash along with the wheat."
7 The LORD has made a promise by the pride of Jacob:
"Surely I will never forget anything they have done.
8 Won't the land shake because of this?
Won't everyone who lives in it mourn?
Yes, the whole land will rise like the River.
It will be stirred up and sink again,
like the River of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A lively picture of dishonest traders:

Verse 5: They do keep the Sabbath and the holidays, but only because they have to. They can hardly wait until the holiday is over and they can do business again.

And this is how they do business: They make the ephah (the measure for grain) smaller, so that the customer gets less. They make the shekel (the weight for money) heavier, so that the customer pays more. And the scales are false. Cheating three times over!

Verse 6: They even sell the trash from the grain to the poor. And whoever cannot pay his debts is sold as a slave.

Verse 7: God does not forget this.

For today: Cheating in business, using workers, charging too much interest, and taking advantage of the weak: God sees all of it.

The sun goes down at noon VERSES 9–10

9 "And on that day this will happen,"
says the Lord GOD:
"I will make the sun go down at noon.
I will make the earth dark in broad daylight.
10 I will turn your feasts into mourning,
and all your songs into songs of sorrow.
I will make all of you wear sackcloth.
I will make every head bald.
I will make it like the mourning for an only son.
And its end will be like a bitter day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: The sun goes down in the middle of the day. Maybe Amos is thinking of an eclipse of the sun. In the year 763 BC there was a great eclipse of the sun. Texts from Assyria mention it.

The Gospels report that when Jesus died, darkness came over the land at noon (Mark 15:33).

Verse 10: Sackcloth is rough cloth that people wore when they mourned. The mourning will be as deep as the mourning of parents for their only child. That is the greatest pain anyone can imagine.

A hunger for the word of the LORD VERSES 11–14

11 "Look, the days are coming,"
says the Lord GOD,
"when I will send a hunger into the land.
It will not be a hunger for bread,
and not a thirst for water,
but a hunger for hearing the words of the LORD.
12 They will wander from sea to sea,
and from the north to the east.
They will run back and forth
to look for the word of the LORD,
but they will not find it.
13 On that day the beautiful young women
and the young men will faint from thirst.
14 Some make promises by the sin of Samaria.
They say, 'As surely as your god lives, Dan,'
and, 'As surely as the way to Beersheba lives.'
They will fall and never get up again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: An unusual hunger: not for bread, but for God's word. The people did not want to listen to the prophets (compare 2:12; 7:12–13). Now God will be silent. And then they will notice how much they need God's word. They will look everywhere and not find it.

Jesus says: "People do not live by bread alone. They live by every word that comes out of God's mouth" (Matthew 4:4; compare Deuteronomy 8:3).

Verse 14: Dan and Beersheba were holy places in the far north and the far south. The people made promises by their idols and their pilgrim roads. But these idols cannot help.

For today: Many people feel an emptiness inside, a "hunger" for meaning and for God, even when they have everything they need.

AMOS

CHAPTER 9

The fallen tent of David

The fifth vision: No one escapes VERSES 1–6

1 I saw the Lord standing beside the altar.
He said,
"Strike the tops of the pillars,
so that the doorways shake.
Break them into pieces on the heads of all of them.
I will kill the last of them with the sword.
Not one of them will run away.
Not one of them will escape.
2 Even if they dig down into Sheol (the world of the dead),
my hand will take them from there.
Even if they climb up to heaven,
I will bring them down from there.
3 Even if they hide on the top of Carmel,
I will search for them and take them out from there.
Even if they hide from my sight at the bottom of the sea,

I will give an order to the sea snake there,
and it will bite them.
4 Even if they are taken away as prisoners by their enemies,
I will give an order to the sword there,
and it will kill them.
I will keep my eyes on them
for evil and not for good."
5 For the Lord, the LORD of Armies,
is the one who touches the land, and it melts.
All who live in it will mourn.
The whole land will rise like the River
and sink again like the River of Egypt.
6 He is the one who builds his rooms in the heavens.
He has set his dome over the earth.
He calls for the waters of the sea
and pours them out over the land.
The LORD is his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the fifth vision, God himself stands at the altar, probably in Bethel. The holy place that the people trusted in will be destroyed.

Verses 2–4: There is no place where you can hide from God: not in the place of the dead and not in heaven, not on the mountain and not at the bottom of the sea. This reminds us of Psalm 139:7–10. There it is a comfort: If I go up to heaven, God is there too. Here it is a warning.

Verses 5–6: Again a song of praise to God's greatness, as in 4:13 and 5:8–9.

Are you not like the Ethiopians? VERSES 7–10

7 "People of Israel,
are you not like the people of the Ethiopians to me?"
says the LORD.
"Didn't I bring Israel up out of the land of Egypt,
and the Philistines from Caphtor,
and the Syrians from Kir?
8 Look, the eyes of the Lord GOD
are on the sinful kingdom.
I will destroy it from the face of the earth.
But I will not destroy the house of Jacob completely,"
says the LORD.
9 "For look, I will give the command.
I will shake the house of Israel among all the nations,
the way grain is shaken in a sieve.
But not even the smallest grain will fall to the ground.
10 All the sinners among my people will die by the sword.
They are the ones who say,
'Disaster will not catch up with us or meet us.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: One of the most amazing verses in the Bible! Israel thought it was something special, because God had freed it from Egypt. God says: You are not more important to me than the Ethiopians. The Hebrew says "Cushites." This means the people of Cush, south of Egypt, who had dark skin. And I also led other peoples: the Philistines from Caphtor (probably Crete) and the Syrians from Kir.

The message: God is the God of all peoples. He loves all people the same, no matter where they come from or what color their skin is. He holds the history of all peoples in his hand. Being chosen does not mean that you are worth more than others.

Verse 8: But God will not destroy his people completely.

Verse 9: The picture of the sieve: God shakes the people the way grain is sifted. The stones and the dirt fall through, but not one single good grain is lost. God knows each person.

The tent of David will be set up again VERSES 11–15

11 "On that day I will set up again the tent of David that has fallen.
I will close up its cracks.
I will set up its ruins again.
I will build it as it was in the days long ago.
12 Then they will take what is left of Edom
and all the nations that are called by my name,"
says the LORD, who does this.
13 "Look, the days are coming,"
says the LORD,
"when the one who plows will catch up with the one who harvests,
and the one who treads grapes will catch up with the one who sows seed.
Sweet wine will drip from the mountains
and flow from the hills.
14 I will bring my people Israel back from captivity.
They will rebuild the ruined cities and live in them.
They will plant vineyards and drink their wine.
They will also make gardens and eat their fruit.
15 I will plant them on their land.
They will never again be pulled up out of their land
that I have given them,"
says the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After so much judgment, the book ends with hope!

Verse 11: The "tent of David" is the royal family of David. It has fallen down like a hut made of branches. But God will set it up again.

Verse 12: It is remarkable: "all the nations that are called by my name." Other peoples belong to God too. In the New Testament, James quotes these verses at the meeting of the apostles in Jerusalem. He uses them to show that non-Jews may also belong to the church of Jesus (Acts 15:15–17).

Verse 13: A picture of unbelievable plenty: The harvest is so big that people are not yet finished harvesting when it is already time to plow again.

Verse 14: The curses from Chapter 5 are turned around. There it said: "You will not live in them ... you will not drink their wine" (5:11). Now it says: "They will rebuild the ruined cities and live in them. They will plant vineyards and drink their wine."

Verse 15: "They will never again be pulled up out of their land." God's last word is salvation.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Amos?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A shepherd as a prophet: Amos was a simple herdsman and farmer from Tekoa, not a professional prophet. God sent him to the rich northern kingdom of Israel (7:14–15).

Justice for the poor: The great theme of Amos is social justice. He accuses the rich: They sell "the needy for a pair of sandals." They cheat with false scales, they twist justice in court, and they live in luxury while others go hungry.

No exception for God's own people: God judges not only the neighboring peoples, but especially Israel too. "I have chosen only you of all the families of the earth. That is why I will punish you for all your sins" (3:2).

Worship without justice: "I hate your feasts. I despise them. ... But let justice roll on like rivers, and righteousness like a mighty stream" (5:21–24). Martin Luther King Jr. made these words a motto of the civil rights movement.

Seek me and live: "Seek what is good, and not what is evil, so that you may live" (5:14).

A prophet who prays: Amos speaks up for his people: "Lord GOD, forgive, please! How could Jacob stand? For he is small" (7:2).

God of all peoples: "People of Israel, are you not like the people of the Ethiopians to me?" (9:7). God loves all peoples the same.

Hunger for God's word: God says: "I will send a hunger into the land. It will not be a hunger for bread, and not a thirst for water, but a hunger for hearing the words of the LORD" (8:11).

Hope at the end: God will set up again the fallen tent of David (9:11).

For today: Amos asks us: How do we treat poor and weak people? Do our faith and our everyday life fit together? Where is justice needed, in our town, our country, the world?

What comes next? Next comes Obadiah, the shortest book of the Old Testament, only one chapter long. It is a word against Edom, which was glad about the disaster of its brother people.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 31 OF 66

OBADIAH

1 CHAPTER

OBADIAH

Chapter 1

Do not be glad about your brother's disaster

Before we begin: Who was Obadiah?

Obadiah is the shortest book of the Old Testament. It has only one single chapter with 21 verses.

We know almost nothing about the prophet himself. His name means "servant of the LORD."

The book speaks against Edom. Edom was a neighboring people southeast of the Dead Sea, in a rocky mountain land. The people of Edom were seen as the descendants of Esau, the twin brother of Jacob (Genesis 25–36). So Israel and Edom were "brother peoples."

The book is probably about the time when the Babylonians conquered Jerusalem in the 6th century BC (around 587/586 BC). At that time the people of Edom did not help. Just the opposite: They were glad. They joined in the robbing, and they handed over refugees (compare Psalm 137:7; Ezekiel 35).

The message: Whoever is glad about the disaster of others and takes advantage of the weak will be judged too. "As you have done, it will be done to you" (verse 15).

The pride of Edom VERSES 1–4

1 This is the vision of Obadiah.
This is what the Lord GOD says about Edom:
We have heard news from the LORD.
A messenger has been sent among the nations.
He says,
"Get up! Let's go to battle against her!"
2 "Look, I have made you small among the nations.
People look down on you very much.
3 The pride of your heart has fooled you.
You live in the cracks of the rock.
Your home is high up.
You say in your heart,
'Who will bring me down to the ground?'
4 Even if you fly up high like the eagle,
even if your nest is set among the stars,
I will bring you down from there,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom lived in a mountain land with steep rocks. The cities were high up. People thought no one could conquer them. (The famous rock city of Petra lies in this area. But it was built up only later by the Nabataeans.)

That is why Edom felt completely safe: "Who will bring me down to the ground?"

God answers: Your pride has fooled you. Even if you build your nest among the stars, I will bring you down.

For today: Whoever thinks no one can touch him easily becomes proud. Safety does not come from walls, wealth, or power.

Robbed and betrayed by friends VERSES 5–9

5 "If thieves came to you,
if robbers came by night,
oh, what disaster is waiting for you!
Wouldn't they steal only until they had enough?
If grape pickers came to you,
wouldn't they leave some grapes behind?
6 How Esau will be searched through!
How his hidden treasures will be found!
7 All the men you made agreements with
have sent you away, as far as the border.
The men who lived in peace with you
have fooled you and defeated you.
Friends who eat your bread
set a trap for you.
He has no understanding."
8 "On that day," says the LORD,
"won't I destroy the wise men of Edom,
and understanding from the mountain of Esau?
9 Your mighty warriors, Teman, will be terrified.
And so everyone on the mountain of Esau will be cut off and killed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: Even thieves take only as much as they can carry. And grape pickers always leave a few grapes hanging for the poor. But Edom will be robbed completely. Nothing will be left.

Verse 7: Of all people, the allies and friends who sat at the table with Edom will betray it. This reminds us of Psalm 41:9 (in some Bibles 41:10).

Verse 8: Edom was famous for its wisdom (compare Jeremiah 49:7). Job's friend Eliphaz came from Teman (Job 2:11). But this wisdom will not help.

Teman is a town or an area in Edom. Here it stands for the whole land.

What Edom did to its brother VERSES 10–14

10 "Because of the violence you did to your brother Jacob,
shame will cover you.
And you will be cut off forever.
11 On the day you stood by and watched,
on the day strangers carried away his goods,
and foreigners went in through his gates
and threw lots for Jerusalem,
you were like one of them.
12 But do not look down on your brother
on the day of his disaster.
Do not be glad about the people of Judah
on the day of their ruin.
Do not talk big
on the day of trouble.
13 Do not go in through the gate of my people
on the day of their disaster.
Do not look down on their suffering
on the day of their disaster.
Do not grab their wealth
on the day of their disaster.

14 Do not stand at the crossroads
to kill those of his people who escape.
Do not hand over those who are left
on the day of trouble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the heart of the book. What did Edom do wrong?

Verse 11: It watched when the enemies robbed Jerusalem. It "stood by and watched," and so it was "like one of them." Whoever watches injustice and does nothing shares the guilt.

Verses 12–14: And it got worse and worse: First Edom looked down. Then it was glad. Then it bragged. Then it joined in the robbing. And in the end it waited for refugees at the crossroads and handed them over to the enemies.

What makes it special: Edom was the "brother people." Here we see the old quarrel between the twins Jacob and Esau (Genesis 27).

For today: Being glad about another person's trouble, looking away, turning refugees away or handing them over, making a profit from the disaster of others. Obadiah shows how seriously God takes this.

The day of the LORD for all nations VERSES 15–16

15 "For the day of the LORD is near for all the nations!
As you have done, it will be done to you.
What you have done will come back on your own head.
16 For as you have drunk on my holy mountain,
so all the nations will drink without stopping.
Yes, they will drink and swallow it down.
And they will be as though they had never been.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A basic rule of God's justice: What you do to others comes back to you. Jesus says something similar: "With the measure you use to measure, it will be measured to you" (Matthew 7:2). And said in a positive way: "So whatever you want people to do to you, you shall also do to them" (Matthew 7:12).

Verse 16: A picture from the prophets: the "cup" of judgment. Edom celebrated and drank on Mount Zion when Jerusalem fell. Now all the nations must drink the cup of judgment (compare Jeremiah 25:15–29).

Rescue on Mount Zion VERSES 17–21

17 "But on Mount Zion there will be people who escape.
And it will be holy.
The house of Jacob will take back what belongs to them.
18 The house of Jacob will be a fire,
the house of Joseph a flame,
and the house of Esau dry straw.
They will burn among them and burn them up.
No one will be left of the house of Esau."
Yes, the LORD has spoken.
19 The people of the South will take the mountain of Esau.
The people of the lowland will take the land of the Philistines.
They will take the land of Ephraim
and the land of Samaria.
Benjamin will take Gilead.
20 The prisoners of this army of the people of Israel,
who are among the Canaanites,
will take the land as far as Zarephath.
The prisoners from Jerusalem, who are in Sepharad,
will take the cities of the Negev.
The Negev is the dry land in the south.
21 Saviors will go up on Mount Zion
to judge the mountains of Esau.
And the kingdom will belong to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: After the disaster there is hope: There will be people who are saved on Zion. Those who were taken away will come back and get their land again.

Verse 18: A hard picture: Jacob becomes a fire, Esau becomes dry straw. This language came out of times of war, after great injustice had been suffered. It announces God's judgment. It is not a command to people to destroy a nation. No people today may use such verses to justify hate or violence against another people.

Verses 19–20: The land will be taken back, in all directions. Zarephath lies on the coast in the north (near Sidon). It is not certain where "Sepharad" was. People often think of Sardis in Asia Minor. Later the Jews called Spain "Sepharad." That is where the name "Sephardic Jews" comes from.

Verse 21: The last word: "And the kingdom will belong to the LORD." Not Edom, not Israel, not any power of the world has the last word. God has it. The "saviors" are people whom God calls to bring justice.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Obadiah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The shortest book: Obadiah has only 21 verses. It is a word against Edom, the brother people of Israel.

Pride comes before a fall: Edom felt safe in its rocks. "Who will bring me down to the ground?" God says: "I will bring you down from there" (verses 3–4).

Looking away makes you share the guilt: "On the day you stood by and watched … you were like one of them" (verse 11).

Do not be glad about others' trouble: Do not be glad when things go badly for your brother. Do not take advantage of his need. Do not hand over refugees (verses 12–14).

What you do comes back: "As you have done, it will be done to you" (verse 15).

God has the last word: "And the kingdom will belong to the LORD" (verse 21).

For today: How do I react when things go badly for others, even for people I am in a quarrel with? Do I look away? Am I secretly glad? Or do I help?

What comes next? Next comes Jonah, the prophet who ran away from God. It is a story about God's mercy, even for the enemies of Israel.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 32 OF 66

JONAH

4 CHAPTERS

JONAH

CHAPTER 1

Jonah runs away from God

Before we begin: Who was Jonah?

The book of Jonah is different from the other books of the prophets. It has hardly any words of a prophet. Instead it tells an exciting story about a prophet.

A prophet Jonah, the son of Amittai, is also named in 2 Kings 14:25. He lived in the 8th century BC in the northern kingdom of Israel, in the time of King Jeroboam II.

Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, Israel's most dangerous enemy. People were afraid of the Assyrians because they were so cruel. Later they destroyed the northern kingdom of Israel (722 BC).

And of all places, Jonah is to go to these enemies!

Many scholars think that the book was written down later. They read it as a story that teaches something. Others read it as a report of things that really happened. Jesus himself speaks about Jonah (Matthew 12:39–41).

In Judaism, the book of Jonah is read on the Day of Atonement (Yom Kippur), the highest holy day. For it is about turning back and forgiveness.

The big question of the book: May God show mercy even to the enemies? The book has 4 chapters.

Jonah runs away VERSES 1–3

1 The word of the LORD came to Jonah, the son of
Amittai. He said,
2 "Get up, go to Nineveh, that great city.
Preach against it,
for their evil has come up before me."
3 But Jonah got up
to run away to Tarshish, away from the LORD.
He went down to Joppa
and found a ship going to Tarshish.
He paid the fare and went down into the ship,
to go with them to Tarshish,
away from the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God sends Jonah to Nineveh. It lies in the east (in what is now Iraq, near Mosul). Jonah gets up and runs in exactly the opposite direction: to Tarshish, far in the west, probably in Spain. At that time it was the end of the known world.

Why does Jonah run away? We only find out in Chapter 4: He knew that God is merciful, and he did not want the enemies to be saved.

It stands out: Jonah always goes "down": down to Joppa, down into the ship, later down into the bottom of the ship and down into the sea. Whoever runs away from God goes downward.

Joppa is today's Jaffa, a part of Tel Aviv.

The storm VERSES 4–6

4 But the LORD sent a great wind on the sea.
There was a mighty storm on the sea,
so that the ship was about to break apart.
5 Then the sailors were afraid.
Each man cried out to his own god.
They threw the cargo that was in the ship into the sea
to make the ship lighter.
But Jonah had gone down into the lowest part of the
ship.
He was lying down and was fast asleep.
6 So the captain of the ship came to him and said,
"What are you doing, sleeper?
Get up, call on your God!
Maybe your God will think of us,
so that we will not die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You cannot run away from God (compare Psalm 139:7–10). God sends a storm.

The sailors come from different peoples and pray to different gods. They do everything they can to save the ship.

And Jonah? He is asleep. Of all people, the captain, a man who does not know God, has to tell the prophet: "Get up, call on your God!" These are almost the same words God had used to call him: "Get up, go!"

The lot falls on Jonah VERSES 7–10

7 They all said to each other,
"Come! Let's throw lots,
so that we can find out who is to blame for this disaster
that has come on us."
Throwing lots was a way of making a decision, a little
like throwing dice.
So they threw lots,
and the lot fell on Jonah.
8 Then they asked him,
"Please tell us, who is to blame for this disaster that has
come on us?
What is your work?
Where do you come from?
What is your country?
What people do you belong to?"
9 He said to them,
"I am a Hebrew.
I fear the LORD, the God of heaven,
who made the sea and the dry land."
10 Then the men were terribly afraid.
They said to him,
"What have you done?"
For the men knew that he was running away from the
LORD,
because he had told them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The lot points to Jonah. The sailors question him.

Verse 9: Jonah's confession sounds faithful: "I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, who made the sea and the dry land." But it does not fit together: He says he fears the God who made the sea. And at the same time he tries to run away from him across the sea.

Verse 10: The sailors understand right away how dangerous this is: "What have you done?"

Jonah is thrown into the sea VERSES 11–16

11 Then they said to him,
"What should we do to you,
so that the sea will become calm for us?"
For the sea was getting more and more stormy.
12 He said to them,
"Pick me up and throw me into the sea.
Then the sea will become calm for you.

For I know that this great storm has come on you
because of me."
13 But the men rowed as hard as they could
to get back to the land.
But they could not,
for the sea was getting more and more stormy against
them.
14 So they cried out to the LORD and said,
"Please, LORD, we beg you,
don't let us die because of this man's life.
Don't hold us guilty for killing an innocent man.
For you, LORD, have done what you wanted."
15 Then they picked up Jonah and threw him into the sea.
And the sea stopped raging.
16 Then the men were terribly afraid of the LORD.
They offered a sacrifice to the LORD
and made promises to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonah knows: It is my fault. He is ready to let them throw him into the sea. But it seems he is still not ready to turn back and pray.

Verse 13: The sailors are amazingly kind: They do not want to sacrifice Jonah. They row as hard as they can to save him.

Verse 14: Then they pray to the LORD, the God of Israel, and ask for forgiveness.

Verse 16: In the end the sailors, who did not know God, fear the LORD. They offer a sacrifice and make promises. The irony of the story: The prophet who runs away brings people from other peoples to God, without even wanting to.

The sailors show more kindness and more respect for God than the prophet. The book of Jonah shows again and again: God works even among people from whom you would not expect it.

The huge fish VERSE 17

17 The LORD prepared a huge fish to swallow up Jonah.
And Jonah was in the belly of the fish for three days
and three nights.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this verse is Chapter 2, verse 1. That is why the verses in Chapter 2 are moved by one there.

God does not let Jonah drown. He "prepares" a huge fish that saves him. The Bible says "fish," not "whale." The whale comes from later translations and pictures.

"Three days and three nights": Jesus compares this with his death and his resurrection. "For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the huge fish, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth" (Matthew 12:40).

JONAH

CHAPTER 2

Jonah's prayer in the belly of the fish

Jonah prays VERSES 1–9

1 Then Jonah prayed to the LORD, his God,
from the belly of the fish.
2 He said,
"I called to the LORD because I was in trouble,
and he answered me.
I cried out from the belly of Sheol (the world of the
dead),
and you heard my voice.
3 For you threw me into the deep water,
into the heart of the seas.
The flood was all around me.
All your waves and breakers rolled over me.
4 I said,
'I have been driven away from your sight.
But I will look again toward your holy temple.'
5 The waters closed around me, up to my life.
The deep was all around me.
Seaweed was wrapped around my head.
6 I went down to the roots of the mountains.
The earth locked me in forever.
But you have brought my life up from the pit,
LORD my God.
7 "When my life was fading away inside me,
I remembered the LORD.
My prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
8 Those who worship worthless idols
turn away from the kindness that could be theirs.
9 But I will offer sacrifices to you
with songs of thanks.
I will do what I have promised.
Salvation belongs to the LORD."
Salvation means: rescue.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles these verses are moved by one (there they are verses 2–10).

At last Jonah prays, at the very bottom, in the belly of the fish. His prayer is a psalm of thanks. Many words remind us of the Psalms (for example Psalm 18; 42:7; 69:1–2; 120:1; in some Bibles 42:8; 69:2–3).

Verse 2: "Sheol": Jonah was very close to death. He felt as if he were already in the place of the dead.

Verse 4: Even when he felt driven away from God, he did not give up hope: "But I will look again toward your holy temple."

Verse 6: It cannot get any deeper. Then comes the line: "But you have brought my life up from the pit." That is the turning point.

Verse 8: A sentence that makes you think. Of all people, Jonah judges the people who worship idols harshly, even though the sailors who did not know God had just prayed to the LORD in Chapter 1.

Verse 9: "Salvation belongs to the LORD." That is the heart of the whole book. God alone saves whom he wants, Jonah too, and later Nineveh too.

For today: Sometimes people only pray when they are at the very bottom. And even then God hears. If you yourself feel "at the very bottom" and do not know what to do: Help is there day and night. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Jonah is spit out on land VERSE 10

10 Then the LORD spoke to the fish,
and it spit Jonah out onto the dry land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fish obeys God right away. In the whole book, everyone obeys God: the wind, the sea, the fish, the sailors, and later the people of Nineveh. Only one finds it hard: the prophet himself.

Jonah gets a second chance. Chapter 3 tells about it.

JONAH

CHAPTER 3

Nineveh turns back

The second chance VERSES 1–4

1 The word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time. He said,
2 "Get up, go to Nineveh, that great city.
Preach to it the message that I give you."
3 So Jonah got up and went to Nineveh,
as the LORD had told him.
Nineveh was a very great city.
It took three days to walk across it.
4 Jonah began to go into the city.
He walked for one day.
He cried out and said,
"In 40 days, Nineveh will be destroyed!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "A second time." God gives Jonah a second chance. He does not give up on people, not even when they have run away.

This time Jonah obeys.

Verse 3: "Three days": Nineveh was huge. Maybe this means the whole area with the towns around it. Or it means the time you needed to visit all the streets and squares.

Verse 4: Jonah's sermon is very short. In Hebrew it is only five words. Not a word about turning back or about grace, only the announcement that the city will be destroyed.

The whole city turns back VERSES 5–9

5 The people of Nineveh believed God.
They announced a fast
and put on sackcloth,
from the greatest to the least.
To fast means: to eat nothing for a time.
6 The news reached the king of Nineveh.
He got up from his throne,
took off his royal robe,
covered himself with sackcloth,
and sat in ashes.
7 He sent out a command through Nineveh.
It was the order of the king and his nobles:
"No person and no animal, no cattle and no sheep,
may taste anything.
They must not eat,
and they must not drink water.
8 But people and animals
must be covered with sackcloth.
And they must cry out to God with all their strength.
Yes, everyone must turn away from his evil way
and from the violence that is in his hands.
9 Who knows? Maybe God will turn and change his mind.
Maybe he will turn away from his burning anger,
so that we will not die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Something unexpected happens: The whole city believes God and turns back. From the poorest person to the king.

Sackcloth and ashes were signs of mourning and of being sorry for wrongs.

Verses 7–8: Even the animals are to fast and wear sackcloth. That sounds strange to us, almost funny. It shows how serious the whole city is.

Verse 8: The king names the real problem: "Everyone must turn away from his evil way and from the violence that is in his hands." Turning back does not only mean fasting and praying. It also means: stopping the injustice.

Verse 9: "Who knows?" The king has no guarantee. He simply hopes for God's mercy.

Jesus says later: The people of Nineveh turned back when Jonah preached (Matthew 12:41).

God has mercy VERSE 10

10 God saw what they did.
He saw that they turned away from their evil way.
Then God changed his mind about the disaster he had said he would bring on them.
And he did not do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God sees that the people turn back, and he spares the city.

This shows: God's words of judgment are often warnings. They are meant to make people turn back. When people turn back, God is ready not to let the disaster come (compare Jeremiah 18:7–8).

God does not "change his mind" because of a mood. He stays true to himself: He is merciful, and he wants people to live.

It is remarkable: Here it is Israel's enemies who turn back. God's mercy is for them too.

JONAH

Chapter 4

Jonah is angry, and God has pity

Jonah is upset about God's grace VERSES 1–4

1 But Jonah did not like this at all,
and he became angry.
2 He prayed to the LORD and said,
"Please, LORD, isn't this what I said
when I was still in my own country?
That is why I hurried to run away to Tarshish.
For I knew that you are a gracious and merciful God.
You are slow to become angry and full of loving
kindness.
You change your mind about doing harm.
3 So now, LORD, please take my life from me.
For it is better for me to die than to live."
4 The LORD said,
"Is it right for you to be angry?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now at last we find out why Jonah ran away. It was not because he was afraid of the Assyrians. It was because he knew: God is merciful. He will forgive them if they turn back. And Jonah did not want that. The enemies should be punished!

Verse 2: Jonah quotes an old confession about God (Exodus 34:6; Joel 2:13). The beautiful thing about it: He complains about exactly what is most wonderful about God.

Verse 3: Jonah would rather die than see God spare his enemies. He is bitter and in despair.

Verse 4: God does not scold him. He asks a question: "Is it right for you to be angry?" He invites Jonah to think about it.

If you yourself have thoughts that you would rather die: You are not alone. Talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The vine and the worm VERSES 5–9

5 Then Jonah went out of the city
and sat down on the east side of the city.
There he made himself a shelter
and sat under it in the shade.
He waited to see what would happen to the city.
6 The LORD God prepared a vine.
He made it grow up over Jonah,
so that it would give shade over his head
and take away his discomfort.
Jonah was very glad about the vine.
7 But at dawn the next day, God prepared a worm.
It chewed on the vine,
so that the vine dried up.
8 When the sun came up,
God prepared a hot east wind.
The sun beat down on Jonah's head,
so that he felt weak.
He asked to die.
He said, "It is better for me to die than to live."
9 God said to Jonah,
"Is it right for you to be angry about the vine?"
He said,
"I am right to be angry, angry enough to die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonah waits outside the city. Maybe he still hopes that God will destroy the city after all.

Again God "prepares" something, as with the fish in Chapter 1: this time a vine (a plant that grows fast; it is not certain which plant is meant; people often think of the castor oil plant), then a worm and a hot wind.

Jonah is very glad about the shade. That is the only time in the book that he is glad. Then the plant dries up, and Jonah is in despair again.

God uses the plant as a lesson. The explanation comes right away.

Shouldn't I have pity? VERSES 10–11

10 The LORD said,
"You feel sorry for the vine.
You did not work for it,
and you did not make it grow.
It came up in one night
and died in one night.
11 So shouldn't I feel sorry for Nineveh, that great city?
In it there are more than 120,000 people
who cannot tell their right hand from their left hand.
And there are also many animals."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's answer is a comparison: Jonah, you feel sorry for a plant that you did nothing for. Then shouldn't I feel sorry for a whole city full of people whom I created?

"Who cannot tell their right hand from their left hand": Maybe this means children, or people who do not know any better. God looks at them with mercy.

"And there are also many animals": God cares even about the animals.

The book ends with a question. We do not find out what Jonah answered. The question is meant for us readers: Are we glad when God shows mercy to people we do not like, even to our enemies?

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Jonah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet runs away: Jonah is supposed to go to Nineveh, the capital of the enemies, and he runs away in the other direction (Chapter 1).

You cannot run away from God: Storm, lot, sea, the huge fish: God does not let go of Jonah, but he does not let him drown either.

Prayer from the depths: In the belly of the fish, Jonah prays: "Salvation belongs to the LORD" (2:9).

A second chance: God calls Jonah a second time (3:1).

The enemies turn back: The sailors who did not know God and the whole city of Nineveh turn to God. And God has mercy.

God's mercy upsets Jonah: "For I knew that you are a gracious and merciful God" (4:2).

God loves all people: "So shouldn't I feel sorry for Nineveh, that great city?" (4:11). God's love is for all peoples, even for enemies.

Jonah and Jesus: Jesus speaks about the "sign of Jonah": As Jonah was in the fish for three days, he will be in the grave for three days (Matthew 12:39–41).

For today: Whom do I not want to receive God's grace? Where am I running away from what God wants from me? And: God gives second chances, to me too.

What comes next? Next comes Micah. He lived in the time of Isaiah and spoke up for the poor. The famous sentence "Human being, he has shown you what is good" comes from him (Micah 6:8). And he announces that a ruler will come from Bethlehem (Micah 5:2; in some Bibles 5:1).

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 33 OF 66

MICAH

7 CHAPTERS

MICAH

CHAPTER 1

God comes to judge

Before we begin: Who was Micah?

Micah came from Morasheth, a small town in the hill country of Judah, southwest of Jerusalem. He lived in the 8th century BC, at the same time as Isaiah, Hosea, and Amos.

His name means: "Who is like the LORD?" At the end of the book he plays on this (7:18).

Micah was a man from the countryside. He saw how rich landowners took the fields away from the farmers. He saw how judges, priests, and prophets took bribes. Like Amos, he fights for social justice.

He announces the fall of Samaria (the capital of the northern kingdom) and even of Jerusalem. 100 years later, people still remembered his words (Jeremiah 26:18).

But Micah also brings great hope: peace for the nations, when swords become plows (4:3), and a new ruler from Bethlehem (5:2; in some Bibles 5:1).

His best-known sentence is: "Human being, he has shown you what is good … to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God" (6:8). The book has 7 chapters.

The LORD is coming VERSES 1–4

1 This is the word of the LORD that came to Micah of Morasheth
in the days of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, the kings of Judah.
He saw it about Samaria and Jerusalem.
2 Listen, you peoples, all of you!
Listen, earth, and everything that is in it!
Let the Lord GOD be a witness against you,
the Lord from his holy temple.
3 For look, the LORD is coming out of his place.
He will come down
and walk on the high places of the earth.
4 The mountains melt under him,
and the valleys split apart
like wax before the fire,
like water that is poured down a steep slope.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micah begins as if in a courtroom: All peoples and the whole earth are to listen. God himself comes as a witness.

Verses 3–4: God comes down from his temple in heaven. The mountains melt like wax. This is picture language. It shows: Nothing can stand before God's power, not even what seems most solid.

Samaria and Jerusalem VERSES 5–7

5 "All this happens because Jacob did not obey,
and because of the sins of the house of Israel.
What is Jacob's disobedience?
Isn't it Samaria?
And what are the high places of Judah?
Aren't they Jerusalem?
6 That is why I will make Samaria a pile of rubble in the field,
a place for planting vineyards.
I will pour its stones down into the valley.
I will lay bare its foundations.
7 All her idols will be smashed to pieces.
All her temple gifts will be burned with fire.
I will destroy all her images.
For she gathered them from the pay of a prostitute,
and they will become the pay of a prostitute again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: The guilt lies in the capital cities: in Samaria (northern kingdom) and Jerusalem (southern kingdom). The powerful people lived there, the kings and the rich. Injustice went out from there.

"The high places" were places of worship where idols were often worshiped too.

Verse 6: Samaria will be destroyed so completely that only vineyards will be planted there. This happened in the year 722 BC through the Assyrians.

Verse 7: As in Hosea, idol worship is compared to prostitution. The riches of the idol temples were gained by being unfaithful to God. And they will go to strangers again when the enemies take them as plunder. This is a picture for unfaithfulness in religion. It says nothing about women.

Micah mourns VERSES 8–9

8 That is why I will mourn and cry aloud.
I will go around stripped and naked.
I will howl like the jackals
and mourn like the ostriches.
9 For her wounds cannot be healed.
For it has come even to Judah.
It reaches to the gate of my people,
even to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micah does not announce the judgment in a cold and hard way. He weeps and mourns for his people. He shows his sorrow in public by going barefoot and without his outer clothes, like a prisoner (compare Isaiah 20:2–4).

Jackals and ostriches make sad, crying sounds at night.

Verse 9: The disaster that hits Samaria also comes up to the gates of Jerusalem. In the year 701 BC the army of Assyria really stood outside Jerusalem (2 Kings 18–19).

A song of mourning over the towns of Judah VERSES 10–16

10 Don't tell it in Gath.
Don't weep at all.
In Beth Ophrah I have rolled myself in the dust.
11 Move on, you who live in Shaphir,
naked and in shame.
The people who live in Zaanan will not come out.
The crying of Beth Ezel will take away his protection from you.
12 For the people who live in Maroth are waiting anxiously for something good.
For disaster has come down from the LORD
to the gate of Jerusalem.
13 Hitch the fast horse to the chariot,
you who live in Lachish!
She was the beginning of sin for the daughter of Zion.
For the sins of Israel were found in you.
14 That is why you will give a goodbye gift to Moresheth Gath.
The houses of Achzib will disappoint the kings of Israel.

15 I will again bring a conqueror against you,
you who live in Mareshah.
The glory of Israel will come to Adullam.
16 Shave your heads and cut off your hair
for the children you loved.
Make yourself as bald as the vulture,
for they have been taken away from you as prisoners!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Micah lists many small towns in his home area that will be hit by the war. In Hebrew these are plays on words with the names of the places. They can hardly be translated. For example:

"Beth Ophrah" sounds like "house of dust": There people roll in the dust.

"Shaphir" means "beautiful": The beautiful one must leave naked and in shame.

"Maroth" sounds like "bitter": There people wait for something good, but something bitter comes.

"Lachish" sounds like the word for "team of horses": Hitch up the horses to flee! Lachish was an important fortress city where many chariots stood. Maybe this is what "sin" means: trusting in military power instead of in God.

"Achzib" sounds like "deception": The town will disappoint the kings.

Verse 10: "Don't tell it in Gath." The enemies (Gath was a city of the Philistines) should not be glad. David had mourned for Saul in a similar way (2 Samuel 1:20).

Verse 15: Adullam is a cave where David once hid (1 Samuel 22:1). The "glory of Israel," that is, the leaders, will have to hide again, as David did back then when he was running away.

Verse 16: Parents mourn for their children, who are being taken away as prisoners. Cutting off your hair was a sign of deep sorrow.

Many of the towns named here were conquered in the year 701 BC by Sennacherib, the king of Assyria.

MICAH

CHAPTER 2

How terrible for those who steal fields

The land robbers VERSES 1–5

1 How terrible it will be for those who think up wrongs
and plan evil on their beds!
When morning comes, they do it,
because they have the power to do it.
2 They want fields, and they grab them.
They want houses, and they take them away.
They treat a man and his family badly.
They take away a man and the land he inherited.
3 That is why the LORD says:
"Look, I am planning a disaster against this family.
You will not be able to pull your necks out of it.
And you will no longer walk around proudly,
for it is an evil time.
4 On that day people will make up a mocking song about you.
They will sing a bitter song of mourning and say,
'We are completely ruined!
The land of my people is being divided up.
He takes it away from me.
He gives our fields to traitors!'"
5 That is why you will have no one in the assembly of the LORD
who divides the land by lot.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: These people lie awake at night and think about how they can take advantage of others. And in the morning they do it, because they have the power to.

Verse 2: Rich landowners take the fields and houses away from ordinary farmers, for example through debts, high interest, or judges who took bribes. In Israel, the land was an inheritance from God. Every family was to keep its own piece of land (Leviticus 25:23). Whoever took a family's land took away what they needed to live.

This reminds us of the story of Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21) and of the commandment that you must not want your neighbor's house for yourself (Exodus 20:17).

Verses 3–5: The punishment fits the guilt: Whoever takes land from others will lose his own land. When the land is divided again by lot, they will get no share.

"Don't prophesy like that!" VERSES 6–11

6 "Don't prophesy!" That is what they prophesy.
"Don't prophesy about these things.
Disgrace won't catch up with us."
7 Should this be said, house of Jacob:
"Is the Spirit of the LORD angry?
Are these the things he does?"
Don't my words do good
to the one who lives an honest life?
8 But lately my people have risen up like an enemy.
You tear the robe and the clothes
from people who pass by without worry,
who are coming home from battle.
9 You drive the women of my people
out of their lovely houses.
You take my blessing away from their little children
forever.
10 Get up and go away!
For this is not your place of rest.
It is unclean, and that destroys,
with a terrible destruction.
11 Suppose a man came who lives by lies.
Suppose he lied and said,
"I will prophesy to you about wine and strong drink."
He would be the right prophet for this people!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: The powerful do not want to hear Micah's message: "Don't prophesy! … Disgrace won't catch up with us." That means: Nothing will happen to us. We already know this from Amos (Amos 7:12–13).

Verse 7: God answers: My words are good for everyone who lives an honest life. Only those who do wrong feel

threatened by them.

Verses 8–9: What the rich do: They rob people who suspect nothing, even soldiers coming home. They drive widows and women out of their houses. They take the future away from the children.

Verse 10: They are told: You yourselves will be driven out of the land.

Verse 11: With sharp mockery: The people want a preacher who promises them wine and beer, that is, pleasant things. They do not want to hear the truth.

For today: Whoever drives people out of their homes, takes advantage of the weak, and only wants to hear pleasant messages should take Micah's words seriously.

The shepherd gathers his flock VERSES 12–13

12 I will surely gather all of you, Jacob.
I will surely bring together the rest of Israel.
I will put them together like the sheep of Bozrah,
like a flock in the middle of its pasture.
The place will be full of people.
13 The one who breaks open the way goes up ahead of them.
They break through the gate and go out.
Their king goes on ahead of them,
with the LORD leading them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the words of judgment there is a promise: God will gather the rest of his people, as a shepherd gathers his sheep. Bozrah was a city in Edom, known for its flocks of sheep.

Verse 13: God himself is the "one who breaks open the way." Like a leader, he breaks open the gate and leads his people into freedom. As at the time of leaving Egypt, God goes at the front.

Some scholars also read these verses as words of the false prophets, who promise cheap comfort. Most understand them as a real promise from God.

MICAH

CHAPTER 3

Against the leaders, priests, and prophets

The leaders eat up the people VERSES 1–4

1 I said,
"Please listen, you heads of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel!
Shouldn't you be the ones who know what justice is?
2 You hate what is good and love what is evil.
You tear the skin off my people
and the flesh off their bones.
3 You eat the flesh of my people.
You strip their skin off them.
You break their bones
and chop them up like meat for the pot,
like meat in the cooking pot.
4 Then they will cry out to the LORD,
but he will not answer them.
Yes, at that time he will hide his face from them,
because they have done evil things."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micah speaks to the powerful: judges, officials, and leaders. Their task would be to make sure there is justice.

Verses 2–3: A shocking picture: They treat the people like animals for slaughter. They strip off their skin and cook them in the pot. Of course this is meant as a picture. It means: They squeeze people dry, down to the last bit. Nothing is left for them.

Verse 4: Whoever has no ears for the cries of the poor will not get an answer from God either when he himself is in need (compare Proverbs 21:13).

Against the false prophets VERSES 5–8

5 This is what the LORD says about the prophets
who lead my people the wrong way:
When they have something to chew on, they shout,
"Peace!"
But if someone does not put food in their mouths,
they get ready to make war against him.
6 "That is why night will come over you, with no vision.
It will be dark for you, so that you cannot tell the future.
The sun will go down on the prophets,
and the day will become black over them.
7 The seers will be put to shame,
and the fortune-tellers will be confused.
Yes, they will all cover their lips,
for there is no answer from God."
8 But as for me, I am full of power by the Spirit of the LORD,
full of justice and strength,
to tell Jacob that he has not obeyed,
and to tell Israel his sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: The false prophets can be bought: To whoever pays them, they promise "peace," that is, good times. Whoever does not pay, they threaten. Their message depends on money, not on God.

Verses 6–7: The punishment: God will be silent. They will have no more visions. Covering your lips was a sign of shame and sorrow.

Verse 8: Micah takes a clear stand against this: He cannot be bought. He is filled with God's Spirit, and he has the courage to tell the truth, even when it is uncomfortable.

Zion will be plowed like a field VERSES 9–12

9 Please listen to this, you heads of the house of Jacob
and rulers of the house of Israel.
You hate justice.
You twist everything that is straight.
10 You build Zion with blood
and Jerusalem with wrongdoing!

11 Her leaders judge for bribes.
Her priests teach for pay.
Her prophets tell the future for money.
And yet they lean on the LORD and say,
"Isn't the LORD among us?
No disaster will come on us."
12 That is why, because of you, Zion will be plowed like a field.
Jerusalem will become heaps of rubble,
and the mountain of the temple will become like hills covered with forest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Jerusalem was built up in a splendid way, but with "blood" and "wrongdoing": at the cost of the poor, through exploitation and maybe forced labor.

Verse 11: Everyone can be bought: judges, priests, prophets. And yet they feel safe: "Isn't the LORD among us? No disaster will come on us." They use God as insurance, without living the way he wants.

Verse 12: The answer: Zion will be plowed up like a field. The temple mountain will become an overgrown hill.

These words were so famous that people still quoted them 100 years later. When the prophet Jeremiah was to be killed because of similar words, some elders reminded the people: Micah said this too, and King Hezekiah did not kill him, but turned back to God (Jeremiah 26:17–19).

MICAH

CHAPTER 4

Swords into plows

Peace for all nations VERSES 1–5

1 But in the last days this will happen:
The mountain of the LORD's temple
will stand firm as the highest of the mountains.
It will be raised high above the hills.
And peoples will stream to it.
2 Many nations will go and say,
"Come! Let's go up to the mountain of the LORD,
to the house of the God of Jacob!
He will teach us his ways,
and we will walk on his paths."
For the law will go out from Zion,
and the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.
3 He will judge between many peoples.
He will settle the quarrels of strong nations far away.
They will hammer their swords into plows
and their spears into pruning knives.
A pruning knife is a knife for cutting back grapevines.
Nation will not lift up the sword against nation.
They will not learn war any more.
4 Instead everyone will sit under his own vine
and under his own fig tree.
No one will make them afraid,
for the mouth of the LORD of Armies has said it.
5 All the nations may walk
in the name of their own gods.
But we will walk in the name of the LORD our God
forever and ever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after the announcement "That is why, because of you, Zion will be plowed like a field" (3:12) comes one of the most beautiful visions of peace in the Bible.

Verses 1–2: At the end of time, the temple mountain will become the center of the world. Not because it is the highest mountain, but because all nations come there to learn from God. They come freely. No one forces them.

Verse 3: God will settle quarrels between the nations. Then no one needs weapons any more. Swords become plows, spears become pruning knives. Weapons become tools for life.

"They will not learn war any more": There is no more training for war.

Almost the same words are in Isaiah 2:2–4. The two prophets lived at the same time.

"Swords into plowshares" (a plowshare is the part of the plow that cuts open the ground) became the motto of the peace movement, especially in East Germany in the 1980s. A sculpture with this picture stands in front of the United Nations building in New York.

Verse 4: Everyone sits in peace under his own vine and fig tree. That is a picture of safety, wealth, and peace for everyone, also for the ordinary people whose land was taken away in Chapter 2.

Verse 5: Until then the nations go their own ways. But Israel stays faithful to its God.

God gathers the weak VERSES 6–8

6 "On that day," says the LORD,
"I will gather those who limp.
I will bring together those who were driven away,
and those whom I have made to suffer.
7 I will make those who limp into a remnant,
and those who were driven far away into a strong nation.
And the LORD will rule as king over them on Mount Zion
from then on and forever."
8 And you, tower of the flock,
hill of the daughter of Zion,
it will come to you.
Yes, the rule of former times will come back,
the kingdom of the daughter of Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: God gathers especially the weak: those who limp, those who were driven out, those who were hurt. From them he makes a strong nation. God begins something new with those who stand at the edge.

Verse 8: The "tower of the flock" was a watchtower from which shepherds protected their flocks. Here it is a picture for Jerusalem. The old rule of David will come back.

The birth pains of the daughter of Zion VERSES 9–13

9 Now why do you cry out so loudly?
Is there no king in you?
Has your adviser died,
so that pains have taken hold of you like a woman giving birth?
10 Twist and groan, daughter of Zion,
like a woman giving birth.
For now you will go out of the city
and live in the open field.
You will go all the way to Babylon.
There you will be rescued.
There the LORD will set you free
from the hand of your enemies.
11 Now many nations have gathered against you.
They say, "Let her be made unclean!
Let our eyes look with joy at the shame of Zion!"
12 But they do not know the thoughts of the LORD.
They do not understand his plan.
For he has gathered them like bundles of grain on the threshing floor.
13 Get up and thresh, daughter of Zion!
For I will make your horn like iron
and your hoofs like bronze.
You will crush many peoples.
I will give what they gained to the LORD,
and their riches to the Lord of the whole earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: Jerusalem is compared to a woman giving birth. The pains are great: The people will be taken away all the way to Babylon. But birth pains lead to new life. And in Babylon of all places, God will save his people. This happened when the people who had been taken away were allowed to return after about 50 years.

Verse 11: The enemies want to enjoy seeing Zion "made unclean," that is, abused and humiliated. This language reminds us of the violence done to women in war. God stands on the side of those who are humiliated. If you have experienced violence, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verses 12–13: The nations think they are the winners. But God has a different plan. The picture of threshing: An ox tramples the grain on the threshing floor. In this way Zion will defeat the enemies. This is picture language for God's judgment on those who oppress others. In the end, everything belongs "to the Lord of the whole earth," not to the winners. These verses do not call people to violence. The goal remains the peace of verse 3.

In some Bibles this chapter has 14 verses. Verse 4:14 there is the first verse of Chapter 5 in the WEB.

MICAH

CHAPTER 5

The ruler from Bethlehem

The judge is struck VERSE 1

1 Now gather your troops, daughter of troops.
The enemy has surrounded us to attack.
They will strike the judge of Israel on the cheek with a rod.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this verse is Micah 4:14. That is why the following verses of this chapter are also moved by one in those Bibles (WEB 5:2 = 5:1 there, and so on).

Jerusalem is under attack. The king ("the judge of Israel") is humiliated: They hit him in the face. Right into this hard situation comes the following promise.

The ruler comes from Bethlehem VERSES 2–6

2 But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah,
you are small among the families of Judah.
But out of you one will come to me
who is to be ruler in Israel.
His beginnings are from long ago,
from ancient times.
3 That is why he will give them up until the time
when the woman who is in labor gives birth.
Then the rest of his brothers
will come back to the people of Israel.
4 He will stand and take care of his flock like a shepherd,
in the strength of the LORD,
in the majesty of the name of the LORD his God.
They will live in safety,
for then he will be great to the ends of the earth.
5 He will be our peace.
When Assyria invades our land
and marches through our strong places,
then we will set up seven shepherds against him,
and eight leaders of men.
6 They will rule the land of Assyria with the sword,
and the land of Nimrod at its gates.
He will rescue us from the Assyrian
when he invades our land
and marches into our territory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: One of the best-known verses of the Old Testament. Bethlehem was a small, unimportant town. But King David came from there (1 Samuel 16). And from Bethlehem a ruler is to come again, a new David. God chooses what is small.

"His beginnings are from long ago": His family line goes far back, to David or even to ancient times.

In the Gospel of Matthew, the scribes quote this verse when the wise men from the East ask about the newborn king (Matthew 2:5–6). Christians see in it a sign pointing to Jesus, who was born in Bethlehem. In Judaism the verse is understood to be about the coming Messiah from the family of David.

Verse 3: First a hard time must pass, until "the woman who is in labor gives birth." Maybe this means the mother of the ruler. Maybe it means the whole people in its "birth pains" (compare 4:9–10). Compare also Isaiah 7:14.

Verse 4: He will be a shepherd, not a tyrant. He rules in God's strength.

Verse 5: "He will be our peace." In the New Testament it says about Jesus: "For he is our peace" (Ephesians 2:14).

Verses 5–6: "Seven ... eight" means: enough and more than enough. At that time Assyria was the great world power. "Nimrod" was a legendary ruler from Mesopotamia (Genesis 10:8–12). His land stands for Assyria here.

The rest of Jacob among the nations VERSES 7–9

7 The rest of Jacob will be among many peoples
like dew from the LORD,
like showers on the grass.
They do not wait for any person,
and they do not wait for human beings.
8 The rest of Jacob will be among the nations,
among many peoples,
like a lion among the animals of the forest,
like a young lion among the flocks of sheep.
When he goes through, he tramples them down and
tears them to pieces,
and no one can rescue them.
9 Let your hand be raised up over your enemies,
and let all your enemies be cut off.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two very different pictures for the small people of Israel among the nations:

Verse 7: Like dew: Dew comes from God, not from people. It brings life and freshness. In the same way Israel can become a blessing for other peoples.

Verses 8–9: Like a lion: strong and impossible to defeat. This picture speaks of the hope of a small people that is treated badly: Those who oppress it will not rule over it any more. It does not give permission for violence against other peoples.

God takes away what the people wrongly trust in VERSES 10–15

10 "On that day this will happen," says the LORD:
"I will cut off your horses from among you.
I will destroy your chariots.
11 I will cut off the cities of your land.
I will tear down all your strong places.
12 I will take away the witchcraft from your hand.
You will have no more fortune-tellers.
13 I will cut off your carved idols
and your stone pillars from among you.
You will no longer worship what your hands have
made.
14 I will pull up your Asherah poles from among you.
And I will destroy your cities.
15 In anger and rage I will take revenge
on the nations that did not listen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God clears away everything his people wrongly relied on:

Military power: horses, chariots, strong places (verses 10–11).

Superstition: witchcraft and fortune-telling (verse 12).

Idols: images, stone pillars, and Asherah poles (wooden poles for the goddess Asherah) (verses 13–14).

In the end Israel is to rely only on God. This fits the vision of peace in 4:3: no more weapons, no more war.

Verse 15: The nations that do not listen to God will also have to answer for what they did. God is the judge over all.

MICAH

CHAPTER 6

Human being, you have been told what is good

God brings charges against his people VERSES 1–5

1 Listen now to what the LORD says:
"Get up, bring your case before the mountains.
Let the hills hear what you have to say."
2 Listen, you mountains, to the LORD's charges,
and you firm foundations of the earth!
For the LORD has a case against his people.
He will argue it with Israel.
3 "My people, what have I done to you?
How have I made you tired?
Answer me!
4 For I brought you up out of the land of Egypt.
I set you free from the house of slavery.
I sent Moses, Aaron, and Miriam ahead of you.
5 My people, remember now
what Balak, the king of Moab, planned,
and what Balaam, the son of Beor, answered him.
Remember what happened from Shittim to Gilgal,
so that you may know the righteous acts of the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A trial in court: The mountains and the foundations of the earth are the witnesses. God brings the charges. His people are the accused.

Verse 3: But God does not accuse coldly. He asks sadly: "My people, what have I done to you? How have I made you tired?" Like a disappointed father or a disappointed mother. Later these words became part of the Christian worship service on Good Friday (the "Reproaches").

Verse 4: God reminds them of what he has done: He freed his people from slavery. And he sent them leaders: Moses, Aaron, and Miriam. It is remarkable: With Miriam, a woman is named here as a leader of the people.

Verse 5: King Balak wanted to have Israel cursed, but the seer Balaam had to bless it (Numbers 22–24). From Shittim to Gilgal: the last part of the way through the Jordan into the promised land (Joshua 3–4).

"The righteous acts of the LORD" are the good and right things he did for his people. Righteous means: right and just, the way God wants it.

What God really wants VERSES 6–8

6 How should I come before the LORD
and bow down before God most high?

Should I come before him with burnt offerings,
with calves a year old?
7 Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams,
with tens of thousands of rivers of oil?
Should I give my firstborn child for my disobedience,
the child of my body for the sin of my soul?
8 Human being, he has shown you what is good.
What does the LORD ask of you?
Only this: to act justly,
to love mercy,
and to walk humbly with your God.
Humbly means: without pride.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: A person asks: How can I please God? And he goes higher and higher: Calves? Thousands of rams? Rivers of oil? And in the end even: my own child?

Child sacrifice was known in the religions of the neighboring peoples. Sometimes it was also done in Israel (2 Kings 16:3; 21:6). The Bible condemns it sharply (Deuteronomy 12:31; Jeremiah 7:31). God does not want children to be sacrificed! Here the question only shows how absurd it is to keep going higher.

Verse 8: The answer is surprisingly simple. God does not want expensive sacrifices. He wants three things:

1. To act justly: to do what is right, especially toward the weak.

2. To love mercy: to be kind, faithful, and good. The Hebrew word "chesed" means faithfulness, love, and kindness all at once.

3. To walk humbly with your God: not to put yourself above others, but to live with God in everyday life.

This verse is seen as one of the most beautiful summaries of what God wants from people. Jesus says something similar: The most important things in the law are "justice, mercy, and faithfulness" (Matthew 23:23).

Cheating in the city VERSES 9–16

9 The voice of the LORD calls to the city.
And it is wisdom to fear your name.
"Listen to the rod of punishment, and to the one who sent it.
10 Are there still treasures gained by evil in the house of the wicked?
Is there still the short ephah that is cursed?
11 Should I put up with false scales,
and a bag of weights that cheat?
12 Her rich men are full of violence.
The people who live in her tell lies.
Their tongues speak to deceive.
13 That is why I have struck you with a terrible wound.
I have made you a ruin because of your sins.
14 You will eat, but you will not be full.
Your hunger will stay inside you.
You will put things away, but you will not keep them safe.
And what you do keep safe, I will hand over to the sword.
15 You will sow, but you will not harvest.
You will press the olives, but you will not rub yourself with the oil.
You will crush grapes, but you will not drink the wine.
16 For people keep the rules of Omri
and do everything the house of Ahab did.
You follow their advice.
So I will make you a ruin,
and the people who live in you something to hiss at.
You will carry the shame of my people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after verse 8, Micah shows what things are really like:

Verse 10: An ephah is a measure for grain. A "short ephah" is a measure that is too small.

Verses 10–11: False measures, false scales, false weights. The traders cheat their customers (compare Amos 8:5).

Verse 12: The rich are full of violence, and people lie everywhere.

Verses 14–15: The punishment: What they gained in the wrong way will not help them. They work, but they get nothing from it. Similar words are in the law of Moses (Deuteronomy 28:38–40).

Verse 16: Omri and his son Ahab were kings of the northern kingdom. Ahab was known for idol worship and injustice, for example for stealing Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21). Now Jerusalem is doing exactly the same.

MICAH

CHAPTER 7

Who is a God like you?

No one is righteous any more VERSES 1–6

1 How miserable I am!
I am like someone who gathers summer fruit
after the harvest in the vineyard is over.
There is no bunch of grapes left to eat.
I long to eat an early fig.
2 The faithful man has disappeared from the land.
There is no honest person left among people.
They all lie in wait to shed blood.
Each one hunts his brother with a net.
3 Their hands are eager to do evil.
The ruler and the judge ask for a bribe.
The powerful man says what evil thing he wants.
That is how they plot together.
4 The best of them is like a thorn bush.
The most honest one is worse than a hedge of thorns.
The day your watchmen warned about, the day of your punishment, has come.
Now is the time of their confusion.
5 Don't trust a neighbor.
Don't rely on a friend.
Even with the woman who lies in your arms,
be careful what you say!
6 For the son treats his father with contempt.
The daughter rises up against her mother,

the daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law.
A man's enemies are the people of his own house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Micah feels like someone who goes into the vineyard after the harvest and does not find a single grape any more. In the same way he looks for good, honest people and finds none.

Verses 2–4: Everyone is corrupt. Even the best are like thorns: You get hurt by them.

Verses 5–6: Trust is broken, even in families. You cannot trust anyone any more, not your friend, not your own husband or wife, not your own children.

Jesus quotes verse 6 when he says that deciding for him can sometimes even divide families (Matthew 10:35–36).

For today: Where corruption and distrust rule, living together breaks apart. If you experience violence in your family, get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. For children and teenagers in the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453.

I will look to the LORD VERSES 7–10

7 But as for me, I will look to the LORD.
I will wait for the God who saves me.
My God will hear me.
8 Don't be glad about my trouble, my enemy!
When I fall, I will get up again.
When I sit in darkness,
the LORD will be a light for me.
9 I will carry the anger of the LORD,
because I have sinned against him,
until he takes up my case
and gives me justice.
He will bring me out into the light.
I will see his righteousness.
10 Then my enemy will see it,
and shame will cover her, the one who said to me,
"Where is the LORD your God?"
My eyes will see her fall.
Now she will be trampled down like the mud in the streets.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: A turning point. In the middle of all the misery: "But as for me, I will look to the LORD." Micah holds on to God.

Verse 8: A wonderful verse of hope: "When I fall, I will get up again. When I sit in darkness, the LORD will be a light for me." These words have given courage to many people in hard times.

Verse 9: Here the people (Jerusalem) are speaking. They admit their guilt: "I have sinned against him." They accept the consequences, but they hope that in the end God will give them justice.

Verse 10: The "enemy" is probably an enemy city or an enemy people that mocked Jerusalem: "Where is the LORD your God?" The enemies mock in a similar way in Psalm 42:3 and Psalm 79:10.

A day for building VERSES 11–13

11 A day for building your walls!
On that day your borders will be made wider.
12 On that day people will come to you
from Assyria and the cities of Egypt,
from Egypt all the way to the River,
from sea to sea,
and from mountain to mountain.
13 But the land will be a ruin
because of the people who live in it,
because of the results of what they have done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: The destroyed walls of Jerusalem will be built again. This happened after the return from exile, under Nehemiah.

Verse 12: People will come from everywhere, from Assyria to Egypt, from sea to sea. Maybe this means the people coming back from exile. Maybe it also means the nations that come to God (compare 4:1–2).

"The River" is the Euphrates.

Verse 13: But first the time of ruin must be lived through.

Who is a God like you? VERSES 14–20

14 Take care of your people with your staff, like a shepherd.
They are the flock that belongs to you.
They live alone in a forest.
Let them graze in the middle of rich pasture land,
in Bashan and Gilead,
as in the days long ago.
15 "As in the days when you came out of the land of Egypt,
I will show them wonderful things."
16 The nations will see it
and be ashamed of all their power.
They will put their hands over their mouths.
Their ears will be deaf.
17 They will lick the dust like a snake,
like the creatures that crawl on the ground.
They will come out of their hiding places trembling.
They will come with fear to the LORD our God,
and they will be afraid because of you.
18 Who is a God like you?
You forgive guilt.
You pass over the disobedience of the rest of the people who belong to you.
He does not stay angry forever,
because he loves to show loving kindness.
19 He will have mercy on us again.
He will trample our guilt under his feet.
You will throw all their sins into the depths of the sea.
20 You will be faithful to Jacob
and show mercy to Abraham,
as you promised our ancestors
in the days long ago.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Micah prays: God, be the shepherd of your people! Bashan and Gilead were fertile areas for grazing east of the Jordan.

Verse 15: God answers: I will do wonders as at the time of leaving Egypt.

Verses 16–17: The powerful nations will be amazed and fall silent. In the end they come to God trembling.

Verse 18: "Who is a God like you?" This is a play on the name Micah, which means: "Who is like the LORD?" The answer:

No one! No god is like him, for he forgives guilt. He does not hold on to his anger, because he loves kindness.

Verse 19: A strong picture: God throws all our sins into the depths of the sea. They are gone, forever.

In Judaism there is a custom at the New Year festival (Rosh Hashanah) called "Tashlich" (from "you will throw" in this verse). People go to a body of water, pray these verses, and throw their sins into the water as a sign.

Verse 20: God stays faithful. What he promised Abraham and Jacob, he keeps.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Micah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet from the countryside: Micah of Morasheth lived in the time of Isaiah. He saw how the powerful took fields and houses away from ordinary people (2:1–2).

Against corrupt leaders: Judges, priests, and prophets took bribes. "That is why, because of you, Zion will be plowed like a field" (3:11–12).

Swords into plows: The great vision of peace for all nations: "They will not learn war any more" (4:3).

The ruler from Bethlehem: A shepherd will come from little Bethlehem. "He will be our peace" (5:2–5). Matthew relates this to the birth of Jesus.

What God wants: "Human being, he has shown you what is good … to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God" (6:8).

Hope in the dark: "When I fall, I will get up again. When I sit in darkness, the LORD will be a light for me" (7:8).

A God who forgives: "Who is a God like you? You forgive guilt. … You will throw all their sins into the depths of the sea" (7:18–19).

For today: Micah 6:8 is a measure for every day: Do I act justly? Am I merciful? Do I live humbly with God?

What comes next? Next comes Nahum. He announces the fall of Nineveh, about 100 years after Jonah. This time the city does not turn back.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 34 OF 66

NAHUM

3 CHAPTERS

NAHUM

Chapter 1

God is a strong place in times of trouble

Before we begin: Who was Nahum?

Nahum came from Elkosh. We do not know exactly where this place was. His name means "comfort."

The whole book is about the fall of Nineveh, the capital of Assyria. About 100 years earlier, Nineveh had turned back when Jonah preached. But after that, Assyria became the cruelest world power of that time. It destroyed the northern kingdom of Israel (722 BC), laid waste to Judah, and surrounded Jerusalem to attack it (701 BC). In their own inscriptions, the Assyrians bragged about how brutally they treated their enemies.

Nahum probably lived between 663 BC (when the Egyptian city of Thebes was conquered; he mentions it in 3:8) and 612 BC. In that year Nineveh was conquered and destroyed by the Babylonians and the Medes.

For the people who had suffered under Assyria, Nahum's message was a comfort: The rule of violence is coming to an end. God sees the injustice.

A word first: The book has hard pictures of war and words that are difficult to read. It is the voice of people who were treated badly and who long for justice. It is not a call for people to take revenge. And in the Bible it stands next to the book of Jonah, which shows: God also has pity on Nineveh, and he gives every people the chance to turn back. The book has 3 chapters.

God is jealous and mighty VERSES 1–6

1 A message about Nineveh.
The book of the vision of Nahum from Elkosh.
2 The LORD is a jealous God, and he takes revenge.
The LORD takes revenge and is full of anger.
The LORD takes revenge on those who are against him.
He keeps his anger for his enemies.
3 The LORD is slow to get angry and great in power.
He will by no means let the guilty go unpunished.
The LORD makes his way in the whirlwind and in the storm.
The clouds are the dust of his feet.
4 He speaks sharply to the sea and makes it dry.
He dries up all the rivers.
Bashan and Carmel wither.
The flowers of Lebanon wither.
5 The mountains shake before him.
The hills melt away.
The earth trembles before him,
yes, the world and everyone who lives in it.
6 Who can stand before his anger?
Who can bear the heat of his anger?
His anger is poured out like fire.
He breaks the rocks apart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Jealous" means here: God does not stop caring. He fights with passion for his people and for justice. In the Bible, "revenge" does not mean that God pays someone back out of personal rage. It means that God does not let injustice go unpunished, and that he gives justice to the victims.

Verse 3: "Slow to get angry": God was patient with Nineveh for a long time, more than 100 years since Jonah. But patience does not mean that injustice stays unpunished forever.

Verses 4–6: God's power is so great that all of nature trembles before him. Bashan, Carmel, and Lebanon were known for being fertile. Who could stand before such a God?

In the Hebrew language, Chapter 1 (verses 2–8) is partly an alphabet poem: Many lines begin with the letters of the alphabet, one after the other.

Good to those who trust him VERSES 7–11

7 The LORD is good,
a strong place on the day of trouble.
He knows those who look for safety with him.
8 But with an overflowing flood
he will put a complete end to her place.
He will chase his enemies into darkness.
9 What are you planning against the LORD?
He will make a complete end.
Trouble will not rise up a second time.
10 For they are tangled up like thorns,
and drunk as if from their own drink.
They are burned up completely like dry straw.
11 Someone has come out from you
who plans evil against the LORD,
who gives wicked advice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: In the middle of the words about God's anger, there is a wonderful sentence: "The LORD is good, a strong place on the day of trouble." For those who are treated badly, God's power is a protection. He knows everyone who looks for safety with him.

Verse 8: "Her place" is Nineveh. The "flood" can be meant as a picture. But there are also old reports that water played a part when Nineveh was conquered (compare 2:6).

Verse 11: This probably means a king of Assyria who planned evil against God and his people. Maybe it was Sennacherib, who had surrounded Jerusalem to attack it (2 Kings 18–19).

The yoke will be broken VERSES 12–15

12 The LORD says:
"Even if they are at full strength and very many,
they will still be cut down and pass away.
I have brought trouble on you,
but I will not bring trouble on you any more.
13 Now I will break his yoke off you
and tear your chains apart."
A yoke is a wooden bar on the neck of an ox. It is a picture for being forced to serve.
14 The LORD has given an order about you:
"No more children will carry on your name.

From the house of your gods I will cut off
the carved idol and the metal idol.
I will make your grave,
for you are disgusting."

15 Look, on the mountains, the feet of the one who brings
good news,
who announces peace!
Celebrate your feasts, Judah!
Keep your promises to God!
For the wicked one will never again march through
you.
He is completely cut off.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–13: God speaks to Judah: I allowed Assyria to oppress you. But now it is over. I will break the yoke and tear the chains apart. For many years Judah had to pay tribute to Assyria.

Verse 14: Now God speaks to the king of Assyria: Your royal family will have no future. Your gods cannot help you.

Verse 15: A messenger of joy runs over the mountains and brings the good news: Peace! The oppressor is defeated. Almost the same words are in Isaiah 52:7. Paul quotes them in his letter to the Romans for the messengers of the gospel (Romans 10:15).

In some Bibles this verse is Chapter 2, verse 1. That is why the verses in Chapter 2 are moved by one there.

NAHUM

CHAPTER 2

The fall of Nineveh

The attack on Nineveh VERSES 1–5

1 The one who smashes things to pieces has come up
against you.
Guard the fortress!
Watch the road!
Get ready for battle!
Make your strength as great as you can!

2 For the LORD will bring back the glory of Jacob,
like the glory of Israel.
For destroyers have destroyed them
and ruined their vines.

3 The shields of his mighty warriors are red.
The brave men are dressed in scarlet.
Scarlet is a bright red color.
The chariots flash with steel
on the day he gets ready for battle.
The spears of pine wood are waved in the air.

4 The chariots race wildly in the streets.
They rush back and forth in the squares.
They look like torches.
They run like lightning.

5 He calls for his best troops.
They stumble as they go.
They hurry to the city wall,
and the protective shield is set up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles the verses of this chapter are moved by one (there they are verses 2–14).

Verse 1: Nahum mocks Nineveh: Get ready to defend yourself! It will not help you.

Verse 2: The reason for all this: God wants to restore his people, who were laid waste by the Assyrians.

Verses 3–5: A lively description of the attack: red shields, soldiers in scarlet, flashing chariots that race through the streets like torches. The "protective shield" was a kind of roof for soldiers who attacked a wall.

The city falls VERSES 6–10

6 The gates of the rivers are opened,
and the palace melts away.

7 It has been decided:
She is stripped naked, she is carried away.
Her female servants moan like doves
and beat their breasts.

8 Nineveh has been like a pool of water since long ago.
But now they are running away.
"Stop! Stop!" people cry,
but no one looks back.

9 Take the silver as plunder!
Take the gold as plunder!
For there is no end to the treasure,
plenty of every kind of precious thing.

10 She is empty, bare, and ruined.
Hearts melt with fear, knees knock together.
Their bodies and faces have turned pale.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Nineveh lay on the Tigris River and had canals and floodgates. When the "gates of the rivers" are opened, the water floods the city. An ancient writer of history reports a flood that helped when the city was conquered. Historians argue about whether it really happened like that.

Verse 7: The city is described as a woman who is "stripped naked" and carried away. This is a picture for the humiliation of a conquered city. The women and female servants mourn and cry. In war, women suffer especially. That is injustice, no matter who does it.

Verse 8: Nineveh was like a large pool in which wealth and people from all over the world gathered. Now everything runs out like water from a broken pool. Everyone is running away.

Verse 9: The treasures that Assyria had stolen from other peoples are now stolen from Assyria itself.

Where is the den of the lions? VERSES 11–13

11 Where now is the den of the lions,
the place where the young lions were fed?
There the lion and the lioness walked
with the lion cubs,
and no one made them afraid.

12 The lion tore up enough food for his cubs.
He killed prey for his lionesses.

He filled his caves with the animals he killed,
and his dens with prey.
13 "Look, I am against you,"
says the LORD of Armies.
"I will burn up her chariots in smoke,
and the sword will kill your young lions.
I will cut off your prey from the earth.
And the voice of your messengers will no longer be heard."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The lion was the symbol of the kings of Assyria. They liked to have themselves shown hunting lions.

Nineveh was like a lions' den: The kings robbed the other peoples and filled their palaces with plunder. No one could stop them.

Verse 13: But now God says: "Look, I am against you." The den will be empty. The "messengers" of Assyria, who brought threats and orders to other peoples (compare 2 Kings 18:17–35), will fall silent.

NAHUM

CHAPTER 3

How terrible for the city full of blood

The city of blood VERSES 1–4

1 How terrible for the city of blood!
It is completely full of lies and robbery.
The taking of prey never ends.
2 The crack of the whip!
The noise of rattling wheels!
Galloping horses
and bouncing chariots!
3 The rider charges forward.
Flashing sword!
Shining spear!
Many killed,
and a great heap of dead bodies.
There is no end to the dead.
People stumble over their bodies.
4 All this is because of the many acts of prostitution of
the attractive prostitute,
the woman who is skilled in witchcraft.
She sells nations through her prostitution,
and families through her witchcraft.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Nineveh is called "the city of blood." Assyria had built up its power through violence, lies, and robbery.

Verses 2–3: In short, choppy sentences you can almost hear the noise of the battle. In the end there are dead people everywhere. War is cruel, for all sides.

Verse 4: Nineveh is compared to a prostitute and a witch. The picture means: Assyria tempted and cheated other peoples, with attractive offers, false promises, and political tricks, so that it could then use them and "sell" them. It is a picture for a world power. It says nothing about women.

God's judgment on Nineveh VERSES 5–7

5 "Look, I am against you,"
says the LORD of Armies.
"I will lift your skirts over your face.
I will show the nations your nakedness,
and the kingdoms your shame.
6 I will throw disgusting filth on you.
I will make you disgusting.
I will put you on display.
7 And this will happen:
Everyone who looks at you will run away from you.
They will say, 'Nineveh is ruined!
Who will mourn for her?'
Where can I find anyone to comfort you?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: These verses are hard to read. They use the picture of a woman being shamed in public. In this way they describe the humiliation of the proud city of Nineveh. Nineveh had humiliated other peoples. Now it is humiliated itself.

Important: This is a picture for the end of a rule of violence. It does not justify violence against women. Sexual violence and public humiliation are always wrong. If you have experienced something like this, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verse 7: "Who will mourn for her?" No one will weep for Nineveh, because the city had brought so much suffering on others. A sad end: a city that no one looks for comfort for.

Like Thebes VERSES 8–13

8 Are you better than No-Amon?
She lay among the rivers.
She had water all around her.
The sea was her defense,
and her wall was made of the sea.
9 Cush and Egypt were her strength, without limit.
Put and Libya were her helpers.
10 And yet she was carried away.
She was taken away as a prisoner.
Her little children were also smashed to pieces
at the corner of every street.
They threw lots for her important men,
and all her great men were put in chains.
11 You too will be drunk.
You will hide.
You too will look for a safe place from the enemy.
12 All your fortresses will be like fig trees with the first ripe figs.
When they are shaken,
the figs fall into the mouth of the one who wants to eat them.
13 Look, your soldiers among you are like women.
The gates of your land are wide open to your enemies.
Fire has burned up the bars of your gates.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–10: No-Amon is the Egyptian city of Thebes. It lay on the Nile, was surrounded by water, and had powerful allies: Cush (south of Egypt), Put, and Libya. And yet it was conquered in the year 663 BC, by the Assyrians of all people!

Nahum says to Nineveh: What you did to Thebes will now happen to you.

Verse 10: A cruel detail: Little children were killed. Conquerors often acted like this at that time, the Assyrians too. The Bible reports this cruelty so that we see how terrible war is. It does not call it good.

Verse 12: Like ripe figs that fall right into your mouth when you shake the tree, the fortresses will fall that easily.

Verse 13: "Your soldiers among you are like women" is an old way of speaking from a time when women were not allowed to fight and were seen as weak. It means: The soldiers will lose their courage and will not be able to fight. It says nothing about what women are really like.

All the preparations are useless VERSES 14–19

14 Draw water for the time when the enemy surrounds you!
Make your fortresses stronger!
Go into the clay
and stamp the mortar!
Mortar is the wet mix that holds bricks together.
Make the brick oven strong!
15 There the fire will burn you up.
The sword will cut you off.
It will eat you up like the grasshopper.
Become as many as the grasshoppers!
Become as many as the locusts!
16 You have made your traders more in number
than the stars in the sky.
The grasshopper strips the land and flies away.
17 Your guards are like the locusts,
and your officials like swarms of locusts.
They settle on the walls on a cold day.
But when the sun comes up, they fly away,
and no one knows where they are.
18 Your shepherds are sleeping, king of Assyria.
Your nobles lie down to rest.
Your people are scattered on the mountains,
and there is no one to gather them.
19 Your wound cannot be healed.
Your injury will kill you.
Everyone who hears the news about you
claps their hands over you.
For who has not felt your cruelty that never ended?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: With mockery: Get ready for the attack! Collect water, make bricks, make the walls stronger! It will not help.

Verses 15–17: Pictures of grasshoppers: Assyria had countless traders, guards, and officials, as many as grasshoppers. But like grasshoppers that fly away when the sun comes up, they will all disappear when danger comes.

Verse 18: The leaders ("shepherds") are sleeping. That means: They are dead or useless. The people are scattered like sheep without a shepherd.

Verse 19: The last words of the book are a question: "For who has not felt your cruelty that never ended?" All peoples had suffered under Assyria. That is why they clap when they hear about its end.

The book of Jonah also ends with a question about Nineveh: "So shouldn't I feel sorry for Nineveh, that great city?" (Jonah 4:11). Together the two books show: God is merciful and gives chances to turn back. But when an empire keeps on using violence, it does not last.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Nahum?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The end of a rule of violence: Nahum announces the fall of Nineveh, the capital of the cruel Assyrian empire. In the year 612 BC the city really was destroyed.

God is patient, but he does not stop caring: "The LORD is slow to get angry and great in power. He will by no means let the guilty go unpunished" (1:3).

A strong place in times of trouble: "The LORD is good, a strong place on the day of trouble" (1:7).

Freedom: "Now I will break his yoke off you and tear your chains apart" (1:13).

The messenger of joy: "Look, on the mountains, the feet of the one who brings good news, who announces peace!" (1:15).

Violence does not last: The "city of blood" that robbed others is robbed itself.

Jonah and Nahum together: Jonah shows God's mercy for Nineveh. Nahum shows God's justice. Both belong together.

For today: No ruler who uses violence lasts forever. For people who suffer under oppression, Nahum is a comfort: God sees the injustice. At the same time the book warns: Revenge is God's business, not ours.

What comes next? Next comes Habakkuk. He asks God the big question: Why do you allow injustice? And he learns: "The righteous will live by his faith" (Habakkuk 2:4).

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 35 OF 66

HABAKKUK

3 CHAPTERS

HABAKKUK

CHAPTER 1

How long, LORD?

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHO WAS HABAKKUK?

We know almost nothing about Habakkuk, except that he was a prophet. He probably lived shortly before 600 BC in Judah, in the time of Jeremiah. At that time the Babylonians (in the Bible also called "Chaldeans") were rising to become the new world power. Nineveh had just fallen (612 BC, see Nahum).

What is special about Habakkuk: He does not only speak to people on God's behalf. He speaks to God, and he asks him uncomfortable questions: Why do you allow injustice? Why are you silent when wicked people swallow up the righteous?

The book is like a conversation between Habakkuk and God:

Chapter 1: Habakkuk complains, God answers, Habakkuk complains again.

Chapter 2: God's answer: "The righteous will live by his faith," and five cries of "How terrible" against the oppressor.

Chapter 3: A prayer and a song. It ends with great trust: "Even though the fig tree does not bloom … yet I will be glad in the LORD."

Habakkuk shows: You may ask God questions, even questions full of doubt and complaint. The book has 3 chapters.

Habakkuk's first complaint VERSES 1–4

1 This is the message that Habakkuk the prophet saw.
2 LORD, how long will I cry for help,
and you will not listen?
I cry out to you, "Violence!"
and will you not save?
3 Why do you make me see wrongdoing?
Why do you look at what is wrong?
For destruction and violence are in front of me.
There is fighting, and quarrels rise up.
4 That is why the law has no power,
and justice never wins.
For the wicked surround the righteous.
That is why justice comes out twisted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Habakkuk begins with a complaint, as in many psalms: "How long?" He sees violence, fighting, and injustice among his own people in Judah. The courts no longer work. The wicked win. The righteous lose. Righteous means: living right before God.

And God seems to do nothing. Habakkuk accuses God: You do not listen! You do not save!

That is allowed: In the Bible, people may be honest with God, also with their disappointment, their anger, and their doubts. God can bear it.

God's first answer: The Babylonians are coming VERSES 5–11

5 "Look among the nations and watch!
Be amazed, yes, be amazed!
For I am doing something in your days
that you would not believe even if someone told you.
6 For look, I am making the Chaldeans rise up,
that bitter and fierce nation.
They march across the whole wide earth
to take homes that do not belong to them.
7 People fear them and are terrified of them.
They make their own rules and decide their own honor.
8 Their horses are faster than leopards
and fiercer than the wolves in the evening.
Their riders charge forward proudly.
Yes, their riders come from far away.
They fly like an eagle that swoops down to eat.
9 All of them come to do violence.
Their crowds of soldiers push forward.
They gather prisoners like sand.
10 Yes, they make fun of kings,
and princes are a joke to them.
They laugh at every fortress,
for they pile up a ramp of earth and capture it.
11 Then they rush past like the wind and go on.
They are truly guilty,
for their own strength is their god."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers, but very differently from what Habakkuk expected: I am sending the Babylonians. They will punish the unjust people of Judah.

Verse 5: This is so unbelievable that no one would believe it. Paul quotes this verse in a sermon (Acts 13:41).

Verses 6–10: An impressive description of the army of Babylon: fast as leopards, fierce as wolves, like an eagle on the hunt. No fortress can stop them. They simply pile up a ramp of earth and climb over the walls.

Verses 7 and 11: The Babylonians know no law except their own. Verse 11 says of them: "Their own strength is their god." That means: They worship only their own power. That is why they are guilty too.

Habakkuk's second complaint VERSES 12–17

12 Aren't you from everlasting, LORD,
my God, my Holy One?
We will not die.
LORD, you have chosen them to bring judgment.
You, Rock, have set him in place to punish.
13 Your eyes are too pure to look at evil.
You cannot look at wrongdoing.
So why do you put up with people who betray?
Why are you silent when the wicked swallows up
someone who is more righteous than he is?

14 Why do you make people like the fish of the sea,
like the crawling creatures that have no ruler?
15 He pulls them all up with a hook.
He catches them in his net
and gathers them in his fishing net.
That is why he is happy and glad.
16 That is why he offers sacrifices to his net
and burns incense to his fishing net.
For through them he lives in luxury,
and his food is rich.
17 Will he keep on emptying his net like this,
and keep on killing the nations without mercy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Habakkuk is not satisfied with God's answer. He has a new problem:

Verse 12: He trusts God, the eternal "Rock." He believes: Our people will not be completely destroyed. He also understands that God is using the Babylonians as a tool of punishment.

Verse 13: But: God, you are holy, and you cannot look at evil. How can you then allow even worse people to swallow up people who are less bad? Judah is guilty, yes, but Babylon is much worse!

Verses 14–17: A picture: Babylon catches people like fish with a hook and a net. And then it worships its own net, that is, its military power, which makes it rich. Will this go on forever?

This is a question people still ask today: Why are violent people so often successful?

HABAKKUK

CHAPTER 2

The righteous will live by his faith

God's answer: Write it down! VERSES 1–5

1 I will stand at my watch post
and take my place on the wall.
I will watch to see what he will say to me,
and what I should answer about my complaint.
2 The LORD answered me,
"Write down the vision.
Make it clear on tablets,
so that someone running past can read it.
3 For the vision is still waiting for its set time.
It is hurrying toward the end, and it will not prove false.
Even if it takes time, wait for it,
because it will surely come.
It will not be late.
4 Look, he is puffed up with pride.
His soul is not honest within him.
But the righteous will live by his faith.
5 Yes, and what is more, wine betrays.
A proud man does not stay at home.
He makes his greed as wide as Sheol (the world of the dead).
He is like death and is never satisfied.
He gathers all nations to himself
and piles up all peoples for himself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Habakkuk takes his place on the wall like a watchman and waits patiently for God's answer.

Verse 2: God says: Write it down big and clear, like on a poster. Everyone should be able to read it, even while walking past.

Verse 3: It will surely come true, even if it takes time. Wait patiently!

Verse 4: The key verse of the book. There are two kinds of people: The proud, who are puffed up and do not live honestly (this means Babylon especially). And the righteous, who live by their faith. Righteous means: living right before God.

The Hebrew word for "faith" also means "faithfulness" or "being reliable." The righteous person trusts God and stays faithful to him, even when he does not yet see how God will act.

This verse is very important in the New Testament. Paul quotes it in his letter to the Romans (1:17) and in his letter to the Galatians (3:11): A person is made right with God through faith. It is also quoted in the letter to the Hebrews (10:38). For Martin Luther, it became the key to the Reformation.

Verse 5: The proud man can never get enough, like death. He always wants to rule over more nations.

The first and second "How terrible": robbery and unjust gain VERSES 6–11

6 Won't all these sing a mocking song about him,
a saying that makes fun of him, and say,
'How terrible for him who piles up what is not his,
and who makes himself rich by forcing money from others!
How long will this go on?'
7 Won't the people you owe rise up suddenly?
Won't those who make you tremble wake up?
Then you will become their prey.
8 Because you have robbed many nations,
all the rest of the peoples will rob you.
This is because of the human blood you shed,
and because of the violence done to the land,
to the city, and to all who live in it.
9 How terrible for him who gets evil gain for his house,
to set his nest up high,
to save himself from the hand of disaster!
10 You have planned shame for your house
by cutting off many peoples.
You have sinned against your own life.
11 For the stone will cry out from the wall,
and the beam in the woodwork will answer it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now come five cries of "How terrible" against the oppressor (Babylon). The nations that were treated badly sing a

mocking song.

The first "How terrible" (verses 6–8): Against the one who robs others. What he did to others will happen to him: Those he robbed will rob him.

The second "How terrible" (verses 9–11): Against the one who builds himself a safe house with unjust gain, "up high," far away from all dangers. But even the stones in the wall will cry out and accuse him, because they were paid for with stolen money.

For today: Wealth that is built on using others is not safe.

The third "How terrible": a city built with blood

VERSES 12–14

12 How terrible for him who builds a town with blood,
and sets up a city by wrongdoing!
13 Look, isn't it from the LORD of Armies
that the peoples work hard only for the fire,
and the nations wear themselves out for nothing?
14 For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the
glory of the LORD,
as the waters cover the sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Babylon built splendid cities, but with the blood and the forced labor of the peoples it had conquered (compare Micah 3:10).

Verse 13: All this work is for nothing. What is built with injustice will burn in the end.

Verse 14: A wonderful look ahead in the middle of the cries of "How terrible": In the end it is not the violent rulers who will fill the earth. It is the knowledge of God's glory, just as the water fills the sea. Almost the same words are in Isaiah 11:9.

The fourth "How terrible": humiliating others VERSES 15–17

15 "How terrible for him who gives his neighbor drink,
who pours out your burning wine until they are
drunk,
so that you can stare at their naked bodies!
16 You are filled with shame, not with glory.
You will drink too, and your nakedness will be shown!
The cup in the LORD's right hand will come around to
you,
and disgrace will cover your glory.
17 For the violence done to Lebanon will cover you,
and the destruction of the animals will terrify you.
This is because of the human blood you shed,
and because of the violence done to the land,
to every city, and to those who live in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A picture for humiliating others: Someone gets others drunk to shame them and take advantage of them. That is how Babylon humiliated the nations.

The picture also describes a real wrong that still exists today: People are made helpless with alcohol or drugs and then used sexually. God clearly condemns this. If this has happened to you, it is not your fault. Help is there. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 16: The punishment: The one who did this must himself drink the "cup" of God's judgment and is shamed himself.

Verse 17: Babylon cut down the forests of Lebanon and destroyed the animals. Destroying nature is also an injustice that God sees.

The fifth "How terrible": idols that cannot speak

VERSES 18–20

18 "What good is a carved idol,
when the one who made it has carved it?
What good is a metal idol, a teacher of lies,
when the one who shaped it trusts in it
and makes idols that cannot speak?
19 How terrible for him who says to the wood, 'Wake up!'
or to the silent stone, 'Get up!'
Can this teach anyone?
Look, it is covered with gold and silver,
and there is no breath in it at all.
20 But the LORD is in his holy temple.
Let all the earth be silent before him!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–19: Babylon trusted in its gods, statues made of wood and stone, covered with gold. But they are dead, without breath. They cannot speak, cannot teach, cannot help.

Verse 20: The contrast: The living God is in his holy temple. The whole world should become quiet before him. The idols are silent because they are nothing. People should become silent because God is so great.

Here Habakkuk's complaint ends. Instead of asking more questions, he becomes quiet before God. That leads to his prayer in Chapter 3.

HABAKKUK

CHAPTER 3

Yet I will be glad in the LORD

Habakkuk's prayer VERSES 1–2

1 A prayer of Habakkuk, the prophet, set to music for
songs of victory.
2 LORD, I have heard of your fame.
I stand in awe of your deeds, LORD.
Do your work again in our own years.
In our own years make it known.
In your anger, remember mercy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapter 3 is a psalm, a song for worship. The heading in Hebrew ("Shigionoth") is a word from music. We do not know exactly what it means. The WEB translates it "set to victorious music."

Verse 2: Habakkuk has heard what God did in the past, for example when Israel left Egypt. He asks: Do it again, in our time! And there is an important request: "In your anger, remember mercy." Even when God has to judge, he should stay merciful.

God appears VERSES 3–7

3 God came from Teman,
the Holy One from Mount Paran.
Selah.
His glory covered the heavens,
and his praise filled the earth.
4 His brightness is like the sunrise.
Rays shine from his hand.
That is where his power is hidden.
5 Plague went ahead of him,
and disease followed his feet.
6 He stood and shook the earth.
He looked and made the nations tremble.
The ancient mountains crumbled.
The age-old hills sank down.
His ways are eternal.
7 I saw the tents of Cushan in trouble.
The tent curtains in the land of Midian trembled.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Habakkuk describes how God appeared in ancient times, like a mighty thunderstorm. He comes from the south: Teman (in Edom) and Paran (on the Sinai peninsula). This reminds us of how God appeared at Mount Sinai (Deuteronomy 33:2; Judges 5:4–5).

"Selah" is probably a sign for the musicians, maybe for a pause or a short piece of music. It also comes often in the Psalms.

Verse 5: Plague and disease go with God like servants. This reminds us of the plagues in Egypt.

Verse 7: Cushan and Midian were desert peoples in the area that Israel traveled through after leaving Egypt.

God fights for his people VERSES 8–15

8 LORD, were you angry with the rivers?
Was your anger against the rivers,
or your rage against the sea,
that you rode on your horses,
on your chariots that bring rescue?
9 You took out your bow.
You called for the arrows you had promised.
Selah.
You split the earth with rivers.
10 The mountains saw you and were afraid.
The flood of waters rushed past.
The deep sea roared
and lifted up its hands high.
11 The sun and the moon stood still in the sky
at the light of your arrows as they flew,
at the flash of your shining spear.
12 You marched through the land in anger.
You threshed the nations in rage.
13 You went out to save your people,
to save your anointed one.
You crushed the head of the land of the wicked.
You stripped them from head to foot.
Selah.
14 With their own spears you pierced
the heads of his warriors.
They came like a whirlwind to scatter me.
They were full of glee, as if they would secretly
swallow up the poor.
15 You trampled the sea with your horses,
stirring up the mighty waters.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Habakkuk describes God like a warrior with horses, chariots, bow, and spear. These are pictures from the language of that time. They remind us of God's great acts of rescue:

Verses 8 and 15: God goes through the sea, as when Israel left Egypt and went through the Red Sea (Exodus 14–15).

Verse 11: The sun and the moon stand still, as in the time of Joshua (Joshua 10:12–13).

Verse 13: The most important sentence: "You went out to save your people." God does not fight because he enjoys violence. He fights to save the weak and those who are treated badly. "Your anointed one" is the king or the people.

Verse 14: The enemies wanted to "swallow up the poor." God takes the side of the poor.

These pictures of battle describe what God does. They are not a command to people to wage war.

Yet I will be glad VERSES 16–19

16 I heard it, and my body trembled.
My lips shook at the sound.
Rot goes into my bones,
and I tremble where I stand.
For I must wait quietly for the day of trouble,
for the people who will attack us to come up.
17 For even though the fig tree does not bloom,
and there is no fruit on the vines,
even though the olive crop fails
and the fields produce no food,
even though the sheep are gone from the pen
and there are no cattle in the stalls,
18 yet I will be glad in the LORD.
I will be full of joy in the God who saves me!
19 The LORD, the Lord, is my strength.
He makes my feet like the feet of a deer.
He lets me walk on high places.
For the music director, on my stringed instruments.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Habakkuk trembles all over. He knows: The Babylonians will come. It will be a hard time. But he has learned to wait patiently.

Verses 17–18: One of the strongest sentences of faith in the Bible. Habakkuk lists everything a farmer needs to live: figs, grapes, olives, grain, sheep, cattle. And then he says: Even if everything is lost, I will still be glad about God.

This is not a shallow cheerfulness. It is deep trust: Even if I lose everything, I do not lose God.

Verse 19: God gives strength. Just as a deer jumps safely over steep rocks, Habakkuk can walk difficult paths with God's help.

The way the book goes: At the beginning Habakkuk asks, "How long?" At the end he says, "Yet I will be glad." His situation has not changed, but his trust has grown.

If you are going through a hard time and have no one to talk to: Help is there day and night. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Habakkuk?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet asks God questions: "LORD, how long will I cry for help, and you will not listen?" (1:2). Habakkuk brings his doubts and his complaint honestly to God.

God's surprising answer: God sends the Babylonians as punishment. That gives Habakkuk even more questions: Why does God use an even worse people? (1:13).

Waiting for God: "Even if it takes time, wait for it, because it will surely come" (2:3).

The key verse: "But the righteous will live by his faith" (2:4). Paul and Luther put this verse at the center.

Five cries of "How terrible": Against robbery, unjust gain, violence, humiliating others, and idols. No ruler who uses violence lasts.

Hope for the world: "For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD, as the waters cover the sea" (2:14).

Trust in spite of everything: "Even though the fig tree does not bloom … yet I will be glad in the LORD" (3:17–18).

For today: Habakkuk encourages us to ask God our questions honestly. And he shows a way from doubt to trust.

What comes next? Next comes Zephaniah. He speaks about the "day of the LORD," but also about God's love: "He will rejoice over you with singing" (Zephaniah 3:17).

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 36 OF 66

ZEPHANIAH

3 CHAPTERS

ZEPHANIAH

Chapter 1

The great day of the LORD is near

Before we begin: Who was Zephaniah?

Zephaniah lived in the time of King Josiah of Judah (640–609 BC). His family tree is given in an unusually long way, back to his great-great-grandfather Hezekiah. Maybe this was the famous King Hezekiah. Then Zephaniah would have been related to the royal family. But that is not certain.

His father's name was Cushi. The name can mean "the Cushite," that is, someone from Cush, south of Egypt. That is why some interpreters think that Zephaniah had African ancestors. This is not certain either.

His name means "The LORD has hidden" or "The LORD protects." That fits his message: Whoever seeks God will be "hidden" on the day of judgment, that is, protected (2:3).

Before King Josiah, the kings Manasseh and Amon had encouraged the worship of idols in Judah. Zephaniah speaks out against this. He probably worked before or during Josiah's great reform (from about 622 BC, 2 Kings 22–23).

The great theme is the "day of the LORD": a day of judgment on Judah and on all nations. But at the end there is one of the most beautiful promises in the Bible: God rejoices over his people with singing (3:17). The book has 3 chapters.

Judgment on the whole earth VERSES 1–3

1 This is the word of the LORD that came to Zephaniah,
the son of Cushi, the son of Gedaliah, the son of
Amariah, the son of Hezekiah.
It came in the days of Josiah, the son of Amon, king of
Judah.

2 "I will sweep away everything,
completely, from the face of the earth,"
says the LORD.

3 "I will sweep away people and animals.
I will sweep away the birds of the sky
and the fish of the sea,
and the heaps of rubble together with the wicked.
I will cut off people
from the face of the earth,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zephaniah begins with a mighty picture: God will sweep away everything. The order people, animals, birds, fish is exactly the opposite of the order in creation (Genesis 1). It is as if creation were being undone, like in the flood.

This is picture language, and it is stronger than real life. It is meant to wake people up: The wrong that people do is so bad that it threatens all of creation.

"Heaps of rubble": The Hebrew word is hard to understand. Some also translate it as "stumbling blocks" or "idols," that is, the things that make people fall.

Judgment on Judah and Jerusalem VERSES 4–6

4 "I will stretch out my hand against Judah
and against all the people who live in Jerusalem.
I will cut off from this place what is left of Baal,
and the name of the priests of idols and of the pagan
priests.

5 I will cut off those who bow down on the rooftops
to worship the army of the sky.
I will cut off those who worship the LORD and swear
by the LORD,
and at the same time swear by Malcam.

6 I will cut off those who have turned back
and no longer follow the LORD,
and those who have not looked for the LORD
and have not asked for him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Four groups of people are named:

1. The servants of Baal, the Canaanite god of fertility.

2. The people who worship the sun, the moon, and the stars ("the army of the sky") on their flat roofs.

3. Those who want to stand on both sides: They swear by the LORD and at the same time by Malcam. Malcam (or Milcom) was the god of the Ammonites. These people do not want to decide.

4. Those who do not care: They have simply turned away from God and no longer ask for him.

Not caring is also named here. It matters to God when people simply forget him.

The day of the sacrifice VERSES 7–13

7 Be silent before the Lord GOD,
for the day of the LORD is near.
The LORD has prepared a sacrifice.
He has made his guests holy.

8 "On the day of the LORD's sacrifice,
I will punish the princes
and the king's sons
and all who dress in foreign clothes.

9 On that day I will punish all
who leap over the threshold,
who fill their master's house with violence and lies.

10 On that day," says the LORD,
"a cry will be heard from the Fish Gate,
and wailing from the Second Quarter,
and a great crashing from the hills.

11 Wail, you who live in Maktesh!
For all the people of Canaan are destroyed.
All who were loaded with silver are cut off.

12 At that time
I will search Jerusalem with lamps.
I will punish the men who sit still like wine on its
dregs.
They say in their hearts,
'The LORD will not do good, and he will not do evil.'

13 Their riches will be robbed,
and their houses will lie in ruins.
Yes, they will build houses but not live in them.
They will plant vineyards but not drink their wine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: A frightening picture: God is preparing a sacrifice meal and has already invited the guests. But the "sacrifice" is the guilty people themselves, and the "guests" are the enemies who will come.

Verse 8: The powerful people at the king's court wear "foreign clothes": They copy the fashion and maybe also the religion of foreign nations.

Verse 9: "Leap over the threshold" was maybe a superstitious custom (compare 1 Samuel 5:5). Others think of servants who break into other people's houses to rob them.

Verses 10–11: The judgment hits the whole city: the Fish Gate, the Second Quarter (a newer part of the city), and Maktesh. Maktesh means "mortar," a bowl for grinding. It was a part of the city, probably a market and trading quarter. The rich traders will lose everything. "The people of Canaan" here means the traders, because the Canaanites were known as traders.

Verse 12: God searches Jerusalem with lamps. No one can hide. He looks especially for the self-satisfied people who sit still "like wine on its dregs." Dregs are the thick stuff that sinks to the bottom of wine. Wine that stands too long on it becomes thick and dull. These people say: "God does nothing anyway, neither good nor evil." They live as if there were no God.

Verse 13: Whoever has used others for their own gain will have nothing from their own riches (compare Amos 5:11).

A day of anger VERSES 14–18

14 The great day of the LORD is near.
It is near and comes very quickly.
Listen, the day of the LORD!
There the strong warrior cries out bitterly.
15 That day is a day of anger,
a day of distress and fear,
a day of trouble and ruin,
a day of darkness and gloom,
a day of clouds and blackness,
16 a day of the trumpet and the battle cry
against the cities with strong walls
and against the high towers.
17 "I will bring such distress on people
that they will walk around like blind men,
because they have sinned against the LORD.
Their blood will be poured out like dust,
and their flesh like dung."
18 Neither their silver nor their gold
will be able to save them
on the day of the LORD's anger.
The whole land will be eaten up
by the fire of his jealousy.
For he will make an end, yes, a terrible end,
of all who live in the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–16: This is one of the most famous descriptions of the "day of the LORD" in the Bible. Again and again it says "a day of …," like the strokes of a bell.

In the Middle Ages, verse 15 became the basis of the Latin hymn "Dies irae." That means: "Day of anger." It became part of the Catholic Mass for the dead. Many composers set it to music, for example Mozart and Verdi in their Requiems.

Verse 18: Money cannot save anyone from God's judgment. The rich, who trusted in what they owned, are left with empty hands.

The judgment came a few decades later, when the Babylonians conquered Jerusalem (587/586 BC). But Zephaniah also has a message of hope. It comes in the next chapters.

ZEPHANIAH

CHAPTER 2

Seek the LORD!

A call to turn back VERSES 1–3

1 Gather together, yes, gather together,
you nation that has no shame,
2 before the set time comes,
when the day blows away like chaff,
before the burning anger of the LORD comes on you,
before the day of the LORD's anger comes on you.
Chaff is the dry skin of grain. The wind blows it away.
3 Seek the LORD, all you humble people of the land,
who have kept his rules.
Seek what is right.
Seek humility.
Maybe you will be hidden
on the day of the LORD's anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the announcement of judgment there is a call: It is not too late yet! Gather together, turn back, before the day comes.

Verse 3: This is a key verse of the book. It speaks to the "humble," the "poor" in the land. They are told: Seek the LORD, seek what is right, seek humility.

"Maybe you will be hidden": This is a play on words with the name Zephaniah ("The LORD has hidden"). God protects those who seek him. The word "maybe" shows: No one can control God. But there is hope.

Judgment on the Philistines in the west VERSES 4–7

4 For Gaza will be left empty,
and Ashkelon will lie in ruins.
Ashdod will be driven out at noon,
and Ekron will be pulled up by the roots.
5 How terrible it will be for those who live by the sea coast,
the nation of the Cherethites!
The word of the LORD is against you,

Canaan, land of the Philistines.
"I will destroy you until no one is left living there."
6 The sea coast will become pastures,
with huts for shepherds and pens for flocks.
7 The coast will belong to those who are left of the house of Judah.
They will find pasture there.
In the houses of Ashkelon they will lie down in the evening,
for the LORD their God will take care of them
and bring them back to good times.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the view turns to the neighboring nations in all four directions: west (the Philistines), east (Moab and Ammon), south (Cush), and north (Assyria).

Verse 4: In Hebrew these are plays on words: "Gaza" sounds like the word for "left empty," and "Ekron" sounds like the word for "pulled up by the roots."

Verse 5: The Philistines lived on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. They probably came at first from the area of the Aegean Sea, maybe from Crete. That is why they are called "Cherethites" here. The word probably means "Cretans."

Verse 7: Those who are left of Judah will one day live there in peace. God will "bring them back to good times," that is, make everything good again.

Judgment on Moab and Ammon in the east VERSES 8–11

8 "I have heard how Moab mocked
and how the people of Ammon insulted,
how they mocked my people
and made themselves great against their land.
9 So as surely as I live,"
says the LORD of Armies, the God of Israel,
"Moab will surely become like Sodom,
and the people of Ammon like Gomorrah:
a place that belongs to nettles and salt pits,
a land of ruins forever.
Those who are left of my people will rob them.
Those of my nation who survive will take their land."
Nettles are weeds that sting.
10 This will happen to them because of their pride,
because they have mocked
and made themselves great against the people of the LORD of Armies.
11 The LORD will be terrifying to them,
for he will starve all the gods of the land.
People will worship him,
everyone from his own place,
all the shores of the nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–10: Moab and Ammon lay east of the Jordan River. They had mocked Israel and threatened its land. Their pride will be punished. Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19) were cities by the Dead Sea. Their destruction became a saying.

Verse 11: A surprising view of the future: God will "starve" the false gods, that is, take all their power away. And then people of all nations will worship God, "everyone from his own place." No one has to come to Jerusalem. God can be worshiped everywhere in the world.

Judgment on Cush and Assyria VERSES 12–15

12 "You Cushites too,
you will be killed by my sword."
13 He will stretch out his hand against the north
and destroy Assyria.
He will make Nineveh a land of ruins,
as dry as the desert.
14 Herds will lie down in the middle of her,
all kinds of animals.
The pelican and the porcupine will spend the night
on the tops of her pillars.
Their calls will echo through the windows.
Ruin will be on the doorsteps,
for he has stripped bare the cedar beams.
15 This is the happy city that lived without a care,
that said in her heart,
"I am, and there is no one besides me."
How she has become a ruin,
a place where animals lie down!
Everyone who passes by her
will hiss and shake their fists.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Cush lay south of Egypt. The Cushites are the people of Cush. For a time, kings from Cush also ruled over Egypt. This is about the political empire, not about the skin color or the origin of people. In Zephaniah 3:10, Zephaniah says that people from Cush will worship God. God loves all nations the same (compare Amos 9:7).

Verses 13–15: Nineveh, the capital of Assyria, will become a ruin where wild animals live. This happened in the year 612 BC (see the book of Nahum).

Which animals exactly are meant (pelican, porcupine, owl, bittern) is not certain. The meaning is: Where people used to celebrate, now only wild animals live.

Verse 15: Nineveh said: "I am, and there is no one besides me." This is pride: putting yourself in the place of God (compare Isaiah 47:8). Such pride leads to a fall.

ZEPHANIAH

CHAPTER 3

God rejoices over you with singing

How terrible for the city that does not listen VERSES 1–7

1 How terrible it will be for her who rebels and is unclean,
the city that treats people harshly!
2 She did not listen to the voice.
She did not accept correction.
She did not trust in the LORD.
She did not come close to her God.

3 Her princes inside her are roaring lions.
Her judges are wolves in the evening.
They leave nothing until the next day.
4 Her prophets are proud and cannot be trusted.
Her priests have made the holy place unholy.
They have done violence to the law.
5 The LORD inside her is righteous.
He does no wrong.
Every morning he brings his justice to light.
He does not fail.
But those who do wrong know no shame.
6 "I have cut off nations.
Their towers lie in ruins.
I have made their streets empty,
so that no one walks through them.
Their cities are destroyed,
so that no one is left,
no one lives there.
7 I said,
'Just fear me.
Accept correction.'
Then her home would not be cut off,
with all that I had decided for her.
But they got up early
and made all their deeds evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it is Jerusalem's own turn. After the neighboring nations, God's own city is no better.

Verse 2: She has failed in four ways: She did not listen, she did not let herself be corrected, she did not trust, and she did not come close to God.

Verses 3–4: All the leaders fail: the princes are like wild animals, the judges like hungry wolves, the prophets are proud, the priests make the holy place unholy.

Verse 5: The contrast: God is in the middle of the city, and he is righteous. Every morning, as faithfully as the sun rises, he shows his justice. But those who do wrong are not ashamed.

Verse 7: God hoped: When they see what happens to other nations, they will turn back. But they even "got up early" to do evil.

God will make the nations pure VERSES 8–10

8 "So wait for me," says the LORD,
"until the day when I rise up to take the prey.
For I have decided to gather the nations,
to bring the kingdoms together,
to pour out my fury on them,
all my burning anger.
For the whole earth will be eaten up
by the fire of my jealousy.
9 For then I will make the lips of the peoples pure,
so that they all call on the name of the LORD
and serve him shoulder to shoulder.
10 From beyond the rivers of Cush,
my worshipers, the daughter of my scattered people,
will bring me my offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Once more the judgment on the whole earth.

Verse 9: But then the great turning point! The goal of the judgment is not destruction but cleansing. God makes the lips of the nations "pure." They will all call on God together, "shoulder to shoulder," like people who carry a heavy load together.

This is a reminder of the tower of Babel (Genesis 11): There the languages were mixed up, and the people were scattered. Here the nations come together again.

Verse 10: "Daughter" here is a picture word for a people. Even from far-away Cush, south of Egypt, people will come to worship God. In the New Testament, a man from Cush (Ethiopia), a court official, is baptized (Acts 8:26–39).

A humble people VERSES 11–13

11 On that day you will not need to be ashamed
of all your deeds
by which you have sinned against me.
For then I will take away from among you
those who are proud and boast.
And you will no longer be proud
on my holy mountain.
12 But I will leave among you a humble and poor people.
They will find safety in the name of the LORD.
13 Those who are left of Israel will not do wrong
and will not tell lies.
No lying tongue will be found in their mouths.
For they will eat and lie down like sheep,
and no one will make them afraid."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: God takes the shame away. But he removes the proud.

Verse 12: What is left is "a humble and poor people." It is not the powerful and rich, but the small ones who find safety with God. With them God makes a new beginning.

This is a reminder of Jesus: "Blessed are those who are poor in spirit … Blessed are the gentle" (Matthew 5:3, 5).

Verse 13: This new people lives honestly, without lies and tricks. And it lives in peace, like a flock that no one frightens.

Rejoice, daughter of Zion! VERSES 14–20

14 Sing, daughter of Zion!
Shout for joy, Israel!
Be glad and rejoice with all your heart,
daughter of Jerusalem!
15 The LORD has taken away your punishments.
He has thrown out your enemy.
The King of Israel, the LORD, is among you.
You will not be afraid of evil anymore.
16 On that day people will say to Jerusalem,
"Don't be afraid, Zion!
Don't let your hands grow weak!"
17 The LORD your God is among you,
a mighty one who saves.
He will rejoice over you with joy.
He will calm you in his love.
He will rejoice over you with singing.
18 "I will take away from you
those who are sad about the set feasts.
They are a burden and a shame to you.
19 Look, at that time I will deal with all
who make you suffer.
I will save those who limp
and gather those who were driven away.

I will give them praise and honor,
those whose shame was known in all the earth.
20 At that time I will bring you home.
At that time I will gather you.
For I will give you honor and praise
among all the peoples of the earth,
when I bring you back to good times before your eyes,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book that began with the "day of anger" ends with a song of joy!

Verses 14–15: Jerusalem is to sing and shout for joy. The punishment is over. God himself is in the city as King.

Verse 16: "Don't be afraid, Zion! Don't let your hands grow weak!" A word of encouragement.

Verse 17: This is one of the most beautiful verses in the Bible. Not only do the people rejoice over God, but God rejoices over his people! He shouts for joy and sings over the people he loves. He is like parents who are happy about their child and sing a song for it.

"He will calm you in his love": Others also translate "he will be silent in his love," that is, so full of love that he needs no more words.

Verse 18: The verse is hard to understand in Hebrew. It probably means: God also gathers those who were sad because they could not celebrate the feasts in Jerusalem while they were in exile. And he takes away their shame.

Verses 19–20: God gathers the weak, those who limp and those who were driven away. Those who were looked down on everywhere receive honor and praise.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Zephaniah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The day of the LORD: Zephaniah announces a "day of anger" on Judah and on all nations (1:14–18). The famous "Dies irae" came from this.

Against idols and not caring: Judgment comes on those who worship Baal, who do not want to decide, and who say in their hearts, "The LORD will not do good, and he will not do evil" (1:4–6, 12). That means: God does nothing anyway.

Seek the LORD! "Seek what is right. Seek humility. Maybe you will be hidden on the day of the LORD's anger" (2:3).

Judgment on all nations: In all directions. And yet in the end people of all nations will worship God (2:11).

Pure lips for all nations: "So that they all call on the name of the LORD and serve him shoulder to shoulder" (3:9).

A humble and poor people: God makes a new beginning with the small ones who find safety with him (3:12).

God's joy: "The LORD your God is among you … He will rejoice over you with singing" (3:17).

For today: God does not just shrug. He takes wrong seriously. But his last word is love and joy, over you too.

What comes next? Next comes Haggai. He lived after the return from exile. He encouraged the people to rebuild the temple that had been destroyed.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 37 OF 66

HAGGAI

2 CHAPTERS

HAGGAI

Chapter 1

Build the house of the LORD!

Before we begin: Who was Haggai?

With Haggai, the last three prophets of the Old Testament begin: Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. They lived after the exile.

What happened before: In the year 587/586 BC, the Babylonians had destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. Many people were taken away to Babylon. In the year 539 BC, the Persian king Cyrus conquered Babylon. He allowed the Jews to go back and to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1). A first group went back and laid the foundation. But then there was opposition from the neighbors, poverty, and disappointment. The work was stopped (Ezra 4).

For almost 20 years the temple lay in ruins. In the year 520 BC, in the second year of the Persian king Darius, Haggai came forward. He called on the people to finally go on building. And they listened to him! In the year 515 BC, the second temple was dedicated (Ezra 6:15).

Haggai and Zechariah are named together in the book of Ezra (Ezra 5:1; 6:14).

The book of Haggai gives very exact dates. It contains four messages within only four months. The book has 2 chapters.

The people say: It is not time yet VERSES 1–4

1 In the second year of King Darius,
in the sixth month, on the first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came through the prophet
Haggai.
It came to Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, the
governor of Judah,
and to Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest.
It said,
2 "This is what the LORD of Armies says:
These people say,
'The time has not come yet,
the time to build the house of the LORD.'"
3 Then the word of the LORD came through the prophet
Haggai.
It said,
4 "Is it time for you yourselves
to live in your houses with fine wooden walls,
while this house lies in ruins?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The date is about August 29, 520 BC. Haggai speaks to the two leaders: Zerubbabel, the governor, and Joshua, the high priest. Zerubbabel came from King Jehoiachin, probably as his grandson. So he was from the house of David.

Verse 2: The excuse of the people: "The time has not come yet, the time to build the house of the LORD." There were many problems, after all: poverty, bad harvests, opposition from the neighbors.

Verse 4: Haggai answers sharply: You have time for your own houses! You have even covered their walls with fine wood, that is, made them beautiful. But God's house lies in ruins.

For today: Sometimes we also say "Now is not the right time" when it is about God. But for our own things we always find time.

Think about how things are going for you! VERSES 5–11

5 So now this is what the LORD of Armies says:
'Think about your ways!
6 You have planted much and brought in little.
You eat, but you do not have enough.
You drink, but you are not filled.
You put on clothes, but no one is warm.
And whoever earns wages
earns them to put into a bag with holes in it.'
7 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
'Think about your ways!
8 Go up to the mountain,
bring wood,
and build the house.
Then I will take pleasure in it,
and I will be honored,'
says the LORD.
9 'You looked for much,
but look, it turned out to be little.
And when you brought it home,
I blew it away.
Why?' says the LORD of Armies.
'Because of my house, which lies in ruins,
while each of you is busy with his own house.
10 That is why, because of you, the sky holds back the dew,
and the earth holds back its crops.
11 I called for a drought on the land
and on the mountains,
on the grain, on the new wine, on the oil,
and on everything the ground produces,
on people and on animals,
and on all the work of your hands.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5 and 7: "Think about your ways!" That means: Think for once about how things are going for you, and why.

Verse 6: A very lively picture: The people work hard, but it is never enough. They eat and are not full. They earn money, but it is as if they had a purse with holes in it. The money just runs through.

Many people know this today too: You work a lot, but at the end of the month nothing is left.

Verse 8: God's command is very practical: Get wood and build!

Verses 9–11: Haggai sees the drought and the bad harvests as a sign: You have put the wrong things first. Each of you only cares about his own house.

Important: Not every hardship in life is a punishment from God. The Bible also warns against thinking this way (the

book of Job; John 9:1–3). Here the prophet says it in a certain situation to certain people.

The people obey VERSES 12–15

12 Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel,
and Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest,
and all the rest of the people
obeyed the voice of the LORD their God
and the words of the prophet Haggai,
because the LORD their God had sent him.
And the people feared the LORD.
13 Then Haggai, the LORD's messenger,
gave the LORD's message to the people.
He said, "I am with you,"
says the LORD.
14 The LORD stirred up the spirit of Zerubbabel
the son of Shealtiel, the governor of Judah,
and the spirit of Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest,
and the spirit of all the rest of the people.
They came and worked on the house of the LORD of Armies, their God.
15 That was on the twenty-fourth day of the month,
in the sixth month,
in the second year of King Darius.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Something rare in the Bible: A prophet speaks, and the people listen at once! All of them obey, the leaders and the whole people.

Verse 13: God's answer is short and strong: "I am with you." That is the most important promise people can receive.

Verse 14: The LORD "stirred up the spirit" of the people. He gives them new courage and new excitement. Then they begin to work.

Verse 15: Only 23 days after Haggai's first sermon, they begin to build.

HAGGAI

CHAPTER 2

The glory of this house will be greater

Be strong and work! VERSES 1–9

1 In the seventh month, on the twenty-first day of the month,
the word of the LORD came through the prophet Haggai.
It said,
2 "Speak to Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, the governor of Judah,
and to Joshua the son of Jehozadak, the high priest,
and to the rest of the people. Say to them,
3 'Who is still left among you
who saw this house in its former glory?
And how do you see it now?
Doesn't it look like nothing to you?
4 But now be strong, Zerubbabel,' says the LORD.
'Be strong, Joshua son of Jehozadak, the high priest.
Be strong, all you people of the land,' says the LORD,
'and work!
For I am with you,' says the LORD of Armies.
5 'This is the promise I made with you in my covenant
when you came out of Egypt.
And my Spirit lived among you.
Don't be afraid!'
6 For this is what the LORD of Armies says:
'Once more, in a little while,
I will shake the sky and the earth,
the sea and the dry land.
7 And I will shake all nations.
The treasures of all nations will come,
and I will fill this house with glory,'
says the LORD of Armies.
8 'The silver is mine, and the gold is mine,'
says the LORD of Armies.
9 'The later glory of this house
will be greater than the former glory,'
says the LORD of Armies.
'And in this place I will give peace,'
says the LORD of Armies."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This was about the middle of October 520 BC, during the Feast of Booths.

Verse 3: Some old people had still seen Solomon's first temple, before it was destroyed 66 years earlier. Compared with its splendor, the new building looked poor. Many were disappointed (compare Ezra 3:12).

Verse 5: A covenant is a binding agreement.

Verses 4–5: God encourages them three times: "Be strong!" And: "I am with you. My Spirit is among you. Don't be afraid!" What matters is not how splendid the building is, but that God is there.

Verses 6–7: God will shake the whole world, and then the treasures of the nations will come to the temple. The letter to the Hebrews quotes verse 6 (Hebrews 12:26–28).

"The treasures of all nations": This is how the WEB translates it. Some other, older translations understand the verse as "the one whom all nations long for," and they apply it to the Messiah. The Hebrew text can mean both.

Verse 8: All silver and gold belong to God anyway. He can provide splendor if he wants to.

Verse 9: The glory of the new temple will be greater than that of the old one. And: "In this place I will give peace." Christians see here a hint that Jesus came to this temple. (Later, Herod had made it much larger and more splendid.)

What makes things holy and what makes them unclean VERSES 10–14

10 On the twenty-fourth day of the ninth month,
in the second year of Darius,
the word of the LORD came through the prophet Haggai.
It said,

11 "This is what the LORD of Armies says:
Ask the priests about the law. Say,
12 'Suppose someone carries holy meat in the fold of his clothes.
And with that fold he touches bread, stew, wine, oil, or any other food.
Does that food become holy?'"
The priests answered, "No."
13 Then Haggai said,
"Suppose someone is unclean because he touched a dead body.
If he touches any of these things,
does it become unclean?"
The priests answered, "It becomes unclean."
14 Then Haggai answered,
"'That is how this people is,
and that is how this nation is before me,' says the LORD.
'And that is how all the work of their hands is.
What they offer there is unclean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Haggai asks the priests two questions from the laws about being clean:

Question 1: Does something become holy when it is touched by something holy? Answer: No.

Question 2: Does something become unclean when it is touched by something unclean? Answer: Yes.

That means: Holiness does not spread to other things, but uncleanness does.

Verse 14: Haggai applies this to the people: As long as the temple lay in ruins and the people neglected God, everything they did was "unclean," even their sacrifices on the altar. A little bit of religion does not make a life holy if the heart is not in it.

From today on I will bless you VERSES 15–19

15 Now please think about it, from this day and back,
before one stone was laid on another in the LORD's temple.
16 All through that time,
when someone came to a pile of grain of 20 measures,
there were only 10.
When someone came to the wine vat to draw out 50 measures,
there were only 20.
17 I struck you with blight, mildew, and hail
in all the work of your hands.
And yet you did not turn to me,'
says the LORD.
18 'Please think about it, from this day and back,
from the twenty-fourth day of the ninth month,
since the day when the foundation of the LORD's temple was laid.
Think about it:
19 Is the seed still in the barn?
Yes, the vine, the fig tree, the pomegranate, and the olive tree
have not produced anything yet.
From today on I will bless you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Blight and mildew are plant diseases.

Verses 15–17: Remember how it was before: The harvest was always only half as big as expected. Diseases struck the grain. But you did not understand what God wanted to tell you.

Verses 18–19: But now, since the day the building started again, everything will change. Nothing has been harvested yet, and the seed has not come up yet. But God promises: "From today on I will bless you."

This is a promise that you have to accept in faith, before you see it.

The date (the twenty-fourth day of the ninth month) is about the middle of December 520 BC.

Zerubbabel, the signet ring VERSES 20–23

20 The word of the LORD came to Haggai a second time
on the twenty-fourth day of the month.
It said,
21 "Speak to Zerubbabel, the governor of Judah. Say,
'I will shake the sky and the earth.
22 I will overthrow the thrones of kingdoms.
I will destroy the power of the kingdoms of the nations.
I will overthrow the chariots and those who ride in them.
The horses and their riders will fall,
each one by the sword of his brother.
23 On that day,' says the LORD of Armies,
'I will take you, Zerubbabel my servant, the son of Shealtiel,'
says the LORD,
'and I will make you like a signet ring,
for I have chosen you,'
says the LORD of Armies."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last message is for Zerubbabel personally.

Verses 21–22: God will shake the great empires of the world. The mighty armies will destroy each other.

Verse 23: Zerubbabel will be God's "signet ring." A signet ring was very valuable. A king used it to seal and sign his letters and laws. Whoever had the signet ring acted for the king.

This is important: God had once rejected Zerubbabel's ancestor, King Jehoiachin (called "Coniah" in Jeremiah). At that time God said: Even if Coniah were the signet ring on my right hand, I would still pull you off from there (Jeremiah 22:24). Now God accepts the house of David again.

Zerubbabel himself never became king. But the promise to the house of David stayed. Zerubbabel is named in the family tree of Jesus (Matthew 1:12–13; Luke 3:27).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Haggai?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the exile: The Jews had come back from Babylon, but the temple lay in ruins for almost 20 years.

The wrong things first: "Is it time for you yourselves to live in your houses with fine wooden walls, while this house lies in ruins?" (1:4).

Think about your ways: Whoever thinks only of himself has "a bag with holes in it" (1:6).

The people obey: A rare success for a prophet. And God says: "I am with you" (1:13).

Be strong and don't be afraid: Even if the new temple is small and plain, God's Spirit is there (2:4–5).

Greater glory: "The later glory of this house will be greater than the former glory" (2:9).

From today on I will bless you: God promises blessing even before people see it (2:19).

For today: Haggai asks us: What place does God have in my life? Do I have time for everything, except for him?

What comes next? Next comes Zechariah. He lived at the same time as Haggai and had many mysterious visions. He announces a king. This king is "humble, and riding on a donkey" (Zechariah 9:9).

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 38 OF 66

ZECHARIAH

14 CHAPTERS

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 1

Return to me!

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHO WAS ZECHARIAH?

Zechariah lived at the same time as Haggai, from the year 520 BC on, after the return from the exile in Babylon. Both of them encouraged the people to rebuild the temple (Ezra 5:1; 6:14).

Zechariah probably came from a family of priests (compare Nehemiah 12:16). His name means: The LORD has remembered.

Zechariah is the longest book of the 12 minor prophets. It has two parts:

Chapters 1–8: Eight visions in the night, with angels, horses, horns, a lampstand, a flying scroll, and other puzzling pictures. An angel explains to Zechariah what they mean. The message: God is with his people again. Jerusalem will be built again.

Chapters 9–14: Words about the future, about a king who is coming, a good shepherd, and the day when God will be King over the whole earth. Many scholars think that this second part was written later.

No other book of the prophets is quoted as often as Zechariah in the reports about the last days of Jesus: the king on the donkey (9:9), the 30 pieces of silver (11:12–13), "They will look at me, the one they have pierced" (12:10), and the shepherd who is struck (13:7).

A note: In some Bibles, the verses at the end of Chapter 1 (verses 18–21) are the beginning of Chapter 2 (there 2:1–4). The book has 14 chapters.

Return to me! VERSES 1–6

1 In the eighth month, in the second year of Darius,
the word of the LORD came to the prophet Zechariah,
the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo.
It said,
2 "The LORD was very angry with your ancestors.
3 So tell the people:
This is what the LORD of Armies says:
'Return to me,' says the LORD of Armies,
'and I will return to you,'
says the LORD of Armies.
4 Don't be like your ancestors.
The earlier prophets called out to them:
'This is what the LORD of Armies says:
Turn back now from your evil ways and from your evil deeds!'
But they did not hear and did not listen to me,
says the LORD.
5 Your ancestors, where are they?
And the prophets, do they live forever?
6 But my words and my rules,
which I commanded my servants the prophets,
didn't they catch up with your ancestors?
Then they turned back and said,
'The LORD of Armies has dealt with us
just as he decided to do to us,
because of our ways and because of our deeds.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This was about October/November 520 BC, that is, between Haggai's second and third messages.

Verse 3: The heart of it: "Return to me … and I will return to you." God is waiting for his people to come back to him. And then he is there at once. The letter of James says something similar: "Come near to God, and he will come near to you" (James 4:8).

Verses 4–6: Zechariah reminds the people of their history: The ancestors did not listen to the prophets. The ancestors are dead, and the prophets have died too. But God's word has stayed, and it came true: The exile came. In the end, the ancestors understood.

The message: Learn from history! Don't make the same mistakes.

The first vision: Riders among the myrtle trees VERSES 7–17

7 On the twenty-fourth day of the eleventh month,
that is the month Shebat,
in the second year of Darius,
the word of the LORD came to the prophet Zechariah,
the son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo.
It said,
8 "I had a vision in the night.
I saw a man riding on a red horse.
He stood among the myrtle trees in a deep valley.
And behind him were red, brown, and white horses.
9 Then I asked,
'My lord, what are these?'"
The angel who talked with me said to me,
"I will show you what these are."
10 The man who stood among the myrtle trees answered,
"They are the ones the LORD has sent
to go back and forth through the earth."
11 They reported to the angel of the LORD
who stood among the myrtle trees. They said,
"We have gone back and forth through the earth.
Look, the whole earth is at rest and in peace."
12 Then the angel of the LORD answered,
"LORD of Armies, how long will you not show mercy
to Jerusalem and to the cities of Judah?
You have been angry with them for these 70 years."
13 The LORD answered the angel who talked with me
with kind words, with comforting words.
14 So the angel who talked with me said to me,
"Call out and say,
'This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"I am jealous for Jerusalem and for Zion with a great jealousy.
15 I am very angry with the nations that live without a care.

For I was only a little angry,
but they made the disaster even worse."
16 So the LORD says:
"I have come back to Jerusalem with mercy.
My house will be built in it,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and a measuring line will be stretched out over
Jerusalem."'
17 Call out again and say,
'This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"My cities will again overflow with good things.
The LORD will again comfort Zion
and will again choose Jerusalem."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: This was about the middle of February 519 BC. In this night Zechariah has eight visions.

Verse 8: Myrtle trees are bushes with a sweet smell.

Verses 8–11: Riders on horses of different colors. They are like scouts that God has sent into the whole world. Their report: "The whole earth is at rest and in peace." After some rebellions, the Persian Empire had just found peace again.

But for Jerusalem this "peace" is not good news: The nations live without a care, while Jerusalem still lies in ruins.

Verse 12: The angel prays for Jerusalem: "How long?" The "70 years" are a reminder of Jeremiah's prophecy (Jeremiah 25:11; 29:10). From the burning of the first temple to its rebuilding, it really was about 70 years (587/586 to 515 BC).

Verses 13–17: God answers with comforting words: I love Jerusalem with a deep and passionate love. I am angry with the nations that went too far when they punished my people. I am coming back with mercy. My temple will be built. The city will be measured and built again.

The second vision: Four horns and four craftsmen
VERSES 18–21

18 I looked up and saw
four horns.
19 I asked the angel who talked with me,
"What are these?"
He answered me,
"These are the horns that have scattered Judah, Israel,
and Jerusalem."
20 The LORD showed me four craftsmen.
21 Then I asked,
"What are these coming to do?"
He said,
"These are the horns that scattered Judah,
so that no one could lift up his head.
But these craftsmen have come to terrify them,
to throw down the horns of the nations
that lifted up their horn against the land of Judah to
scatter it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, these verses are at the beginning of Chapter 2 (there verses 1–4).

In the Bible, a horn is a picture of power and strength, like the horns of a bull. The four horns are the world powers that destroyed and scattered Israel and Judah. "Four" can stand for all four directions, that is, for all the enemies all around.

The four "craftsmen" (workers skilled with their hands) come to knock off the horns. For every power that oppresses his people, God has a power against it.

The message: Those who oppress others will not rule forever.

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 2

A city without walls

The third vision: the man with the measuring line
VERSES 1–5

1 I looked up and saw
a man with a measuring line in his hand.
2 Then I asked,
"Where are you going?"
He said to me,
"To measure Jerusalem,
to see how wide and how long it is."
3 Then the angel who talked with me went out,
and another angel went out to meet him.
4 He said to him,
"Run and tell this young man,
'Jerusalem will be lived in like villages without walls,
because there will be so many people and animals in it.
5 For I,' says the LORD,
'will be a wall of fire all around her,
and I will be the glory in the middle of her.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, the verses of this chapter are usually moved by four (WEB 2:1 = there 2:5, and so on), because there the last four verses of Chapter 1 already belong to Chapter 2.

A young man wants to measure Jerusalem, probably to plan the new city walls.

But an angel says: Stop! Jerusalem will become so big that no wall can go around it. So many people and animals will live there.

Verse 5: And Jerusalem does not need walls of stone. God himself will be the wall, a wall of fire. This is a reminder of the pillar of fire when the people left Egypt (Exodus 13:21). God protects his city, and he lives in the middle of it.

Come home from Babylon! VERSES 6–9

6 'Come! Come! Flee from the land of the north,'
says the LORD.
'For I have scattered you like the four winds of the
sky,'
says the LORD.
7 'Come, Zion!
Escape, you who live with the daughter of Babylon!'
8 For the LORD of Armies says:
'For the sake of honor he has sent me to the nations
that robbed you.

For whoever touches you
touches the apple of his eye.
9 For look, I will shake my hand over them,
and they will be robbed by those who served them.
Then you will know that the LORD of Armies has sent me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: This is a call to the Jews who still lived in Babylon (the "land of the north"): Come home! Not all of them had gone back with the first group. Many had built a new life in Babylon.

Babylon really lay in the east. But the road from there came into Israel from the north. That is why it is called the "land of the north."

"The daughter of Babylon" means the city of Babylon and its people.

Verse 8: A famous picture: "Whoever touches you touches the apple of his eye." The "apple of the eye" is the pupil, the dark center of the eye. It is the most sensitive part of the body. People protect it without thinking. That is how precious and how protected God's people are to him (compare Deuteronomy 32:10; Psalm 17:8).

"The apple of his eye": In Hebrew it is not quite clear whose eye is meant. The usual understanding: God's own eye.

Who is speaking here ("he has sent me")? Maybe the prophet, maybe the angel of the LORD. Interpreters disagree about this.

Many nations will come to God VERSES 10–13

10 Sing and rejoice, daughter of Zion!
For look, I am coming, and I will live among you,'
says the LORD.
11 On that day many nations will join themselves to the LORD,
and they will be my people.
I will live among you,
and you will know that the LORD of Armies has sent me to you.
12 The LORD will take Judah as his own share in the holy land,
and he will again choose Jerusalem.
13 Be silent, all people, before the LORD,
for he has risen up from his holy home!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: God himself comes and lives among his people. The Gospel of John says about Jesus: "The Word became flesh and lived among us" (John 1:14).

Verse 11: A great view of the future: Many nations will join themselves to God and be "my people." God's people will be bigger than Israel alone. Other nations are not shut out but invited.

Verse 12: The words "holy land" are very rare in the Old Testament. Many interpreters think that this is the only place where they appear.

Verse 13: The WEB says "all flesh," that means: all people. God has risen up to act (compare Habakkuk 2:20).

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 3

New clothes for the high priest

The fourth vision: Joshua on trial VERSES 1–5

1 He showed me Joshua the high priest
standing before the angel of the LORD.
And Satan was standing at his right side to accuse him.
2 The LORD said to Satan,
"May the LORD rebuke you, Satan!
Yes, may the LORD, who has chosen Jerusalem,
rebuke you!
Isn't this man a burning stick pulled out of the fire?"
To rebuke means to speak sharply against someone and stop him.
3 Now Joshua was dressed in filthy clothes,
and he was standing before the angel.
4 The angel answered and said to those who stood before him,
"Take the filthy clothes off him."
And to Joshua he said,
"Look, I have taken your guilt away from you,
and I will dress you in fine clothes."
5 I said,
"Let them put a clean turban on his head."
So they put a clean turban on his head
and dressed him in clothes.
And the angel of the LORD was standing nearby.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A court scene in heaven. The one on trial is Joshua, the high priest. He stands for the whole people before God.

In Hebrew, "Satan" means "accuser" or "enemy." Here he is like a prosecutor who accuses Joshua (compare Job 1–2). He stands at Joshua's right side. That is where the accuser stood in court.

Verse 2: But God himself rejects the accuser! Joshua is like a burning stick that was pulled out of the fire just in time. The people barely survived the fire of the exile. God has saved them, and he will not let them fall again.

Verse 3: Joshua is wearing filthy clothes. This is a picture of guilt and uncleanness. Normally a priest was allowed to come before God only in clean clothes.

Verses 4–5: God takes the guilt away. He gives Joshua new, festive clothes and a clean turban (the turban of the high priest).

This is a wonderful picture of forgiveness: God not only takes our guilt away, he also gives us something new. The New Testament says something similar: We may "put on" Christ like new clothes (Galatians 3:27). And in the parable of the lost son, Jesus tells how the father has the best robe put on the son who came home (Luke 15:22).

The Branch and the stone VERSES 6–10

6 The angel of the LORD made a solemn promise to Joshua.

He said,
7 "This is what the LORD of Armies says:
'If you walk in my ways
and if you follow my instructions,
then you will also rule my house
and take care of my courtyards.
And I will let you come and go among these who are
standing here.
8 Listen now, Joshua the high priest,
you and your companions who sit before you.
They are men who are a sign.
For look, I will bring my servant, the Branch.
9 For look at the stone that I have set before Joshua.
On this one stone are seven eyes.
Look, I will carve words into it,'
says the LORD of Armies,
'and I will take away the guilt of this land in one day.
10 On that day,' says the LORD of Armies,
'each of you will invite his neighbor
to sit under the vine and under the fig tree.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: If Joshua stays faithful to God, he may lead the temple. And he will be allowed into God's heavenly council, "among these who are standing here," that is, among the angels.

Verse 8: God announces his servant, the "Branch." This is a title for the coming king from the house of David (compare Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5; 33:15). A new shoot can grow out of a tree stump that was cut down. In the same way, new life will grow out of David's royal family, which had been destroyed. At that time, people may have thought of Zerubbabel (compare Zechariah 6:12). Christians also see in it a hint of Jesus.

Verse 9: A mysterious stone with seven eyes. Maybe it is a foundation stone for the temple or a precious stone on the clothes of the high priest. The seven eyes stand for God's eyes, which see everything (compare 4:10). The exact meaning is not certain.

God will take away the guilt of the land "in one day." Christians think of the day when Jesus died on the cross.

Verse 10: A picture of peace and friendship: People invite their neighbors to sit in the shade of their own vine and fig tree (compare Micah 4:4).

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 4

Not by might or power, but by my Spirit

The fifth vision: the golden lampstand VERSES 1–5

1 The angel who talked with me came again
and woke me up,
like a man who is woken up from his sleep.
2 He said to me,
"What do you see?"
I said,
"I have seen a lampstand made all of gold.
There is a bowl on top of it,
and seven lamps are on it.
There are seven pipes to each of the lamps on top of it.
3 And there are two olive trees by it,
one on the right side of the bowl
and the other on its left side."
4 I answered and said to the angel who talked with me,
"What are these, my lord?"
5 Then the angel who talked with me answered me,
"Don't you know what these are?"
I said, "No, my lord."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zechariah sees a golden lampstand, like the lampstand in the temple (the menorah, Exodus 25:31–40). On top there is a bowl with oil. From the bowl, pipes lead to seven lamps. Next to it stand two olive trees, which always give new oil.

The special thing is: No one has to fill up the oil. It flows by itself from the trees. The light never goes out.

The exact form is not quite clear in Hebrew. People understand the number of pipes in different ways.

Zechariah honestly asks what this means. It is okay not to understand everything right away and to ask.

By my Spirit VERSES 6–10

6 Then he answered and said to me,
"This is the word of the LORD to Zerubbabel:
'Not by might, and not by power,
but by my Spirit,'
says the LORD of Armies.
7 Who are you, great mountain?
Before Zerubbabel you will become flat land.
And he will bring out the top stone
while people shout, 'Grace, grace to it!'"
The top stone is the last stone that finishes a building.
8 Then the word of the LORD came to me.
It said,
9 "The hands of Zerubbabel have laid the foundation of
this house.
His hands will also finish it.
Then you will know that the LORD of Armies has sent
me to you.
10 Yes, who looks down on the day of small things?
For these seven will rejoice
when they see the plumb line in the hand of
Zerubbabel.
These are the eyes of the LORD,
which go back and forth through the whole earth."
A plumb line is a string with a weight. Builders use it
to make walls straight.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: This is one of the best-known verses in the Bible: "Not by might, and not by power, but by my Spirit." Zerubbabel had no army, no money, no power. Building the temple seemed impossible. But God says: It does not depend on your strength, but on my Spirit. Just as the oil in the lampstand flows by itself, God's Spirit is at work.

Verse 7: All obstacles, as big as a mountain, will become as flat as a plain. And at the end the top stone will be set in place with shouts of joy: "Grace, grace!" Everything is God's gift.

Verse 9: Zerubbabel has laid the foundation, and he will also finish the building. This happened in the year 515 BC (Ezra 6:15).

Verse 10: "Who looks down on the day of small things?" Many were disappointed because the new temple was so small and plain (compare Haggai 2:3). But God says: Don't look down on small beginnings! Great things often begin small.

"These seven" are the seven lamps. They are "the eyes of the LORD," which look over the whole earth. God sees everything, even the small beginnings, and he is glad about them.

For today: Sometimes we feel small and weak. But with God, what counts is not how strong we are, but that his Spirit is at work.

The two olive trees VERSES 11–14

11 Then I asked him,
"What are these two olive trees
on the right side of the lampstand and on its left side?"

12 And I asked him a second time,
"What are these two olive branches
beside the two golden pipes,
which pour out the golden oil?"

13 He answered me,
"Don't you know what these are?"
I said, "No, my lord."

14 Then he said,
"These are the two anointed ones
who stand by the Lord of the whole earth."

Anointed means: oil was poured on them to set them apart for a task.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The two olive trees are "the two anointed ones." Word for word, the Hebrew says "the two sons of oil." This probably means the two leaders of the people: Zerubbabel, the governor from the royal family, and Joshua, the high priest. Kings and priests were anointed with oil when they began their service.

Through them, God lets his "oil" flow to the people, that is, his Spirit and his blessing. The political leader and the spiritual leader work together.

In the Revelation to John, "two witnesses" are compared with these two olive trees (Revelation 11:4).

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 5

The flying scroll and the basket

The sixth vision: the flying scroll VERSES 1–4

1 Again I looked up and saw
a flying scroll.
2 He said to me,
"What do you see?"
I answered,
"I see a flying scroll.
It is 20 cubits long and 10 cubits wide."
That is about 30 feet long and about 15 feet wide.
3 Then he said to me,
"This is the curse
that goes out over the whole land.
For everyone who steals
will be cut off, as it says on one side.
And everyone who swears falsely
will be cut off, as it says on the other side.
4 I will send it out,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and it will go into the house of the thief
and into the house of the one who swears falsely by my name.
It will stay in the middle of his house
and destroy it, with its wood and its stones."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A huge scroll flies through the air: 20 cubits long and 10 cubits wide, that is, about 30 by 15 feet, as big as a large billboard. A cubit is about 18 inches. Everyone can see it.

On the scroll is a curse against two kinds of wrong: stealing and swearing falsely. To swear falsely means to make a promise before God and lie. This is a reminder of the Ten Commandments: "You shall not steal" and "You shall not misuse the name of the LORD."

Verse 4: The curse goes into the houses of those who do these things and destroys them from the inside. In the end, wrong destroys the life of the one who does it.

The message: In the new Jerusalem that God is building, there should be no more wrong. God is cleaning up.

The seventh vision: the woman in the basket VERSES 5–11

5 Then the angel who talked with me came forward
and said to me,
"Look up now
and see what is coming out."
6 I said,
"What is it?"
He said,
"This is an ephah basket that is coming out."
He also said,
"This is what they look like in all the land.
7 Look, a lid made of lead that weighed one talent was lifted up.
And there was a woman sitting inside the ephah basket."
8 He said,
"This is Wickedness."
He threw her back down into the ephah basket
and threw the lead weight on its opening.
9 Then I looked up and saw
two women.
The wind was in their wings.
They had wings like the wings of a stork.

They lifted up the ephah basket between the earth and
the sky.
10 Then I said to the angel who talked with me,
"Where are they taking the ephah basket?"
11 He said to me,
"To build a house for her in the land of Shinar.
When it is ready,
she will be set there in her own place."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An ephah was a measure for grain, about 5 to 10 gallons. Here it is a large basket or barrel with a heavy lid made of lead. A talent weighed about 75 pounds.

Verse 6: Word for word, the WEB says "their appearance." Many translations follow a small change in the text here and read "their guilt." It probably means: The basket shows how things stand with the guilt in the whole land.

Verses 7–8: A woman sits in the basket. The angel says: "This is Wickedness." In Hebrew, the word for "wickedness" is feminine. That is why it is shown as a woman. This is a picture. It says nothing about women. Men and women can both be wicked.

Verse 9: Notice this: Two other women, with wings like storks, carry the basket away. They are serving God. So in this vision, women are also God's helpers.

Verse 11: The basket is taken to "Shinar." That is Babylonia (compare Genesis 11:2, the tower of Babel). There Wickedness gets a "temple." The message: God removes evil from his land and takes it where it belongs, far away.

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 6

The four chariots and the crown

The eighth vision: four chariots VERSES 1–8

1 Again I looked up and saw
four chariots coming out
from between two mountains.
The mountains were mountains of bronze.
2 The first chariot had red horses.
The second chariot had black horses.
3 The third chariot had white horses.
The fourth chariot had spotted horses.
All of them were strong.
4 Then I asked the angel who talked with me,
"What are these, my lord?"
5 The angel answered me,
"These are the four winds of the sky.
They go out after standing before the Lord of all the
earth.
6 The chariot with the black horses goes out toward the
land of the north.
The white horses went out after them.
And the spotted horses went out toward the land of the
south."
7 The strong horses went out
and wanted to go back and forth through the earth.
He said, "Go, go back and forth through the earth!"
So they went back and forth through the earth.
8 Then he called to me and said to me,
"Look, those who go toward the land of the north
have given my spirit rest in the land of the north."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last of the eight visions is a reminder of the first one (1:8–11): Again it is about horses of different colors. This time they pull chariots.

The two mountains of bronze are maybe the gate to God's home in heaven.

Verse 5: The chariots are "the four winds of the sky," that is, God's messengers who go out in all directions. God rules over the whole world.

Verse 8: In the "land of the north," that is, in Babylon, where God's people were held captive for so long, God has now "given his spirit rest." That means: His anger against Babylon is calmed. The judgment has been carried out.

Here the eight visions of the night end. They have shown: God is at work. He punishes the enemies, makes his people clean, and builds Jerusalem again.

Joshua is crowned VERSES 9–15

9 The word of the LORD came to me.
It said,
10 "Take gifts from those who were captives,
from Heldai, from Tobijah, and from Jedaiah.
They have come from Babylon.
Go on the same day
into the house of Josiah the son of Zephaniah.
11 Yes, take silver and gold,
make crowns,
and set them on the head of Joshua the son of
Jehozadak, the high priest.
12 Speak to him and say,
'This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"Look, the man whose name is the Branch!
He will grow up out of his place,
and he will build the LORD's temple.
13 He will build the LORD's temple.
He will carry royal honor,
and he will sit and rule on his throne.
He will be a priest on his throne.
And there will be peace and agreement between the
two of them.
14 The crowns will be for Helem, for Tobijah, for Jedaiah,
and for Hen the son of Zephaniah.
They will be kept in the LORD's temple so that people
remember.
15 Those who are far away will come
and build in the LORD's temple.
Then you will know that the LORD of Armies has sent
me to you.
This will happen
if you truly listen to the voice of the LORD your
God."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the visions comes an action with a meaning in the real world:

Verses 10–11: Three men had just come from Babylon and had brought silver and gold, probably as a gift for the temple. Zechariah is to make crowns from it and to put them on the head of Joshua the high priest.

Verse 12: "The man whose name is the Branch": The "Branch" is the coming king from the house of David (compare 3:8). He will build the temple. At that time, people may have thought of Zerubbabel, who really did build the temple.

Verse 13: Something special: The Branch will be king and priest at the same time. And there will be peace between the two offices. In Israel, king and priest were normally separate. In the New Testament, Jesus is described as king and high priest at the same time (Hebrews 7).

Why is Joshua crowned and not Zerubbabel? Interpreters disagree about this. Maybe it was too dangerous to crown a descendant of David in public, because the Persians could have seen it as a rebellion.

Verse 14: The crowns are to stay in the temple, to remind people of this promise. Helem and Hen are probably other names for Heldai and Josiah from verse 10.

Verse 15: People from far away will also come and help. But there is one condition: "This will happen if you truly listen to the voice of the LORD your God."

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 7

Fasting that pleases God

A question about fasting VERSES 1–7

1 In the fourth year of King Darius,
the word of the LORD came to Zechariah
on the fourth day of the ninth month, the month of Chislev.
2 The people of Bethel had sent Sharezer and Regem Melech and their men
to ask the LORD for his favor.
3 They were also to speak to the priests of the house of the LORD of Armies
and to the prophets. They asked,
"Should I weep in the fifth month and keep away from food,
as I have done for so many years?"
To fast means to go without food for a time, to pray or to mourn.
4 Then the word of the LORD of Armies came to me.
It said,
5 "Speak to all the people of the land and to the priests.
Say,
'When you fasted and mourned in the fifth and in the seventh month
for these 70 years,
did you really fast for me, really for me?
6 And when you eat and when you drink,
don't you eat for yourselves
and drink for yourselves?
7 Aren't these the words
that the LORD announced through the earlier prophets?
That was when people lived in Jerusalem and it did well,
together with its cities all around,
and when people lived in the South and in the low hills.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This was about two years after the visions of the night, in December 518 BC.

Verses 2–3: A group from Bethel asks a practical question: Since the destruction of the temple (in the fifth month) we have fasted and mourned every year. Now the temple is being built again. Should we go on fasting?

Verse 5: God answers with a question of his own: Did you fast for me at all? Or was it only a habit, a ritual for yourselves?

In the seventh month, people probably remembered the murder of the governor Gedaliah (2 Kings 25:25; Jeremiah 41).

Verse 6: When you ate and when you fasted, you only thought of yourselves.

Verse 7: The earlier prophets already said what really matters. That comes now.

What God really wants VERSES 8–14

8 The word of the LORD came to Zechariah.
It said,
9 "This is what the LORD of Armies has said:
'Judge in a way that is true and fair.
Show kindness and mercy to one another,
each of you to his brother.
10 Don't treat the widow, the orphan,
the foreigner, or the poor harshly.
And none of you should plan evil in his heart against his brother.'
11 But they refused to listen.
They stubbornly turned their backs
and closed their ears, so that they would not hear.
12 Yes, they made their hearts as hard as flint,
so that they would not hear the law
and the words that the LORD of Armies had sent by his Spirit
through the earlier prophets.
That is why great anger came from the LORD of Armies.
13 And so it happened:
As he called and they refused to listen,
so they will call, and I will not listen,"
says the LORD of Armies.
14 "I will scatter them as with a storm wind
among all the nations they did not know.
So the land behind them lay in ruins,

so that no one traveled through it or came back.
For they made the lovely land a ruin."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: This is what God really wants, more important than fasting:
Judge in a fair way.
Show kindness and mercy.
Do not treat the weakest people harshly: widows, orphans, foreigners, and the poor.
Do not even plan evil against others in your heart.

This is a reminder of Isaiah 58:6–7. There God says: The fast that I want is this: to break the chains of wickedness ... and to share your bread with the hungry. And it is a reminder of Micah 6:8.

Verses 11–12: The ancestors did not want to hear this. They made their hearts "as hard as flint" (others translate "as hard as a diamond"). Flint is a very hard stone.

Verses 13–14: That is why the exile came. Whoever does not listen to God when he calls will find that God is silent when he himself calls.

For today: How do we treat foreigners, poor people, and people who are alone? To God, this is more important than any religious practice.

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 8

Children play in the streets of Jerusalem

God returns to Zion VERSES 1–8

1 The word of the LORD of Armies came to me.
2 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"I am jealous for Zion with a great jealousy.
I am jealous for her with great anger."
3 This is what the LORD says:
"I have come back to Zion,
and I will live in the middle of Jerusalem.
Jerusalem will be called 'The City of Truth,'
and the mountain of the LORD of Armies will be called
'The Holy Mountain.'"
4 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"Old men and old women will again live
in the streets of Jerusalem,
each one with a walking stick in his hand
because they are so old.
5 And the streets of the city will be full of boys and girls
playing in its streets."
6 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"In those days this may seem too wonderful
to those who are left of this people.
But should it also seem too wonderful to me?"
says the LORD of Armies.
7 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"Look, I will save my people
from the land in the east
and from the land in the west.
8 I will bring them home,
and they will live in Jerusalem.
They will be my people,
and I will be their God,
in faithfulness and in righteousness."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapter 8 is full of promises. It says "This is what the LORD says" 10 times.

Verse 3: Jerusalem gets a new name: "The City of Truth." The Hebrew word also means "faithfulness": a city where people can rely on each other.

Verses 4–5: This is one of the most beautiful pictures in the Bible: Old people sit in peace in the streets, and children play there. It is a picture of peace and safety. In war, the weak die first, the old people and the children. When they can live in peace, there really is peace.

Verse 6: For the small, poor community in the ruins, this sounds unbelievable. But God says: For me, nothing is impossible.

Verses 7–8: God will bring his people home from east and west, from the whole world. "They will be my people, and I will be their God." These are the words of the covenant (compare Jeremiah 31:33).

Be strong! VERSES 9–17

9 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"Let your hands be strong,
you who hear these words in these days
from the mouth of the prophets.
These prophets were there on the day when the
foundation
of the house of the LORD of Armies was laid,
the temple, so that it could be built.
10 For before those days there were no wages for people
and no wages for animals.
And no one who went out or came in
had peace from the enemy.
For I turned all people against each other,
everyone against his neighbor.
11 But now I will not treat those who are left of this people
as I did in the earlier days,"
says the LORD of Armies.
12 "For there will be a seed of peace.
The vine will give its fruit,
the ground will give its crops,
and the sky will give its dew.
I will give all these things
to those who are left of this people as their own.
13 And it will happen:
Just as you were a curse among the nations,
house of Judah and house of Israel,
so I will save you,
and you will be a blessing.
Don't be afraid.
Let your hands be strong."
14 For this is what the LORD of Armies says:
"When your ancestors made me angry,

I decided to do evil to you,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and I did not change my mind.
15 In the same way, in these days I have decided again
to do good to Jerusalem and to the house of Judah.
Don't be afraid.
16 These are the things you are to do:
Each of you, speak the truth with his neighbor.
At your city gates, judge in a way that is true and
brings peace.
17 None of you should plan evil in his heart against his
neighbor.
And don't love false oaths.
For all these are things that I hate,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–12: Just like in Haggai: Since the building of the temple started again, everything is turning to good. Before there were no wages and no peace, only fighting. Now "a seed of peace" is growing.

Verse 13: A great turning point: Until now, Israel was an example of curse and misfortune among the nations. Now it is to become a blessing. This is a reminder of the promise to Abraham: "You will be a blessing" (Genesis 12:2).

"Don't be afraid. Let your hands be strong." This is the encouragement.

Verse 16: In those days, people met at the city gates to judge cases.

Verses 16–17: And again the commands for everyday life: speak the truth, judge fairly, don't plan evil against your neighbor, no false oaths. The letter to the Ephesians takes up verse 16: "Speak truth, each one with his neighbor" (Ephesians 4:25).

Days of fasting become feasts of joy VERSES 18–19

18 The word of the LORD of Armies came to me.
19 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"The fasts of the fourth, the fifth, the seventh, and the
tenth months
will become joy and gladness for the house of Judah,
and happy feasts.
So love truth and peace!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now at last comes the answer to the question of the people from Bethel (7:3): The days of fasting will become feasts of joy!

The four days of fasting reminded people of the disaster of Jerusalem:

In the fourth month: The wall was broken through (Jeremiah 39:2).

In the fifth month: The temple was burned (2 Kings 25:8–9).

In the seventh month: Gedaliah was murdered (2 Kings 25:25).

In the tenth month: The siege began (2 Kings 25:1).

In Judaism, some of these days of fasting are still kept today, especially Tisha B'Av (the ninth of Av), to remember the destruction of the temple.

"So love truth and peace!" That is the condition.

The nations come to Jerusalem VERSES 20–23

20 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"Many peoples will still come,
and people who live in many cities.
21 The people of one city will go to another and say,
'Let's go quickly
to ask the LORD for his favor
and to seek the LORD of Armies.
I will go too.'
22 Yes, many peoples and strong nations will come
to seek the LORD of Armies in Jerusalem
and to ask the LORD for his favor."
23 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
"In those days, 10 men
from all the languages of the nations
will take hold of the edge of the robe of a Jewish man
and say,
'We will go with you,
for we have heard that God is with you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of the first part of the book there is a great view of the future: People from many nations will come to seek God. They invite each other: "Come, let's go! I will go too!"

Verse 23: A strong picture: 10 people from different nations hold on to the edge of a Jewish man's robe and say: "We will go with you, for we have heard that God is with you."

The Jewish people are to become a signpost to God for the world. For Christians, this came true because many people from all nations found the God of Israel through the Jew Jesus and his Jewish apostles.

This verse is also a warning against every form of hatred of Jews: The nations are to look at the Jewish people with respect and love.

ZECHARIAH

CHAPTER 9

Your king is coming to you

Judgment on the neighboring nations VERSES 1–8

1 A message from God.
The word of the LORD is against the land of Hadrach,
and it will come to rest on Damascus.
For the eyes of people
and of all the tribes of Israel are turned toward the
LORD.
2 It is also against Hamath, which borders on it,
and against Tyre and Sidon,
because they are very wise.
3 Tyre built herself a fortress.
She piled up silver like dust
and fine gold like the mud in the streets.
4 Look, the Lord will take away what she owns.
He will strike down her power on the sea,
and she will be eaten up by fire.

5 Ashkelon will see it and be afraid.
Gaza too will twist in pain,
and so will Ekron, for her hope will come to nothing.
The king will disappear from Gaza,
and no one will live in Ashkelon.
6 Foreigners will live in Ashdod,
and I will cut off the pride of the Philistines.
7 I will take the blood out of their mouths
and the disgusting food from between their teeth.
They too will be left over for our God.
They will be like a clan leader in Judah,
and Ekron will be like a Jebusite.
8 I will camp around my house to guard it against the army,
so that no one passes through or comes back.
No oppressor will pass through them anymore,
for now I have seen it with my own eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the second part of the book of Zechariah begins (Chapters 9–14). It sounds different from the first part and talks more about the far future.

Verses 1–6: Judgment on the neighboring nations in the north (Hadrach, Damascus, Hamath, Tyre, Sidon) and in the west (the cities of the Philistines). Tyre was a rich trading city on an island, and people thought that no one could conquer it. Many interpreters think that these verses are about the war of Alexander the Great (333–332 BC). He really did conquer Tyre.

Verse 7: A surprising turn: The Philistines are not only punished, they are made clean. They no longer have to eat blood and unclean sacrifices (the WEB says "abominations"). And then they too belong to God's people, like a tribe in Judah. The Jebusites were the first people who lived in Jerusalem. Later they became part of Israel.

Verse 8: God himself protects his temple.

The king on the donkey VERSES 9–10

9 Rejoice greatly, daughter of Zion!
Shout for joy, daughter of Jerusalem!
Look, your King is coming to you!
He is righteous, and he brings salvation.
He is humble, and riding on a donkey,
on a colt, the young one of a donkey.
10 I will cut off the chariots from Ephraim
and the war horses from Jerusalem.
The bow for battle will be cut off.
And he will speak peace to the nations.
He will rule from sea to sea,
and from the River to the ends of the earth.
"The River" means the great river Euphrates.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most famous verses in the Bible.

Verse 9: A king comes to Jerusalem. But he does not come on a war horse or in a chariot like other kings. He rides on a donkey, the animal of ordinary people and of peace. He is righteous, he brings salvation, and he is humble.

Verse 10: This king does away with weapons: no more chariots, no more war horses, no more bows. He brings peace to the nations. His kingdom covers the whole world. This is a reminder of Psalm 72:8.

All four Gospels tell how Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey. Matthew and John quote this verse directly (Matthew 21:4–5; John 12:14–15). Christians remember this on Palm Sunday.

In Judaism, this verse is applied to the Messiah who is coming.

Prisoners of hope VERSES 11–17

11 And as for you,
because of the blood of your covenant,
I have set your prisoners free from the pit
that has no water in it.
12 Turn back to the fortress,
you prisoners of hope!
Even today I announce
that I will give you back twice as much.
13 For I bend Judah like a bow for me.
I have put Ephraim on it like an arrow.
I will stir up your sons, Zion,
against your sons, Greece.
I will make you like the sword of a strong warrior.
14 The LORD will appear over them.
His arrow will flash like lightning.
The Lord GOD will blow the trumpet
and will go out in the storms from the south.
15 The LORD of Armies will defend them.
They will destroy and win with sling stones.
They will drink and roar as if from wine.
They will be full like bowls,
like the corners of the altar.
16 The LORD their God will save them on that day,
like a flock, because they are his people.
For they are like the jewels of a crown,
shining high over his land.
17 For how great is his goodness,
and how great is his beauty!
Grain will make the young men grow strong,
and new wine the young women.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: "Because of the blood of your covenant": The covenant between God and Israel was sealed with blood at Mount Sinai (Exodus 24:8). Because of this covenant, God frees the prisoners from a pit without water, a picture of hopeless trouble (compare Joseph in Genesis 37:24; Jeremiah in Jeremiah 38:6). At the Last Supper, Jesus speaks of "my blood of the new covenant" (Mark 14:24).

Verse 12: "Prisoners of hope" is a beautiful phrase. They are still prisoners, but they have hope. God promises to give them back twice as much as they have lost.

Verses 13–15: A picture of battle: God uses his people like a bow and arrow against "Greece." In Hebrew it is "Javan," that is, the Greeks. Maybe the text is thinking of the Greek rulers after Alexander the Great. These pictures describe God's protection for his people when they are in danger. They are not a call for people to make war. After all, the king from verse 10 is the one who brings peace.

Verses 16–17: God saves his people like a shepherd saves his flock. They are as precious to him as jewels in a crown. At the end there is plenty: enough grain and wine for the young people.

Chapter 10

God gathers his scattered people

Sheep without a shepherd VERSES 1–5

1 Ask the LORD for rain in the springtime,
the LORD who makes the storm clouds.
He gives showers of rain to everyone,
for the plants in the field.
2 For the teraphim have said empty things.
Teraphim are small figures of household gods.
And the fortune-tellers have seen lies.
They have told false dreams.
Their comfort is empty.
That is why the people wander like sheep.
They suffer because there is no shepherd.
3 My anger burns against the shepherds,
and I will punish the male goats.
For the LORD of Armies has taken care of his flock,
the house of Judah.
He will make them like his proud horse in battle.
4 From Judah will come the cornerstone,
from him the tent peg,
from him the bow for battle,
from him every ruler together.
5 They will be like strong warriors
who trample down the mud of the streets in battle.
They will fight, because the LORD is with them.
And the riders on horses will be put to shame.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Ask God for rain! He alone gives what people need to live, not the idols.

Verse 2: The "teraphim" (small figures of gods) and the fortune-tellers have comforted the people with lies. That is why the people wander around "like sheep without a shepherd." Jesus uses the same picture when he feels pity for the crowds (Matthew 9:36).

Verse 3: God is angry with the bad "shepherds," that is, the leaders who have let their people down. The "male goats" are the powerful people who push their way through at the cost of others (compare Ezekiel 34:17).

Verse 4: New, good leaders will come out of Judah itself. The "cornerstone" holds up the whole house. The "tent peg" holds the tent in place. Christians often apply the "cornerstone" to Jesus (compare Psalm 118:22; Ephesians 2:20).

I will bring them home VERSES 6–12

6 "I will make the house of Judah strong,
and I will save the house of Joseph.
I will bring them back,
because I have mercy on them.
They will be as if I had never rejected them,
for I am the LORD their God,
and I will answer them.
7 Ephraim will be like a strong warrior,
and their hearts will be happy as if from wine.
Yes, their children will see it and be glad.
Their hearts will rejoice in the LORD.
8 I will whistle for them and gather them,
for I have set them free.
They will become as many as they were before.
9 I will scatter them like seed among the peoples.
In far countries they will remember me.
They will live with their children and will come back.
10 I will also bring them back from the land of Egypt
and gather them from Assyria.
I will bring them into the land of Gilead and Lebanon,
and there will not be enough room for them.
11 He will pass through the sea of trouble
and strike the waves in the sea.
All the depths of the Nile will dry up.
The pride of Assyria will be brought down,
and the power of Egypt will go away.
12 I will make them strong in the LORD.
They will walk here and there in his name,"
says the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: God will save not only Judah (the southern kingdom) but also "the house of Joseph," that is, the northern kingdom of Israel, which had already been destroyed in 722 BC. All Israel is to be united again.

"As if I had never rejected them": God's forgiveness is complete. He makes a new start, as if nothing had happened.

Verse 8: God "whistles" for his people like a shepherd for his flock. And they come.

Verse 9: A beautiful picture: God has "scattered" his people among the nations like seed. Even far away, they will remember God and grow.

Verses 10–11: As when the people left Egypt, God will lead his people through the sea. Egypt and Assyria stand for all the countries where Israel was scattered.

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 11

The good shepherd and the 30 pieces of silver

A sad song about the fallen trees VERSES 1–3

1 Open your doors, Lebanon,
so that the fire may burn up your cedars!
2 Wail, cypress tree,
for the cedar has fallen,
because the splendid trees are destroyed.

Wail, you oaks of Bashan,
for the thick forest has come down.
3 Listen to the wailing of the shepherds!
For their glory is destroyed.
Listen to the roaring of the young lions!
For the pride of the Jordan is ruined.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A song of mourning: The splendid cedars of Lebanon and the oaks of Bashan fall. In the Bible, trees are often a picture of proud, powerful people and rulers (compare Isaiah 2:13; Ezekiel 31). This probably means: The proud rulers will be brought down.

The "shepherds" (the leaders) mourn too, because their power is gone. "The pride of the Jordan" is the thick bush along the banks of the Jordan River, where lions used to live.

Zechariah as a shepherd VERSES 4–14

4 This is what the LORD my God says:
"Take care of the flock that is meant to be slaughtered.
5 Those who buy them kill them and are not punished.
Those who sell them say,
'Praise the LORD, for I am rich!'
And their own shepherds have no pity on them.
6 For I will no longer have pity on the people who live in the land,"
says the LORD.
"Look, I will hand each person over to his neighbor and to his king.
They will strike the land,
and I will not save anyone from their hands."
7 So I took care of the flock that was meant to be slaughtered,
especially the weakest of the flock.
I took two staffs for myself.
One I called "Favor,"
and the other I called "Union."
And I took care of the flock.
8 In one month I got rid of the three shepherds.
For I was tired of them,
and they hated me too.
9 Then I said,
"I will not take care of you anymore.
What is dying, let it die.
What is to be cut off, let it be cut off.
And let those who are left eat each other's flesh."
10 I took my staff Favor and broke it in pieces.
In this way I broke my covenant that I had made with all the peoples.
11 It was broken on that day.
And so the weak ones of the flock who listened to me knew that it was the word of the LORD.
12 I said to them,
"If you think it is right, give me my wages.
If not, keep them."
So they weighed out 30 pieces of silver as my wages.
13 The LORD said to me,
"Throw it to the potter,
that fine price at which they valued me!"
So I took the 30 pieces of silver
and threw them to the potter in the house of the LORD.
14 Then I broke my other staff, Union, in pieces.
In this way I broke the brotherhood between Judah and Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is one of the hardest in the Old Testament. Interpreters understand it in very different ways. What is clear: Zechariah acts out a kind of parable. He plays a shepherd who takes God's role.

Verses 4–6: The "flock that is meant to be slaughtered" is the people who are used and exploited by their own leaders. The traders get rich. They sell the sheep and even thank God for it! No one has pity on them.

Verse 7: The shepherd takes care especially of the weakest. He has two staffs: "Favor" (kindness, grace) and "Union" (belonging together).

Verse 8: We do not know who the "three shepherds" are. There are very many different explanations.

Verse 9: The people reject the good shepherd. So he gives up. The terrible result: hunger and misery, so bad that people eat each other. This describes the horrors of a siege and a famine (compare 2 Kings 6:28–29). It is a warning, not a wish.

Verses 10–11: The staff "Favor" is broken: God takes back his grace that protected them. Only the weak ones of the flock understand what is happening.

Verses 12–13: The shepherd asks for his wages. They give him 30 pieces of silver. That was the price of a slave (Exodus 21:32). God calls it, with bitter irony, "that fine price at which they valued me" (Zechariah 11:13). That is how little God is worth to his people! The shepherd throws the money to the potter in the temple.

These verses are taken up in the New Testament: Judas betrays Jesus for 30 pieces of silver. Later he throws the money into the temple, and with it a potter's field is bought (Matthew 26:15; 27:3–10). Matthew names the prophet Jeremiah there. He probably connects Zechariah with words of Jeremiah about a potter and a field (Jeremiah 18–19; 32).

Verse 14: The second staff, "Union," is broken: The unity of the people breaks too.

The worthless shepherd VERSES 15–17

15 The LORD said to me,
"Take once more the tools of a foolish shepherd.
16 For look, I will raise up a shepherd in the land
who will not care for those who are lost.
He will not look for those who are scattered.
He will not heal the ones that are hurt.
He will not feed the healthy ones.
Instead, he will eat the meat of the fat sheep
and tear off their hoofs.
17 How terrible it will be for the worthless shepherd who leaves the flock!
The sword will strike his arm and his right eye.
His arm will dry up completely,
and his right eye will go completely blind!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the good shepherd was rejected, a bad shepherd comes. He is the exact opposite: He cares for no one. He does not look for the lost. He does not heal the hurt. He only uses the flock for himself.

We do not know who this bad shepherd was. He is a picture of all leaders who misuse their power.

Verse 17: The judgment on him: His arm (his strength) and his eye (his understanding) will be destroyed.

The opposite of the good shepherd: Jesus says: "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd gives his life for the sheep" (John 10:11). He looks for the lost (Luke 15:4–7).

For today: A warning to everyone who is responsible for others, in politics, church, family, or work: Good leadership means caring for the weak.

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 12

They will look at the one they have pierced

Jerusalem, a heavy stone for the nations VERSES 1–9

1 A message, the word of the LORD about Israel.
This is what the LORD says,
who stretches out the sky
and lays the foundation of the earth
and forms the human spirit inside a person:
2 "Look, I will make Jerusalem a cup
that makes all the peoples around it stagger.
And it will also come on Judah
when Jerusalem is under siege.
3 On that day
I will make Jerusalem a heavy stone for all the peoples.
All who try to lift it will be badly hurt.
And all the nations of the earth will gather together
against it.
4 On that day," says the LORD,
"I will strike every horse with terror
and its rider with madness.
But I will keep my eyes open over the house of Judah,
and I will strike every horse of the peoples with
blindness.
5 The clan leaders of Judah will say in their hearts,
'The people of Jerusalem are my strength
through the LORD of Armies, their God.'
6 On that day I will make the clan leaders of Judah
like a pan of fire among wood,
and like a burning torch among bundles of grain.
They will eat up all the peoples around them,
on the right and on the left.
And the people of Jerusalem will again live in their
own place, in Jerusalem.
7 The LORD will also save the tents of Judah first,
so that the glory of the house of David
and the glory of the people of Jerusalem
will not be made greater than Judah.
8 On that day the LORD will defend the people of
Jerusalem.
Whoever is weak among them on that day
will be like David.
And the house of David will be like God,
like the angel of the LORD going before them.
9 On that day
I will set out to destroy all the nations
that come against Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last three chapters speak about the end times, about "that day." These words come up very often in Chapters 12–14.

Verse 1: God introduces himself as the Creator of the sky, the earth, and the human spirit. He has the power to do what follows.

Verses 2–3: Many nations attack Jerusalem. But for them the city becomes like a "cup that makes all the peoples around it stagger" (they will stagger as if they were drunk). And it becomes like a stone that is too heavy, so that whoever lifts it gets hurt.

Verses 4–6: God fights for Jerusalem. These pictures describe God's protection for a city in danger. They are not a command for people to make war against other nations.

Verse 7: Interesting: God first saves the ordinary people in the countryside ("the tents of Judah"), so that the capital city and the royal family do not think too highly of themselves. God does not favor the powerful.

Verse 8: Even the weakest will be as strong as the hero David.

Mourning for the one who was pierced VERSES 10–14

10 "I will pour out on the house of David
and on the people of Jerusalem
a spirit of grace and of prayer for mercy.
They will look at me, the one they have pierced.
They will mourn for him
as people mourn for an only son.
They will weep bitterly for him
as people weep for a firstborn son.
11 On that day the mourning in Jerusalem will be great,
like the mourning of Hadadrimmon in the valley of
Megiddo.
12 The land will mourn,
each family by itself:
the family of the house of David by itself, and their
wives by themselves;
the family of the house of Nathan by itself, and their
wives by themselves;
13 the family of the house of Levi by itself, and their wives
by themselves;
the family of the Shimeites by itself, and their wives
by themselves;
14 all the families that are left,
each family by itself, and their wives by themselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: This is one of the most mysterious and most important verses of the Old Testament. God pours out a "spirit of grace and of prayer for mercy." The people see their guilt. They look at "me, the one they have pierced," and they mourn for him as for an only child.

Who is the one who was pierced? The Hebrew text says "at me," that is, at God himself, and then "for him." This is hard

to understand. Some old manuscripts and translations read "at the one whom they have pierced."

The Gospel of John quotes this verse when a soldier sticks a spear into the side of Jesus on the cross: "They will look at the one they pierced" (John 19:37; compare Revelation 1:7).

In the Jewish tradition, the verse is explained in different ways, for example as being about a Messiah who falls in battle, or about a martyr.

Verse 11: Hadadrimmon was probably a place near Megiddo. Maybe the verse is a reminder of the great mourning for the good King Josiah, who was killed in battle near Megiddo (2 Chronicles 35:22–25).

Verses 12–14: The whole people mourns, each family by itself, the men and the women apart, as was the custom at funerals at that time. Everyone is affected: the royal family (David, Nathan) and the families of priests (Levi, Shimei).

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 13

A fountain to wash away sin and uncleanness

A fountain is opened VERSES 1–6

1 "On that day a fountain will be opened
for the house of David and for the people of Jerusalem,
to wash away sin and uncleanness.
2 On that day,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"I will cut off the names of the idols from the land,
and no one will remember them anymore.
I will also remove the prophets and the unclean spirit
from the land.
3 And it will happen:
If anyone still prophesies,
his father and his mother, who gave birth to him, will
say to him,
'You must die,
because you speak lies in the name of the LORD.'
And his father and his mother, who gave birth to him,
will stab him when he prophesies.
4 On that day
the prophets will be ashamed,
each one of his vision, when he prophesies.
They will no longer wear a coat of hair to fool people.
5 Instead, he will say,
'I am not a prophet.
I am a farmer.
I have been made a servant since I was young.'
6 And someone will ask him,
'What are these wounds between your arms?'
Then he will answer,
'I got them in the house of my friends.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A wonderful picture: A fountain is opened that washes people clean from sin and uncleanness. It follows the mourning for the one who was pierced (12:10). Christians see in it a picture of forgiveness through Jesus. A well-known hymn by William Cowper begins with this picture: "There is a fountain filled with blood."

Verse 2: God will remove all idols and all false prophets from the land. This is about lying prophets who tell lies in God's name (compare 10:2).

Verse 3: To prophesy means to speak as a prophet. This is a very hard verse. It uses strong words to say: False prophecy will be taken so seriously that not even a person's own parents will put up with it. This takes up the law in Deuteronomy 13:6–10 and 18:20.

Important: This describes a future in which lies about God are no longer accepted. It is never a command for parents to hurt or kill their children. Violence in the family is wrong. If you experience violence at home, get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 4–6: The false prophets will be ashamed. They will no longer wear the "coat of hair," the mark of prophets like Elijah (2 Kings 1:8). They will deny that they were ever prophets.

The "wounds between the arms" (that is, on the chest or the back) were maybe cuts like the ones the prophets of idols made on themselves (1 Kings 18:28). The man makes an excuse: "I got them in the house of my friends" (Zechariah 13:6).

Some Christians have applied verse 6 to the wounds of Jesus. But in this passage it is about a false prophet.

Strike the shepherd! VERSES 7–9

7 "Wake up, sword, against my shepherd,
and against the man who is close to me,"
says the LORD of Armies.
"Strike the shepherd,
and the sheep will be scattered.
And I will turn my hand against the little ones.
8 And in all the land,"
says the LORD,
"two parts of it will be cut off and die,
but the third part will be left in it.
9 I will bring the third part into the fire.
I will make them pure, as silver is made pure,
and I will test them, as gold is tested.
They will call on my name,
and I will answer them.
I will say, 'They are my people.'
And they will say, 'The LORD is my God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: God calls the sword against "my shepherd," the "man who is close to me." This shepherd is clearly a good shepherd who is very close to God. When he is struck, the sheep are scattered.

Jesus quotes this verse in the night before his death: "Tonight all of you will fall away because of me. For it is written, 'I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered'" (Mark 14:27; Matthew 26:31). To fall away means: to doubt him and leave him. Soon after that, all the disciples run away.

Verses 8–9: A hard time of testing. Only a third is left. The numbers are a picture, not an exact count.

But the goal is not destruction but making pure: As silver is cleaned of waste in the fire, God will make his people clean.

At the end there are again the words of the covenant: "They are my people." "The LORD is my God." God and his people belong completely together again.

ZECHARIAH

Chapter 14

The LORD will be King over the whole earth

The day of the LORD is coming VERSES 1–5

1 Look, a day of the LORD is coming,
when the things taken from you will be divided up among you.
2 For I will gather all nations against Jerusalem to fight.
The city will be taken,
the houses will be robbed,
and the women will be raped.
Half of the city will be taken away as captives,
but the rest of the people will not be cut off from the city.
3 Then the LORD will go out
and fight against those nations,
as he fights on a day of battle.
4 On that day his feet will stand on the Mount of Olives,
which lies to the east of Jerusalem.
And the Mount of Olives will split in two,
from east to west,
so that a very large valley is formed.
Half of the mountain will move toward the north,
and the other half toward the south.
5 You will flee through the valley of my mountains,
for the valley of the mountains will reach to Azel.
Yes, you will flee,
just as you fled from the earthquake
in the days of Uzziah king of Judah.
And the LORD my God will come,
and all the holy ones with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The last chapter describes the great "day of the LORD," the end of history.

Verse 2: First, terrible things happen: Jerusalem is conquered and robbed, and women are raped. The Bible does not keep silent about what happens in war, especially what is done to women. This is a grave wrong, and the guilt lies only with those who do it. If you have experienced sexual violence, you can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verse 3: But then God himself steps in and fights against the attackers.

Verse 4: God stands on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem. The mountain splits, and a large valley is formed, a way of escape for the people of the city.

The Mount of Olives also plays an important role in the New Testament: There Jesus prayed in the night before his death (in the garden of Gethsemane at the foot of the mountain), and from there he was taken up into heaven (Acts 1:9–12). There the angels say: "This Jesus ... will come back in the same way."

Verse 5: The earthquake in the time of King Uzziah was so strong that people still remembered it centuries later (compare Amos 1:1). We do not know where Azel was.

"All the holy ones" are probably the angels who come with God.

Living water and one God VERSES 6–11

6 On that day
there will be no light,
no cold, and no frost.
7 It will be a day like no other,
a day that the LORD knows,
neither day nor night.
But it will happen:
In the evening there will be light.
8 On that day
living water will flow out from Jerusalem,
half of it toward the eastern sea
and half of it toward the western sea.
It will be like this in summer and in winter.
"Living water" means fresh, flowing water.
9 The LORD will be King over the whole earth.
On that day the LORD will be one,
and his name one.
10 The whole land will be made flat like the Arabah,
from Geba to Rimmon, south of Jerusalem.
The Arabah is the low, flat valley of the Jordan River.
But Jerusalem will be lifted up and will stay in her place,
from Benjamin's Gate to the place of the First Gate,
to the Corner Gate,
and from the Tower of Hananel to the king's winepresses.
11 People will live in it,
and there will be no more curse.
Jerusalem will live in safety.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: A completely new day, different from all the days before. Day and night no longer take turns. "In the evening there will be light": When people expect it to get dark, it becomes bright. The book of Revelation says about the new Jerusalem: "There will be no night" (Revelation 22:5).

Verse 8: Living, fresh water flows out of Jerusalem, east to the Dead Sea and west to the Mediterranean Sea, all year long. This is a reminder of the stream from the temple in Ezekiel (Ezekiel 47) and of the river of life in Revelation 22:1. Jesus speaks of the "living water" that he gives (John 4:10–14; 7:37–38).

Verse 9: The high point of the book: "The LORD will be King over the whole earth. On that day the LORD will be one, and his name one." This is a reminder of the basic Jewish confession of faith, the "Hear, Israel": "The LORD is our

God. The LORD is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4). In the end, all people will know the one God. In the Jewish prayer "Aleinu," this verse is still prayed every day.

Verses 10–11: The land becomes flat, and only Jerusalem is lifted up. People will live in the city again within its old borders. And there will be "no more curse," no more destruction. At last Jerusalem will live in safety.

The end of the attackers VERSES 12–15

12 This will be the plague
with which the LORD will strike all the peoples
who have fought against Jerusalem:
Their bodies will waste away while they are still
standing on their feet.
Their eyes will waste away in their sockets,
and their tongues will waste away in their mouths.
A plague is a terrible sickness or disaster.
13 On that day
a great panic from the LORD will come over them.
Each one will grab the hand of his neighbor,
and each one will raise his hand against his neighbor.
14 Judah too will fight at Jerusalem.
And the riches of all the nations around will be
gathered together:
gold, silver, and clothes, in great amounts.
15 The same kind of plague will also strike
the horses, the mules, the camels, the donkeys,
and all the animals that are in those camps.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are hard to read. They use strong pictures to describe God's judgment on the nations that attacked Jerusalem and did the horrible things from verse 2.

Verse 13: The attackers become confused and fight against each other, as in earlier stories in the Bible (Judges 7:22; 2 Chronicles 20:23).

Verse 14: The treasures that the nations had robbed come back.

Important: It is God who judges here. No person has the right to use such pictures to justify violence against others. And the chapter does not end with destruction, but with an invitation to the nations. That comes now.

All nations celebrate the Feast of Booths VERSES 16–21

16 And it will happen:
Everyone who is left of all the nations
that came against Jerusalem
will go up year after year
to worship the King, the LORD of Armies,
and to celebrate the Feast of Booths.
Booths are simple huts made of branches.
17 And it will happen:
If any of the families of the earth do not go up to
Jerusalem
to worship the King, the LORD of Armies,
no rain will fall on them.
18 If the family of Egypt does not go up and does not
come,
no rain will fall on them either.
This will be the plague
with which the LORD will strike the nations
that do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths.
19 This will be the punishment of Egypt
and the punishment of all the nations
that do not go up to celebrate the Feast of Booths.
20 On that day these words will be written on the bells of
the horses:
"HOLY TO THE LORD."
And the pots in the LORD's house
will be like the bowls in front of the altar.
21 Yes, every pot in Jerusalem and in Judah
will be holy to the LORD of Armies.
All who offer sacrifices will come and take some of
them and cook in them.
On that day there will no longer be a Canaanite in the
house of the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: An amazing turn: The nations that fought against Jerusalem will now come to Jerusalem every year to worship God. Enemies become guests at the feast.

The Feast of Booths reminded people of the journey through the desert, when God took care of his people while they lived in tents. It was also a thanksgiving feast for the harvest. Now all nations celebrate together that God takes care of them.

Verses 17–19: Whoever does not come gets no rain. This makes sense: Whoever rejects the God who gives rain cuts himself off from the source of life. Egypt is named especially, because it lived from the Nile River and did not depend on rain. Even there it will have results.

Verses 20–21: In the end, everything is holy. Before, the words "HOLY TO THE LORD" were written only on the gold plate on the high priest's turban (Exodus 28:36). Now they are written even on the bells of the horses! And every cooking pot is as holy as the dishes in the temple. There is no longer a difference between holy and everyday things. All of life belongs to God.

"No longer a Canaanite": The Hebrew word can also mean "trader." Then it means: No more business will be done in the temple. Jesus drove the traders out of the temple (John 2:16).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Zechariah?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Return to me: "Return to me ... and I will return to you" (1:3).

Eight visions of the night: riders, horns, the measuring line, Joshua in new clothes, the golden lampstand, the flying scroll, the basket, and the four chariots. All of them show: God is with his people again. He forgives guilt and builds Jerusalem again.

By my Spirit: "Not by might, and not by power, but by my Spirit" (4:6). "Who looks down on the day of small things?" (4:10).

What God wants: "Don't treat the widow, the orphan, the foreigner, or the poor harshly" (7:10).

Peace in the city: Old people in the streets, children playing in the streets (8:4–5).

The king on the donkey: "Look, your King is coming to you ... humble, and riding on a donkey" (9:9).

The good shepherd: He is rejected and paid off with 30 pieces of silver (11:12–13). "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (13:7).

The one who was pierced: "They will look at me, the one they have pierced" (12:10).

God is King over all: "The LORD will be King over the whole earth. On that day the LORD will be one, and his name one" (14:9).

Zechariah and Jesus: No other book of the prophets is quoted as often as Zechariah in the reports about the last days of Jesus.

For today: God begins with small beginnings, works through his Spirit, and has a great goal: that all people know him and live in peace.

What comes next? Next comes Malachi, the last book of the Old Testament. It ends with the announcement that God will send a messenger, the prophet Elijah, before the great day of the LORD comes.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 39 OF 66

MALACHI

4 CHAPTERS

MALACHI

CHAPTER 1

I have loved you

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHO WAS MALACHI?

In Christian Bibles, Malachi is the last book of the Old Testament. (In the Jewish Bible, the prophets are in a different order, and the Bible ends with the books of Chronicles.)

The name Malachi means "my messenger." Maybe it is his name, maybe it is a title (compare 3:1, where God says: "I am sending my messenger"). We know nothing about the person.

Malachi probably lived in the 5th century BC, a few decades after the second temple was built again (515 BC), maybe at the time of Ezra and Nehemiah. The first excitement was over. The priests were careless, and the people did not care. Many asked: "Is it even worth it to serve God?"

The special thing about Malachi: The book is set up like an argument. God says something, the people object ("How? In what way?"), and God answers. This happens six times.

At the end, Malachi announces that God will send a messenger, the prophet Elijah, before the great day of the LORD comes. In the New Testament, this is applied to John the Baptist.

A note: In the WEB, our English source text, Malachi has 4 chapters. In some Bibles there are only 3. There the WEB's Chapter 4 is 3:19–24.

God's love for Israel VERSES 1–5

1 A message, the word of the LORD to Israel through
Malachi.
2 "I have loved you," says the LORD.
But you say, "How have you loved us?"
"Wasn't Esau Jacob's brother?" says the LORD.
"Yet I loved Jacob,
3 but Esau I hated.
I made his mountains a wasteland,
and I gave his land to the jackals of the desert."
Jackals are wild dogs.
4 Edom says,
"We have been beaten down,
but we will come back and build up the ruins again."
But the LORD of Armies says,
"They may build, but I will tear down.
People will call them 'The Wicked Land,'
and 'the people with whom the LORD is angry
forever.'"
5 Your eyes will see it, and you will say,
"The LORD is great,
even beyond the border of Israel!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: The first words of the book are God's declaration of love: "I have loved you." But the people doubt it: "How? We don't notice any of it!"

Verses 2–3: God reminds them of the twins Jacob and Esau (Genesis 25). God chose Jacob, not Esau. Here "love" and "hate" are a Hebrew way of saying "choose" and "not choose," or "prefer" and "prefer less." It does not mean that God personally hated Esau. Jesus uses the same way of speaking when he says that people must "hate" father and mother in order to follow him (Luke 14:26; the WEB, our English source text, says "disregard" there). Compare Matthew 10:37: "Whoever loves father or mother more than me."

Paul quotes this verse in the letter to the Romans (Romans 9:13), when he speaks about God's free choice.

Verse 4: Edom (the people who came from Esau) had by then been driven out of its land by other nations. Israel, on the other hand, was allowed to come back. By this they are to see God's love.

Verse 5: "The LORD is great, even beyond the border of Israel": God is not only a God for Israel, but for the whole world.

The priests look down on God VERSES 6–14

6 "A son honors his father,
and a servant honors his master.
If I am a father, where is the honor I should get?
And if I am a master, where is the respect I should
get?"
says the LORD of Armies to you priests,
who look down on my name.
"You say, 'How have we looked down on your name?'
7 You bring unclean bread to my altar.
You say, 'How have we made you unclean?'
You do it when you say, 'The table of the LORD is not
worth anything.'
8 When you bring blind animals as a sacrifice, isn't that
evil?
And when you bring animals that are lame and sick,
isn't that evil?
Try giving it to your governor!
Will he be pleased with you?
Or will he welcome you?"
says the LORD of Armies.
9 "Now, please ask God to be kind to us.
With gifts like these, will he welcome any of you?"
says the LORD of Armies.
10 "Oh, if only one of you would shut the temple doors,
so that you would not light fire on my altar for
nothing!
I take no pleasure in you,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and I will not accept an offering from your hand.
11 For from where the sun rises to where it goes down,
my name is great among the nations.
In every place incense is offered to my name,
and a pure offering.
For my name is great among the nations,"
says the LORD of Armies.
Incense is something that gives off a sweet smell when
it burns.

12 "But you treat it as unholy when you say,
'The table of the LORD is unclean,
and its fruit, its food, is not worth anything.'
13 You also say,
'What a bother this is!'
And you turn up your noses at it,"
says the LORD of Armies.
"You bring animals that were stolen, the lame and the sick.
That is what you bring as your offering.
Should I accept this from your hand?"
says the LORD.
14 "But cursed is the cheater
who has a male animal in his flock
and promises it to the Lord,
but then sacrifices an animal with a defect to him.
For I am a great King,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and my name is feared among the nations."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: God asks the priests: A child honors his parents, an employee his boss. If I am your father and your master, where is your respect for me?

Verses 7–8: The priests sacrificed sick, blind, and lame animals, even though the law allowed only animals without defects (Leviticus 22:20–22). They gave God what they themselves could no longer use.

God says with irony: Just try that with your governor! Would you give the Persian governor a sick animal as a gift? Surely not!

Verse 10: God says: It would be better for someone to lock up the temple than for you to go on like this. Worship without the heart is worse than none at all.

Verse 11: An amazing verse: Everywhere in the world, "from where the sun rises to where it goes down," God's name is honored and a pure offering is brought, while his own priests look down on him. Interpreters explain this in different ways: as being about the Jews scattered in other lands, about people of other nations who honestly seek God, or as a view into the future. In the early church, the verse was applied to the Lord's Supper.

Verse 13: "What a bother this is!" The priests are bored with their service. It is only a routine now.

For today: Does God get the best from me, or only what is left over, for example of my time, my strength, my money?

MALACHI

CHAPTER 2

Do not be unfaithful

A warning to the priests VERSES 1–9

1 "Now, you priests, this command is for you.
2 If you will not listen,
and if you will not take it to heart
to give honor to my name,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"then I will send the curse on you,
and I will curse your blessings.
Yes, I have already cursed them,
because you do not take it to heart.
3 Look, I will rebuke your children,
and I will spread dung on your faces,
the dung from your feasts.
And you will be carried away with it.
4 Then you will know that I have sent you this command,
so that my covenant with Levi may continue,"
says the LORD of Armies.
5 "My covenant with him was a covenant of life and peace.
I gave them to him so that he would honor me.
And he did honor me
and stood in awe of my name.
6 The law of truth was in his mouth,
and nothing wrong was found on his lips.
He walked with me in peace and honesty,
and he turned many away from sin.
7 For the lips of a priest should keep knowledge,
and people should look for teaching from his mouth,
for he is the messenger of the LORD of Armies.
8 But you have turned away from the path.
You have made many people stumble by your teaching.
You have ruined the covenant of Levi,"
says the LORD of Armies.
9 "That is why I have made you looked down on
and low before all the people,
because you have not kept my ways,
but have favored some people when you teach the law."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Dung is animal waste.

Verses 2–3: Hard words to the priests. Because they do not honor God, their blessing becomes a curse. The picture of dung on their faces is meant to be shocking: The waste of the animals for sacrifice was burned outside the camp (Exodus 29:14). That is how unclean the priests have become.

Verses 4–7: God reminds them of the ideal: Levi, the ancestor of the priests, was faithful. A good priest speaks the truth, lives in peace with God, and helps others turn away from wrong. People are to find advice and teaching with him. He is a "messenger of the LORD." In Hebrew this is the same word as "Malachi."

Verses 8–9: But these priests have failed. They have led many people the wrong way and were unfair: They "favored some people," that is, they gave the rich and powerful better treatment.

For today: A warning to all who are responsible in church and congregation: Speak the truth, be honest, and treat everyone the same.

Unfaithful to God and to each other VERSES 10–12

10 Don't we all have one father?
Hasn't one God created us?
Why are we unfaithful to each other, each against his

brother,
and make the covenant of our ancestors unholy?
11 Judah has been unfaithful,
and a disgusting thing has been done in Israel and in Jerusalem.
For Judah has made unholy the holy things of the LORD, which he loves,
and has married the daughter of a foreign god.
12 The LORD will cut off the man who does this
from the tents of Jacob,
whoever he is, the one who is awake and the one who answers,
and the one who brings an offering to the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "Don't we all have one father? Hasn't one God created us?" An important sentence: We are all brothers and sisters, because we have the same Creator. That is why we should not cheat each other.

Verse 11: Judah "has married the daughter of a foreign god." That means: Men married women who served other gods, and they took over the worship of those gods. This is about faith, not about origin or skin color. The Bible also tells about women from other nations who came to the God of Israel and are highly honored, like Ruth, the woman from Moab and great-grandmother of David.

Verse 12: A serious judgment. "The one who is awake and the one who answers" is an old saying. Its exact meaning is not certain. It probably means: everyone, with no exception.

Faithfulness in marriage VERSES 13–16

13 "And this is another thing you do:
You cover the altar of the LORD with tears,
with weeping and with sighing,
because he no longer pays attention to the offering
and no longer accepts it gladly from your hand.
14 And you say, 'Why?'
Because the LORD has been a witness
between you and the wife of your youth.
You have been unfaithful to her,
even though she is your partner
and the wife of your covenant.
15 Didn't he make you one,
even though he still had the rest of the Spirit?
And why one?
He was looking for children who would belong to God.
So be careful in your spirit,
and let no one be unfaithful to the wife of his youth.
16 Whoever hates and divorces,"
says the LORD, the God of Israel,
"covers his clothes with violence!"
says the LORD of Armies.
"So be careful in your spirit,
so that you are not unfaithful.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: The men weep at the altar because God no longer answers their prayers. God tells them why: You have been unfaithful to your wives. It seems that men left the wives they had been married to for many years, to marry younger women, maybe from rich foreign families (compare verse 11).

At that time, women had hardly any rights. A woman who was sent away was often left without support and without protection. Here God takes the side of the women who were left.

Marriage is a "covenant," and God himself is the witness. The wife is "your partner," that is, an equal partner.

Verse 15: In Hebrew, this verse is one of the hardest in the whole Old Testament. The translations are very different from each other. It probably means: God has made husband and wife one in marriage.

Verse 16: "Whoever hates and divorces ... covers his clothes with violence!" That means: Whoever sends his wife away because he dislikes her does violence to her. This is about men who leave their wives without caring what happens to them.

Important: This verse wants to protect the weak. It must never be used to keep someone in a marriage where he or she experiences violence. Violence in a marriage itself destroys the covenant. Help is available: For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Where is the God of justice? VERSE 17

17 "You have made the LORD tired with your words.
And you say, 'How have we made him tired?'
You do it when you say,
'Everyone who does evil is good in the LORD's eyes,
and he is pleased with them,'
or, 'Where is the God of justice?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people have become bitter and mocking: "Evil people are doing well. It seems that God likes evil. Where is this God who is fair?"

God is "tired" of this talk. The answer to the question "Where is the God of justice?" comes in the next chapter: He is coming!

MALACHI

CHAPTER 3

I am sending my messenger

The messenger and the fire that makes metal pure VERSES 1–6

1 "Look, I am sending my messenger,
and he will prepare the way before me!
The Lord whom you are looking for will suddenly come to his temple.
Look, the messenger of the covenant, whom you long for, is coming!"
says the LORD of Armies.

2 "But who can bear the day when he comes?
And who will stand when he appears?
For he is like the fire that makes metal pure,
and like the strong soap of those who wash clothes.
3 He will sit like someone who melts silver and makes it pure.
He will make the sons of Levi pure.
He will make them pure like gold and silver.
Then they will bring offerings to the LORD in the right way.
4 Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem
will please the LORD,
as in the days of long ago,
and as in years long past.
5 I will come near to you to judge.
I will be quick to speak as a witness
against those who practice magic, against those who break their marriage,
against those who lie under oath,
and against those who cheat the hired worker out of his wages,
who treat the widow and the orphan harshly,
and who take away the rights of the foreigner,
and who do not fear me,"
says the LORD of Armies.
6 "For I, the LORD, do not change.
That is why you, sons of Jacob, have not been destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The answer to the question "Where is the God of justice?" (2:17): God sends a messenger who prepares the way for him. Then the Lord himself suddenly comes to his temple.

In the New Testament, this verse is applied to John the Baptist, who prepared the way for Jesus (Mark 1:2; Matthew 11:10; Luke 7:27). Jesus himself says this about John.

Verses 2–3: But God's coming is not only pleasant. He is like the fire that is used to make silver and gold pure, and like strong soap. He will remove everything unclean, first among the priests.

Verse 5: Whom does the judgment strike? Not only people who sin in religious ways (those who practice magic), but also those who do wrong to others: people who break their marriage, people who lie in court, employers who hold back their workers' wages, and all who treat widows, orphans, and foreigners harshly. For God, faith and justice belong together.

Verse 6: "For I, the LORD, do not change." God's faithfulness is the reason why Israel still exists at all. He keeps his promises, even when his people are unfaithful.

Return to me! VERSES 7–12

7 "Since the days of your ancestors
you have turned away from my rules
and have not kept them.
Return to me,
and I will return to you,"
says the LORD of Armies.
"But you say, 'How should we return?'
8 Will a person rob God?
Yet you rob me!
But you say, 'How have we robbed you?'
In the tithes and the offerings.
9 You are under a curse,
for you rob me,
yes, this whole nation does.
10 Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse,
so that there may be food in my house.
And test me in this,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"and see if I will not open the windows of heaven for you
and pour out a blessing on you,
until there is not enough room for it.
11 For your sake I will stop the one who eats up your crops,
so that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground.
And your vine in the field will not lose its fruit before it is ripe,"
says the LORD of Armies.
12 "All nations will call you happy,
for you will be a land that brings joy,"
says the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Again the invitation: "Return to me, and I will return to you" (as in Zechariah 1:3).

Verse 8: A tithe is a tenth part of what a person earns or harvests.

Verses 8–9: The people ask: "How should we return?" God names a clear example: the tithe. According to the law, the Israelites were to give a tenth of their harvest. This was what the Levites lived on, since they had no land of their own. And the poor, widows, orphans, and foreigners were also cared for with it (Deuteronomy 14:28–29). So whoever did not give the tithe also took something away from the poor.

Verse 10: "Test me!" This is one of the few places in the Bible where God tells people to put him to the test. Whoever gives generously will see that God blesses generously.

Important: This verse is sometimes misused to put pressure on people or to take their money, for example with the promise: "If you give money, you will get rich." That is not what it means. No one can buy God's blessing. The New Testament says: "Let each one give as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under pressure. For God loves a cheerful giver" (2 Corinthians 9:7).

Verse 11: "The one who eats up your crops" probably means locusts or other pests.

Is it worth it to serve God? VERSES 13–18

13 "Your words against me have been harsh,"
says the LORD.
"But you say, 'What have we said against you?'
14 You have said,
'It is useless to serve God.
What good is it that we have kept his instructions
and have walked around sadly before the LORD of Armies?
15 Now we call the proud people happy.
Yes, those who do evil do well.
Yes, they test God and get away with it.'"
16 Then those who feared the LORD talked with each other.
And the LORD paid attention and heard it.
A book to remember them was written before him

for those who feared the LORD
and honored his name.
17 "They will be mine,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"my own treasure, on the day that I am preparing.
I will spare them,
as a man spares his own son who serves him.
18 Then you will again see the difference
between the righteous and the wicked,
between the one who serves God
and the one who does not serve him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: Many people ask this question: Is it even worth it to believe in God and to live the right way? Those who do evil are doing much better! Psalm 73 asks this question too.

Verse 16: A quiet, beautiful scene: Those who are faithful to God talk with each other and encourage each other. And God listens! He writes their names in a "book to remember them." No faithful person is forgotten.

Verse 17: They are God's "own treasure," something special that belongs to him (compare Exodus 19:5). He cares for them like a father for his child.

Verse 18: Righteous means: living right before God. In the end it will be clear that it makes a difference whether people serve God or not.

MALACHI

CHAPTER 4

The sun of righteousness

The day is coming VERSES 1–3

1 "For look, the day is coming,
burning like an oven.
On that day all the proud and all who do evil
will be like straw.
The day that is coming will burn them up,"
says the LORD of Armies,
"so that it will leave them neither root nor branch.
2 But for you who fear my name,
the sun of righteousness will rise,
with healing in its wings.
You will go out and jump for joy
like calves let out of the barn.
3 You will trample on the wicked,
for they will be ashes under the soles of your feet
on the day that I am preparing,"
says the LORD of Armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, these verses are Malachi 3:19–24.

Verse 1: The day of judgment is like a glowing oven. Everything proud and evil burns up like straw.

Verse 2: But for those who honor God, the same day is a sunrise! "The sun of righteousness" rises. Its rays are like wings that bring healing. And the people jump for joy like young calves that are finally allowed out of the barn onto the pasture after the winter.

Christians have applied the "sun of righteousness" to Jesus. This picture comes up in many Christmas songs. Zechariah, the father of John the Baptist, speaks of a special light. He calls it: "the dawn from on high" (Luke 1:78).

Verse 3: The righteous will win over evil. This is a picture of the victory of good. It is not a call for people to use violence. Judgment belongs to God.

Remember Moses, and Elijah will come VERSES 4–6

4 "Remember the law of my servant Moses,
which I commanded him at Horeb for all Israel,
the rules and the laws.
5 Look, I will send you Elijah the prophet
before the great and terrible day of the LORD comes.
6 He will turn the hearts of the fathers to their children
and the hearts of the children to their fathers.
Otherwise I would come
and strike the earth with a curse."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These are the last words of the Old Testament (in the Christian order):

Verse 4: Remember the law of Moses! Horeb is another name for Mount Sinai, where God gave Moses the commandments.

Verse 5: God will send the prophet Elijah. Elijah had not died, but had been taken up into heaven in a chariot of fire (2 Kings 2:11). That is why people expected him to come back.

In Judaism, a cup is still set out for Elijah at the Passover meal today, and the door is opened for him, in the hope that he will come and announce the Messiah.

In the New Testament, the angel says that John the Baptist will go ahead "in the spirit and power of Elijah," "to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children" (Luke 1:17). Jesus himself says about John: "He is Elijah, who was to come" (Matthew 11:14; 17:10–13).

Verse 6: Elijah's task: to bring the generations back together. Parents and children are to find their way to each other again. When families and generations are at peace with each other, God's blessing can come instead of the curse.

So the Old Testament ends with a hope that waits: God will come. It ends with an open door, and the New Testament begins with John the Baptist, who walks right through this door.

LOOKING BACK: WHAT HAVE WE READ IN THE BOOK OF MALACHI?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

I have loved you: God's first word in this book is a declaration of love (1:2).

Giving God the best: The priests sacrificed sick and lame animals. God does not want what is left over, but the heart (1:6–14).

One God for all: "From where the sun rises to where it goes down, my name is great among the nations" (1:11). "Don't

we all have one father?" (2:10).

Faithfulness in marriage: God is the witness of the marriage covenant, and he takes the side of the women who were left (2:14–16).

The messenger is coming: "Look, I am sending my messenger, and he will prepare the way before me" (3:1).

God does not change: His faithfulness is the reason why his people still exist (3:6).

Return to me: "Return to me, and I will return to you" (3:7).

A book to remember them: God forgets no one who is faithful to him (3:16).

The sun of righteousness: For those who honor God, a sun rises, with healing in its wings (4:2).

Elijah will come: He will turn the hearts of parents and children to each other (4:5–6).

For today: Does God get the best from me, or what is left over? Am I faithful to God and to the people I am connected with?

Looking back: What have we read in the whole Old Testament?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the beginning: God creates the world and human beings in his image, male and female (Genesis 1–2). But people turn away from God, and violence and suffering come into the world.

Abraham and the ancestors of Israel: God calls Abraham and promises: "Through you, all the families of the earth will be blessed" (Genesis 12:3). He leads Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph.

Freedom: God sets his people free from slavery in Egypt. At Mount Sinai he gives the Ten Commandments: rules for a life in freedom with God and with each other.

In the promised land: Under Joshua, the judges, and the kings Saul, David, and Solomon, Israel lives in the land. There are good times and bad times, faithfulness and unfaithfulness.

The prophets: Again and again God sends prophets. They call people to turn back, stand up for the poor, and give hope: Elijah, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Amos, Hosea, Micah, and many others.

Exile and return: Because the people do not listen, Israel and Judah are destroyed and taken into exile. But God does not give up on his people. They are allowed to come home and build the temple again.

Prayer and wisdom: The Psalms show how people talk with God, in joy, in sorrow, and in doubt. Proverbs, Job, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs ask about the meaning of life, about suffering, and about love.

The great hope: The prophets announce a new covenant, a king from the house of David, a servant of God who suffers for others, and a day when God will be King over the whole earth and all nations will live in peace.

For Jews and Christians: These writings are the Holy Scriptures of the Jewish people, the "Tanakh." For Christians, they are the Old Testament. Jesus himself knew these Scriptures, prayed them, and taught them. Whoever wants to understand the New Testament needs to know the Old.

What comes next? Next, the New Testament begins with the Gospel of Matthew. It tells about Jesus of Nazareth, about his birth in Bethlehem, his life, his death, and his resurrection. And right at the beginning, John the Baptist appears, the messenger that Malachi announced.

Help is available

You are not alone.

If you are not doing well, it is okay to ask for help.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (USA)
Call or text 988
free, 24 hours a day

Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline (USA)
1-800-422-4453
free, 24 hours a day

National Domestic Violence Hotline (USA)
1-800-799-7233
free, 24 hours a day

RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline (USA)
1-800-656-4673
free, 24 hours a day

Samaritans (UK and Ireland)
116 123
free, 24 hours a day

Childline (UK, for children and young people)
0800 1111
free

Other countries
findahelpline.com
free help lines worldwide

Emergency
911 (USA) · 999 (UK) · 112 (Europe)
police, ambulance, fire